

Religion, Myth, and Folklore
in the World's Epics

Religion and Society 30

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Religion, Myth, and Folklore in the World's Epics

The Kalevala and its Predecessors

Edited by
Lauri Honko

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The vignette on the cover of this book represents the symbol of the *Agathos Daimon*, the snake of the Good Spirit, known from Greek astrological and magical texts. As its Town God, the *Agathos Daimon* was believed to protect Alexandria, which was famous world-wide for its library with precious manuscripts and books.

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Table of Contents

List of Authors	IX
---------------------------	----

Prologue

Lauri Honko

The Kalevala and the World's Epics: An Introduction	1
---	---

Models

Minna Skafte Jensen

The Homeric Epics and Greek Cultural Identity	29
---	----

Teivas Oksala

Virgil's Aeneid as Homeric, National and Universal Epic	49
---	----

Lars Lönnroth

The Old Norse Analogue: Eddic Poetry and Fornaldarsaga . . .	73
--	----

Hans Fromm

Kalevala and Nibelungenlied: The Problem of Oral and Written Composition	93
---	----

Derick Thomson

Macpherson's Ossian: Ballad Origins and Epic Ambitions	115
--	-----

Result

Matti Kuusi

Epic Cycles as the Basis for the Kalevala	133
---	-----

<i>Väinö Kaukonen</i>	
The Kalevala as Epic	157
<i>Lauri Honko</i>	
The Kalevala: The Processual View	181
<i>Pirkko Alhoniemi</i>	
The Reception of the Kalevala and Its Impact on the Arts . . .	231
Points of Comparison	
Europe	
<i>Vilmos Voigt</i>	
The Kalevala and the Epic Traditions of Europe	247
<i>Eduard Laugaste</i>	
The Kalevala and Kalevipoeg	265
<i>Felix J. Oinas</i>	
Russian and Finnish Epic Songs	287
<i>David E. Bynum</i>	
The Väinämöinen Poems and the South Slavic Oral Epos	311
<i>Péter Domokos</i>	
Epics of the Eastern Uralic Peoples	343
<i>Rudolf Schenda</i>	
Frédéric Mistral's Poem Mireille and Provençal Identity	359
Africa	
<i>Jan Knappert</i>	
Is Epic Oral or Written?	381
<i>Christiane Seydou</i>	
Identity and Epics: African Examples	403
<i>Micheline Galley</i>	
Arabic Folk Epics	425

Asia

Jaan Puhvel

The Iranian Book of Kings: A Comparativistic View 441

Walther Heissig

Motif Correspondences between Mongolian Epics and the Kalevala 455

'Jam-dpal rgyal-mtsho

The Singers of the King Gesar Epic 471

Silke Herrmann

The Life and History of the Epic King Gesar in Ladakh 485

Jia Zhi

Epics in China 503

Taryo Obayashi

The Yukar of the Ainu and Its Historical Background 519

Epilogue

Eino Karhu

The Role of Mythologism, Past and Present 537

Lauri Honko

The Kalevala: Problems of Interpretation and Identity 555

Index of Names 577

Index of Epics and Epic Heroes 583

List of Authors

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Prologue

Lauri Honko

The Kalevala and the World's Epics: An Introduction

Great epics are powerful repositories of myth, religious worldview, and history. It is through them that many details of past forms of religion and society have come to us. But they are also works of literature. Literature again is not necessarily their original form of existence. Most great epics are widely considered as embodiments of oral tradition, folk poetry, myth and ritual. Thus they differ from purely literary epics in a special way, by having a preliterate past. The precise nature of that past is mostly uncertain, because we usually know only the end, the result of a sometimes long process through which an epic material was transformed into a piece of written literature. It is no wonder that in this situation problems of source criticism abound. Whatever we wish to say on the basis of great folklore epics, be it a statement on religious, social, historical or poetic features reflected in them, our views must be subject to a critical evaluation of the source value of the epic in question.

This requirement would be so much easier to fulfill if we knew more of the sources behind the epic and their original cultural context. Unfortunately, the initial stages and cultural functions of epics based on folk poetry are usually clouded in mystery. The *Mahābhārata*, the epics of Homer, *Beowulf*, the *Nibelungenlied* and the *Edda* all have origins which can only be guessed at, and even such conjectures are at best probabilities. It is impossible to know the author or authors of folklore-based epics as definitely as the name of the author of purely literary epics: they do not have clearly defined authors as do, for instance, the *Aeneid* by Virgil or *Paradise Lost* by Milton.

Paradigms of the making of epics

From the customary folkloristic point of view this is perfectly normal, for the composers of various traditional works — folktales, legends, ballads, ritual songs — are as a rule anonymous. There are, however, important exceptions to this view, much depending on the genre in question, or the poetic culture in general. It is possible to find examples of an awareness of authorship bordering on the concept of copyright in purely or predominantly oral cultures (cf. Finnegan 1988: 98, 104); in China, for example, it is not unusual for the author of a narrative poem to be remembered in tradition by name, domicile, and the time when the composition is said to have taken place (Honko 1986: 10). This exactitude cannot of course be taken as reliable without scrutiny, and it does not exclude the existence of narrative poetic materials nor even ‘variants’ of the poem prior to the alleged composition. To put it briefly, the problem of Homer arises in many genres of oral folk poetry.

Another dimension of this problem, and an exception from the assumed anonymity of oral poetry, is the case where composition takes place in performance. The oral-formulaic school of Parry and Lord and their followers has very successfully propagated the model of an epic singer in which the author and the performer tend to coincide: the performer does not memorise any given ‘text’; instead he creates out of traditional materials a product which is in essence a new rendition of a commonly known plot. The theory has had a powerful impact on comparative epic research, especially in Homeric studies (e. g. Kirk 1976) but it has been criticised because it neglects other forms of oral composition (e. g. Kiparsky 1976: 91–104; Finnegan 1988: 86–109). When the theory holds true, it becomes difficult to maintain the line of demarcation between the original composer and an occasional performer. Instead of one anonymous author we then have many, and most of them well-known.

This line of theorising opens up the possibility of multiple authorship and collective creation which has its roots in Romanticism. During the

Romantic period traditional poetry and national epics were seen as the result of collective effort, of a process of creation in which the contribution of one single individual did not stand out in any way. The moment a single author could be pointed out, the product would have ceased to be folklore, because collectivity was the dividing line between folk poetry and art poetry. The Herderian principle of “das Volk dichtet” (cf. Wilson 1976: 236, note 76) was formulated by Elias Lönnrot (1840) in his foreword to the *Kanteletar*: “Folk poems cannot therefore be said to have been made. They are not made, they make themselves, they are born, they grow and take shape without any special care on the part of the maker” (cf. p. 213). This view was one of the undercurrents in the Romantic theories of epic. It left little room for even an anonymous author and made the process of origin somewhat difficult to conceptualise. None other than Hegel felt the need to demystify the theory by stating firmly: “Yet the epic poem, as a work of art, can emanate from only a single individual. For insofar as the epic proclaims the affairs of the entire nation, it is not the nation as a whole that is the poet but some individual” (cf. p. 207).

The conflict between the two paradigms of the single authorship and collective creation of epics was paralleled by another clash of opposing paradigms, namely that between devolution and evolution. In devolutionary thinking the original composer of an epic was all-important, his creation was the best and most complete; later singers represented a decline both in content, form and function. The paradigm of evolution provided another way of reasoning: out of the sometimes modest initial poem could grow a number of better and larger ones as the poem or the entire genre developed and was adapted to more favourable environments. All four paradigms have been used in comparative research on epics, mostly paired so that single authorship and devolution go side by side, as do collective creation and evolution.

The fate of broad generalisations is to become demystified by everyday experience and empirical evidence. At the moment this is taking place, as scholars are developing multi-faceted typologies of oral composition, as they observe genre-specific and culture-historical differences

in the development of oral poetries, and as they concentrate on the analysis of living epic traditions by focusing on oral epics still to be found in full action, not as fading memory. This analysis renders practically all alternatives feasible, under certain cultural and tradition-ecological conditions. Collective creation also proves to be a fact of life, sometimes depending on the cooperative or social nature of the genre in question, at other times because of real team work by an advanced group of oral poets. Similarly the primordial creator-individual can be brought out into the daylight by examining genre-specific rules of production and reproduction in oral poetry, by specifying forms of adaptation and variation of tradition and by observing folk ideas of the ownership of oral works.

A third pair of opposite paradigms seems, as far as epics are concerned, even more important, namely the oral or literary form of their existence. The burning question in the making of epics concerns the juncture between oral folklore and written literature. Where, when, how and by whom were the oral forms codified into script? We do, after all, know most epics as well-edited texts, not as haphazard oral renditions of narrative episodes. The latter is the air that contemporary oral epics breathe, but we hardly get close enough to sense it, because that which is made available to the fellow scholar or common reader is always the well-edited text. Thus there is always an intermediating hand between us and the oral existence of epics. To whom does this hand belong? The scale of possibilities runs from the scribe who wrote down the *Iliad* at the dictation of the primordial creative singer known by the name of Homer in the quasi-historical tradition to the conscientious scholar of modern times deciphering epics with linguistic exactitude from his sound tape. Between these extremes — the hypothetical scribe and the conscientious linguist, both of whom create an illusion of fidelity — the history of epic making is populated by editors of the most diverse kinds. The oral-formulaic theory purported to solve the Homeric problem, but actually it transferred the problem from the primordial first poet to the late singers, collectors of their songs and the editors of texts thus acquired. Anyone familiar with the field

situation of oral epics is aware of the difficulties met at this end of the folklore process. The moment one tries to present a coherent text to a remote readership important decisions have to be taken. The multitude of variants and contexts of performance is impossible to transmit within one text and its commentary. What usually happens is that the editor chooses one or two singers as key informants, intensifies his work with them and uses their renditions as his guideline. Even so, numerous variations must be set aside and several gaps filled in with other available materials. So long as the editing process is explained to the reader, the scholarly requirement has been met, but quite often the information does not get across. This textualisation of oral epics leads to a situation where we read oral epics that were narrated or sung and, more specifically, we read them in forms that were never actually used in real life.

The performance and textualisation of epics are, then, quite separable processes which follow different sets of rules. The attitude of some scholars, to accept texts as they are offered and without questioning their context and variation, approximates the naivete of the idea of the Homeric scribe whose only task was to write down with the utmost fidelity what was being dictated.

If we care to look at the performance of epics, we see a multitude of forms far from the monotony of the epic text. Two observations readily present themselves. The first is that there is in the oral tradition more epic material than can go into one song, and that the volume of the epic story clearly transcends the format of one performance during, say, one night. Epics tend to fall into rather independent episodes, and the listener's preferences may determine which section is sung or narrated most often. The entire plot of the epic may be known only to specialists in tradition. Another thing which becomes obvious is that an epic is not just one book or text: it is a theme that can be handled in alternative ways. For example, an epic may have a dramatic version, it can be acted out. In India, which still abounds in oral epics, this is more or less the rule. Whenever an old epic or a fragment of one is performed, there is a musician and a narrator and a couple of people who discuss the events and if necessary assume the roles of the characters

in the epic itself. Parts of the epic may be acted out in pantomime. Sometimes dance is the main media used side by side or intertwined with narration. In Tibet the narrator of the Gesar epic dresses up in a special costume, wearing a high conical hat and carrying a sword and other such props (cf. pp. 477–478). Although narration is his main occupation, he performs in a very special dramatic, dance-like way, stabbing an enemy to death with his sword from time to time.

These observations in fact question the concept of epic as a single genre. There is probably always an umbrella in the form of a relatively coherent main plot, but it tolerates variation, it is hardly ever told in its entirety and it manifests itself in several parts through a number of media. To call this narrative frame and general plot a genre may be possible but does not reflect the actual situation of the tradition in question. The editor may be able to put everything into a coherent narrative, but he certainly faces a number of problems.

The transformation of an epic performance into a text takes many forms. Sometimes the situation is reversed, and a literary text becomes the backbone of an epic performance, which then contains many other ingredients from relatively spontaneous commentary to cultic behaviour and worship. As if to underline the wide range of possibilities in epic performance, even the physical audience may recede, and the recitation of an epic becomes a ritual act performed in solitude to a god or goddess. This is the case with Rāmāyana in South-Indian oral tradition (Blackburn 1987: 572–586). Interestingly, only 825–1400 verses of the Rāma story of about 40.000 lines (10.000 verses) told by the court poet Kampan (and composed between 885 and 1185 A. D. in Tamil) are used in the folk performance, mostly unaltered, but expressed through the medium of shadow puppetry and involving lengthy commentaries of a philosophical nature and narrative expansion. Together with extra-textual elements these prolong the puppet plays to last for 8–21 nights. Much of the text, i. e. about 5–10% of the verse material plus the commentaries, represents oral lore attached to the selected verses (maximally 2.000) of Kampan's epic. The absence of an audience is explained by the votive nature of the ritual: the epic is performed to

the goddess Lakṣmi, who was in Śiva's heaven promised a vision of the death of Rāvaṇa (a demon king) (Blackburn 1987: 579).

The performance approach to epics thus widens the scope of the predominantly textual comparisons of epics. Just as oral composition must be freed from the unilateral tenets of the oral-formulaic school and a typology of all observable forms of oral composition must be created, so the stereotype "from oral to literary" must be replaced by a typology of forms which covers the oral but "written-like" handling of material, the interaction of oral and literary sources, the use of notebooks and manuscripts, sometimes visible, at other times not visible in the oral performances of epics, the recitation of texts in written style or in oral style, various forms of 'copying' oral text, the transfer of ownership of oral texts, etc. At this level of analysis important paradoxes may surface: a particular written text may be more oral than another relegated to human memory only.

Empirical research into living epic traditions in different parts of the world is capable of providing new impulses for the predominantly textual research on the world's epics. The contextual approach presumes the participation of historians of religion, folklorists and anthropologists, alongside philologists and literary historians. This interdisciplinary work aims at a better understanding and criticism of our sources, and ultimately it enables us to decipher the meaning and function of epic expression in its cultural diversity. It should also provide a sufficient number of models for our imagination, when we conjecture on the origin of great epics.

The position of the Kalevala in comparative research on epics

Romanticism created a folklore movement in Europe, especially in nations that were young or otherwise in need of support for their cultural identity. Romanticism idealised the people although it was

distant, and claimed it was creative and active when it was in fact suppressed and passive. Folklore was a description of a people by the people itself; its collective experiences and mood were crystallised in the words of folk poems. Folk poetry was natural, created collectively, as opposed to art poetry and its individual poets. In Germany J. G. Herder wanted his fellow citizens to turn away from the admiration of things foreign, especially French, and to enhance national self-esteem by finding the spiritual resources hidden in folk songs, which could be seen as the basis for new national literature. Herder characterised folk poetry as the “imprints of the soul” and the “archives of a nationality”; it was “the expression of the weaknesses and perfections of a nationality, a mirror of its sentiments, the expression of the highest to which it aspired” (Wilson 1973: 825–826). Folk poetry opened up a channel to the history, language, mores and thinking of a community. In addition to his nationalistic view, Herder also thought of folklore in the global perspective, not only as the “living voice of nationalities” but of all mankind.

The seeds sown by Romanticism brought a rich harvest in Europe. Folklore publications began to appear, first in Germany, then in Czechoslovakia, Poland, Serbia, Russia, and the Nordic countries, notably Norway and Finland. Herder’s impact was so strong in Eastern Europe that he has been called “the real father of the renaissance of the Slavic peoples” and “the creator of their philosophy of culture” (Wilson 1973: 831). In Finland Romantic ideas were absorbed by an underdeveloped new nation which lacked literature in its own language but was rich in oral poetry. Of all the nations of Europe Finland came closest to the fulfillment of the Herderian dream when an epic based on folk poems, the *Kalevala*, was published in 1835–36 and became the cornerstone of Finnish literature. The work almost instantly acquired the status of national epic.

It is against this background that the position of the *Kalevala* must be defined. The discussion of the genesis of great epics has been somewhat hampered by imprecision. For some scholars an epic meant a given people’s epic poetry in general, others used the word for any

largish narrative poem, whereas some reserved this term only for extensive, written poetic works. According to this last-mentioned group of scholars, the epic is actually not considered a form of folk poetry at all. An epic is not born without being organised by its compiler and editor. Thus, it is the birth of an epic that transforms oral poetry into literature. It was this view that was widely adopted by the scholars who studied the Kalevala and compared it to other great epics. The Romantic concept of “folk epic” as a sizeable, ready-made oral work had to be abandoned, although Romantic theories lingered in the mind of scholars and partly still do. It seemed that most folk poetry epics were the result of some kind of editing process and the use of some writing system. What was usually left open was the question: what were the sources used in the compilation of an epic? What guidelines were adopted for the selection of oral poetry, and what was the method developed for the compilation process itself?

As regards many of the folklore-based epics the answer to these questions can only be approximate, if indeed they can be answered at all. From this point of view the Kalevala constituted an interesting exception. The compiler-editor is well-known: he is Elias Lönnrot (1802–1884), who for twenty years acted as district physician in Kajaani, in north-eastern Finland, and after that as Professor of Finnish language and literature at the University of Helsinki. We know exceptionally well, line by line, the sources of the Kalevala: the folk poems which Lönnrot collected during the eleven journeys he made to the eastern and northern provinces of Finland in 1828–1844 as well as the poems which were collected by dozens of other collectors and which were included in the second edition of the Kalevala in 1849. We also know much about Lönnrot’s working methods: he describes them in his travel accounts and newspaper articles. Since the original recorded poems have been preserved (they were published in the 33-volume *Suomen Kansan Vanhat Runot* 1908–1948), and since other documentary material also abounds, we are able to follow in the footsteps of the compiler of the epic, as if we were looking over his shoulder as he sits at his desk, and thus to follow the process which resulted in the

Kalevala. Such precise knowledge may be helpful in attempting to reconstruct similar processes preceding the birth of other great epics. And Lönnrot's key problem — how to put into book form variegated but contentually and stylistically coherent narrative poetry — is very much alive in the case of the living oral epics of today.

The visibility of the Kalevala in epic research

A hundred years ago the Kalevala was an academic sensation that inspired foreign scholars to write lengthy treatises (e. g. Comparetti 1891), but since then interest among epic scholars has declined. For this there are many reasons: the original poem material used by Lönnrot was not translated *in extenso*, so the source analysis became a Finnish affair; the scholars analysing the Kalevala were few and they did not publish their results in widely-spoken languages; folkloristic research steered away from the epic toward the plentiful oral materials and the study of the Kalevala was assigned to the literary historians (of whom only few acquired the necessary competence through comparative epic research); the Romantic theory of epics provoked a disappointment once Lönnrot's role as compiler became clearer: the Kalevala was not, according to this opinion, an authentic folk epic but Lönnrot's fabrication. Even today there are influential scholars who are not very well informed on the problems of epic research but who subscribe to the Romantic concept of the folk epic and dismiss the Kalevala from the family of great epics (Dundes 1985).

The decline in interest is visible in the absence of the Kalevala from some representative works. A fairly recent survey of the world's epics, *Traditions of Heroic and Epic Poetry* (1980) edited by the well-known British scholar A. T. Hatto, does not even mention the Kalevala, and the same applies to *La poesia epica e la sua formazione*, the publication of the international epic research symposium arranged by Italian

scholars in 1970. The years in between saw the publication of *Heroic Epic and Saga* (1978) edited by Felix J. Oinas, a good general survey of European epic traditions and the epics of the ancient cultures of Persia, Mesopotamia and India. This work does contain a chapter on Baltic-Finnic epics, the *Kalevala* and the *Kalevipoeg*.

These works represent the classic, Eurocentric line of research, modelled on and gauged according to Homeric studies. The curtain is rising only slowly on Third World epics and living contemporary epic traditions: the result is a modicum of uncertainty, perhaps also a thirst for new empirical facts and a healthy wariness of generalisations. The last of these is reflected in the remark by Arthur Waley: "When I think of epics, I think how different they all are" (Hatto 1980: 2). The dominant position of Homeric research has in the post-war period been considerably protracted by the oral composition theory based mainly on the preservation and performance of Serbo-Croatian epics, put forward by Milman Parry and Albert Lord, largely because they applied it not only to their field material but also to the problem of Homer (e. g. Lord 1965). This meant a shift of paradigms: the old theories of Wolf and Lachmann on the literary editing of Homeric epics from individual songs existing in the oral tradition were obliged to step aside. Homer, by then virtually eliminated as a person, was reinstated: "a great bard" (one or more) had orally conceived complete epics and dictated them to scribes. In this development we see one more reason for the decline of interest in the *Kalevala*: the *Liedertheorie* of Lachmann and the decisive role of the editor, as defined by Wolf, are clearly more in line with the *Kalevala* process.

As pointed out above, the oral-formulaic theory was a step toward living epic tradition, toward late singers and the rules for the reproduction of tradition. In other words, the focus began to shift from the written epic to the oral. This change was already foreseen by the Soviet scholar A. N. Veselovski in 1940, when he accused research into Homer and the *Nibelungenlied* of "totally neglecting the living epic tradition":

Western scholars with only the slightest acquaintance with living epic tradition mechanically transfer the principles of a purely literary text

criticism to ancient folk poetry. All Nibelungenlied criticism has suffered from this, and to some extent criticism of the Homeric epic, too. — — It is essential to start with the sung epic and to examine with care its structure and the stages in its evolution. — — This method is impossible in the German-speaking area, which no longer has any kinds of living epic whatsoever (Schirmunski 1961: 5).

The view expressed here is interesting in that the Finns and the Russians are in the same position: neither can boast a great (over 1.000 lines long), sung, oral epic. Yet both have a rich heroic narrative poetry preserved in areas close to each other (easternmost Finland and north-western Russia). Even so, scholarly views on the relationships between the epic and folk poetry travelled in different directions. The reasons for this were numerous: the Finns had the Kalevala where the Russians lacked a comprehensive epic, the Finns applied the geographic-historical method with its text-critical approach whereas the Russians were opposed to the method (e. g. Honko 1985: 324–326), the views of societal development were divergent and, last but not least, there were real differences between poetry in Kalevala metre and *byliny* (see Oinas, below, pp. 287–309). The greater variation in *byliny* prompted Russian scholars to reason along the lines of composition-in-performance, where the Finnish scholars saw mechanical slips of memory.

A further step toward oral epics has been taken thanks to the publication of several epics still living in the developing countries. Many of these have entered the world of scholarship after many years of laborious work out in the field by researchers who have also taken a long look at the technique of performance and the social context of the epic. Such works as E. Boelaert's *L'Epopée nationale des Nkundo* (1949), Daniel Biebuyck and K. C. Mateene's *The Mwindo Epic* (1971), Gordon Innes' *Sunjata, Three Mandinka Versions* (1974), Nigel Phillips' *Sijobang, Sung Narrative Poetry of West Sumatra* (1981) and Brenda E. F. Beck's *The Three Twins, The Telling of a South Indian Folk Epic* (1982) have placed areas once in the literary outback right in the centre of the world's epos map. The feeling for the life of oral epics

once almost extinct — most epics were known from literary sources and even short epic poetry was vanishing from Europe — has been revived. At the same time belief in central postulates of epic theory has been undermined, as is well reflected in this book in the article by Jan Knappert (pp. 381–401). Good examples of the new wave in epic research are the analysis by Christiane Seydou of four African epics (pp. 403–423) and the observations of ‘Jam-dpal rgyal-mtsho (pp. 471–484) and Silke Herrmann (pp. 485–502) on the present state of the Tibetan epic *Gesar*. In addition to Africa, India and Indonesia, Central Asia and certain regions of China are among the most important preservers of the oral epic.

This state of affairs is of considerable significance to *Kalevala* research. New empirical observations on oral epic traditions, even if they come from very different cultures, are forcing Finnish scholars to re-read both Lönnrot and other collectors of Finnish and Karelian poetry with greater attention. We must once again enter the world of living poetry and its varied performance against which Lönnrot constantly viewed his *Kalevala*. The development profiles of individual folk poems designed in the spirit of comparison may not be as useful as systemic studies of local poetic cultures and the ideas and interpretations of the singers, still readable in the folk poem texts. From the general epic research point of view, the Lönnrot experience may be something to think about and compare to the situation of the modern editors of oral epics.

What is an epic?

“An epic is a superstory,” says Brenda Beck (1982: 196). It is a folk genre implying first-class narration. There are five points which, in Beck’s opinion, entitle us to classify the story of the twin brothers living in the western central area of Tamilnadu as an epic: 1) it is

performed by professional bards, 2) it is long, much longer than any of the other folk narratives encountered in the region, 3) its heroes are sacred figures worshipped in the local temples, 4) it links up with broader mythological and civilizational traditions, and 5) both the narrators and the listeners believe that the events described really did once take place (Beck 1982: 196–197). Although this definition is deliberately bound to its Indian cultural background, it does contain features that could be transferred, such as the overlapping of mythology and history, the scope of the narrative, the cultural representativity and the expert narrators.

Research to date has for the most part applied the concept of the epic inherited from the Romantic era. This includes, for example, the oral origin of the lore on which the epic is based, the concentration of what may in principle be very varied material around the valiant deeds of national heroes; memories of a heroic era are handed down from one generation to the next, because out of the battles waged at that time emerged a national identity; it was also then that material culture and a thriving economy laid the foundations for the birth of a powerful and militant elite whose members fought above all to achieve lasting fame both for themselves and for their families. Various kings, chiefs and nobles kept at their courts, and also on their journeys, singers to compose songs about their valiant deeds and to raise morale by singing about the heroic deeds committed by ancestors (Yoshida 1974: 906).

This explanation by a Japanese epic scholar may be regarded as an aristocratic version of the definition. There is indeed something in it; it finds support in, for example, modern Africa, where a noble of the Fulbe tribe of the Sudan took a singer with him on his adventures to carry his shield and to compose an epic poem about his feats of valour (Yoshida 1974: 907). The truth was of course in many cases more mundane, since the songs of praise of the griots or professional singers of the Gambia were sometimes a major strain on the master's purse, for a mighty song of praise demanded a considerable fee (Innes 1974: 4–5, 10–11). In former times the griots did not have to work and their epics were long, containing genealogies linking their masters with

the family of King Sunjata — the national hero — or one of his generals; nowadays mere songs of praise are sung on such occasions as weddings, and the verse of the Sunjata epic repeated perhaps more than any other, the singer's comment, reflects the decline of this institution:

In Sunjata's day a griot knew nothing of water carrying,
To say nothing of farming and gathering firewood.
Father World has changed, changed. (Innes 1974: 16.)

In any case Sunjata is, even today, something more than other narratives. Gordon Innes describes how the Gambian-born Bakari Sidibe sees the importance of the epic:

Though Sunjata is undoubtedly stronger and braver than we are, he is nevertheless a human being like ourselves. The qualities which he has are the qualities which we ourselves have, in however diminished a form. Sunjata shows us of what a man is capable. Even if we could never aspire to equal the deeds of Sunjata, nevertheless we feel our stature as men is enhanced by the knowledge of what a man like Sunjata could achieve. Before a battle, a griot would narrate the Sunjata epic to the king and his followers. This narration encouraged the listeners to excel themselves when the battle was joined, not so much by inspiring them to emulate Sunjata, but by making them feel that they were capable of greater things than they had previously thought possible. By reminding them of what Sunjata could do, it raised their estimate of what they themselves could do. Mr Sidibe said that listening to the Sunjata epic not only gives a man a feeling of intense pride, but also makes him look at his own life — what has he achieved, has he acquitted himself in a way befitting a man in his position, has he enhanced the family name, or at any rate not diminished it? (Innes 1974: 10.)

Sidibe's statement reflects a model familiar from mythology the world over: the characteristics of the exemplary and the primordial deeds are accessible even to people today "the same but smaller". Innes points

out the interesting similarity between what Sidibe says and the definition of heroic poetry given by C. M. Bowra:

The admiration for great doings lies deep in the human heart, and comforts and cheers even when it does not stir to emulation. Heroes are the champions of man's ambition to pass beyond the oppressive limits of human frailty to a fuller and more vivid life, to win as far as possible a self-sufficient manhood, which refuses to admit that anything is too difficult for it, and is content even in failure, provided that it has made every effort of which it is capable. (Bowra 1952: 4.)

The similarity noted by Innes is not an indication of e. g. 'Europeanisation'. The exemplariness described in concrete terms is quite sufficiently transformed. For example, the Western Sumatran hero Anggun Nan Tungga, whose adventures would take seven nights, at the shortest 23 hours and 40.000 lines to tell (Phillips 1981: 18–21), is in the mind of the listener a paragon of virtue, even though he cheats his most loyal companion (admittedly in favour of the companion's parents), seduces a woman to test another's feelings and is on countless occasions cunning and treacherous, which is described as mere diplomacy, for treachery and hiding one's true intentions are regarded as praiseworthy acts both in proverbs and in everyday life. What is more, Nan Tungga's untiring efforts to satisfy, during his odyssey lasting many years and taking him to numerous islands, all the requests made of him by his bride Gondoriah at the moment of parting is an almost heart-breaking proof of loyalty, even if the hero does repeatedly take new brides (Phillips 1981: 34).

Observations on oral epics have thrown new light on the importance of context in the variation of content, the problem of memorisation and oral composition, differences between oral and written compilation, changes in the text caused by singing and dictating, the status of the singer and his position in the power structure of society, etc. It has repeatedly had to be admitted that no indisputably 'correct' version exists. One characteristic of the oral epic is the almost endless variation, though even here it is possible to discern signs of standardisation: for

example, the versions of the young boy singing the Sijobang epic are labile, whereas his teacher is able to turn out lines with 8–9 syllables for hours on end without making any significant changes in the structure or meaning (Phillips 1981: 164–170).

The exemplary nature of the heroes is occasioned not only by individual psychology but by the culture. How could it be otherwise, at least in cases where the narrative derives its strength from group identity or the social context? Brenda Beck has given an interesting account of the relationship between the values expressed in the regional epic examined by her and the universal Indian values as presented in the fundamental narratives of Indian civilisation, the *Mahābhārata* and *Rāmāyaṇa*:

The Brothers story is a mouthpiece for the powerfully mixed judgments of those who live on the margins of a wider political system. It describes their view of those who move at the center. References to India's great epics and to known Brahmanical views are to be found throughout this regional legend. What is more impressive, however, is that this account mocks so many pan-Indian norms. Opposition and inversion both play key roles in this epic's thematic organization. These structural features help to define the story as separate from the great literature of India in many ways. In fact, these particular details thoroughly color its oral variants. Sanskritization, as a desire to imitate or to borrow, does not take account of this counterculture construction process. The Three Twins attempts to capture the playfulness, double meanings, and sense of paradox so deeply imbedded in this regional perspective. It also lays out some of the richly textured details about a specific folk identity that this specific legend projects. (Beck 1982: 197.)

A. T. Hatto comes close to saying that each epic carries a very special cultural identity and deplores the fact that Homer and Aristotle were long regarded as norms and authorities in epic research:

Heroic and epic traditions are the products of culture in the highest degree. Their bearers, whom we term 'bards', cultivate their reper-

toires unceasingly in terms both of the experience of their societies and of the latent potential of their languages, with the result that to the best ability of its bards each tradition presents an extreme case. As long as little else is known, the Homeric poems were regarded as norms for epic, a view buttressed by the authority of Aristotle. Yet had Aristotle collected 'barbaric' epic poems as open-mindedly as he collected 'barbaric' constitutions and had he studied them as profoundly, he must have placed Homer differently. Comparisons such as those undertaken by the London Seminar on Epic show the Homeric poems to be as extreme and idiosyncratic as those of any other tradition, irrespective of aesthetic quality. (Hatto 1980: 2–3.)

Hatto classifies the world's epics into four categories: 1) oral (such as those of the Ainu, the Kirghiz, the Mongols and the Serbo-Croats), 2) sub-oral (Homeric), 3) post-oral (the old French and medieval Spanish epic and the Nibelungenlied) and 4) secondary epics (the Aeneid, Paradise Lost) (Hatto 1980: 11). His classification of Homer is due to the presence of written culture at the codification stage. The oral epic may also border on the written tradition, as in Yugoslavia. What is, however, decisive is the preservation of the oral style (including the mode of performance, singing); for this reason the Nibenlungenlied is post-oral, though there is proof that it was collected on parchment and spread in this way. The term "written" may in these contexts denote the potential for reading a text, rather than dissociation from the norms of the oral tradition. These would appear to be sensible modifications in view of the numerous parallel versions of oral epics to be found today. Take, for example, the part played by the written tradition in the oral folklore of India, or the acting out of epics. The Three Twins is performed at the annual festival, even including the central battle scenes (the heroes die and are brought back to life by the technique of possession), the Tibetan singer of Gesar presents the most important scenes in dance, and the alternative presentation of the Sijobang epic is specifically a play (*randai*).

Then what about the Kalevala? How does it fit into Hatto's classification? Not, it would seem, as a secondary epic the artistic nature of

which is stressed. Perhaps the Kalevala comes closest to 'post-oral', still tied in many ways to the norms of oral expression, as we shall see later. Surprisingly enough, the Kalevala is biased towards literature not so much by its content or texture as by the fact that it was originally published as something to be read, not sung. Homer, too, has always been an epic to be read, and there are fewer variants of this than of the Kalevala, but because research will never have access to Homer's folklore sources, its oral nature is open to infinite speculation.

Although the oral epics examined here vary even down to the logic and structures of their plots, their length, for example, nevertheless remains a *conditio sine qua non*. In comparative studies on oral epics the shortest length allowed so far has been "more than 200–300 lines" (Haymes 1977: 4). It may be a bit short; the longest cycles of Finnish and Karelian epic poetry — for example, the 366 line Sampo cycle by Ontrei Malinen (cf. pp. 201) — would then qualify as an epic. At the other extreme we have the figures for the numbers of lines stated below (pp. 480–481) for the epics of China, but perhaps they also include variants. The extent of the Sijobang epic has already been mentioned. It is generally estimated that 4.000–5.000 lines are the limit beyond which the audience, if not the singer, does not wish to go without some technical arrangement which allows intermission and rest. For example, no listener has a command of the entire Sijobang, nor do all singers, presumably, for this epic is sung in highly independent episodes as requested by the audience, so that the less popular episodes are seldom performed. The singers know the sequence of episodes, which can be varied, but for many listeners there probably only exist a number of stories about Anggun Nan Tungga, without any special order (Phillips 1981: 29).

Despite this loosening in concepts of the stability of the epic, the notion applied by, for example, Russian scholars nevertheless seems somewhat inflated. According to this the name of the hero is sufficient as the connecting element; the poems themselves may even be completely separate, but still the epic can be attributed to a particular nation on the argument that the epic is the outcome of one stage in the development of

society and is hence homogeneous and a marker of identity. Marxist scholarship has never accepted the idea of an aristocracy and a feudal society in the Kalevala; instead the epic has been viewed as founded on a classless kinship or tribal community operating on the principle of common ownership. The external structure and the consistency of the overall plot are in this line of thought less important than the internal organisation of the poetry in question. This may explain to a degree the fact that Russian epic poetry was unhesitatingly presented to international scholarship as such, as shortish poems, or more precisely, as cycles of loosely-connected poems, more as epic traditions than book-like epics. Vladimir Propp presents this viewpoint as follows:

The folk epic requires not outward consistency but inner consistency, consistent heroic figures. The heroes are the same in all the songs. The folk epic is characterised by stylistic and, most important of all, contentual national-ideological consistency. Any educated person can immediately distinguish the Karelian-Finnish poem, the Russian bylina, the Serbian heroic song, the Yakut olonho, etc. The sum of the distinguishing features in any folk epic is the consistency that is one of the best and most valuable features of the epic in question. This inner consistency is not, however, the same as the outward uniformity, limited scope and perfection. The true epic always consists of isolated songs which the people do not join together, yet even so these songs form an entity. The literary epic is outwardly uniform, but inwardly like a mosaic. (Propp 1984: 74.)

According to Propp, the epic, in the conventional, literary sense, is a genre alien to folklore:

The people themselves sometimes combine various themes by means of contamination, but the people never create an epic. They would be capable of doing so, but their aesthetic sense does not require it, because they do not aim at outward consistency. The reasons why the people do not aim at outward consistency are very complex. One is that it would destroy the creative freedom and vitality of folk poetry.

Turning individual songs into a vast epic would, as it were, inhibit the epic, reduce its flexibility, mobility and charm, its potential for daily reconstruction, creative amendments and additions. The individual separate song gives the singer complete freedom. Narrative poetry is created for singing, not reading, the song strives towards freedom and mobility, whereas the epic is rigid and changes and adaptations require great perseverance. (Propp 1984: 73.)

In 1949 Propp was not familiar with the epics of the developing countries, but he did have some idea of the epics and epic poetry of the Soviet peoples. He seems to have underestimated the folkloric ability to create broader entities, too, as necessary. Thus he does not speak of length as a criterion for an epic; he presumably regarded this as being of secondary importance. If we accept Propp's view, then Lönnrot struggled in vain. The Finns already had an epic. But so did most other nations of Europe and the rest of the world. In this constellation it suddenly becomes very easy to let the Romantic dream of a national epic come true. That Soviet studies on epics have been so vigorous is no wonder: Soviet folkloristics has long been the most unassailable bastion of romantic interest in folk poetry.

The Kalevala in the comparative perspective

The 150th anniversary of the Kalevala in 1985 provided an opportunity for putting Finland's national epic back on the world map of comparative epic research. The jubilee year stirred up quite sufficient interest in the Kalevala among scholars outside Finland. The most important conferences devoted to it were organised in Turku and Dublin (papers from the latter published in Almqvist, Ó Catháin & Ó Héalaí 1987). Delegates at the Turku symposium were supplied in advance with the following list of themes that might possibly be taken up:

- a) the general problems of epic research,
- b) romantic theories of the folk epic in 18th and 19th century Europe,

- c) the origin, materials and compilation of epics founded on oral traditions,
- d) the possibility of an oral epic and its performance,
- e) the cultural context of the emergence of an epic,
- f) the reception of the epic and the influence of the epic as literature,
- g) the relationship between epics and identities (cultural, national, regional, ethnic),
- h) the special problems of some particular epic,
- i) research into the Kalevala and
- j) comparison of the Kalevala with other epics.

Although the main emphasis was on general comparative epic research, several participants viewed their themes in relation to the Kalevala.

The material fell naturally into three categories in the course of editing: Models — Result — Points for comparison (Europe, Africa, Asia). The first main section takes a look at the epics with which Elias Lönnrot was in all probability familiar and which therefore influenced his Kalevala. The problem is to decide how well he knew them and how far their influence can be proved. In addition each writer does, of course, concentrate on the special questions of the epic dealt with, and these too in most cases have direct links with the problems behind the Kalevala.

The paramount model was Homer. “The paradox of traditional narrative is that what is original is the end of the process, the poems as the expression of the creative art of the rhapsode who dictated them and the receptive art of his audience,” says Minna Skafte Jensen at the end of her paper (p. 47). The Kalevala, too, is the terminal point at the end of a long development which led to the transformation of folklore into literature. These two epics occupy different positions in the research strategy, for the variants and source materials of the Homeric epics have not been preserved in any other form, whereas more is known about the five versions of the Kalevala and their sources than about any other epic. At one time scholars — Lönnrot included! — viewed the Kalevala process as a model for the process of origin of the Iliad

and the *Odyssey*. Today this is not the case, but the pendulum may swing again.

The impact of other models is also estimated. Lars Lönnroth points out that the *Edda* had more influence than was thought, whereas Hans Fromm claims that the *Nibelungenlied* was virtually unknown to Lönnrot when he compiled the *Kalevala*. Should Lönnrot be compared to Homer or to Virgil? Teivas Oksala seeks an answer to this. Macpherson, the scapegoat of Romantic interest in the epic, is examined by the greatest expert on him, Derick Thomson, who cleverly distinguishes between the objective influence of the *Songs of Ossian* and the wave of opinion that surrounded it. For Lönnrot, too, Macpherson was an important reference on the question of authenticity.

The second main section is devoted to Finnish contributions. Matti Kuusi examines the sequences of oral epic poems to be found as cycles, i. e. the possibility of much smaller but oral epics than the literary *Kalevala*. Some of them deserve the name of folk epic, but generally their kernel consists of poems sung separately by most singers. Still it seems that research into regional small epics should be continued, not least because of the differences in the local interpretations of the material. Väinö Kaukonen, who has devoted most of his scholarly life to the *Kalevala*, discusses the way in which the *Kalevala* functions specifically as an epic. Analysis of the *Kalevala*'s plot structure, which was in a way Lönnrot's problem par excellence, is here very much to the fore. The article by the editor opens a processual view on the *Kalevala* from the early beginnings and historical vicissitudes to an analysis of Lönnrot's method and interpretation of the Romantic theories of epics in the final phase. Pirkko Alhoniemi surveys the reception of the *Kalevala* in Finland and its influence on the arts, with special reference to literature.

The European points of comparison for the *Kalevala* emerge from the basic situation in the first half of the 19th century, as outlined by Vilmos Voigt. The relations between the *Kalevala* and the Estonian *Kalevipoeg* (Eduard Laugaste), comparison of the Russian and the Karelian epics (Felix J. Oinas), an analysis of mythologemes in the

basic material of the Kalevala and a comparative perspective on the South-Slavic epics (David E. Bynum), the numerous often fragmentary attempts at an epic among the Uralic peoples (Péter Domokos), and a comparison with Mireille, the literary epic of Provence (Rudolf Schenda), provide cornerstones on which to construct a contemporary view of the Kalevala.

Africa, as was pointed above, offers interesting material for comparison on the dynamics of living oral epics (Jan Knappert, Christiane Seydou). Micheline Galley adds a portrait of an Arabic epic co-existing as both an oral and a literary tradition.

The epics alive today in Central Asia (Walther Heissig, 'Jam-dpal rgyal-mtsho, Silke Herrmann), the north-south opposition between historical and mythical epics in China (Jia Zhi), the relationship between the Ainu epic and the Siberian and Japanese influence (Taryo Obayashi), and the mythical-historical ruler genealogies of the Persian Book of Kings (Jaan Puhvel) are only the tip of the iceberg of comparable themes manifest in the epics of Asia. Due to unfortunate circumstances India, the motherland of epics, is present only in random references.

In spite of his basically historical interpretation of the poetry on which the Kalevala was founded, Elias Lönnrot did not alter the truly mythical character of the folk poems. There is wide agreement among experts that the Kalevala is above all a mythical, some say 'shamanistic' epic. The historical element so prevalent in the epics surviving in the neighbourhood of the poetry in Kalevala metre, the Russian byliny, is almost totally lacking, and the heroes are fighters not with swords but with words. The epilogue (Eino Karhu, Lauri Honko) is devoted to an examination of how this mythical heritage survives in modern literature and contemporary society with its problems of defining national and regional identity.

The problems surrounding the Kalevala are not solved by any jubilee year. Lönnrot's epic is, it seems, destined to totter like a tightrope walker between folk epic and literary epic. Perhaps it is time to leave the terms imposed by the Romanticists in peace and to examine the evolution of the epic as one manifestation of the production of folklore

that covers both processes, namely, those set in motion by the singers of oral epics and those completed by persons who noted down and edited the epics. To place the Kalevala on this scale is an illuminating task for research, because here one can view the processes intertwined and fully documented.

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Models

Minna Skafte Jensen

The Homeric Epics and Greek Cultural Identity

The achievement of Milman Parry, in analysing and describing the style of Homer ("Homer" is in this paper used as a brief way of saying the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*) as oral and traditional, is well known, and his investigations into the technicalities of this style — the formulas, the themes, and the adding style — have been the basis for most comparative studies of the epic during the last few decades. In the field of Homeric scholarship, Parry's followers have concentrated mainly on reaching a fuller understanding of the function of the formula, its flexibility and variability, its relation to the demands of the metre, etc., and much fruitful work has been done. One overall aim of these studies might be seen as that of describing oral composition from the point of view of the poet, almost of understanding the mentality of the oral bard. Thus, of the two adjectives with which Parry characterised Homeric style, "oral" has been given priority over "traditional", and of the two main creative forces involved in the performance, the poet has been given priority over the audience.

In the present paper I shall build on Parry's description of Homer's oral, traditional style, but pass from the level of style to that of content. I shall discuss the ways in which I think traditional poems influence the cultural identity of their audience, what it means to our reading of the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* that they are traditional, and how they still reflect the identity of the Greek culture shared by the poet and his public, as well as characteristic traits peculiar to the Athenian audience.

The nature of traditional texts

“Tradition” is Latin for “handing over” — but what is handed over, and by whom to whom? Narrative traditions have their analogy in the traditions of natural languages: words and grammar are handed over from one generation to the next in a continuous chain, and any utterance in a given language is an individual manifestation of the common tradition. The grammar may be described or not, the single speaker may know of the existence of grammar or not, but he/she nevertheless conforms to its rules and expects other speakers to do the same. The “words” and “grammar” of a narrative tradition are more comprehensive units: its “words” are elements of the story, roughly what Parry and Lord called “themes” (and I shall not here discuss the criticism that this term has met), while its “grammar” is narrative patterns. “Once upon a time there was a farmer who had three sons” — no more need be said before an expectation has been built that the youngest and despised son will win the princess and half the kingdom. The “grammar” of traditional narrative may or may not correspond to experience from the real world. When it says in the Old Testament that the infant Moses was exposed in a basket on the Nile, such a practice must have been known to the community where the story was first told, and in this sense the narrative corresponds to reality. However, the fact that the audience knows immediately that this child is going to become an important hero is due exclusively to the “grammar”; in real life the future of an exposed child would be less brilliant.

In a modern Western society literature is not without traditions; there are, e. g., different expectations for different literary genres. The reader who opens a novel does so with different expectations from the one who begins reading a volume of lyrics, or the spectators taking their seats in a theatre. But there is no guarantee that their expectations will be fulfilled; the author is free to stick to the rules of the genre or not. Readers and spectators will not protest if the rules are broken; they are far more likely to be irritated if all their expectations come

true. Our literature is mainly individualistic, and the rules of tradition are there to be broken.

The opposite is true of a traditional text. Deviations from the “grammar” are considered errors, to which the audience will react with derision or protests: the text will be considered ungrammatical in a way analogous to how a sentence is disapproved of if the rules of grammar are broken. A narrative tradition is an unconscious social contract in the same sense as a language, and a traditional text is composed according to rules that are not created by any single performer but by the tradition as such.

Each single traditional text is an individual manifestation of the common tradition. This does not mean that traditional texts are identical any more than utterances in one and the same language are identical; on the contrary, there are infinite possibilities for different manifestations of a tradition, be it of language or of story-telling. However, scholars often treat traditional texts as if they were the whole tradition; this is an error that is especially close to hand where only a few manifestations of a tradition are known, as is the case with the ancient Greek epic. Failure to distinguish between the tradition and its manifestations has often led to underestimation of the individual qualities of texts, and to a lack of interest in their specific social contexts. Scholars have not uncommonly felt that the oldest layers of a tradition are most worthy of study, and in their eagerness to select the most original parts for special analysis they have overlooked qualities manifest in the surviving examples of an otherwise lost tradition (cf. Holbek 1987).

Whenever an oral, traditional text of some length and complexity is performed, the performance marks the end of a traditional process, however much the tradition as such goes on in an infinite number of other manifestations. The text is composed of elements of different ages, but the elements are selected by the author in question with regard to the special situation for which the text is meant. The same is true when such a text is recorded in writing. For an analysis of aesthetic qualities (and presumably for other types of analysis too) it is therefore necessary to analyse this particular final text and to see its

components, the oldest as well as the newest, from the viewpoint of the unity of the individual text of which they are a part.

In a synchronic analysis the tradition is the constant as against its manifestations, which are the variables. In a diachronic analysis, however, even the tradition is unstable: any natural language develops, and so do narrative traditions. One main reason for this are changes in the life of the community to which the tradition belongs. But change in vocabulary is more common than change in grammar, and even drastic change is slight in comparison with the general stability of the tradition: if not, the language would no longer be understood and would thus no longer be a language.

The nature of Homeric language and style

When Parry analysed the traditional style of the Homeric poems, he followed a model that had been developed for the history of the Homeric language. It has never been the spoken dialect of anybody, but is a mixture of word-forms belonging to different natural Greek dialects, not to speak of hybrid forms, or of completely artificial forms. This state of affairs bears witness to the difficulties the Greek epic poets were up against: the hexameter as such excludes many normal Greek word-forms. For example, a noun like *ktemata*, “goods”, suits the hexameter in the nominative, accusative and dative cases, but its genitive form has a rhythm that excludes it from being used in the hexameter. This means that for the genitive case the epic poet must resort to a synonym or avoid speaking of “goods” in the genitive altogether (Meillet 1923: 57–70).

What is interesting in the study of traditions is the fact that the mixture of dialects is not haphazard but makes up a system. For example, the very first verse of the *Iliad* has a formula for the main hero, Achilles, at the end: *Peleiadeo Achileos*, which is genitive for

“Achilles, son of Peleus”. The forms in which the patronymic and the proper name are given belong to two different stages in the development of Homeric language, where *Peleiadeo* is a younger form than *Achileos*. The formula is easily “translatable” into an older stage than both: *Peleiada*’ *Achilaos*. From here the patronymic has taken two steps, first the change from long *a* to long *e*, and next from the ending *ēō* to *ēō̄*. These two steps were taken without any problems, since in both cases the younger forms were applicable to the same place in the hexameter as the older ones. Achilles’ proper name, however, in the genitive case used here, has taken only the first of these two steps, from *—āōs* to *—ēōs*, whereas the next step, from *—ēōs* to *—ēō̄s*, would have given the word a new rhythm and thus demanded a complete change of the formula (Chantraine 1943 and 1958).

Since it is possible to follow in detail the history of Homer’s language, it has been possible to demonstrate the inherent feature that old and new coexist, but not in a chaotic mixture: where a younger form can take the place of an older one without serious damage to the hexameter, then it does, otherwise the older form is retained. The language undergoes constant change, just like normal spoken language, but the technical demands involved in oral performance in metrical form tend to promote the retention of forms obsolete in the spoken language. The more demanding the metre, the more conservative the language; this conservatism is enforced by the feeling that an archaic flavour suits the elevated style in which tales of a heroic past are told. Opposing these two conservative factors is the fact that the language must be understood by the audience; if the poetic language lagged so far behind the spoken language that it was no longer understood, the epic would lose its audience, which for an oral genre is the same as extinction.

Parry’s investigations into Homeric style were built on this model, and the result was analogous: the style must be acceptable to the audience, and therefore it must constantly change. Two factors promote the retention of existing formulas, the demands of the hexameter and the desire to make the style “distant and wondrous”. “When the formula

can be changed it sooner or later will be, and the cleavage between the old and the new in the style depends on whether it is easy or hard to change the formula" (Parry 1971: 332).

From style to content

Transferring this model to the level of content, the conservative trend of the wish to make the poem "distant and wondrous" still holds good, and the demands of oral verse-making still favour the repetition of existing passages over the formation of new ones. But the hexameter as such can hardly be considered the main conservative factor at this level: there is no metrical pressure on the poet to choose one theme rather than another. In the epic genre, however, there is a very important conservative strain at the level of content, which is the respect for truth. A general definition of oral epic might be: a long narrative in poetically heightened form that is considered to give true information on the past.

The oral epic poet cannot change his/her stories beyond the limits imposed by the audience's feeling for what is true. The Homeric poet, for example, might vary the accounts of what happened at the sack of Troy, but it would have been impossible for him to let the Greek army return without having sacked Troy. There might be different reasons for the disaster of Agamemnon, and various ways of telling how it came about, but it would have been impossible to have him die before Troy, or survive his homecoming (Kullmann 1960). The audience knew the main lines of what happened in the heroic age, and manifest deviations from the tradition would be felt as errors, brought about either by the poet's lack of professional knowledge, or even by his conscious wish to distort the facts, and both would be disapproved of.

However, life changes, also in traditional communities. What interested an audience a generation ago may no longer be interesting. The

power structure of the community may have changed, a family that used to be important may have died out, religious or other customs may have been altered. Such changes bring about changes in an oral epic tradition at the level of content: epic is there not only to give information on the past, but to keep the link between past and present. The importance of the past lies in its relations to the present (Jensen 1986). Just as the language changes for the sake of intelligibility, while remaining unaltered for the sake of metre and the desire for an elevated style, so the content changes for the sake of acceptance by the audience, while remaining unaltered for the sake of archaism and the desire to describe correctly the events of the heroic past.

Thus old and new coexist in an oral epic tradition. But any single manifestation of the tradition makes its ordered choice among possible elements, and even the conservative genre of epic allows for innovations inside the limits of what is acceptable as truth. The happy term of “the double scene” of oral poetry (Lönnroth 1978) becomes the manifold scene of the oral, traditional epic: any single text preserves elements of widely differing ages, while constantly relating them to the special audience present at the performance.

Epic and identity

A sense of cultural identity is based on a group’s feeling of having something in common and at the same time of being different from somebody else. One of the tasks of all oral traditions seems to be to retain and support cultural identity, even such oral traditions that still exist in modern Western societies, as political anecdotes or children’s naughty songs. They convey the feeling that here is something that we enjoy, and that marks us as different from those who would not only not enjoy it but perhaps even punish us for the performance.

The epic as defined above is a very important genre for maintaining cultural identity, precisely because it ties the present to the past and thus supplies the listeners with a feeling that they share their culture with former generations. At the same time, the very broadness of the narrative enables the poet to encompass whatever is considered typical of the group concerned: its way of life, political and religious practices, material surroundings, etc., and to introduce a great variety of persons to set good or bad examples. A successful oral epic conveys to listeners a feeling that they live as they do because so did their ancestors, that their norms and values have been as they are since time immemorial, and that they should look to their ancestors to learn how to behave properly. Since epic narrative is normally concerned with heroic deeds executed among foreign enemies and perhaps in distant countries, there is great potential for underlining what separates the audience and its ancestors from those not belonging to their common culture. Add to this that the oral epic normally has a comprehensive audience (all men, all adults, or even the whole population), and it will be obvious that the epic is an especially important genre in this respect.

Ancient Greece was divided up into many small city-states, most of the time at war with one another. However, the Greeks also had a sense of belonging to one and the same culture, and an important factor in establishing and retaining this feeling was the epic genre. There were rhapsodes touring the Greek-speaking lands, performing to large audiences at private and public festivals, and thus carrying about an epic tradition common to all Greeks. Compared with the description given by Honko (1980: 12–15) of the composition of the *Kalevala*, in archaic Greece the rhapsodes themselves must have acquired a broad concept of all that was inherently Greek, uniting in their persons Honko's first two levels, that of the singer and of the collector. But whereas Elias Lönnrot "wanted the best parts of the poetry of all provinces and rune areas to be reflected in the epic" (Honko 1980: 19), the rhapsodes did so simply because they had no other choice: the material in their tradition consisted of contributions from different parts of Greece as well as from different times.

But any rhapsodic performance had its own audience and was a unique event; the Homeric poet had to adapt his composite tradition to the audience present at the occasion. However, we are hampered in our evaluation of this by the fact that only two Homeric epics have survived, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, which, however long, are just two single manifestations of the tradition, marked by their special social context.

The borders of Greek culture

At this point let me state very briefly my theory of this social context; the scope of the present paper does not permit argumentation, but I have in a previous book expounded the basis of my theory (Jensen 1980). I consider the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* to be orally composed poems, written after dictation — first the *Iliad* and then the *Odyssey* — at the Pisistratean court in Athens c. 525 B. C. This is in many respects a return to the stand of F. A. Wolf, but with the difference that his redactor has been replaced by a poet dictating to a scribe. The rhapsode who dictated the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* had been performing to a broad audience — in principle the whole population of Athens — at a Panathenaic festival, and this was the audience he still had in mind while dictating. Thus the poems that we know may be expected to tell of the events of the heroic past in a way acceptable to an Attic audience of the late sixth century B. C., including the tyrannic family.

The epic's nature as manifestations of a common Greek tradition is perhaps most evident in the *Odyssey*, because this poem so aptly exploits the contrast between Greek and non-Greek (Vidal-Naquet 1973, Friedman 1983, Harbsmeier 1985). The wanderings of Odysseus (*Odyssey* 9–12) bring him to distant and strange peoples, to immortals, and even to the land of the dead, thus defining by contrast what it is to be mortal as opposed to the immortal gods, what it is to be alive as

opposed to the dead, and what it is to be Greek as opposed to foreigners.

The contrasts are placed in a system that is roughly geographical: the more distant a place is, the more distant is the culture of the population. The first station on Odysseus' voyage home from Troy is the land of the Cicones, and there is nothing strange about them, they are a Greek people living in a city-state. But at the south end of the Peloponnese a storm throws Odysseus and his men off course, and from then on the peoples they visit become contrasting pictures of Greek culture. The Lotus-eaters are vegetarians, and they are not hostile, but dangerous none the less because of their non-Greek diet: those of Odysseus' men who eat the fatal flowers forget about being Greek in so far as they lose their wish ever to return home. The Cyclopes live in the far distance, and their diet marks them drastically as opponents to Greek civilisation: Polyphemus eats human flesh, and eats it "like a lion from the mountains, without leaving anything: entrails, meat and marrowful bones" (*Odyssey* 9:292–293) — no more obvious contrast can be thought of. But in many other respects, too, the Cyclopes make up a contrast to Greek culture, thus defining its borders: they do not live in an organised city-state but in caves, and they live as individuals without laws and justice. They do not till the ground or sail the sea, and they do not worship the gods. They do not comply with Greek rules on how to treat guests; Polyphemus even ridicules the Greek custom of giving guest-presents when he offers Odysseus the "present" of being the last one to be eaten. Polyphemus drinks wine without mixing it with water — and he drinks unmixed milk too! In all this he is characterised as the non-Greek par excellence, and his outward appearance underlines this: he is huge and one-eyed.

Even so the Cyclopes are loved by the gods, and Polyphemus is the son of Poseidon, god of the sea. The fact that they do not live off agriculture makes them superhuman rather than uncivilised, considering that freedom from agriculture was part of the Greek image of the golden age. The land of the Cyclopes brings forth by itself whatever

is needed, and so they do not share the curse of the Greeks: hard work in the stony fields.

From the Cyclopes Odysseus and his men come close to their home through the help of Aeolus, but they lose this chance and are again thrown off course, this time to end in a place where the population in its non-Greek qualities occupies a middle position between the Lotus-eaters and the Cyclopes, the Laestrygonians. These are hostile man-eaters of superhuman size; but they live in cities, and young women go out to fetch water at the well just as Greek women do. That they are far away and close to the edge of the world is signalled by the fact that they live where the roads of day and night almost meet, and an energetic man without the need to sleep might earn a double salary, watching cows and sheep alternately! On the other hand, that they are typologically closer to the Greeks than the Cyclopes has its spatial parallel in the fact that Odysseus was in the meantime so close to his homeland.

From then on Odysseus' adventures bring him into contact with the gods and the dead, and the message is no longer so much concerned with what it is to be Greek as with what it is to be human. But at the border of the Oceanus, from where Odysseus enters the land of the dead, live the Cimmerians. They are only mentioned in passing as the narrative hastens on to the important story of the underworld, but the two pieces of information given on them make them complementary to the Laestrygonians: like them, they live in a city-state at the edge of the world, but while the Laestrygonians have no nights, the Cimmerians have no days and live in ever-lasting darkness.

The Lotus-eaters, the Laestrygonians, and the Cyclopes thus illustrate three degrees of non-Greekness, as a foil to the Greek world of Odysseus with its norms and values, represented as sufficiently similar to that of the audience so as to be accepted as an older stage of the same culture. The briefly mentioned Cimmerians form a counterpart to the Laestrygonians and take their place beside them in the middle position. The two general criteria for Greekness that stand out are diet and political organisation: city-state or not.

Scheria and Troy: a tale of two cities

After his many dangerous adventures in the world of gods and monsters, Odysseus reaches the final stage before home, the land of the Phaeacians, who are mortal beings. The description of their state is more detailed than that of any other fairy-country in the *Odyssey*, and more than anything else it is the description of a Greek colony. The Phaeacians used to live next to the Cyclopes, but as they were constantly pressed by them and were weaker than they, they left their country and settled instead on the island of Scheria; their act of settlement is described as follows: they constructed walls, built houses, made temples for the gods, and distributed the arable land among themselves. This might have been the description of a real Greek colonisation. In the city there is a market-place with a shrine to Poseidon, and outside the city a sacred grove of Athena. The Phaeacians are ruled by a king, and the people live in peace with him and each other. When they feast, they eat and drink in abundance, and their diet is meat and wine as that of Greeks at a banquet; they are entertained by a bard singing of heroic deeds — as is the audience of the *Odyssey* — and their further festivities include a performance by an expert choir of young dancers, and athletic competitions. In all this the Phaeacians are described as a model of the Greek city-state; the only special thing about them is their almost monomaniac concern with ships and seafaring. It is explicitly stressed by the young princess, Nausicaa, and it comes out implicitly in the names of the Phaeacian aristocrats, dominated by derivatives from or compounds with the word for “ship”, *naus*. The atmosphere of the narrative is in these passages one of cheerfulness: the Phaeacians live a peaceful and idyllic life (*Odyssey* 6–8).

One strange thing about the *Iliad* is that it does not exploit the possibilities of describing the Trojan enemies as a contrast to the Greeks. Considering that the war with Troy was the one great Panhellenic expedition of the past, the epic might have been expected to have built up a polarity of civilisation and barbarism, but it does nothing of the

kind. The Trojan enemies are as civilised as their Greek invaders: they speak the same language, live in a city-state, and worship the same gods in the same ways as the Greeks. A mere glance at a poem like the “Song of Roland” makes the contrast glaring: there the Saracens are heathen and barbarian and deserve nothing better than to be cut into pieces by the dozen. In Homer there is no good-bad evaluation of Greeks and Trojans, and no hero is described with more sympathy than the Trojan Hector. If there is a bias towards the Greeks, it is only to be found in quantity: the *Iliad* spends more time among the Greeks than among the Trojans, on the battlefield we hear much more of the deeds of the Greeks than of those of the Trojans, and the main plot, of course, is concerned with affairs inside the Greek camp.

This is not because the stories about Troy did not offer material for a cultural polarisation. Even as we know the Trojans from the *Iliad*, there are elements that would have offered themselves easily for a contrastive picture of them: Priam with his many wives and fifty sons might have been used as an opposition to Greek monogamy, and the story of Paris’ violation of the guest-friendship of Menelaus might have been used in a way analogous to what the *Odyssey* makes of the barbarian conduct of Polyphemus as a host. Instead, Priam’s household is to all practical purposes narrowed down to something that resembles a normal Greek family: Hecuba is *the* wife of Priam as much as Penelope that of Odysseus, and his two contrasted sons, the conscientious Hector and the wanton Paris, dominate the poem so much as to almost make us forget what a lot of sons and daughters Priam has. As to Paris’ offence, it is laid at his own door and by no means used to characterise Trojan behaviour as such.

In the *Iliad*, Troy is as much a model of a Greek city-state as Scheria is in the *Odyssey*. Its lay-out, with the enclosing wall and the dwellings of the citizens surrounding an acropolis where the gods are worshipped and the king has his palace, is exactly that of a city-state. Outside the city are the tombs and the spring where the women used to go and wash when there was still peace. Troy is ruled by king Priam in harmony with his subjects; major decisions are taken not by him but by the

assembly, where different speakers advocate their views; Priam has the last word, more because of his age and wisdom than because he is the king, very much like the way in which Nestor often has the last word in the assemblies of the Greek army (*Iliad* 7:345–379). The male citizens of suitable age go out to defend their city exactly as they did in any archaic Greek city-state, while their wives and parents follow the proceedings from the top of the wall. The Troy of the *Iliad* is a tragic counterpart to the idyllic Scheria of the *Odyssey*; the two are large-scale analogies to the city-at-war and the city-at-peace described on the shield of Achilles (*Iliad* 18:490–540).

Greek and non-Greek

Why does the *Iliad* not use Troy to build a picture of a strange, non-Greek culture as the *Odyssey* treats the foreign communities? An answer that once seemed obvious was: because it is older than the *Odyssey* and represents a static world before the great age of colonisation, while the *Odyssey* belongs to the period when the Greek cities sent out expeditions to far-away shores to found colonies. Such an explanation is still acceptable, also in a framework such as the one I use, but it is far too simple, and combined with the nowadays currently accepted dates for the two poems, composed just before and just after 700 B. C., it makes little sense: if the *Iliad* should be older than the colonisations, it would have to be dated at least a century before that, while on the other hand the current date does not account for the many elements in both poems that are younger than the beginning of the 7th century B. C.

The linguistic texture of the *Iliad* is as a whole more archaic than that of the *Odyssey* (Janko 1982). But even inside each of the two poems it is possible to distinguish passages older or younger than the average, while no passage adheres purely to one and the same linguistic

stage. The differences must be explained by the theory of the general conservatism of the poet and his forerunners: they kept what was transmitted to them as precisely as possible, and if the *Iliad* has more recognisably old passages than the *Odyssey*, and more of them at the beginning than towards the end, this reflects a general experience that oral epic tends to be most fixed in its initial parts (Lord 1960: 119). At the level of content, as well as at that of language, elements of widely different age coexist, which does not exclude the idea that the two poems as we know them are coeval and both look at the past with eyes that belong to the 6th century B. C. The narrative “vocabulary” of themes is conservative in the same way as the vocabulary proper; innovations occur, but the poet prefers to adhere to transmitted themes as much as possible, and only innovations that are not felt to be violations of the traditional truth are accepted.

The *Odyssey*’s experience of distant shores, strange and barbarian peoples, and the dangers of the sea was still as interesting to a sixth-century audience as it must have been to audiences centuries before. Colonisation was still a very important practice in Greek life, and long and dangerous voyages through the Mediterranean and the Black Sea had by no means gone out of use; on the contrary, such elements would still have been interesting to any audience all over the Greek world. The rhapsode could count on his normal audience to include people who had sailed the seas, and people who had taken leave of friends or relatives going to settle far away.

But a joint military adventure against a barbarian foe was not immediately comparable to any historic event of recent times for a sixth-century audience. The war as it is described in the *Iliad* is modelled, instead, on the wars between the Greek city-states that were an only too common pattern of archaic Greece. The feeling of Greek cultural identity is not at this period based on antagonism to an organised barbarian power; the foreigners most naturally taken as non-Greek types must have been precisely the native populations of the shores to which Greek merchants and colonists came. In less than half a century this picture changed: with the Persian wars the Greeks were furnished with other patterns of what it meant to be Greek. Thus the

great importance of being free citizens as against the Persian slaves ruled by a despot confronts us in the works of Aeschylus and Herodotus, and if we had known Homeric epics from the 5th century B. C., it is probable that their ideas of Greek and non-Greek would have been different.

In some cases old elements got new interpretations as times changed; an example of this may be found in the Homeric kingship. It is generally thought to be a real reminiscence of the political structures of Mycenaean times, where the great palaces such as those of Tiryns and Mycenae bear evidence to royal rule. This is in all probability true, and the Homeric king is therefore a very old element in the world of the two poems. But for audiences living in the age of tyrants, the Homeric king must have been understood as the prototype of the tyrant, and communities such as those described for Phaeacia and Troy must have been seen as historic parallels to the rule of tyrants (the term does not necessarily have bad connotations when used for this period of Greek history) common in their own days. The word *basileus*, "king", is still used for the tyrants of the time in the poetry of Pindar in the 5th century B. C.

It is sometimes asserted that the Homeric poems show an overall picture of the Greek world as it was before the emergence of the city-state (e. g. Finley 1954). Such an opinion can be maintained only if important aspects of the poems are ignored as late and allegedly superficial elements. To the way of interpretation advocated here, there is no doubt that the civilised, Greek way of living is that of living in a city-state.

The singer's audience

In such respects as these the world of the heroes is seen through the eyes of a 6th-century audience. And there are elements to show that the poet aimed directly at his Athenian audience, that e. g. his model

city-states were not just models of any archaic Greek city-state, but quite definitely of the *polis* of Athens.

In Phaeacia we hear of the cult of two gods, and they are precisely the two main gods of Athens, Poseidon and Athena. They are also the two great combatants over the fate of Odysseus, and it is an old idea to compare the plot of the *Odyssey* with the Athenian legend of how the two gods competed to become the patron of Athens: Poseidon let a spring of salt water well forth, whereas Athena planted an olive tree (Murray 1934: 312–313). The judge of the competition was king Cecrops, and he awarded the prize to Athena. The visible results of the competition, the spring of salt and the olive tree, were among the sights of the Athenian acropolis, and when during the 5th century B. C. Pericles had new temples built there, this contest was chosen as the motif for the Western pediment of the Parthenon. In Phaeacia, however, it seems that the two gods share the power to the favour of Poseidon: he is the one who is worshipped in the city, while the grove of Athena is outside. Is the humorous picture of the sea-mania of the Phaeacians a mild mockery of the Athenian citizens? It may be. We have no contemporary written sources, but judging from the development in trade and the frequency with which ships are represented in Attic vase-painting from the Peisistratean period, Athens was even then already very intent on seafaring and thus preparing the base on which to build the supremacy of the sea she gained under the leadership of Themistocles and maintained during the 5th century B. C.

The idyll of Scheria is brought to a sudden end when Poseidon realises that a Phaeacian ship has carried Odysseus home to Ithaca. The ship is on the point of returning into the harbour of Scheria, with all the leading Phaeacians out to welcome it home, when Poseidon in his anger turns it into stone; besides, he threatens to enclose the whole island with a mountain (*Odyssey* 13:125–187). The contrast between Poseidon's cruel treatment of the state of which he is the patron, and Athena's way with her favourites is brought out sharply: the story has been immediately preceded by the beautiful description of the harbour of Odysseus' island shaded by a huge olive tree — the symbol of the

goddess — and it is followed by the charming meeting of Athena and Odysseus on his native shore.

Similar elements relate the other model city-state, Troy, directly to Athens. On the Trojan acropolis is the house of Priam and a temple to the goddess Athena, just as in Athens the tyrants shared the acropolis with the goddess. At a critical phase of the war, the old queen and some other noble ladies go to the temple of Athena to pray for protection, and with them they carry a richly ornamented *peplos* as a present to the goddess; they hand it to her priestess, and she puts it in the lap of the seated cult-statue inside the temple (*Iliad* 6:286–311). Such a passage recited to an audience gathered to worship Athena at the Panathenaic festival must have made them see the event as a forerunner of their own religious practice: the main event at the Panathenaea was a procession where Athenian women in the same way brought a new *peplos* to the cult-statue in her temple on the acropolis (Lorimer 1950: 442–447).

Examples such as these demonstrate the poet's constant awareness of his audience. They have been chosen to show how the epic tradition is adapted to the interests of Athens as a whole, but other examples might be given to show how the poems also reflect the social breadth of the audience. The harmonious pictures of kingship with their inherent argumentation for the blessings of the rule of the tyrants would be apt to please the authorities present at the performance, and the lower strata of the population would be given models to identify with too, and not only the famous noble swineherd in Odysseus' household. By way of the similes a wealth of representatives of the humbler parts of society are introduced — harvesters, other land-labourers, wood-cutters, ditchers, potters, even thieves — and the narrative is often seen from their angle, as in the remark referred to above of the labourer in the land of the Laestrygonians who would be able to earn a double salary if he could only do without sleep. Different age-groups occur, and both sexes have their important representatives; among all their other characteristics the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* are very much poems about the proper relations between the sexes, showing a whole range of

married couples on a carefully graded scale from deterrent examples to ideals. All such things combine to make the poems important vehicles for the maintenance of the norms and values of society, and therefore of cultural identity.

Homeric epic is everything at once, different layers of history, legends from various parts of the Greek-speaking world, many dialects melted into one. There is no reason to think that the Homeric tradition ended with the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, but what we know of it ends in precisely these two individual manifestations of the tradition. And they are the proper object of an analysis of the art of Homer: the paradox of traditional narrative is that what is original is the end of the process, the poems as the expression of the creative art of the rhapsode who dictated them and the receptive art of his audience.

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Teivas Oksala

Virgil's Aeneid as Homeric, National and Universal Epic

Is there any place for the Aeneid at a symposium dedicated to the world's great epics and held in honour of the Kalevala? Does it belong to this context, even though art epics have been purposely excluded from the synopsis? The Aeneid is in no way a folk epic carrying on the true oral poetic tradition, but a work of art consciously created within the domain of high culture. And yet it is a national epic, and more unconditionally and consciously so than perhaps any of the works of epic poetry. What is more, it is not merely the national epic of Rome, but also that of United Italy. This was experienced in a moving manner in 1981, when Italy, the *Saturnia Tellus* of Virgil, beset today by social problems, honoured its great poet on the 2000th anniversary of his death. In addition the Aeneid is a continental epic without which our continent would be in danger of losing its identity.

I wish to examine the Aeneid from four aspects: that of the birth of the epic, and as a Homeric, national and universal epic. These views are also of fundamental importance in interpreting and assessing the Kalevala. And naturally I cannot overlook the question raised once again by Lauri Honko: was Lönnrot a Homer or a Virgil?

The relationship with Homer has in many ways been the central problem surrounding the Aeneid for two thousand years. Europe's leading epic throughout the Middle Ages and the Modern Era, the Aeneid fell under the shadow of Homer with the advent of Romanticism: the originality of the poem and the creative independence of its poet were placed open to doubt. It is indicative that when the well-known folklore researcher Väinö Salminen gave a survey of national

epics from Homer to Kalevipoeg in his work on the Kalevala, he did not even mention the Aeneid (Salminen 1947: 7–39). This further reflected the Romantic illusion that the epics of Homer were genuine creations of the “folk spirit”, whereas the Aeneid was a non-independent and untrue imitation of them. Virgil research of the present century has made a thorough revision of the situation in this respect.

The conception of the epic, birth of the work and death of the poet

Some epics have gradually won an established position as national epics, others have consciously set out to do so. The Iliad and the Odyssey unquestionably belong to the former category, the Aeneid and the Kalevala to the latter. Virgil and Lönnrot knew what they wanted and what the cultural community (the Rome of Augustus and autonomous Finland inspired by the spirit of National Romanticism) expected of them. Virgil, furthermore, worked under even greater public pressure, and it was impossible for him to turn back. He came to an impasse in his creative work that was resolved both by his death and Augustus’ decree that his work be preserved.

Homer created his epic from the oral song tradition (oral composition) and laid the foundations for Greek literature when the poetry was written down. On his journeys collecting material Lönnrot became a skilled rune singer and competent linguist, but the very extent of his collection work and material called for an advanced recording technique and comparative sifting of the material. He constructed his epic from genuine pre-literate material, sitting at his desk, in accordance with a gradually emerging holistic concept guided by the continental epic tradition, the Homeric theory of F. A. Wolf and the Romantic concept of the epic (Kaukonen 1956: 450–456; Kaukonen 1979: 49–50). Virgil

created his epic by literary methods in a high culture then at its apex and drew on the whole tradition of Greek and Roman literature. He did not have the oral composition technique of Homer, the genuine folklore material of Lönnrot or a vast store of mythology from which to create nine Iliads or seven Kalevalas. What he did have was Roman history as recorded in epics and prose works (*res gestae populi Romani*), the legends developed by Greek and Roman writers about Aeneas and Romulus, all manner of detailed information on ancient times (*antiquitates Romanae*) and the hexameter as developed by his predecessors Ennius, Lucretius and Catullus that was ripe for harvesting. Virgil reaped this harvest in a manner that, according to T. S. Eliot, was marked by complete maturity (Eliot 1945: 10–15).

Virgil's predecessors Naevius and Ennius had in their epics dealt with Roman history from its mythical beginnings onwards and had thus solved the mutual relationship between myth and history in, so to say, normal chronological order. Virgil solved the problem of his overall concept in a new and unique manner. He created a synthesis of all the epic types of antiquity: 1) the Homeric heroic epic, 2) the historical Roman epic (e. g. Ennius' *Annales*) and 3) the narrative epic of eulogy. In addition to these basic types the poet absorbed influences from the prophetic epic concerned with the future (such as Lycophron's *Alexandra*), the Hellenistic psychological epic (e. g. Apollonius' *Argonautica*) and the short epic (such as Catullus' *Peleus*; P. Oksala 1962). The result was a new synthesis that is simultaneously an epic about Aeneas, Rome and Augustus (Klingner 1967: 367–382) but these elements do not follow on narratively continuously at the same level; instead they overlap, at different levels. The Homeric derivative of the myth, the tale of Aeneas (*errores Aeneae*), provides the narrative frame; Roman history is presented fragmentarily in the speech of the gods, the prophecies and visions of the future (especially the journey to the underworld in book 6 and the description of the shield in book 8).

The story of Aeneas developed out of the legend about Troy in Greek literature and had by about 300 B. C. become crystallised into the form taken up by the Roman epic poets — above all Naevius —

in developing this great national myth. From the point of view of comparative religion it is thus a literary pseudosaga. Admittedly Italian archaeology believes it has in recent years found relics of a hero cult surrounding Aeneas dating from early times that would lend a certain authenticity to the legend of Aeneas, but the findings so far are not very convincing.

The first level in the epic is the hero theme, the other meanings being manifest in between and within this. Heeding the gods' command, Aeneas flees from burning Troy, for he is destined to establish a new realm somewhere on the Mediterranean. He gradually becomes aware of his calling and finally comes to Italy, the promised land. He learns that his descendants are to hold dominion over the world and, under Augustus, to create a golden age and lasting peace. Thus the epic expands from myth to history and reaches its climax with its praise of Augustus (*laudes Augusti*). The heroic epic grows into a developmental epic and an epic of ideals, at the heart of which is the Rome ideology supported by a teleological philosophy of history. The *pius Aeneas*, in strict obedience of the voice of duty, becomes crystallised as the personification of the Roman virtue *pietas*: he sacrifices his personal happiness to his great purpose. In this respect Aeneas differs from the chief heroes of Homer. It is Achilles' aim to seek recompense for the wrongs he has suffered, Odysseus is intent on reaching home, but Aeneas works towards a goal of greater consequence, world peace.

In order to be able to control this multi-level entity, the poet first compiled a prose version of the story of Aeneas, which he divided up into 12 books. He then embarked *particulatim* on the task of transforming this into hexameters (VSD 23–24). Suetonius uses the descriptive term *componere*, meaning not so much 'putting together' as 'composing in poetic metre'. To ensure that nothing should curb his inspiration, Virgil did not follow any system, turning to whatever section inspired him at the time. Some sections had to be given only temporary lines, which are called "wooden props" (*tibicines*), his intention being to return to them later and insert "marble pillars". The first portions of the prose novel about Aeneas to be given poetic form were books two, four and six, i. e. the episodes

acclaimed by posterity as being the greatest in the work. The poet himself found these themes the most inspiring. The poet's inspiration and the reception afforded the work appear to have been on the same wavelength.

Virgil devoted eleven years to the Aeneid, working under the enormous pressure of publicity. Rome was full of anticipation for its national epic. Augustus kept an impatient eye on the progress of the work. And Sextus Propertius did not hesitate to proclaim that a work even greater than the Iliad that would overshadow all previous poetry was in the making (VSD 30–34). The envious, the “watery-hats” of the Kalevala, were malicious in their criticism even before the work was ever published (VSD 44–46). The scrupulous Virgil took all criticism with the outmost seriousness.

The final stages in the poet's life and the ultimate fate of the Aeneid are well known from the ancient biographies of Virgil (VSD 35–41). When the work was almost complete, in the year 19 B. C., the poet decided to travel to Greece to put the finishing touches to his work under a Homeric sky, for a touch of the “ultimate file” (*ultima lima*) was an inseparable element of the working morals of the Augustan classics. Virgil set aside a whole three years for this phase, planning to dedicate himself thereafter to philosophy. In Athens the poet met Augustus on his return to Rome from the East, changed his mind and decided to return to Italy with the imperial party. But the consumptive poet suffered a serious attack of illness. His condition rapidly deteriorated during the sea voyage, and he died at Brundisium on 21.9.19 B. C. He was buried near Naples and on his stone was engraved the laconic distich:

Mantua me genuit, Calabri rapuere, tenet nunc
Parthenope; cecini pascua, rura, duces.

Mantua gave me life, and from life Calabria stole me;
but to Parthenope I now belong; my singing was
of pastures and farms, and chieftains at their wars.

(English translation by C. Day Lewis)

Before setting off on his journey, the poet had asked his friend Varius to destroy the unfinished Aeneid should anything happen to him during

his travels; but Varius had flatly refused. Even on his death bed Virgil again requested that the unfinished Aeneid be destroyed. When this request was refused, he dictated his will, stating that none of his posthumous texts be published. But Augustus ordered that the Aeneid be published, and so Rome got its eagerly-awaited national epic.

The tragic but unfulfilled decision of the dying poet was, in my opinion, dictated by three factors: 1) self-criticism spurred on by age, 2) the insuperable burden of publicity and 3) working methods that did not correspond to the poet's basic inclinations and brought him to an impasse (T. Oksala 1978b). The first books to be completed (2, 4 and 6) rose to such heights that they overshadowed the rest of the material. It is my belief that the latter half of the work in particular, with its Italian events, which should by its very nature have constituted a mighty climax, was something of a problem to the poet. Virgil presumably wanted to let his inspiration pervade the entire work "in order to replace all the wooden props by marble pillars", to use his own metaphor.

The genesis of the Aeneid is the individual creation of an individual work in which the creative individual bears the entire weight on his own shoulders.

The Homeric Aeneid

The Romans saw in the Aeneid a Homeric epic more than anything else, a synthesis of the Greek and the Latin worlds, his true goal being to express in a mythical form the historical development of Rome towards world peace as created by Augustus. Suetonius records these views as follows (VSD 21): "Last of all he embarked on the story of Aeneas, a varied and manifold theme corresponding in a way to both the epics of Homer, this theme being furthermore the common property of the Greek and Latin worlds in names and events, and it was at the

same time, this being the poet's central goal, to contain the origin of the city of Rome and of Augustus." The expression "corresponding to both the epics of Homer" was, of course, to be understood so that the first six books with their sea journey corresponded to the Odyssey and the last six books with its battles to the Iliad. Brooks Otis uses the apt names "The Odyssean Aeneid" and "The Iliadic Aeneid" for the two halves of the epic (Otis 1963: 217 ff.). A significant "chiastic" pattern prevails between Homer's epics and the two halves of the Aeneid. In Homer destructive warfare is followed by the hero's adventures, which finally lead him to his destination. Virgil reversed the pattern. The hero's wanderings are followed by a great war (*horrida bella*), which ends in a constructive solution, the founding of a new realm.

A tripartite division of the 12 books of the Aeneid has also been suggested into three groups of four books (Carthage — the journey from Sicily to Latium and the preparations for war — the decisive battle). A tripartite scheme has also been proposed for individual books (Quinn 1968). Compared with Homer, the material in the Aeneid (c. 10.000 lines) is more concise and concentrated (cf. Iliad c. 15.000 lines, Odyssey c. 12.000 lines).

The relationship between the Aeneid and Homer has been one of the key problems of research ever since ancient times. Virgil's contemporaries were already accusing him of Homer-plagiarism (*furta*). The poet, who had a good sense of humour, used to reply by asking: "Why didn't the critics themselves try the same plagiarisms?" He knew from experience what the answer would be: "Because it was easier to wrest a club from Hercules than a verse from Homer's hand" (VSD 46).

The Aeneid dominated the European epic tradition up to the Romantic Era, when the reading public became more strongly aware of Homer's epics, which overshadowed the civilised world of the Aeneid with their early-morning freshness. Scholars stared at Virgil's borrowings from Homer (they could not see the wood from the trees) and were guilty of the false quantitative conclusion that because there were

countless loans, the poet was an unoriginal imitator of the ingenious Homer, but lacking his genius.

Richard Heinze began a new century in Virgilian scholarship with his work *Virgils epische Technik* (1902). He aimed not so much at an apology as at defining Virgil's narrative technique by comparing it with Homer, but he was not content merely to ask "what?", for he also went on to ask the essential question "how?". How did Virgil use his borrowings from Homer? What was genuine Virgil? This approach proved fruitful in interpreting Roman literature in general. The poet of the *Aeneid* now appeared in a new light: he had not only imitated Homer, he had also reformed the narrative technique. Virgilian scholarship in the present century has basically carried on from Heinze, taking his theories to their logical conclusion. One example is G. N. Knauer's study *Die Aeneis und Homer* (1964), in which the author compares the epic structure at all levels, from broad units to line-by-line quotations. One of the paradoxes of the humanities is that the qualitative dimension supersedes quantitative evidence. The more we examine the thousands of connections between Virgil and Homer, the more sovereign is the creative independence of the author of the *Aeneid*.

It is easy to list the similarities between the epics for comparison at the level of books, sections of books, characters, scenes, metaphors and verses, but the differences are just as important, beginning with the main characters. The pious Aeneas differs considerably from Homer's individual heroes, the enigmatic Odysseus (*polytropos*) and Achilles, who is uncompromising in his anger and his arrogance. Aeneas fulfills not himself but an ideal and he cannot become a great tragic figure comparable to Achilles, loving life itself above all other, both in life and in death; in the *Aeneid* this role is appropriated by Dido, Queen of Carthage, the counter-role to that of our hero and the counter-figure to Rome. There is no full counterpart to Dido in Homer's epics (cf. Calypso and Circe). Nor does Aeneas' chief opponent Turnus become a Hector, remaining "a man without a destiny" (Eliot 1945: 21).

Events are directed by the gods in both Homer and Virgil, but Virgil's gods are exponents of a higher, philosophical concept of

fate. Juno torments Aeneas just as Poseidon does Odysseus. The hero finds support in Venus, his divine mother, just as Achilles received from his mother Thetis and Odysseus from Pallas Athena. In the now lost epic the Aithiopis the goddess Eos helped her son Memnon in his difficulties.

The heroes of Homer and Virgil are faced by similar situations in life. At Dido's feast Aeneas tells of his adventures (Aeneid 2–3) in the same way, though with less boyishness and playfulness, as the arch-liar Odysseus at the court of Alcinous (Odyssey 9–12). The contests held in Sicily (Aeneid 5) provide a lighter episode amid the tragic events, though they are in no way comparable to the “Olympic Games” described in book 23 of the Iliad, during which the listener/reader can pause for breath before the great final scene in the last book. This conciliatory final scene, in which the enemies Achilles and Priam discover the human element in one another and respect the human in the other (Lesky 1963: 57), has no counterpart in the Aeneid. The fatal blow imposed by Aeneas on his opponent is the final chord to the epic. The idea of humanity is contained implicit throughout the epic development of the Aeneid.

Study of the books on the underworld (Odyssey 11 and Aeneid 6) is extremely illuminating in revealing similarities and differences (see especially Knauer 1964: 107–147 and the comparative structural scheme 2). Having offered up the prescribed sacrifice, the hero of the Odyssey consorts with the dead at a sort of spiritistic séance. The underworld remains an undefined world of shadows. The Hades of the Aeneid is a spatially organised entity in which — in anticipation of Dante — it is possible to distinguish Tartarus and Elysium and a neutral zone. Odysseus recounts his experiences himself, Aeneas really does cross the border into the other world but returns enigmatically through the ivory gate of false dreams. Virgil consciously incorporates philosophical ideas in his description of the underworld — the transmigration of souls and pantheistic doctrine on the soul of the world (Aeneid 6:726–727): “for immanent Mins, flowing / Through all its parts and leavening its mass, makes the universe work”. Thus Aeneas, under his father's guidance,

is able to see much further into the future than Odysseus in his conversations with Tiresias and his mother. In his description of Hades Virgil decisively shifts the fixed points offered by Homer and gives it a more profound role in the epic as a whole. Neither of the great epics of Antiquity can provide a counterpart to the swan of Tuonela in the Kalevala as the symbol of the mystery of death or to Lemminkäinen's mother as the apotheosis of motherly love.

The forging of our heroes' weapons by the divine smith Hephaestus-Vulcanus at the command of the goddess mothers is as a creative act an interesting point for comparison (Iliad 18:468–617; Aeneid 8:370–453 and 608–731). The descriptions may be compared to the forging of the Sampo in the Kalevala or the forging of Siegfried's sword, around which Wagner developed a mighty functional tenor aria in his tetralogy. As the forger of the firmament and the Sampo, Ilmarinen grows into rather an Apollonian cultural hero and cosmic titan. The creative act is developed more colourfully in the Aeneid than in Homer, with richer orchestration. The illustrations on Achilles' shield are determined according to the cosmos and consist of scenes from human life, the siege of the city, and agriculture. Virgil devotes the iconology of the shield to Roman history; in the centre is the decisive battle of Actium in the year 31 B. C.

In addition to the major sections, it would in fact be possible to list the innumerable episodes and lines which Virgil managed to wrest from Homer's hands, to continue his own metaphor, but let us take just one example. At first reading the descriptions of the storm by Homer and Virgil appear almost identical (Odyssey 5:291–296 and Aeneid 1:81–91), but they differ at one decisive point. Homer's battle of the winds is constructed additively from details. In Virgil Nature functions as a unity (*intentant omnia mortem*). This corresponds to the development in the Georgics and the pantheistic concept of Nature expounded in book six of the Aeneid (T. Oksala 1978a: 84–90).

The influence of Homer is evident at every level of the Aeneid, but in "wrestling" with Homer, Virgil expresses his independence, to use the poet's metaphor again.

The national Aeneid

In interpreting the Rome ideology in the suggestive frameworks provided by the myth, the Aeneid becomes more profound and undergoes the change from heroic epic to an epic of ideals. The main character puts into practice the world plan assigned him by the gods, and Rome's task becomes crystallised as the implementation of divine order on earth. In the same way the leading idea behind Horace's Roman Odes is the comparison of Jupiter's heavenly order and Augustus' worldly order (T. Oksala 1973: 96–113). The epic presentation of the Roman ideology called for the philosophical coordination of mythical ideas on fate into a unified conception in which *fatum* and Jupiter's will are merged in the overall concept of *fata Iovis* (resp. *fata deum*). The Fates (*Moirai* and *Parcae*) do not feature in the Aeneid as forces of destiny ruling over Jupiter.

In accordance with his calling, the hero's will and fate become one (Aeneid 8:133): *fatís egere volentem* – “I follow the bidding of fate most gladly”. The tragedy of external fate is, as T. S. Eliot pointed out, transferred to the hero's conscience.

Aeneas experiences his greatest visions of the future in Hades, when he meets his father Anchises in the fields of Elysium and with him gets to know the souls of the future heroes of Rome, who are awaiting incarnation. Augustus appears as a benefactor of mankind comparable to the heroes of Greek myths (Aeneid 6:791–797):

Hic vir hic est, tibi quem promitti saepius audis,
 Augustus Caesar, divi genus, aurea condet
 saecula qui rursus Latio regnata per arva
 Saturno quondam, super et Garamantas et Indos
 proferet imperium; iacet extra sidera tellus,
 extra anni solisque vias, ubi caelifer Atlas
 axem umero torquet stellis ardentibus aptum.

And here, here is the man, the promised one you know of —
 Caesar Augustus, son of a god, destined to rule
 Where Saturn ruled of old in Latium, and there
 Bring back the age of gold: his empire shall expand
 Past Garamants and Indians to a land beyond the zodiac
 And the sun's yearly path, where Atlas the sky-bearer pivots
 The wheeling heavens, embossed with fiery stars, on his shoulder.
 (English translation by C. Day Lewis)

Saturn's age of gold (*Saturnia regna*) becomes crystallised as the central symbol of the epic. Virgil develops it in all his main works, always in a different way. In the fourth eclogue the myth of the golden age is like a budding, ecstatic but as yet unorganised dream of the future, the symbol of which becomes the boy child (*puer nascens*) soon to be born. According to the Georgics *Saturnia tellus* is Italy: the golden age is immanent in the smiling countryside, and through his work the industrious farmer can conjure it forth (T. Oksala 1978a: 97–104). In the Aeneid the golden age is linked as a mythical symbol with the philosophy of history, teleology, and gives it a deeper meaning (*telos*).

In Hades Aeneas also learns the task of the Romans in the world history in relation to the cultural achievements of the Greeks (Aeneid 6:847–853):

Excudent alii spirantia mollius aera
 (credo equidem), vivos ducent de marmore vultus,
 orabunt causas melius, caelique meatus
 describent radio et surgentia sidera dicent:
 tu regere imperio populos, Romane, memento
 (hae tibi erunt artes), pacique imponere morem,
 parcere subiectis et debellare superbos.

Let others fashion from bronze more lifelike, breathing images —
 For so they shall — and evoke living faces from marble;
 Others excel as orators, others track with their instruments
 The planets circling in heaven and predict when stars will appear,

But, Romans, never forget that government is your medium!
Be this your art: — to practise men in the habit of peace,
Generosity to the conquered, and firmness against aggressors.
(English translation by C. Day Lewis)

This proclaims in oracular tones that the cultural task (*artes*) of the Romans is to rule mankind in peace (*paci morem imponere*).

The *Aeneid* is not only an epic about Rome, it is also an epic about the unity of fate of Rome and Italy. In the great song of praise to Italy in the *Georgics* Virgil for the first time in poetry presented Italy as a geographical entity extending from the Alps to the southern tip of the peninsula, the land of Saturn, *Saturnia tellus* (Klingner 1956: 11–33). This idea is impressively developed in the *Aeneid*. When, before the denouement of the epic, Juno appeases her anger and stands in support of Aeneas' future (*Aeneid* 12:818–828), she does so on condition that Latium may keep its name and its language, thus in a way proclaiming the mythical birth of Latin and prophesying the community of fate between Rome and Italy: *sit Romana potens Itala virtute propago* — “Let the line be Roman, the qualities making it great be Italian”. Jupiter accepts the condition imposed by Juno. Italy may keep her mother tongue and newcomers and original inhabitants merge to form a uni-lingual nation: *faciamque omnis uno ore Latinos* — “All will be Latins, speaking one tongue”. This basic mythical situation recurs in the battle of Actium in the year 31 B. C., when Augustus assembles Italy, the Senate and people of Rome into battle against the threat from the Orient (*Aeneid* 8:671–713). The link between Italy and Rome is crystallised in the description of the shield as follows:

hinc Augustus agens Italos in proelia Caesar
cum patribus populoque, penetibus et magnis dis
stans celsa in puppi (...)

On one side Augustus Caesar, high up on the poop, is leading
The Italians into Battle, the Senate and People with him,
His home-gods and the great gods (...)
(English translation by C. Day Lewis)

The series of historical scenes on the shield culminates in the battle of Actium, and this is followed by a gesture on the part of the hero that takes on a metaphorical meaning and seals the description of the preparations for battle (Aeneid 8:729–731):

Talia per clipeum Volcani, dona parentis,
miratur rerumque ignarus imagine gaudet
attollens umero famamque et fata nepotum.

Such were the scenes that Aeneas admired on the shield of Vulcan
His mother gave him. Elated by its portrayal of things
Beyond his ken, he shouldered his people's glorious future.
(English translation by C. Day Lewis)

The future of Rome and Italy lies on the hero's shoulders.

One night in July in the year 13 B. C. Augustus entered the Eternal City along the Via Flaminia on his return from Hispania and Gallia. He rejected the tributes proposed by the Senate, but the following day he agreed to make a sacrifice to the world peace he had created (*Pax Augusta*). The event was immortalised in marble, and the Emperor's gesture and Virgil's epic thus received a marble monument, the Ara Pacis Augustae (9 B. C.). The relief on the western end of the altar depicted the main characters in the myth of Rome: Aeneas and Romulus. On the eastern end were the female personifications: the fond figure of Mother Earth, Saturnia tellus (Italy) and the goddess Roma on top of a silent pile of weapons. The idea of the Aeneid and the price of world peace could hardly be depicted more clearly by iconological means.

The universal Aeneid

The Aeneid becomes a universal epic via its idea of peace, just as the Pax Augusta takes on the meaning of world peace. The Saturnus myth, the promise of the return of the golden age, plays *mutatis mutandis* a

role similar to the Sampo myth in the Kalevala. As a symbol of the welfare of mankind, the Sampo is the central theme through which the Kalevala becomes a universal epic, belonging to all nations of the world (Kaukonen 1984: 246–249). Enigmatic and unsolved, the Sampo is perhaps even more universal than Saturnus, which is in turn more concrete and more precise as an idea and does not permit dozens of interpretations, each more ingenious than the last, from red fly mushroom to a Byzantine mint.

The universality of the Aeneid can also be tested by comparing its idea of peace with the principles of the United Nations, which ultimately aim at world peace, but which are constantly plagued by the practical question of who is to guarantee this world peace, i. e. who is to take charge of weapons. The Aeneid and the Ara Pacis entrusted Rome with this task. At this level of meaning the national and the universal epic are combined in the Aeneid. The universal meaning of the idea of power and civilisation contained in the Aeneid has been discussed by such scholars as Frank Kermode (Kermode 1975: 15–45).

The universal value of the Aeneid is not restricted to the political-ideological level of meaning. Of the other timeless properties of the epic, I would first like to mention the tragedy of war. The second book is dedicated to Aeneas' narrative about the death struggles of Troy (Aeneid 2:361–366):

Quis cladem illius noctis, quis funera fando
explicitet aut possit lacrimis aequare labores?
urbs antiqua ruit multos dominata per annos
plurima perque vias sternuntur inertia passim
corpora perque domos et religiosa deorum limina.

That night! — what words can render its deaths and its disaster?
What tears can rise to the level of all that was suffered then?
An ancient city is falling, after long years of power:
So many motionless bodies prostrated everywhere
Along the streets, in the houses, on the gods' holy thresholds.
(English translation by C. Day Lewis)

Aeneas is at the same time an active hero who puts up a resistance and a passive witness who feels all the sufferings of his native city in his soul. The sacking of Troy becomes his earthly inferno, from which nightmare he is never released. But his narrative breaks away from its political-historical contexts and becomes the tragedy of a city ravaged by war — always and everywhere. The universal meaning of the book of Troy is clear to anyone who has lived through world war or who in general considers this the biggest misfortune to befall mankind. Through its humane emphasis Virgil's empathetic account becomes a protest against the madness of war. The poet has a talent comparable to that of the Russian classics for the symphonic development of the horrors of war *crescendo*. Take, for example, Eisenstein's film Alexander Nevsky and Shostakovich's seventh symphony.

In the seventh book and at the beginning of the eighth Virgil describes how Latium is overcome by a war psychosis. I was 3 or 4 years old when the shadow of world war was cast over Europe, but even so I cannot avoid thinking of 1939 when I read the Aeneid. The narrator's attitude in describing war (Aeneid 9–12) is one of inward repression, even to such an extent that his accounts of battle do not become a heroic allegro, but this does not detract from the universal humanity of the epic.

The narrator in Homer's epics is objective, uncommitted and impartial; this signifies not coldness but true humanity. The narrator of the Aeneid avoids propagandistic bias by means of his humane, tragic basic experience. One cannot in this context but admire and love the smiling attitude of the Kalevala narrator, which is not lacking in epic humour.

The most impressive character in the Aeneid in human terms is Dido, Queen of Carthage, whose "past fate" briefly coincides with Aeneas' "future fate", to borrow the apt description of Hermann Broch. Circe, Calypso and Nausicaa are merely episodes in Odysseus' journey, but when Aeneas and Dido meet, their entire fate, their higher ego, is in the balance: one must be destroyed. Dido falls in love with not only the very essence of the hero, but with his past fate, believing she has found a lifelong companion equally mistreated by fate, but the hero's

future fate destroys her world, and Dido decides to kill herself when the hero, obeying the will of the gods, continues his journey. On her death Dido is a queen proud of her achievements and a woman whose heart is broken and whose inner world has collapsed. This is precisely the heart of the tragedy, not the fact that the queen falls from on high.

Dido is a *figura humanitatis* and she introduces new content to the concept of tragedy in classical and European literature. For example, the tragedy of Boris Godunov, in which the ruler's inner and outer worlds collapse simultaneously, could not have been possible purely according to the Greek concept of tragedy. It is characteristic of Virgil's open humanity that he makes Dido the most truly humane figure in his work, and yet it is the Queen of Carthage who becomes the archenemy of Rome, the mythical fomenter of the Punic Wars, the figure behind Hannibal, who crowns her curse in the following words (Aeneid 4:628–629):

Litora litoribus contraria, fluctibus undas
imprecor, arma armis: pugnent ipsique nepotesque.

Shore to shore, sea to sea, weapon to weapon opposed —
I call down a feud between them and us to the last generation!
(English translation by C. Day Lewis)

Dido's words have acquired universal meaning as an expression of the violent hate between two nations, and they have, as we know, been quoted in e. g. the final negotiations to the First World War.

By transferring the epilogue to Aeneas' and Dido's tragedy to Hades, the central point of the book of the underworld (Aeneid 6:450–476), Virgil at the same time transfers it to the depths of the human soul. Aeneas meets, or thinks he meets the ghostly spectre of Dido, speaks to it and admits he has done wrong. He thirsts after a gesture of forgiveness, but Dido stands expressionless as a stone slab and a marble statue and vanishes into the shadows. T. S. Eliot perceived the deeper significance of this scene (Eliot 1945: 20–21):

But I have always thought the meeting of Aeneas with the shade of Dido, in Book VI, not only one of the most poignant, but one of

the most civilised passages in poetry. It is complex in meaning and economical in expression, for it not only tells us about the attitude of Dido — what is still more important is what it tells us about the attitude of Aeneas. Dido's behaviour appears almost as a projection of Aeneas' own conscience: this, we feel, is the way in which Aeneas' conscience would expect Dido to behave to him. The point, it seems to me, is not that Dido is unforgiving — though it is important that, instead of railing him, she merely snubs him — perhaps the most telling snub in all poetry: what matters most is, that Aeneas does not forgive himself — and this, significantly, in spite of the fact of which he is well aware, that all that he has done has been in compliance with destiny, or in consequence of the machinations of gods who are themselves, we feel, only instruments of a greater inscrutable power.

T. S. Eliot's delicate Virgil critique is convincing proof of the position of the poet of the *Aeneid* as a universal classic. He regards the *Aeneid*'s world of values as being simultaneously Roman and European:

It will be observed, finally, that the behaviour of Virgil's characters (I might except Turnus, the man without a destiny) never appears to be according to some purely local or tribal code of manners: it is, in its time, both Roman and European. Virgil certainly, on the plane of manners, is not provincial. (Eliot 1945: 20–21.)

As the second modern criterion for Virgil's status as a classic I would mention the novel *Der Tod des Vergil* by Hermann Broch (1945), in which Aeneas' fate provides the framework for the examination of the ethical and metaphysical responsibility of the poet. The work demands the internalisation of Virgil's life and poetry, for it is many times more than a historical novel (T. Oksala 1986b). The historical theme turns into a prose poem, the inner monologue of the dying poet. Virgil's presence is felt on every plane of the work — almost like in Dante's *Divine Comedy*.

I shall not go into the numerous successors to the *Aeneid* (Dante, Camoens, Tasso, Milton, etc.), because they are not on the programme

for this synopsis. Suffice it to say that the Aeneid has had a strong influence on the European concept of the epic — all in all an even stronger influence than Homer. Side by side with Dante and through him the poet of the national epic of Rome in a way became one of the two universal classics of Italian literature, a representative of the European view of man in world poetry.

Was Lönnrot a Homer or a Virgil?

Lauri Honko has, on the eve of the Kalevala jubilee year 1985, again taken up the question posed by Hans Fromm at the Hamburg Symposium in 1965: was Lönnrot closer to Homer or to Virgil (Honko 1984; Fromm 1968; cf. Honko 1961)? Both Fromm and Honko come down in favour of Virgil, regarding the Kalevala as being primarily the conscious literary creation of Lönnrot.

This question may prove useful and throw light on the nature of Lönnrot's work, so long as it is not taken too literally. Lönnrot resembles Virgil in that both aimed at a national epic and took Homer as an outline model for their conceptions. But Virgil created his epic as a free poet, without any pre-literate poetic tradition, whereas Lönnrot used the horn of plenty of true folk poetry as his material and did not attempt to be a free poet. The poets are comparable in the scale of their conception: each in his own way aspired towards a new synthesis of the material and potential available.

The comparison with Homer is more problematic, as Homer is himself problematic. Homeric scholarship has travelled far since Wolf's and Lönnrot's day, now approaching the opinions of some radical ancient scholars, according to whom the blind rhapsodist by the name of Homer was the creator only of the Iliad. Inner analysis of the epics has proved that they are not products of an anonymous tradition or compilations of folk-tales but the works of an individual poet (Bowra

1930; Schadewaldt 1938). The creative talent with which the figure of Achilles is developed in the *Iliad* (and again in book 11 of the *Odyssey*) bespeaks a poet in the same category as Dante, Goethe and Dostoyevski. On the other hand comparative folklore research has created an empirical picture of how oral composition operates and how the singer commands epic entities (Parry 1930–1932). One thing the Homer thus described and our own historical Lönnrot have in common is the fact that both created their epics on the basis of the myths and epic language in poetic metre passed down by oral tradition. But Lönnrot, sitting at his desk, did by means of his notes what Homer recalled from memory, himself acting as a poet of genius in the stream of epic tradition. Luckily the art of writing preserved Homer's creations for European literature. In their own way Homer and Lönnrot both signified end points to an oral pre-literate tradition — Homer as a culminator, Lönnrot as a compiler — and the start of literature proper. Homer was more of a poet, Lönnrot more a creator of myths who, in the words of Eino Leino, dreamed up the *Kalevala* (T. Oksala 1986a: 275–279). The myths about Troy existed independently of Homer as recorded by many cyclic epicists, but the world of the *Kalevala* exists as mythology only via Lönnrot's collection trips and desk. This being the case, the definition of myth used in comparative religion applies only to the mythical elements of the *Kalevala*, but the work as a whole is a literary pseudo-myth, like the story of Aeneas. Thus in spite of everything the problematic Homer comparison becomes illustrative.

Deciding how far Lönnrot consciously took the classical epic as his model in conceiving the *Kalevala* is quite another matter, and one that is more fruitful for research. Väinö Kaukonen has in his extensive research to my mind justly looked into the relevance of Homer and Homer research in the great synthesis created by Lönnrot. Lönnrot seems to have been well aware of F. A. Wolf's work *Prolegomena ad Homerum* (1795), which H. G. Porthan had discussed in his lectures and which had since then been part of the research tradition of his school (Kajanto 1984: 145–149). Lönnrot found in Wolf a theoretical justification for his own work of compilation, and when the work was completed in 1849, he considered

that his own experience threw light on the manner in which Homer's songs came into being (Lönnrot 1849).

Lönnrot was also familiar with Homer's text. There is a decisive proof of this in his hexametric translations into Finnish, which were appended as examples to his popular introduction to the epics (Becker 1836). In their unforced epic style they clearly surpass the level prevailing at that time. Even better is his interpretation of the book of Nausicaa in the Odyssey written a couple of decades later (Lönnrot 1855), which illustrates Lönnrot's final achievements in hexametric technique (P. Oksala 1959). By that time the translator did, after all, have a great epic work behind him. In his interpretations of Homer Lönnrot observes pure quantitative metre, making no allowance for the accent in Finnish words. But if read without scanning, his Finnish translations sound very natural.

Väinö Kaukonen is, to my mind, correct in stressing that it is impossible to find any true loans from Homer or sections composed in the manner of Homer in the Kalevala. But a knowledge of Homer definitely guided Lönnrot's choices, helping him, amid that wealth of material, to decide which of the motives on his overflowing desk were significant and worthy of epical development.

The mighty synthesis dreamed up for us by Elias Lönnrot, the Kalevala, may in one sense be described as "a creative error", for it was founded on a subsequently discarded theory of Homer. But it is neither the first nor the last creative error in our European culture, for error and creativity often walk hand in hand.

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Lars Lönnroth

The Old Norse Analogue: Eddic Poetry and Fornaldarsaga

When Elias Lönnrot was collecting his material for the Kalevala, he was at least partly prompted by a desire to find a Finnish equivalent to the Scandinavian heritage of sagas and epic poetry from medieval Iceland (Honko 1969: 47). He reveals this ambition in his preface to the Kalevala edition of 1835, where he describes his efforts to find not only isolated songs about Väinämöinen and other Finnish folk heroes but “longer accounts, too, just as we see that the Greeks and the Icelanders and others got songs of their forebears”.

Even though the Greeks are here mentioned first, perhaps out of traditional respect for Homer and the classical heritage, the Icelanders may well have provided Lönnrot with a more disturbing challenge. The Poetic Edda had, during the first decades of the 19th century, been discovered by the literary world of Europe and recognized as a sacred source of national pride not only for the Icelanders but for all the Scandinavian people, including the Swedes, whose culture was still the dominating one in Finland. A whole generation of Romantic poets, enthusiastically admired by the educated classes in Finland, had transformed the Old Norse myths of the Edda and the sagas into cherished national symbols, proclaiming the past and present glories of the Swedes (cf. Blanck 1911; Mjöberg 1967). It is no wonder, then, that Elias Lönnrot wished to find a similar poetic treasure for his own people, the Finns, whose lives were spent in the shadow of all this Viking glory.

Had Elias Lönnrot been alive today, he would probably have been surprised to find that the national value of the Kalevala for the Finns

is nowadays much higher than that of the Edda for the Swedes. The Old Norse myths have largely lost their patriotic appeal to the Scandinavians, even though their literary values are still recognized. The romantic mystique once surrounding the mythical-heroic lore of the Vikings has evaporated, even though scholars still puzzle over many problems concerning the meaning, the origins, the oral transmission, and the preservation of Eddic lays and sagas.

I shall consider some of these problems in the light of recent research but viewed, as far as it is possible for me, from a Finnish perspective. The questions I shall try to answer are the following: what distinguishes the Old Norse genres from their Finnish counterparts? What conclusions can be drawn about the oral performance of epic songs and prose tales in early Scandinavian society? To what extent have these songs and prose tales influenced the collection of the Kalevala?

The genres

It should be noted, then, that the epic forms of medieval Iceland are quite different from the stichic songs of narrative verse found in the Kalevala, or the Iliad, or Beowulf. On one hand we have the *fornaldarsögur* (literally: “sagas of ancient times”), which are mythical-heroic prose tales, preserved in manuscripts from the 13th and 14th centuries but evidently based on a much older oral tradition (see, for example, Buchholtz 1980; Glauser 1983), known not only in Iceland but also in other parts of the Scandinavian language area; some of them, for example, were translated into Latin by Saxo Grammaticus in his Danish chronicle, *Gesta Danorum*, from around 1200 (Olrik 1892; Hermann 1901–22). On the other hand we have the poems or lays of the Edda, which in form are more similar to ballads than to the epic songs of the Kalevala; they are, for example, generally shorter, divided into stanzas

and contain a much higher proportion of direct speech, either monologue or dialogue, so that the mode of expression frequently appears more lyrical or dramatic than epic. The oldest and most celebrated of these lays are found in the Codex Regius, an Icelandic 13th century manuscript, where the narrative contexts of the poetic texts are often presented in prose. Several Eddic lays are also presented within the framework of a *fornaldarsaga*, and some were translated into Latin verse by Saxo; a few Eddic lines are even found on rune stones from the Viking age, a fact which proves that the genre existed at that time throughout Scandinavia. Linguistic evidence suggests that some of the preserved Eddic lays may be even older, perhaps from the Germanic migration era (see, for example, Hallberg 1975; Helgason 1953; Dronke 1969; Harris 1985).

I shall here, at least for the moment, disregard the dating problems, which, in my opinion, have preoccupied Old Norse scholars far too much. Instead, I shall focus on the formal relationship between the genre of *fornaldarsaga* and the genre of Eddic lay in the 13th century, when the Old Norse texts were first committed to vellum by Icelandic scribes. Whatever preceded that century is a subject of learned speculation, not of precise knowledge, and thus it is always in 13th century Iceland that any study of the epic tradition in early Scandinavia must begin, just as any study of the Kalevala must begin in the 19th century culture of Eastern Finland, where Lönnrot collected his texts.

It is evident, first of all, that the prose of the *fornaldarsaga* and the poetry of the Eddic lay were meant to supplement each other in 13th century texts. Together, they constitute a mixed narrative form, an Old Norse *prosimetrum*, in which the prose is supposed to tell most of the story, while the poetry is supposed to give a dramatic and lyrical presentation of some particularly moving incident, for example the death of the hero. The same division of labor between prose and poetry may be found in Saxo's mythical-heroic tales, a fact which indicates that the combination was not invented by Icelandic saga-writers of the 13th century but existed in the oral tradition even before their time.

The performance

What, then, was the nature of the oral performance, out of which this combination of prose saga and Eddic lay originated? Unfortunately, there are no authentic eyewitness accounts of such performances from 13th century Iceland, but there is at least one *fornaldarsaga* in which the main character is himself a legendary oral performer, and it appears likely that the story about him, although obviously mythical, can give us some clues as to what such a performer was normally expected to do. I am referring to the so-called *Norna-Gests þáttur*, 'The Story of Norna-Gest' (Nordal 1944: 384–398), apparently written in Iceland around 1300 but clearly dependent on an old tradition, since the story has been shown to have close parallels not only in earlier sagas but also in the Anglo-Saxon poem *Widsith* (cf. Schlauch 1931; Holtsmark 1965; Lönnroth 1971).

In *Norna-Gests þáttur* we are told that Olaf Tryggvason, king of Norway during the early Conversion period, was visited some time before his death by a strange old man, who called himself Norna-Gest ('Guest of the Norns'). The stranger turned out to be several hundred years old and to have met several great legendary heroes of the past. Shortly before Christmas, as King Olaf's men sat drinking, Norna-Gest entertained them by first playing his harp and then telling various stories about Sigurd the Volsung and other heroes he had met. He also showed some heroic relics that he carried with him: the golden ring of the Volsungs (Wagner's *Nibelungenring*) and a strand from the tail of Sigurd's horse, Grani. Episodes from the Volsung legend are included in this part of the text as told in the first person by Norna-Gest himself. At various points in his prose narrative, Norna-Gest lets his characters speak in verses, which are in fact verbatim quotations from two well-known dialogue poems included in the *Codex Regius*, *Reginismál* (The Sayings of Regin) and *Helreið Brynhildar* (Brynhild's Ride to Hel).

The entertainment is said to have met with enthusiasm by the courtiers, although the king himself showed some slight disapproval, evidently because of the pagan elements in the Volsung legend. Afterwards, however, the king strikes up a conversation with his guest, asking him about the various kings he has served and about the reasons for his amazing age. It is then revealed that Norna-Gest (like Meleager of the Greek myth) had been bewitched at his birth by three Norns (hence his name, 'Guest of the Norns'), who allowed him to live until a certain candle, which he carried with him ever since, had burned out. Norna-Gest now decides to take the Christian faith and then die in peace. King Olaf has him baptized, the candle is lit, and as it burns out, the old visitor from a mythical past is finally put to rest.

Although Norna-Gest himself is clearly a creation of myth (both pagan and Christian), his performance and its social context are probably in several important respects typical of mythical-heroic entertainment in Iceland and Norway during the 13th century. We know, for example, from other sources, that such entertainment occurred at big feasts, when people were drinking (Foote 1955–56; Pálsson 1962), and that it was based on a combination of poetic recitation and story-telling (Hofmann 1971); we also know that it was regarded with some disapproval by religious authorities but still accepted in aristocratic circles (Sveinsson 1953). We know, furthermore, that heroic relics were treasured possessions in the homes of Icelandic chieftain families (Sveinsson 1953), and that the most famous oral performers, the skalds, were surrounded with a great deal of pagan mystique, since they supposedly, according to the myth, derived their art from Odin himself (de Vries 1957: 66–75; cf. Frank 1981).

As a performer, Norna-Gest is similar in many ways to the *scop* of West-Germanic tradition, described in *Beowulf* and other Anglo-Saxon texts. This is to be expected, since their cultures and languages are closely related. Like the *scop*, Norna-Gest carries a harp, his implied audience consists of mead-drinking warriors in a royal hall, and he plays the role of a wanderer who has seen many such mead-halls before; the same role is played, for example, by the narrator of *Widsith*. Norna-

Gest's repertory of myths and legends is also very similar to that of the scop, centered on tales of revenge and warfare featuring Germanic heroes from the Migration period. The story of Sigurd the Volsung, for example, is also well known from West-Germanic sources (see, for example, Andersson 1980). The alliterative meter of the Eddic lays, finally, is virtually the same as that of Beowulf, Widsith, Hildebrandslied, and the other epic poems within West-Germanic tradition (cf. Lehmann 1956).

These similarities between Old Norse and West-Germanic "singers of tales" become even more evident if we compare them to the Finnish folksingers in the Kalevala tradition. While the Finnish singers belong to a marginal society consisting of small farmers and hunters, their Germanic colleagues belong to an aristocratic and rather wealthy society consisting of kings, earls, chieftains and their entourage of warriors, the *hirð* or *comitatus*. Their epic songs are not as concerned with magic as the Kalevala is, and their typical epic setting is not the wild Northern landscape of Scandinavia or Finland but rather the battlefields and royal courts of Western Europe. It is obvious that the mythical-heroic traditions of Iceland, Scandinavia, England and Germany all have a common origin in the heroic age of the European Migration period, while the origin of the Kalevala tradition is much more obscure and obviously quite different.

It is important to note, however, that the epic performance of Norna-Gest, in spite of its similarities to the epic performance of the West-Germanic scop, is also different in several important respects, suggesting that the art had developed differently in Iceland from in England or Germany. The scop's singing of epic tales to the harp, first of all, seems to have been divided here into three separate activities: harp-playing, story-telling in prose, and poetic recitation. Apparently, prose had in Old Norse society taken over more and more of the narrative function of the earlier heroic lays, so that eventually only some especially dramatic speeches and dialogues were highlighted in verse form: heroic boasts, the hero's last words on the battlefield, a lover's farewell, an exchange of insults between enemies, and so on. This explains why

there is a much higher proportion of direct speech in the lays of the Edda than in the corresponding poems of the West-Germanic tradition. It also explains why early Eddic poems contain more narrative than late ones, which often look like pure drama with nothing but dialogue (Hofmann 1971; Lönnroth 1971).

An attempt was made in the early twenties (Philpotts 1920) to explain the dramatic form by the assumption that a large number of Eddic poems were originally meant to be performed as ritual dramas. Although this theory is still referred to by some mediaevalists (for example Jones 1961), it has never been accepted by Old Norse scholars. There are no indications that a ritual drama even existed in Scandinavia, much less that it influenced the Edda. In any case, it is more natural to assume that the dramatic form developed out of narrative, rather than the other way around (cf. Heusler 1902, 1921–22). Nevertheless, it seems quite likely that the dramatic speech poems were intended to be performed in a semi-theatrical fashion, although by one performer only and normally within the prose context of a saga presentation.

It is difficult to determine whether music played any considerable role in the Old Norse performances, even though scholars have believed they were sung or chanted (Einarsson 1963; Hofmann 1963; Hofmann & Jammers 1965). Harp-playing is mentioned in several early sources, sometimes in conjunction with poetry but never in such a way as to suggest that the harp was used to accompany epic singing (Jónsson 1907–8). In *Norna-Gests þáttur* it is said that Norna-Gest one evening took his harp and played for a long time on it, “so that everybody liked to listen to it, yet he played *Gunnarsslag* best; and at last he played the old *Guðrúnarbrögð*, which people had not heard before.” It is evident that *Gunnarsslag* (Gunnar’s melody) and *Guðrúnarbrögð* (Guðrún’s trick) are both names of tunes that are somehow associated with the Volsung legend told by Norna-Gest later on in the story, since both Gunnar and Guðrún are main characters in this legend. Yet it is also evident that Norna-Gest’s epic recitation does not really start until he has put his harp away. Perhaps we should interpret his harp-playing as a sort of “overture” and, at the same time, as a reminiscence from

more archaic times, when the harp had indeed been used to accompany the recitation in much the same way as in West-Germanic performances. We never hear of such recitations, however, in Iceland during the 12th or 13th centuries. And only a few Eddic texts that are in some way associated with magic are clearly characterized as “songs” (*ljóð* or *galdr*).

We may learn more about the nature of the mythical-heroic performance by looking more closely at the speech poems recited by Norna-Gest and their relation to the prose context in which he presents them. The first poem appears in the famous story of Sigurd’s youth, just after he has received his father’s sword but before he has killed Fafnir or won the Rhinegold. He is now on his way to his first important battle, when he is suddenly hailed by a mysterious stranger, obviously Odin in disguise. At this point, Norna-Gest shifts into verse in order to deliver what is essentially a very general lecture by Odin on how a young warrior should behave — a piece of didacticism which seems to be aimed just as much at the listening warriors in King Olaf’s mead-hall as at the hero in the prose story. After the poem has been recited, Odin disappears from the narrative and his encounter with Sigurd does not seem to have any consequences later on, so the whole poetic episode clearly appears as a digression.

The second poem, Brynhild’s Ride to Hel, is recited by Norna-Gest after he has told his audience about the death of Sigurd and Brynhild, and about how their bodies were burned on the funeral pyre. As an introduction to the poem, he relates in prose how the dead Brynhild, riding to the other world, was stopped by a giantess, who refused her passage through her domain. Then the poem itself starts with the giantess’ hateful speech against Brynhild: she is an evil creature whose hands have been reddened in the blood of men. In answer to this accusation, Brynhild delivers a magnificent apologia, recapitulating her misfortunes and the tragic chain of events which led to Sigurd’s death. She concludes, finally, that her suffering has made her worthy of becoming Sigurd’s consort in the world of the dead: “Men and women on Middle-Earth/Must contend with grief and for too long:/Never shall

Sigurd be sundered from me;/None shall unjoin us./Giantess, yield!” (transl. W. H. Auden and Paul B. Taylor). Like Odin’s lecture to Sigurd, this poem is clearly digressive from a narrative point of view, since the audience is already supposed to know Brynhild’s life, and the giantess does not have any function in the story except to give Brynhild an excuse to deliver her poetic speech. The main reason for presenting this poem is clearly to let the audience *see* Brynhild a last time in all her tragic splendor, and perhaps to let them identify her sorrows with those of all women.

In both cases, the poems tend to retard the action and break the narrative flow of the prose. At the same time, the poems are highly “dramatic” in the sense that they present characters and their emotions in direct speech and give excellent opportunities for theatrical posturing. The verses provide exactly the kind of thing that could not be provided by a cool, objective prose of the sagas, i. e. passions and rhetoric. In many respects, Norna-Gest’s poetic *intermezzi* can be compared to the arias of a 19th century opera (Wagner’s Siegfried naturally comes to mind), where the hero or heroine suddenly stops doing whatever he or she is doing on the stage in order to address the audience directly in a melodramatic outburst. Judging from the *fornaldarsögur*, this was a fairly common way to use the verse form within the framework of a prose presentation. If my assumption is correct, there is consequently a definite relationship between, on the one hand, the cool “objectivity” of Old Norse saga style and, on the other hand, the rhetorical fervor of many Eddic poems — they were meant to complement each other, at least to some extent, in the same performance (cf. Lönnroth 1970, 1971).

Prose and poetry may thus be interpreted as two different “voices” in the performance — the voice of narration and the voice of emotion. The same voices also appear in *Beowulf*, the *Iliad* or the *Kalevala*, but there they are not as clearly distinguished and tend to mingle and flow together, often within the same sentence or verse line. In Old Norse performances, on the other hand, such as the one provided by Norna-Gest, the shift from one voice to the other is very clearly emphasized,

forcing the performer to shift back and forth between two different roles: the role of the narrator, simply representing “what happened” without any subjective comments, and the role of a character within the story, expressing his or her emotional reactions to whatever happened in some memorable poetic stanzas.

As we have seen, the first speech poem recited by Norna-Gest — in Odin’s name — could well be interpreted as having a specific application to the audience, the warriors in King Olaf’s hall. There are other examples of Eddic recitations being adjusted to the situation of the audience. The most famous example is found in Snorri’s *Saga of Olaf the Saint* (Hkr II: 361), where we are told that the skald Thormod woke up the king’s army before the battle of Stiklastad by reciting for them *Bjarkamál hin fornu* (The Old Lay of Bjarki), a dialogue poem about the last battle of the legendary King Rolf Kraki. The introductory stanzas contain a dramatic exhortation to battle by one of King Rolf’s warriors, who has seen the enemy approaching in the early morning and now tries to wake up his comrades: “Dawn has come,/And the cock has flapped his wings./It is time for the workmen/To start their toil.” The whole poem can be said to define the duties of the royal retainer when his liege lord is in danger. Nothing could be more appropriate to recite in this specific situation. Through his recitation, Thormod establishes a “double scene” (Lönnroth 1978, 1979), a sense of identity between the scene of the poem and the scene of the performance, so that the warriors of King Olaf must feel the obligation of being as staunch and unflinching in their loyalty as were the legendary warriors of King Rolf in *Bjarkamál*.

There are several Eddic poems in which the scene of action seems to blend with that of the performance in a similar way (cf. Lönnroth 1971: 8). There are, for example, many references in direct-speech poems to drinking in the mead-hall. A number of poems start out with the arrival in the hall of a tired wanderer from afar (frequently Odin in disguise), a man expecting to be hospitably received and well-treated with food and drink. It appears likely that this theme at least partly reflects the performer’s, the entertainer’s, own situation. Like Widsith

and Norna-Gest, he naturally wants to be identified as the wise old traveller who has come in from the cold and who deserves respect and good treatment from his audience in return for his stories and his verses. To create the desired effect he chooses an appropriate dramatic role for his performance.

To summarize, we may say that many of these Eddic poems in direct speech appear to serve as a kind of indirect exhortation of their audience, delivered in a prose context as a lyrical-dramatic intermezzo, in which the performer assumes the role of one or more legendary characters, who have usually been introduced in the prose that went before.

We also find in the West-Germanic tradition of heroic poetry a similar but much weaker tendency towards concentration on a few scenes, where the action often seems to stand still and the characters express themselves in didactic and rhetorical terms: we may think, for example, of the elegies and the many edifying speeches in *Beowulf*. The Norsemen, however, pushed the separation between factual narration and dramatic exhortation a step further by letting the saga prose take care of the former while reserving poetry for the latter.

How, then, shall we account for the difference between the two traditions? It seems probable that the Scandinavians once had pure verse narration of the West-Germanic type, the narrative parts of which they later consigned to prose. This development seems to have been paralleled by a development away from a musical or semi-musical delivery — in which the harp was used to accompany the recitation — towards a more dramatic enacting of the verse lines without any instrumental accompaniment but possibly with a sort of musical “overture” on the harp such as the one performed by Norna-Gest. At the same time, there is evidently a trend towards a stricter poetic form: compared to the West-Germanic poems, the Eddic lays of Iceland are not only composed in regular lyric stanzas but they also seem more concise, since they are not as full of ornamental formulas and repetitions.

It seems most natural to conclude that these various developments are dependent upon each other and prompted by the tendency towards separation between straight narrative and lyrical-dramatic exhortations.

As prose took over narrative and verse became more lyrical, the performer would no longer be dependent on oral formulas to fill out his verse lines, since the verses would now be shorter and hence easier to memorize. If they were also dramatically enacted in his performance, he may at some stage have found the harp superfluous or even bothersome during the actual recitation, and so he may have decided to give the harp a more limited function or even to put it aside altogether.

We can never hope to reconstruct in detail each stage of the development from early Germanic epic forms to late Norse prosimetrum. We can only speculate about various possibilities. It is not inconceivable, for example, that Eddic poetry was once based on oral-formulaic improvisation of the kind studied in Yugoslavia by Milman Parry and Albert Lord (1960). Such an origin has been postulated by Francis Peabody Magoun (1953) and Robert Kellogg (1958, 1966), both adherents of the “oral-formulaic school” at Harvard University. If they are right, however, the poetic form must at some later stage have become fixed and transmitted verbatim like lyrical ballads. The Poetic Edda we now have shows every sign of being based on (more or less imperfect) memorization, not on formulaic improvisation, but it is impossible to know whether this was always the case.

We may conclude with certainty, however, that there was an increasing tendency towards separation between prose and verse in the Old Norse tradition. From an artistic point of view this separation was beneficial. It liberated heroic narrative from the straight-jacket of metrics and poetic conventions while at the same time giving the poets a chance to fulfil their true potentialities by subjecting their art to further discipline and refinement. In comparison to West-Germanic narrative poetry, the Edda is much less lax, repetitious and conventional in style; its didacticism more epigrammatic; its rhetoric more succinct and precise.

What we have said about the performance and its history could perhaps partly explain why this is so, and why these poems are not to be regarded as oral-formulaic improvisations. *Norna-Gests þáttur* — as well as other evidence — suggests that we should rather interpret Eddic

lays as carefully polished products of poetic craftsmanship, as rhetorical and dramatic showpieces meticulously preserved from one performance to the next, where they would be the especially esteemed highlights of a legendary and, presumably, highly variable *fornaldarsaga*.

The Edda and the Kalevala

Is it, then, possible that the Finnish rune-singers were in some way influenced by the art of their Old Norse neighbors? Such a theory has been advanced by Francis P. Magoun (1960) on the basis of two sets of arguments. The first consists in similarities between the performance techniques of the rune-singers and early Germanic performance techniques described in *Widsith*, primarily the use of antiphonal epic singing involving two different performers (cf. Mustanoja 1959). The second set of arguments is based on stylistic similarities, particularly the use of certain recurring images and formulas, which Magoun has found both in the *Kalevala* and in Anglo-Saxon poems such as *Beowulf*. From such evidence Magoun concludes that Finns in the Viking Age “must often have heard Swedish singers and Swedish-speaking Finnish singers of the time may well have picked up and adapted phrases, images and conceivably other techniques of Old-Germanic versification, including possibly antiphonal singing *à deux*, which may have struck them as useful and attractive” (Magoun 1960: 181).

As we have seen, however, the performance techniques of the Icelandic and Old Norse performers were quite different from those described in Anglo-Saxon sources. Antiphonal singing is not known to have existed at any time among Old Norse and Old Swedish folk singers; the Finns are more likely to have learned this technique in their own churches. And the stylistic parallels between Anglo-Saxon and Finnish epic poetry are of a very general kind, which does not prove anything about influence. The closest parallels, such as the

metaphoric formula “to open one’s word-box” (in the sense of “to speak”), are not found in the Edda, as we might have expected, if these images and phrases had indeed been borrowed by the Finns from their Swedish neighbors. There is of course a theoretical possibility that the Swedes had preserved certain oral formulas and performance techniques which were lost in Iceland, and that these were then in turn borrowed by the Finnish rune-singers, but there is really no evidence for such a theory. In essence, there is a very large difference between the art of the rune-singers and the art of their Scandinavian-speaking neighbors.

There is, on the other hand, a distinct possibility that the structure of the Kalevala was partly influenced by Elias Lönnrot’s studies of the Edda. A letter which he wrote to J. G. Linsén in 1834 is, in my view, worthy of closer attention than it appears to have received, at least from Old Norse scholars. Lönnrot writes as follows:

As I compared these (the results of my collections on my fourth journey) to what I had seen before, I was seized by a desire to organize them into a single whole in order to make of the Finnish mythology something similar to that of the Icelandic Edda. So I threw myself into the labors before me immediately and continued working for a number of weeks, actually months, until Christmas, when I had quite a volume of poems about Väinämöinen in exactly the order in which I desired them. I gave attention especially to the chronology of the feats described in the poems. (af Forselles 1911: 187; cf. Honko 1969: 47.)

Further on in the same letter Lönnrot expresses the hope that his collection will be valued as highly by “our descendants” (*våra efterkommande*) as the Edda has been valued by “the Gothic people” (*de Göthiska folkslagen*), i. e. by the Scandinavians. He also compares his collection with Hesiod rather than with Homer. Lönnrot is, in other words, seeing the Edda as a sort of national mythology rather than as an epic in the ordinary sense of that term (cf. Fromm 1985). This was how the Edda was generally regarded at the time, not as a mere anthology of poems taken out of their prose contexts from various sagas. The collection of

Eddic poems found in Codex Regius was still attributed by many scholars to Sæmund the Wise, an Icelandic priest who lived in the 12th century and supposedly organized the older Norse songs about gods and legendary heroes into a consistent whole, a mythical-heroic history presenting the events in chronological order, much as Hesiod's *Theogony* had supposedly done for Greek mythology (cf. Afzelius 1818, preface). Nobody today believes that Sæmund had anything to do with the Edda, but Lönnrot most probably believed what most experts had taught about this matter, and he probably wanted to play the role of Sæmund himself when organizing the material he had collected from the Finnish rune-singers. It may then be profitable to compare the ordering of poems in the so-called "Sæmund's Edda" or, in other words, the Codex Regius, with the ordering of songs in the various versions of the Kalevala.

The Codex Regius starts out with *Völuspá*, a sybil's poetic recitation about the creation of the world and the wars between gods and giants, finally culminating in universal destruction, *Ragnarök*, and the rise of a new and better world out of the ruins of the old one. Then follows a series of didactic speech poems, featuring Odin, the oldest and wisest of the Scandinavian gods, as the protagonist: *Hávamál*, basically a series of proverbs presented as the sayings of Odin, *Vafþrúðnismál*, a dialogue poem presenting a contest of wisdom between Odin and the giant *Vafthrudnir*, and *Grímnismál*, a didactic monologue supposedly spoken by Odin in the hall of king *Grimnir*. After these "Odin poems" follows a series of poems about Frey and Thor, the two other main gods of the Old Norse pantheon. The collection is finally concluded with a series of poems about human heroes, particularly Sigurd and other heroes of the Volsung cycle. All these poems are placed in an approximate chronological order to form a continuous story (provided that the poems are presented within a prose narrative, as in Norna-Gest's oral performance).

Even in the earliest versions of the Kalevala, Elias Lönnrot appears to be organizing his material according to similar principles, starting out with mythical songs about *Väinämöinen* and the creation of the

world, then continuing with songs about other heroes, finally concluding with the virgin's immaculate conception and the passing of the old, pagan world order. In the Proto-Kalevala of 1834 he has still not managed to find much mythological material about the creation, evidently not a very common theme among rune-singers, but in the New Kalevala of 1849 there is, nevertheless, a wealth of such material, now organized in such a way as to make the Finnish work even richer in pagan lore than the Edda. After a lengthy description of the creation, Väinämöinen's birth and early activities as a demi-god or culture hero, there follows a didactic dialogue in the form of Väinämöinen's and Joukahainen's contest of wisdom, which includes Joukahainen's "maxims" and some magic charms. This section may be said to correspond to the first "Odin poems" of the Edda, in particular *Hávamál* and *Vafþrúðnismál* (with its similar contest of wisdom between Odin and the giant Vafthrudnir).

The similarity between the first songs of the Edda and the first songs of the Kalevala is particularly remarkable when we consider the fact that Elias Lönnrot had stated rather flatly in his early dissertation of 1827 that Väinämöinen's place of birth could "hardly be determined from the traditions of our ancestors", and that he only knew one poetic fragment describing Väinämöinen's growing up (Lönnrot 1969: 277). Lönnrot was evidently on the outlook for such material, but it took many years before he was able to find it in sufficient abundance to provide what he considered an appropriate mythological beginning for his Finnish national epic. In his dissertation he had nevertheless defended the theory that Väinämöinen belonged to the race of trolls and giants mentioned in the Icelandic texts, once the aborigines of the North but driven away by Odin and his followers (Lönnrot 1969: 280). If he really seriously believed in this theory, it must have been tempting for him to let the Finnish giants take their revenge on the Scandinavian gods by creating a new Edda, a sort of "Anti-Edda", seen from a Finnish perspective.

Yet it would be foolish to claim that the Kalevala is a mere imitation of the Edda. Although both works were regarded in the 19th century

as national epics of a similar nature, they are based on folklore traditions that are fundamentally different in terms of language, ethnic culture and the very nature of the oral performance.

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Hans Fromm

Kalevala and Nibelungenlied: The Problem of Oral and Written Composition

What is the meaning of the copula “and” in the phrase in the title “Kalevala and Nibelungenlied”? In other words, was Elias Lönnrot familiar with the Nibelungenlied before 1849? And is it, then, perhaps conceivable that the German epic had some influence on the Finnish one? These questions must be answered before we can proceed to a treatment of the topic itself. The Nibelungenlied is often mentioned in connection with the genesis of Lönnrot’s epic. The erudite character of the latter’s work induces us to assume he kept an eye out for other epics.

Did the Nibelungenlied have any influence on the birth-process of the Kalevala?

However, as far as we can see, there is no tangible evidence to indicate that Lönnrot ever read the Nibelungenlied or that he was more than superficially acquainted with its content. He was scarcely capable of reading the text in the Middle High German original, for he never received any systematic formal teaching in German. At school in Hämeenlinna the emphasis was on the classics and on religious education; German was available on an extracurricular basis only for a brief period and only for the most talented pupils (Anttila 1931: 58). And although Lönnrot had to study no less than eleven subjects at university,

as the curriculum decreed, German was not one of the subjects he chose (Anttila 1931: 82, 121).

On his field trips for research purposes, Lönnrot did occasionally, out of necessity, have recourse to German, the rudiments of which he had presumably taught himself. But even as late as 1845 he wrote to a certain Councillor von der Hagen — not the well-known German philologist — about the difficulties he had when writing or speaking German (Lönnrot 1902, II: 282). His “inadequate ability to use the language” prevented him from writing letters in German. Admittedly, even as early as 1837, Lönnrot was able to report from the Kola peninsula that he had encountered Germans there and had “recalled to a certain degree the German words” he had read in books but had never actively employed to any great extent (Lönnrot 1902, I: 336). In 1844, during a six weeks’ stay in Dorpat, Lönnrot felt that this basis was nevertheless sufficient and had been intensified by the “German surroundings” there to such an extent that he could carry out his bold plan to compose a comparative Finnish, Estonian, Veps and Lapp grammar written in German (Lönnrot 1902, II: 251). In the trilingual “Gespräch-Buch”, which he published in 1847 and which is of significance for research into the terminology used by the Finns for natural history, it is difficult to gauge the level of Lönnrot’s active knowledge of German.

1827, the year in which Lönnrot completed his Master’s degree in medicine and the year of the Great Fire of Turku, in which, among other things, the second part of Lönnrot’s dissertation was destroyed, saw the publication of Karl Simrock’s translation of the *Nibelungenlied* into New High German, the first translation which departed sufficiently from the original for it to be understood without a knowledge of Middle High German (Simrock 1827). At that time there were still no translations of the *Nibelungenlied* into Scandinavian languages. Lönnrot does not appear to have taken cognizance of Simrock’s edition.

On various occasions, for the first time on 3 December 1833, in a letter to a former fellow student of his, Henrik Cajander, Lönnrot was at pains to compare his conception of the epic with Homer (Lönnrot

1902, I: 196), whose epics he considered against the background of Friedrich August Wolf's theory (af Forselles 1908: 228), according to which these epics were composed of individual lays, a theory which at that time could claim almost universal support. Since his schooldays, Lönnrot had felt more at home in the world of classical antiquity than in any other cultural realm. It was not merely the fact that throughout his life spontaneous parallels and associations occurred to him — for example, when he used the Delphic Pythia to illuminate shamanistic ecstasy (af Forselles 1908: 8) and explained the verse of the Kalevala in terms of classical versification (Lönnrot 1902, I: 399–400); he himself translated parts of the Iliad and the Odyssey into Finnish, and related how he occasionally had recourse to Latin as a *lingua franca* when difficulties in communication arose.

There can be little doubt that Lönnrot was also unaware of the fact that Karl Lachmann, one of the founders of German philology as a modern 'science' and a trained classical philologist, had applied Wolf's theory to the Nibelungenlied as early as 1816 and had postulated that it was composed of 20 individual lays (Lachmann 1876: 1–80). Otherwise Lönnrot would scarcely have failed to embrace this additional argument in connection with his own historicizing definition.

The second model referred to by Lönnrot himself is the Edda. Lönnrot first mentioned it in a letter dated 6 February 1834 to Johan Gabriel Linsén, the prominent representative of the Turku National Romantic Movement and Professor of Classical literature. Lönnrot planned "to create something in Finnish mythology which would correspond to the Icelandic Edda". It is worth recalling, however, that Lönnrot was anxious here to interest the Kongliga Fornskrifts Sällskab in Copenhagen in his project; the latter had approached him in a letter passed on to him by Linsén. That the Edda consisted of traditional lays and was not an epic along the lines of the Homeric model, naturally made little impression on a man who had found in Wolf's theory the historical legitimation for his plan to compose an epic anyway. What had attracted him to the Edda from the outset was no doubt its cosmological aspect; and this is endorsed by the fact that in the above-

mentioned letter to Linsén, he added to the names Homer and the Edda the name Hesiod (Lönnrot 1902, I: 198).

The Nibelungs epic was first related to the Kalevala in evaluative comparisons by recipients of the latter. Thus Robert Tengström, the philosopher who died at an early age and to whom we are indebted for an interesting essay on the Old Kalevala (Tengström 1845: 111–189), placed the Nibelungenlied, together with Ossian and the Edda, behind the Kalevala. For Tengström, the Kalevala was second only to the Homeric epics. The criteria which determined Tengström's judgement were the "beauty" of the content, the "cordiality", particularly of the "family life", and the poetic quality of the form.

In the same year as Tengström's essay appeared, 1845, ten years after the publication of the Old Kalevala, Jacob Grimm expounded, on 13 March in the Berlin Academy, his thoughts "On the Finnish Epic" (Grimm 1865: 75–113). Here, too, the Nibelungenlied was mentioned, admittedly no less in passing than had been the case with Tengström, but here in the context of a historical argument as opposed to an aesthetic one. Grimm regarded the two epics — for he no more doubted than the others that the Finnish lays were fragments of an old epic (Grimm 1865: 78) — as representing different stages of an evolutionary development of the epic. The course of this development was from an "ältesten mythischen element" with "dunkleren und kräftigeren bestandtheilen" to the heroic legend, which is "menschlicher und anmutig ausgebreitet". "In unseren Nibelungen, wie wir sie übrig haben (i. e., in the extant version), waltet entschieden diese verdünnung des mythus...; in der Edda und bei Homer ist noch den göttern ihr theil, obgleich die helden vorwiegen, gelassen..." (Grimm 1865: 76). The ranking of Lönnrot's Kalevala is determined in terms of the position it occupies in the evolutionary scale, i. e. by the importance of the role played in it by 'myth'.

Later, too, the comparison with the Nibelungenlied must have suggested itself particularly strongly to the German readers of the Kalevala, a surprisingly large number of whom were men of learning.

The linguist Heymann Steinthal drew this comparison (Steinthal 1868: 33 sqq., 43), as did Andreas Heusler, the researcher into heroic legends, but even this expert on the material produces remarkably little of typological value. He does not proceed beyond the stereotype comparison of the knightly world of the Nibelungs and the peasant culture of the Finns, the belligerency and feudality on the one hand and the magic on the other (Heusler 1943: 215).

In Finland the comparison was made almost two decades before Lönnrot's epic came into existence. In 1817, Carl Axel Gottlund, the collector of folksongs and later critic of Lönnrot, wrote in a newspaper review:

The reviewer goes so far as to claim that if an attempt were made to collect the old folksongs and to form them into a systematic unity — quite irrespective of whether this should be an epic, a drama or whatever — the result could be a new Homer, Ossian or a new Nibelungenlied. (Gottlund 1817: 394.)

It is evident that the comparison with the Nibelungenlied was part of the stock of common ideas which enjoyed currency at that time, and Lönnrot, like most others, undoubtedly assimilated a great deal of his knowledge second hand, with the obvious exception of his knowledge of the Antiquity and of the Edda. Lönnrot's library did not contain a single work by the great stimulator, Johann Gottfried Herder. The former borrowed *Stimmen der Völker in Liedern* from Helsinki University Library in 1840, when he was working on the preface to the *Kanteletar* (Anttila 1931: 340).

The results of the survey: there is no evidence to suggest that the Nibelungenlied could have had any influence whatsoever on the conception of the Finnish epic. For this reason, we shall concentrate in what follows on a small number of aspects of the typological and historical comparison. This is intended to illuminate certain characteristics which, if considered in a non-comparative context, would not be so distinct.

The epics as historical dreams

However, to begin with we should like briefly to take an apparent detour. The comparison of the two epics as was undertaken on countless occasions over a period of some 100 years, from 1850 to 1950, in German reviews of the *Kalevala*, focused less on the epics themselves, which have very little in common, than on the historical influence which the two epics exercised at the time the interpreter drew the comparison. In other words: the *Kalevala*-myth and the *Nibelungen*-myth of the 19th century determined what was written. The fact that the geneses of the two epics are separated by over 700 years, disappeared behind the parallel which had been discerned.

With the end of the Middle Ages, the *Nibelungs* epic had been lost from general consciousness, and its second history had not begun until 1755, when the physician Jacob Hermann Obereit from Lindau/Lake Constance discovered in Schloss Hohenems in the now Austrian Vorarlberg the Manuscript C from the middle of the 13th century, which is now held at Donaueschingen, and Johann Jacob Bodmer, the Swiss poet and antiquarian, had the second part of it published two years later (Bodmer 1757). The beginnings were difficult, for an interest in mediaeval German culture did not concur with the spirit of the times, and it was only Romanticism (Körner 1911), with its return to a sentimental, stylized notion of the Middle Ages, that laid claim to the Hohenstaufen epic for its unfulfilled dream of the great empire. This ideological interpretation of the *Nibelungenlied* was to prove extremely difficult to eradicate. For many decades it served journalists for their commentaries on 'kleindeutsch' and 'grossdeutsch' politics (Brackert 1971: 343–364), as they cast a retrospective historical glance at the tragic grandeur of the Hohenstaufen Empire. Even in the final months of the Second World War, the as it were official reference to the annihilation of the Burgundians at the Court of Etzel (Attila the Hun) was intended to reconcile the German nation with the fate of having once played a great historical role in defeat. Similarly, it is a well-known fact that solemn reminiscences of the *Kalevala* and of the

eastern land of the lays accompanied the Finnish soldiers in the war against Russia from 1941 to 1944 (Wilson 1976: 192).

The harmony of the voices in such ideological simplification necessarily obscured the matter itself. The fact that the culture of the Karelian Middle Ages and of the centuries that immediately followed as reflected in the *Kalevala* cannot be taken unconditionally to be a representation of the “ancient forefathers” of the contemporary Finns, had to be ignored just as much as the fact that the *Nibelungenlied* is not a literary reflection of early German history. The historical background of the *Nibelungenlied* is the battles fought in the period of the Migrations by an East Germanic tribe, the remains of which was later to found a state in France, and, in addition to this, probably incidents from the time of the Franconian Merovingians, long before the Franconians formed the centre of a linguistic community which considered itself to be German. Moreover, that treachery, intrigue and cunning play a central role in the events of the *Nibelungenlied* did not always make as deep an impression on academic interpreters as it ought to have done.

The ahistorical world of the *Kalevala*, with only the vague historical setting of the eve of a turning point in time, merely adumbrating the coming of Christianity as the keystone of the new aeon, admittedly made it easier for interpreters. Yet not only general consciousness, but academics, too, had their own difficulties in accepting the conception of the epic, with its prehistoric, heathen stylization as a great literary achievement in the spirit of European Romanticism, and in contemplating the conclusions which were to be drawn from the fact (Kaukonen 1979: 186–187 et passim).

On the boundaries of oral and written composition

We shall return later to these preliminary remarks. It is time now to turn to the problem of literacy and illiteracy, i. e. to questions which are related to oral and written composition, transmission and their

reciprocal influences. This aspect appears to be broad enough and of central significance to both works. As far as we can tell, it has been discussed in greater detail for the *Nibelungenlied* than for the Finnish-Karelian realm. The first decisive impulses came from the American "Theory of Oral Composition" school, which has since become history with many of its theories, significant and fruitful history at that. The fact that the *Kalevala* came into being 'at the writing desk' can no more be called into question than the oral tradition of the lays which comprise its material. The collectors, and Lönnrot with them, were the first to record in their oilcloth-covered booklets the content, form and technique that had been passed on by oral tradition for century after century in the villages and generations.

However, in the eyes of its creator and its age, the epic never achieved full literacy and full "book quality" as a component of a history of literature; nor did it want to do so. An external manifestation of this can be found in the fact that Lönnrot's name does not appear on the title page of either edition, and the anonymity of popular poetry is adopted. As a collector, too, Lönnrot revealed great indifference towards his informants. In his notes he makes little effort to lift the veil of anonymity of the oral singer by means of scientific research. On various occasions he emphasized that he himself should be equated with the singers of the oral tradition. Thus he writes in 1849, for instance, with respect to the arrangement of the lays:

Finally, when none of the singers could compete with me on the amount of lays I had collected I thought of having the same right that most singers allow themselves, namely the right to organize the lays in the way they best fitted each other, or to express it as in a poem: 'itse loimme loitsijaksi, laikahtime laulajaksi', in other words, I thought of myself as a singer, a singer just as good as they themselves (af Forselles 1908: 220).

Lönnrot claimed the same rights for his memory as the singers themselves. That he had achieved this through literacy did not appear to him to make any decisive difference.

The collectors who moved to Karelia after 1835, whether learned or not, also did not consider providing the Kalevala with the character of a work with fixed contours or textual stability. The work was conceived of in principle as an "open form". There are numerous remarks indicating that the collectors went to Archangel Karelia in order to find "additions" to the epic. Lönnrot himself gave this conception its legitimacy in the new edition of 1849 by integrating into the work a great deal of new textual material.

The orality of the Karelian singer, i. e. the composing of the lays by the means of oral composition, is inextricably bound to the particular structure of the memory of the illiterate. The isolation from the world as experienced by the Karelian farmers and fishers, but also by the merchants and beggars, helped to preserve illiteracy in their highly inaccessible villages into our own century. It would, however, appear to be worthwhile, in the face of such an apparently straightforward division, to take a coherent look at mixed phenomena. This has, it would appear, never been done before. What we are concerned with here are two phenomena and observations: that the rule of the correlation between the quality of the oral poetry and illiteracy does not apply without exception and that the literacy of the Kalevala can have a retroactive effect on the composition of oral poetry.

The most significant exception to this rule was without doubt around the middle of last century Simana Sissonen from Mekrijärvi in the parish of Ilomantsi (Virtaranta et al. 1968: 138 sqq. [Lehtipuro]; not mentioned by Haavio 1948). He was one of the great epic singers whose versions of the lays had a significant influence on the composition of the New Kalevala. His ability to read was connected with the particular situation of Ilomantsi in Finland, where Russian Orthodox and Lutherans lived side by side, where the first people who could read could be found as early as the 17th century, and where the first schools were built in the 1870s. In the circumstances, it is no great surprise that a mere ten years later the epic lay was already dying out there. In Simana's lays, reflections of the written

tradition and also a few verses from Matias Salamnius' Messianic poem "Ilo-Laulu Jesuxesta" from 1690 can be found. As it was composed in the metre of the Kalevala, it is impossible to say with any certainty whether Simana became familiar with the oral or written form of the work, which was frequently printed and which comprises over 2000 verses. Examinations of his lays, which were recorded by several collectors, revealed an above-average fondness for variation, and this will be connected with his literacy.

Simana Sissonen was the greatest of the literate singers, but he was not the only one. Jyrki Malinen from Vuonninen could read, as could Vatsuni Iivana from the parish of Latvajärvi, Jaakko Huovinen in Hietajärvi, Juhana Puhakka in Ilomantsi, a Lutheran, and many others. (Virtaranta et al. 1968: 54, 90, 98, 144 [Vento, Ilomäki, Virtaranta, Lehtipuro]; cf. Helmi Virtaranta 1975: 18, 19, 66.) Although the information which has been handed down to us is not sufficient for proof positive, it would presumably be an accurate differentiation to say that all those mentioned above were capable of passive reading perception but not of active written production. It is a well-known phenomenon from the Middle Ages in Europe that many people, starting with Charlemagne, were well versed in reading but less in writing.

The singer had two possible ways of receiving Lönnrot's epic: in aural or in written form. As far as we can see, the first was used more frequently. For any singer who was skilled in learning through hearing, this must have been the most natural thing to do. Oral recitation from the written text and reception with the organ which the illiterate was accustomed to using, is the classical form of mediation in symbiotic cultures such as the Middle Ages in Europe. The attempt by Lönnrot's friend, J. F. Cajan, to stimulate the Karelian singer to sing by reading to him from the Kalevala, appears to be extremely immediate (Virtaranta et al. 1968: 50). An interesting case in this context is that of Vihtoori Lesoni from Vuokkiniemi, who sang verses to the collector in 1894; the latter —

it was Karjalainen — was delighted at the coherence and quality of these verses, until he later discovered that they came from the Kalevala itself (Virtaranta et al. 1968: 72). Vihtoori was illiterate and learned these verses aurally — and it is worth mentioning here that this is a good argument against the claim by orthodox followers of the oral tradition school that the singers built up their repertoire of songs solely on the basis of formulaic learning. Similarly, Jeremei Bogdanoff from Kivijärvi sang material that he had learned from the epic (Kaukonen 1979: 123), and Palaga Melentšev from Akonlahti acknowledged to Väinö Kaukonen that she herself had read some of the Kalevala (Kaukonen 1979: 111).

There was, then, in individual cases, a retroactive effect of the epic on the lay. A number of mixed forms can be discerned. To what extent the difference between reciting and singing the text also played a role in this context, cannot be reconstructed on the basis of the scanty information passed on by the collectors, for whom this aspect was of no relevance. There were, however, degrees of legitimacy and authority which were, one would imagine, ultimately connected with the original function of the epic lays. The impression of such a classification was given by the famous singer Anni Tenisova from Vuokinsalmi, who was unable to recite the text which she could sing magnificently (Kaukonen 1979: 104).

Epics on the borders of cultures

Lönnrot introduced himself at the beginning (I: 1—102) and at the end (L: 513—620) of his epic in the role of the rune-singer in so-called “Sängerverse”, which were rich in allusion to his own age. By doing so, he integrated the technique of the lay into the epic. Around the year 1200, another master adopted precisely the same approach. The

Nibelungs epic, probably written at the Court of the Bishop of Passau, begins with the strophe:

Uns ist in alten mæren wonders vil geseit
 von helden lobebæren, von grôzer arebeit,
 von frôuden, hôchgezîten, von weinen und von klagen,
 von küener recken strîten muget ir nu wunder hœren sagen.
 (Bartsch 1972: 3.)

That is:

We have been told in ancient tales many marvels of famous heroes, of mighty toil, joys, and high festivities, of weeping and wailing, and the fighting of bold warriors — of such things you can now hear wonders unending! (English translation by A. T. Hatto.)

A strophe which might have been made to measure for oral recitation in front of a crowd of eager listeners: the reference to the validity of ancient tradition, the *uns*, which unites the singer and his audience, the announcement of what awaits his listeners, the direct address of the audience (*ir*), with the repetition of the word *wunder* arousing curiosity almost in the manner of contemporary advertising. However, the strophe has a fault in the metrification, it is not old, and therefore we do not know here whether it was itself part of the ancient tradition and became defective or whether it was not the case here that a Middle High German Lönrot used the technique of the introduction to the lay for the introduction to an epic in large-scale book form.

The story of Siegfried, of his wooing of Kriemhild, his assistance in the wooing of Brunhild, of the quarrel between the two queens and the murder of the hero at the hands of Hagen, and then of Kriemhild's second marriage to the King of the Huns, Etzel (Attila), and the bloody revenge she takes on Siegfried's murderer and his accomplices, her brothers — this was all handed down orally in lays for more than half a millenium before it found its way onto parchment. It was passed on as a piece of ancient historical tradition, and this was evidently considered worthy of remembrance not only by those Germanic tribes involved

in the action of the epic; for, in several waves, lays and chronicles also reached the north of Europe, where the inhabitants could have at best only vague conceptions of Worms, the Danube and the Court of the Huns. The Sigurd lays of the Edda and the Völsunga saga are evidence of this shift; and here, too, it was on the periphery and in isolation that the oral epic poetry managed to survive best: on the Faroes, the old legend was sung and stamped out in songs of epic proportions till the middle of the 20th century.

In Germany, the saga appeared on parchment in the Hohenstaufen period, around 1200 — in the form of the *Nibelungenlied* itself, and we shall concentrate on this historical moment as it appears to us to be significant from a typological point of view. It enables us — leaving aside all the obvious cultural and social differences — to cast a comparative glance at the point of time in which Lönnrot's *Kalevala* was created — as a piece of simultaneity of phenomena which were not simultaneous and as a contribution to Bowra's considerations of how forms of retrospective reference to the heroic age appear to be subject to cultural and historical laws (Bowra 1964: 73 sqq.).

The genesis of the *Nibelungenlied* has its origin in the fact that the old boundaries between two symbiotic cultures have become problematic and crisis-ridden. It is necessary to simplify here for the sake of clarity: one of the two cultures is that of the established, prestigious, clerical Latin literacy, which had helped the cultural realms of classical Antiquity and the content of the early Christian Middle Ages to develop into a world-embracing mediaeval Latin culture in its own right; the other is the vernacular culture with its unique form of historical remembrance and of Christian teaching, which was used for specific, illustrative functions, not bound to the written word, not socially determined, but characterized by the absence of a Latin education. The division of social functions between a written and an oral culture had functioned extremely well for centuries; the exigencies of matters of the State, the Church and public life had brought about a gradual shift towards literacy since the ninth century. Political events in the 11th and 12th centuries helped part of the illiterate stratum of the population

to obtain a new sense of social awareness. With it the laity conquered new cultural fields and founded a new, unique literature, in which it expressed its own ideas and identity. The prerequisite for this new literature with the large scale epic form of the metrical romance was an alliance between the illiterate knights and the literate clerics. The results of this were the Arthurian romance, the Minnesang and the heroic poetry of the Nibelungenlied. The new, written form of composition allowed the poet to achieve a degree of reflection which had been hitherto unattainable for the illiterate (cf. Bäuml 1972, 1980; Fromm 1974; Curschmann 1979, 1984; Wachinger 1981).

At the same time, the Nibelungenlied maintained its unique position. It extended the traditional technique of the oral lay to an artificial, literary orality, to conscious archaism. There is no documentary evidence of the name of the man who ventured to take this step. The anonymity of the epic must be understood as an expression of the poet's intention to pay his dues to the convention of the collective anonymity of oral composition (Höfler 1955). The society of his age, to whom the poet's name could not possibly have remained a secret, evidently understood and respected this.

In addition, the epic never achieved the final, closed form of a literary work. There are extant manuscripts from as early as the 13th century which reveal considerable differences in the forms of the texts: these are dubbed "versions" by some philologists, and "adaptations" by others. Here philological analysis reached its limits, and it was not possible to come up with an "original". Written versions of the epic which are no longer extant influenced one another. Moreover, the oral tradition, which did not, of course, cease to exist with the completion of the first written version, also exercised an influence on the written form of the text; similarly, the practice of oral declamation, in turn, could not remain unaffected by the written form of the text, which was steeped in prestige (Brackert 1963: 164 sqq.; Neumann 1967: 35–59).

For both forms concurred in their function: the written epic was not only destined for the homo litteratus to read to himself (aloud or silently), but was also intended to be recited orally in public, undoubted-

ly in front of a large audience — the inhabitants of a castle, those who frequented a large market, or on comparable occasions. The audience would then be composed of litterati and illitterati and all the forms in between which were brought about by the symbiosis. Most extant manuscripts are not the manuscripts which were made to be used; on the contrary, they were commissioned so that they could be owned, to decorate the bookshelves, as we would say nowadays.

Many philologists and historians of music have come to the conclusion today that the epic, too, just as had been the case with the lays, must have been sung rather than recited. Since both the text and the musical notation have on no occasions been handed down together, this assumption is based on inferences from complicated circumstantial evidence which cannot be reconstructed in detail here (cf. Jammers 1957; Bertau—Stephan 1956/57; Brunner 1979). One question which does seem worthy of further consideration is whether the practice of singing can also be taken to have been used for the epic in large-scale book form around 1200, or whether there is not conceivably a difference in the form of declamation between the hypothetical intermediate form of the large-scale epic lay, which might also be called a short epic, and the large-scale epic proper. The fact that the strophe of the *Nibelungenlied* can be found as a sung metric form in the earliest *Minnesang* around the middle of the 12th century (the *Kürenberg strophe*), supports only the existence of a stage of evolution of which we do not know whether it was dependent on writing. It is possible that the large-scale epic merely occasionally hinted at the sung recitation here and there as a sign of its own literary position.

We must break off here, because we are aware of the dangers of attempting to compare incommensurable phenomena with only limited possibilities for differentiation. Thus we shall also take care to avoid emphasizing further the analogies which have become visible. We believe, however, that both the historical moment of the appearance of the *Nibelungenlied* in around 1200 and that of the Finnish world of *Lönnrot's Kalevala* can usefully be described from the point of view of the problematization of the symbiosis of two cultural and functional

realms with their varying degrees of participation in the phenomenon of literacy. The way in which Lönnrot, with his knowledge of non-literary traditions and his conception of his own role, enters the world of literacy, which appears to be the preserve of a self-assured Swedish-language literature, has typological significance. In the light of this aspect, a well-known incident takes on symbolic character: at a session of the newly founded Finnish Literature Society, the keeper of the minutes, Elias Lönnrot, had to admit, somewhat taken aback, that there was no Finnish word for the concept “literature”, and without much deliberation he formed the word which has since become a permanent fixture in the Finnish vocabulary: *kirjallisuus*, literally “bookishness” (Anttila 1931, I: 133–134, 138). This was in the years when Lönnrot, on his travels to collect lays among the singers in Karelia, observed the phenomenon of the formation of cycles, and his plan to compose an epic began to take shape.

The role of the narrator in the epics

With a few concluding considerations at least, we shall enter the two epics, the texts themselves — again from the viewpoint of oral and written composition or literacy and illiteracy.

For the reader of today it is almost moving to observe how Lönnrot, in his commentaries on the *Kalevala*, drafted a clear picture of the main figures in the epic, how he thought that he knew what sort of virtues and weaknesses they had (Fromm 1967: 36, 123, 236 et al. loc.). For us it is the very opposite that is significant. The Homeric heroes, Hagen, Gunther or Siegfried, Guðrún or Völundr, indeed even Gilgamesh or Enkidu, are more clearly delineated than Väinämöinen or Kullervo, Lemminkäinen or Ilmarinen. The latter are surrounded by a fleeting and intangible, indistinct and unreal aura. At most, one could talk of

epic roles, only with reservations of figures, and certainly not of persons or characters.

This is a heritage of the oral composition of the lay. Lönnrot often tried to temper this; he endeavoured to create coherence, and, in the truest sense of the word, humanity, in the epic. Faithful as he was to tradition, he met with only limited success. The basic impression has survived in the epic, too. The original function of the lay, its ritual character, shines through; the epic figure, that is to say its name, the result or the bestowal of its function. And with this definition it is in accord with the formula-like stereotype with which the figure and its actions are merely stated rather than described.

It is a commonly held view that poets who compose their works orally take pains to animate the relationship between themselves, their subjects and their audience. Evidence of this is said to be found in addresses to the audience, anticipations and the like. The first strophe of the *Nibelungenlied* cited above can serve as an example of this. But this is only one side of the coin; for as a rule what is lacking in oral literature is what literary theory calls the narrator. The poet who composes his work orally feels justified only to a very limited extent in playing the role of the narrator in his story. The narrator reflects, controls, interprets and mediates; he is the master of a stratum which is elevated above the events and to which the listener feels a closer affinity than to the events themselves. As so often, Lönnrot revealed a fine instinct when he refused to have such a narrative stratum in his epic. The process of ordering and interpreting the material took place before the work, and in the text it is invisible. Poetry of the oral tradition is impersonal and without an atmosphere of gregariousness, and its creations bear witness to this.

It is a different story in the *Nibelungenlied*. Its archaism, the heroic magnificence and the formalized simplicity are not, as already indicated, evidence of preserved, but the result of stylized oral composition. The linguistic technique and the block-like construction of the lay are turned into the conscious stylistic technique and the carefully planned structural form of the epic. The man who was capable of composing this after

careful, conscious reflection, was at home in both traditions. There is a great deal of evidence to indicate that the oral lay continued to exist side by side with the book; this only became known from 16th century printings, but also in the minstrel poet-singers such as der Marner in the first half of the 13th century, who in one strophe praises his repertoire, in which material from the *Nibelungenlied* can be found. The 179 strophes of the lay “Vom Hürnen Seyfrid” still clearly reveal the influence of the written epic.

If one wishes to venture a comparison, using the *Kalevala* as a starting point, to make clear to oneself the transition from the oral composition of epic lays to a new stage of reflective consciousness via literacy, one is tempted to think of the Helka lays of Eino Leino, in which the second wave of Finnish national Romanticism took hold of the Karelian epic lay.

In the *Nibelungenlied* there is also the narrator (Linke 1960). It is not easy to determine his peculiarity. It is not true, as some interpreters have suggested (Mergell 1950: 310; Pörksen 1971: 211 sqq.), that he disappears completely behind the narrative and the figures of the epic. This claim is based on general considerations. On the contrary, the narrator's voice can be heard quite frequently. In the final lines of the strophes, his presence can be felt as he anticipates what is going to happen, as in, for example, strophe 138, 4: *dâ von im sît vil liebe und ouch vil leide gescach* — who was to bring him (Siegfried) much joy and yet much sorrow, too (transl. A. T. Hatto). In many ironic refractions the narrator preserves his own stratum. He is, as can be seen in his anticipations of what is going to happen, omniscient, but not auctorial. The ranking and peculiarity of the epic are revealed in his very attitude to himself and his knowledge. He does not question the world of facts, the visible surface level of events; his figures have hopes and fears, experience sadness and joy, but he does not present the action as a transparent interplay of inner and outer worlds; his motivating psychology is bound to the situation. His psychology is actually the function which describes the relationships which exist between the individual figures (Wachinger 1960: 143 sqq.). The latter are defined by the

uniqueness and unalterability of the relationships. The narrator limits his perspective to the figures' next tasks, no matter how well he himself might be able to overview the whole. These figures do not possess what the people of today call man's inner freedom, and what also becomes visible in the time of the poet of the *Nibelungenlied* himself, for instance in the peculiar serenity of the finder of the Graal, Parzival. The introductory strophe of the *Nibelungenlied* cited above is correct in its additive announcement of events: *weinen und klagen* itself is only the interior membrane of the exterior world.

The examination of the role of the narrator in the *Kalevala* and in the *Nibelungenlied* epic has revealed a significant contrast. Indeed, contrasts and analogies, as could be observed from the point of view of symbioses of traditions, are methodologically speaking, the most useful conceptual tools for obtaining insights. Drawing parallels between synchronic processes within the reception, on the other hand, can provide sufficient information only about the latter, not about the poetic works and their typological characteristics.

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Derick Thomson

Macpherson's Ossian: Ballad Origins and Epic Ambitions

Aberdeen in the 1750's was quite a small town though it had the curious distinction of having two universities, King's College and Marischal College. Scotland itself was a small country, which had recently lost parliamentary control of its own affairs, in 1707. The Highlands had recently suffered from the political and military restraints and oppressions that followed the Jacobite Risings of 1715 and 1745, and were soon to experience commercial and socio-political exploitation, as incomers developed sheep farming and deer forests, and the native leaders encouraged the emigration of their clansmen.

Literary ambition is not bound and determined by external circumstances, though they may have a share in shaping it. We may surmise that James Macpherson had a strong urge to recapture what he saw as the lost glory of his native land, and to secure for himself an honoured place in its literary history. As a very young man he thought he saw a promising prospect for these twin aims.

He had been a student at both of Aberdeen's universities, and his attainment in the classics was evidently respectable. He seems to have studied briefly at the University of Edinburgh also. He was brought up in Badenoch, close to the site of the Hanoverian barracks at Ruthven, barracks that were established to tame the Jacobite insurgents. Both at Aberdeen and at Edinburgh he would be aware of rising literary reputations (James Beattie, David Hume, Adam Ferguson, Hugh Blair, John Home), and he soon made literary acquaintances and friends. He spoke Gaelic, and so had some access to another literary tradition.

The 18th century had seen a strong revival of antiquarian and historical interest in Scotland. An interest in the origin and theory of

epic was also in the air of his times. The motivation was there, so it might seem, for the creation of a new Scottish epic; it turned out that there were ingredients available also.

The events that led to James Macpherson's Ossianic publications, and the sequence of these, can be quickly summarised, and once we have established that basic profile we can look in some detail at a number of matters that arise, including the Gaelic literary material and tradition to which Macpherson related, and the theory of epic with which he was familiar.

The Highlander, Fragments, Fingal and Temora

After his university career (1752 — c. 1756) Macpherson taught briefly in the Charity School at Ruthven, his home district, but by 1758 was employed as a tutor in Edinburgh. In that year he published a long poem entitled *The Highlander*. In October 1759 we have record of Macpherson being in the Border town of Moffat, with a pupil whom he was tutoring, and there he met the popular dramatist John Home. In the course of literary conversation Macpherson referred to several pieces of ancient Gaelic poetry he had in his possession, and was persuaded to read translations of some of these. Home was greatly taken with the translations, and soon afterwards showed them to Dr. Hugh Blair and other friends in Edinburgh, and later in the year to friends in London, "where they were equally admired".

Macpherson was soon introduced to Blair in Edinburgh, and with his and other people's encouragement published the *Fragments of Ancient Poetry* collected in the Highlands early in 1760. Its reception was somewhat remarkable. The *Scots Magazine* for June 1760 gave over practically the whole review section to printing extracts, and in the July issue extracts and verse adaptations from the *Fragments* have pride of place in the Poetry section. By April, 1760, the poet Thomas

Gray was writing to Walpole about "advance copies" he had received of two of the "fragments", saying "I am so charmed with the two specimens of Erse (i. e. Gaelic) poetry that I cannot help giving you the trouble to enquire a little further about them" (Toynbee — Whibley 1935: Letter 310) and he wrote later to Thomas Warton of "their infinite beauty", saying of Macpherson: "this Man is the very Demon of Poetry, or he has lighted on a treasure hid for ages" (Toynbee — Whibley 1935, II: 679—680).

Such public interest, much of it friendly and adulatory, encouraged both Macpherson and his Edinburgh friends, especially Hugh Blair, who arranged a dinner to encourage Macpherson to search for further Gaelic poems, including the epic at whose existence he had hinted in the published *Fragments* (Preface, V, VII, VIII). With this encouragement, and with funds raised to meet his expenses, he set out in August 1760, on a six-week trip, and undertook a second one between late October 1760 and early January 1761. In the course of these trips he visited Perthshire, Argyllshire, Inverness-shire, and the islands of Skye, North and South Uist, Benbecula and Mull. A good deal of evidence survives of these expeditions, so that we know many of his contacts and something of his working methods, both then and in Edinburgh where he worked over his materials. This work took up a good deal of time in the first half of 1761, and by early December of that year the first edition of the epic *Fingal* had been published, both in London and in Edinburgh, and early notices had begun to appear. Already in December 1761 its epic claims were being debated, and the debate continued, in Scottish and English magazines, throughout much of 1762. *Fingal* had already gone into a second edition by January 1762. Published along with *Fingal* were a number of shorter poems.

Shortly afterwards we can say, perhaps a little cynically, that the Ossianic industry began, with a long succession of dissertations, accusations, rejoinders, parodies, translation, editions, illustrations, and with various by-products such as dramas, operas and other musical works, in a succession which has now lasted over 220 years, with such latter-day items as the Japanese translation first published in 1971 (with a

second edition later that year) and the new Russian translation published in 1983.

By late 1763, when Macpherson's second Ossianic epic *Temora* was published, (a short version had already appeared along with *Fingal*) domestic interest was beginning to cool, and relatively little contemporary critical comment appeared. Macpherson may have read these signs accurately, for he was on the point of embarking on his next career, in politics and colonial exploitation. His pre-occupation with Ossian had lasted, on and off, for four or five years, and he was now aged twenty-seven.

The tradition found by Macpherson

Macpherson had claimed that his *Poems of Ossian*, to give his work the title that had firmly emerged by the early 1770's, were translations of the work of Gaelic bards of very early times, the 3rd century A. D. being mentioned specifically. A basis in Gaelic poetry was usually assumed, even by his adverse critics, but the nature of that basis was vague and uncertain. The age of his originals was frequently challenged, and this sometimes led to rash and uninformed statements such as that of Dr. Samuel Johnson that there was no Gaelic MS in existence more than a hundred years old.

From the more deeply informed standpoint of modern scholarship we can achieve a balanced perspective on these questions, distinguishing carefully between our modern understanding and what was likely to have been James Macpherson's understanding.

That there has existed, for many centuries, a large body of Gaelic balladry on the kind of themes used by Macpherson, is beyond question. Some of these ballads were ascribed to Ossian and to his contemporaries in the heroic age in which the action of the poetry is set. Such balladry was popular and widespread in Macpherson's time, and he had probably encountered it in his native district of Badenoch.

It is probable, however, that a specific interest in it was first aroused by the publication of a translation of a Gaelic heroic ballad in the *Scots Magazine* in 1756. This was the *Lay of Fraoch*, the ballad version of an ancient story (not in fact belonging to the Ossianic cycle) which also exists as a prose saga. The saga probably dates from the eighth century, and the ballad from the 14th century (Meid 1967: xxv), but the version translated in the *Scots Magazine* had been recently collected by Jerome Stone who was a schoolmaster in Dunkeld and died in 1757. From late 1758 to 1760 James Macpherson was tutor in the family of Graham of Balgowan (Fenton & Palsson 1984), near Dunkeld, and he visited with his pupil the Manse of Logierait in 1759, probably meeting Adam Ferguson, the son of the manse, there. Ferguson had apparently made some collection of Ossianic ballads in the 1740's, and in the 1750's a very important collector began work in the same Perthshire parish. This was James McLagan, from Ballechin, some eight miles from Dunkeld; he collected close on 10,000 lines (including many variants) of heroic Ossianic balladry. McLagan was ordained by the Presbytery of Dunkeld in 1760, and in 1760–61 we find Macpherson corresponding with him, and acknowledging the receipt of specific ballads from him (Report, 1805: App. 153). In the case of several other assiduous collectors of ballads in the eighteenth century (see Campbell 1872), some were directly inspired by the Ossianic controversy, and some had begun to collect before Macpherson published. In a few cases collections are distinctly older than Macpherson's time, as is the case with the Rev. Alexander Pope's 756 lines (collected about 1739), the *Ardchonaill MS*, dated 1690, and the *Book of the Dean of Lismore*, dating from the early decades of the 16th century.

The most important of all these collections is the *Dean of Lismore's*. His collection of heroic verse runs to over 2,600 lines, and is the earliest Scottish anthology of Gaelic heroic verse, although it forms part of a general anthology. The evidence points strongly to the conclusion that this MS came into James Macpherson's hands in 1760 (Mackintosh 1947: 11–20, and Malcolm Macpherson's *Affidavit*, Report 1805: App. 92–94), and we may owe its ultimate preservation to him. There is a subsequent view, that Macpherson acquired the *Dean's MS* from

Fraser of Boleskine (Thomson 1987: 254). The Dean's MS is written in the "secretary hand" of its time, and he used an eccentric system of orthography — eccentric for Gaelic at least — which has posed many problems for later editors. Macpherson could not be faulted for failing to read this MS with any fluency, but both he and his advisers could have understood enough to see that the MS contained a good range of heroic poems. He may even have believed that it contained a heroic epic, or sequence of poems on an epic theme, and the impossibility of deciphering all this may have led him to rely instead on his own resources. But it is much more probable that he had already postulated an epic before he saw this "evidence" through a glass darkly.

In the longer perspective, however, the Dean's collection of heroic ballads is a relatively late item. Many of the individual ballads in the Dean's book had been naturalized, even localized, in Scotland, and a few had evidently been composed in Scotland, but a greater number belonged to the common Scottish/Irish tradition and had originated in Ireland. The late Gerard Murphy established a basic chronology for these earlier ballads, suggesting composition of some fourteen ballads in the 12th century or thereby, some twenty-three in the 13th century, 10 in the 14th, 17 in the 15th, and 6 in the 16th (Murphy 1953: 96–97). Furthermore, some of the themes and motifs in these ballads have a history which was already ancient by the 12th century, and some of these may indeed go back to the very early Christian centuries if not beyond. On the other hand, one of the ballads in the Dean's book is ascribed, credibly enough, to a known Scottish poet of the late 15th century, and there may well have been later Scottish ballads than that.

The sources of the Poems of Ossian

What we are dealing with, and what Macpherson stumbled upon, is an ancient, widespread and long-lasting literary tradition which has its roots in myth and legend, was strongly cultivated by people who

belonged to the professional literary orders, and ultimately came to be perpetuated as part of popular, and eventually non-literate, culture.

The myth and legend was concerned with such heroes as Find/Fionn (Macpherson's Fingal), Oscar, Oisín/Oiseán (Macpherson's Ossian), Caoilte, Goll and many others, who are represented as belonging to a warrior-and-hunting élite which has uneasy relations with the representatives of the new (Christian) faith, and at a later stage of history becomes involved in resistance to the new invaders (the Vikings). The ballads have a wide spectrum of themes: battles, wars, hunting expeditions, romantic entanglements, elopement, treachery and intrigue, the reconciliation of opposing systems (e. g. the heroic/pagan and the Christian). They sometimes accommodate subsidiary and parenthetical themes such as nature observation and description or legends about place-names. They have a reasonably coherent overall structure, into which we can fit a few generations of heroes, rival family and power structures, and various external enemies. The basis of most of this is Early Gaelic/Irish myth, legend and history, much of it being regarded as part of the normal Scottish Gaelic inheritance.

In course of time, certain aspects of these ballad themes achieved special prominence in Scotland, among them the theme of resistance to Viking invasion. James Macpherson may have become aware of this aspect of the ballad tradition, and his interest in it was reinforced by his other reading and by his natural inclination to give Scotland a more prominent role in this verse tradition.

The outlines of Macpherson's adaptation of his ballad sources, and their incorporation in his larger scheme, are clear to us, as they were not to his contemporaries. This adaptation follows an interesting progression from the *Fragments* of 1760 to *Temora* in 1763. In the *Fragments*, several of the items can be linked with Gaelic ballads, although none is a close translation. Thus Fragment 6, later in *Fingal* to be identified with the "Maid of Craca", is based on two Gaelic ballads, *Cath Rìgh na Sorch*a and *An Ionmhuinn*. Fragments 6, 7 and 8 refer to the theme of the Death of Oscar ballad, used more fully in Book 1 of *Temora*. Fragment 14 is partly based on the *Garbh mac Stairn*

ballads, in origin referring to early Irish invasion legends. Fragment 15 has no Gaelic original, but was to be used again in *Fingal*.

When we come to *Fingal*, which was put together after Macpherson's collecting trips of 1760–61, there is a wider-ranging and more detailed use of Gaelic ballad sources. He uses two ballads, those of Garbh mac Stairn and of Mànus, to provide the main outlines of the plot, and another three (*Fingal's* visit to Norway, *The Lay of the Maiden* and *Ossian's* courtship) for the main episodes. Then he uses three or four other ballads in a more restricted way, e. g. *The Praise of Goll* as a stylistic model for Ullin's war-song, addressed to Gaul in Book IV of *Fingal*, or *Sliabh nam Ban Fionn* to provide some names and other details in a brief hunting scene in Book VI.

There is similar evidence of the use of Gaelic sources in the shorter poems that were added to the two epics to make up the *Poems of Ossian*. *The Battle of Lora* is unusually faithful to its ballad original *Teanntachd mhór na Féinne*. In this instance we know that Macpherson got a version of the ballad from the Rev. James McLagan, but it is clear that he used other versions as well (Thomson 1952: 47). In "Carthon" he handles his source, the *Conlaoch* ballads, more distantly, and in "Carric-Thura" the *Spirit of Loda* probably owes part of its character to the Gaelic hag known as the *Muilgheartach*. The story of *Deirdre* lies behind that of "Darthula", and the ballads of *Dearg* and *Conn mac an Deirg* are somewhat obscurely in the background of *Calthon* and *Colmal*.

Ossian's "translator's" ambitions

From all this we can see that Macpherson had collected and studied a good range of Gaelic ballads, and had used variant versions of some, and probably many, of these. A close analysis of the use he made of these sources shows that he often misunderstood some of the linguistic

detail, or guessed at the meaning of obscure words and phrases. It shows too that he manipulated plot detail to suit his own purposes, used different aspects of Gaelic ballads in separate parts of his work, that he Scotticized or Anglicized nomenclature, and sometimes constructed names from familiar Gaelic elements. It is in *Fingal* that he leans most heavily on his Gaelic sources, but after Book I of *Temora* he more or less floats free of them. None of this would be regarded as unusual or reprehensible in an acknowledged work of the imagination, but Macpherson had got boxed in to a situation in which he had assumed the character of translator, and this was what gave him his initial hearing. It was therefore impossible to abandon this stance, though there are occasional hints of his wish to do so.

Although both the epics, but especially *Temora*, lack clarity and firmness of plot structure, there can be no doubt that Macpherson built them on a carefully considered historical plan. His earlier epic, *The Highlander*, was concerned with a war between the Scots and the Danes, and by the time he came to write *Fingal* and *Temora* he had become more closely acquainted with the Gaelic ballads on Viking themes, a range of ballads which are more fully developed in Scottish than in Irish tradition. He proceeded to take this development much further, giving Scotland rather than Ireland the leading role in the whole Ossianic context. This involved a repudiation of Irish historical claims. Long after Macpherson's time it has been shown that a school of medieval pseudo-historians in Ireland constructed an elaborate scheme of Irish history for the early centuries of the Christian era. This scheme placed the Ossianic heroes in the 3rd century A. D., and used the fable of Ossian's survival to an extreme old age to bring him into contact with the later St. Patrick. Macpherson repeatedly pours scorn on this scheme of Irish history, and proceeds to put an equally fantastic one in its place, which give precedence to Scotland. He constructs his new scheme in his introductions and notes, producing an ingenious fabric of deception, half-truth and innuendo.

In this way he sought to glorify Scotland, and in particular the Highlands, which were admittedly in need of moral and psychological

boosting at the time. This may also have been his aim in attempting to create epics claiming Gaelic origins, although here again we can see that interplay of patriotic motives and personal vanity and ambition that are so characteristic of his early work.

Epic theories' contribution

The background to Macpherson's epic ambitions is fairly clearly delineated. Milton's epics had given a fresh impetus to the study of the form, as had Pope's translations of the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* in 1720 and 1726 respectively, while in 1726 also Voltaire had published his essay on poetic epic (*Essai sur la poesie epique de toutes les nations*). Probably Macpherson's interest in epic theory was first stimulated by Thomas Blackwell, who was one of his teachers at the University of Aberdeen, and whose *Enquiry into the Life and Writings of Homer* was published in 1735. Josef Bysveen, in his recent study *Epic Tradition and Innovation in James Macpherson's Fingal* underlines both Blackwell's and Macpherson's insistence on the importance of the heroic spirit, and the marvellous, for epic, and suggests that Macpherson was, as it were, putting Blackwell's theory into practice when he "contrived a plan for *Fingal* into which he fitted the heroic age of the Noble Savage. In this age man is directly dependent upon the environment for survival. In Blackwell's theory this element is an incentive to heroic actions" (Bysveen 1982: 54). Macpherson had served his apprenticeship in writing *The Highlander*, and was able to have a fruitful collaboration with Hugh Blair in 1760–61. We can assume that both men contributed to the composition of the Preface to the *Fragment*s, as Blair long afterwards claimed (Report 1805: App. 57–58). Blair's late account at least makes it clear that they had frequent discussions while *Fingal* was being written:

When he returned to Edinburgh in winter, laden with his poetical treasures, he took lodgings in a house immediately below where I lived, at the head of Blackfriar's Wynd, and busied himself in

translating from the Gaelic into English. I saw him very frequently: he gave me accounts from time to time how he proceeded, and used frequently at dinner to read or repeat to me parts of what he had that day translated. (Report 1805: 59.)

Both Blair and Macpherson had another shared literary experience, the Authorized Version of the Bible, and no doubt they were familiar also with the work of William Lauder, who had fabricated so-called originals for *Paradise Lost*. They may also have used ideas about the Sublime and the Beautiful developed by William Hogarth and Edmund Burke in the 1750's.

When we compare the notes to *Fingal* with what Blair later published in his *Dissertations*, we can see their community of ideas. Blair continually makes comparisons with Homer and Virgil, while Macpherson in his notes quotes from the *Aeneid*, Dryden's translations from the Classics, and the *Iliad* (e. g. Macpherson 1762: 22, 23). Macpherson makes it clear that he is consciously setting his "translation" against the classical epics. Early in his Preface he says:

Several gentlemen in the Highlands and isles generously gave me all the assistance in their power; and it was by their means I was enabled to compleat the epic poem. How far it comes up to the rules of the epopoea, is the province of criticism to examine. It is only my business to lay it before the reader, as I have found it — — . (Macpherson 1762: 4.)

And his final footnote to the poem runs thus:

It is allowed by the best critics that an epic poem ought to end happily. This rule, in its most material circumstances, is observed by the three most deservedly celebrated poets, Homer, Virgil, and Milton; yet, I know not how it happens, the conclusions of their poems throw a melancholy damp on the mind. One leaves his reader at a funeral; another at the untimely death of a hero; and a third in the solitary scenes of an unpeopled world. (Macpherson 1762: 85.)

And he goes on to quote from Homer, Pope's translation, Virgil, Dryden's translation, and Milton. All this is a footnote to the last

paragraph of *Fingal*, which runs: "Spread the sail, said the king of Morve, and catch the winds that pour from Lena. — We rose on the wave with songs, and rushed, with joy, through the foam of the ocean". We may compare Blair's comment on the closing passage:

The conclusion of the poem is strictly according to rule; and is in every way noble and pleasing. The reconciliation of the contending heroes, the consolation of Cuthullin, and the general felicity that crowns the action, sooth the mind in a very agreeable manner, and form that passage from agitation and trouble, to perfect quiet and repose, which critics require as the proper termination of the Epic work. (Macpherson 1797: 214.)

These two men had combined, — however we allocate shares of involvement — to present a Scottish epic to the literary world. It was clearly intended that its scope and shape and style should bear comparison with the great epic achievements of other countries and times, and that its matter should conform to the theoretical expectations concerning epic with which Macpherson was familiar. There was a certain naiveté or disingenuousness about the type of circular argument that was used: epic requires such-and-such; the new work exhibits such features; the new work is therefore laudable epic. But the confidence and scale of the operation were impressive.

The Poems of Ossian and the Kalevala

In different circumstances the native Gaelic ballads might have had a quite different potential for literary elaboration, especially in their original language. As it happened, they did not achieve that particular culmination either in Scottish Gaelic or in Irish. When the Dean of Lismore, in the early 16th century, collected heroic ballads it was only as one category of syllabic verse. He seems to have taken such items

as they came to hand, and there is little close grouping of such ballads in his MS: we find items from p. 3 to p. 294, with at most three items closely grouped, out of a total of over two dozen heroic items. Duanaire Finn, the first specific collection of heroic ballads in Ireland, comes a century later, and it too is an ingathering of such matter, not an ordered or reshaped sequence. Nor was the sophisticated twelfth-century prose and verse compilation of Ossianic stories, *Acallam na Senórach*, cast in an epic mould.

The tendency in Scotland is to diminish or dismiss Macpherson's work as being flawed, not serious in intention, a discredited imposture. In part at least this attitude is a product of the Controversy, and it has been argued (see Saunders 1894: 185 ff. and Hook 1984) that some of the lines of the Controversy were drawn for political and ethnic reasons: because Macpherson early became identified in England with the hated Bute, fount of political patronage, and a symbol of Scottish nepotism. That Macpherson's work was an imposture cannot be denied, but it also had serious artistic intentions, and some at least of its achievement can be measured by its wide-ranging and pervasive influence, an influence that easily crossed linguistic and artistic borders, inspiring work in English, French, German and many other languages, and in music and art.

The comparison here with the influence of the *Kalevala* is striking, and there are a good many comparisons and contrasts between the work of Macpherson and Lönnrot that may be instructive. Both men had a classical educational background, and thus a degree of familiarity with classical epic which, as we saw, Macpherson was at some pains to develop. Both had access to an ancient verse tradition which belonged to a people who had been seriously overshadowed, in political and social terms, by neighbouring powers and different cultural traditions. Lönnrot was much more deeply immersed in that verse tradition than Macpherson was, and his involvement was a much longer one: with Macpherson's five years at most we can contrast Lönnrot's involvement for about thirty years, from the early 1820's to the publication of the second *Kalevala* in 1849. This latter difference helps in part to explain

the great contrast in method between the work of the two men: Lönnrot's detailed and pervasive use of the original sources which he fitted into his scheme and arrangement, but Macpherson's episodic and impressionistic culling from the ballads.

The origin of heroic verse tradition

By far the most interesting similarities would seem to lie in the existence of an old heroic and ballad tradition in both societies (taking now the Gaelic society of Scotland and Ireland as a continuum), and the movement of that verse tradition from a literate élite to an illiterate one. Behind the literate tradition in both cases there also lies an oral tradition which stretches back to the early centuries of the Christian era and no doubt beyond. As far as I can understand there was an important clerical involvement in the growth and dispersal of the Kalevala poetry, involving the Dominican order. Similarly we can read into some of the Gaelic ballads, and notably into the 12th century prose-and-verse *Acallam*, a monkish involvement, and we find this also in the construction of that Irish pseudo-history of the 11th and 12th centuries which is concerned among other things with devising a historical placing for the Ossianic heroes. A famous note appended to the list of tales in the 12th century Book of Leinster has been translated "he is no *fili* who does not harmonize and synchronize all the stories".

I do not think we understand adequately the processes by which the heroic verse tradition later passed into the keeping of the oral tradition. We may well assume a continued existence for elements of that heroic tradition in oral circulation over the last thousand years or more, but I think we cannot argue that the ballads had their specific origin in an oral context. They have, too clearly, the marks of literate composition whether we think of their metrical structure and literary vocabulary, or of the mental attitudes portrayed, including the attitudes to the

Church. And we have, perhaps incautiously admitted, ascriptions of authorship to historical poets, such as Ailein Mac Ruaidhri, and most notably Giolla Coluim Mac an Ollaimh, a late 15th century Scottish poet, and this may give us an important clue to the growth of the corpus of heroic ballads. The convention of not ascribing heroic poems to their authors seems to be more generally observed in Irish MSS — this is clearly the convention in *Duanaire Finn*. The answer to the question ‘How did the heroic ballads pass into the oral repertoire?’ may lie partly in the merging of the professional poetic dynasties with the general population (see Murphy 1953: 38 ff.), and partly in the gradual dilution and dispersal of this part of the literary tradition through the agency of the strolling bards and minstrels — the *Cliar Sheanchain* to use the term common in Ireland and Scotland for these companies which are still reported in Scottish Speyside in the late 17th century.

Whatever the answer is to that important question, it is clear that Macpherson had some sort of vision of the dispersed elements of an epic tradition, that he made a serious if hasty attempt to collect them, and to forge them into an epic structure. Perhaps that forging did not have the intricate beauty of the *Sampo*, but it left an indelible mark on the Europe of the 18th and 19th centuries.

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Result

Matti Kuusi

Epic Cycles as the Basis for the Kalevala

Julius Krohn, founder of the geographical-historical approach in folkloristics, was born in Viipuri on 19.5.1835. His chief work, “Suomalaisen kirjallisuuden historia. I. Kalevala” was completed in 1885. 150 and 100 years have lapsed since these two events, which is the reason why I intend to attack the problem of the development of the folk epic from Julius Krohn’s perspective.

Just as Elias Lönnrot was inspired by Homer’s example to compile the Kalevala, so Julius Krohn applied the models of Homeric research in examining the Kalevala. His classic work ends with the chapter “The birth of uniform heroic poetry in general”. Having summarised the concepts of Wolf, Lachmann, Nitzsch and Gautier, Krohn gave priority to the thesis proposed by Heymann Steinthal that uniform epics are folk poetry both in their material and in their overall conception. Although each poem was originally an individual creation, every listener can mould it as he wishes. Folk poetry is a process of continued poetic creation.

The evolution model of Krohn

In his article (1868: 11–12) Steinthal defined three basic forms for the epic: 1) the individual poem telling a particular myth or event and ruling out other poems, 2) the poetic cycle, telling a series of individual events about a particular hero, and 3) the epic crystallised into an

organic entity, such as Homer, the Nibelungenlied, the Song of Roland and the Kalevala.

Julius Krohn disputed Steintal's claim that there is as a rule no transition from one form to another in the folk epic, and that only "a total revolution in the entire poetic spirit of the people" may lead to the rejection of individual poems or cycles and the creation of a uniform epic. He wrote:

We Finns are extremely fortunate in that our people have managed to create one of the few uniform epics in the world; we are also fortunate in that the history of the birth of this epic has been preserved in our thousands of variants. Through them we alone have occasion and an opportunity to solve the question of the birth of uniform epics on real, indisputable grounds. (Krohn 1885: 579.)

Julius Krohn had formed his own theory on the basis of the theory of evolution: to begin with there was universally nothing but individual little songs but — contrary to Steintal's belief — it was precisely these songs that grew into broader entities, either so that the singer stretched out his song using motifs borrowed from other songs, or so that the songs became merged to form longer poems or miniature epics. An epic proper does not come into being until

there emerges from the wealth of legends and songs one that contains a heroic deed of such splendour and importance that it attracts the people's attention more than any other and wins a central position. For us the Sampo episode is one such deed; for this reason all other poems do their utmost to associate with it, even though they are still at a very different degree of association. It seems to have been the centre of a whirlpool swallowing up anything that came in reach of it with its irresistible force. (Krohn 1885: 581.)

Krohn stressed the almost blind mechanicalness of the process of evolution. Although the singer generally tends to reproduce a poem he has heard as such, imperfect memory and misconceptions hasten its development. Deeds and events originally belonging in another context

are attached to a central hero. The singer wishes to continue an impressive poem, and it is easy to find some element that logically fits the motif. Among the conservative singers there may sometimes be singers of exceptional talent with a gift for adding to the tradition.

Completely new songs were, Julius Krohn concluded in the manner of Steinthal, produced very seldom, “at moments of turmoil in the spirit of the people”. Such inspiring stages might, in his opinion, be the era in which the Finns migrated to Finland, later on participation in the founding of the Vargarian Empire and the Byzantine expeditions.

Krohn’s belief in evolution culminated in the assumption that, had the pressure from neighbouring peoples and modern civilisation not interrupted the entire “mechanical” process of poetic integration, the epic would, even without Lönnrot, have become increasingly uniform and complete.

The question of the epic of Sampo

In my doctoral thesis *Sampo-epos* (“The epic of the Sampo”) of 1949 I listed eleven theories put forward in Finland in reply to the question raised by the *Kalevala* and Julius Krohn: should the appearance of given heroic poems within broad epic entities be considered an original, a relatively early or a late phenomenon? It appeared that the proto-epic idea of the Romanticists was followed in the 19th century by the theories of composition of such men as Julius Krohn, then again in the 1910s by theories of the uniform epic, and finally again by composition theories. The development of folk tradition unquestionably displays both the merging of individual poems into cycles and the disintegration of entities, but which trend was more characteristic of the process of change around the birth of poems remained a matter of speculation. Perhaps both trends applied.

In my thesis I examined the 41.762 lines dealing with the Sampo and divided them into 33 redactions and 48 separate variants, which seemed to derive from three proto-redactions. Since they all appeared to contain motifs from five different ancient epics (on the origin of the world, the forging of the Sampo, the stealing of the Sampo, the wooing competitions and the golden bride), I ventured to conclude that at one time, at least in the “Finnish-Karelian” era, before the Treaty of Pähkinäsaari in 1323, the said poems already constituted an epic cycle that in Karelia subsequently developed into an established wooing epic and in Western Finland into two thematically-linked poetic episodes.

Not wishing to enter into an argument with a researcher 35 years my junior, I do contend that the most substantial source of error concerning the Sampo epic, so often criticised for the very volume of its material, is the narrowness of the material used for debate: only by extending our study to include the corresponding poetry of Ingria and Estonia, international motifs and schemes and other genres of folklore can we justify the drawing of generalising conclusions on the history and development of the Savo-Karelian epic. I have attempted to give a more precise picture in later studies and in my general account of oral literature in *Suomen kirjallisuus I* (“Finnish Literature I”).

I now wish to summarise the most important observations supporting the affinity between different poems on the Sampo theme.

At the heart of the epic describing the origin of the world is an international myth about an egg which, when broken, becomes heaven and earth, the sun, the moon and the stars. The Estonian, Ingrian and Karelian redactions are descended from a common root. Only in Karelia is there a prologue describing the birth of Väinämöinen, the way he is shot into the sea where, as he drifts, he fashions from the seabed islets and deep waters and raises his knee to provide a hummock or island, as a haven for a bird seeking a place to build its nest. In Russian Karelia the poem continues with the forging and stealing of the Sampo, whereas in Finnish Karelia the cosmogonic poem is usually a separate entity of its own.

The Väinämöinen redactions of Karelia are clearly of a later construction than their Estonian and Ingrian counterparts, in which the basic elements are merely the sea, a bird, a hummock in the sea and a gust of wind that blows the egg into the sea. There are, however, some interesting epic connections in the southern redactions, too.

In the cosmogonic poem of the Orthodox Ingrians a swallow, its eggs having been blown off the hummock into the sea by the wind, flies to a smith's and forges a rake with which it collects the fragments of egg from the sea to form the sun and the moon. In Russian Karelia raking the seabed is generally part of the Sampo episode, but its content varies: sometimes Väinämöinen is sought from the sea, sometimes the Sampo, or it is a description of the forging of the Sampo, or of how Väinämöinen used a giant rake forged by Ilmarinen to find a piece of fishbone and turn it into a kantele. The myth motif in question is: cultural hero obtains the material for creation from the bottom of the primeval sea. Who rakes what and for what purpose are questions that still have not been answered by research. The forger of the rake was in all probability Ilmarinen the smith.

In the Kuusalu region of Estonia the bird broods until its chicks are hatched and then gives them different tasks: one becomes a smith who forges harnesses, axes and knives, and finally a golden bride.

The Ingrian Lutherans, and in places also the Savo-Karelians, sang about a swallow that made its nest in the bows of a ship. As the boat rocked, its egg rolled into the water, an island was born and on it a maiden whom many came to court. It is unlikely that the story does, as was suggested by Julius Krohn (1885: 389), have any connection with the poem about the stealing of the Sampo. However, the origin-of-the-island motif recurs so frequently in conjunction with the drifting Väinämöinen (Kuusi 1949: 160) that it is tempting to view this variation on the conclusion to the myth of origin as a distant offshoot of the same cosmological myth.

The Song of Creation of Karelia would appear to reflect an early epic in which the role relations of the heroes correspond only in part to those of the extant main version. Thus the Giant Oak ties in with

the epic about the origin of the world in two quite unique variants to be found in Russian Karelia (SKVR I 35 and 47), likewise in one Estonian redaction.

The poem about the forging of the Sampo is relatively rare. Such epic-singing families in the northwestern parts of Russian Karelia as the Perttunens, the Malinens, the Kettunens and the Karjalainens usually present it as a bridge between the poems describing the origin of the world and the stealing of the Sampo: Väinämöinen is drifting northwards when the Mistress of the North hears his cries and demands that if he wishes to return home he must forge a Sampo, at which Väinämöinen either forges a Sampo himself or manages to persuade Ilmarinen to do it for him. The forging of the Sampo is almost never found as an independent poem, and it is missing entirely from the repertoires of even the best singers of Finnish Karelia, Olonetsia and the southern songlands.

According to the singers of Uhtua and Akonlahti Väinämöinen, on being commanded to make a Sampo, has a rake made, uses it to find a piece of fishbone on the bottom of the sea to be made into a kantele, which he then plays.

A few of the Sampo-forging motifs, such as the description of how the mistress, early in the morning, sweeps the floor and takes the sweepings out into the yard, Väinämöinen's cry for help, the introduction of Ilmarinen as forger of the sky, and the raking of the seabed, are also to be found in other contexts outside Russian Karelia. They do not, it would seem, have their origins in a song similar to the Sampo forging poem of northwest Russian Karelia, but in some more primitive stratum of cosmogonic poetry.

The most important parallel occurrence of the Sampo forging poem is the task set the suitor of making a Sampo, of producing a 'lid of many colours' or something similar. In the Kiimasjärvi redaction this is the only task, in the Olonetsian-Ladoga Karelian Devil's Wooing the last and decisive task. In certain other Karelian redactions which lack this task the decisive assignment is producing a vast pike from the Tuonela river. The pike may in earlier versions have been a sturgeon

(“sampi”) or a sampo pike. The Izhors, a tribe related to the Karelians, have a redaction of the Giant Oak at the end of which a brother uses fragments of oak to build a miraculous sauna which is called Kirjamo Church. The sauna is subsequently stolen and taken away by boat.

As the Sampo became obscured, the poem about its forging came in for considerable revision. It is significant to note its preservation as a continuation to the cosmogonic epic of Russian Karelia or in conjunction with other cosmological motifs. Although, for example, the Sampo > sampi > pike theory is more of a conjecture than a probability, there is no denying that the suitor’s tasks did play a central part in the dissolving of the Sampo legend.

The poem about the stealing of the Sampo may be regarded as the core of the epic chain. It has even been preserved among the Forest Finns of Scandinavia, fragments from it have been found further west than any other parts of the Sampo poems, and its general plot has remained more fixed than that of the Origin of the World and the Forging of the Sampo.

The Malinens and the Perttunens alone tell of a separate plundering expedition made after returning from the forging. According to the far more general tradition the Sampo was stolen immediately after it was forged.

It is extremely common to find the epics about the boat trip and the stealing of the Sampo interwoven. Acting as a prologue is an account of how the boat is fashioned, the visit to Vipunen or Tuonela this involves, the rowing of old and young, the big pike, and the making and playing of a kantele. For example, the crossing of three waters and sighting the gates of the North are found more often in the boat trip poem than in connection with the journey to steal the Sampo, to which it is primarily regarded as belonging. The playing of the kantele ends with the listeners falling asleep in the Sampo-stealing poems sung by, for example, Martiska Karjalainen and Jyrki Kettunen of Russian Karelia, but also in a few boat trip variants found in Ladoga Karelia. As the poems have merged one with another, the Sampo has in places been interpreted as a boat or a kantele.

In the redactions of South Russian Karelia and Ladoga Karelia in which the account of the suitor's tasks culminates in the forging of the Sampo, the making of a 'lid of many colours', etc., the hero is allowed to set off home with both the maiden and the Sampo. The chase and battle are usually replaced by other motifs. Thus at Kiimasjärvi in Russian Karelia Väinämöinen's flint and tinderbox do not place a rock in the way of the boat of the North; instead they take the place of the spark between the Air and Väinämöinen and/or the shooting of Väinämöinen and his drifting at sea. What makes this ending all the more interesting is that at the end of the well-preserved Ilomantsi version of the stealing of the Sampo Väinämöinen likewise finds himself on a misty sea, and there are references to a similar shipwreck in several other variants.

In the only variant from Paatene the son-in-law gets not only the bride but also the 'lid of many colours', which he made as one of the tasks set him. But his mother-in-law mourns for the lid, flies after the young couple in the form of an eagle and seizes it. The son-in-law strikes her with an oar, at which the lid falls into the water. The son-in-law makes a rake and rakes the seabed for a kantele with which he captivates the inhabitants of the forest and the water.

Like the boat trip epic, the poem about the freeing of the sun has been linked with the stealing of the Sampo in many ways. In the *Festschrift to Hans Fromm (Explanationes et tractationes Fenno-Ugricae 1979: 165–180)* I pointed out that the poem about the stealing of the Sampo, which was known to the author of the *Freeing of the Sun*, is most reminiscent of the explication of Ilomantsi and Repola in which putting the North to sleep and stealing the Sampo are preceded by Väinämöinen's visit to Vipunen. These poems appear to have had a mutual influence on one another: the stony hill at Pohjola as the place where the Sampo is kept and the golden millstone over the Ilomantsi Sampo stealer probably originate in the *Freeing of the Sun*.

The poem about the wooing competition ties in with the Sampo poems proper in that in both cases the main characters are Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen, the Mistress of Pohjola and her daughter, and the events

take place on home ground, at Pohjola and on the sea that separates them.

As regards plot, the wooing competition comes closest to the forging of the Sampo, in the course of which Ilmarinen was promised the beautiful maid of the North, but he is unable to “appease” her. When the young Anni discovers that Väinämöinen is sailing northwards for the purpose of courting her, she rushes to warn her brother, from whom others are taking a maiden redeemed for a large sum. The Malinens’ version of the wooing competition still has a closing episode in which the maid is given to the one to whom she was promised: Ilmarinen the smith, forger of the Sampo.

The northwest Russian Karelian version of the wooing competition represents a more recent stylistic stratum than the other Sampo poems. It is characterised by an ethnic and psychological realism and the development of the plot as extensive dialogues, as in the Island epic. The poem has, however, merged with the older Suitor’s Tasks drawing on fairytale motifs. The first instance is the link in plot established by the Kiimasjärvi redaction: Ilmarinen’s only task is to forge a Sampo. In place of or alongside this a host of other tasks have been either developed or borrowed. In her study of the Devil’s Wooing (*Hiidestä kosinta*) of 1964 Pirkko-Liisa Rausmaa demonstrated that fairytales of the type AT 531 and 300A+513 had a decisive influence on the assimilation of fairytale features into the wooing poem in Karelia and Ingria.

The development of the wooing competition poem has been most fragmentary as regards the conclusion. The Malinens end at the point where Ilmarinen gets the maid and Väinämöinen sets about making a golden bride. The Perttunens present the opposite conclusion: Ilmarinen fails in his final task, Väinämöinen gets the maid, and Ilmarinen makes a golden bride. In most cases the one who completes the tasks gets the maid, but he encounters various misfortunes on the way home. Fairytale type 300A+513 is varied in the Ladoga Karelia Devil’s Wooing so that it is the maid who is chased: although she is transformed into various

figures, the smith catches her. Angered by this or for other reasons, he finally sings his bride into a seagull on a rock.

The outcome designed by the *Shemeikkas* of *Suistamo* is of the utmost interest. On the way back the maid orders *Ilmarinen* to sing “on getting a good *Sampo*”. Just as *Väinämöinen* on the way back from stealing the *Sampo*, *Ilmarinen* at first refuses to sing, but finally gives in. *Pohjolainen* hears him singing and swallows him, just as *Ukko Untamoinen* swallowed the fetcher of the ‘lid of many colours’ in the *Olonetsian* redaction of the *Devil’s Wooing*. Just as in the *Kiimasjärvi* *Suitor’s Tasks*, the *Ladoga Karelian* version goes on to incorporate motifs from the stealing of the *Sampo*.

The *Karelian* redactor combined elements from the *Suitor’s Tasks* and the *Sampo* poems to form an extensive courting epic the prologue to which is, in *Ladoga Karelia*, a description of the birth and departure of three heroes. The scenes depicting the shooting and drifting of *Väinämöinen* are repeated feature by feature: a blue elk or elk-like horse as draught horse, the warning issued on departure, the ride across the sea with dry hoofs. In the etiological poem the marksman hits the horse, *Ilmarinen’s* sleigh or harness gets broken on the way to or from the courting, but the hero is not killed. In both poems he creates islands or rocks and ends up at *Pohjola* or *Hiitola*. The forging and stealing of the *Sampo* are minor episodes in the adventure. Whereas in the *Sampo* episode of the northwest Russian *Karelian* epic the role of *Väinämöinen* is reinforced at the expense of *Ilmarinen*, the *Karelian* redactor makes the smith *Ilmarinen* the main character above all others. In this and a couple of other respects the *Kiimasjärvi* redaction comes closer to the tradition of northwest Russian *Karelia* than to that of *Ladoga Karelia*.

The golden bride is, like the core of the cosmogonic poem, part of the Finnish-Estonian stratum. That the poems are approximately the same age is suggested by a stylistic device they both share: a closing parallel couplet.

As a general rule the golden bride is in *Karelia*, and in some places further west, a continuation of the wooing contest: in the north the

loser, in Ladoga Karelia the winner seeks consolation when his bride is turned into a seagull by making a golden bride who turns out to be cold.

In Ingria, too, the golden bride is a continuation of the wooing poem, and the chief character is the smith Ilmarinta, Ismaroinen, Ilmari the King. In Kuusalu, Estonia, the birth of the smith is recounted in connection with the birth of the world. Like a cultural hero the smith, both there and in Ingria, makes tools until, infuriated by the women's scolding, he sets about making a golden bride. The connecting of the wooing poem and the golden bride is presumably not among the common features of Estonia and Finland and only appeared in the Finnish redactions. The golden bride got involved in the courting tasks in connection with the Sampo poems.

Family or village redactions?

Had the poetry about the Sampo been preserved as a single ancient manuscript, or as the relatively uniform tradition of a single Karelian family of singers or a single rune area, the debate over its plot, structure, age, origins and development would greatly resemble the debate among researchers over Homer's epics, the Song of Roland, Beowulf, and so on. Instead the problems are more closely related to the problems of research into bylinas or the Southern Slavic folk epic. There are so many clues to the common origins of the hundreds of texts that have been preserved that the researcher is tempted to make do with just the information from the "best" singers or poetry regions.

Nevertheless, Kaarle Krohn was in principle right in claiming that any analysis must be based on all the material available.

In Elias Lönnrot's opinion the great singers of Russian Karelia — Arhippa Perttunen of Latvajärvi and Ontrei Malinen of Vuonninen — had kept relatively close to the ancient poems. He thus to a great extent

constructed the central plot of the Kalevala on the basis of their epic and used poetry from other areas to fill in the gaps, thus achieving epic breadth and detail.

For a long time the suggestive model of the Kalevala also made researchers content with the assumption that the two rune singers mentioned had more or less retained the “original” mode of singing, whereas the more the mode of singing diverged from the tradition of Perttunen and Malinen, the more “spoilt” it became.

It is nowadays realised that the unique character of the Kalevala-metre tradition lies in its temporal depth and local differentiation. This tradition took shape as the Proto-Finnic linguistic community dispersed, in the millenium before the birth of Christ; it did not include the Lapps, whose language broke away from Proto-Finnic about a thousand years B. C., or the easternmost Karelians, the Ludic-speaking peoples and the Veps. One problem is that the first poetry recordings were not made until the 16th century. The language, poetic technique and the poems themselves have developed in different directions in different regions, and international influences have repeatedly deposited new motif and stylistic strata on top of the oldest common tradition. In order to investigate these the geographical-historical or Finnish method was devised at the end of the 19th century; its principles are explained by Kaarle Krohn in the work *Die folkloristische Arbeitsmethode* (1926). The results of research into the epic have been collected in the comments to the anthology *Finnish Folk Poetry: Epic* (1977). Among the commentaries to the Kalevala in German are Kaarle Krohn's *Kalevalastudien* I–VI (1924–1928) and the excellent commentary to the translation of the Kalevala by Hans Fromm (1967).

The areas in which the Kalevala poetry has been preserved can roughly be divided into five categories: 1) Western Finland, where only few relics of Kalevala poetry have been found since the 18th century; 2) Eastern and Northern Finland, i. e. the Savo dialect region, whose ancient epic poetry has in general dispersed to become *historiola* motifs of an ample incantation or verbal magic tradition; 3) Orthodox Karelia on both sides of the old national frontier, centring around the present

Kalevala administrative district in northwest Russian Karelia, the area around the Kuittijärvi lakes, and Ladoga Karelia between lakes Ladoga and Pielinen; 4) the regions inhabited by the Izhors, a tribe related to the Karelians, on the isthmus between the Gulf of Finland and lake Ladoga and in Ingria, especially three headlands in the Gulf of Finland west of Leningrad; 5) the whole of Estonia, especially Orthodox Setumaa south of Lake Peipus.

Whether different poems belong together or apart can be debated according to how far the same interconnections are features of the *redactions* of different families, villages or rune regions. This term, used by Walter Anderson in his fairy-tale monographies, is used to apply to a group of variants that are genetically and typologically closer to one another than the variants of other redactions.

At the beginning of the century Carl von Sydow was already pointing out a process which he called the formation of ecotypes ('ekotypisering' in Swedish): the tradition in a given area has a tendency to standardise if its preservers are in constant contact with one another. In Karelia the redactions of the Sampo poems are generally family redactions, whereas in Ingria, on the southern shores of the Gulf of Finland, there are differences between the mode of singing of different villages and of different generations. The milieu preserving the rune-singing tradition was in Ingria the village band of maidens with its own leader. The singers visited the religious festivals in neighbouring villages, the maidens often married into other villages, and it is worth noting that as the generations succeeded one another, so the mode of singing tended to become standardised in many nearby villages. In Karelia the Kalevala-metre epic was, until the beginning of the 20th century, chiefly sung by men. The Karelian institution of the extended family maintained contact among even distant members of the family, and it was the norm that a rune had to be sung "correctly", in accordance with the common tradition. We can thus assume that at the beginning of the 20th century the Perttunens, the Malinens, Karjalainens, Sissonens and Shemeikkas sang their runes to almost or exactly the same words as their predecessors in the mid 19th century. But in Ingria the

tradition could change more in the course of one generation than during three generations in the northern rune regions.

Standardised ecotypes are usually clearly distinguishable from one another. Since they are, however, the most recent surface stratum in their development, the researcher must keep a careful watch out for any divergences and contrasts visible in the shadow of the local or family redaction. "The differences between close local variants and the similarities between variants geographically remote from one another are, when joined together, the surest guide to the earliest strata" (Kuusi 1949: 13).

The cycles and oral epic

Critical comparison of texts has in Finland been applied to folk poetry ever since the 18th century: "by comparing several variants of the same poem, there is some chance of returning them to a more harmonious and more reliable form", wrote H. G. Porthan. Most of the Kalevala-metre variants of epic poems have been published in the 33-volume work *Suomen kansan vanhat runot* (1908–1948), and numerous epic poems are the subject of monographs or studies, or else they have been dealt with in detail in general treatises — see the select bibliography in *Finnish Folk Poetry: Epic* (Kuusi et al. 1977: 603–606) and for research in Finnish the comments on individual poems in the anthology *Kalevalaista kertomarunoutta* (Kuusi 1980: 220–250).

These two anthologies, based on identical folk poetry, contain a number of examples of how a single motif may occur both as an independent poem and as part of various cycles. A cycle may be based on a fixed association of ideas, such as the Song of Creation (nos. 59–62), or else two poems are interwoven and their heroes confused, as in the case of Lemminkäinen and Kaukamoinen (nos. 34–38), or else Elias Lönnrot has compiled an epic entity out of poems about a

hero who is sometimes called Kullervo, sometimes son of Kaleva (nos. 41–45, 137–139).

It is therefore impossible to guess from the general development of poetry whether the different cycles of Sampo poems are a primary or a secondary phenomenon. As Leea Virtanen pointed out in her study *Kalevalainen laulutapa Karjalassa* (1968), the criterion of an eminent singer was in Russian Karelia repeatedly mentioned as being the ability to sing for a week or even two without ever repeating the same song (Virtanen 1968: 14). The longest variants have been obtained from the most illustrious singers. On the other hand one would imagine that short individual poems would have taken preference over long cycles at the singing competitions in which the contestants took it in turn to sing songs until one or the other came to the end of his repertoire. But “long hymns”, as Larin Paraske called her epic songs, were clearly valued higher than short ones.

There are two elements in the Sampo episode that certainly belong to the Estonian-Finnish stratum of poetry: the description of how the earth, the sky, the sun, the moon and stars came from the fragments of a broken egg, and the making of the golden bride. As I pointed out in the *Festschrift* to Felix J. Oinas (*Folklorica* 1982), relicts of the forming of the seabed have also been preserved in the poetry of Estonia. There is, however, nothing to prove that these myth motifs belonged to the same epic entity in Estonia. On the other hand there are signs in the Karelian-Ingrian tradition that the origin of the world, the golden bride and the Ilmarinen epics did belong together to some degree hundreds of years ago.

The poems do, however, belong together in a different way in the case of the origin of the earth and the singing contest, the forging of the Sampo and the wooing contest.

The singing contest, on which the third poem in the *Kalevala* is based, tells how old Väinämöinen and young Joukahainen come up against one another and embark on a contest to see what ancient things they remember. Joukahainen boasts that he can remember the time when the sea was ploughed and islands were created in the sea, but

Väinämöinen announces that he himself took part in this creation. The singing contest here refers to the episode which the poem about the origin of the world presents as taking place as Väinämöinen drifts in the *primaeval* sea. Reference is made to the same act of creation in two Estonian poems (*Eesti rahvalaulud* 892 and 998).

The Russian Karelian poem about the forging of the Sampo in turn relates that the mistress of Pohjola promises her beautiful daughter to whoever forges the Sampo. According to Arhippa Perttunen Ilmarinen made the Sampo but did not win the bride. But in the poem about the wooing contest Ilmarinen hears from his sister that Väinämöinen has gone sailing off to woo the daughter of Pohjola, who is said to be Ilmarinen's own, Ilmarinen having wooed her for many years. The outcome of the wooing contest is, according to Ontrei Malinen, that the maiden is promised to Ilmarinen without any further conditions once he has made the Sampo. The later poet thus continues, in the poem about the wooing contest, where the older poet left off in the poem about the forging of the Sampo.

The two examples shed considerable light on the way in which oral epic comes into being. There existed an epic tradition familiar to the poet and his community. The order of the acts of creation was known. Every singer and listener was more aware than we are of the purpose of raking the seabed, the Sampo and everything to do with it. The poet relied on collective tradition; he could refer to it, like the poet of the singing contest, or assume that it was familiar, like the poet of the wooing contest. The logical order of events made a uniform epic out of epic poetry, a cosmos out of chaos.

It was not enough for a new poem to be founded on an older one. As poems became associated with one another, they also assimilated. The Joukahainen of the singing contest acquired various secondary roles in poems about the Sampo: in the poem telling the origin of the world he took the place of the Lapp in various parts of Karelia as the shooter of Väinämöinen, in several redactions of the stealing of the Sampo of Savo origin he became Väinämöinen's travelling companion,

and in the Ladoga Karelian wooing epic he was the brother, travelling companion or rival suitor of Ilmollinen and Väinämöinen.

The linking of motifs from the forging of the Sampo and the wooing contest also had the effect that the Karelian re-composer/poet invented a new wooing epic of fixed construction on the basis of the wooing by the performance of trials and the poems about the Sampo. In it forging the Sampo or fashioning the lid became the decisive task on completion of which Ilmollinen the smith got or stole both the maid and the Sampo. This uniform epic spread widely and put out new, fairytale-like episodes, as was shown by Pirkko-Liisa Rausmaa in her special study *Hiidestä kosinta* (1964). The older structure, in which the forging of the Sampo and the wooing contest belonged to different entities, was preserved only on the northwestern periphery of Russian Karelia.

Many of the vague points in the old poems are probably references to even older poems that have subsequently been lost. There are illogicalities suggesting damage inflicted by re-composers but also the order in which cycles were compiled. It thus seems likely that the description of the stealing of the Sampo and the disputes between Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen and the mistress of the Pohjola was not yet a continuation of the forging of the Sampo on which the author of the wooing contest poet relied. The daughter of Pohjola belonged to the forger of the Sampo, but hardly to the stealer of the Sampo.

How to define an epic?

Certain folk epic researchers from Eastern Europe define epos as being the entire oral tradition of some community, the poems being linked together by mutual motif lines of varying strength, joint clichés and stereotype characters, without forming any fixed entity. Speaking of the Sampo epic as the epic nucleus of the Kalevala likewise means

marking off a motif of very uncertain contour. The Sampo epos should in the narrow sense be read simply as the forging and the stealing of the Sampo, and possibly also the introduction that occurs rather regularly in Russian Karelia: the poem about the origin of the world. The wooing contest poem and the following golden bride poem are thematically connected with the forging of the Sampo, and in the Karelian wooing epic all five poems constitute a fixed entity.

The criteria could be slackened, so that the epic could also be made to include the Ingrian releasing of the day, which relies on the stealing of the Sampo, and the extensive boat journey cycle, which tells how Väinämöinen fashioned a boat, his journey by boat, and the making and playing of the kantele. Both have on many occasions been grafted on to the stealing of the Sampo. Such motifs as the visit to Vipunen and seeing the gates of Pohja are found in all three poetic contexts (the releasing of the day, the epic about the boat journey and the various Sampo poems), and it is not clear where they originally belonged.

A few rare texts have been preserved in Russian Karelia and Ingria in which the origins of a giant oak follow on from Väinämöinen's drifting or his disputing. In Ingria fragments of the oak are made into a miraculous sauna, which is compared to Kirjamo church; a certain Virpoi lifts the sauna onto his back and carries it to his boat and the shores of Estonia. E. N. Setälä was, to my mind, right in claiming that this displays a relic of the Izhors' lost stealing of the Sampo. Theoretically such associations in strict contrast to the general tradition could possibly reflect a more archaic epic plot than the 19th century Sampo episode and the poem about the giant oak that hatched into an incantation historiola on the birth of Pistos (disease). Lurking behind the poem on the origin of the world and the forging of the Sampo is the Proto-Finnic story of creation, the cosmologic cycle or the epos of origin, likewise the stealing of the Sampo, the boat journey and the releasing of the day may be based on some older and subsequently lost poem of adventure from which they have descended.

The word 'epos', like 'poem' or 'proverb', is in this sense a term stretched by every user to suit his own needs. The 'Sampo epos' may

be the scholar's fiction of an epic composed by some ancient poet, the text sung by Ontrei Malinen to Elias Lönnrot, the poem fashioned by Lönnrot from this text or by Paavo Haavikko from Lönnrot's text, or a general term for a thousand-year process that has neither beginning nor end.

A cursory survey of the Sampo poetry may create an impression of a chaotic network of relationships and changes in which motifs become associated with one another according to the rules of chance. This is a false impression. There is an astonishing degree of uniformity in poems and their mutual relations, considering that they have probably been handed down over thirty generations — the oldest ones possibly as many as a hundred — ever since the late Proto-Finnic era. The norm has been: "If you don't know it, don't sing it". Counterbalancing differentiation there has been the continuity of tradition, respect for the "correct" common mode of singing. Otherwise it is impossible to explain why identical lines from myth poems occur in identical contexts from the borders of Lapland to Southern Estonia. There were seldom any periods of great change, and even then the changes were not total, especially in the forest villages of Karelia, before the 20th century.

Lönnrot's role

What truth is there in the view expressed by Julius Krohn that Elias Lönnrot, as compiler of the Kalevala, brought to a conclusion a process that had already been highly developed by the rune singers of Karelia?

Like the best singers, Lönnrot tended to standardise the style of poems and to establish their plot and overall structure by cultivating the same clichés and epithets throughout the epic, reinforcing the part played by Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen and the other main characters or interpreting figures going under different names in different poems (e. g. Lemminkäinen, Ahti Saarelainen, Kaukomieli, Äijön poika, Pä-

töinen poika, Lyylikki, Kauppi) as being the same people, by eliminating illogicalities and adding references to events in earlier poems. The emphasis on historical veracity and the human psychological level at the expense of mythology and the fairytale element was also in keeping with the general trend in folk poetry.

Contrary to the trend in folk tradition, Lönnrot archaised poems by eliminating Christian and modern features; he dramatised the epic by creating a basic epic tension between the conflicting national interests of Kalevala and Pohjola and by emphasising the rare battle scenes and acts of violence in the folk poetry; he expanded the epic by imposing parallel variants one on top of the other and interspersing incantations and lyrics. It is the wide-spread use of parallel lines and the combination of different genres that distinguish the Kalevala most sharply from genuine folk poetry.

In Julius Krohn's opinion, Lönnrot was close to the rune singers in spirit:

Ein Glück können wir es auch nennen, dass Lönnrot selbst nicht die geringste praktische poetische Begabung hatte. Die wenigen Gedichte, welche er geschrieben hat, sind ganz erbärmlich. Dadurch wurde ein gar zu grösser persönlicher Einfluss auf die Ausbildung des Kalevala-Epos verhindert. (Krohn 1888: 67–68.)

This concept, which is supported by A. R. Niemi and strongly opposed by Väinö Kaukonen, both of whom have studied the compilation of the Kalevala, more or less corresponds to Lönnrot's own self-image. Appealing to the freedom of the rune singer, he consciously broke away from the models of compilation employed by the great rune singers he had previously examined in putting together the New Kalevala, but in doing so he in fact also broke away from the improvisation of ancient poetry based on tradition that was characteristic of Arhippa Perttunen or Ontrei Malinen. The result was a collage epic that is a folk epic to the extent that Seurasaari Open Air Museum in Helsinki is a Finnish peasant village.

Convergent research on epic styles

The image created by Julius Krohn of folk poetry as a continuing folklore process in which new forms are adopted in time of change, combining poems and extending plots to produce broader epic entities, greatly corresponds to my own view. We can see on comparing rune regions that one characteristic feature of the living epic is the balanced dispersion and joining together of cycles, whereas in areas where the old narrative poem is on the point of extinction, dispersion seems to have gained the upper hand. Whether the earliest forms of the Kalevala epic poetry were simpler than in the 19th century is a matter for conjecture. Against the background of more distant Finno-Ugrian peoples it may be claimed that extensive semi-improvised poetic narratives are no recent phenomenon. If myth poems really did exist within a ritual framework in the pagan era, as is generally assumed, their order was certainly more fixed and they could be distinguished more clearly from other epic poetry than at the start of poetry collection.

Julius Krohn's optimistic belief that the riddle of the birth of epics could be solved on the basis of the Baltic-Finnic poetic tradition has proved to be nationalistic wishful thinking. The Harvard school led by Milman Parry and Albert B. Lord has found the folkloristic keys to epic theory in the folk epics of Serbia and Croatia. The confirmities to certain rules are not for the most part the same as those observed on examining the folk poetry of Karelia and Ingria. The differences may be explained by the fact that the margin for improvisation is wider in Yugoslavia than in Karelia. In the 1950s researchers both at Harvard and in Finland, unaware of each other's research, turned to the analysis of style and formula. It is somewhat amusing that the most recent study of the Kalevala poetry tradition quoted in the research anthology produced by the Harvard school, *Oral Literature* (edited by Joseph J. Duggan, 1975), is *Il Kalevala o la poesia tradizionale dei Finni* by Domenico

Comparetti (1891). Equally conspicuous is the almost total absence of the Harvard school from the bibliographies of Finnish epic research.

There is obviously a need for international symposia.

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Väinö Kaukonen

The Kalevala as Epic

The most widely known epic poem in Finnish literature, the Kalevala or Old Karelian Poems about the Ancient Times of the Finnish People, appeared in 1835–36, the second edition of almost twice the size and simply called the Kalevala, in 1849. The poems of the Kalevala — 32 in the first edition and 50 in the second — constitute the epic that, translated into dozens of languages, has become known the world over. The compiler of the Kalevala was one of the leading figures in Finnish culture last century — Elias Lönnrot (1802–1884), a district doctor who subsequently became a professor in Finnish language and literature. Drawing widely on the technique of compilation, he wrote a poetic work on the basis of traditional poetry of the pre-literate era as sung to him by rune singers. Lönnrot was thoroughly familiar with this poetry on the basis of his personal study and collection trips (made in 1828–1844), and the uniform, ancient Finnish poetic metre based on the structure of the language permitted the combination of artefact lines, fragments and longer episodes to create new entities satisfying the aesthetic goals of the author. Most of the folklore material in the first edition of the Kalevala was recorded by Lönnrot himself, but in the second edition he was able to draw on thousands of recordings made by the other folklore collectors listed in the preface.

The vision about the Kalevala universe

The Kalevala is a poetic work telling about an entirely fictive ancient world and universe which finally took shape in Lönnrot's mind over a period of 16 years. It is a vast, visionary fantasy that lacks any

immediate link with the historical and ethnological reality of the folk poetry from which it is composed. The leading issue of research into the background sources of the Kalevala is the concept held by Lönnrot and his contemporaries of the early history of the Finnish people and folk tradition as a means of illuminating this.

Interest in the recording of the oral tradition from the 16th century onwards was generated above all by the desire to throw light on the history of past eras, as has been proved by Annamari Sarajas in her study of familiarity with Finnish folklore in literature of the 16th–18th centuries (Sarajas 1956). In 1820 Reinhold von Becker described the Väinämöinen of the epic as “an excellent fellow”, even a king, and Gabriel Rein regarded him as a historical figure of note who really did once exist and who fought with the settler Finns in their battle against the Lapps. In his foreword to the *Kantele taikka Suomen Kansan sekä Vanhoja että Nykyisempiä Runoja ja Lauluja* (“Kantele, The Harp, or Old and Later Poems and Songs of the Finnish People”), which was his first collection of folk poems, Lönnrot hoped that the poems would provide more information “on the lives and way of life of our forefathers”, and he also believed that the Kalevala, too, would in some respect “be able to throw light on our earliest history”, as he wrote to J. L. Runeberg in March 1835.

According to the concepts formed by linguistic and historical research, there had been people speaking Finno-Ugric languages living in the Russian parts of Europe and the western parts of Asia before the advent of the Russians, and H. G. Porthan thought it probable that the Finns and with them the Estonians, whose language he regarded as a Finnish dialect, came from the east along the coast of the Gulf of Finland; some of them settled on the southern shores, in Estonia, others spread north to the shores and later the inner regions of Finland (Porthan 1784: 161). Referring to this, and influenced partly by the Books of Moses in the Old Testament, Lönnrot gradually formed a quasi-historical vision of the ancient abode of the people of Karelia, Häme and Estonia east of the Ural Mountains. From there these tribes came first to the banks of the Volga; the Häme and Estonian peoples,

led by Kaleva, then migrated towards the Gulf of Finland while the Karelians headed north to the shores of the White Sea. The giant Kaleva of the prose tales was interpreted by Lönnrot as an “elder of the people” something in the style of Moses, who led his people to the *suotu* or ‘promised’ (from which came the name of *Suomi* or Finland, the promised) land. Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen and the other “sons of Kaleva” were thought by Lönnrot to be his descendants.

The rebirth of an epic era

Hans Fromm has emphasised that European late-Romantic concepts had a fundamental influence on the birth of the Kalevala (Fromm 1974: 12). The Romantic vision of a heroic era way back in the history of a nation and of an epic begotten by this, fragments of which were preserved in tradition up until very recent times, was extremely important. This concept was also assimilated by the linguistic scholar A. J. Sjögren, who in the introduction to his work *Über die finnische Sprache und ihre Literatur* (1821) regrets that the epic era of the Finnish nation had long since passed and that the historical information about the known poems did not extend very far back. He nevertheless believed that the renewed interest in folklore collection at around that time would also introduce new light on the epic era of the nation too.

A classical scholar, Lönnrot was extremely well acquainted with the literature of Antiquity, especially Hellenic literature. He was familiar with Fr. A. Wolf’s epoch-making theory on the birth of Homer’s epics in the 6th century B. C. by compiling songs previously known only orally. In many respects Homer’s *Iliad* was thus Lönnrot’s model.

Taking the poetic portrait of Väinämöinen put together by Reinhold von Becker in 1820 from folk song excerpts and allowing for later collections, Lönnrot tried by the same method to devise a fuller poetic narrative about Väinämöinen and the other characters appearing in the

poems, such as Lemminkäinen and Ilmarinen. These attempts and the collection of wedding poems were never completed but represented a preliminary step towards the future epic. The decisive inspiration came to Lönnrot on his 4th collection trip beyond the border in Vuonninen, where he wrote down the excellent narrative poems told him by Ontrei Malinen and discussed their content and interconnection with the ageing seer Vaassila Kieleväinen, whose memory was already failing him.

The epic folk poetry familiar to Lönnrot was very varied and covered numerous themes. It included poems on historical themes, such as the destruction of Viipuri Castle, poems connected with the Swedish rulers and military campaigns, mythical poems about the origin of the world and the *sampo*, tales of adventure in poetic metre, courting poems, ballads, legends (such as the extensive Karelian Messianic poem), and so on. Many of the poems centre around the same figures, but the names vary greatly.

During Lönnrot's discussions with Vaassila Kieleväinen, the idea of an epic era began to concretise. Lönnrot began to form a vision of an ancient era in which Väinämöinen and many of the other characters in the poems were real historical figures whose deeds and fates were, he believed, related in the poems. This was the beginning of the quasi-historical fantasy of the ancient "Kalevala-era", which subsequently developed into one of the great myths of European literature. Lönnrot regarded his discussions with Vaassila as so important that he later, admittedly with considerable exaggeration, claimed he arranged the poems to form a continuous episode in accordance with Vaassila's suggestion. That same autumn, in November 1833, he moulded together his former drafts to form the 5.000-line Collected Songs about Väinämöinen, which posterity has called the Proto-Kalevala because the basic structure of the future epic is already evident. And Lönnrot decided to continue collecting poetry until he had enough to make an epic corresponding to "half of Homer".

Lönnrot met the greatest of the Russian Karelian rune singers, Arhippa Perttunen of Latvajärvi, the following spring, on his V collection trip, the results of which exceeded anything that had gone before.

He was thus able to realise his great dream of creating an epic comparable to the *Iliad*. The manuscript was completed in February 1835. The name is misleading in that the *Kalevala* is the continuous poetic work written by Lönnrot and not a collection of old, prehistoric poems.

The *Kalevala* was originally intended as a description of Väinämöinen, and its structure was determined by this aspect: the work begins with Väinämöinen's birth and ends with his departure. Lönnrot tried to adapt the episodes telling about Väinämöinen to the work so that the account would "flow", i. e. so that the events would follow one another without any sense of conflict. In between the parts of the tale about Väinämöinen Lönnrot inserted the two Lemminkäinen episodes and the Kullervo episode. The Collected Songs about Väinämöinen is still a very fragmentary and conflicting draft and the first edition of the epic is not without these faults either. The regional centre dominating the Collected Songs is Pohjola, but side by side with this in the epic is Kalevala. Thus the epic becomes an account of the relationships between two peoples — the people of Kaleva and the people of Pohja.

The epics of Homer, being compilations, were Lönnrot's chief models and had a notable influence on the structure of the *Kalevala*. According to A. R. Niemi (1898: 247), Lönnrot learnt from Homer that the narrative may be interrupted by interim episodes that do not disturb the continuity. The stereotype expressions appearing in the same wordings throughout the epic have their counterpart in Homer, and the people of Kaleva and Pohja are analogous to the Greeks and the Trojans. The epic was also named the *Kalevala* by analogy with *Iliad*, meaning Troy. The reference technique linking the parts of the epic together also has its counterpart in the poetic works of Homer.

Lönnrot assumed that the pre-literate poems used as his sources were the outcome of descriptions of events in which "one recalled one thing, a second another, whatever he had seen or heard" (Lönnrot 1835: 5), and he believed these poems had been preserved and passed down from one generation to another, retaining their original content but changing their outward form. By excluding from his poetic material

poems connected with recent Finnish history and poetic elements of Christian and other later origin, Lönnrot believed he could provide a reliable picture of the poems he presumed were sung in the epic era and which were not at that time performed in any set order, as he mentions in the preface to the *Kalevala* (1835). He located the scene of the events described in the songs on the southern shores of the White Sea.

Lönnrot's concept of epic

In the 1840s Lönnrot's concept of his task became less restrained than before. The vast new collections of rune recordings convinced him that still unknown "Kalevala poems" handed down from the envisaged epic era were no longer to be found, and that it was the task of a poet to compile a uniform work. The philosopher Robert Tengström stressed in his notable *Kalevala* essay (Tengström 1845) that the great epic poems are at the same time the poetic works of a single person and also the outcome of many joint influences, and that the uniform, artistic epic had to have just one poet. Lönnrot had also noticed that not all the later features he noted in the poems could be eliminated. The poems thus contain some loan words borrowed from Swedish and other foreign languages, which did not in his opinion originally belong there. Nevertheless, "it is enough that they belong to the poem just as time has passed it on to us and I have ultimately to accept this" (Lönnrot 1849a).

Lönnrot characterised his new attitude to his source poetry, now free from his strivings towards reconstruction, in the line of folk poetry: "Itse loime loitsijaksi, aikahtime laulajaksi" (cf. p. 100). He now became intent on creating a comprehensive work based on folk poetry telling about the life, customs and history of the Finns who, he believed, lived on the southern shores of the White Sea some thousand or more years

ago. And this description drew not only on ancient Karelian poems, for he also made indiscriminate use of recordings from Ingria and other areas. A comprehensive work also called for the inclusion of a wealth of incantations in keeping with the magical concept of life that was widespread in ancient times. In order to achieve perfection, there also had to be room for lyrical songs, the chief source of which was the *Kanteletar* published in 1840. Although the basic structure of the work remained almost unchanged (Lönnrot wrote his additions and corrections in the big empty spaces of the interleaves in the first edition of the *Kalevala*), Lönnrot was aware that the work as a whole could be drawn up in an infinite number of ways. Thus in a letter to Fabian Collan in May 1848 he says that enough poems had been collected so far for at least seven *Kalevalas*, all of them different.

With his new manuscript already complete, Lönnrot again returned to the problems of his great model, Homer. In an article entitled *Anmärkningarna till den nya Kalevala upplagan* in J. V. Snellman's *Litteraturblad* of January 1849 he states that he believes he has solved the centuries-old problem of Homer. Lönnrot writes:

If those who have written about the birth of Homer's songs had had the same experience of how a song handles tradition as I have with Finnish songs, there could never have been any argument as to how these songs came into being. They would gradually have noticed that some bard at the time the events took place first sang about them in brief, after which tradition expanded the songs and came up with numerous variants. Whoever subsequently collected the variants had a task similar to mine in arranging the songs of the *Kalevala* —.

Inspired by Homer, Lönnrot began to plan a great, continuous epic made up of folk songs, resumed his successful collection work in the latter half of the 1830s and towards the end of the 1840s put the final touches to his great feat of literary creation based on folk poems and songs.

The Kalevala as a literary work

Kaarle Krohn stressed the contrast between the Kalevala and the folk songs, the pre-literate poetry constituting the material for it. He made the weighty observation that the Kalevala and the other folk poetry works by Lönnrot are unnecessary and even misleading in the study of the life of the people, be it ethnology, historical research, mythology, sociology or folkloristics (Krohn 1918: 8–20). Väinö Salminen likewise considered it strange that the old epic folk poems have both on publication and in research been placed within the framework of the Kalevala (Salminen 1934: 241). Surely there is neither Kalevala epic nor lyrical poetry anywhere but in the epic, and it could not even have existed previous to this. The Kalevala is literature but its primary materials are pre-literate poetry.

In order to realise in poetic form his great vision of an ancient “Kalevala era”, Lönnrot linked together pre-literate poems to form a series of scenes, drawing on numerous devices to connect up the various parts more closely than was possible merely by using names of people and places that recurred in different contexts. The events of the period between the birth and departure of Väinämöinen are woven into an entity by means of two central motifs, the wooing of the maiden of Pohja and the forging of the Sampo. Thus the Kalevala is fundamentally both a poem about a maiden’s wooing and an epic about the Sampo. Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen and Lemminkäinen all have their eye on the beautiful, famous daughter of Pohjola, and the wooing episode ends with a description of the Pohjola wedding. The latter part of the work is dominated by the theft and destruction of the Sampo with its numerous consequences. The forging of the Sampo, the wedding and the theft of the Sampo thus become the three climaxes in the chain of events and everything else is grouped around or in between them. Lönnrot tied the parts together using a technique also found in Homer, by laying the foundations for future events and by referring back to earlier phenomena.

Like other poetry and art in general, the *Kalevala* is an autonomous entity, a poetic world of its own, in which everything is fictitious. It is the poetry of poetry in the sense that in it Lönnrot set out to provide a picture of the remote period in history that is in his opinion described in pre-literate poetry, but which in reality never existed. The *Kalevala* can be interpreted purely as a work on its own: everything we know about the *Kalevala* world and universe is contained between the covers of this epic. The numerous articles on the *Kalevala* written by Lönnrot himself and the commentaries he drew up for his lectures at the university provide an excellent aid to interpretation. These are preserved in the archives of the Finnish Literature Society (*Lönnrotiana* 121) and some of them were published by Lönnrot at the end of the abridged *Kalevala* (Lönnrot 1862: 341–411), but not even the opinions of the author of the *Kalevala* can be regarded as absolute criteria. Viewed from this angle, the picture of the “*Kalevala* era” is as follows.

Cosmogony and the conflict of border people

The first two cantos in the epic present the cosmogony of the *Kalevala* universe, this being supplemented by the fragment on Antero Vipunen’s account of the origin of the world in canto 17 (17:541–552). Väinämöinen is a supernatural being born of the first Spirit of Nature; so, we are led to believe, is Ilmarinen, who helped to forge the sky. Väinämöinen leaves one birch “as a resting place for birds, as a tree for a cuckoo to call in” (2:257–280), never dreaming that this act would later be his salvation when he was shot by Joukahainen and found himself at the mercy of the waves (7:89–115).

Cantos 3–6 tell of the contest of wisdom between Väinämöinen and Joukahainen and its unhappy consequences. In his distress Joukahainen, a young stripling from Lapland, promises his sister Aino as Väinämöinen’s wife and thus brings on her untimely death. The young man

from Lapland should not be understood as a true Lapp, but as anyone from the border lands, Lapp being used to denote any of the border peoples in general (Lönnrot 1862: 344, 354). In his commentaries Lönnrot excludes the place names of 19th century Finland and its neighbouring regions from the epic in the quasi-historical belief that “in the days of the Kalevala” they referred to completely different places in the abodes of the forefathers of the Finns at that time. Vuoksi, Imatra, Häme, Karelia, Kemijoki and so on were names the Finns brought with them from what were assumed to be their original dwelling places, and Suomi (Finland) was not at that time a common name for the country but the name of a province, like e. g. Savo in later centuries.

The myth of the Sampo

On Aino’s death, Väinämöinen sets off to woo the daughter of Pohja, but due to Joukahainen’s attempt at revenge he arrives with the help of an eagle in a sorry state. The episode describing the forging of the Sampo (cantos 7–10) thus has an unfavourable beginning: Väinämöinen has to agree to Ilmarinen as the forger of the Sampo, while himself encountering failure in his attempts at wooing and even injuring himself badly while making a boat. According to Lönnrot’s commentary the description in the epic of the maiden weaving “taivon kannella” (on the lid of heaven) is merely a poetic expression for a girl sitting weaving in an outhouse loft, and the tasks she sets poetic expressions for the trials demanded of wooers (Lönnrot 1862: 349–350). The third task, fashioning a boat, is not completed as Väinämöinen injures his knee. On his return home he sends Ilmarinen to Pohjola to forge the Sampo.

The forging and theft of the Sampo are the great central myth of the Kalevala, from which the work has been described as a mythical epic. The origin and influence of the Sampo can be understood only

in the light of the mythical life-concept of the Kalevala. Earlier Lönnrot seems to have conceived of the object of the worship of the Sampo as being the image of God, but he subsequently joined in the concept of Jacob Grimm by which the Sampo meant ploughing, sowing, tending the cattle and spinning in general (Grimm 1846), and thus ended the allegorical interpretation of the Sampo and in fact of the entire epic. The Sampo is not merely a miraculous object producing the yield of the forest, the cattle and the field one hundredfold (Lönnrot 1862: 349): it stands for the civilisation and culture achieved by mankind in general. It had, in Lönnrot's opinion, at all times been the task of truth and true civilisation to make both individuals and nations happy, and the allegorical interpretation made it possible to interpret Väinämöinen's divination at the end of the epic as a promise to return, bringing the nation all possible happiness (Lönnrot 1858).

The tasks of the hot-headed young man and the cosmography of Manala

The first episode about Lemminkäinen (cantos 11 – 15) adds the wooing theme to the epic entity. The hot-headed youth likewise sets off with little fortune to seek the famous maiden of Pohja. He manages his first task, which is to catch the elk belonging to Hiisi, a spirit of evil intent towards man, and to bridle Hiisi's gelding, but his attempt to shoot the swan on the river leading to Tuonela, the underworld, proves fatal. The "watery-hatted herdsman" of Pohjola kills him and casts him into the river, where the "bloody son of the Underworld" hews him into pieces.

The names of the various areas in Tuoni, Tuonela, the Underworld (the river, forests, etc.) mean, according to Lönnrot, dangerous places in general; the people of Tuoni kept watch over those meeting their death, to bear them to the Underworld. The land created at the beginning of the description of the world in the Kalevala is surrounded

by *primaeval* sea, and above it are the nine layers of heaven. Tuonela or Manala is not actually under the ground: it is an island cut off by a river or strait at the extremity of the world inhabited by the people of Tuoni and the dead. Lemminkäinen was not, however, destined to go there, and his mother was able to collect the pieces of his body from the river and, with the help of the highest Creator, the omnipotent God, to bring her son back to life. In the final lines of the episode Lönnrot leads the reader to believe that Lemminkäinen will be returned to later in the epic.

The wooing contest and the wedding drama

Although the maiden of Pohja was promised to the forger of the sampo, Ilmarinen, Väinämöinen is not content with his fate and in the episode describing the wooing contest (cantos 16–20) still tries to win her for his own, even trusting in the sympathy of the mistress of Pohjola. In preparation for his journey Väinämöinen “made a boat by singing”, which according to Lönnrot means that the success of journeys made by boat had to be ensured by singing chants, which Väinämöinen did not, however, know in full. To begin with he seeks in vain for the missing words in Tuonela, but he is finally given them by Antero Vipunen, who was “a fine old sage and a man-eating giant” (Lönnrot 1862: 358). Väinämöinen arrives in his boat and Ilmarinen overland on horseback at Pohjola, and the maiden of Pohja now finally agrees to take the forger of the Sampo as her husband. Just as Väinämöinen in canto 8 and Lemminkäinen in canto 13, Ilmarinen is now set certain tasks, all of which he manages. Preparations for the wedding can thus begin. He makes the fateful decision not to invite Lemminkäinen to the wedding, in view of the trouble he has previously caused in Pohjola, and thus lays the foundations for his offence and his revenge.

In cantos 21–25 the epic style becomes dramatic in the description of the Pohjola wedding, celebrated first at Pohjola and then at Ilmari-

nen's home. Only one tenth of the lines in the episode constitute introductions to the dialogues and the monologues and descriptive narrative, such as the couple's journey. The bulk of the episode consists of wedding poems. Despite its unusual structure, the episode is a description rich in content and variety of the everyday life of a farming community and the demands this imposes. In the overall scheme of the epic, the Pohjola wedding is a great joint festival for the people of Pohja and Kaleva, the real main character being the great seer and singer Väinämöinen. The communal, harmonious, festive spirit is not marred by such hidden problems as the ownership of the Sampo.

The second Lemminkäinen episode (cantos 26–30) is a tale of adventure telling how Lemminkäinen sets off on a voyage of revenge that ends with the death of the master of Pohjola and the ensuing adventures “with the island virgins” and the war against Pohjola. At the end of the episode Lönnrot again leaves Lemminkäinen to his own devices to await the theft of the Sampo.

As regards the outward events, the Kullervo episode (cantos 31–36) has less connection with the rest of the epic than the other episodes; neither Kullervo nor his people feature in the other events. Nevertheless the death of Ilmarinen's wife, the maiden of Pohjola, at Kullervo's hand marks the beginning of the enmity between Kalevala and Pohjola leading to the theft of the Sampo. The turning point could be described as a didactic poem rather than as a myth telling of how a golden maiden was forged (canto 37); it does, after all, end with Väinämöinen's admonition not “to bow down to gold, to truckle to silver”.

The battle for the Sampo and the hero's departure

The final section of the epic (cantos 38–49) tells about the violent attempt by the people of Kalevala to wrest the Sampo from Pohjola, its destruction and the unsuccessful attempts by the mistress of Pohjola

at revenge. The entire complex chain of events is logical in that the mistress of Pohjola is finally forced to submit, to return the lights in heaven she has stolen, so that Väinämöinen can greet them as the bringers of lasting happiness to mankind, but in other respects it is fragmentary and illogical. The events begin with Ilmarinen's new journey of wooing to Pohjola, which ends with the abduction of the maiden and ultimately her rejection, turned into a seagull. On this journey Ilmarinen sees that Pohjola is well provided for by the Sampo. This observation leads Väinämöinen and Ilmarinen to decide to set off on a journey that becomes their attempt to steal the Sampo from Pohjola.

Despite the purpose with which they set out in their iron war-boats, the journey is interrupted by the making and playing of a pike-bone kantele. According to Lönnrot's interpretation, this would have been a kind of harp played with a bow, for which the twisted jawbone and curve of the fish were suitable (Lönnrot 1862: 382). The kantele is tried out in Pohjola too, but Väinämöinen alone is able to play it, and in such a way that all Creation is enchanted. Only after this episode can the journey to fetch the Sampo continue.

The battle for the Sampo described in cantos 42 and 43 ends with its destruction and the defeat of both parties, the defeat being even greater for the people of Pohjola. The handle and lid of the Sampo could not save Pohjola from hunger and wretchedness in general. The crumbs of the Sampo washed up on the shores of Kalevala do not in themselves signify eternal happiness, but they do contain the seed of eternal happiness and success. Väinämöinen regards the battle as bringing victory to Kalevala and in place of the kantele now lying on the sea bed eagerly makes a new one out of birchwood and with it again charms all Creation (canto 44).

Cantos 45–49 describing the misfortunes that befall Kalevala are in most respects independent, but because they deal with the attempts at revenge of the mistress of Pohjola they are among the consequences of the robbing of the Sampo. Through his mighty charms against disease Väinämöinen rids the people of Kalevala of disease and illness. The

felling of the bear sent to slaughter the cattle and the resulting feast turn into a major festival. The threat of greater destruction caused by the vanishing of the lights in heaven is finally removed when the mistress of Pohjola realises her ultimate defeat and releases the sun and the moon from the stony hill of Pohjola.

The last canto in the *Kalevala* is a separate conclusion to the epic in that it is connected with what has gone before only by the fate of Väinämöinen and it is separated from previous events by an undefined period in time. Marjatta's half-month-old boy, whom Väinämöinen has ordered to be thrown into the marsh, upbraids him for handing down a wrong verdict. An old man christens the boy king of Karelia, guardian of the whole realm. Angry and ashamed, Väinämöinen sets off by boat into the unknown, "toward the upper reaches of the world, to the lower reaches of the heavens", and as he departs he predicts that he will one day be needed again "to fetch a new Sampo, to prepare a new instrument". The christening of Marjatta's son as the future ruler of the realm marks the beginning of a new era in the world of the *Kalevala* in which Väinämöinen has no place. The new era is not explicitly described, and there is no reference to Christianity in the 50th canto, any more than there is elsewhere in the epic. The fact that Väinämöinen made no attempt to resist his fall from power once the time came was, in Lönnrot's opinion, a unique sign of Väinämöinen's wisdom.

Is the *Kalevala* a uniform epic?

As a whole the *Kalevala* is a series of dramas made up of separate pre-literate poems not connected with one another that proceeds in a logical order but, due to the method of compilation, makes many halts. The longest fall between the second and third cantos, before the last canto and either side of the episodes, when the transition to new subjects has been pointed out. The method explains why certain motifs recur two

or more times, like the wooing of the maiden of Pohjola, the tasks set the wooers, the abduction of the bride, building a boat, making and playing the kantele, combing the river and the sea, and so on. Some of the cantos, on the other hand, are more or less units in themselves. These breaks and motif repetitions could not altogether be avoided without digressing from the source poems and thoroughly reviewing the process of creation, as demanded by the theory of Fr. A. Wolf on how Homer's epics were compiled.

Domenico Comparetti concluded in an extensive study that the only uniformity in the Kalevala is the logic connecting the events, sometimes loosely, sometimes firmly, which every poem must have if it is to be poetry (Comparetti 1892: 314). K. B. Wiklund would like to see some sort of "red line" linking the different parts of the Kalevala together (Wiklund 1901: 28). Rafael Koskimies points out, in speaking of these concepts, that as regards the unity of the Kalevala, normative aesthetics lead nowhere at all, since the unity and entity of the epic do not observe the rules and laws of classical epic theories. The Kalevala's uniformity has its own laws, the most conspicuous and easily perceived being the great trinity: narrative, lyric and incantation (Koskimies 1978: 13, 19, 66). The uniformity of the Kalevala cannot be understood merely as the progress of the narrative, since there is another vital factor that must be taken into account: the mythical life-concept of the epic, in which the incantations and other lyrical poetry also play a dominant role.

The mythical hierarchy of the Kalevala

In an important letter to the translator into French of the first edition of the Kalevala, L. Léouzon Le Duc, dated March 30, 1851, Lönnrot gives a detailed account of the mythical life-concept in the Kalevala.

The cosmogonic basis of the *Kalevala* is concentrated in lines describing the singing of Antero Vipunen (17:541–548):

Lauloi synnyt syitä myöten,
Luottehet lomia myöten,
Kuinka Luojansa luvalla,
Kaikkivallan vaatimalla
Itsestänsä ilma syntyi
Ilmasta vesi erosi,
Veestä manner maatelihe,
Manteresta kasvut kaikki.

He sang the origin charms in the
proper way, the spells correctly,
how by leave of its Creator,
at the Almighty's demand,
the sky was created of itself,
how water separated from the heavens,
how solid land was formed into earth apart from the water,
how on solid ground all growing things sprang up.
(Translation by Francis Peabody Magoun, Jr.)

According to Lönnrot's explanation, there was in the beginning Ukko or the Creator, and he created from nothing the air, which then gave birth to water and the water to Ilmatar, the Spirit of the Air, the first Spirit of Nature. This cosmogony does, in Lönnrot's view, have many points in common with the story of the creation in the Old Testament. The Supreme Creator, the Supreme God, the Almighty, the Old Man in Heaven, etc., who rules over the entire *Kalevala* world is the constant receiver of prayers, and he often intervenes in the lives of men. The Supreme God and the numerous spirits or keepers have Christian overtones, partly as a result of the Biblical origins of these folk counterparts, partly of Lönnrot's life-concept.

Next to the Creator in the mythical hierarchy of the *Kalevala* come the Spirits of Nature; Väinämöinen, born of the former, and Ilmarinen,

also in on the creation as the “heavenly smith”, hold a special status among the characters in the Kalevala because of their supernatural origin. In addition to Ilmatar there were numerous other Spirits of Nature, three of which took part in the origin of iron, and according to Lönnrot’s explanation (Lönnrot 1862: 351) man, too, was originally born of the Spirit of Nature.

The number of minor deities, good and evil spirits is limitless in Kalevala mythology, for there is not a single plant or animal, object or part of it that does not have its own omnipresent spirit, and often these are feminine. This entire band of invisible beings is widely represented in the incantations. In seeking to create as varied and as comprehensive an overall picture of the Kalevala world as possible, Lönnrot considered it vital to devote a considerable amount of space to incantations and charms, which he regarded as holding a dominant position in the life-concept of the epic. Various incantations: to be recited at a birth, in healing all manner of diseases and injuries, spells, prayers connected with farming, tending the cattle, hunting and fishing, the utterances of seers, etc., make up more than 4.000 lines in the epic, or more than one fifth of the total. At the end of the Kalevala Lönnrot gives a list of 53 different incantations encountered in the epic.

The hierarchy of persons in the Kalevala

The hierarchy of mythical beings also has its counterpart at human level. At the top, naturally, stands Väinämöinen, with whom the epic is most concerned. Of the great band of humans, about thirty are specifically mentioned by name or are in some other way identified for description. Most of them bear epithets that follow them throughout the epic, such as “eternal sage” (Väinämöinen), “skilful smith” (Ilmarinen), “reckless” (Lemminkäinen), “golden-haired” (Kullervo), and so on.

These epithets, which do occasionally vary, are used to describe the heroes' social status and characteristics, which seem to have some influence on their fates.

The Väinämöinen of the *Kalevala* is, according to Lönnrot (Lönnrot 1835: xiii—xvi), grave, wise, a man of great wisdom, exceptionally skilled at singing and playing, and a Finnish hero who is not, however, a god. The other heroes closest to Väinämöinen are Ilmarinen, Lemminkäinen and the mistress of Pohjola, who play a major role in the stages of the Sampo. Ilmarinen is described by Lönnrot as a fine smith of iron and other metals, lacking in humour, grave and honest. Lemminkäinen, on the other hand, is reckless, proud, bragging, short-sighted but brave. Louhi, the mistress of Pohjola, is the despotic ruler of the people of Pohja, a woman with a lust for power, a strong will and a desire for revenge.

Most of the other characters markedly display certain human traits or have exceptional fates. The mothers of Lemminkäinen and Kullervo are thus models of self-sacrificing motherly love, Aino of dormant virginity, the maiden of Pohja of proud awareness of her beauty, Joukahainen of the arrogant lust for revenge and the Watery Hatted Herdsman of Pohjola of the all-embracing evil of the cattleherd. Of all the tragic fates that befall the characters in the *Kalevala* the most tragic, being predetermined, is that of Kullervo: born a hero, he is destroyed by the pitiless strokes of fate and his own inner conflicts. Other tragic figures are Kullervo's sister and Joukahainen's sister Aino.

Alongside the main characters there are others who stand out from their immediate circle because of certain individual traits: Lokka, Ilpotar, Osmotar and Annikki, skilled in the affairs of the household, the frivolous Kyllikki of large family, and Lemminkäinen's telltale sister Ainikki, the helpless and submissive master of Pohjola, the brothers Untamo and Kalervo, who hate one another and argue, the warrior Tiera, Marjatta, the giver of "noble birth", and many others. They all help to enrich in many ways the cavalcade of characters passing through the epic.

The message of the Kalevala

In the preface (§ 8) to the Kalevala of 1849 Lönnrot says he considers that the pre-literate Karelian poems noted down by him have their original home in the land of the Permians familiar from historical sources living on the southern shores of the White Sea, and estimates that the Karelians, who lived beyond the eastern borders of Finland, were “the direct descendants of the ancient rich, strong and famous Permian people”. The forefathers of the Karelians, who originally came from the south, around Lake Ladoga, could not, however, have been Permians, and therefore the Permian history, customs and inherited culture mentioned by Lönnrot could not in any way be reflected in Karelian folklore, and certainly could not have their origins there. In view of the way in which it was created, as a work of compilation, the Kalevala cannot tell of the Permians or of any other country or people, for the historical-ethnological reality of the epic is fictive throughout.

Autonomous and visionary, the Kalevala is like a document from another planet — the only source of information on this planet and reporting everything worth knowing. This Kalevala worldview is infinitely rich, just like the pre-literate Karelian poetry from which it is derived, and the poet has forced its historical-ethnological reality, mythology, poetry, figures of speech and syntax into the confines of one great epic in Kalevala language. A universal and cosmogonic epic, the Kalevala is unique in the literature of Europe.

The Kalevala is an epic born of poetry, and should chiefly be interpreted as an allegorical work. The Sampo and the explanation Lönnrot gives it play such a central part that they constitute a natural point of departure. In this respect the Kalevala is an archaic story in poetry of mankind’s constant striving and fight for lasting material well-being and eternal happiness, achievable only through civilisation and culture. The people of Kaleva and Pohja do not represent primitiveness in this development, for with their varied occupations, highly-developed social systems and multitheistic religious concepts they

already stand for a diverse culture. The fundamental message of the Kalevala to mankind comes at the end of the epic in Väinämöinen's prophesy that he will one day return to make a new Sampo and new music. In this prophesy Lönnrot brings out in allegorical form the firm faith that the great seers and sages and the culture created by them are the unshakeable foundation for the eternal happiness of mankind.

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The Kalevala: The Processual View

The Kalevala has been and still is approached from three levels: as a folk epic, as Lönnrot's epic and as a national epic. We might call them the levels of folkloristics, literature and cultural policy. Whichever level we operate at, we are always confronted with three interwoven skeins of problems: the authenticity of the epic, the interpretation of the epic and the cultural identity represented by the epic. The formulation of the questions and the nature of the answers vary according to whether the emphasis is on the folk poetry on which the Kalevala is founded, the creative contribution made by Lönnrot, or the community that ordered and claimed ownership of the epic. The various approaches and problems tend more often to intermingle rather than to stand apart in the debate on the Kalevala. A typical example is the controversy over which — the written Kalevala or the oral folk poetry — should be proffered and with what interpretation as the reflection of the Finnish identity. Inconclusive debate easily finds itself fenced in by national values and taboos. The relatively slender cadres of Kalevala research are not sufficient to ensure that the debate is constantly guided by new, weighty findings.

Let us now survey the entire Kalevala process from the three angles of authenticity, interpretation and identity, and begin by sketching each one in turn.

The *folk epic* angle is seldom touched upon by contemporary research, even though this was what interested people most on the publication of the Kalevala. When they realised that no extensive oral epic ever in fact existed, and that the work of Lönnrot could not be regarded as

one of reconstruction, they began to ask instead whether the Kalevala was in fact authentic. What was Lönnrot's method, and what was the precise source-critical relationship between folk poetry and the epic? Does the edited text preserve the style and the message of the folk poetry? As far as comparative epic research is concerned, the Kalevala is in any case a folklore epic and cannot as such be compared to the purely literary epics. Is it a mere curiosity in epic literature — an exceptional case? Or does the Kalevala have counterparts elsewhere? How important is the fact that the exact sources and origins of the Kalevala are known? Does Lönnrot come closer to Homer or to Virgil, the great singer or the epic poet, or should he be placed on a par with the collector-editor-publishers of living oral epics?

The view of the Kalevala as *Lönnrot's epic* has won more and more support. The mask concealing a man of studied or naturally humble bearing is being drawn aside to reveal a determined and even ambitious epic poet fettered by the bonds of the folk epic theory crystallised by the Romantics but never content to become a mere publisher of poetic texts. Source criticism of the Kalevala is joined by analysis of the concepts and goals adopted by Lönnrot. Whereas folkloristic source criticism seeks to unearth the cultural foundations or folk materials supporting the Kalevala, analysis of the written opus is focused on Lönnrot's own interpretation. Distinct from these, as it were, is the purely text-oriented aesthetic assessment of the Kalevala. The classical path through the interpretation of the Kalevala and folk poetry — “historical or mythical?” — needs constant weeding, and this applies just as much to Lönnrot himself.

The position of the Kalevala as a *national epic* is undisputed. Even so the question “right or wrong identity?” may for various reasons suddenly become topical. Karelian culture did, it may be pointed out, lie on the periphery of Finnish folk culture, so how could the Finnish majority possibly grasp the essence of, say, the way of life of a tribe the far side of the border — the Karelians? Or did the fact that old poetry in the so-called Kalevala metre flourished most on both sides

of the Finnish/Russian border make it function as a cultural bridge or common code between Finns and Karelians in its original setting? Was the cultural threshold to understanding the Kalevala still too high even as the Finnish language became more firmly established and commentaries on the epic were made available? Questions such as these force us to examine the accommodating role assumed by Lönnrot from an angle other than one of folkloristic authenticity: how consciously did he set about making the Kalevala more universally Finnish? We may for the sake of comparison also examine the selection of identity symbols in other cultures, too, and see whether nations have a predilection for symbols close to the real culture of the majority, or whether they are just as likely to choose ideal images rooted in a hypothetical past. One of the tests of a national epic is a national crisis: does the nation turn to it in times of national uncertainty, and in what way? Or to put it more mildly: is it of any help in building a new identity or in identity negotiation under pressure from other national, regional or group identities? The direct link between the birth of the Kalevala and the national identity crisis that paved the way for it seems to answer the question of intellectual ownership, even though this is not entirely straightforward. It is interesting to observe the geography of the epic: most of the poetic material in the Kalevala came from a rather narrow border zone between Finland and Karelia and it cannot be regarded as, for example, universally Karelian.

The Kalevala process in the broader sense of the word has its origins in the 1760s in Henrik Gabriel Porthan's encouragement of the collection of Finnish folk poetry and above all in his recognition of its literary value. The end of the Kalevala process is still not in sight: so long as the Kalevala is read and referred to, the process will continue. Taken as a whole this process is by no means the only example but it is a fine example of the discovery, use and influence of folklore on the shaping of cultural identity. Its study is in fact multi-disciplinarian and a task for not only epic research or folkloristics but also for comparative cultural research and the history of culture and ideas.

The discovery from outside

The discoverers of folklore are usually outsiders. In its native environment folklore is in many ways an inherent part of the life of society and does not as a rule attract attention to itself among its users as being specifically folklore, as genres of tradition complying with given stylistic norms. To the member of the tradition community folklore is above all a form of communication, a body of messages open to interpretation. He does not discern any border between folklore and non-folklore in the same way as an outsider, since for him tradition is always an organic part of some broader entity and some actual behavioural situation. Tradition is not a problem since sufficient competence exists for its use. The outsider, who either partly or completely lacks this competence, is incapable of communicating through the given tradition, but he does introduce a new intellectual interest. The motive for this may be sought in vain from within the tradition community.

The cornerstone of Finnish and Swedish folklore collection is the decree signed by Gustav II Adolf in May 1630, containing detailed instructions for the recording of relics of the past. They bear the exhortation to inquire into “all manner of chronicles and narratives, time-honoured legends and poems about dragons, gnomes and giants — likewise tales of celebrated persons, old monasteries, castles, and dwelling places of kings and towns, so that we may discover what used to be, the old poems about heroes and incantations, not forgetting their melodies” (Sarajas 1956: 325). This collection programme was not, however, a sign of interest in living tradition and its genres. The interest of knowledge was antiquarian: an interest was taken in folk tradition if it was believed to be a means of shedding light on the way of life, occupations, settlement, rulers and pagan religion of ancient times. The motive for curiosity is revealed in the arguments for the decree, which manifest a desire to prove “that our ancestors were not barbarians”, “that we are the oldest of nations” and “that our language is the oldest of all”, and there is concern at the Danes’ attempt to appropriate this

honour for themselves. The decree of Gustav II Adolf was a reaction to the summons sent by King Christian IV of Denmark to the bishops of Denmark and Norway in 1622 concerning the collecting of Danish antiquities. Lurking in the background was the need to reinforce the national identity and to rank high among nations.

This, in a nutshell, is the story of the discovery of folk poetry two hundred years before the publication of the *Kalevala*. The discovery of tradition is usually followed by its transfer to some other use, archives, publication, as an instrument of cultural policy. The *Kalevala*, too, is the result of precisely one such transfer of tradition. The administrative or cultural elite setting the collection of tradition in motion also bears the responsibility for the new use of the tradition in an environment quite unlike that in which it existed before its discovery.

The problem of the transmission of tradition

The transfer of tradition so common in modern folklore does, it seems, always raise questions of authenticity, as regards both the context of its performance and the cultural identity it represents. It is in fact necessary to distinguish the “second life” of folklore from the first, in which it is a natural part of a broader tradition system and not necessarily very easy to identify. This first life (the one the folklorists like most to study) ends with the documentation of tradition. Texts and images are detached from their background and left to lie dormant, no longer having any influence on the further development of the tradition in question. Archive material is in this respect dead and ineffective: it joins the queue waiting for the beginning of a “second life” — getting taken into use again, published, performed, recycled.

The problem of this “second life” is its false context, its false performer. This is one reason for the call for the safeguarding of folklore: tradition presented falsely or in the wrong context may offend

against the identity of the community that produced it and/or recognises it as its own. Whether or not this is the reaction (it does, after all, presuppose emancipation, an awareness of tradition, of identity and of course an ability to take action on the part of the folklore community), the problem of authenticity remains for a long time to come, at least until the tradition in question has become completely adapted to its new use and environment. As far as scientific research is concerned, this period of “quarantine” often far exceeds the time of adaption the users of the tradition deem necessary: researchers and archivists are more interested in the original folklore communities than in the target communities. The much discussed concept of “folklorism” often has a pejorative ring to it, for it suggests the false recycling of tradition or quasi-tradition, fictitious or misplaced elements aspiring to the status of folklore. There has been very little debate on the correct recycling of tradition.

The course mapped out by Porthan

The Kalevala may, in the light of the history of ideas, appear to be a late blossoming of Romanticism. It cannot be denied that Romanticism did indeed influence the very conception of the Kalevala, but it was not the birth-giving factor as such. For there existed two other basic conditions, one cultural-historical, the other political, without which the idea of an epic would scarcely have crystallised and taken shape. The cultural-historical condition was the interest in the collection of Finnish folklore sparked off by Mikael Agricola in the 16th century and the 17th century summons by Gustav II Adolf quoted above. It gained considerably more weight in the work of Henrik Gabriel Porthan in the latter half of the 18th century. The early collections satisfied the needs of the Reformation, historiography, the so-called economic-historical descriptions of provinces and the budding science of ethnography:

the value of folk poetry lay in the factual information it was believed to impart. We can already discern here the thirst for history which, amid the changes of the 19th century, prompted not only the Finns but many other young and “historyless” nations of Europe to look upon folklore as an untapped resource (Honko 1980: 61–62).

We need go no further back in the prehistory of the Kalevala than to the 1760s and the publication of Porthan’s *Dissertatio de poesi Fennica* (1766–1778). Despite all the work done by collectors, news of the genres of folk poetry and the areas in which they were to be found was slow to spread in Finland: one reason for this was that the learned circles had a poor command of Finnish and had little contact with the easternmost corners of the realm to which the archaic epic poetry had receded. Not until the age of Porthan, and greatly to his credit, did people become sufficiently aware that folk poetry preserved as oral tradition (and art poetry in the same style) was in fact a more valuable part of literature in Finnish than any other poetry printed in Finnish up to that date. The crucial point was that Porthan spoke of the value of folk poetry specifically as poetry and as part of Finnish literature: indigenous poetry ceased to be a collection of academic curiosities and entered the strongholds of book-learning as the representative of the poetic muse, styles and genres. The turning point is especially significant in view of the fact that the bulk of Finnish folk poetry at that time still remained to be discovered, and Romanticism had not yet begun to exert its influence. When Porthan was working on his *Dissertation*, Herder, for example, was only a young man of 22 just embarking on his literary career, and many years were to pass before the *Volkslieder* appearing in 1778 was mentioned in the writings of the Turku scholars.

There is indeed justification for calling Porthan ‘the father of Finnish folklore research’: many of his observations seemed to anticipate subsequent scientific views, and his principles for publishing material leave little room for criticism. He insisted that poems must be published as they were noted down, and that they must be equipped with the

necessary details of where they came from. Looking ahead to the Kalevala, his most important hypothesis was as follows:

It is no wonder that such old monuments in particular, relying solely on memory, which so easily fails, inevitably get spoiled, becoming more and more obscure and in many places scarcely comprehensible. Added to which, most poems purposely present the mythical origins in very mysterious terms. What is more, the nature of ancient Finnish mythology is almost unknown to us today. It is therefore laborious to explain the tasks and characteristics of the old, oft-mentioned heathen gods, to say nothing of references to already forgotten institutions and customs of our forefathers. This great obscurity makes it extremely difficult to find just the right interpretation among all these variants. Experience has, however, taught me that it is somehow possible, by comparing a number of variants, to restore poems as entities and to give them a more appropriate form. Therefore let no one be surprised if the examples given below do not in every respect fully correspond to the variants that may happen to be at hand. For I have taken from one variant what is missing from another, and estimating individual points in accordance with the rules of text criticism, I have where possible tried to present them in their entirety. I nevertheless regarded it as being in order to retain the interpolations added since the assimilation of the Christian faith. I shall also be mentioning noteworthy variants that are in some way exceptional. I have, however, given preference to variants that do not look as defective as others and that furthermore help us to some extent to understand the customs and opinions of our ancestors. (Porthan 1983: 92.)

Many another scholar and publisher of folk poetry variants was to come to similar conclusions in the century to follow; and herein lies one of the basic premises of the geographical-historical method of folklore research. It nevertheless seems right to limit the potential of “patching” to the minimum in the case of Porthan and his pupils: they were the budding, critically conscientious publishers whose vision

extended only so far as producing a representative selection of different folk poems. This was the course mapped out by Porthan, still adhered to by Zachris Topelius the elder but diverged from by Elias Lönnrot.

Porthan's view was backed by the changing and increasingly international concept of literature prevailing in Europe, news of which was brought to Turku first from France and later from the British Isles (Sarajas 1956: 229–232). One crucial feature of the change was the lowering of the threshold between folk poetry and art poetry. The poems of Ossian were already being widely discussed in the 1770s (Sarajas 1956: 351–352), and Porthan stood up in defence of Macpherson from the very beginning, deeming that he had merely arranged the poems and did not compose them himself. His own experience did, it seems, lead him to believe in the possibility of a broader epic entity made up of separate poems. This was the closest Porthan and his circle ever got to the idea of an epic.

Identity crisis: an epic is ordered

The dealings with folk poetry of Porthan and his colleagues were of course of a purely academic nature: they laid the foundations for an epic but did not exactly anticipate one. It remained for some quite different event to create from these leanings and the Romanticism that was sweeping Europe the potential for the birth of an epic at that particular stage in Finnish history. In this case that something was the war of 1808–1809 that severed Finland from 700 years of allegiance to Sweden and made her an autonomous grand duchy under the Russian Tsar. The close ties with Swedish culture were severed, the way lay open to the kindred peoples living in Russia, and the first Finnish Diet set the Finns thinking about a Finland that was more than a mere collection of Swedish or Russian provinces. The result was an identity crisis. The Swedish-speaking educated circles appeared to have two

alternatives: they either had to turn towards Russian culture or to identify with the language of the majority and its underdeveloped culture. They chose the latter, even though it meant a dramatic change of language and the laborious building of a new identity. At this stage Finland became a real developing country. The Finnish language had to be raised from its inferior position and made the language of culture, literature in Finnish had to be created, material collected for a new species of Finnish history. This task was undertaken by a Swedish-speaking but Finnish-minded intelligentsia. Progress was slow, and after many intermediate stages achieved its ultimate results only after the school reform in the latter half of the century and with the new generation.

The idea of the *Kalevala* belonged to the initial stage of this development. In the first decade of the new nation, the 1810s, the Turku students read their Herder, rediscovered the almost forgotten legacy of Porthan, and argued the problems of constructing a national identity and culture. They never dreamt of political independence above and beyond autonomy, but they were aware of the importance of creating basic assets founded on an original culture. One burning issue was the absence of a literature in the vernacular to compare with that of Europe. In this respect Finland lagged behind: this is immediately apparent even today on reading any history of western literature, for Finland is not mentioned until very late, much later than many European nations which it has nowadays overtaken in both the economic and the cultural spheres. And literature lay at the heart of identity — it was no isolated problem. Had not Herder once said: “A poet is the creator of the nation around him, he gives them a world to see and has their souls in his hand to lead them to that world” (Irmischer 1974: 800)?

This being the case, folk poetry presented itself as a lifeline well worth considering. A model for debate was found in, for example, the opinions of Herder on the state of German literature, which he considered poor because it had lost contact with the spiritual world of the true people. Homer and Shakespeare were great because they were folk

poets, and England was great because it had its Shakespeare, a literary genius constantly drawing fresh ideas from myths, ballads and legends. Herder had no time for the literature aimed at “the housewives of the capital”: it had nothing whatsoever to do with the people, because the people were peasants and craftsmen, the subservient classes, but also a bourgeoisie promising independent progress and strength. The folk also embraced the illiterate savages of distant cultures, for they had in their oral poetry risen to heights that made them brothers to the European peasant. The folk was the antithesis of the alienated elite, and folk poetry was the tie joining together the countless cultures of mankind. Folk songs were “the nation’s archive”, “the soul of the people” and “the living voice of nationalities” (Wilson 1976: 30) — and the best mirror of both the ordinary and the unique. Folk singers were thus the best interpreters of the nation’s mentality.

The giant paradox of Romanticism was the idolisation of the people — even though the people were in reality remote — the view of the people as creative and active — though they were in reality subordinated and passive (Honko 1980: 62). The interest of the Finnish peasant in the affairs of state or national culture at the beginning of the 19th century hardly bears mentioning; with the possible exception of the religious revivalist movements, intellectual influence travelled in one direction only — downwards. Many decades were to pass before the men to put the Romantically-minded national manifesto into practice were to emerge from where, it was assumed, the new resources lay hidden. For the time being they were members of the elite. Even so the paradox operated extremely well in Finland, because the people, uneducated though they were, possessed the most important of all attributes — language. Once again folk poetry acted as proof of the literary merits and potential of that language at a time when it had not really become accepted as a medium of civilisation.

It is also thanks to Romanticism that attention was turned on the epic. The worldview of the Romanticists was strongly evolutionist, and the roots and models of cultural evolution lay in Antiquity. Particularly stimulating was the mystery of Homer, the fact that the best epic in

world literature was the product of an oral tradition (e. g. Schlegel 1796: 220–225; see Behler 1979: 122–126). This created the paradigm for development: first came the epic, and only then the lyric and drama. When the Turku Romanticists, above all the university students A. I. Arwidsson, A. J. Sjögren, A. Poppius and C. A. Gottlund, urged one another to collect and publish folklore, they initially had in mind an anthology of representative samples of folk poetry. They knew very little, however, about the existence and potential of materials, even though they were familiar with the preliminary work carried out by Porthan and others.

The man most familiar with the living poetry tradition was, perhaps, Gottlund, for he had been collecting himself in Eastern Finland. While studying at Uppsala he had also been in contact with the Swedish Romanticists, who were in many respects truer disciples of literary Romanticism than the Finns. It is surely no coincidence that Gottlund was the man to put forward the idea of a Finnish epic in an article written in 1817: “If someone were to collect the old folk songs and to make of them an organised entity, be it an epic, a drama or whatever, he could make of them a new Homer, Ossian or Nibelungenlied; and Finnish nationalism would be aroused, conscious of itself, adorned by the splendour and honour of its unique nature and the halo of its own development, for the admiration of both the present-day world and posterity” (Hautala 1954: 97). In other words: an epic would provide the longed-for self-esteem and prestige. And the fairy godmothers present at its birth would be the earliest epic singers. At this stage Gottlund probably did not have any very precise idea how the epic should be put together. Nor do we know whether he or any of the other Romanticists at Turku were familiar with the poetic theory abroad on the continent of Europe, especially among Homer scholars, attributed from 1795 onwards to F. A. Wolf, though even before him it had been put forward in the 17th century by Abbot Francois Hédelin d’Aubignac (Schadewaldt 1959: 11–12; de Vries 1963: 2–3). According to this theory epics are born of the songs created by different poets, which are put together by an epic poet of genius to form a uniform

entity. The idea of an epic was in any case in the air and within reach of many, as is also evident from the fact that Lönnrot, for example, was probably not familiar with the article by Gottlund.

Three generations stand at the head of the Kalevala process: Porthan and his colleagues, the Romantic students at Turku and finally the executors of the nationalist policy. The emergence of this third generation coincided symbolically with the year 1822, when three students enrolled at the University of Turku: J. V. Snellman, J. L. Runeberg and Elias Lönnrot. Who could have guessed that here were the three chief architects of the Finnish identity — the chief ideologist, the leading poet and the creator of the national epic?

Lönnrot was introduced to the world of folk poetry by his teacher of Finnish at the University of Turku, Reinhold von Becker. In 1820 Becker had published an article in a journal on Väinämöinen, the central character in Finnish narrative poetry, attempting to gather together the fragmentary information provided by different poems and thus to obtain an overall concept of a figure that seemed to bear features of a great man, a king and a demi-god. Von Becker concluded that Väinämöinen was a great historical figure. This historical view was assimilated by Lönnrot, and it was a view that was to remain with him for life. Lönnrot had, it would appear, already come into contact with Homeric research as a student; some claim that he may while at the University have come across the theory on the origin of Homeric epics (e. g. Kaukonen 1979: 50) which, thanks to F. A. Wolf, fell like a bombshell amid the Romantic epic proponents. The interest in folklore of Porthan and Ganander also caught his attention at an early date. But it was in the folk poetry publication of Zachris Topelius the elder that Lönnrot found an important practical pointer: the mysterious, northerly Karelia, where epic poetry still existed in all its splendour, began to exert its pull. When death put an end to Topelius's work, Lönnrot began to feel his turn had come to try to fulfill the desire expressed by many, and claimed to be vital, of a representative publication of Finnish folk poetry.

A journey into the reality of the rune singers

In 1828 Lönnrot began his collecting expeditions. These took him first to Finnish Karelia and then to Archangel Karelia beyond the border, where the Karelian dialect was very close to Finnish, not least because a great part of the population had originally come from the Finnish side of the border. On completing his medical studies Lönnrot accepted a post in Kajaani to be closer to the best regions for collecting poems. Severe epidemics and the lack of physicians curbed his plans for collecting poems, and he often had to wrestle with his conscience, debating whether he had the right to squander his time on these secondary projects, however important they might be for Finnish language and literature. The Finnish Literature Society, established in 1831, began supporting Lönnrot's work through grants. As regards the process of giving form to the Kalevala, the journeys Lönnrot made in 1832–1837 to the regions beyond the border were the most important. Each journey could, at least in theory, change the composition of the forthcoming epic.

What did Lönnrot find on his journeys? He found poems, their singers and the living environments where the poems were used between daily toil and on festive occasions. The variants known from the collectors' manuscripts now became a living stream of poems, flowing from the lips of dozens, and later hundreds of singers. It was rewarding to hear a poem sung after having pondered over it at a desk. In a way the text of the poem became more complete and gained a new meaning: it was now surrounded by living culture. It was shattering to find a poem, then another, and a third which no one had recorded before. Poems which had been known in fragments came up in a more extensive form and could be connected with other poems into sequences of hundreds of verses. The poetic tradition seemed to be in constant movement; the main characters could change: in a given region the poems were centred around one hero, in another region the hero was quite another. The poems could be continued or added to, which linked

them to quite different types of poetry: wedding songs, charms and lyrical songs. One singer kept the poems clear and in good order, another tended to blend them into each other, and yet another knew them only in fragments.

What Lönnrot encountered was living verse material, productive stylistic devices like the metre of the ancient poems, the four-foot trochaic metre, alliteration and repetition with its complicated but learnable rules, countless formulae and clichés, whose uses seemed to be endless, the plot constructions, which could offer the basis now for a limited, now for a more extensive version of the same subject matter, and finally the variations in plot development and the different ways of linking one theme to another. In a word: Lönnrot stepped into a world of living epic poetry, his mind recorded not only the content of the poems but also the whole varied but strictly restricted verse language on which the whole poetry lived. Without his mastery of that language the peculiar genesis of the *Kalevala* would not have been possible.

These qualitative factors relating to the life of the poems were of crucial importance. But we must also keep in mind the purely quantitative outcome which by the summer of 1834 was in itself respectable: Lönnrot had collected approximately 25.700 lines of poetry sung in the ancient Finnish metre; until then only 10.000 lines had been published (Kaukonen 1979: 59). Poems constituted only a fragment of his total collection, since he also recorded folktales, riddles, proverbs, laments, etc., as well as material connected with folk custom and above all with the language. Even after completing his *Kalevala* he still worked for another 35 years on his great dictionary and the publication of different folklore tracts.

For Lönnrot it was the poems and not the people that mattered. He did learn to adapt to different environments, to enter into relationships with people and to avoid any behaviour that could endanger the success of his collection. His modesty and simple manners have given rise to a whole tradition of anecdotes. Yet we have to remember that Lönnrot's journeys were short, of only some weeks', at the most months', duration, and that most of his time was spent travelling from one place to

another. He appears to have stayed nowhere for very long; he probably did not record the whole repertoire of any singer of note. There is no evidence that Lönnrot was deeply interested in the context in which the poems were used or in the lives and fates of the rune singers. As a rule he did not even record the names of the singers in his notebook. Exceptions were such key informants as Juhana Kainulainen, Ontrei Malinen, Vaassila Kieleväinen and Arhippa Perttunen, whose views on the time sequence of the events in the epic poems were important to the Lönnrot aiming at an epic.

Lönnrot and the rune singers thus kept a considerable cultural distance from one another. Despite his modest social background Lönnrot belonged to an elite with a different culture, different thoughts and goals from the people who provided the poems. He came to know folk life, but he also spent time in parsonages. He attended peasant weddings, but only as an observer and guest. The Finland and Karelia of folk songs were to him a succession of passing landscapes, people, situations and events that provided him with verse material and filled pages of his journal. He liked to wear peasant clothes and to lead a simple life, but still no one could mistake him for a peasant. In his rucksack he had poems he had written on the theme of homesickness.

The fact that Lönnrot did not identify with any area or community that he encountered was both understandable and important; understandable in that he was primarily interested not in modern folk life but in the ancient Finnish society of which it possibly still bore traces, important in the sense that he was freer to create a poetic world of his own which represented the entire tradition as conceived by himself and not a system of tradition as conceived by a single family of singers or by one singer. Seen against the scientific norms of today, the method he used could be called superficial, but such a claim loses its validity when we remember that Lönnrot subconsciously reserved and needed time for the process of integrating the results obtained. In his relation to the most important singers he met, he kept his attitude of apprentice almost to the end, until the first edition of the *Kalevala* was published.

Return to the reality of the compiler

The Kalevala process can, in the narrow sense as the process that took place in Lönnrot's mind, be restricted to the years 1828–1862. This rules out the stimuli, extremely important in themselves, of his student years, and his publication of folklore after the three Kalevalas. The period does embrace the preliminary work on and variants of the Kalevala, beginning with his compilation of the first Kantele booklets and ending with the abridged edition of the Kalevala for schools. Elias Lönnrot was not a folklore collector in the conventional sense of the word. He did not rescue valuable material, to be stored in an archive for some non-specified purpose. His work had a concrete goal: publication. The collection of oral poetry served this goal and ended once the publication was complete. The achievements of other collectors were important only insofar as they were of immediate use in the epic on hand. There are few indications that Lönnrot ever seriously considered doing more collection above and beyond his own powers or the needs of the Kalevala (see, however, Anttila 1931: 315); others were more concerned than he was. Lönnrot did, however, take careful note of the often critical comments expressed on the Kalevala; he invited advice and was in principle at least ready to share the responsibility with both the rune singers and his friends or the dignitaries at the Finnish Literature Society. The criticism put forward did have an influence on the Kalevala, but it was Lönnrot who made the decisions.

The four Kantele booklets dating from 1829–1831 are more relevant to Lönnrot's method than to the idea of the epic. Using these constraints, we have five variants of the Kalevala: 1) three separate unpublished poetry sequences, Lemminkäinen (825 lines) dating from summer 1833, Väinämöinen (1867 lines) and the Wedding Lays (499 lines) from October 1833; 2) the likewise unpublished Collected Songs About Väinämöinen or the Proto-Kalevala (16 cantos, 5.052 lines) from November 1833; 3) the Kalevala, or Old Karelian Poems about the Ancient Times of the Finnish People, i. e. the Old Kalevala (32 cantos, 12.078

lines) from 1835–1836, 4) the Kalevala or the New Kalevala (50 cantos, 22.795 lines) from 1849 and 5) the abridged edition of the Kalevala (50 cantos, 9.732 lines) from 1862.

Even in the Kantele booklets Lönnrot was already handling the poetry more freely than Porthan in his day or Zachris Topelius the elder, who published an anthology of his own at about the same time. In the foreword to the booklets Lönnrot provides information on where the poems were collected, but the poems themselves were edited by combining pieces of different variants, by patching a gap in one with a line from another. Only three of the poems are as written down in the field. In any case the poems were published separately and more or less as products of their native region. It looked for a while as if Lönnrot would go no further than this.

While editing the material not published in the Kantele booklets he nevertheless changed his mind. He began to combine the poems about Lemminkäinen and Kaukomieli, surmising, like Topelius, that these were one and the same person (Kaukonen 1979: 41). The result was a chain of poems presented by different singers and linked together by lines from authentic runes to cover the gaps and smooth over the seams. The finished result was not very different from the sequences presented by certain rune singers who tried to group different themes to form a more or less logical, uniform chain. In Lönnrot's hands the sequence nevertheless lost its home, for the lines were from variants taken from different regions. Inspired by a successful collection trip made in the meantime, Lönnrot put together two more sequences in October 1833, one about Väinämöinen and the other about wedding ceremonies.

All the principles for the publication of folklore adhered to so far had now finally been discarded, but still the sequence technique seemed to be leading nowhere: there were not enough poems about a single character, nor was the plot structure entirely satisfactory. The decisive change in the technique of compilation came in November 1833, when Lönnrot compiled the more than 5.000 lines of the Collected Songs About Väinämöinen. The earlier sequences were still of such propor-

tions that a gifted singer could memorise and present them; the same could no longer be said. True, entities far longer than this have in fact been found in certain oral epic traditions of the world, but their performance is broken down into a number of parts, some of which are more popular than others. There are, however, no indications of sequences of more than a thousand lines in the Karelian rune tradition.

The Collected Songs About Väinämöinen are called the Proto-Kalevala because they already contain the basic plot of the Kalevala: the two stories of the forging and stealing of the Sampo, a miraculous object bringing material prosperity, are separated from one another and interspersed with the poems about the wooing contest, the wedding at Pohjola and the isolated Lemminkäinen and Kullervo cycles. The basic contrast running through the Kalevala, the competition and battle between the peoples of Kalevala and Pohjola, also begins to take shape when the mistress of Pohjola and her beautiful daughter are placed in antithesis to the Kalevala heroes led by Väinämöinen. Even so the plot still contained inconsistencies which Lönnrot later amended.

Scholars have debated whether the technique of compilation of the embryo epic was influenced by a specific image, the Homeric model in the form postulated by Wolf. Did Lönnrot already liken himself to Homer even at this stage? Theory has it that no Homer ever in fact existed, and that 'Homer' was simply a group of epic folk poems originating in different ways that were put together to form an epic in the days of Peisistratus in the latter half of the 5th century B. C. (Schadewaldt 1959: 9–24; most recently in Finland Kaukonen 1979: 49–50). At around the time he published the New Kalevala, Lönnrot was already openly comparing his work to the birth of the Homeric epics (Lönnrot 1849; see af Forselles 1908: 228), but how familiar was he with what scholars on the continent were writing about Romantic epic theory in autumn 1833? It seems unlikely that he would have read in the original such writers as Friedrich Schlegel, who applied the Wolfian view to Romantic literary theory (Behler 1979: clii–clv; Schlegel 1796). Even presuming his command of languages posed no obstacles, the difference in temperament certainly did. S. G. Elmgren mentions that Lönnrot once said of German works that "there were only

one or two pages of real content per volume” (Elmgren 1884: 20). Lönnrot might, of course, have heard whispers of the Romantic epic debate via other routes. Homer’s example was, however, so readily at hand that Lönnrot had no need to approach it via the theorists.

There were probably a number of models. In a letter to H. Cajander dated 3.12.1833 Lönnrot stated that his aim was “a collection corresponding to approximately half of Homer” (af Forselles 1911: 170), and writing to J. G. Linsén on 6.2.1834 he spoke of “a considerable collection of previously unpublished mythological poems” he had obtained the previous autumn in Russian Karelia and of the idea that had occurred to him of arranging these and poems he had collected earlier to produce “a Finnish mythology something like the Icelandic Edda” (af Forselles 1911: 187). In the same letter he doubted whether the work of editing should be undertaken by one or more, “because future generations will perhaps come to value such a collection as highly as the Geats the Edda or the Greeks and Romans if not Homer, then at least Hesiod”. This multiplicity of models raises the question of whether Lönnrot envisaged both a fixed epic (Homer) and a sort of mythological encyclopedia (Theogonia, Edda). The latter model in any case best explains the steady process by which the Kalevala was expanded and at the same time exonerates Lönnrot from the criticism aimed at the lack of uniformity in the plot.

The method used in compiling the Old Kalevala is better suited to Wolfian song theory than to the Romantic theory of the original folk epic by which the ancient epics were thought to have evolved collectively, ‘untouched by human hand’ (the theory of “das Volk dichtet” founded on Herder was developed by e. g. A. W. Schlegel and Jacob Grimm, see Wilson 1976: 236 and Friedman 1961: 250). It was in fact the latter view that prevailed in Lönnrot’s day, and it forced him to seek signs at least of a broader, even though disintegrated plot structure. At times he believed he was already on the tracks of a structure. In his letter to Cajander he says: “The poems in my possession have now been arranged in the order an old man partly sang, partly told me about Väinämöinen, and they amount to 16 whole songs.” Lönnrot was referring to Vaassila Kieleväinen. He had expressed some ideas on the

temporal order of the events in the narrative poems, and Lönnrot apparently took him seriously, even though Vaassila was past his prime as a singer and had a poor memory. Väinö Kaukonen in fact calls the notes taken down at Vaassila's "minutes of the meeting". It would appear that Lönnrot overrated Vaassila, but he did have other encouraging guides, too, such as Ontrei Malinen, who on that very same journey sang him the 366-line Sampo cycle combining a number of poems (Niemi 1898: 135–146; Kaukonen 1979: 45, 50). In his letter to Linsén Lönnrot mentions "the many prose narratives I happened to hear from old people in the Government of Archangel that dealt with the same heroic deeds" and "gave me some sort of a lead" (af Forselles 1911: 187). The reference may be to Vaassila, but Lönnrot probably also talked to others, but no detailed records remain. In April 1834 Arhippa Perttunen in Latvajärvi sang poems to Lönnrot for three days "in good order, without any noticeable gaps" (af Forselles 1911: 210). Most of them were quite new, never collected before, and Lönnrot congratulated himself on his discovery, surmising that they would no longer be available anywhere else.

Latvajärvi marked the culmination of the hunt for an ancient epic and the birth of the Kalevala. As far as possible Lönnrot wanted to share the responsibility with the best rune singers, but he sensed that the ultimate responsibility would lie with him. Arhippa was the end of the road — it was possible to go no further. Here was the limitation of the folk epic: relatively full-bodied poems that seemed to have some sort of mutual logic. This was no ancient epic; it was poetry telling of ancient times.

Reception creates the epic

Lönnrot has collected a wealth of 'poems' among the Finns living in the Government of Archangel, and in putting them together he has made the significant observation that there exists a great, complete,

mythical national epic, divided by its collector into thirty-two songs chiefly dealing with the valiant deeds and fates of Väinämöinen. Taking endless trouble, yet gaining sweet reward on the successful completion of his work, the astute arranger and discoverer has fitted together fragments of this ancient Finnish poetry and thus rescued it from being irretrievably lost, or rather: he has brought to light something that, in shattered fragments, was already shrouded in oblivion. (Haavio 1949: 240.)

These words were spoken by J. G. Linsén at the annual meeting of the Finnish Literature Society in 1835, at a time when no one had yet seen the epic in its final form. The *Kalevala* was not completed and ready for sale until early the following year. Study of the reception accorded the *Kalevala* has to recognise that people had heard about the *Kalevala* and knew what it was long before they knew what was in it. Even before it was published, the work was classified in a flash as a folk epic and a national epic. What were the grounds for the certainty and perspicacity? Had Elias Lönnrot himself possibly given grounds for such lofty expectations in his letters from Kajaani? It is generally true to say that no one can consciously sit down to write a national epic, for it is the community receiving the epic that gives it its value, and often only after a long period of time. There have, however, been cases in which high expectations have been sustained of an epic poet. This applied to Virgil and Lönnrot, for example. Lönnrot's letters do nothing to reinforce the concept that he "discovered an epic": he merely spoke of a "collection" and its organisation according to the materials and indications provided by the rune singers. We may, however, discern in them signs of growing pressure and anxiety at the responsibility placed on one man's shoulders. Lönnrot's aim had been known for years, though no one had any precise picture of what the future work would be like. The project was treated with the same respect that was usually bestowed on folk poetry in the Romantic era. In precisely the letter to Linsén Lönnrot expresses his awareness of the value posterity may place on his work. He announces that he intends to submit the manuscript to

the Finnish Literature Society “just as a draft for it to scrutinise”, because he is not sure “whether the whole attempt to organise mythical poems into a single entity should be the work of one or perhaps more” (af Forselles 1911: 187). These words are not an expression of false modesty, nor of any fear of criticism on the part of the Society. Lönnrot realised that the expectations in keeping with Romantic epic theory that had been hovering in the air for at least a couple of decades would be focused on the folk poetry epic. He felt it would be a great advantage if there were more than one person who understood the true nature of the venture and more people to share the responsibility.

Linsén, however, had neither the time nor the need to apprehend the anxiety behind Lönnrot’s words. He had never collected any folklore, nor was he familiar with the folk culture in which it existed. Like many of his contemporaries he therefore resorted to the Romantic concept of the epic in assessing the results of Lönnrot’s work. This permitted him to view the Kalevala as an epic broken up into scattered splinters which, if duly put back together again, would be able to throw light on the ancient times, customs and belief of the Finns. No single person, neither Lönnrot nor the rune singers, had any decisive part to play in creating the epic, for it was created by ‘the people’, that cultivator of the earliest language of mankind — poetry.

Such preconceived ideas acted as an obstacle to an awareness of the true nature of Lönnrot’s work. Lönnrot became a compiler, a renovator and the maker of a clean copy. It should, however, be remembered that the dignitaries at the Finnish Literature Society, who read the manuscript of the Old Kalevala and whose opinion Lönnrot sought, did not appear to suffer from any Romantic illusions. The Board, consisting of M. Akiander, F. Aminoff, R. von Becker, B. Frosterus, A. Ingman, C. N. Keckman, G. Rein, W. S. Schildt and C. H. Ståhlberg, expressed the wish that all the variants in Lönnrot’s possession be published as such, even in translation into other languages, so that foreign scholars might also have a chance to study the material for the epic as such (Protokoll hållet vid Sällskapet för Finsk Litteratur Sammankomst den 7 Maj 1834, 3). Lönnrot himself had in a way envisaged something like

this in placing some of the “variants” at the end of the Old Kalevala. It is often imagined that the mission thus defined was in fact accomplished with the publication of the 33-volume *Ancient Songs of the Finnish People* and the source studies by A. R. Niemi and finally Väinö Kaukonen. To be precise this is not, however, the case, for the material Lönnrot selected and left still calls for investigation, specifically as a process of choice regulated by a number of alternatives, to say nothing of the need to place the variants used by Lönnrot and other relevant information at the disposal of international epic research. The dignitaries at the Finnish Literature Society in 1834 were, it seems, not only ahead of their own times but even ahead of the 1980s, too.

A problem of a very different nature lay in the concepts subscribed to by the educated circles. The question of reception likewise awaits more comprehensive research; scholarship has so far had to be content with quotations from individual expressions of opinion. Even the prevailing concepts of epic display a wide range of variants. The profile of the “breakthrough” of the Kalevala would take shape according to different target groups and decades. When I said that the Kalevala was instantly classified as a national epic, I did not of course mean that the Kalevala became common property overnight. It is a known fact that few were even able to read it, that a small edition was quite sufficient for a decade and a half, and that many, among them such men as Snellman, had trouble estimating its value. The Kalevala was just as much, if not more, a subject for debate as for blind admiration. Yet the views of its supporters won over in time, thanks to a great extent to the weight of international opinion and despite the criticism to be found in it. The Kalevala began to function as a symbol of national identity even before people learnt what it really contained and any scientific source analysis was conducted. Patronising voices soon began to make themselves heard in the debate on the Kalevala: care must be taken not to offend the prevailing concepts, not to taunt Lönnrot, and so on. And the voices of enthusiastic non-experts, too, began to weigh in this debate.

Epic concepts of the Romantic era

Basically, what was it all about? What exactly was all the discussion about, and what were the main sources of disagreement and misconception? The cultural history of the Kalevala process still remains to be written, though there is no shortage of interesting materials. This has been proved by William A. Wilson (1976), whose book only began to scratch the surface, and a few small-scale studies by certain Finnish scholars (e. g. Karkama 1985). Suffice it at this stage to underline the multiplicity of the epic concepts behind the debate. We cannot really speak of one single Romantic epic theory. Instead we must speak of different theoretical trends during the Romantic period, also and specifically within the movement, in the texts of the chief ideologists, and further of the profound interaction between the epic concepts designated classic and Romantic. A heroic era as the crucial stage preceding epics, the epic in the theory of the evolution of literature, the gyration of epics round one central event or the defiance of this demand for uniformity, the epic as a reflection of the spirit of the people or of a particular stage in the development of a society and its culture and numerous other problems abound in the writings of philosophers, aestheticians, mythologists and other scholars of the Romantic era, who approached their subject from the most varied of angles.

In surveying the reception afforded the Kalevala it is of course vital to know what people were debating in the period between the Old and the New Kalevalas, and on what premises. Pertti Karkama has examined the background to the debate with special reference to the somewhat opposing aesthetics of Hegel and Friedrich Schlegel and the arguments between Snellman and Runeberg on King Fjalar (Karkama 1985: 98–104). The definitions of the classical and the Romantic epic are constantly intertwined, even though Snellman, for example, “made a clear distinction” between them. One interesting signpost was the young Robert Tengström, whose criticism influenced not only the plot

of the New Kalevala but the development of Lönnrot's concept of the epic in general. His *Erwartungshorizont* was as follows:

There was once in the life of nations a time when all the elements in which they have subsequently specialised still comprised a simple entity, when the individual did not yet stand apart from the people and this was not yet broken up into classes differing in their civilisation and their living conditions, but when the same spirit prevailed in everything and everything was held together by a natural affinity of souls. We may say of this era in particular that poetry burst forth from the heart of the people. One interpreted what thousands felt, and called forth a strong response in everything. Songs were handed down by word of mouth, on the lips and instruments of living singers; they sang of what was to their minds charming and sorrowful, what they experienced, suffered and hoped. The songs became a flowering of the innermost life of the people, its language and its homeland. It was immaterial who put this inner life into words: a folk song never knows its composer. But if the people had a greater fund of spiritual gifts, and if its time did not all go in a dream-like ecstasy of living, the song was not confined to individual events or feelings but grew unceasingly, its lines flying from one generation to another like electric sparks; it was reincarnated in countless souls; it was experienced by countless spirits; individual feelings developed into new outlooks; events increasingly hung together and grew into series. The entire nation took a greater or a lesser part in the creation of such series, and such a series of events scarcely lacked any feature that existed in reality. This was the birth of folk epics, these great poetic works in which the people have presented, clothed in great and everlasting figures, their entire infancy in its original harmony. (Tengström 1845a: 139.)

Here we have the origin of folklore and the epic presented in the true spirit of Herder. It is a collective process that barely needs even an anonymous poet. Karkama stresses the way in which Tengström's

thinking is suffused with the spirit of Hegel. He may well have a point, but the existence of conflicting epic concepts is illustrated by the fact that Tengström's view can be refuted by a quotation from none other than Hegel himself:

Yet the epic poem, as a work of art, can emanate from only a single individual. For insofar as the epic proclaims the affairs of the entire nation, it is not the nation as a whole that is the poet but some individual. The spirit of the times and the nation is, admittedly, a substantial, cogent reason, but it is realised only as a work of art in the hands of an individual genius who then makes this communal spirit and its content a conscious part of his own view and of his own work and implements it as such. For poeticising is a form of spiritual production and the spirit exists only as an individual, true awareness and self-awareness. (Hegel 1955: 411; see Karkama 1985: 105–106.)

On the other hand Herder's view of the poet (quoted above) as the psychopomp of the people, the leader of souls and the creator of the spiritual world, is not far from Hegel's. In the background we catch a glimpse of the literary idol of the Romantics, Shakespeare. The conflict should not, however, be explained away simply by arguing the distinction between folk poetry and art poetry; this would be contradicting the basic views of Romanticism.

What, then, is the relevance of the Wolfian answer to the question of Homer to, say, the theories of Tengström? Very little, for in a way it eliminates the original folk epic and transfers the birth of the epic to the domain of literacy and literary editing. There would be no collectively created epics at all, and few oral. Friedrich Schlegel, the inventor of Romantic literary theory, adopted the view of Wolf, which does not necessarily mean this was the fundamental view of the Romantics. Goethe, for example, subscribed to Wolf's view, but only for a time, and later abandoned it (Schadewaldt 1959: 14, 19). Although it was, as I have said, an explanation recurring from time to time and handed down from Antiquity, it nevertheless sounded revolutionary in the

Romantic atmosphere of the 1790s, and to Goethe at least somewhat abhorrent.

Since the Wolfian model is so exceptionally well suited to Lönnrot's situation, it might be assumed that — if it was generally known — it would have influenced the reception of the Old Kalevala. Both Tengström and Linsén appear at times to have adopted a Wolfian approach, in speaking, for example, of an epic “divided by its compiler into thirty-two poems” (Linsén) or in issuing advice on how to clarify the progress of the plot of the Kalevala (Tengström). If the Wolfian interpretation really had become widely assimilated, it would have been but a short step to a discreet dissociation from the demand of the Romantics for an authentic, collectively produced epic and to likening Lönnrot to the editors of Peisistratus's day who put together a great epic. But this was not the case. Both Linsén and Tengström appeared to sustain a strong belief in the existence of an original, even if crumbling folk epic exactly as Romanticism demanded. But did Lönnrot believe this too? Karkama says ‘yes’ (Karkama 1985: 97); I personally have my reservations.

The many levels of authenticity

If the Kalevala were an art epic akin to Milton's *Paradise Lost* or Virgil's *Aeneid*, the question of its authenticity would have to be either reformulated or withdrawn altogether. But the Kalevala is a folk poetry epic, its lines were not created by Lönnrot, though he did edit them. They have counterparts in oral folk poetry with which they can be compared. One of the norms of authenticity may be said to be a correspondence with folk poetry material, so long as we remember that folk poems do not have an unquestioned, authoritative form in the oral tradition. Other norms may be sought from the perspective of tradition communication. These norms should be borne in mind in assessing the

artistic goals of Lönnrot's epic; it is also pertinent to ask whether he was aware of them.

Quite a lot is known about Lönnrot's method. We could undoubtedly learn a lot more, but it is already clear that the correspondence between the Kalevala and folk poetry differs considerably at the levels of line, line sequence and broader plot structure. Taking a look at the line material, the number of lines composed by Lönnrot himself is extremely small — 3% according to one calculation (Kaukonen 1979: 72). He himself belittled the significance of these lines, regarding them chiefly as elucidations, as isolated appendages (cf. Anttila 1931: 225 and 1935: 70–71); such sections as the prologue and the epilogue require separate assessment. In this sense Lönnrot cannot be compared to Virgil, an epic poet writing in his own words. We may, instead, ask who was more faithful to the original material, Lönnrot or the determined author of the plot of the *Odyssey*, or the creator of the *Nibelungenlied* who forced existing ingredients into a new poetic metre (cf. Honko 1961: 32)? The Kalevala is a highly authentic folk poetry epic if we take as our criterion the authenticity of the individual line. But what about the remaining 97% of the lines? Were they lifted straight from poems? About 50% of the lines in the Kalevala are ones in which Lönnrot changed the orthography, the language or the poetic metre (Kaukonen 1979: 72). Lönnrot decided very early on that dialects and other linguistic deviations could impose too great a strain on the reader, for the receiver of the work was not merely the academic community but the entire nation. In a review of the collection of folk poems of Z. Topelius the elder he stated his views on the treatment of dialect words:

Regardless of the dialect, the critic would in the case of such words always have used the orthography most easily understood by the Finns of most regions. The linguist engaged in the study of Finnish dialects may have much to say against this procedure, but poems are not his private affair. They must be regarded as a sacred legacy handed down to us, like the kantele, by our forefathers. Viewed in this way they must, if possible, be made generally comprehensible;

every attempt must be made to present them in such a form that the entire nation can read them, which is not the case if slight differences of dialect are adhered to. (Lönnrot 1829; Anttila 1931: 114–115.)

This principle in time led to the elimination of certain Karelian features from the Kalevala, not always, however, and not at the cost of the poetic metre; in Lönnrot's opinion these were mainly questions of orthography. 14% of the lines have no identical counterpart in the folk poetry noted down and were put together by Lönnrot from folk ingredients. Finally 33% of the lines are identical to those to be found in the original notes (Kaukonen 1979: 72).

The statistics show that Lönnrot did not indulge in poetic licence at *line* level. He took his liberties in other ways. As a result of his working method the Kalevala came to have very few sections of any length to be found as such in the original variants. The combining of different poems, patching and padding by drawing on variants and adding parallel lines took care of this. Thus the "co-text" of most of the lines has changed, making them not necessarily any less authentic but different from the poems communicated by the oral tradition. Estimation of the authenticity of sections cannot possibly be a mechanical line-by-line check; it must be done within the confines of the folk poetry variants, but mainly asking: would a folk poem put it like this? The comparison would thus be founded not so much on the preserved lines as such as on the range of variation within a poetic theme. Some item in the Kalevala consisting of authentic lines and line sequences might in the light of such analysis soon prove to be less in keeping with folk poetry than an item with less material correspondence. Only then do structural considerations enter the analysis. For example, fewer than ten lines are devoted in the folk poems to the inquiry into the origin of disease; the Kalevala devotes several dozen. The authenticity of the treatment cannot of course be determined merely by checking the correspondence of individual lines. The question is not simply how much or how little Lönnrot diverged from the poems in his possession

on a given theme, but also how the final outcome, “Lönnrot’s variant”, stands in relation to the poetic culture. The examination may also include variants not available to Lönnrot. The domain of “possible variants” has to some extent also been entered in seeking line counterparts.

Even though no sufficiently comprehensive comparison has been made at *line sequence* level, there seems to be little doubt that the authenticity of the Kalevala is here in quite a different category from that of individual lines. Both the editing principles and the artistic goals adopted by Lönnrot inevitably meant that the poetic material gradually became homeless in his hands, it ceased being the product of a particular local culture and merged to form a mixture into which Lönnrot dipped as required. One of the criteria for expansion may have been representativeness: if the beauty of a folk poem could be rescued by placing it in the epic, then this means was resorted to. The additional material available for the New Kalevala was utilised rather than discarded. Was this a conscious striving towards synthesis, an attempt to place in one cover the best that each poetic province could provide, either within or by constantly relaxing the confines imposed by the plot structure? The New Kalevala was, after all, criticised again and again for its wide scope, not for its omissions. This technique yielded a pan-Finnish epic, not an epic of any particular poetry area or province. Interesting in this respect is the abridged version of the Kalevala (1862), produced *without compromising over the plot* (unlike the later school editions), cutting out less important lines and smallish sections to reduce the number of lines to 43%. It was veritable proof of the padding in the epic and of Lönnrot’s flexibility and capacity for producing more and more versions. Yet still the critics were not all satisfied (see Anttila 1935: 76–89).

In devising the *plot structure* Lönnrot first of all took all the liberties exploited by the rune singers themselves in presenting the same poems in different ways on different occasions. But conceiving of the overall structure of the Kalevala was a task that clearly exceeded the capacity of the ordinary rune singer. Lönnrot took as his guideline the semi-personal, semi-scientific vision of the era in which the events described

in the poems were a natural part of the Finns' way of life. I shall be returning later to this quasi-historical vision of the ancient Finns. It incorporates the historical and ethnographical authenticity of the Kalevala, and the very question of authenticity begins to transform itself into a problem of interpretation. Otherwise the plot structure is of interest today chiefly as an aesthetic issue and in comparing epics. The situation is in this sense quite different from that in the years immediately following the publication of the Kalevala, when the advisers and critics believed they were concerned with no less than the reconstruction of a shattered mosaic, at the level of either a complete epic (Tengström) or a "minor epic" (Ahlqvist), i. e. of partial entities included in the Kalevala and also existing in the oral tradition (Ahlqvist 1884: 14–15).

Even the best rune singer could command only a fraction of the material at Lönnrot's disposal as he compiled the New Kalevala. The situation was more or less the opposite when he was working on the Old Kalevala: then it was necessary to stretch the poems out, to find more material, now the poems threatened to be too long, there was even too much material. Lönnrot's oft-quoted saying about the seven Kalevalas — all of them different — that could be got out of the material available (af Forselles 1911: 495) reveals just how much material there was available and also his change of attitude. Gone were the days when new material would solve the problems of the plot. The nascent epic was to be Lönnrot's, and he knew it.

Lönnrot's own view

When it came to the epic, Lönnrot was a man of practice, not of theory. He had in the 1820s read the works of such men as Hegel, but the only reference we have to this is in a letter of a friend (Anttila 1931: 74). He could not work up any enthusiasm for the dissident aestheticians, the weighty German tomes. But he did lay store by the criticism put

forward on the Kalevala. Here again he was forced to admit that it was impossible to please everyone. Seldom did he utter any statements of a theoretical nature on the origins of folk poems and epics, nor were his views particularly independent. All the more interesting are his sketches of the life of folklore. Speaking of the origin of folk poetry in the foreword to the Kanteletar he says:

The poetries of both the ordinary people and the learned have their own value and merits — that we neither can nor will refute. But on placing them side by side, we see a predominance of *nature* in the former and of *variety* in the latter. Folk poems cannot therefore be said to have been *made*. They are not *made*, they *make themselves*, they are born, they grow and take shape without any special care on the part of a maker. The soil that nurtures them is the mind and thought, the seeds from which they spring all manner of dispositions. But since the mind, thoughts and dispositions are at all times and in all people as one, then the poems that are born of them are not the special property of one or two but common to the nation as a whole. The moment they are said to be made by some particular person, they lose their value as folk poetry.

Not even an anonymous maker is required; folk poems are born again and again, collectively and naturally out of the basic feelings and thoughts of man and become the property of all. This is a highly orthodox, though not original, concept of the Romantic era. It prevented Lönnrot from emphasising his own part in the begetting of the Kalevala: “authorship” would have destroyed its value as folk poetry. Lönnrot’s sympathies lay with natural poetry, not with learned poets: in the former Finnish poetry ranks among the finest in the world, while in the latter it lags “far behind many other nations”. In recognising this, Lönnrot came close to the famous appraisal of Porthan, but he only succeeded in annoying Snellman (Anttila 1931: 338), in whose opinion it was false aesthetics and the disparagement of book learning, a situation unacceptable in Finland. Interesting and more original is the classification of folklore genres given in the foreword to the Kanteletar.

J. L. Runeberg, Jacob Grimm and Robert Tengström provided Lönnrot with important assessments of the Kalevala. We know what Runeberg thought of the Kalevala from a letter he wrote to J. K. Grot (21.4.1839), in which he sees the ways in which Homer and the Kalevala came into being as mutually illuminating. He surmises that Lönnrot saw an image of “the existence of a great, complete poem that, held together by tradition and memory alone would have fallen into pieces and spread among the people so that no one recalled it in its entirety...seeking out these scattered fragments and putting them back together as they were originally” was a goal Lönnrot achieved with the help of Vaassila Kieleväinen:

There is no doubt that the poems of Homer were collected in the same way. Like the Finnish poems, the Greek ones were noted down among the people, and possibly the different poems in the Iliad and the Odyssey were put in their present beautiful order on the advice of some aged singer who, like Vaassila, had forgotten individual lines but could recall the order and mutual relationships of the immortal poems about Achilles and Odysseus. (Quoted by Kaukonen 1979: 89.)

What Runeberg here assumes of epic re-construction as the goal of Lönnrot’s collecting, can not be corroborated in full by Lönnrot’s own writings, but Runeberg and Lönnrot almost certainly discussed the origins of Homer and the Kalevala at some stage, possibly with others, too. It cannot possibly have been any new invention when, ten years later, Lönnrot wrote in his article *Anmärkningar till den nya Kalevala* in the *Litteraturblad* as follows:

If the people who have written about the origin of the songs of Homer had had the same experience of the way tradition handles a song as I have, there could never, I believe, have been any disagreement as to how they came into being. For they would have generally observed that some poet at the time of the events first sang shorter versions, then folklore would have added to them and presented

them in many variants. So whoever subsequently collected the variants faced a task much the same as mine in arranging the songs and combining a number of variants; do not, however, misunderstand me, for this does not mean that I wish to liken my own skills or even the subject on hand to his. The very fact that numerous different dialects often appear in the poems of Homer make it impossible for us to imagine that they had a single author or a single tradition devoid of numerous variants. Anyone who sets about arranging and combining items belonging to a particular poetic sequence is from time to time forced to add the occasional connecting line, and I do not doubt that such lines can be found in the Homeric poems, too, if we look hard enough. Connecting lines also had from time to time to be added to the Kalevala; mentioning this on every occasion would, however, seem pedantic, not only to me but to others too, and would be equally futile in that this does not in the least concern the matter itself... (Lönnrot 1849; af Forselles 1908: 228–229.)

The following addition, also analysing the life of the poems, is to be found under the foreword in the interleaved copy of the Old Kalevala used by Lönnrot:

The original narrative, which was by no means so extensive as it is today, was added to by generation upon generation of poets, and they are still doing so even today. The good rune singer was little troubled if he failed to recall word-for-word a poem as sung by previous singers and would sing on to the end, possibly filling in the forgotten lines in his own words. This is precisely the reason for the numerous variants and also for the present extent of a poem. The Greeks probably put together their magnificent Homeric poems in just the same way. Passed down over the centuries as oral legends among the Greek peoples of Europe and Asia, the poems changed, grew and were embellished with the years until some collector came across them and wove them together. It is hard to believe that if anyone had begun to collect these Kalevala poems two or three

hundred years ago, he would have discovered even half of them, and a few centuries earlier Kalevala poems of such beauty would not have been found to such an extent that an edition of the Kalevala such as the present would have been possible, even though I myself was indeed reluctant to believe this and many as a rule still think this. (Borenius & Krohn 1895: 2–3.)

The ‘song theory’ of Homeric research was, it seems, already common currency in Finland in the 1840s, and the parallel drawn by Lönnrot was anything but irrelevant. Even today we may still debate what impact Lönnrot and the Kalevala might have had on Homer research if, instead of second-hand information, it had had at its disposal the wide and representative selection of texts and translations of the poem variants used as the basis for the Kalevala.

Little attention has been paid to the comment at the end of the quotation that is in fact no less than a change of paradigm. While editing the new Kalevala Lönnrot had adopted the paradigm of evolution. This signified the final abandoning of the possibility of an original but shattered ancient epic. Only in recent centuries had the epic poems developed to the point where the Kalevala became possible. This realisation was supported by Lönnrot’s concept of the life of poetry, its production and variation. This was based not on some academic theory but on his experience out in the field. The core of his concept is the clear distinction between the text and the texture of a poem. The “original narrative” may be old and long-lasting, but all the variants available are recent and disjointed, containing, for example, loan words from different periods. The variants are able to put across the content, i. e. the text, but their language and vocabulary vary endlessly at the level of texture, and this variance links up with the presentation of the poem, its performance. It is therefore futile to seek any ‘original form’: “If, despite everything, we wished to restore a poem to its original form, it would be a thankless task that would, furthermore, lead to very different results, as we all have our own subjective views” (Lönnrot 1849; cf Forselles 1908: 225).

This view, based on observations in the field, of the life of poetry may also be Lönnrot’s strongest contribution to modern theoretical

debate. In his own day it went beyond most people's comprehension. An amusing example is the letter politely quoted by Lönnrot in his article in the *Litteraturblad*, the writer of which estimates the first canto of the *Kalevala* as being of Christian origin and also of being composed of many elements in subsequent eras. Lönnrot speaks of the large number of variants and of his own compilations, even inviting better solutions, whereas the writer of the letter envisages a process of combination taking place in the oral tradition. The dividing line is infinitely thin, but vital. Lönnrot must surely have been aware of his pedagogical role: readers must be made to realise the life and mutation of a poem in the oral tradition. In the same article he leads up to this goal in writing:

I am not at all of the opinion that the *Kalevala* poems are even today such as they were originally sung; nor am I of the same opinion as those who believe that if someone had undertaken to collect them a few centuries earlier, the yield would have been much greater. It is not merely possible but also probable that some poems have with time got lost; but on the other hand anyone more closely acquainted with the state of affairs must admit that some, so to say, have grown longer. The singers who have passed these poems down from generation to generation over the centuries were not so meticulous that many of them, when encountering a more fitting idea, a better expression they thought would make the poem more beautiful, would not also use it. If you tell a good singer a poem he has not heard before, and then ask him to sing it, he seldom says it has not yet lodged in his memory, and he sings it — not, however, in every respect word-for-word, but omitting some words, adding or amending others. If you were now to note down the poem such as he repeated it from memory and to tell it to another singer, asking him to sing it in turn, it would again be modified. If you were to continue telling the latest reproduction to a new singer and then to compare the version sung by the tenth singer with the original song, you would observe that even the tenth variant of the song was basically the same as the original but that many expressions would

have changed, some for the better, some for the worse, and that one or another less important section would have disappeared and another been added. (Lönnrot 1849; af Forselles 1908: 227.)

Lönnrot outlines a study of reproduction such as was not undertaken in folkloristics for a hundred years to come (cf. Bartlett 1920: 149; Anderson 1951 and 1956). Bearing in mind his views on the relative permanence of the text and the constant variation of the texture, it is far easier to understand his way of dealing with folk poems. He repeatedly speaks of the problem of arranging poems, but what exactly does he mean? The concept also features largely in the letter from Runeberg to Grot quoted above, concerning the origin of Homer's epics. Let us once more quote from the same article by Lönnrot.

The order in which the rune singers themselves sang their poems cannot entirely be overlooked, though I do not wish to give it too much emphasis, especially if these orders differ greatly from one another. It was precisely this difference (often causing the order of poems as sung by one singer to differ from that chosen by another, and since after noting down the same songs from different singers many times there were very few songs not in some way joined together or attached to some other poem) that confirmed my belief that all poems of this type may be combined with any other. I could not regard the order chosen by one singer as more authentic than that of another, and explained this as springing from a natural desire to place his knowledge in some order, which varied according to the individual visions of different singers. Finally, since there was not a single singer able to compete with me in the number of poems I had collected, I believed I had the same right which, I was convinced, most singers permitted themselves to arrange the poems as I considered best, — — in other words I regarded myself as a singer, as their equal. (Lönnrot 1849; af Forselles 1908: 219–220.)

In other words poems have a tendency to form sequences in the singer's repertoire, but the order is not necessarily fixed even with one singer and may vary at different performances. Some singers vary the order even more. The result is a large number of possible combinations that

increase as the repertoire grows. No original, normative order is to be found; the exceptional size of Lönnrot's own 'repertoire' provides new potential for estimating new combinations and producing more. It is, as it were, a potential built into the material itself that must as far as possible be exploited. The resulting order may in theory be "the best possible", but it can hardly be called the original one, for this would presuppose some ancient epic with a set order of events. It should be emphasised that Lönnrot in fact applies here a definition of the epic according to which an epic may in principle consist of separate poems, because they have similar features, the same principal characters, etc. Yet we may if we wish also seek the clue in, say, the chronology of events, a consideration that, because of the historical interpretation to which Lönnrot adhered, acquired greater emphasis and attracted a certain amount of external interpretation, too. It is, however, generally true to say that the "history" portrayed in the poems had to be written on the basis of the poetic material. It is here that Väinö Kaukonen's somewhat complex definition of the Kalevala as Elias Lönnrot's poetic narrative about ancient folk poems is perhaps most appropriate (e. g. Kaukonen 1979: 188).

"Order" clearly has to do with content, not textural units. "Variants" are thematic rather than formal. The singer's "right" applies to the combination of themes, to the order of presentation. Slavish adherence to, for example, a particular line formula thus begins to seem unnatural and diverging from it natural. But this is not the case. We are here confronted with another factor: the authenticity threshold envisaged by Lönnrot.

Lönnrot's opinion on the question of authenticity

Invisible, yet always present in the background of the Kalevala process was Macpherson. He was already the subject of debate in Porthan's day, and it was to him that Lönnrot was likened in questioning the

existence or use of an original Kalevala source. The Songs of Ossian was the great pioneer of the pre-Romantic era but was deposed on the discovery that it was 'fake'. Unfortunately for him, Macpherson had introduced himself as the 'translator' of the poems and had to hold on to this role to the bitter end. The poetic merits of Ossian were not sufficient to rescue the work. The falsehood was aggravating in itself, but even more aggravating was perhaps the offense against the Romantic view of the epic. At root was the birth of folk poems and also of extensive epics 'without an author', 'untouched by hand', as the result of a mysterious collective process of creation.

Lönnrot, too, began by subscribing to the conditions of this Romantic view, stated most plainly in the foreword to the *Kanteletar*. It is hard to imagine what he was thinking when the theory failed to work out in practice. The chances that a large-scale original epic ever existed diminished the more material he collected and the further his work progressed. On the other hand the poems from Russian Karelia did display a clear tendency to hang together and to be grouped in broader entities. The poems were in principle "authentic", neither their author nor their age could be proved, but examination of their variation and the conditions for their existence inevitably led to the conclusion that the role played by the singer was greater than had been assumed. Despite this the preservation of the 'original narrative' was not in any danger: a common core could be discerned in the versions of different singers. These problematic observations contained the seeds of a juicy dispute that might even undermine the Romantic view of the epic.

There are a number of reasons why Lönnrot did not immediately go so far, the primary one being his open-mindedness and his avoidance of rigid theorising. The Romantic view of the epic was, when all is said and done, no more than a half-empty mystification that Lönnrot began little by little to fill from within with his own experience. In his defence he called on the folk singers, the authenticity of whose products could not, especially in the remote regions of Finland and Karelia barely touched by book-learning in a different language, be questioned. Even so the journey to the epic grew much easier as the theory on the

origin of Homer's epics became more widely known. It was easy for Lönnrot to accept, for it settled the relationships between the poems, the singers and the epic in one stroke, in a way that appeared in the light of his experience to be the only one possible. In the first half of the 19th century Lönnrot was one of the few people in the world who could have put forward the idea subsequently named the 'song theory' independent of F. A. Wolf.

The atmosphere around the time the Old Kalevala appeared was not, however, ripe for a direct attack on the fundamental concept of the Romantics. The public expectations increasingly in the air were still firmly embedded in the Romantic coordinates that were to be fatal for Macpherson. We cannot fail to notice the sense of forlornness exuded by Lönnrot's letters at the time. In March 1835 he sent one of his field reports to Runeberg for publication and wrote:

Secondly I feel obliged to give my contemporaries and posterity a step-by-step account of the Finnish poems I have been collecting for several years now and arranged for publication. Without laying too much store by them, I nevertheless believe that since they may to some extent also explain our earliest history, the question may be raised of their authenticity. True, I do not believe anyone can seriously do so, but so much is written and said just for the fun of it. So anyone wishing, for the fun of it, to be convinced that they are really sung by the ordinary people may accompany me on my coming journey or any of those I have made previously, and may furthermore, if he so wishes, come to Kajaani market sometime, when the whole house is full of rune singers, so that one is speechless in the face of such abundance and does not know what to note down first. (af Forselles 1911: 219.)

He does not mention Macpherson's name, but it shines through his anxiety about the public's almost complete ignorance of the life of folk poetry. This ignorance and the tense anticipation of the Kalevala (Lönnrot himself had a presentiment that it could become a national epic) were the combination that could in fact turn the public, infused

with the Romantic view of the epic, against Lönnrot. No wonder Lönnrot felt the need for understanding and someone to share the responsibility. But these proved surprisingly difficult to find.

Lönnrot was thus very much on his own, and not merely because he was living in the remote town of Kajaani. The end of the road had been reached as far as Romantic epic theory was concerned, and he had had to take the last, decisive step himself in devising the plot structure of the *Kalevala*. In the light of prevailing opinion the *Kalevala* would not have been genuine if it had, for example, been founded on folk narratives in prose form rather than poetry. This was one reason why the Estonian *Kalevipoeg* did not evoke a response similar to that of the *Kalevala* in its day.

The demand for authenticity goes a long way to explaining Lönnrot's working method: he went to extremes (greater extremes than many a rune singer, to say nothing of epic poets) to avoid composing new lines and resorted to a patchwork technique in which new entities could only be created from existing lines of folk poetry. The fact that the lines used in the *Kalevala* came from poems alive in the oral tradition was the 'authenticity threshold' to which Lönnrot consciously adhered. The line material became both the foundations for the *Kalevala* and a psychological wall providing protection against relevant and irrelevant criticism. Topping this wall was a layer of bricks we may call the singers' freedom: Lönnrot considered he was entitled to use the same rules as those applied by folk singers in producing their poems. These rules applied to variation and the structure of the plot.

Lönnrot needed the singer's freedom for a different purpose from the folk singer, however. Whereas the folk singers constantly varied their poems to suit each new performing context, drawing on a relatively small stock of lines and plots, Lönnrot set out to achieve quite different goals, one being representativeness: the *Kalevala* was to reflect narrative poetry as comprehensively and as widely as possible. The clearest proof of this is the incorporation of incantations and wedding lays, which Lönnrot argued by appealing to ethnographic authenticity (Borenius & Krohn 1895: 4), but it comes to light as soon as we try to analyse any

poem in the Kalevala. Lönnrot's likening himself to the singer is indeed not without justification: he had a far greater repertoire than any singer, though this necessitated making written notes and did not therefore comply with the rules of poetry stored in the memory, to say nothing of the fact that he did not grow up in a culture producing oral poetry. He also had a phenomenal grasp of the old poetic metre, of possible lines and plots, though he did admittedly tend to even out the differences existing between poetic regions.

The biggest differences between Lönnrot and the rune singers lie, therefore, in the extent of his repertoire and above all in his technique of expansion and the goals for producing poetry. The rune singers did indeed combine poems to form a logical sequence, and there was considerable borrowing of episodes from one poem to another, but Lönnrot gave this potential completely new dimensions. This led to the expansion technique and the fact that in handling episodes of any length Lönnrot needed more and more freedom to place lines taken from different poems side by side. The variation in the contents of the narrative poems from one singer and region to another enticed Lönnrot to take more responsibility into his own hands. Up to the publication of the Old Kalevala he persistently sought hints from singers as to the plot structure of the Kalevala, but he no longer did so in compiling the final edition. The journey from the Old to the New Kalevala is in Lönnrot's case a gradual liberation from the chains of Romantic epic theory. This is clearly evident in the laconic comment in which Lönnrot said he could if necessary produce as many as seven Kalevalas, all of them different.

But did Lönnrot alone break free from the Romantic theory? August Ahlqvist once said that Lönnrot was the only person who did not tremble at the mention of the origins of the Kalevala (Ahlqvist 1884: 15). By giving a detailed account of his own methods at various stages of the Kalevala process he in a way shelved the whole issue for other, possibly wiser men to debate. The Kalevala gave rise to plenty of debate, but Lönnrot felt no great need to participate in it.

In a letter to L. Léouzon Leduc in March 1851 Lönnrot, however, took stand to the question of authenticity. He wrote:

Any doubt as to the authenticity of the poems in the Kalevala such as that which at one stage led the critics to debate the authenticity of, for example, Macpherson's Ossian cannot occur to anyone in the least bit familiar with the conditions. For doubt would then be levelled at the collectors, partly that they changed the original poem discovered among the people and partly that they concealed the origin of poems they themselves compiled, or then I could be suspected of having subsequently done so in organising them to form the Kalevala epic. That this was not the case can be confirmed by anyone who so wishes among the ordinary people in the areas where the poems were noted down, for everything to be found in the Kalevala was already familiar in one or another region, and this familiarity is founded on tradition and is not caused by any printed or written book, because no such books exist in those regions, and furthermore they would not be of any use among the Finns in the governments of Archangel or Olonetsia, who cannot read and who are nevertheless the chief preservers of the poems. Truly the fact is that all the material in the Kalevala is not merely familiar to the peasant from that area; the poems in the Kalevala could still be collected again among the present generation, if there was anyone willing to spend several years travelling and staying among the people. The multiple variants of the same poems noted down, some of which are at the Literature Society in Helsinki but most of which are still in my possession, may also be mentioned as proof of the authenticity of the poems, since a falsifier would surely not have produced ten, twenty and often even more variants of poems. During my work of editing I had such a wealth of variants that many of the poems could have been supplied with two or more parallel texts almost from beginning to end, all with the same content but so different in their words and expressions that they would have little in common apart from the names. (af Forselles 1911: 521.)

This was Lönnrot's final statement on the authenticity of the Kalevala. It is prophetic in that this possible re-collection really was needed in a situation in which the sources of the Kalevala were not as readily available as they are today. The touchstone of authenticity was, according to Lönnrot, in the living folk poems: so long as the ingredients for the Kalevala are to be found in them, allusions to Macpherson are unfounded. The mention of the re-collection of the poems in the Kalevala may of course apply merely to the poetic themes appearing in the Kalevala, not their written form, which is in harmony with Lönnrot's view that authenticity must be assessed specifically from the perspective of the living poetic tradition.

It is important to observe that Lönnrot spoke of the similarity of poems at the level not of texture but of text. The wealth of variants warrants two conclusions. First, no texture is necessarily the original or of particularly ancient stock: the wordings of variants reflect relatively late stages in the development of poems. Secondly, since there is no normative texture, the similarity of poems has to be dealt with at the level of plot structure and content, in other words text. Only in this way is it possible to parallel two variants whose only common texture lies in their names. Only thus is there justification for Lönnrot's claim that he did not alter the original poems.

When he said, that he finally regarded himself as a singer, as their equal, he meant not the uninhibited freedom to compose but an inevitable selection in a situation in which an unparalleled abundance of variants ultimately destroyed the idea of a single true form. It is worth reading Lönnrot's *Anmärkningarna till den nya Kalevala upplagan*. For this portrays the life of the folk poem as an endless stream of variation frozen only by being written down, committed to paper. This life of the poem is of primary importance, and only then comes the editor of the epic. Lönnrot does not hesitate to compare himself to the compiler of the Homeric songs of antiquity such as was, he believed, always necessary in putting together a broader entity, an epic, founded on separate poems from different eras. It is not far from the conclusion: the epic is ultimately part of written culture, only then is it possible.

The tyranny of theories

Lönnrot and his public were governed by the Romantic theory of an original epic, to which the Wolfian theory made an important modification. And it was in the light of the Romantic view that the *Kalevala*, too, had to be produced and received. No one was so brave as to question the realism of this epic concept, or even to launch an open debate on its inherent inconsistencies. Many, suffering beneath the yoke of a model theory, failed to recognise that there were any problems. We may in this sense speak of a tyrannising epic theory, and the tyranny seems to continue even today. It even acts as an obstacle to the comparative study of epics by engendering biased expectations, just as if the Romantic view of the epic were the yardstick for all epics. A clear traumatic tendency thus appears from time to time in debate — researchers, for example, who without further analysis brand the *Kalevala* as, say, a fake. One may well ask: a fake of what? Such researchers prefer, it seems, to adhere to the Romantic epic concept rather than to debate the question of how the various folk epics in the world actually came into being.

The second factor dominating, and sometimes curbing, comparative epic research is Homer research. The state of this research at any given time provides the criteria for the assessment of epics even of quite a different nature. Recent research into the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* has experimented widely with the theory of oral composition suggested by Milman Parry and Albert Lord. This is not necessarily very far from Lönnrot's observations on the life and presentation of folk poetry. According to it the part played by variation and improvisation is considerable in the oral production of songs. This theory, as in the case of Lönnrot, is backed by empirical field observations by which hypotheses concerning Homer have been tested. South Slavonic rune singers have had a greater influence on Homer research than their Karelian counterparts. The many thousands of lines at their command have directed attention at the ability of the person living within an oral culture to 'remember' very large entities, to compose them again and again by means of appellations, phrases, formu-

lae, plot schemes, etc. In the case of Homer research this has meant the return of the “great singer”: the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* are the result of dictation, not editing. The combination of poems to form a broader epic entity was already taking place in the oral tradition as the result of the determined efforts of some singer of genius. The process by which the *Iliad* was orally composed and preserved is thought to have taken close on 200 years, at a time when literacy was gradually spreading among the Greeks. How soon after its inception the *Iliad* acquired the written form we know is not clear. The conclusions are mere conjectures, because no oral poetic tradition has been preserved parallel to the *Iliad* or the *Odyssey*.

The question of whether the *Kalevala* may be likened to the epics of Homer is somewhat unsound in the sense that some new school of research may in the future revolutionise concepts of how the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* came into being, whereas in the case of the *Kalevala* the massive weight of source material prevents such a revolution but at the same time offers unique potential for probing deep into the method by which the epic was produced. Both will presumably always be classified as folk poetry epics, because they are founded on an oral poetic tradition, but whereas Lönnrot's *Kalevala* is clearly a literary product of almost exclusively literary influence, Homer scholars may still be debating the state of the oral versions of the epic even after the dawning of the literary era of the epic. Paradoxically, the situation would become more balanced if Lönnrot's sources had been lost and the oral folk poetry of all Finland and Karelia had died before anyone had a chance to write it down. The *Kalevala* would then be studied on the same terms as the epics of Homer.

This is the story of how an epic came into being. Another story has to be told about its reception, its interpretation and impact in the minds of contemporaries and posterity. Being based on folk poems, reaching coherence in the style of great epics and becoming a proof of the talent and spiritual quality of a nation the *Kalevala* comes close to fulfilling Herder's dream of lifting folklore to literature and permitting oral poetry to become a visible part of cultural identity and worldwide intellectual heritage.

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Pirkko Alboniemi

The Reception of the Kalevala and Its Impact on the Arts

When it was published in 1835, the Kalevala was the materialisation of hopes that had already been held out for several generations. H. G. Porthan's *De poësi Fennica* (1766–1778) had been preceded by the pioneering work of the nationalist-minded Daniel Juslenius, and following in Porthan's footsteps were his pupils Chr. Lencqvist and Christfrid Ganander. In the closing decades of the 18th century an aesthetically-biased interest in folklore was developed by the young members of the Aurora Society A. N. Clewberg and Jacob Tengström, with additional support from F. M. Franzén (Sarajas 1956: 297–305). The growing awareness of the past and the importance of ancient poetry lent impetus to the Turku Romantics, and one of their descendants was Elias Lönnrot. Lönnrot was neither the first collector nor indeed the first publisher of folk poetry; he was the final link in a chain of tradition, immediately preceded by C. A. Gottlund, the German-born H. R. von Schröter, Reinhold von Becker, and Zachris Topelius the elder. Becker taught Lönnrot at the University, and it was at Becker's suggestion that the young student, inspired by his collections, wrote his master's thesis *De Väinämöine, priscorum Fennorum numine* (1827). Yet no one but Elias Lönnrot created a synthesis or compiled a national epic, the Kalevala; therein lay beyond all doubt the unique aspect of his work.

Two-stage reception

The epic was clearly received in two stages, the first in about the ten-year period from 1835 onwards, the second in 1849, the year in which the final version of the Kalevala consisting of 50 poems was published,

and the beginning of the next decade. Yet only once was the epic acclaimed as a national identity symbol, and that was in the mid 1830s, when “new breezes” swept through Finnish educated circles and the nation was admitted into the “company of the chosen”, to quote the eloquent phrases of Martti Haavio (Haavio 1949: 240).

The Kalevala was both an outcome and a source: it was the brilliant concretisation of the goal-oriented pursuit of folk poetry and the start of a new wave of nationalist feeling; it was thus in line with the poetry of J. L. Runeberg and the declaration of ideals of J. V. Snellman. The first edition of the epic ran to a modest 500 and it appeared in two volumes: the first in time for Christmas 1835 and the second at the beginning of March 1836, i. e. roughly a year after the date under the foreword, February 28, 1835 (Anttila 1931: 236). At around the time it was published the Kalevala had little chance of becoming a widely-read folk opus, and the Swedish-speaking educated circles were faced with problems of both language and mentality. A contemporary memoirist Aug. Schauman recalled:

The Kalevala was naturally not read in wide circles; the language was impossible to understand, it was said, even by those who thought they knew Finnish. Translations and summaries provided some idea, however, of the contents of the epic. Everybody felt a certain pride in having such national treasure and therefore the Finnish language came to be looked upon in a rather different light from before. (Schauman 1922: 17.)

Schauman further mentions that Elias Lönnrot the man aroused great admiration, and as a whole his statement underlines the symbolic significance of the Kalevala.

The epic became a milestone both in culture as a whole and on the linguistic dimension: in one stroke Finnish threw off its reputation as being a language fit only for peasants and became accepted as a fully-fledged language of poetry in the true Romantic spirit. Among the first to pass aesthetic judgment was J. L. Runeberg, a friend and fellow student of Elias Lönnrot, to whom the compiler of the epic sent the 9th poem in the Kalevala before the appearance of the first volume of the work. In a

November issue of the Helsingfors Morgonblad for 1835 the author of the epic work *Elgskyttarne* heralded the advent of a true national treasure and compared it to the masterpieces of Greek epic, the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey* (Runeberg 1835). A poet with an established reputation, Runeberg's views could hardly fail to influence his readers. When in 1845, ten years after the epic was published, Robert Tengström attempted the first synthetic view of the *Kalevala*, he again mentioned the epopees of Homer by way of comparison. Without lapsing into excessive national pride, Tengström claimed that while the *Kalevala* might not surpass the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, it nevertheless made a considerable artistic impact in telling of the nation's youth, its spiritual development and unique world-view. It deserved to hold its place alongside the national epics of other countries (Tengström 1845: 181–182).

The work of Elias Lönnrot did not, however, arouse the unconditional praise of the public, as subsequent generations have tended to assume, and there was pointed criticism among the eulogies. C. A. Gottlund thought that Lönnrot's reputation had risen out of all proportion. He was not, after all, the first to collect ancient poetry. And J. G. Linsén, who joyfully greeted the *Kalevala* in the 1830s, was far less effusive in his admiration for the compiler of the epic by the following decade. In 1847 Linsén even commissioned his son to draw the well-known cartoon depicting a bare-footed peasant with a pack on his back and a stick in his hand: "*Unus homo nobis cursando restituit rem*" ("A single man, by scurrying about, has created a heritage for us", Anttila 1931: 239–244, 358). Linsén clearly found the personal cult surrounding both Lönnrot and J. V. Snellman distasteful; meanwhile Gottlund had undeservedly remained in Lönnrot's shadow.

Significance of the reception abroad

The *Kalevala* also became established as national Finnish property in translation and through the recognition it received abroad. The first to cross the linguistic border in Finland — the pioneer in Scandinavia —

was M. A. Castrén, whose Swedish translation was completed in 1841. Only when the work had been translated into Swedish could most educated Finns even read and assimilate the Kalevala, since few of them spoke Finnish, the language of the majority. Inspired by the spirit of national awakening, the young docent was at the same time lecturing on Kalevala poetry at Helsinki University, so that Castrén likewise had a chance to reinforce the concept of the fundamental significance of the national epic (Estlander 1928: 44–45). The linguistic barrier between Finland and Central Europe was, however, high, and in 1852 Anton Schiefner, the first translator of the Kalevala into German, admitted that despite its artistic merits Castrén's translation could not get across to a German readership. The prose translation into French by Léouzon Le Duc in 1845 did much to spread the work, though the first German version did not appear until after the completion of Lönnrot's second edition (Schiefner 1852). We know that Schiefner was a professor at the St. Petersburg Academy and was one of the most ardent defenders of the natural mythological interpretation, even publishing an article entitled *Zur Sampo-Mythe im finnischen Epos* in 1851 (Fromm 1967).

The way to making Finnish folk poetry known in German had to some extent already been cleared by H. R. von Schröter, a student at Uppsala in the 1810s. There he met such representatives of the Turku Romanticists as K. A. Gottlund and published the work *Finnische Runen*. This little book dealing with the nature of the Finnish language, poetry and the places where poems had been found, had run to a second edition in Germany (Krohn 1964: 25). From the Finnish point of view this meant that the Germans were introduced to the heroic figure Väinämöinen at about the very time he was being written about, partly in poetry, partly in prose, in Finnish and Swedish by such men as Jaakko Juteini, C. A. Gottlund, Reinhold von Becker, and A. I. Arwidsson (Alhoniemi 1969: 57).

The real breakthrough of the Finnish epic in the German-speaking world came in 1845, the year of Le Duc's translation into French, a coincidence that was underlined by Anton Schiefner (Schiefner 1852). On March 13th Jacob Grimm gave a lecture at the Berlin Academy

“Über das finnische Epos” in which, having first extolled the splendour of epic poetry, he went on to speak of the special merits of the Kalevala. He quoted Finland’s break with Sweden as a decisive historical event reinforcing the Finn’s national self-awareness and compared it to the break between Holland and Belgium. Grimm was lavish in his praise of both the vastness of the Kalevala’s mythical worldview and the richness of its imagery, and he was particularly impressed by the descriptions of Nature in the poetry. He predicted that Elias Lönnrot would have a growing reputation among subsequent generations (Grimm 1865: 78–79).

The *Fosterländskt Album* immediately published a Swedish translation of Grimm’s lecture that very same year (Grimm 1845) and this, along with Robert Tengström’s analysis of the Kalevala, helped to establish the position of the epic in Finland’s Swedish-speaking circles. This prestigious feedback from Central Europe was of no little significance, especially as Grimm’s lecture acted as an incentive. Inspired by Grimm, the German Sanskrit scholar and Orientalist Hermann Brockhaus invited another Sanskrit scholar, the young Herman Kellgren, to come and teach Finnish; Brockhaus had plans for translating the Kalevala into German. During the academic year 1846–47 Professors Schott and Stuhr also lectured on the Finnish language and the Kalevala in Berlin (Anttila 1931: 249). In Finland the whole decade 1840–1850 was a time for growing national awareness and burgeoning international contacts, while the intellectual and literary distance between Finland, St. Petersburg and Russia in general decreased, as Annamari Sarajas has pointed out (Sarajas 1968: 29–33). In Estonia the Kalevala provided the impetus for compiling the epic *Kalevipoeg*. Although F. R. Faehlmann had been collecting heroic poetry and legends even before the appearance of Finland’s national epic, only when Finland set the example did her linguistic relatives hit on the idea of compiling a single epic (Anttila 1931: 250). But in 1839 there were still two decades to go before the *Kalevipoeg* was published: the Estonian epic dates from 1857–1861.

The beginning of Kalevala scholarship

Finland suffered a cultural set-back in 1850, little more than a year after Elias Lönnrot completed the final 50-poem edition of the Kalevala. For the new censorship legislation was in danger of stifling all of Finland's embryo literature, claiming that the only literature to be printed in Finnish had to be of an economic or religious nature. The consequences were not, luckily, as disastrous as was initially feared, but there was an almost convulsive obsession with the attainments of national culture so far. A similar situation was to arise at the turn of the century, when Russian authority threatened to take away Finland's autonomy and her potential for a nationalist line of development. Although 1849 did mark the conclusion of the compilation of the Kalevala, the Finnish nationalists closed their ranks about Lönnrot and students embarked on what may be termed a national migration to the homelands of its poetry. "Dozens of ardent students were sent out with the Kalevala in their knapsacks" to travel the length and breadth of Finland and even the part of Karelia beyond the border (Haavio 1949: 256). At the same time the foundations were being laid for Kalevala scholarship; it could as yet hardly be called the study of folklore proper, since it revolved round the idea of the Kalevala as such, as a vast intellectual product of the Finnish people, and of Elias Lönnrot as the man who assembled the fragments of a shattered entity (Haavio 1949: 256). This "romantic axiom" remained established for decades to come (Kaukonen 1979: 88), and it was reinforced from without by the romantic theorisings of Jacob Grimm (Kaukonen 1979: 111). When, in 1854, Elias Lönnrot was appointed Professor of Finnish at the university as the successor to M. A. Castrén, he lectured on the Kalevala during the full 17 semesters for which he held office (Anttila 1935: 123). His successor, August Ahlqvist (who was one of the first translators of the Kalevala poems into Swedish) followed in his footsteps both as a scholar and a lecturer. In his lectures Ahlqvist also criticised the compilation of the

New Kalevala in particular, though out of respect he did not publish his comments in Lönnrot's lifetime (Kohtamäki 1956: 351). A study by him of the text of the Kalevala appeared in 1886.

The Kalevala as model for the arts

The Kalevala had come to occupy an established position in Finnish art by around 1860. This applied to painting, music, and even poetry. That the Kalevala made an impact over such a wide field was of significance in the process by which the epic was assimilated, though even without the appearance of the Kalevala folk poetry might at least to some extent have served as a source of inspiration to nationally-minded Finnish artists. For the firstlings of Kalevala art were born in the decades of the 19th century before the completion of Elias Lönnrot's masterpiece. In the second decade of the century Erik Cainberg had already been commissioned to sculpt a series of six reliefs depicting the history of civilisation for the Academy building in Turku, and representing antiquity was The Song of Väinämöinen (Lindström 1949: 175–176), while the Finnish lyric, especially the contemporary poetry of Jaakko Juteini, swore by the name of Väinämöinen. One experiment in the use of folklore in drama was the three-act Väinämöinen by Gustaf Anton Brakel of 1829 (Laurila 1949: 140). But in music we have to jump ahead to the year 1860, which saw the first performance of Filip von Schantz's Kullervo Overture and the music by Fredrik Pacius to the play by Z. Topelius entitled Prinsessan af Cypern (Väänänen 1949: 195). One special chapter in the history of Finnish-Swedish cultural relations was the admiration of the Swedish sculptor C. E. Sjöstrand for motifs from the Kalevala. The intermediary was the Finnish-born Scandinavian poet Emil von Qvanten and the initial impetus was received in 1853. His love of folklore later caused Sjöstrand to settle in Finland, where he created a magnificent set of Kalevala works. Most

of all he is remembered for his immortalisation of Kullervo. At Fredrik Cygnaeus' suggestion he was also commissioned to produce a statue of H. G. Porthan for Turku (Lindström 1949: 176–178).

The influence of the Kalevala on poetry was felt in both metre and motif, though because of the oral tradition the trochaic tetrametre would certainly have remained a feature of the Finnish lyric had the Kalevala never been compiled. Paradoxically the metres that originally belonged to a pagan culture took root in printed literature via the church, since from the 17th century onwards the clergy cleverly and appropriately cast their moral teachings in the poetic guise long familiar to the Finnish-speaking peasant (Laurila 1949: 139). Kalevala metre was also a natural choice for the self-taught ordinary people who in the 18th and 19th centuries began to write verses telling of the everyday life of the peasant population and the sorry state of the Finnish language in particular.

The art lyric in the Finnish language which Elias Lönnrot called “the poetry of the learned” in the foreword to the *Kanteletar* can claim a serious existence only from the mid-19th century onwards. Linguistic history regards this as the era at which different dialects were competing for supremacy, while the history of literature regards it as one tinged with disputes over poetic metre: should Finland's new poetry be built on the ancient Kalevala tradition or should it set about adapting metres of Germanic and Romance origin? The result was a compromise, and August Ahlqvist (alias A. Oksanen) wrote the first sonnet in the Finnish language in 1854. Throughout the closing decades of the 19th century Finnish lyricists from J. H. Erkko to Eino Leino nevertheless kept the Kalevala tradition alive, and Leino in particular revealed the inherent splendour of the ancient tradition with its alliteration and parallelisms.

An unusually interesting fusion of Kalevala-ism and Runeberg-ism is displayed in the “Runo” (Poem) published by D. E. D. Europæus in the *Suometar* in 1853 (no. 4, 167–168), in which the national anthem “Vårt land” by J. L. Runeberg first performed five years previously was translated into Finnish using the trochaic tetrametre, and what is more with great artistic effect. A close colleague of Elias Lönnrot's

and the discoverer of the poems about Kullervo, Europaeus had a fine command of Kalevala poetics and the ideals of contemporary culture. Lönnrot himself could have become a notable developer of Kalevala metre as a creative artist too, had he had more time and inclination. A considerable artistic feat and at the same time something of a curiosity is the extensive correspondence in Kalevala metre between Lönnrot and Pastor Kaarle Heickell, a guest of his in Kajaani, in the year in which the Old Kalevala made its appearance, 1835 (Anttila 1931: 189–191).

Are we Kullervos or Lemminkäinens?

The process by which the Kalevala became Finnish cultural property was at times one of immediate reaction, at others one of cultural diffusion less easy to trace. One factor important as regards the motif and stylistic tradition inspired by the Kalevala was the aesthetic study “The tragic element in the Kalevala” published by Fredrik Cygnaeus in 1853, in which he concentrated on analysing the contraversial character of Kullervo, finally concluding that Nature intended him to be a hero. But Fate made him a slave and channeled all his mighty mental and physical powers in the direction of revenge (Cygnaeus 1853: 119). In seeking literary parallels Cygnaeus turned to the Old Testament, especially the book of Job, and pointed out that Job’s sufferings were comparable to those of Kullervo, though the Kalevala went even further than the Bible in its descriptions of nuances of the mind (Cygnaeus 1853: 150–151). Pointing out that the Finnish national epic had so far (i. e. up to the early 1850s) attracted only little aesthetic attention, he was aware of the pioneering nature of his study (Cygnaeus 1853: 152). And he was equally convinced of the pertinence of the tragic element in the Kalevala — for as long as a single Finnish heart still beat and a single Finnish mind could understand the meaning of

great ideals (Cygnaeus 1853: 153). Cygnaeus, who studied at the Turku Academy at the same time as such men as Elias Lönnrot, J. V. Snellman and J. L. Runeberg in the 1820s, retained his romantically-rooted idealism throughout the decades and from the 1850s onwards passed on his wisdom, his learning and his enthusiasm to new generations of students. For from 1854 onwards he was professor of aesthetics and contemporary literature at Helsinki University; one of the young men who heard his lectures (and those of Elias Lönnrot too) was Aleksis Kivi. When in the late 1850s and early 1860s Kivi set about formulating the Kullervo legend as a drama, he was able to draw on a ready analysis of this heroic character: Cygnaeus' study of the Kalevala.

Aleksis Kivi was not the only person to be influenced by Cygnaeus' article, since it also prompted Z. Topelius to attack the Kullervo theme, though to begin with he knew nothing of Kivi's attempt. The Swedish-speaking Topelius was fascinated by the "battle of the free spirit against slavery" stressed by Cygnaeus (Vasenius 1931: 446–449), but on hearing that Kivi was working on the same theme he abandoned his original plan and developed his opera *Prinsessan af Cypern* out of the Lemminkäinen legends (1869). His drama has Romantic traits: he shifted Lemminkäinen's adventures with the island maidens to distant Cyprus and made a marked contrast between North and South — a feature typical of the contemporary lyric, for example. Lemminkäinen returns from the South to the North like Odysseus to Ithaca, and the patriotic overtones are obvious: poor though it may be, barren Finland is still the fatherland, not to be exchanged for the flowery groves of the South. All in all the "Finnish poverty" motif with its implied positive values was a pronounced element of contemporary literature.

In Topelius' drama the legends of the Kalevala were transformed into a contemporary drama whose colours look somewhat faded in the light of the present day. But in his *Kullervo* (first version 1860, published 1864) the pioneer of Finnish literature Aleksis Kivi created a highly individual work of art in which his hero, a catastrophe man, outlaw and social recluse (Ervasti 1965: 70–71) grows towards tragic greatness in much the same way as Shakespeare's Hamlet. Using the

Kalevala as his source, Kivi gave a brilliant portrayal of the opposition between Romantic idealism and the new realistic philosophy characteristic of the mid 19th century and at the same time perpetuated the problem of Good and Evil. There was also a word of warning underlying this tale of fratricide in a Finland under the shadow of linguistic conflict: "Why did they not seek agreement, since life still shone upon both of them?" A word of warning to seek agreement also held historical relevance at a later date in Finland too, such as in the Civil War, though people have not always wished to hear it in time. Even in the 19th century the social powerlessness of the crofter under a large landlord was attached to the figure of Kullervo. Juhani Aho's *Illuded by the World*, a slight but artistically effective prose work, socialised and historicised this tragic hero from the Kalevala in 1894 and presaged the contrasts that would become aggravated to the point of Civil War. It is in many respects thus highly indicative that Finnish art set in motion by the Kalevala was from the very beginning anchored on the Kullervo theme, in literature, painting and music alike.

The myth capable of acting as an explanation for the world and as a means for man to recognise himself carried the most significance: this was pointed out by Hans Fromm in his analysis of the Kalevala-ism of Eino Leino (Fromm 1980: 42). Although the Lemminkäinen episodes have also proved fertile soil for Finnish art, Kullervo has nevertheless been seen as a more inherently Finnish hero than the hot-blooded Viking, and the line in this sense continues right up to the Paavo Haavikko of the 1970s and 1980s. Haavikko belongs to the third great wave of Kalevala-inspired poetry, a wave completely different in nature and goals from those of the National Romanticism of Aleksis Kivi's day and the Neoromanticism of the turn of the century. There is no longer any need for a national epic to reinforce national identity, or for immediate defence against political pressure from without. Paavo Haavikko has, more convincingly than any other poet in the last few decades, revealed the flexibility and modernisability of myths. In his poetic work *Twenty and One* (1974) about the stealing of the Sampo he analysed a collective project, and in his *Iron Age* (1982) he humanised

the Kalevala heroes, from Väinämöinen to Ilmarinen, as individuals capable of sorrow and of joy. From the literary/historical perspective Haavikko can, especially as the teller of Kullervo's tale, be compared to Aleksis Kivi, but his style and certain structural solutions show that more than hundred years have passed. Tradition is a highroad; the poet and the artist follow their own paths. What is important is the realisation that the Kalevala has not lost any of its importance in the course of the decades, either as national Finnish cultural property or as a source of inspiration for Finnish art. A natural part of the Finnish character, the Kalevala tradition is still to be found again in art poetry.

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Points of Comparison Europe

Vilmos Voigt

The Kalevala and the Epic Traditions of Europe

In a letter to Henrik Cajander dated 3.12.1833 Elias Lönnrot, then aged 31, told of a recent journey to Russian Karelia, stating that he had obtained five or six thousand lines of poetry on Väinämöinen alone. “In the winter I intend to visit Archangel Province again,” he said, “and I shall not cease until I have a collection of verses equal to half of Homer” (Anttila 1931: 217). Lönnrot was prompted to utter these noble words by his fourth journey, or to be more precise, the five days or so he spent at Vuonninen. It was then that he met Ontrei Malinen and Vaassila Kieleväinen, two singers who were to have a decisive influence on the overall structure of his collections.

A further important document by Lönnrot is his letter of 6.2.1834 to J. G. Linsén, chairman of the Finnish Literature Society, in which he stated his plan for arranging Finnish mythical poems into one composition “something like the Icelandic Edda” (Anttila 1931: 217–218). He also dealt with the question of whether the material in his collection could be combined to form an entity as great and as highly respected in the eyes of posterity as the Edda among the Gothic peoples, and if not Homer, then at least Hesiod among the Greeks and the Romans. Lönnrot again touched on the subject in the preface to the Old Kalevala of 28.2.1835, mentioning a few historical facts to facilitate the understanding of the epic’s structure. Lönnrot writes:

I have tried to put these songs into some sort of order, a task of which I should give some account. Even when reading the songs previously collected, particularly those collected by Ganander, I already wondered whether it might not be possible to find enough songs about Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen, Lemminkäinen and other

memorable forebears to form longer accounts of them, too, just as we see that the Greeks, the Icelanders and others found songs about their ancestors. The idea grew in my mind when, in 1826, I happened to write a book about Väinämöinen with the help of von Becker, reader in history at Turku [Academy]...

Forerunners of the Kalevala

According to Lönnrot both Christfrid Ganander and Reinhold von Becker were to some extent aware of similarities between the old Greek, Icelandic and Finnish poems. As Fromm has pointed out (1968: 6–7), Lönnrot was not only repeatedly comparing himself to Homer; he was an active student of Greek and Latin and translated sections from both the Iliad and the Odyssey. Finnish folklore scholars underline the role of H. G. Porthan as mediator. Porthan was acquainted at least indirectly with the publications of such men as Percy and Macpherson, and later also of Herder (Hautala 1954: 62–64). No wonder, therefore, that Ossianism took root in Finland in the Turku of Porthan, and at a relatively early date. It is a well-known fact that Hugh Blair's famous *Critical Dissertation on the Poems of Ossian* appeared in 1763, and Percy's foreword to the *Reliques of Ancient Poetry* in 1765. The first translations of Ossian into Swedish appeared in Finland in the *Åbo Tidningar* from 1775 onwards. Also dating from 1775 is a thesis by Johan Henrik Kellgren entitled *De poesi ubivis gentium philosophiae praevia*, which also mentions Ossian. The subject was set by Porthan (Sarajas 1956: 230–234, 350–353). The thesis is especially interesting as it quotes Homer via Ossian, thus adhering to the romantic trend and approach then fashionable in Europe (Sarajas 1956: 351). The works by the Turku writers also contain a handful of references to ancient Scandinavian poetry (Sarajas 1956: 235).

Finnish and comparative research have a tendency to emphasise the influence of nationalist sentiments and the state of contemporary Finnish society on Lönnrot's work and the Kalevala. It would seem obvious from the above that his epic is a continuation of the European tradition, and that it was being compared to Homer, Ossian and ancient Icelandic poetry at a very early stage. The parallel was drawn not by Lönnrot alone, but by many before and after him.

The Swedish translation of the work *Finnland und seine Bewohner* by the German historian Fr. Rühs published in Stockholm in 1811 was reviewed in 1817 by Carl Axel Gottlund in the *Svensk Litteratur-tidning*. Gottlund predicted that if anyone were to collect and publish the traditional Finnish folk songs in any form whatsoever, as a narrative poem, a play or some other poetic genre, the result would be "a new Homer, Ossian or Nibelungenlied". A. J. Sjögren also debated the potential for a Finnish epic in his book *Über die finnische Sprache und Ihre Literatur* of 1821. Although Lönnrot had not, so far as we know, read this book, he could have been familiar with Sjögren's ideas from some other source.

In 1845 Robert Tengström, in his major treatise on the Old Kalevala, wrote that the Kalevala may rank second to the Iliad and the Odyssey, but that it rates higher than Ossian, the Nibelungenlied and Edda. Tengström's article also contains some interesting ideological references that cannot be taken up here as the role of the Hegelian left-wing faction in the development of Finland's national culture has not yet been sufficiently investigated (Manninen 1983; oral communication from Aili Nenola).

In Finland as elsewhere (e. g. Hungary, Marót 1948; Simonsuuri 1979) the history of the birth of the Kalevala has been tied in with the problems surrounding Homer and Ossian. Worthy of more attention than they at present receive are the connections with ancient Icelandic poetry, above all the Edda, and ancient Germanic poetry, such as the Nibelungenlied, or such 19th century Scandinavian poetry in archaic vein as that of Tegnér. Unfortunately no systematic study has been made of Lönnrot's acquaintance with Scandinavian poetry. We do, on

the other hand, know that an interest in Scandinavia may have put him on the tracks of the Kalevala, as was the case with Longfellow (Hilen 1947: 43–44; Moyne 1963). Numerous attempts have been made, but no one has yet managed to provide an exhaustive answer to the question of whether there are in fact any connections between the classical scholarship conducted in Finland and Lönnrot's concept of the Kalevala (see, however, Aalto 1980). Another special item for research would be the connections between the Kalevala and Finnish Orientalist research (see, however, Aalto 1971; Alphonso-Karkala 1985). Some recent research has come up with signs that Lönnrot was familiar with Indian and Persian myths, but no concrete sources have been traced. Mention must in this context be made of an important work called *Samling af de äldsta folkslagens religionsurkunder* (1820), which appears to have got a good reception in Finland.

In brief: the Kalevala is a summary of Finnish literature, culture and social development, and it is against this broad background that it should be understood and interpreted (Voigt 1982).

First reactions

The Kalevala became the subject of much debate and controversy shortly after it was published. It was a superb example of a living epic, and this applied to singers and collectors alike — something that could not possibly be said of other epics: nothing was known of the singers of Ossian and Homer, the author of the *Nibelungenlied* was anonymous, and in some cases, such as Macpherson, even the text turned out to be nongenuine.

It is an established fact that large numbers of both Finnish and Swedish-speaking Finns gave the Old Kalevala a good reception, and that it was also mentioned in the Swedish, Russian, German and British press. The first translations into Swedish, Russian, German and

Hungarian were embarked on even before the second edition. Educated circles were introduced to the Kalevala through lectures and reviews. It was thanks to Jacob Grimm that people came to hear of it on a wider international scale. On March 13, 1845 he gave a lecture at the Imperial Academy in Berlin entitled *Über das finnische Epos*; this was published in Finland that same year in an abridged, Swedish version (Grimm 1845). Grimm compared the Kalevala to the Nibelungenlied, Edda, Homer and Ossian, drawing on all the key words then in circulation in 19th century theory of the epic (see Kunze 1952). It is interesting to note that Lönnrot was aware of Grimm's opinion: he referred to the abridged Swedish version of the article in a letter to M. A. Castrén dated 4.9.1845 (af Forselles 1911: 452–453) and in his important introduction to the second edition *Anmärkningar till den nya Kalevala upplagan* in 1849 (af Forselles 1908: 225–226; Fromm 1980; Kaukonen 1963).

Even the Old Kalevala — like the new one that followed — was for its readers above all a source of mythology, and only then a work of poetry. Jacob Grimm made a convincing comparison of motifs from the Kalevala and ancient Teutonic and Greek myths and legends in his work *Deutsche Mythologie* published as early as 1844, i. e. before his Berlin lecture. This trend was to prevail for about as long as the “nature mythological” school (Hautala 1969: 41–53).

Estonia: Kalevipoeg

The epic most obviously influenced by the Kalevala is the Kalevipoeg of Estonia. As we know, Fr. R. Kreutzwald published this in two languages (German and Estonian) and six volumes between 1857 and 1861, after many years spent collecting Estonian folklore. He in fact began editing his epic with a view to publication one year after the release of the Kalevala, in 1836, when the periodical *Das Inland* issued

an article by R. Hollman called *Beiträge zur estnischen Mythologie*, which presumably included examples of folk poetry from Kreutzwald's pen (text of the poem *Vaskjala silla piiga*). According to Laugaste the first Estonian reaction to the Kalevala was the set of folk tales published by G. H. Schüdlöffel in *Das Inland* in 1836. To my mind Hollman's article does, however, have some even earlier and more exact points in common. As early as 1835 Kreutzwald was already writing his ballad in German "Kalews Sohn" (Naan et al. 1953: 213). From the very outset mythological and poetic values were closely interwoven in the national epic of Estonia. In his foreword to the 1853 edition (the Proto-Kalevipoeg) Kreutzwald forbids future generations to alter the spelling, and he clearly expresses his claims to his personal copyright. The closing statement to the foreword, famous in its day, begins with a psychologically interesting identification with Homer: "Since this is the supreme achievement of my life, and one which — like Homer today — will be in every library thousands of years from now..." (Kreutzwald 1961–63: II, 15–16). The preface of 1857 again begins with a quotation from Grimm, and in the course of the text he mentions both Macpherson and the Kalevala.

It is easy to provide evidence that Kalevipoeg was compiled according to the same comparative principles as the Kalevala. G. J. Schultz-Bertram put forward a general theory on the compilation of a national epic in an address to the Estonian Learned Society in October 1839. The main genres of folklore (song, legend and narrative) are universal, and they provide each nation with sufficient scope for independent expression. "How can our Society best help our nation to become enlightened," he asks, "to further the spiritual rebirth of this nation, which has, it is claimed, come of age and been freed from serfdom but which still sighs under the yoke of its immaturity and hardships? In two ways, I think: let us give the nation an epic and a history, and all will be well. There is sufficient substance for the latter, let us continue to collect for the former" (Laugaste & Normann 1959: 97).

Even more astonishing are the points of comparison put forward by Schultz-Bertram. This scholar, known for his translation of Kalevipoeg into German, saw two strata in the character of Kalevanpoika.

The first is “a monster incomprehensible to the Europeans in his might and his boundlessness”. He likens this Kalevanpoika to the rough, primitive epic heroes of ancient times and distant regions, from the fantasy world of infant nations. The figure is akin to the giant ox of the Finns, the subterranean mammoths of the Tungus, the 1000-limbed giant of the Kalmuks out of whose bleached bones the Himalayas grew. He sees in the idea and structure of the epic the influence of Greek and Teutonic models: as the true hero of the epic Kalevanpoika corresponds to the Hercules, Odysseus and Siegfried of the European peoples (Laugaste & Normann 1959: 97–98).

Thus even before the publication of the epic its main hero was already being compared to Hercules and Odysseus, Siegfried and Achilles; corresponding images were found in Tungus and Kalmuk poetry, and Kalevipoeg was branded as “Asian”, in contrast to the “classical charming or elegant” or “more civilised” European creation.

The first Estonian to set about translating the Kalevala was M. Mühlberg in 1840, who published the first canto and a brief summary of the contents of the epic in Estonian. These are not the only references to Finnish folklore. For example, Schultz-Bertram mentions Finnish folklore in his introduction to Estonian fairytales, and even begins his history of Estonian folklore with the *Mythologia Fennica* of Christfrid Ganander (Laugaste & Normann 1959: 103–104).

To summarise: even before the final materialisation of Kalevipoeg and before the second edition of the Kalevala, scholars in Estonia were putting forward the same ideas about the contents and role of a national heroic epic as their colleagues in Finland.

Hungary, Scandinavia, Russia

One might expect Hungary to have produced a work comparable to Kalevipoeg. In Hungary the shared fate with the Finno-Ugrians was a recognised and overlooked fact — widely debated and proven false,

hotly defended by linguists but scorned by aristocrats: they could not imagine how they could be related to such paltry nations living in semi-slavery in a northerly territory that differed little from Siberia.

Antal Reguly, an ardent field worker among almost all the Finno-Ugrian peoples, had already heard of the Old Kalevala by 1839. His first short translations date from 1841. In the years that followed Hungary's literary journals carried references to the Kalevala, and the leading folklorist at that time, Jonas Erdélyi, was pointing out the Finns' achievement even before Hungary's bid for freedom in 1848–1849, and thus before the second edition of the Kalevala (Domokos 1983). From then onwards there was a steady interest in the Kalevala that persisted uninterrupted and that can to some extent be seen as perpetuating the older national strivings of the Hungarians (Voigt 1983).

The Kalevala might also be expected to have struck a similar chord in Russia and Scandinavia, too, but so far as we know, there was no attempt in this direction, apart from a general interest in the Kalevala. To the literary circles of Sweden, Finland was still a Swedish province in which all literature of any note was in the Swedish language and helped to distinguish Finnish culture from the Russian and place it against its common Scandinavian background. While they could accept the excitement caused by the Kalevala, it did not occur to them to embark on a similar venture. It was generally consented that the *Frithiofs saga* by Esaias Tegnér (1820) was the consummate representative of the poetic revival.

Finnish literature was now appearing in two languages; Lönnrot did not wish to follow in Tegnér's footsteps and Runeberg could not read the Kalevala in Finnish without the help of the Swedish translation. This is the background to an anecdote told in 1832, according to which Runeberg and Lönnrot stood for the melancholic art poetry being written in Swedish at that time and genuine Finnish folk poetry (Anttila 1931: 142–143).

The most notable example of the Russian literary epic is “*Slovo o polku Igoreve*” (The Song of Igor's Campaign). The manuscript of this ancient chronicle was found in the 1790s and published in 1800;

the original manuscript in Moscow was destroyed by fire during the Napoleonic Wars. Wise from the counterfeit Ossian, scholars began to doubt that such a manuscript had ever even existed. In 1858 the Zadonshchina text edition, which referred beyond all doubt to the text of Igor, finally silenced most of these doubts. The Song of Igor's Campaign is a literary product already hundreds of years old when the debate on its authenticity broke out. It is important to know that the question of the Song of Igor's Campaign was a major item for linguistic-literary debate in Russia at the time the Old and New Kalevalas were being created (Likhatchev 1978; Adrianova-Peretc 1974).

More recent Russian heroic epics, *byliny*, began to be collected in the mid-18th century and published at the beginning of the 1800s. A surprising number of contemporary authorities believed that *byliny* were no longer sung, until one day in 1860 P. N. Rybnikov took refuge from a storm on an island in Lake Onega and woke in the night to the strains of an unusual song, a Sadko *bylina*. In the years to follow this discovery spurred collectors into an almost frenzied search for new *byliny*. Between 1861 and 1867 a total of 24 *bylina* texts were published in four volumes (Oinas 1978a: 237). Folklorists, linguists and historians entered into lively debate. Unfortunately the history of *bylina* research makes no mention of the Kalevala (see e. g. Anikin 1978–1980). It does, however, seem likely that Lönnrot was aware of the occupations of his easterly colleagues.

The literary ties between Russia and Finland in the first half of the 19th century were not as straightforward as may be imagined. The chief intermediary was Jakov K. Grot (1812–1893). He made his first visit to Finland in summer 1837, when he was working on a translation of Tegnér's Frithiofs saga into Russian and wanted to improve his command of Swedish. In June 1840 he took up residence in Helsinki and in April 1841 was appointed professor of Russian literature, history and economics at the University of Helsinki.

The Finnish university had celebrated its 200th anniversary in July 1840, and Lönnrot was a guest of honour. Also present was a distinguished Russian delegation that met both Lönnrot and the poet laureate,

Runeberg, learnt about Lönnrot's fieldwork and came to the conclusion that Lönnrot was superior to Runeberg (Anttila 1931: 352–355). In 1840 Grot wrote a leading article on the Finns and their folklore in which he paid due homage to Lönnrot and his work. Lönnrot was familiar with the journal, *Sovremennik*, in which it appeared.

Grot spent a good 12 years in Helsinki, gathering about him a group of Finnish-minded Russian intellectuals (Kiparsky 1975: 72–83). We learn from an interesting letter from Lönnrot to Grot on 31.8.1841 that he knew of Grot's translation of Frithiof and urged him to translate Tegnér's *Axel*, too (Čistov 1950: 201–202).

Literary scholars in Soviet Karelia have given a detailed account of the communications between Lönnrot and Grot (Karhu 1962: 116–126; Karhu 1978). Yet all we can say is that although Lönnrot probably knew about Russian folklore and contemporary literary debate, he paid them little attention. It seems that Russian intellectualism was for him the antithesis of the Swedish model. He did not know that only a few miles away from the singers he so praised was a rich folklore in the Russian language. It thus played no part in his *Kalevala*.

From the Old *Kalevala* to the New

Lönnrot's two versions of the *Kalevala* are an unparalleled aid to the scholar attempting to devise a theory for the creation of an epic. As we have seen, the Finnish epic was from the very beginning regarded as meeting the generally accepted theoretical demands. In his final edition Lönnrot was able to incorporate the material and observations that appeared in European literature following the publication of the Old *Kalevala*. It is in fact important to remember that the earliest comparisons and theoretical observations were already provoked by this period in Lönnrot's creative output, i. e. the years between the publication of the Old and the New *Kalevala*.

The situation changed with the publication of the “final” monument to Finnish folklore in 1849. Scholars do not appear to have been disturbed by the increase in the number of epic songs. This is explained by the widely-known Homer theory of Wolf that was also applied to Germanic and ancient Icelandic poetry and according to which a genius is capable of creating a great heroic epic even out of little songs (*Kleinlied*). Lönnrot was likewise acquainted with this interpretation. He did not draw primarily on the original work by Wolf but on the 6th edition of C. Fr. Becker’s *Svensk Verldshistoria*, parts of which he personally translated into Finnish. Strangely enough, the references to Homer are to be found on the pages he did not translate, but it is certain that Lönnrot addressed the task of translation immediately on completing the Old Kalevala. The translation includes more than 700 lines of Homer and deals with the problem of Homer at least twice (Anttila 1931: 287–290; Kaukonen 1979: 50). How to translate the ancient Greek hexameter into Finnish? This was a question that fascinated Lönnrot for some time, and he seems here to have found a satisfactory answer. The stylistic influence of Homer is indeed evident at certain points in the Kalevala.

The epic since the New Kalevala

Following the publication of the New Kalevala, epic theory soon assimilated the evidence thus provided as scholars learnt to read it or at least parts of it. True, there were to begin with few such scholars.

In 1855 Karl Rosenkranz looked with favour on the Kalevala in his oft-quoted work *Die Poesie und ihre Geschichte*. Stylistically he compared the work to Ossian. Max Müller, referring to the *Iliad* in his first series of philological lectures in 1861, stressed the oral quality of the Kalevala. In his essay “Das Epos” (1868) Heymann Steinthal classified epics in three categories according to their structure and in

this respect compared the Kalevala to Homer, El Cid, the Nibelungenlied, the Song of Roland, etc. In Paris M. A. Geffroy was moved in his article "La Finlande et le Kalevala" (1871) to make an even broader comparison and claimed that the social background to the Finnish epic was Russian. The English scholar F. C. Cook went so far as to refer in his article "The Kalevala" (1885) to the Indian epic. In addition to these articles two separate publications were issued: *Über epische Dichtungen der finnischen Völker, besonders die Kalevala* by W. J. A. von Tettau (1873) and the work on the Kalevala by Domenico Comparetti (1891). Comparetti gives a detailed account of the Kalevala problem, emphasising the inherent features of the work as a national epic. This major work by Comparetti ended the first chapter in the history of the world's reception of the Kalevala.

Translations of the Kalevala, both partial and complete, gradually began to appear in different languages, and scholars who did not understand Finnish were thus granted access to the work. Towards the end of the 19th century both Finno-Ugrian linguistics and folklore research became established in Finland as honoured disciplines. This trend also inspired literature introducing the public at large to the results of their research and bringing the Kalevala closer and closer to the foreign reader.

Just over a hundred years ago, in 1886, Domenico Comparetti made his first visit to Finland to get to know the Kalevala and the literature dealing with it. He was already well versed in Homer, Virgil and mediaeval cultures. He intended to collect material that might, by analogy, throw light on the problems of the Homeric epic. In a symbolic gesture he dedicated the work in question, published five years later, to Julius Krohn, founder of the world-famous Finnish school. It is a well-known fact that Krohn took a very broad view of folklore and the Kalevala; he avoided any national narrow-mindedness (Hautala 1969: 87; Kuusi 1986). Thus attempts at understanding epics in 19th century Europe led as far as Finland was concerned to the clearly-recognised discipline of folklore research.

While the Finnish school was working on a method for investigating folklore, certain intellectuals were occupied elsewhere on new “Kalevala-ish” products. In 1888 Andrejs Pumpurs (1841–1901), one of the first writers in Latvia, published the epic *Lāčplēsis* (The Bear Killer). Not only did he adhere closely to the example of the Kalevala and Kalevipoeg, he widened their stylistic scope to serve a completely different Latvian epic (*Lāčplēsis* 1975). On the other hand it is interesting to note that neither Lithuania nor Poland greeted the Kalevala with such warmth at the end of the 19th century. Non-Catholic and not anti-Russian, the Kalevala probably did not have sufficient appeal. The Kalevala did not appear in Lithuanian translation until 1910, and the first fragmentary translations into Polish date from the 1880s (Krawczyk-Wasilewska 1985).

Nowadays, in the 1980s, creative work inspired by the Kalevala has spread even beyond the borders of Europe. In Asia and Africa the Kalevala is regarded as an example of how the old oral tradition can help to build up a national identity.

The Kalevala thus acts as an example of three time levels in the process of creating a national epic. The first coincides with the first half of the 18th century, when the most influential motifs in Europe were those of Scandinavian origin (Omberg 1976), though F. Ohrt does not, surprisingly enough, make any reference to the question of Scandinavian influences in his monographs (Ohrt 1908, 1909). The second period falls at the beginning of the 19th century, when for close on half a century the Finnish national epic, the predominant symbol of Finland’s national awareness, gradually took shape. Both foreign (Mead 1962; Wilson 1976) and Finnish folklorists have in recent general treatises laid special emphasis on this specific aspect (Honko 1980, 1985; Klinge 1980). Some scholars state that in arousing a sense of national awareness among the Finns the Kalevala was also an inherent element in the emergence of national sentiments among Finland’s Swedish speakers (Andersson 1967), that it combined these two lines (Honko 1969) and that it was equally important to the national awareness of

the Estonians (Oinas 1969). This view merits more attention than it at present receives.

From a purely literary perspective the Kalevala is one of the most conspicuous representatives of the Romantic era in Europe, and one that is especially characteristic of the peoples inhabiting the eastern regions (Sõter 1977; Sziklay 1977; Hoffmeister 1978). Scholars have not looked sufficiently into the political aspect, if indeed such an aspect exists (see, however, Branch 1985; Wilson 1978; Oinas 1978b).

The third period in the history of the Kalevala is the birth of subsequent national epics, for it would appear that this stage has been important both to the Finno-Ugrian peoples and to “new” nations in general (Pakhomova 1977).

The 150th anniversary of the publication of the Kalevala once again provided a suitable forum for re-examining the reception of Finnish folklore and its influence in Europe — an influence so broad in scope it is difficult to analyse exhaustively.

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Eduard Laugaste

The Kalevala and Kalevipoeg

The Estonians, like the Finns, have more reason than any other nation to know and cherish the Kalevala, not merely as a source of inspiration and example for Kalevipoeg and other national literature, but also because it is an epic shared by all the Baltic-Finnic people and a descendant of the ancient culture common to both Finland and Estonia, and much of the folk poetry it contains is just as much our common heritage (A. Annist).

The study of the folk culture of former eras is national research in the sense that it attempts to seek out the roots of the nation's culture, and the people conducting this research are nationals of the country in question, but it is also international, since our ancient culture has international roots and connections (E. N. Setälä).

The most obvious proof of the power of collective creativity is the fact that for centuries now no individual has managed to produce anything comparable to the Iliad or the Kalevala, nor has individual genius succeeded in achieving anything of universal application that is not in some way connected with the nation's creative power (M. Gorki).

The Kalev of early lore and literature

There are numerous references in the oral tradition to Kalevi (Kalev, Kalevipoeg), a figure who features in both prose and poetry. Kalev, Kalevipoeg in the legends and myths explaining the origin of living

creation and phenomena — lakes, rocks and boulders, i. e. the early history of the world's topography. He is a giant figure who engages in battle with other giants or enemies of the nation. Studies have been made of the origin of these stories and the various guises in which Kalev appears (see Laugaste & Normann 1959). Kalev is a prominent figure in the old Estonian alliterative folk poetry (*regilaulud*); his name appears in various forms — Kalev, Kalevine, Kalevipoiss, Kalevine poisikine. Kalevin poika also appears in e. g. poems of the type “Suisa suud” (Laugaste 1959: 202–208, 274–282; Viires 1961). Kalevipoeg appears to occupy a dual role in oral folk tradition: in legends he is a giant hero, in poetry a figure of note, an aristocrat. His name was to begin with very much a proper name. As a whole the Kalevipoeg tradition consists of materials from very different sources which learned scholars immersed in various epic projects began to join together.

The first written mention of the name Kalev is to be found in *Leyen Spiegel* (*ninck ux Kalliweb*) by H. Stahl appearing in 1641. The name was also used to denote a giant by J. Gutsclaff, A. Thor Helle, A. W. Hupel and S. H. Vestring. Finland can boast of an even earlier appearance, in the list of deities published by Mikael Agricola in 1551: the *Caleuanpoiat* are according to this mowers, chiefly giants. Sometimes a topography caused by giants causes infertility. A. Knüpfker wrote: “Kalevipoeg ploughed the land with his wooden plough until it was barren. This evil giant also molested women until Christ converted him” (Rosenplänter 1817: 58–59). Kr. J. Peterson expressed the same thing in a different way: “The Estonians say that one of Kalevi's sons ploughed grassy lands with a wooden plough, after which not a blade of grass sprang up. This evil giant also harassed women” (Rosenplänter 1822). We likewise find Kalevipoeg molesting a maiden in poems of the “Suisa suud” type. Peterson's text is included in the translation into German (1822: 102) of *Mythologia Fennica*, originally written by Chr. Ganander in Swedish (1789). In the course of translating it Peterson reorganised the material in the original work, adding a number of notes and supplementing it with Estonian material, chiefly with passages from old alliterative folk poems. It is interesting to note that in the

poem about the maid of the island (*Saarepiiga*) Kalevipoeg also acquires a sister-corrupting motif that would in part at least seem to explain the mention of “molesting the maidens” in old texts. The motif must in fact have been familiar to Kreutzwald even before he began studying the Kullervo poetry. Under the entry “Väinämöinen” Peterson again supplements his account with Estonian elements; this time he introduces the folk poem “Kannel”, adding: the Estonians, too, probably knew a god such as this. Admittedly the divine figure has vanished from the poem, and his place is taken by the singing peasant (*talupoeg*). The translator also notes that in the poem “Tähemorsja” (Star Bride) the sun, the moon and the stars are also regarded as deities.

Peterson’s translation of *Mythologia Fennica* also contains certain other mythological concepts significant in this context, such as *Soini*, the babe-in-arms three days old that tears its swaddling clothes apart in its cradle. In Kreutzwald’s epic Kalevipoeg tears his swaddling clothes apart and breaks his cradle to pieces at the end of the first month of his life (Kalevipoeg II, I:658–662). Another example is the name *Obto*, a euphemism for the bear commonly known as *ott* in Estonian; from this is derived the place name Odenpäh, and Peterson believes this place was in fact associated with the culture surrounding the bear. It is quite possible that Kreutzwald’s ballad Kalew’s Sohn was written even before the publication of the Kalevala. In it Kalevipoeg runs off with the daughter of a Finnish witch, and for this he is later put in irons and finally killed.

Faehlmann’s view and the first impression of the Kalevala

A new era dawned in the cultural history of Estonia with the reopening of the University of Tartu in 1802. The spirit prevailing at this seat of learning was to begin with that of the Enlightenment, and it was here that a small band of young Estonians received their higher education.

The voluntary learned society *Õpetatud Eesti Selts* established under the auspices of the University attracted not only Estonians but also German lecturers at the University and other members of the local intelligentsia. The society subsequently assumed responsibility for the publishing of *Kalevipoeg*.

The part played by F. R. Faehlmann, an active member of the society, in promoting the idea of compiling *Kalevipoeg* was of primary significance. His counterpart as pioneer pointing the way to the compilation of the *Kalevala* is, perhaps, Gottlund or von Becker. This was the golden era of the romantic vision of the epic; and it seems natural to assume that such a learned assembly was already debating the subject of a national epic even before the appearance of the *Kalevala*. By 1833 both Faehlmann and Kreutzwald had had some experience of collecting Estonian folk poetry; they had also got to know the folk *Kalevipoeg* material through such works as Rosenplänter's *Beiträge* and Ganander's German version of the *Mythologia Fennica*, *Finnische Mythologie*. At around the time the *Kalevala* was published, in 1836, Pastor G. H. Schüdlöffel published fragments from the legends about *Kalevipoeg* in a journal called *Das Inland*. On January 4, 1839 F. R. Faehlmann gave a lecture at the Estonian Learned Society in which he gave an account of the collection and contents of the legends about *Kalevipoeg*. What is significant is that he classified the *Kalevipoeg* legends according to subject. Later the lecture was to provide valuable material for Kreutzwald when he began to create *Kalevipoeg*.

The first clear equation of the *Kalevala* with *Kalevipoeg* dates from slightly later, October 1839, when G. J. Schultz-Bertram addressed the Learned Society on the subject of the *Kalevala* and presented the Society with a copy of the epic he had brought with him from Finland. Give the nation an epic and a history, he said, and all is won. This is precisely what is needed to arouse a sense of national self-awareness. And he appealed to his listeners to collect material based on the *Kalevipoeg* tradition, claiming that all this material was characteristic of the Finnic peoples. While in Finland he had seen what the epic meant to the nation's culture; the epic alone was capable of portraying

the historical might of the nation in so convincing a manner. The nation reacts in the same way as the beggar on learning he is the king's son. From the European perspective Kalevipoeg could be just as important as Hercules or Siegfried. His listeners were fired by this speech. The words spoken by Schultz on that occasion are reminiscent of those uttered by Gottlund on the birth of the Kalevala, and they most certainly made an impression on Faehlmann, who made the compilation of an Estonian epic his life's work and even wrote some lines in German by way of experiment, but death put an end to this work. We can, however, conclude from the fragments he did complete that his text would have resembled not the old alliterative folk poetry but classical poetry. In any case the initial impetus was there, and this was reflected in the wide-scale collection of folklore.

Lönnrot, Faehlmann and Kreutzwald

In late 1844, equipped with Ahrens' grammar of the Estonian language, Elias Lönnrot arrived in Kuusalu ready to study the language and to collect philological material. From Kuusalu he continued his journey to Koeru and Tartu (see Kettunen 1908: 1–9; Eisen 1923: 337–346; Suits 1931: 157–169). As a result of his journey we have a lively account of the relationships between the large land-owners and the peasants, Faehlmann, and the work of the Estonian Learned Society. Members of the Society now had a chance to meet the creator of the Kalevala in person. Lönnrot and the Kalevala were the subject of debate at no fewer than ten meetings of the Learned Society in the course of the 1840s. Lönnrot was probably aware of the state of Estonian folklore at that time. An account of his journey and the contacts he made is given in his work *Matkat 1823–1844* (1980: 11th journey, 1844). In South Estonia Lönnrot happened to meet Kreutzwald, at Võru. Their meeting was brief, and his acquaintance

with Kreutzwald extremely superficial. With Faehlmann, however, he had a much closer relationship. Both were, after all, dedicated to noting down manifestations of non-material folk culture and editing them to form a work of art. As a person, too, Faehlmann was clearly more of a kindred spirit to Lönnrot, despite certain differences of opinion over such matters as spelling. Lönnrot was greatly moved by Faehlmann's death; he regarded it both as the loss of a personal friend and as a misfortune for the Estonian language and Estonian culture in general.

Lönnrot was impressed at the meetings of the Estonian Learned Society by the uninhibited and warm relations that existed between its members. Both Faehlmann and Lönnrot took as their model the metric variety of length and stress in folk poetry. Lönnrot provided Faehlmann with the necessary literature. He nevertheless disagreed with Faehlmann's way of creating legends and stories. Lönnrot's visit to Tartu undoubtedly had an invigorating effect on plans for an epic in Estonia. By the time he left Tartu, he had a wealth of new information, and he left behind a desire to create Kalevipoeg that later bore fruit, first in the hands of Faehlmann and finally of Kreutzwald. August Annist believes that Faehlmann first set about writing Kalevipoeg as early as 1833; he in fact told Kreutzwald this in a letter. And the theory that he may even have finished a work by that name cannot altogether be ruled out (Annist 1936: 52–59).

The birth of Kalevipoeg

Kreutzwald, having inherited the task of creating an epic, was to collect material, include metric poetry, and where possible to apply Finnish material, too. He set the events of the work in the 13th century, for it was in the battle for freedom waged at that time that the might and tragic defeat of ancient Estonia were most clearly in evidence. The epic thus progresses according to the nation's history. Kalevipoeg is no

longer a giant; instead he is ruler of the ancient kingdom of Estonia and the personification of its might, as expressed in Old Kalev's wish: the kingdom must remain undivided, under the rule of one man (II:167–168). The destructive ploughing of the land by giants gives way to farming (cf. canto 1 of the *Kalevala*). Kreutzwald did, however, utilise the idea of destructive ploughing in describing the moment of revenge in the journey to the end of the world in chapter XVI.

The material on loan from Finland includes the story of the killing of the smith's son, which Kreutzwald combined with the cursing of the sword, and again the words of the Finnish smith: death be upon you, by the sword (VI:697–698), and the episode of the maid of the island. At last, after a period of frenzied work, the first version of *Kalevipoeg* was finally completed in 1853, and a gentleman by the name of Santo from the Learned Society hastened to claim that the epic may deservedly be placed alongside the *Kalevala*. This work is now known as the Proto-*Kalevipoeg* and it consists of 14,180 lines. Drastically cut by the censor, it never got into print. Kreutzwald completely revised the manuscript, paying special attention to the essence of folk poetry, and by September 1855 a new version was ready. The Society decided to print it as a scientific publication together with its German translation. This meant that *Kalevipoeg* could be published uncensored in six booklets, the first appearing on April 10, 1857 and the sixth on August 16, 1861.

Meanwhile the work had aroused interest in Berlin, Helsinki and — especially among the educated circles well disposed towards the people — St. Petersburg (F. A. Schiefner, F. J. Wiedemann, G. J. Schultz-Bertram, Ph. Karell, G. Hirsch). In 1859 Kreutzwald spent three weeks with friends in St. Petersburg, winning their respect and encouragement. Brimming with enthusiasm, he returned home and continued with his translation. In the same year, after the publication of the first part of the work, he received the Deminov honorary award from the Russian Academy of Sciences. His nomination for this award was particularly endorsed by the Russian philologist I. I. Sreznevski.

His friends in Finland also made it possible for a popular edition of *Kalevipoeg*, in Estonian only, to be printed in Kuopio in 1862.

The national epic of Estonia is a disjointed work made up of many pieces; this is also evident from the style. It is, however, held together by the writer's overall grasp of the main character: his human properties are emphasised, everything is overshadowed by the fateful cursing of the sword. Life and customs are as far as possible described in a manner in keeping with the people. The supporting theme is an abhorrence of the system of exploitation and injustice, and a respect for learning, manifest at the point where *Kalevipoeg* rashly promises to give *Varraku* the Book of Wisdom in chapters XVI and XIX. Also evident are the hero's humanity and his sympathy for the nation's fate. Kreutzwald changed the end of the work to make it optimistic and encouraging. *Kalev* returns home and brings happiness to the nation, eternal fortune to the land of Estonia.

The work contributed towards the national awakening beginning in Estonia, providing ideas and inspiration. The large number of translations and abridged versions proves that it kindled interest and found a readership outside Estonia, too. At home the epic prompted Estonians to collect folklore — Hurt, Eisen, Kallas and numerous other local collectors, who went out in their hundreds. A scientific folklore publication, *Vana Kannel*, went into publication. Scientific research into folklore got under way in Estonia. The most distinguished of the researchers looking into the epic itself was A. Annist, with his doctoral thesis and numerous articles. C. R. Jakobson used *Kalevipoeg* to stir up a sense of national awareness among the people. In the 19th century it became fashionable to read *Kalevipoeg* at reading circles. Motifs from the epic spawned Estonian literature, especially poetry. It was also a source of inspiration for sculptors, painters and composers, and it was not overlooked by drama, either. Art poetry attempted to imitate the metre of the old poetry (Ridala, Annist, more successfully G. Suits in his poetic work *A Child is Born*). Numerous prose narratives were also composed on themes from the epic (Fr. R. Kreutzwald, J. Kunder, E. Laugaste, E. Raud).

A widely-annotated, scholarly edition of Kalevipoeg was published by the Institute of Language and Literature of the Soviet-Estonian Academy of Science in honour of the work's centenary in 1961. A number of other editions have also appeared in Soviet-Estonia. Kalevipoeg has been translated into German, Russian, Ukrainian, Latvian, Finnish, Hungarian and Czech. It is no exaggeration to claim that Kalevipoeg was the stimulus that sparked off Estonian literature as we know it today. It was the first work actually written in Estonian — in the idiom of the people, national and democratic. A work that matured in the hands of Kreutzwald has delighted readers from the moment it was published right up to the present day.

Translation of the Kalevala into Estonian

Translators of the Kalevala into Estonian have repeatedly stressed the unusually favourable conditions for their work: linguistic problems were easily overcome, and the attitude of mind prevailing in the Kalevala was close in spirit to the Estonians. Estonian and Finnish folklore were seen to have much in common, and it was even said that much of the material in the Kalevala originally came from Estonia. All these things inevitably had a favourable effect on translation.

The first to translate the Kalevala was M. Mühlberg (1810–1854), a linguist with a university degree living in Tartu. He could speak several languages and had been on expeditions to Finland, Lapland and several islands in the Baltic. A translation of canto I in the 1835 edition of the Kalevala appeared as publication 11 of the Estonian Learned Society in 1840 with a glossary and a brief account of the epic. This stated that the Kalevala differs greatly from other major epics in a number of ways; the introduction prepares the reader for what is to come, by appealing to his heart. The performer of folk poetry views the world in a different light from the ordinary mortal. All creation is

sacred poetry to him. Fortune and misfortune are transformed into poetry, as stated by the creator of the epic in his preface. Mühlberg gave a lecture on the Kalevala at a meeting of the Estonian Learned Society on February 7, 1840. His translation consisted of the introductory canto only, but it was accompanied by a summary of the epic by H. J. Holmberg.

It remained for the generation following Kreutzwald to translate the Kalevala in its entirety. In the 1880s Estonian students took a very close interest in literary events in Finland. They also came into personal contact with Finns, for the song festival in Tallinn was attended by three Finnish scholars: Professor J. R. Aspelin, Dr. H. Appelgren and the young philologist O. A. F. Lönnbohm (Mustonen). Lönnbohm extended an invitation to the Estonians to attend the 50th anniversary of the Finnish Literature Society in Helsinki in 1881. A delegation consisting of the 12 members duly set off; one of them was M. J. Eisen, who was later to translate the Kalevala in its entirety. He got the idea for his work while staying in Finland in 1881 and 1882; he gave a detailed personal account of his stay in his diary, which he entitled *Isamaa Kalender* (1883) and later in the periodical *Eesti Kirjandus* (Eisen 1882: 101–106 and 1931, 169–185). Eisen began his work by publishing notes on the Kalevala and an abridged version in 1883; this mini-Kalevala was an adaptation of the work by R. Hertzberg. In the preface the writer stated that although the Finnish nation was poor in terms of material wealth, the Kalevala made it richer than many other nations. It was significant for the Estonians, too, that the work had found an established place among the finest epics in the world. The Estonians were interested in the Kalevala heroes, the only difficulty being that they did not understand Finnish. Translation would take years, so the edition with notes would have to suffice to begin with and prepare the reader for an understanding of the work as a whole. He further suggested that the notes could be used as an aid in schools. M. Kampmann, a writer of textbooks, later published a larger abridged version of the epic in *Eesti Kirjandus* (Kampmann 1910: 187–203).

Eisen soon began working on his translation and was to continue his task for years to come. The first fragment appeared in a periodical as early as 1882, but other brief excerpts were published in albums and calendars. Under the heading "The battle for the sun" Eisen published in *Isamaa Kalender* canto 47 (the sun is stolen), canto 48 (fetching the sun) and canto 49 (the new sun). The first half of the *Kalevala* appeared in translation in 1891, the second half in 1898. This was a notable achievement in the history of the translation of the *Kalevala*, even though not all the lines were in trochaic metre and certain critics proposed that it be shortened. The translator in fact took heed of the sharp criticism afforded his work and the second edition, dating from 1912 and 1921, got a more favourable reception. A third edition was published in 1926.

The poet and linguist V. Ridala also began translating the *Kalevala*. He only completed the Kullervo episode, publishing the six poems in a separate booklet in 1921. Ridala tried to fit his translation to the original metre, and he logically applied the archaic morphology.

Still the result was not entirely satisfactory. This was demonstrated by A. Annist in 1922 in an article "Kalevala eesti keeles" which he published in the periodical *Eesti Kirjandus*, in which he claimed, among other things: "Our attitude to the *Kalevala* so far is once again proof of our shallowness... in our treatment of our national heritage. For the Estonians, too, have helped to create the material for the *Kalevala*" (Annist 1922: 123). If we are to understand and value works founded on folklore, it is essential for us to get to know the performance, structure and spirit of folklore. The unique beauty of ancient poetry does not fade with time, it is as lasting as Nature herself; it is in fact part of Nature, as a reflection on the human mind. In order to share in these riches, it is essential for us to study the epic in schools, where it could be taught alongside the old alliterative Estonian folk poetry. It is not enough for students merely to know that the *Kalevala* exists, they must have a more thorough acquaintance with its actual content. There was, in Annist's opinion, much room for improvement in this respect in Estonia. The *Kalevala* was the chief stimulus behind the

birth of Kalevipoeg. Yet its spirit remained alien to Kreutzwald, just as the spirit of folklore. Lönnrot, by way of contrast, became almost a folk poet in his own right. To the leaders of the national awakening Kalevipoeg remained but a formal stimulus. The same criticism may be levelled at the younger generation, which was indeed well versed in literature but which had little to do with the Kalevala. Worst of all, it overlooked the aesthetic side of the epic, regarding the work simply as folklore material. The public at large did not read the work, and it featured neither in the school curriculum nor among youth activities. Yet Finnish culture is based on the Kalevala: it has provided substance for literature, music and the other arts, and it is also taught in school. The Kalevala has echoed all over Europe and even further afield. By 1922 as many as 78 translations had been made, including partial ones. Inspired by the epic, H. W. Longfellow wrote his *Hiawatha*, Leconte de Lisle his poems on Kalevala themes; Lamartine was well acquainted with the work and the aging Victor Hugo was by no means sparing in his praise.

Annist's article did indeed have the required effect; measures were gradually taken to rectify the shortcomings mentioned in it, and the epic began to be studied in more depth in schools. The critic himself even set about putting things right. It seems likely that by the time of his article he had already completed a translation of one of the Kalevala cantos. For the grammar school reader *Kirjanduslooline lugemik IV* (1925) edited by A. Raud includes one of the poems — the Battle for the Sampo — in a translation by Annist. Fourteen years later a new translation of the entire Kalevala appeared, an unusually fine achievement compared with previous interpretations. This 1939 edition is also superb to look at; the illustrations, one of which is in colour, are by A. Gallen-Kallela. It also includes a preface, good notes on the proper names, a glossary and a list of chants. The preface by Annist, both to this and to the first part of the *Kanteletar* appearing in 1930, are both extremely useful. Annist tried as far as possible "to transmit into Estonian the merits of the poem and the wording of the original". The critics asserted that the language of Annist's translation was truly close

to the original. Translating from Finnish into Estonian is easy because the two languages share many archaic words, which helps to retain the rhythm of the poem. Annist also observed the rules on length. All in all his translation is probably the closest to the original of any produced so far. "Folk poetry is quite fresh even today", uttered the critic B. Kangro on the publication of the work (Kangro 1940: 89). A third edition of the translation was published in Soviet-Estonia in 1985.

Estonian elements in the Kalevala

Let us now turn to a problem that has caught the attention of a number of researchers. Is the poetry, the basic substance of the Kalevala, of Karelian or western origin? D. V. Bubrih, H. Moora and A. Annist proved that the Karelians already had a feudal society made rich by trade and taxation of the hinterlands by the beginning of the millennium. It is probable that the Karelians did not consist solely of settlers from Western Finland, and that the majority of them were native inhabitants who to some extent mixed with migrants from Ingria and the banks of the River Volkhov and also some Veps. It is also probable that some of the Kalev lore came from the south along with other "lesser" material. The name Kalev may have been known outside Estonia, in the regions to the east. From there the name Kolovan Kolovanovich could have passed into *byliny* and the Novgorod chronicles. It is thus possible that Kalev lore came to Karelia from somewhere further south, and that it found its way to Western Finland with Estonian migrants. Naturally this tradition continued to develop both in Western Finland and Karelia. The relationships between the various tribes seem to have been close, especially in Central Finland, where the Karelian and Häme tribes merged to form a new Savo tribe. So why could interesting songs not have travelled from west to east, and vice versa?

Understandably, the songs began to die out in the more highly developed feudal conditions of Western Finland, while at the same time they continued to flourish in the more primitive society and patriarchal system. Throughout the epic there are traces of the decline of the primitive form of society. The songs lived on among the men, chiefly because of their communal fishing and hunting expeditions. Working together unites people and inspires them to sing. It is largely thanks to the communal task of clearing the land among the land-owning nobility that the old song tradition lived on in Estonia.

The attitude of Finnish researchers to alliterative Estonian folk poetry (*regilaul*) was less than favourable right up to the last quarter of the 19th century. Ahlqvist regarded these poems as lacking in imagery, for they originated and spread amid the harsh conditions of Estonian feudalism. By way of contrast Karelian poetry was regarded as “strongly undulating”, Ingrian (*Izhor*) poetry as melodic and poetic, but Votic poetry as weak and obscure, like the Estonian. The main reason for such opinions was that the Finnish scholars knew the Estonian texts only from Neus’ anthology. This attitude was also slow to die among the Estonian intelligentsia, and the appearance of *Kalevipoeg* did nothing to correct it. It was only later, thanks to the Estonian Literature Society, that things changed, as the results of Hurt’s folk poetry collection became known.

The importance of Estonian folk poetry to Finnish folklore research was underlined by Otto Donner in his work on *Kalevipoeg* from the point of view of stories of the gods and history published in 1886. The greatest expert in Finland on Estonian folk poetry proper was probably Lönnbohm-Mustonen, who collected folk poetry from Sarema and published a booklet on his material. He was the first to put into words the theory that the poems in the *Kalevala* originally came from Estonia. The issue was taken up by K. Krohn in his article “*Soome-Eesti vanast rahvalaulust*” in the periodical *Eesti Kirjandus* (1923–1924). Julius Krohn was greatly interested in the way Hurt and the Estonian Literature Society (founded in 1872) had organised the collection of folklore. In 1883 he sent his son Kaarle to Tartu to catalogue the material and

to copy any poems akin to the lyric-epic poems in the Kalevala. The number of variants grew to more than 1.500. The collection of Mihkel Veske alone amounted to more than 1.200 variants. Jakob Hurt took the poems in the Estonian Literature Society to St. Petersburg, where Kaarle Krohn went through a further 6.500 variants. This material convinced Julius Krohn of the artistic merit of Estonian folk poetry (Krohn 1885: 157–186). Kaarle Krohn in turn considered that most of the poems to be found in Estonia also originated there, though he also stressed that folk poems cannot have a common place of birth any more than a common date of birth. All the types of poetry to be found in the Estonian-speaking area are to be found in Estonia, which in turn creates the impression of an uneven material but at the same time permits detailed and productive research within the confines of the Estonian language. This research situation may even be considered ideal.

Thus there gradually emerged an ‘Estonian theory’, according to which close on half the poems in the Kalevala originally came from the Estonian region. The problem was given comprehensive treatment by M. J. Eisen (1910: 214–238), who noted that many scholars had looked into the Kalevala material of Estonian origin. According to the Krohns the Kalevala contains 20 poems of Estonian origin or at least dealing with a motif to be found in Estonia, two Ingrian and 23 Western Finnish poems. Such a list does undoubtedly provide substance for research, though the similarity of content is in certain cases mere coincidence (e. g. the news of death). According to Eisen and certain other researchers the reason why the Estonians lack a large-scale epic may be that Estonian women played a dominant role in the creation and performance of poetry. Women do, after all, always tend more towards lyricism in their poetry. The Karelian epic is clearly masculine. In his doctoral thesis on the types and structure of repetitive songs dated 1901 O. Kallas drew some interesting parallels to demonstrate the influence of the Estonians on the development of the Kalevala. There is, for example, one motif in which an Estonian maiden has her trinkets stolen while she is bathing. In the Kalevala Aino goes to bathe

and vanishes beneath the water, the reason being that she does not wish to be wed to the aging Väinämöinen. The maid of Järvamaa merely becomes angry, but Aino drowns.

The similarities between Finnish and Estonian poetry are a reminder of the three alternatives that always have to be allowed for in estimating the mutual dependence of folk poetry: (1) common origin (a certain song dates from the time when the people who know it were still living together), (2) borrowing (a motif was borrowed from another people or tribe), and (3) spontaneous generation (neither borrowing nor common origin but proximity and parallel development).

Some of the lyrical poems in the Kalevala represent types that may have been passed on by the Estonians. Thus an eagle rescues Väinämöinen from danger in gratitude to him for sparing the birch (canto 7). The theme in which the birch is left to grow also appears in old Estonian folk poems ("Treetops for the birds"). The following poems are well known in Estonia: "Taught by elders to sing" (canto 1), "From a family of singers" (canto 1), "Poetic vein" (canto 1), "The Sarema fire", the Lemminkäinen episode (canto 29), "The Bride's Advisor", "Brother in Strange Lands" (canto 22), Aino's complaint to her mother "Forced to Marry an Old Man" (canto 3), "Crippled Young by Work" (cantos 1 and 45). The "Stone in the Bread" poem is known on the island of Kihnu, usually under the name of "Brother's Axe Wound". We could continue the list, but suffice it to say that the proportion of Estonian material in the Kalevala is greater than has so far been believed. On the other hand we do not yet know whether all these poems really were borrowed from the Estonians.

Lönnrot and Kreutzwald as creators of an epic

The most important factor prompting Kreutzwald to create Kalevipoeg was, when all is said and done, the Kalevala. Although his meeting with Lönnrot in 1844 had been surprisingly short (the two men were

not at all alike and did not manage to get on the same wavelength), their meeting was indeed a stimulus. More interesting details of this are provided by the correspondence between Kreutzwald and Sachsensal. Kreutzwald did not speak Finnish, so he did not have any direct contact with the Kalevala. Only through the German translation was he able to get his first impression of this great work. The most weighty comparisons of the Kalevala and Kalevipoeg have been made by F. Tuglas, G. Suits and A. Annist. According to Tuglas

Lönnrot was a folk poet and a singer, a composer, he penetrated the creative spirit of the people, he understood nothing of the theories of aesthetics. He was “old-fashioned”, he spent years roaming the wilds of Karelia in heavy boots with a birchbark knapsack on his back. He was a man of the people, he knew the folk poems and his epic by heart, like a true poet, without ever embarking on anything original of his own. Kreutzwald was the complete contrast: poet, artist, creative individual. Kreutzwald looked forwards to the future, was modern and progressive, a detached and erudite poet. He was influenced by the Kalevala but also by our lyrical folk poetry, which he did not fully understand. Any shortcomings he may have had cannot be attributed to folk poetry. Folk poetry does not create a style, it is that already. But Kreutzwald creates a style because he lacks the ability to fathom the world of a folk poem. Compared with him, Lönnrot has an excellent feeling for style. (Tuglas 1935: 83–89.)

In a more critical attack Tuglas notes many errors in Kalevipoeg. He nevertheless later came to the conclusion that despite its shortcomings Kalevipoeg was of great social significance. It may not have been a folk epic, but it was a national epic (Tuglas 1936: 43). The same comment had been made two decades earlier by G. Suits (Suits 1916: 16). Kreutzwald acquired the honorary title of “Lauluisa” (father of poetry), and posterity certainly does not wish to tarnish his halo (Tuglas 1936). Suits later wrote: “Kalevipoeg is the joint product of the creative efforts of the Estonian people and of one writer. The conviction stated in the last lines of Kalevipoeg that the nation will gain its freedom raises the import of this folk epic” (Suits 1953: 171). A. Annist thought

along the same lines in his doctoral thesis and articles, and similar opinions have been put forward by many others, too.

The appearance of the *Kalevala* and the contacts with Lönnrot thus had a direct influence on the publication of *Kalevipoeg*, even though the subject of *Kalev* had indeed been dealt with earlier. Some works on *Kalevipoeg* might also have been produced even without this influence. Stories about *Kalevipoeg* (and to a lesser extent *Kalev*) frequently appeared in the prose tradition, and the names *Kalev* and *Kalevipoeg* are often encountered in poetry. The *Kalevala* and Lönnrot did, however, provide the final spark for the collection and publication of Estonian folklore, also acting as a source of inspiration for Neus, whose anthology of Estonian folk poetry *Estnische Volkslieder* appeared between 1850 and 1852. The introduction and notes in the anthology contain numerous references to the Old *Kalevala* and the *Kanteletar*, likewise to the collections of Finnish folk poetry made by Arwidsson. And the process continues: under the joint influence of the *Kalevala* and *Kalevipoeg* A. Pumpers created the work *Lāčplēsis* for the Latvians.

In an article addressed to the public at large in 1871 Jakob Hurt stated that there were learned people in England, Germany and other European countries noting down the creations of the primitive peoples of Africa, America and Australia. "Some people lay more store by such information than by silk and velvet." Hurt also mentioned the *Kanteletar*, which he regarded as an exemplary publication. And the *Kanteletar* did in turn give its name to the broad publication of Estonian folk poetry *Vana Kannel*, which is still being published even today. In the work *Kaks keelt vanalt kandelt* published towards the end of his life, in 1906, Hurt used the same method to string poems together as Lönnrot in the *Kanteletar* and the *Kalevala*. The model provided by Lönnrot cannot be underestimated. From the 1880s onwards periodicals published more and more articles about Lönnrot. Perhaps the most vivid picture of Lönnrot was given by M. Lipp in the periodical *Eesti Kirjandus* issued in 1910; in it the creator of the *Kalevala* is framed by such well-known folk singers as Arhippa and Miihkali Perttunen.

Finland awoke with the publication of the *Kalevala*. With *Kalevipoeg*, Estonia followed in Lönnrot's footsteps.

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Felix J. Oinas

Russian and Finnish Epic Songs

A rich body of oral epic songs survived well into the twentieth century both among the Russians and the Finns and Karelians. In Russia, the folk epic comprises the *byliny* and historical songs; the *byliny* — as opposed to historical songs — are mostly ahistorical and embellished with much fantasy and hyperbole. The Finnish-Karelian epic songs are predominantly mythical and shamanistic. In the following we will give a comparative sketch of Russian and Finnish-Karelian (here called simply “Finnish”) epic songs.

Origins

Several theories about the origin of Russian epic poetry have been advanced. According to V. J. Propp, heroic poetry is opposed to myth and grows out from prestate poetry, in which the hero meets a monster, sets out to court a bride, finds himself in the other world, fights his son, etc. After a state is formed, the new epic poetry that arises reflects the state and its interests (Propp 1984: 54). E. M. Meletinskij considers heroic poetry a continuation of mythical epic poetry, whereas V. M. Žirmunskij views it as a derivation of the *bogatyr* (hero) tale (Liberman 1984: lxxviii).

Whatever type of epic poetry once existed among the East Slavs, the sweeping historical events of the Kievan period (9th to 13th century) caused a thorough change and mutation. These events began with the

Christianization of Russia in the 10th century and the skirmishes with waves of Asian intruders, such as the Polovtsy and Pechenegs. They culminated with the arrival of the Tatars in Russia in the 13th century, the devastation of the land, the destruction of the Old East Slavic civilization, and the domination of the Russians by the Tatars. According to V. F. Miller, the main representative of the historical school of Russian folkloristics, the byliny of Kievan period were created and kept alive among the singers of the princes' retinue. For political reasons, this theory of the aristocratic origin of byliny has been most vigorously opposed by the party and government of the Soviet Union. Folklorists were forced to adopt the idea that the working people created the byliny. While it is true that the peasants preserved these songs, altered them, and even created some new ones on the existing models, internal evidence shows they could not have been responsible for the original composition. Ultimately, these songs had to have been the work of professional singers, in the same way that the West European epic was the creation of minstrels and troubadours (Oinas 1971: 541 ff.).

Whereas the ancient history of East Slavic epic songs is based on scholars' conjectures without tangible proof, the determination of the origin and prehistory of the Finnish epic is on more solid ground, owing to the application of stylistic criteria worked out by Matti Kuusi. Kuusi divides the prehistory of Finnish epic poetry into different periods, beginning with the pre-Finnic era, which comprises the last centuries before our time. He shows that the core of this folklore consisted of a series of sacred stories in verse about primeval events, such as the creation of the universe, the imprisonment and the liberation of the luminaries, the first spark of fire, and the creation of the bear, elk and the first men. The protagonists originally appeared in the shape of animals (Kuusi 1963: 31–80, 147). In the following periods, the place of the animals was taken by culture heroes of gigantic strength, who seemed as if hewn out of rock. It was in the Viking Age (A. D. 800–1050) that they were replaced by humans with their extraordinary adventures and passions. This change in content was also accompanied by a change in the consciousness of time: the holy time of the older

songs, in which the cult function was foremost, gave way to the profane-historic time in the Viking songs (Fromm 1968: 9). There was also a marked change in the diction (Kuusi 1958: 252).

Dissemination

Byliny were best preserved in the north, but they could not have originated there. The frequent mention of southern Russian cities (Černigov, Kiev, Smolensk) and personages (headed by Kievan Prince Vladimir) gives an indication that they must in fact have originated in the south. A number of details refer specifically to Old Kiev, such as the Počajna River located on the outskirts of Kiev and the “Relics of Boris,” which designates a ford at Vyšgorod, a suburb of Kiev. Boris, one of Prince Vladimir’s sons, was murdered in 1015.

No byliny have been recorded in the Ukraine and only a few in Belorussia. It was the North of European Russia that preserved and tended them. But how did they get from the south to the north? This migration has been credited to the *gusljari* (psaltery-players), the court poets who joined their lot with that of the *skomoroxi*, the wandering minstrels and buffoons from the lower class. In the process of this amalgamation, the *skomoroxi* became the heirs to the oral tradition nurtured by the court bards. Under the pressure from the church, they began to drift northward. The attacks by the clergy became more and more severe, attaining their peak during the reign of Tsar Aleksej Mixajlovič in the 17th century. The musical instruments of the *skomoroxi* were confiscated and burned and the minstrels themselves beaten, arrested and banished to the border regions. To escape harassment, some left voluntarily for the north, taking the byliny with them. Personal entertainers who accompanied their boyar masters into exile in Karelia also contributed to the spread of byliny (Zguta 1978: 20–21, 58 ff.).

In the north, byliny found conditions favourable for survival. The isolation of these areas from cultural centers became almost complete after the conquest of the Baltic region by Peter the Great. Connections between northern Russia and the outside world were cut off when the northern trade route via Olonec was abandoned. The Olonec and Karelian regions became secluded and fertile gardens for the tending of folklore, including byliny. In addition, the northern way of life and climate offered an atmosphere conducive to relating and listening to long, tranquil tales of antiquity (Sokolov 1971: 297–298).

The Finnish epic songs, found primarily in southeastern Finland and Eastern Karelia, are not indigenous to this area either. During the time when Finnish folklore scholarship was being born, a heated dispute arose about the origin of the Kalevala songs. The youthful A. A. Borenius examined the linguistic, historical and ethnological basis for the variants of the poems and concluded that “ancient Finnish poems cannot have originated where they were last sung, i. e., in Carelia” (Hautala 1969: 64). Referring to the presence of Swedish loanwords — unknown in the common language — and the names of Roman Catholic saints in the poems sung by Greek Orthodox performers, he concluded that “the poetry has come to Russian Karelia from the West, from Finland...” (Hautala 1969: 65). The ever-dissenting August Ahlqvist championed the opposite view, that the Kalevala, actually the Kalevala songs, had been composed where they were sung, that is in Karelia. Despite Ahlqvist’s stubbornness in clinging to his ideas, bordering on demagoguery, Borenius’ view won the upper hand. Leading Finnish folklorists of the new generation (with some dissenters, such as Väinö Salminen) accepted Borenius’ theory, with some modifications to be sure. Toward the end of his life, Kaarle Krohn, who had been inspired partly by the ideas of his father Julius, considered West Finland and Estonia as the areas where the songs had been composed. From West Finland they had spread to Northern East Karelia, Finnish Karelia and Estonia; and from Estonia, through Ingria and Finnish Karelia to Northern East Karelia (Hautala 1969: 132). Martti Haavio, too, despite his general skepticism about the feasibility of determining the place and time of the creation of folk poetry, was inclined to concur with the

general view of their migration from West Finland to the east, by proving that the milieu represented in the core of these songs was typical of the West Finnish heroic age (Hautala 1954: 365–366).

Why did the Finnish epic songs disappear in West Finland and why were they preserved in the east? The prime reason was the intensive — and successful — campaign Catholicism and Lutheranism waged in West Finland in the Catholic Middle Ages and the first centuries of the Modern Age against ancient beliefs and the songs that contained rudiments of heathen superstitions. Russian Orthodoxy in Eastern Finland and Karelia was much more tolerant of old customs, practices and old songs. It should also be remembered that West European culture spread first to West Finland, whereas in Karelia, which was at a great distance from the cultural centers of the time, life continued in ancient ways for centuries.

It is surprising that both the Russian and Finnish epic songs have been best preserved in almost the same geographical area — Russian East Karelia and Olonec. The reasons are unclear. Was it the awe of the people felt toward grandiose nature untouched through the ages, that made them cherish powerful images from the past and cling to them? Matti Kuusi points out that a song filled with the spirit of the ancient Finnish sea Vikings was preserved only in some Karelian forest villages beyond the Finland border. He surmises that “the way of life of the peddlers and hunters obviously created better conditions to comprehend the longing for faraway places by the ancient seafarers than the domesticated, quiet life in the fishing villages of Ladoga Lake and the Gulf of Finland” (Kuusi 1963: 236).

Rediscovery

After the publication of the large *bylina* collection attributed to the Cossack Kirša Danilov (1804, complete ed. 1818), individual *byliny* were written down in various parts of Russia and sent to the collector

and folklore expert P. V. Kireevskij. Bylina as a genre was believed to be extinct by the middle of the nineteenth century. Then came a surprise: P. N. Rybnikov, a government official banished to Olonec, rediscovered a flourishing bylina tradition in 1860. The subsequent publication of his bylina collection (1861–67) caused a “tremendous sensation”. Nobody suspected that the bylina had not disappeared, let alone that it still flourished and that numerous rhapsodes were extant, not in some Godforsaken corner, but in the proximity of Petersburg. Rybnikov’s collection was greeted with amazement and enthusiasm, but also with doubts about its authenticity. Suspecting that the collection was a counterfeit and falsification, people were inclined to view Rybnikov as a “new Macpherson” (Azadovskij 1963: 228).

Ten years later, when A. F. Gil’ferding set out for the same region to supplement Rybnikov’s work, it was stubbornly believed by some circles that the prime purpose of his expedition was to check the genuineness of Rybnikov’s recordings. This charge of course was not true and the doubts had essentially already been dispelled by the “Collector’s Note” that appeared in the fourth volume of Rybnikov’s collection.

After the work of Rybnikov and Gil’ferding, systematic search for byliny continued in northern Russia — in Olonec, on the shores of the White Sea and the banks of the rivers flowing to the north. While the end of the 19th and the beginning of the 20th century yielded several large bylina collections, as the time advanced, the collectors’ finds grew ever more meagre.

What occurred in Russia in the 1860s happened in Finland after the publication of the *Kalevala*. After it was established in the middle of the century that the greatly admired Poems of Ossian by Macpherson were not genuine folklore, there arose “doubts with regard to Lönnrot’s work and the popular origins of the *Kalevala*, both in Finland and abroad. Lönnrot’s method was even directly compared with that of Macpherson” (Hautala 1969: 59). It was especially the Swedish movement that challenged the originality of the *Kalevala*. C. G. Estlander, in an article published in *Helsingfors Tidningar* in 1858, placed Lönnrot

side by side with Macpherson and demanded that the materials Lönnrot had used be made public so that his work could be examined (Hautala 1969: 59–60). Fortunately, when Lönnrot's original notations, which had been lost, were recovered, doubts about the authenticity of the Kalevala songs were dispelled. Just as in Russia, the collection of epic songs in Finland and Karelia has continued up to recent times.

Classification of epic songs

Russian epic poetry is predominantly heroic. According to Propp, it is characterized by struggle and victory, but the struggle is waged not for narrow, petty goals but for the people's highest ideals (Propp 1984: 149). The term "heroic" has been used somewhat improperly in reference to epics, including the Russian. The hero who is not destined to be defeated or to die will ultimately win the victory, no matter what happens or however improbable the action. Although Il'ja Muromec, e. g., in the bylina about Tsar Kalin, has been tied up by the legs and hands and readied for execution, he still finds time to pray to God and is saved by heavenly intervention. Heroes in the Mongol epics, even if they are defeated and killed in an early skirmish, are revived in a Märchen-like context (Hatto 1980: 276). C. B. Bawden is correct when he argues that "one has to question the aptness of the term 'heroic' [in 'heroic epic'], since the forces opposed to the hero are by definition bound to fail" (Hatto 1980: 276).

The so-called Older Heroes of Russian byliny are considered to be the symbolic representations of the elemental powers of nature. Svjatorgor, for example, represents brutal strength (even if ultimately doomed), and Mikula, the prodigious skill of the tiller of land, but only Volx Vseslav'evič qualifies as a supreme warrior, although he — like the Finnish heroes — fights with magical means.

The Younger Heroes embody the true heroic spirit of Russian bogatyrs (epic heroes). They perform such difficult tasks as slaying dragons, defending the Russian land against foreign invaders, killing brigands, delivering tribute, or seeking brides. Il'ja Muromec, the most idealized hero, fights and kills Solovej Razbojnik (Nightingale the Robber), a monstrous combination of a bird and a human, Idolišče (monstrous Idol) and the Tatar Tsar Kalin. Also the other prominent Younger Heroes, Dobrynja Nikitič, an able diplomat and courageous fighter, and the valiant Aleša Popovič, distinguish themselves, among other feats, with dragon slaying. Dobrynja fights several dragons, who hold Prince Vladimir's niece as well as Russian warriors captives. Aleša's adversary is the gluttonous, fire-breathing Tugarin, who soars skyward on his paper wings during the encounter, but is brought down by God's rain (Arant 1979: 71–72).

The bylina singer strives to produce powerful effects, particularly of surprise and amazement, in his listeners. As A. P. Skaftymov has shown, he does so by the constant use of contrasts. At the beginning of the bylina, the hero is underestimated while the strength and power of the enemy is overestimated. The latter is depicted as invincible; all are afraid of him and depressed by his violence. Nevertheless at the end, the hero conquers him with utmost ease (Skaftymov 1924: 46–61).

Among the bogatyrs, Dobrynja and Aleša are evidently historical, but Il'ja Muromec's origin is still in dispute. Soviet scholars connect Il'ja with the ancient principality of Murom. In his appellative "Muromec" some Western scholars see a corruption of "Norman" (Old Norse *Norðmanðr*) and think that Il'ja was originally a Scandinavian leader active in Russia. This suggestion gains support from the Russians' practice of attributing the highest valor to foreign heroes. Thus the Estonian hero Kalev (Kolyvan) or Kalevipoe (Kolyvanovič), transplanted to Russia, is considered stronger than any Russian hero. Il'ja is warned not to fight him, and the mothers of several other heroes deplore the fact that their sons are not as strong as Kalevipoe (Vasmer 1929: 320–329).

Romantic *byliny*, which take love, intrigue and infidelity as their subject matter, comprise another group of Russian epic songs. At Vladimir's court, Čurilo Plenkovič, who has come to Kiev from the southern frontier of the Prince's possessions, is the greatest ladies' man. Renowned for his blond curls and good looks, he arouses the interest of Vladimir's wife Apraksija, who wants him as her chamberlain. His life ends in bed with a married woman whose enraged husband kills him. The heroic Aleša Popovič even has a role in an Odysseian romance; he makes an unsuccessful attempt to marry the wife of his sworn-brother Dobrynja during his absence. In the *bylina* about Nightingale Budimirovič, the amorous interest is reversed; after Nightingale, a rich foreign merchant, builds a palace in Kiev, Prince Vladimir's niece Zabava Putjatična offers him her hand. The girl's proposal to the man is less surprising if we interpret the building of the palace as a marriage trial. Tragic lovers in *byliny* include Mixajlo Potyk and Dunaj Ivanovič, who kill the objects of their love; Dunaj, shaken by his deed, commits suicide.

The historical songs in Russia arose in the 16th century, as the result of a new attitude toward historical personages. At that time, the heroes could no longer be described as superhumans whose deeds were above the level of ordinary laws. The historical songs are not history, but a contemporary poetical reaction to a historical character or event (Stief 1953: 265). Some are anecdotes about popular tsars, such as Ivan the Terrible and Peter the Great. Others deal with events of historical importance, e. g., the conquest of Siberia, the Time of Troubles, and the peasant movements led by Stepan Razin and Emel'jan Pugačev.

The Finnish epic is completely different from the Russian. It is essentially mythical and shamanistic. The central figure of this epic is Väinämöinen, the eternal sage and a great shaman, who does not shy at going to the other world to obtain knowledge. For the same purpose, he visits the long-dead shaman Antero Vipunen, whose soul has been separated from his decayed body. During a singing competition, Väinämöinen sings the young braggart Joukahainen into the swamp, transforms his horse into a seal, the saddle into a duck, and the whip into

a reed. In the poem about Väinämöinen's art of singing, he enchants the forest animals and nature spirits with his melodies (Haavio 1952: 160–163; Haavio 1961: 13). Lemminkäinen too has the role of a magician. It was obviously Lemminkäinen, and not Väinämöinen, who originally paid a visit to Antero Vipunen (cf. Kuusi 1954: 294–308). His major adventure involves a journey, full of dangers, to the home of a rival shaman and their contest in magic, a theme which is taken over from a Russian *bylina* (Haavio 1967: 232 ff.; Oinas 1985: 115 ff.). Another — and final — magical act of his entails the transformation of the garments of the participants in the festivities in Päivölä, except for one, into gold and silver.

In Finnish folklore, heroic and romantic songs combine and cross rather than exist in distinct cycles. The *Kaukomieli* song and the song of Ahti and Teuri breathe the Viking spirit: a longing for wars, wild drinking bouts, love adventures and duels. *Kaukomieli* (or *Kaukamoinen*) is a powerful Viking, who uses his sword too readily yet does not hesitate to run away when the situation becomes unbearable and dangerous. He is a sexually attractive young man of Herculean powers and becomes involved with women almost by accident — an adventurer, but not a seducer (Kuusi et al. 1977: 540). Ahti Saarelainen (man of the Island) is so eager to fight that he abandons his young wife after she breaks a promise to him and — together with his war-loving comrade Teuri — sets out for war. In the *Kalevala* Lönnrot has attributed the adventures of *Kaukomieli* and Ahti to Lemminkäinen and has thus created a composite figure.

Finnish historical songs arose at about the same time as the Russian — toward the end of the 16th and the beginning of the 17th century. They closely resemble the Swedish political songs and are about the “good lord” Duke Charles, the “noble lord” Jaakko Puntus, or some other leader, who gets his craft ready to sail below the towns of Turku, Viipuri, Narva or Riga. The tone of these poems depends on whether they were sung in Swedish Finland or among the Russian Orthodox Karelians. The latter, e. g., depict King Charles XII as a

bloody invader and a wretched refugee. Typical of the historical songs is their penetrating perception, briskness and military trustworthiness (Kuusi 1963: 398–399).

Story pattern

Russian *byliny* usually begin with the hero leaving home, an action that initiates the subsequent story. Feeling restless, the hero mounts a horse and rides out in search of adventure or an adversary. The narrative ends either with the hero's return or his arrival in another city or another land. Sometimes the hero's departure is preceded by a few introductory lines that tell of his birth, growing up and/or of the place where he lives. The hero's leaving may come after a longer introductory episode involving a feast at Prince Vladimir's. During the feast a request is made for someone to perform a task. Or the boasting of the hero may cause him to be singled out for a particular assignment. After the task is completed, the hero returns to Kiev (Arant 1968: 9–16). Propp thinks that the plots with a different construction are younger (Propp 1984: 22).

The dominant pattern of the Finnish epic songs, like that of the Russian *byliny*, also involves the hero's departure. But whereas the departing Russian hero usually does not know where he is going or what he is doing, and often first goes hunting (Oinas 1971: 516–519), the Finnish protagonist leaves with a definite plan, as e. g.: "Old Väinämöinen went off/ he went off to woo the maid/ to angle for the sea-trout" (Kuusi et al. 1977: 128); "The squat smith of the mainland/ ...jerked up leather boots/ and went for Tuoni's daughter/ the bride from the underworld" (Kuusi et al. 1977: 147).

Another type of Finnish epic songs tells the story in the first person, from the supposed perspective of the singer. Thus "Kantele" tells of the herdsman who was a serf in Estonia, had the kantele made and

finally found an excellent player (Kuusi et al. 1977: 172–173; cf. 263–265). On the other hand, the song may begin with the singer's story, but continue as a third-person account (Kuusi et al. 1977: 174–178, 269–270).

The majority of Finnish epic songs begins with a brief presentation of the protagonist and a laconic description of the situation. Some singers work out definite beginnings for their songs. Characteristic is the statement by Varvana of Lenttisi, one of the most noteworthy Ingrian singers, who said that she started her songs from the "beginning". After having asked for God's help, she began with a poem that told how "God's only son" put the sun to shine for the joy of the people. "With this poem she... always made the start" (Haavio 1967: 231).

Magical function

During the last centuries, the primary function of the telling of byliny in Russia has been entertainment. Fishermen in northern Russia sometimes had to wait for days or weeks for a storm to pass; woodcutters had to spend long fall and winter nights in huts in deep forests; family members and friends had to weave nets over the course of many weeks or sometimes even months. During such intervals songs and stories constituted the most appropriate pastime (Sokolov 1950: 297–298).

Yet the singing of byliny during a storm may also have been motivated by a different reason: their expected magical effect. Byliny occasionally end with an enigmatic epilogue, containing a reference to the calmness of the sea, e. g.:

They tell the bylina about Dobrynja, to calm down the blue sea,
and for you all to hear, good people (Rybnikov 1861: 139).

Cf. further examples of byliny: "On the calm blue sea"; "On the peaceful blue sea" (Chadwick 1964: 90, 133). It is known that people in northern

Russia used to pacify the raging waters by singing or rhythmically reciting *byliny*, and thus this epilogue may preserve an echo of the *byliny*'s once magical function (Pomeranceva 1970: 161–162).

There is much more information about the singing of epic songs for magical purposes in Finland. There, these songs were believed to contain the most sacred and powerful knowledge that could influence nature. The song of Väinämöinen's *kantele* music served as a kind of incantation, sometimes for fishing or sometimes for hunting. Chr. Ganander wrote in 1789: "Fowlers, hunters, and woodsmen asked Väinämöinen to play his harp, so that its sweet music would call forth all the game..." (Haavio 1952: 171). To increase the fertility of the fields, spring and autumn sowing were accompanied by Sämpsä Pellervoinen's song, which reiterated the primeval sowing. The sowing incantation, followed by the song of the forging and stealing of the Sampo and the pursuit of the mistress of Pohjola, was sung at the spring and autumn plowing. Statements recorded from some of the singers attribute the riches of the sea to the Sampo's falling into the water and point to the ritualistic use of the Sampo sequence, not only in agriculture, but also in fishing (Haavio 1952: 180–189; Kuusi 1963: 73, 227).

Cycles and epics

The length of epic songs varies. Russian songs range from less than 100 lines to 1,000 or more. Finnish songs are somewhat shorter, averaging from 50 to 400 lines.

Since Friedrich August Wolf's *Prolegomena* (1795), one of the theories for the creation of major epics involves the compilation model — the joining of a number of smaller songs into a single epic (Hansen 1978: 11–15). In Russia, there are examples of composite songs with identical protagonists. Thus, the patriarch of the Olonec singers, Trofim Rjabinin, worked out a special model for such unification (Arant 1970: 80 ff.). In

“Dunaj” he, e. g., strung together two songs about the same hero, the first about his mission to the Lithuanian king to obtain a bride for Prince Vladimir and the second about his subsequent duel with his amazon-wife Nastasja. In “Dobrynja and Vasilij Kazimirov”, Rjabinin combined Vasilij’s delivery of tribute to Batjan (= Batyj) and Aleša’s attempt to marry the wife of Dobrynja (Vasilij’s traveling companion). In linking these songs, the singer makes the hero (or heroes) stop to spend the night. During this transitional episode, one narrative pattern mixes with another and the second story is inaugurated (Arant 1970: 87). The prophetic dove is used as the messenger to tell what has happened to Dobrynja’s wife during her husband’s absence.

Some adulterated texts of byliny and tales about Il’ja Muromec were united in Russia for commercial purposes (Astaxova 1948: 104–105). One such collection, edited by V. P. Avenarius as *Book of the Kievan Heroes* (*Kniga o kievskix bogatyryx*, 1876), deserves special attention as an example of the epic *in nascendi*. Avenarius chose the available byliny variants of Vladimir’s cycle and of the Older Heroes, compared them line by line and selected the best verses. “By removing or softening everything that was too harsh and by polishing the roughness of versification that hindered the smooth flow of verses”, he created the composite texts of 24 byliny. He arranged the texts chronologically, following — as he says — the example of the German Simrock’s *Amelungenlied* and Lönnrot’s *Kalevala* and united them “into as a consistent chronicle as possible” (Avenarius 1876: XIV–XV).

In Finland, the combination of songs into small units was occasionally undertaken. The most noteworthy of such creations is the Sampo cycle. It has been shown that the oldest episode in the Sampo epic recounted the theft of the Sampo and belongs to the same tradition as the Scandinavian *fornaldar* sagas (Lid 1949: 104–120). In order to weld the cosmologic and heroic Sampo-image together, the creator of the theft of the Sampo, or perhaps his contemporaries, created the “Forging of the Sampo” as the introduction to the theft song (Kuusi 1963: 227). In Karelia, the White Sea singers worked with great success on concatenating the songs into short epics. Thus they sung up to five

poems of the Sampo epic to the collectors of folksongs, strung together on the basis of their content — the world creation song, the forging of the Sampo, the theft of the Sampo, the competition in wooing, and the golden maiden (Kuusi 1949: 335 ff.). Other epic cycles were also created by the Karelian singers, such as the Lemminkäinen epic and the Kullervo epic.

The crowning achievement of epic compilation in Finland is the *Kalevala* by Elias Lönnrot. Since the history of its successive stages is well known, we will refrain from discussing it here. It is of interest that Avenarius' Book of the Kievan Heroes corresponds closely to one of the preliminary stages of Lönnrot's *Kalevala* — his "Runokokous Väinämöisestä" (Proto-*Kalevala*, in manuscript, 1833). Both are collections of songs about the chief heroes of Russian and Finnish epic songs, Il'ja Muromec and Väinämöinen. Avenarius' collection also contains songs about Dobrynja, Aleša, Dunaj, etc., and Lönnrot's "Runokokous" includes poems about Lemminkäinen, Kullervo and Joukahainen. The guiding principle for the arrangement of the poems in both instances was chronology. Lönnrot states, "I took special notice of the chronological order of the heroic deeds mentioned in the poems" (Hautala 1969: 24). Since neither work has a central plot, each can be considered an intermediary between a collection of epic songs and a unified short epic.

Epic ceremonialism

The Russian epic adheres to a grandiose "epic ceremonialism" — commonplaces, detailed descriptions of actions, fixed epithets, and various kinds of repetition. The historical songs use them much more sparingly.

Commonplaces (*loci communes*) are formulaic, stereotypic descriptions of recurring situations, such as the banquet at Prince Vladimir's, the hero's entrance into the hall, jumping of the horse, and the slaughter of the enemy. The geographical distribution of commonplaces varies greatly.

Those mentioned above are found wherever byliny are recited and obviously are the oldest. Some are from a single region; some are restricted to narrators of a single school; and some are used only by individual singers. The commonplaces often begin and end the bylina or appear in transitional places. Whenever the singer has to describe a situation for which he has a commonplace, he uses the same description, occasionally with a slight modification. Reliance on these familiar images gives him an opportunity to relax and simultaneously to plan ahead (Uxov 1957: 119 ff.).

Fixed epithets are used in byliny to qualify a particular noun. The horse, e. g., in about 95 per cent of the cases is "good", the field is "open", the birch, the tree, the day, the swan, and the tent are "white", the table and the gate are "high", the sun and gold are "red", and the steppe, road and yard are "broad". According to Uxov, fixed epithets function as means of generalization and typification, pointing to more characteristic, permanent, typical features of certain objects and phenomena (Uxov 1958: 158 ff.).

The use of fixed epithets has become automatic: whenever a certain noun is used, it appears with its epithet. The Tatar Kalin Tsar even calls his own subjects by the epithet "heathen Tatars". The epithet for Kalin Tsar is "dog", thus he is normally referred to as "the dog Kalin Tsar" (*sobaka Kalin tsar*).

Byliny make frequent use of various kinds of repetition: the repetition of prepositions; simple repetition of words; palilogia — the repetition of the end of one verse at the beginning of the next; the repetition of contrasts by way of negation, etc. (Sokolov 1971: 305–306). Characteristic of the Russian epic is the negative analogy, which involves affirmation by denial, e. g.:

It was not a dark storm-cloud that came up,
and not a dark cloud was rolling up,
— it was Dunaj, Ivan's son.
(Weiher 1972: 152.)

The repetitions of extensive units, popular in Russian epic songs, are divided by Kuusi into the nucleus repetition and the frame repetition.

The first repeats the nucleus of the motif literally for the purpose of emphasis. The second changes the nucleus, retaining the recurring frame for retardation (Kuusi 1952: 83 ff., 107 ff.).

In contradistinction to Russian, Finnish singers generally rely much less on epic ceremonialism. Repetition and parallelism are frequently used, whereas negative analogy, taken over from Russian (Oinas 1985: 83–90), is used less often. Paul Kiparsky states aptly:

The important point is that the [Finnish] singers dispose of very little floating thematic material which can be freely inserted at appropriate points in the narrative. There are no standard sequences describing fighting, forging of weapons, preparation for battle, etc. Each event is unique, and most epic verses are identified with a particular song. (Kiparsky 1976: 95–96.)

For this reason, the diction of the Finnish epic song is much more matter-of-fact and sober than that of Russian. The differences between a Finnish singer's repeated renditions result not from the use or omission of embellishments, but from omission and addition of verses from his own or other singers' versions (Kiparsky 1976: 95–96).

Formula

In numerous cultures, the singers of epic songs compose while singing, with the application of the formulas, as Parry and Lord have shown. There are two studies available on the formula analysis of Russian *byliny* — by William E. Harkins and Patricia Arant. Both argue for the significance of the formula to Russian singers. Harkins writes: "The formulas... help the singer who has a ready stock of such formulas, in his work of composition" (Harkins 1963: 164). Arant "tried... to show the usefulness of this method to the singer in the rapid composition of his songs" (Arant 1967: 45).

On the basis of the main stresses, Harkins divides the bylina line into three segments: "Formulas were identified which tended to recur in a given segment of the line: in the beginning (anaphora), middle (mesodiplosis), or the end (epiphora). These results suggest that the bylina line is properly divided into three segments or colons..." (Harkins 1963: 165.)

Arant adopts the formula analysis used by Parry and Lord for Yugoslav epics and concludes that "the Russian material falls into the same basic pattern of composition as the Yugoslav" (Arant 1967: 45). She divides the bylina line into two segments and identifies the formula either with the first half line, the second half line, or the whole line. Since the metrical structure of Yugoslav and Russian epic verse is different, their formulas can hardly be identical.

The formula has no significance for the singers of Finnish epic songs. Paul Kiparsky has shown that the repertoire of the Finnish singers consists of fairly stable compositions. Changes in the content and organization of the story are rare, and only small changes of wording, word order and substitutions of synonyms are found. The singers, in the course of time, work out a stable form of a song, which with minor changes is repeated at each performance (Kiparsky 1976: 95). Therefore composition-in-performance, so important e. g. in Yugoslav epic songs, is not used by Finnish singers. If this type of composition were a criterion, "then the Perttunens and Malinens must be counted as second-rate, degenerate singers" (Kiparsky 1976: 98). Kiparsky finds that "the differences in stability between the Finnish and Yugoslav oral epic poetry spring from the different roles they play in their respective cultures. Whereas the Yugoslav poetry functions largely as storytelling and entertainment, the Finnish poetry contains strong elements of *myth* and *ritual*" (Kiparsky 1976: 98). Just as in medical spells, etiological verses and ritual texts which promote the growth of crops, changes in wording and content are avoided. Matti Kuusi expresses the same idea: "The most holy tradition of a clan was not changed light-mindedly or adapted to the sacred rites and words of even a superior neighboring people. It was preserved for millennia;

everything else slipped into oblivion” (Kuusi 1963: 80). Kiparsky corrects Parry and Lord, demonstrating that the fixity of a text is determined not by the technique (writing versus speech), but rather the function of the text in society (Kiparsky 1976: 101).

Meter and singing

The Russian and Finnish epic songs are composed not in stanzas but in single lines. The Russian *bylina* line is characterized by the presence of three or four dominant stresses, whereas the number of unstressed syllables is unimportant. The length of a *bylina* verse varies from eight syllables to as high as fourteen or fifteen. Verses tend to end with a dactylic cadence.

The Russian epic songs were sung by a man or a woman, and in former times generally accompanied by musical instruments. The oldest instrument was the *gusli* (psaltery) — a low, irregular four-sided box with five or (later) more strings. It was demonstrated recently that the Russians in the Old Novgorod area took over the Balto-Finnic and Baltic psaltery-type musical instrument (Finnish *kantele*, Lithuanian *kanklės*) and gave it their own name (Tõnurist 1977: 149–177). The *gusli*’s place was eventually taken over by the *balalaika*, which in some areas (like Olonec) went out of use some time ago.

The line of the Finnish epic song is made up of four trochaic feet, that is, of eight syllables altogether. The quantity rules require that a short first syllable of a word not be used in the ictus position. The Kalevala songs make abundant use of alliteration — the repetition of initial identical consonant or vowel sounds in successive or closely associated words.

In Finland and Karelia, epic songs customarily were sung by men. Two men, with their right hands joined, sang, whereas a third man accompanied them on the *kantele*. One of the men, the fore-singer,

sang a line, which the after-singer then repeated. The specific position taken by the singers and their cooperation could be a vestige of shaman activity, reflecting the collaboration of the shaman and his helper.

Concluding remark

The Russian and the Finnish epic songs constitute a vanishing tradition. They have gradually disappeared in northern Russia and in Karelia as a living form, although individual singers who ply their art can be found. The prime reason to perform Russian epic songs, at least during recent centuries, was to tell a story. These songs varied from performance to performance, as a result of the special improvisational technique of oral composition and the use of considerable movable material. In Finland and Karelia, singing was an individual art. The singers worked out an acceptable, stable version of a song to be repeated at each performance. Since the songs were also sung for magical and ritualistic purposes, an effort was made to avoid changes in wording and content. Whereas the most famous Russian singers were admired for their ability to improvise a great number of songs, the fame of the Finnish-Karelian singers was based on their ability to present the ancient songs faithfully and without change.

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David E. Bynum

The Väinämöinen Poems and the South Slavic Oral Epos

Having emanated from the common fund of ideas current in European intellectual life during the last two hundred years, many tendencies in scholarship about the oral epic tradition of the South Slavs have paralleled those to be found in such studies of the Finnish runic tradition as have been published in the several *linguae francae* of modern academic discourse. Yet none of these tendencies has hitherto resulted in a systematic comparison of the two poetic traditions themselves — Finnish and South Slavic — by a South Slavicist. Such an exercise is, I think, both feasible and rewarding, although I find that it yields certain rather novel results for interpretation of the Kalevalaian poetry.

In what follows, I take my point of departure with relation to the Finnish tradition from Martti Haavio's study *Väinämöinen, Eternal Sage* (1952). Although the book is now more than thirty years old, I have found much in it worthy of further reflection, and it has been a springboard for me in reaching such an understanding of the Kalevalaian poetry as I have been able to achieve. My debt to it is in no wise diminished by my several divergences from its views.

Haavio's avowed purpose was to disengage the several discrete strands of traditional poetic narrative about Kaleva's cunning old son Väinämöinen from the intricate web of Elias Lönnrot's literary weaving in the *Kalevala*, and by so doing to establish as perfectly as he could the pure original form of each of the several primary runes that he believed historically underlay the many related variants found by collectors in the several different regions and provinces of greater Finland and in ethnically cognate enclaves in neighboring lands. Haavio proceeded towards this end by

identifying the common elements shared among many texts from different singers, and then constructing from those elements a simplified 'core' of story purged of the many merely local accretions and contaminations which he thought had everywhere attached themselves to the pristine narratives since the remote and unknown moments of their first composition by hypothetical early medieval poetic geniuses. Moving away thus from Lönnrot's intentional artistic conflation of many disparate materials into a new literary unity, Haavio's different method was to conflate from the resemblances among similar regional variants of the 'original' texts a new scholarly unity of concept for individual episodes in the runes pertaining to Väinämöinen. In a manner generally consistent with the tenets both of the historic-geographic school of folk narrative criticism and with literary *Textkritik* (the two being in any case closely similar and similarly motivated systems), Haavio printed his hypothetical *Urtexte* like epigraphs to the successive chapters in his book.

Haavio's aim in applying such a method was to arrive as exactly as possible at what in each rune he could believe an original creative poet had once long ago composed in a unique act of poetic genius, a solitary coruscation of own personal verbal skill and of singularly gifted insight into the nature of the world. He denied such original poetic power to both the ordinary *runo* of the modern collectors' experience (even when the runo was a giant of Simana Sissonen's or Arhippa Perttunen's stature) and even to what he called the unknown "adapters", whom he regarded as historically responsible for the big divergences and mixtures of 'different' runes such as he often found in the actual collected texts.

Working as I do in the South Slavic field a generation after Haavio, I can concur very little in his methodological presuppositions, which simply belong to an earlier era and are for me now quite out of date. For me there are no *Urtexte* to be separated from the dross of later accretions and admixtures, and no great original *primaeval* poets from whom such poetry sprang like *die Schöpfung aus Gottes Absicht*. For me the process of accretion and admixture is itself the great first principle of poetic creativity in an oral narrative tradition, and the modern runo is fundamentally indistinguishable from all his precursors forever. I also

regard such traditions as having very much more ancient histories than can usefully be reconstructed by the historic-geographic method. Thus it is not Haavio's approach to his subject that has been useful to me (as in the course of time, mine may not be of much use to later generations); what I have found valuable is rather the result of his remarkable intimacy with the vital details of the many difficult texts in the diverse Finnish collections which he achieved once he had approached them by whatever avenue of method he found congenial.

The several narrative runes concerning Väinämöinen which Haavio treated are basically six in number, and include those that Elias Lönnrot wove into the First, Sixth, Fourteenth, Fifteenth, and Sixteenth Songs of his so-called Proto-Kalevala; the First, Ninth, Tenth, Twenty-Second, Thirtieth, and Thirty-Second Songs of the Old Kalevala; and the First, Third, Sixteenth, Seventeenth, Fortieth, Forty-First, Forty-Fourth, and Fiftieth Songs of the classic Kalevala. More recent editions of some corresponding texts of the actual songs as collected from the Finnish oral tradition itself have been anthologized with English translations in Matti Kuusi, Keith Bosley, and Michael Branch's book *Finnish Folk Poetry: Epic* (1977, hereinafter referred to as FFPE). Pertinent items in that volume include texts nos. 2, 3, 4, 5; 10, 11; 23, 24, 25; 28; 30; 57 and 58.

Haavio called his six basic narratives about Väinämöinen: 1) The Creation Rune; 2) The Singing Contest Rune; 3) The Journey to Tuonela; 4) The Rune of Antero Vipunen; 5) The Kantele Sequence; and 6) Väinämöinen's Judgment. I shall now assess each of these same narratives in the same order.

The Creation Rune — the primordial fusion of nature and culture

The pertinent texts are the First Song in all three redactions of the Kalevala and texts nos. 2, 3, 4, and 5 in FFPE.

A bird flies over the open sea seeking a nesting place. Väinämöinen, who is submerged "in the middle of the sea's navel", raises his knee,

which emerges from the water as “a green hummock” of “fresh turf”, and the bird casts a copper nest upon it, in which it then lays a golden egg. The bird’s subsequent incubation of the egg burns Väinämöinen’s knee, and he shakes the nest and egg off onto a shoal, where they shatter. Väinämöinen makes the earth from the lower shell, the welkin from the upper shell, the sun from the egg-white, the moon from the egg-yolk, and the stars from the lesser fragments of the egg-shell.

I note as a matter of plain ethnographic reality the characteristically knee-level position of the metal-smith’s anvil as pictured in the photographic illustration no. 44 in FFPE. Again in the Visit to Antero Vipunen (q.v. *infra*) Väinämöinen’s knee burns as he makes an anvil of it to work other metal. As is typical of the Väinämöinen runes, so here too the quintessentially artificial, humanly calculated, cultural act of metal-working is analogized with its logical opposite: the quintessentially instinctual, natural animal act of ovarian reproduction. The bird is inseparably at one and the same time both egg-layer and smith. This is a conspicuous rôle-reversal as between the bird and Väinämöinen; but it needs to be remembered that this is a tale about a primordial mythic time, a time before the present order of things as we know them in the post-Väinämöinen era had yet come into being; and in that mythic time it is the unthinking bird that is the smith, while the humanly intelligent Väinämöinen reacts in a merely animal, instinctual fashion with a simple tactile reflex to cool his hot knee. But as may accidentally happen at a real forge, the premature quenching of the bird’s hot-cast egg shatters it. If in this rune Väinämöinen is as yet not the great smith that he later becomes (not yet able to avoid either being burnt or dropping his work into the quenching-bath before it is ready), he is nevertheless superbly inventive, for his subsequent creation of the world from the broken egg is pure inspiration and unpremeditated opportunism. It is a brilliant act of spontaneous improvisation from scavenged debris. And that, suggests this rune, is how even the most momentous things come to pass.

The Singing Contest — the fitness of the bridegroom

This is the tale of Väinämöinen's encounter with Joukahainen and the consequent betrothal to him of Joukahainen's sister. The pertinent texts are Song Fifteen in the Proto-Kalevala, Song Thirty in the Old Kalevala, Song Three in the classic Kalevala, and texts nos. 10 and 11 in FFPE.

Old Väinämöinen and young Joukahainen collide head-on as they drive in opposite directions over ice. They agree that whichever of them knows more shall have the right-of-way. But Joukahainen's most ponderous knowledge is only of things Väinämöinen has done. Väinämöinen first claims his own deeds for himself, then by the power of his words inhumes Joukahainen (and his dog) and alienates various items of Joukahainen's property, either by transforming them or transporting them to other places. Joukahainen begs for the restoration of himself and his chattels, promising Väinämöinen money, or horse(s), or boat(s), and when these are rejected, finally he promises his own sister in marriage as ransom. Väinämöinen accepts the offer of the girl, and Joukahainen returns home to his mother crestfallen about the bad bargain he has made for his sister. His mother replies however that she has waited her whole life long hoping one day to gain Väinämöinen for her son-in-law.

Here again we see Väinämöinen scavenging an advantage from an accidental misfortune. As in a riddling-contest before a wedding, Väinämöinen demonstrates his fitness in knowledge to be a girl's husband and a capable affine to her agnates. One is reminded powerfully of Samson's similar prowess before his wedding at Timnah in the Old Testament (Judges 13–14). As in the Creation Rune, so too again in this one: both the Creation of the World and Väinämöinen's betrothal appear in the cosmogonic time of the narrative to be merely accidental contingencies resulting from pure chance, but in post-cosmogonic time (i. e., in the world as we know it after Väinämöinen has formed it), what for Väinämöinen were only improvisations are for us the

indispensable prerequisites to those results. He just happened to match wits with another man and won that man's sister to wife thereby; ever since, due proof of manly superiority is the conventional, expected means to winning a wife. Here then once again Väinämöinen acts as a cosmogonic culture-hero, doing for the first time by accident and inspired improvisation what has since that mythic time *in illo tempore* become the obligatory, prescribed way of accomplishing that same thing again by lesser persons who epigonically follow his example.

The prime test of superior manhood in this tale (i. e., of manhood fit for marriage) is the power of movement. After the collision, Joukahainen and Väinämöinen are both momentarily immobilized together with all their equipment and appurtenances. Whichever of them is to move forward must first put the other out of his way, and this Väinämöinen does in such a manner as to deprive his rival (and his rival's dog) of even that lesser residual power of movement that is left to them in their own persons after the collision: he inters Joukahainen (and dog) in the earth. Joukahainen's chattels, on the other hand, which lie inertly barricading the road after the collision, Väinämöinen transports out of the way, in several cases even imparting to them a power to move in their own right. Thus the stalled horse of Joukahainen leaps like a seal; the immobilized saddle now moves like a duck swimming in the sea; the transfixed collar-tree flows away in the form of a splashing spring, and Joukahainen's whip, still in the wreck, sways of its own accord when transformed into a reed by Väinämöinen. What was an inert still-life becomes a veritable catalogue of the different kinds of motion observable in nature.

I have previously commented in another place (Bynum 1981) on the metaphorical expression of certain standard qualifications to be a bridegroom as found in oral narrative traditions worldwide. Expressed always in the idiomatic imagery of each particular people who share the tale, these qualifications are in summary: 1) mastery over wood [either in its hewn state or as fuel for fire, or both], 2) mastery over water, 3) mastery over multitudinous animal life, and 4) the critical power to make a right choice among alternatives, especially between a

proper bride [or her tokens] and specious substitutes. In the same manner that the Creation Rune fused the disparate conceptual elements of natural reproduction and the metal worker's cultural artifice into a single, unified idea by means of the image of the bird forging a metal egg, so again the Singing Contest fuses the concept of mobility (as a measure of manliness in general) with the concepts of mastery over wood, water, animals and selection (as tests of male worthiness for marriage) in the images of Joukahainen's chattels. What more portentous expression of mastery over hewn wood and water could there be than Väinämöinen's conversion of Joukahainen's collar-tree into the running water of a spring? And what greater power over animal life could there be than the transformation of Joukahainen's terrestrial and domestic horse into an aquatic and feral seal? Then finally Väinämöinen makes the able bridegroom's choice of his true bride-to-be from among the several alternatives proffered him by Joukahainen, for he correctly prefers the girl to any further means (which he already possesses sufficiently) of either terrestrial mobility (horses) or aquatic mobility (boats).

The Journey to Tuonela — the perfect smith

The pertinent texts are the Sixth Song in the Proto-Kalevala, the Ninth Song in the Old Kalevala, Song Sixteen in the classic Kalevala, and text no. 30 in FFPE.

The sledge on which Väinämöinen is riding breaks down under him. He requires an auger to repair it and, not having one, goes to Tuonela for it. A river obstructs his journey to that place. From its far bank, he summons a girl (or girls) to fetch a boat to him for his conveyance across the river. The girl questions the cause of his coming to Tuonela, and he tells her that fire, or water, or iron have

caused him to come there. To each of these answers, which she takes to be falsehoods, she objects that his appearance betrays no mark of those elements' fatal effects. He finally says that he has come to obtain pointed iron tools from Tuonela, whereupon the girl provides the boat for his passage over the river.

The girl and her kin then entertain their visitor in the correct manner: feeding him, giving him to drink, and laying him to rest in what, for Tuonela, must be considered a proper bed, although it is "...a bed of silk which was serpent venom" (FFPE), or even more sinisterly, "...the man lay a-bed, the cover kept watch". Shifting his shape into that of a reptile, Väinämöinen flees the place of death by swimming the same river he had earlier needed a boat to cross, and so returns home. There he cautions young people not to repeat his journey to Tuonela, the difficulty of return being extreme.

Thus for the third time — as seen previously in the Creation and Singing Contest runes — Väinämöinen scavenges benefits from a seeming misadventure, which in this instance is the breakdown of his sleigh. I defer to the judgement of others the question of whether such an accident might possibly be fatal in the real world; or perhaps it is only a dead man's unique place of honour in a funeral procession that causes Väinämöinen to be "resplendant above the other proud folk" on this occasion. As in the Singing Contest, it is in any case immobility that again afflicts Väinämöinen in consequence of his accident. To overcome his immobility in the land of the living, he goes from the scene of his accident to Tuonela, the place of the dead, only to find himself immobilized there too, unable to cross its river. Thus he is aquaticly immobile in Tuonela, terrestrially immobile in the land of the living. The child of Tuonela whom he summons to ferry him over the river is not unfamiliar with the advent of dead men — those who have drowned, or been mortally burned, or fatally pierced by metal objects. From her list of the forms of death known to her, it would seem that Tuonela's daughter is particularly conversant with men who have died through a kind of confusion of themselves with products of the forge; here

again, as in the Creation rune, firing and quenching and forming of metals are analogized with the processes of natural organisms. But Väinämöinen shows none of the expected effects of smithing, and so Tuonela's daughter cannot identify him with the other dead forms she is familiar with. In other words, Väinämöinen lacks the appearance of a metal object that has been worked at the forge, and so she will not be "deceived" into thinking him dead. The scene is not however really a scene of deception, but rather of mutual incomprehension. For the living, the distinguishing characteristic of death is motionlessness, while for the dead, it is the condition of a finished artisanal artifact — just such an artifact as, indeed, Väinämöinen has come to Tuonela to fetch.

In keeping with the inability of Väinämöinen and the daughter of Tuonela to understand each other, we too are obliged to equivocate in an extraordinary way about Väinämöinen as he appears in this rune, for surely he is as at one and the same time both dead and alive. And so once again the narrative tradition about Väinämöinen conflates into a single image (that of Väinämöinen himself) certain contrastive ideas which are utterly polarized and incommensurate with one other in *our* world, but which were *in illo tempore*, when Väinämöinen was still arranging and discovering the proper order of the world, still capable of commingling. Like the bird that commingles the artisan's culturally acquired skill of forging metal with its own natural act of egg-laying in the Creation rune, so in a similar manner Väinämöinen in this rune commingles in himself the two states of being which have not ever since his time been so commingled: life and death. For there is only a single class of objects in the world after Väinämöinen's time that may regularly be both 'dead' and 'alive', namely the category of things called 'tools'. Like the auger which Väinämöinen at first only seeks, but then eventually becomes in his own person, tools in general are inert, fixated, dead things in one sense; but they may also become through the uses made of them in culture quasi-living forms, things as able as any real animate being both to move and to do.

The exchange between Väinämöinen and Tuonela's daughter is thus remarkably like Odysseus' "lying" to Athena in Odyssey 13. In both

cases, what the supernal female interlocutor takes for mere deceit is actually more than that. It represents an irreconcilable fundamental difference between the man and the maid toward causation, toward the question of why the man has come to be where he is and in need of the maiden's help to finish his journey. The deficiency in both Väinämöinen's and Odysseus' case is the same; they do not either of them appear sufficiently worn and damaged to be eligible for the next stage of their intended journeys. Thus Väinämöinen does not show in his appearance the necessary marks of the fire for softening, the water for hardening, and the iron itself of the forge. These are, moreover, precisely what Väinämöinen has come to Tuonela to obtain, for his reasons for going there are posterior reasons: fire, water, and iron are the very things he — or any blacksmith — must have and understand to forge a gimlet, an augur, or a drill. Thus Väinämöinen tells the maid of Tuonela an impeccable truth as to why he has come; only she does not understand posterior reasons, nor is it in the nature of death that she should. Death occurs only for anterior, and not for posterior reasons; it results from various causes but it is not the means to any subsequent purpose of those who die. In this crucial point Väinämöinen is, as always, an incomparably brilliant inventor, for he turns his misadventure with his broken sleigh into a reason for further travel that is ulterior to death itself, and this is what makes him unlike any other traveller to Tuonela either before or after himself.

He tells the girl that he has come for an augur, a gimlet, or a drill (bit), thus finally acknowledging to her satisfaction that he will be contented to obtain such a tool in its finished, dead state; he has not come to her river by reason of mishandling any of such a tool's active, living principles of manufacture. A mission of the same kind occurs again in the rune of Antero Vipunen, and under similar circumstances. For here in the Journey to Tuonela, just as in the rune of Antero Vipunen, it is not merely the physical object of a particular, concrete auger, drill-bit, or gimlet that Väinämöinen lacks, or even the several necessary substances and skills to form such a tool; no, his deficiency in both instances is very much more serious than that. He lacks indeed

the very model, pattern, or idea for such a tool. He lacks the abstraction of the “word” concerning it as well as the material object and the means to form such a metal implement.

Nor was he mistaken in coming to Tuonela in search for such knowledge, for the girl of Tuonela who ferries him across the river is also a praeternaturally able iron-smith. Not only she but her kin-folk also fabricate metals as easily as other women spin and weave cloth. A naive reader might however object that, although Väinämöinen does ultimately escape Tuonela’s oppressively retentive hospitality, he does not obtain from his hosts and bring back from Tuonela the thing he went there to fetch: the auger or gimlet for repairing his broken sleigh. To escape his hosts’ retention, he only shifts his own shape from that of man to worm, lizard, or snake, and so swims out of Tuoni’s realm by the same route he entered it — the river that intervenes between the land of the living and the place of the dead. Thus he achieves the aquatic mobility in the place of the dead that is requisite to the ideational restoration of his terrestrial mobility in the land of the living, but seemingly he does not obtain the carpenter’s tool requisite to an actual physical restoration of his sleigh.

Now we have observed previously how, in the Creation rune, a supernal bird incorporates a supreme act of artful metal-working into its natural act of egg-laying, and we duly noted on that occasion the conceptual conflation of disparate orders of experience into a single poetic image. I submit that it is precisely another instance of the same principle at work that we have before us now in the Journey to Tuonela. For whereas Väinämöinen brings home no actual (dead) gimlet or auger of iron for his trouble in going there, his urgent need to penetrate the barrier that separates the place of the dead from the land of the living induces him to assume in his own person the very shape and pattern of the tool which he came to fetch for the repair of his wooden sledge. Watch but for a moment the worm or reptile swimming in the stream of a watercourse, and how can you fail to recognize in its living form that same pointed spiral, a self-propelled, living animal exemplar of the very thing that Väinämöinen had sought in Tuonela. Thus the Creation

rune and the Journey to Tuonela affirm the same proposition: that inert artifice is best that most perfectly replicates a living, moving form. Väinämöinen returns from Tuonela bearing no mere static, lifeless metal tool, but rather the live pattern incorporated into his own being of all such implements ever after. He is indeed the perfect smith.

And if I am right in my further conjecture that Väinämöinen's conversion of himself into a live piercing and penetrating tool in order to rend his way homeward into renewed life through the tissues of the maids who weave iron fabrics in Tuonela is also phallic, and therefore makes symbolically both a son and a lover of Väinämöinen, then so much the better for the power of these poems' imagery in its deep understanding of the tool-like essence of masculinity in all its aspects.

Antero Vipunen — a conflation of life and death

The pertinent texts are the Sixth Song in the Proto-Kalevala; the Tenth Song in the Old Kalevala; the Seventeenth Song in the classic Kalevala; and text no. 28 in FFPE.

Väinämöinen cannot finish building a ship for want of three "words" wherewith to fasten a part or parts of it in place. Other expedients having failed, he goes to the mouldering heap of a long-defunct sage of the past, Anter(v)o Vipunen, where the latter lies with "a great ash tree (growing) on his shoulders,/ ...an alder on his jaws,/ a bird-cherry by his beard". Seeking access to Vipunen, Väinämöinen walks on the edges of men's sword-blades for one day, on the points of women's needles for a second day, and on the third day he slips and falls into the crevasse of Vipunen's open mouth. There, bent double like a fetus and using his knees for an anvil, shirt as a forge, fur-piece as bellows, elbow for hammer, and fingers for tongs, Väinämöinen shapes a cowlstaff, which he then deploys as a brace

to keep Vipunen's mouth from closing on him. Vipunen bids him begone from his insides, but Väinämöinen obtains a wealth of precious words from him before departing. Väinämöinen then finishes the building of his ship.

I have written extensively elsewhere (Bynum 1978) about the world-wide mythologem in oral narrative tradition that involves an ogre in greenwood and certain reversals of fortune that habitually occur there between the ogre and a visiting *cosmotact*. The copse of trees growing on Antervo Vipunen's face and shoulder is just such greenwood, and Vipunen is the man-destroyer who, functioning in this case like a pit-fall for trapping games, catches the cosmotact Väinämöinen as he roams at random in a desert place. But Väinämöinen is a hewer of wood (as seen in his boat-building, which is both the initial and the ultimate event in this rune), and as such he inescapably imparts a relationship of *quid pro quo* and the exaction of price or recompense in his dealing with others. Vipunen, on the other hand, whose type is that of the wild greenwood's denizen, is unaccustomed to orderly exchanges. He says of himself that in past time gratuitously "a hundred men have I eaten,/ a thousand heroes destroyed", while clearly he has answered to no one for these depredations. Thus, Vipunen is used to having men inside himself as his victims: in a word, he is a cannibal ogre domiciled in the wilderness of the same general type as the Anglo-Saxon Grendel.

But the usual or customary course of Vipunen's freely exploitative dealings with others is reversed when Väinämöinen comes to him in this rune. Now, instead of simply consuming his victim with no thought of indemnification to anyone, Vipunen is unprecedentedly obliged by his cosmotactic visitor to *give* something (namely his precious words) instead of simply *taking* the victim who has chanced his way. Correspondingly, instead of becoming the ogre's prey, Väinämöinen, as the typical cosmotact of this mythologem, becomes instead the ogre's beneficiary. And so, as usual in this bit of universal oral narrative tradition, the reversal of fortune as between the expected predator and the expected victim involves a question of identities: "what manner of

man may you be, and what fellow?" A round of hide-and-seek is also played out between the wild would-be predator and his tricky, civilizing visitor: first Vipunen's exact whereabouts are concealed from Väinämöinen, and then in turn Väinämöinen is concealed for a time in Vipunen, from whom he finally emerges to be asked the question who he really is.

Much ink has been spent in efforts to represent Antervo Vipunen as a mythic emanation of the sub-arctic and Asian shaman. I am inclined to discount such speculation as mostly groundless and based, to the extent that it has any basis at all, on *post*-narrative social phenomena. In other words, the narrative foundation of this rune — what actually appears in the texts — is certainly of far greater age and far wider geographic range in the world than the local elements of particular people's ritual and religion that can be associated with it typologically either in the Baltic region or in Central Asia. And as for Antervo Vipunen's putatively being dead — of course he is dead, in the same way and to the same degree as is Väinämöinen in the Journey to Tuonela. Which is to say that of course he is *not* dead at the same time that he *is* dead; for this merging together in fiction of things that are rigidly distinct in reality is one of the notional constants that run continuously through the fabric of all the Väinämöinen narratives alike. Thus Vipunen also is a conflation into one mythic being of ideational categories — life and death — that in post-cosmogonic time (i. e., in historical time) are clearly and finally separated, but which, so the myth tells us, were not uniformly separate *in illo tempore*.

But the identity of the characters does not depend on whether they are dead or alive. Whereas Väinämöinen's identity is murky in proportion to his cultural complexity, Vipunen is simple and unambiguous. He is an innocently rapacious, casually forgetful denizen of the wild who moulders with age and yet at the same time teems with vital assets in a quintessentially natural manner; like some unexploited natural resource in the wilderness, he veritably waits to be mined by some civilizing cosmotact such as Väinämöinen. But in order successfully to exploit the great recumbent natural resource of Vipunen, the cosmotact

must first know how to make artful use of himself, to such a degree of artfulness indeed as to raise a ponderous question about his own identity. For what is he, after all, when he is finally down in Antero Vipunen's belly? Is he the blacksmith, or the blacksmith's shop? Are his fingers really fingers, or the blacksmith's tongs? Is his elbow an elbow of flesh and bone, or a hammer? Once again the perfect smith applies the principle: that artifice is best that most perfectly replicates a living, moving form, and once again (as previously in the visit to Tuonela) he accordingly assumes that form in his own person. But as always in his stories, Väinämöinen performs this wonderful creative metamorphosis or shape-shifting in direct consequence of an accident; in this instance, the accident of his chance tumble into Antero Vipunen's mouth when "his left foot slipped". Surely there is not anywhere in all of collected oral tradition any better example of the cosmotact as scavenger, not any example so compactly and economically formulated in verse.

Väinämöinen's scavengery is of a particular sort: what he acquires by his accidentally induced scavengery is habitually the means or method of achieving a purpose, not the achievement itself. He returns from Tuonela with the idea of an auger or gimlet, not with the tool itself. Both in the Journey to Tuonela and in the present rune, what Väinämöinen needs is pointed fasteners to repair his sleigh in the one case and to attach components to his boat in the other case. The only important difference between the two cases is the same difference already noted in the Singing Contest: he wishes to perfect a vehicle for terrestrial travel in the one rune, and for aquatic travel in the other. But this purpose — to render himself mobile by land or by sea — entirely precedes his scavenging for the means to accomplish it after an accident.

The nature of the joiner's craft is elegantly analyzed, and craftsmanship is again related to the artisan's own physical being in the images of the swords and needles upon which Väinämöinen treads on his way to Vipunen's subterranean belly (or womb). For it is in the essential nature of joinery that it first *separates* matter and then *recombines* it in

different configurations, where it is fastened together once again with other matter. This principle, which Väinämöinen as shipwright must pragmatically obey in the practice of first hewing boards from timber and then fastening them together again as he frames a sea-going vessel — this same principle is applied also to Väinämöinen himself as he passes first across the cutting, separating edges of male swords for a whole day, and then for a second day across the penetrating, reunifying points of female needles (the distinction made here between female clothes-fasteners and male flesh-cutters is interestingly the same as in Homer's *Iliad*, E 425). So he is himself first symbolically hewn and then reconstituted, just as his craft of joinery first hews and then reassembles and refastens the constituent pieces to make his ship. Only he lacks certain "words" to finish the job, and must scavenge for them. Martti Haavio quotes an instructive passage from Elias Lönnrot concerning such "words".

It seems rather likely that while old people were occupied at a task, they said words special to the work in hand, by which they wished for each task or object better luck, solidity, and success. Of this belief there are certain traces among us still today. The smith for instance, beginning to forge some object says, 'I have been an apprentice, I have stood at the smith's forge for thirty summers, for the same number of winters'. Then shoveling coals into the firebox, he declares, 'I put my coals into the fire, drive the charcoal into the firebox'; in speaking of the fire, 'fire has come down from heaven, has come from the zenith'; putting his iron into the fire, 'I thrust my iron into the fire, my steel under the forge'; in fanning with bellows, 'Now I work the bellows, now I fan the fire'. Some smiths still use such phrases, and special ones for each step. I have heard it said also that some, while making a boat, pronounce strange phrases when attaching each rib and driving each nail home, and such probably were the three words of Väinämöinen.

Now such words as these are not at all the incantations of a shaman making magic; they are only step-by-step summarizations of the actual

acts of artisanship by a smith as he fabricates some object of ordinary material utility. But when in this same way Väinämöinen comes to a certain juncture in ship-building, he finds that he is not able to proceed because, *in illo tempore*, the next step of the necessary joinery has not yet been invented. And so, no differently than the figures of ancient Greek myth in a comparable impasse of ignorance, Väinämöinen goes to his Finnish Cheiron, to a Nordic *Φῆρ λαχνήεις* (Iliad B 743) or *θήρ ὀρεσκῶος* (Iliad A 268) to learn the art of which he is ignorant. For I regard the wild, centauric repositories of arcane artisanal knowledge in ancient Greek tradition as much closer analogs to the Finnish Antervo Vipunen than Jonah's whale, with which earlier authorities have compared him. That sub-arctic and Asian shamanism has in some places borrowed such imagery from a narrative tradition older and wider than itself is entirely credible; for this is self-evidently a very old, a very durable, and a pandemically familiar nexus of ideas in oral narrative tradition — a nexus more ancient, more widely known, and plainly more durable than any attested ritual practice of shamanism in the Old World has been.

The kantele music and the psychopomp

The tradition concerning the invention of *kantele* music is manifold, with some poems describing the fabrication of the kantele by hewing from wood or from other terrestrially obtained substance, while other poems relate its derivation from the natural model of fish-bones.

Texts pertaining to the fish-bone kantele are Song Twenty-Two in the Old Kalevala, Song Forty and Forty-One in the classic Kalevala, and texts nos. 23 and 24 in FFPE. Texts pertaining to the wooden or otherwise terrestrially derived kantele are Song Fourteen in the Proto-Kalevala, Song Twenty-Nine in the Old Kalevala, Song Forty-Four in the classic Kalevala, and text no. 25 in FFPE.

I regard the accounts of the origin of the kantele and of Väinämöinen's singing to it as sub-narrative material in the tradition: a constituent of story, but not a whole story in its own right. In this I only follow resolutely after Haavio, who observed that the "...variants of the Kantele sequence... do not often go straight to the heart of the story". On the contrary, the narrative about the invention of the kantele and Väinämöinen's mesmeric singing with it was usually found in combination with some other tale: the Rival Courtship, for example, or the Sampo sequence, the Singing Contest, the Journey to Tuonela, or the Sea Expedition. Haavio mentioned further the ancient Greek analog concerning the invention and playing of the *φόρμιγξ* or *κιθάρις* as found in the Homeric "Hymn to Hermes". The Finnish tradition does indeed resemble that work both in appending the invention of the musical instrument to a larger tale and in distinguishing between the maker of the kantele and its greatest player, who in the Greek instance were Hermes and Apollo respectively. Similarly, even in those Finnish poems where Väinämöinen is made the inventor of the kantele, he is not its first player, and only when it passes into his hands after the attempts of others does the resultant music fix its hearers' attention and suspend their movements in the characteristic way.

Haavio argued also for the origins of this rune in the international folktale type of the Singing Bone. His reasoning in support of that opinion turned upon references in some of the multiforms to parts of "a maiden" that were incorporated into the kantele at the time of its creation: her hair, or her 'little fingers', or her finger-bones. Other components of the newly invented instrument are however equally prominent in the variants, and in no way support the derivation of the poetry from any folktale. These include the horns of a ram, the thighbone of a deer or of a goat, and 'shoots of Tuoni's barley'. All that these components disclose is that the making of the kantele is once again an act of scavenging, i. e., the exploitation of otherwise useless articles that come to hand accidentally. And as usual, these scavenged constituents of the kantele are not its actual constituents as found in any real, historically attested kantele; they are instead only ideal

constituents or models found in nature of what should be a kantele's various parts. And again, the perfect smith's function is one of joinery: he fastens them together into an artful assemblage which only makes the best possible use of his accidental discovery of them.

Very conspicuously in the making of the kantele, the pieces are matter that would otherwise be useless waste: fishbones; detached (and otherwise discarded) strands of hair; the horns and bones of meat-animals that remain after they have been eaten; even bits of human skeleton. Things therefore *that have no other use* go into the manufacture of the implement which then becomes the tool *par excellence* for whiling away time that has no other use; time, that is, such as one may properly devote to singing when the other, economic activities of life are finished. And when the preeminent singer sings to the kantele, all living things correspondingly give over their other, usual pursuits and idly listen to the music. In the same way too blind men, sea-farers when they have run aground, young and old, man and maiden — all beguile idle time with kantele music. Even the idle and otherwise useless boat that has been left to rot unemployed on the strand tends under Väinämöinen's captaincy toward his invention of music, which thus becomes the universal resort of all moving as well as living things in time of inactivity. Indeed it is so much so that at the end of the myth kantele-music becomes the very action for physical inactivity in otherwise active beings of every kind.

Such inactivity is of course a trait not only of living things when they are wakefully at rest but also when they have died. It should accordingly be asked whether Väinämöinen's use of an idle and rotted boat to travel aimlessly out to sea with a company of men and maidens who do not touch each other and old persons who are too weak to row effectively is really a multiform of the Sea Expedition rune, or something else. In the Greek instance, Hermes invented the lyre, but Hermes was also *psychopompos*, conveyor of the souls of the dead away from the land of the living. The later Orphic tradition in ancient Greece also connected mesmeric music with transitions between the place of the dead and the world of the living. In a perhaps similar manner, and

even apart from the Kantele sequence, Väinämöinen's dealing with a great pike at sea is a metaphor of death, as Haavio has observed. It might well reward those who can do it to review the Finnish corpus for other evidence of psychopompic meaning in Väinämöinen's or other heroes' music-making and sea-faring; for such further evidence, if it could be found, might considerably amplify the meaning which it has been possible to attach to the metaphors in the Kantele sequence thus far.

Väinämöinen's Judgment — a return to the Creation

The pertinent texts are Song Sixteen in the Proto-Kalevala; Song Thirty-Two in the Old Kalevala; Song Fifty in the classic Kalevala; and texts nos. 57 and 58 in FFPE.

A male infant is born illegitimately, or taken in as an illegitimate foundling, and then named by its maternal kin while they are still ignorant of its paternity. Väinämöinen is asked, or volunteers, his opinion of the naming, but he evades the question and desires instead that the infant not be named at all. He recommends that it be taken into a swamp, or to a marsh, or to a beach by the sea, and its head bashed in at that deserted place.

But the child miraculously speaks out in defense of itself against Väinämöinen's harsh judgment, and in turn accuses its judge of either illegitimately begetting it himself, or of incest, or both. In some variants the christening of the infant then proceeds with the added dimension of a coronation, he being declared a king. Väinämöinen goes down to the sea, sails away upon it until he reaches a maelstrom, where he disappears into the depths.

Haavio commented on this piece: "The beginning of the Väinämöinen's Judgment rune, like the introductions of many other Finnish narrative

runes, is vague and almost groping". I find it neither vague nor groping, but telegraphically brief and direct in its transmission of a clear message. It begins, in a manner which one now understands very well as characteristic of the Väinämöinen runes, with an accident. It is not this time a physical accident (although it has a physical aspect), but rather a social "accident", an accident of seduction and illegitimate birth. Accordingly, the rune is a parable about kinship in general and agnation in particular. It speaks of the injury which illegitimate paternity may do, not, paradoxically, to a bastard's mother or her kin, but rather to an illegitimate father. Here again Väinämöinen functions as an inventor, although not this time of any artisanal implement or craft. Rather, it is a mechanism of social consequence which he invents in this rune. For the rune points out by inference — too obvious an inference no doubt to any of the rune's original listeners for it to need any greater articulation than it already has in the poetry itself — that marriage and the legitimate paternity of male descendants perpetuates a man (i. e., it perpetuates the only part of him that is capable of continuation beyond his own finite lifetime, namely his lineage). This reality is symbolized in the male child's proper derivation of a name — its identity — from its married father. But illegitimate paternity has an exactly opposite effect: it extinguishes the father's lineage by reason of the injustice he does a son in begetting him out of wedlock, even though by dint of his own ability (and even if that ability is genetically inherited from the father) the child may still achieve a kingly destiny among his mother's kin. Indeed the child's genetic inheritance from its father, demonstrated in its precocious speaking with profound ironical wisdom at so tender an age, is the very thing that proves Väinämöinen's paternity; but while the child benefits from it, its illegitimate father can only be injured by it and in no way benefits from it.

So, as always, Väinämöinen once again realizes the conceptual essence of his invention in a transformation of his own physical self. The social perdition of illegitimate paternity is like the physical perdition of being lost at sea, except that in the social case a man brings it on himself. True to that idea, Väinämöinen deliberately goes down to the

very beach where he desired that the illegitimate child be destroyed and proceeds to lose himself without a trace. Väinämöinen's subsequent submergence in the open sea carries with it, however, an interesting suggestion of 'ring-composition' with respect to the Creation rune. For once he is submerged beneath the sea at the end of the Judgment rune, Väinämöinen is once more in precisely the same topographical location which he occupied at the very beginning of the Creation rune, when he raised his knee from the water to form the islet where the marvelous metal-casting bird made its fateful nest. Thus the scene is set for an eventual return of the culture-hero in the manner so typical of his kind the world over.

South Slavic comparisons

I said at the beginning of this disquisition that I attribute my license for such commentary as I have just made on six of the Väinämöinen runes to comparison of them with similar features of the South Slavic oral epic tradition. I say that the two traditions are substantively quite similar in respect at least to the specific features of the Finnish tradition which I have just reviewed; but it must remain for my readers to judge of that for themselves from some actual South Slavic evidence, which I now adduce.

The South Slavic tradition embraces both long and short performances, but narrative songs are very rarely as short as the Finnish narrative runes. They are commonly longer than the Finnish poems by a factor of ten or more, and single songs sung in domestic places (rather than at public gatherings) were not infrequently many thousands of lines long. One exactly recorded performance of this sort is the song "The Marriage of Vlahinjić Alija", the *editio princeps* of which I have published in *Serbo-Croatian Heroic Songs* collected by Milman Parry, 1980. This oral traditional epic poem is a little more than six thousand

lines in length, and incorporates many elements found in the Finnish Vainämöinen runes. It is one of a very numerous class of South Slavic oral epics called “wedding songs”, a name that refers to the songs’ narrative content and not to the typical occasion of their performance, which was unrelated to nuptials.

Wedding narratives of this same kind were widely familiar in the nineteenth and early twentieth century to the Slavic-speaking peasantry, both Christian and muslim, in much of the mountainous western region of the Balkan Peninsula. The present example happens to be muslim. Its narrative, which has not yet been translated out of Serbo-Croatian, runs as follows.

A conclave of muslim dignitaries and warriors has gathered in the town of Udbina. All of them converse together contentedly except one of the most prominent warriors, Mujo Hrnjica. He is asked why he seems so morose, and replies that he is not really dispirited but only distracted by a certain train of thought that has preoccupied his mind. He has, namely, been recalling certain moments of his reckless youth when he had gone from place to place looking for a girl to marry, first in his native muslim country, but later also in Christian territory. Finally he settled upon a pair of girls in the Christian town of Sinj, one of them the daughter of a famous Christian warrior, Ivan Senjanin, and the other an age-mate of hers of equally good family. (The reader must keep in mind that the muslim social ideal of polygyny was an avowed part of this tradition.)

Mujo tells how strenuously he courted the two girls, who guilefully affianced themselves to him and accepted his rich gifts of betrothal, only to jilt him when finally he had spent his last farthing on them. Dreading the mockery which he had now to expect from all the muslim girls at home, whom he had passed over in his vain pursuit of the two duplicitous Christians, and downcast moreover by the Christians’ ultimate rejection of him, Mujo then wished for nothing better than to save his honour and be done with his irksome life by provoking a fight and dying at the hands of some prominent Christian warrior.

So he made his way to the manor house of a certain Zakarić, to whom he bellowed a challenge as soon as he arrived there, intending to duel to the death with him. But as chance would have it, Zakarić was not at home, and there was no one except Zakarić's unwed sister, Ruža, to answer Mujo's call. She demanded to know what madness or inebriation made him behave so foolishly. Mujo then told her his whole misfortune, and explained that he no longer knew any recourse but to await her brother's return and be killed by him, unless perhaps Ruža herself would have him for her husband.

Swearing him to faithfulness (because, says she, Moslems are great liars), Ruža surprisingly accepted Mujo's proposal on the spot, hastily fetched a rich dowry consisting of all she could carry out of the manor-house, and then rode away with Mujo to be his wife in Udbina. Now, says Mujo, she has borne him two fine young sons, and never was there a happier husband than he.

This portion of the Serbo-Croatian epic occupies the first 314 of its 6,048 verses. It displays two of the several features noted repeatedly in the Vāinämöinen runes, namely: invention by scavengery after a mishap, and the cosmotact's typical use of his own body as a means for the production of what he needs. Thus, Mujo first woos nubile Christian girls in a way that can succeed for a Christian suitor, but not for a Moslem. Predictably therefore his suit fails, and with it also the possibility of his returning honorably to his own land (predictably, that is to say, from a historical point of view, but not *in illo tempore* when the events of this tale happened). He accordingly seeks a noble and sure quietus through death in manly combat. Thus for Mujo, as for Vāinämöinen in the Journey to Tuonela and the Antero Vipunen rune, what is initially only a rather casual desideratum — a gimlet, a word about ship-building, or a bride — becomes, as the quest for it advances, a matter of life and death. Then, true to the expected form, an accident befalls the hero: Zakarić is not available to kill Mujo. Nevertheless, out of the double wreckage of both his plans, he still manages to scavenge a bride, because *in extremis* he still has the wit to recognize

in Ruža a specimen of the very thing he needs: a Christian girl who will elope with him. This happy discovery and appropriation of her to his purpose on the spur of the moment does not happen, however, until he, like Väinämöinen in building his ship, has exhausted all other possibilities and finally placed his own physical body at risk to achieve his purpose. But the body he took to Zakarić's manor house to be the object of Zakarić's hate and onslaught becomes instead the object of Ruža's love and adoption (as with Joukahainen's female kin vis-à-vis Väinämöinen). So in the upshot he carries away from his adventure not only the particular thing he needed — a Christian bride — but much additional enrichment besides, including in Ruža a superb exemplar of the type of Christian girl and the type of courtship appropriate to wooing her which have become the norms for muslim suitors ever since.

It is a well known principle that features associated with a single or few personae in short forms of an oral traditional story are commonly redistributed among a larger number of personae in longer forms of the same essential narrative. That is true not only as between the long and shorter forms of the South Slavic "Wedding of Vlahinjić Alija" but also as between the longer South Slavic and the shorter Finnish manifestations of the present narrative system. For Mujo's framed tale of how he married Ruža is only background to his subsequent consideration of whether he ought to try now to marry again a second time.

All the world seems suddenly filled with the renown of a certain Zlata, who is daughter of the muslim military commander in the city of Klis, and who has only recently come of marriageable age. Every other able-bodied man in the land is eager to marry her, and Mujo has been considering whether he too might not sue for her as a second wife. But Mujo's itch for the girl Zlata is promptly reproached by others in the conclave who have heard his talk as being unseemly in a man of his years, and moreover unlikely to succeed, since Zlata is so desired by so many that she is able to choose virtually anyone in the realm for her husband, and would surely prefer someone less encumbered than Mujo.

From the periphery of the assembly an obscure young man, Alija Vlahinjić, now addresses Mujo and the rest of the company. He begs Mujo not to woo Zlata, but to leave her to him, because he loves her dearly and has reason to hope she may accept him. Mujo immediately relinquishes the girl to Alija, but another, toothless, white-haired, wealthy, devious, and sterile old member of the conclave now thrusts himself into the conversation. He insultingly denies that the young man might be chosen by Zlata, and insists that she will choose him instead, because he will lap her in unheard-of luxury by reason of his boundless wealth. He hopes that Zlata, who would be his eighth wife, may finally bear him the heir that none of his previous wives have given him. He abusively recounts also the several reasons why Zlata would never marry the hopeful youth. He is, first of all, a bastard who does not even know the identity of his own father; he was born to his morally reprehensible, helot (Vlah) mother while she tended sheep alone in the mountains. He has no real property of any kind and no chattels except his warhorse and his arms, and he lives alone with his now hundred-year-old mother in a ramshackle hovel on the rich man's land, where the old man tolerates them as, he says, a matter of common charity. (There is, however, the clear inference to be drawn from the location of Alija's house and its ownership that the old man himself is Alija's undeclared natural father). The two social outcasts are so poor, the old man says, that the youth often hasn't so much as a crust of bread properly to nourish his fallen and kinless old parent while he is away fighting. With no property and nothing to recommend him except his admittedly extraordinary ability and reputation as a warrior, he is no match for the peerless Zlata (whose name means 'Gold', for indeed she is her wealthy father's only child and will bring both power and great property as dowry to her eventual husband).

The girl nevertheless chooses Alija for her bridegroom, since she is already breathtakingly wealthy and wants to gain the service of a strong fighter, not merely more wealth, through her marriage. She particularly values Alija's fighting ability because, as her father's only

child, she has an ancient vendetta-obligation to discharge. When she was a little girl four years old, she had twin brothers twice her age. One fine summer day their mother went for pleasure into the mountains to visit her flocks of sheep and to fetch home fresh cream and cheese. While she was away, the two boys also decided to go to their mother in the mountains, and set forth together in that direction unattended. But they lost their way and wandered instead into the hands of a vicious Christian frontiersman named Ivan Višnjić, who murdered the two innocents for their elegant clothes. Since that time, Višnjić has erected and become commandant of a great blockhouse and frontier guard-post on the border between the muslim and Christian countries. The blockhouse, which is built of pine-wood timbers, stands beside a dangerous river atop three hundred and sixty-six high pilings, three hundred of which are steel and sixty-six of pine-tree boles. It houses a garrison of three hundred Christian troops who habitually dine together at a single long table in the blockhouse's great assembly hall. At night, when the garrison are at table together, the blockhouse is protected against surprise attacks by the raising of its great drawbridge, which is its only avenue of communication with the ground beneath. As a precondition to her marriage, Zlata requires that her betrothed cross the flooding river, which has neither any bridge nor fording-place, pluck Ivan Višnjić out of the blockhouse from amongst its garrison, and bring him either dead or alive to her father in vengeance for Višnjić's murder of Zlata's two brothers.

Alija Vlahinjić accepts his fiancée's commission and performs it, killing all three hundred of the Christian garrison single-handedly, burning the blood-soaked blockhouse to the ground, and returning to Klis with Višnjić as his helpless captive. He arrives in the early hours of the morning when no one is yet awake except his watchful fiancée and the sleepless old rival suitor, who still hopes that Alija will perish in the fight with Višnjić and Zlata thus become his eighth wife. With Višnjić tightly bound and tied to Alija's horse, Zlata takes Alija into her garden, where he feels the fatigue of his successful mission and falls asleep. Then the old man, who has been watching

the scene from an upstairs window, creeps into the garden, cuts Višnjić free of his bonds, helps him silently subdue Zlata, mounts her with Višnjić on Alija's horse, and sees Višnjić off at the gallop toward the frontier and the enemy city of Aršam beyond. Alija sleeps through the entire incident, and no one sees Višnjić's getaway with the captive Zlata except her mother, who from her upstairs window happens to notice them disappearing into the distance when she awakes and looks out on the new morn.

She noisily awakens Alija, who, now all unhorsed and tired as he still is from his previous exploit, nonetheless immediately sets out to trudge on foot along the spoor of his escaped enemy and his captive fiancée. Without his horse to help him, he must now swim the dangerous river by himself. He reaches the far bank in an agony of fatigue, then passes the still smouldering site of the former blockhouse and moves on into enemy territory until finally his strength fails completely and he collapses on the way like a dead man (v. 3453). In the distance the cannon of Aršam boom in celebration of Višnjić's advent with the coveted Zlata and Alija's wondrous horse.

Eventually an itinerant carpenter approaches him from the direction of Aršam, and Alija asks this artisan the cause of the celebration there. The carpenter replies that he has just finished building a special apartment for the king of Aršam's nubile daughter, who has just occupied it. Furthermore, the king's new two-week-old son has just had his hair cut for the first time. These glad events have coincided with Višnjić's remarkable acquisitions to make the mood of Aršam very merry indeed.

Goaded beyond endurance by this news, Alija kills the carpenter, takes his workman's clothes and tools for a disguise, and proceeds to Aršam. There, assuming a further disguise as a pretty young woman, and with help of an unexpected ally whom he appropriates to his cause, he insinuates himself into a conclave of the princess's age-mates, who have gathered to celebrate her establishment in her new court. Supposing Alija to be one of themselves, they include

“her” in their festivities, then leave her alone with the princess to act as maid-in-waiting for the night. Alija makes love with the princess and promises to marry her. She in turn discloses Alija’s advent to the captive Zlata, and the three of them — Alija, Zlata, and the princess — escape together from Aršam. When they arrive at the frontier, the whole society of muslim warriors meets them in an otherwise empty meadow, where Alija abruptly beheads his old rival, the one who helped Višnjić steal Zlata. Alija then has a double wedding, first with the princess of Aršam, and afterwards with Zlata. With his two wives he dwells thereafter permanently in Klis as heir-apparent to Zlata’s father.

Another half-dozen prime features of the Väinämöinen narratives appear in this portion of the Serbo-Croatian epic. First we have the illegitimate son who, as in Väinämöinen’s Judgment, survives his lack of legitimate paternity to become a rightful king amongst his cognatic rather than agnatic kin, since he has no agnates. Instead of his perishing miserably alone in a desert place as his concealed father would wish (in the fight with Višnjić), it is the undeclared father who is destroyed in that manner, and who thus passes out of the world leaving no heir behind him.

As Väinämöinen did in the Singing Contest, so also Alija Vlahinjić in this epic proves himself fit to marry by mastering water (the raging river), wood (which he heroically overcomes and eventually destroys with fire in the form of an elevated pine-wood fortress), and multitudinous wildlife (the garrison of wild-wood denizens kept in the great blockhouse by Višnjić, all of whom Alija slaughters as in an abattoir. It is useful in this connection to appreciate that the Yugoslav bard who sang this epic was a professional butcher, as this part of his song plainly reflects). Finally, Alija correctly selects his bride from amongst the stellar collection of nubile women which he finds gathered in the court of the princess of Aršam on the evening of the night when he physically takes possession of her.

For Alija, both terrestrial and aquatic mobility are assured by his marvelous horse, which swims as perfectly as it runs — and its running is like

the flight of something winged. But like Väinämöinen he too suffers an immobilizing accident, losing his horse to Višnjić while he sleeps in Zlata's garden. Out of this terrible mishap he however scavenges an unexpected advantage, finding in Zlata's foreign warden, the princess of Aršam, a second perfect bride for himself. But before wedding her he must overcome his accidental immobility, and to accomplish this he puts his own physical person at risk repeatedly both at the deadly river and in the foreign land of his racial enemies. To reach that land he must, like Väinämöinen travelling to Tuonela, cross the forbidding river. But once he has crossed it, an ambiguity develops as to whether the crossing will result in his death or in his mating; in the event indeed both these things happen, but not before Alija, again like Väinämöinen, has taken on the character and the apparatus of a consummate artisan in joinery.

Nominally, the motifs of the Väinämöinen runes and of the Serbo-Croatian epic are of course distinctively different, each answering to familiar, inherited cultural requisites of the Finnic peoples on the one hand and of the southern Slavs on the other. But one need penetrate this surface of superficial dissimilarity only a little to discover the sameness of an underlying physiology in the two traditions, a sameness that quite belies the importance of the differences between the languages of the two peoples and the consequent differences in the prosodies of their respective oral poetic traditions. For even more than music ever was, oral narrative tradition is also a kind of universal "language" of great communicative power to those who will learn to read it in the way that it ultimately must be read, a way that reaches well beyond the mere natural languages in which it is everywhere expressed.

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Péter Domokos

Epics of the Eastern Uralic Peoples

Epics hold a distinguished place among literary genres in the majority of smaller peoples (Veenker 1968). Almost without exception, they are more than just one of the literary genres and even more than literature itself. Compared to other manifestations of literature, they carry an ideological, a political, and an artistic “surplus”, but what is really important in them is their “nationalistic” message. Peoples who lack this genre are certainly poorer spiritually than those who do not. By now, a better knowledge of the history and fate of these peoples enables us to see the question of epics from a different angle, separate from the question of other genres. The relation of these epics to “Weltliteratur” (and to its different periods of styles and ideas) again has to be approached from a different starting point from that of the other historical genres of literature. We have, for instance, to think of and re-evaluate the frequently-used and widely-accepted term “belatedness” in connection with the literatures of Eastern Europe.

Belated literatures

The history of these peoples — among them all the Uralic peoples — can be characterized as “belated” with returning periods of great efforts making up for lost time or, to use a term used mainly by Soviet scholars, as a case of “accelerated development”. This deliberate acceleration is especially characteristic of the culture and literature of the 20th century. Therefore it is of extreme interest that, for instance, from the point of view of literary theory, there is in the process of acceleration a distinct

and powerful demand for developing — *a posteriori* stages long antiquated in high literatures but missing here. Although it may sound paradoxical, this trend is anything but retrograde or reactionary. The importance of the intention, instinctive or deliberate, to create epics as cultural conveyors comprising encyclopaedically and poetically all the “indigenous” traditions of a people lies in the fact that in the last moment before being melted in the huge pot of international literature such endeavours promise monuments to these small communities (of their history, language and traditions).

Epics have been given thorough study in literature from a general and from certain particular points of view. Of the epics of Uralic peoples, Finnish and Estonian folklore (two of the “greater” Uralic peoples), and especially the Kalevala, won worldwide fame. In Hungary, scholars as well as the public miss, even now, the so-called “naive epic”, and the bitterness over its loss as expressed in János Arany’s classical study is still felt, the more so since the baroque epic of Miklós Zrínyi, just as the romantic epic of Mihály Vörösmarty and the national-historical epic of János Arany, could not provide a substitute for a “true”, a really “national” epic. In the case of the Kalevala and the Kalevipoeg, these two brother-epics proved to be powerful means of national education in Finland and Estonia. A good indicator of their importance is the large number of studies about them, amounting to the size of a library, and also the fact that the debate concerning their origin and nature is livelier now than ever before.

It is an undeniable fact that they became envied and imitated patterns and ideals for several smaller national literatures, among them, of course, those of some Uralic peoples.

Difficulties in the study of Uralic epics

The problem of the epics of smaller Uralic peoples is discussed mainly in essays and studies written in Russian. It is no simple task, even for a student of folklore, to come to terms with the Russian terminology,

which suffers not only from *embarrass de richesse* but is also full of ambiguities. Without going into detail, let me mention only one thing. Some scholars use the term *epos* as a common term for epic genres in general (let us take it as one of the extreme poles of interpretation or classification), while others use the term *poema*, covering Mayakovski's lyrical poem only a few pages long about Lenin and the Mordvinian poet, Radayev's, epic of ten thousand lines with equal ease. I might also mention a number of transitory forms between the *poema* and the *epos* that could well fill a smaller volume whose items could, in turn, "raise hell" among experts in the field, for instance, among folklorists and literary critics. The cause of this trouble is that it is almost impossible to find adequate translations for these terms in any other language (cf. the difference between *skaz* and *skazanie*).

A further problem is that no student of the field has tried to collect, classify and interpret the terminology of genres in each of the smaller Uralic languages. In this connection only one circumstance can safely be stated: namely, that among the terms of folkloristic genres there is a clear dominance of "indigenous" words, whereas for the classification of literary genres words of Graeco-Latin origin are used internationally.

As a consequence of the unorganized and belated collection work by the majority of the smaller Uralic peoples, certain genres disappeared irretrievably (e. g. genuine Votyak and Cheremis epic songs, authentic Zyrian sagas). Some collectors wrongly declared that these unrecoverable genres never existed in the folklore of the peoples in question. In order to show the difficulties the student has to face, I would mention only that in spite of long correspondence with experts and prolonged inquiry, I still know nothing about the circumstances and ways of performance of the still existing, vivid and abundant historical song-cycles of the Mordvinians (whether they are sung solo or in chorus, whether they are accompanied by instrumental music or not, whether their tunes are old or new or whether they are just recited without any melody). As a matter of fact, I am convinced that they are sung like the epic songs of the Finns, Ob-Ugrians and the Samoyeds, although

there is hardly any supporting data for this in the vast material published so far.

In the case of the majority of the Uralic peoples, the conditions were ripe for realizing the ideal epic as was done by Lönnrot, i. e. a rich folklore, a *poeta doctus* versatile in the material and a favourable spiritual and political atmosphere for the awakening of a national feeling of identity among the public were all at hand. On the other hand, there were also differences over the quantity, the quality and the arrangement of the “raw material” of these epics-to-be. In the course of time the conditions for creating such epics also took a change for the worse, as was the case with such talented possible epic-makers as the Votyak Gerd, the Cheremis Čavayn and Olik Ipay, all of whom were first stigmatized as nationalists and then disappeared in the purges of the thirties or for the better, as was the case with the Mordvinian Radayev (1960; 1972; 1973; 1980) who — due to the favourable political climate after the 20th Congress of the CPSU — was able to carry out his grandiose plan.

The possibilities of an epic among the Volga-Finnic peoples

Among the larger Uralic peoples the Mordvinians are undoubtedly those whose epic folklore is the richest and the most colourful (also in its mythological and historical bearings) and almost offers itself as raw material for an epic (Paasonen I-VIII; *Ustno-poètičeskoe tvorčestvo mordovskogo naroda*, 1–14). The Mordvinians knew and even now they know how to make use of their envious heritage. The most interesting and most controversial Mordvin epic is *Sijažar* by V. K. Radayev (1960; 1973). It is used for teaching purposes in schools and thus enjoys something of the status of a national epic. It tells about the battles fought by the Mordvins under their leader, *Sijažar*, against the Tatars in the 16th century. Official acceptance of the epic has been

helped by the fact that the Mordvins were fighting on the side of the Russians. Mordvin folklorists have, however, tended to reject the epic because there is no lore about Sijažar in any of the known collections. The author reports hearing the stories from old people in his native region. It may be assumed that the Sijažar tradition has been so local that it has not passed into the hands of collectors. The style of the epic has many features typical of the indigenous epic poetry of the Mordvins (Domokos 1980; 1983: 135–152).

We know much less about the similar heritage of the Cheremis and actually nothing about their epic songs; the available sagas in prose also seem to be fragmentary (Akcorin 1972). The most prominent heroes of these sagas are Onar, Čotkar, Čumbulat, Aqpars, Aqpater, but nowadays no one would venture to “sing of their brave deeds”. The well-trained and energetic poets and scholars of the twenties and thirties, full of nationalistic enthusiasm, were ready to carry out this plan and, moreover, they actually produced an epic entitled *The Song about Knight Čotkar*. But the collective work of S. Čavayn, O. Ipay and O. Šabdar remained in manuscript which, in turn, disappeared without trace between 1936 and 1938, when the authors were also liquidated as bourgeois nationalists (Vasin 1954: 20).

The epic among the Permian peoples

The idea of making an epic for the Votyaks was a permanent but unanswered challenge in the short life of Kuzebay Gerd, the greatest figure in the cultural and literary history of the Votyaks (Domokos 1971–1972). The story of the Votyak epic is all the more interesting since there is an authentic Votyak epic — written in the early twenties in Russian by the Russian M. Hudyakov, an archaeologist and ethnographer of the Volga Finns. His work, in which 90% of the lines are undoubtedly of Votyak folkloristic origin and which reveals an amazing-

ly high literary standard, is still unpublished (Pozdyeyev 1981; Jašin 1983).

The Zyrian folklorists of today spare no effort in denying the existence of traces of an earlier common Permian culture in Zyrian folklore and they excel in proving “the possibly early traces of genuine Zyrian folklore”, as was proved by the preceding generation of scholars to be false and misleading. They are trying to prove the “international nature” of folk epics of the Zyrians instead. It is not long since a great many epic songs were discovered among the Northern Zyrians, who borrowed not only their material culture and life style from the Nenets (they are reindeer-breeders) but probably also their folklore, especially the said epic songs (Vászolyi 1967; 1968). This peculiar group of folklore texts was treated thoroughly and several times by an excellent Zyrian folklorist, A. K. Mikušev (1969; 1972; 1977; 1981). For this reason, and also because these pieces of Zyrian folklore are local by nature, of an alien origin, did not become part of Zyrian culture and could not attract the attention of Zyrian poets and writers, I will not deal with them here.

Nevertheless, we know of an attempt to create an epic among the Zyrians, too. K. Žakov created an epic of 7.000 lines entitled *Byarmia* in 1916, using the then available folklore material and historical data. He was not, however, able to publish his work, although he did manage to send Gorki a copy of his manuscript (and it is still in Gorki’s archive), and another copy can be found in the Library of the Komi Republic. Gorki is said to have read the manuscript with great interest, but his opinion remained a secret. The Zyrian philologists are prejudiced with respect to Žakov’s oeuvre and especially with respect to his epic, since they avoid the subject of Perm — *Byarmia* like the plague. Consequently, not a single line has so far been published of this important and interesting epic, which, like the rest of the author’s oeuvre, has been labelled “reactionary”, “idealistic”, etc. This epic was also written in Russian, thereby increasing the number of Russian-language Uralic epics waiting to be published. All this I learned “incidentally” during an official visit to Syktyvkar in the summer of 1983.

Whereas subsequent attempts to wipe out any traces of an indigenous Zyrian tradition of history and mythology were successful, the Permyaks, the close relatives of the former group, who became Orthodox Christians at a much later period, preserved much of their once common folklore tradition. Both the more archaic Kudim-Oš (i. e. bear-ancestor) and the more recent Knight Pera have the format of an epic (Möššeg 1926; Ožegova 1971). A prominent figure in Zyrian culture and literature (and in Soviet Finno-Ugristics), V. Lytkin (known also under his pen-name Ilya Vas) was well aware of the importance of these epics. Had he not been castigated for being a “bourgeois nationalist” and, as a consequence, had he not lost almost two decades of his active life, he could have made a grandiose epic of the deeds of these two heroes. Instead he wrote only a shorter, but significant work about Knight Pera for the young (1967), in which the hero is shown as a faithful ally of the Russians. Several members of his perished generation could have qualified for this noble task. Surviving friends and contemporaries are said to have known of sketches and plans, even completed parts of works describing the heroic age of the Zyrians in the since ravaged and perished archives of this unfortunate generation. The Zyrian and Permyan poets and writers of today do not seem to be prepared to repair this damage: perhaps they think both the subject and the genre outdated and also politically improper (*Istorija Komi literatury* 1–2). In the discovery and evaluation of the saga tradition it was an Englishman, an eminent expert on Zyrian language and literature, J. Coates, who did an excellent job (Coates 1966).

Ob-Ugric and Samoyed epic materials

Every one of the smaller Uralic peoples has an enviably rich epic tradition. Some of the thousand and three-thousand line songs (I mention only known and recorded texts) and an ensemble of them even

more, could in themselves qualify as epics. All they need is for an initiated poet to make some corrections in structure and style by adding or eliminating parts or by giving them a new interpretation (Vértes 1978). And in the hands of a personality of Lönnrot's stature, with his patience and training, epics no less valuable than the Kalevala could be born in Vogulic, Ostyak, Nenets and Selkup. In the life of these small peoples the birth of an intelligentsia came too late, however, and even then they remained too few to exercise any influence on their peoples. The dialectical diversity and the geographical dispersion of these peoples were also almost insurmountable obstacles for the learned to achieve something like an epic of their own and, last but not least, there was little or no demand from the public for such works.

The first writers and poets of these peoples learned very late the real values of their own peoples' folklore, and even then indirectly, through the mediation of Russian literature. It is no wonder that none of them undertook the demanding task of epic-making, especially since they could hardly expect any promising answers to the natural questions: for whom, for how many persons will such a work be published in their native language? Nevertheless, the Ostyak poet V. Voldyin wrote a small epic in his native tongue about an Ostyak rebel, Tak Molupsi, whose name is unknown in recorded history. Since no publisher showed any interest, this work has likewise remained unpublished and, therefore, unknown in the homeland of this tragically deceased poet.

The famous Vogul poet Yuvan Šestarov certainly had and still has the ability to create a grandiosely poetic epic, since he is the man with the knowledge, the training and the necessary maturity for such an undertaking. His ever decreasing Vogul-language poetry does, however, indicate that even he does not believe in the future of a literature in Vogulic any more, knowing that few would read and even fewer would understand his writings.

And yet a Vogul epic exists, and not only one, but two. Plotnikov's *The Fringe of the Earth* published in 1933 and Kličkov's *The Victorious Madur Vaza*, which is a "free adaptation" of the former, published in the same year and, in addition, in the same volume as Plotnikov's work,

make a strange Cain-and-Abel-like twin-epic. And to make things stranger both of them were written in Russian. Gorki is said to have held a favourable opinion of Plotnikov's work and on this ground he held Vogul folklore in high esteem. In a recent series presenting the epics of Soviet peoples part of Plotnikov's work was published as a Vogul epic (*Skazanija stoletij* 1981).

This case is, however, more problematic than that of Hudyakov's Votyak epic, which remained unpublished. Plotnikov, who spent the first few years of the First World War among the Voguls (and fell in love with their poetry and their way of life and human kindness, as did many others, among them his most severe critic, Černecov), heard and recorded many songs and sagas and also made a thorough study of fields of Finno-Ugristics connected with his subject. As a result of Plotnikov's laborious work, a new epic was born that could not find favour with the publisher, who regarded it as slightly nationalistic in spirit; and since the author had otherwise "disappeared" from the publisher's sight for years, the task of rewriting the epic in a spirit both ideologically and artistically more adequate to the requirements of the era went to Kličkov. Meanwhile Plotnikov "reappeared", so both works, the original "Vogulophil" one and the rewritten version with a pro-Russian tint were published in the same volume.

The publisher's procedure was criticized by many, and experts on Vogul language and folklore also expressed their opinion. Černecov's main objection was that Plotnikov went too far in the manipulation of Vogul folklore, especially when he added Ostyak and Samoyedic motifs to the original material. Therefore — he argued — the authenticity of the epic is doubtful, to say the least. (Let me mention in this connection that the Kalevipoeg of the Estonians also contains Finnish texts!) Supposedly only a few copies could reach the Vogul literati (who could not have been too numerous then), since even now it is hardly known among experts of Vogul language and folklore. Despite its shortcomings the work is highly interesting. The main proof of this is Gorki's high opinion of it which, given his sensitivity and good taste, cannot be accidental.

The position of Nenets literature is clearly much better and more promising than that of either the Voguls or the Ostyaks: they have more poets and writers and also a more numerous group of literati. In spite of these relatively favourable conditions, there are no signs of an emerging epic, so the lengthy *sudbabc*-es (legends about giants) and *jarabc*-es (laments) of several thousand lines are still awaiting their Lönnrot (Kupriyanova 1960; 1965; 1969).

According to K. Donner (1913–1918) and P. Hajdú (1975) the gentle touch of an expert, perhaps a poet, could awaken the Selkup epic from its apparent death, the more so since it is, even in its folkloristic frames, almost “ready”. Unfortunately, among the Selkup “literati” there has so far been no one to discover the “miracle” in the story of Itye and Punegoosee, the two heroes of Selkup folklore.

How Karelian is the Kalevala?

It is a difficult and also an unrewarding task to speak of Karelian folklore and literature in the presence of Finnish experts, because the Soviet-Karelians have a specific position regarding the Kalevala (Karhu 1974). Due to the fact that Lönnrot collected most of the epic’s “raw material” in Karelia, Soviet scholarship and accordingly also the most recent Soviet publications and anthologies today regard the Kalevala as a Karelian-Finnish epic, i. e. one of the achievements of the Soviet peoples (Skazanija stoletij 1981). This interpretation is, however, a simplification, to say the least. Without getting entangled in debate that is not entirely scholarly but also politically influenced and, therefore, not exactly tasteful, let me just mention that 1) raw material is not the same as the work composed from it, 2) the Kalevala — *volens volens* — became the foundation of Finnish linguistic and literary culture inside and outside the present boundaries of Finland, 3) the language of Karelian literature is not based on any Karelian dialect, but on Standard Finnish, which was formed not in Karelia and long before 1917, 4) the

Kalevala, it is true, also belongs to the Karelian people and literature, but, as a matter of fact, only in part, and a smaller part at that, 5) the Soviet-Karelian interpretation of the Kalevala is only one (and certainly not the best) of the possible interpretations.

The Karelian poets and writers are aware of the outdatedness and the inconveniences of their “heritage”, so they want to make this heritage fit their recent ideals and political affiliations. The task of composing an epic restricted exclusively to the recent history of Karelia in the spirit of the present day *genius loci* was undertaken by one of the most experienced and most famous Karelian poets, Rugoyev. Although his Karelian Story (1975) of some three hundred pages does in several parts recall the Kalevala, it remains nothing but an over-politicized and over-actualized piece of work. As to its genre, it is more of a novel in verse or a longer epic poem than an epic.

A Saami epic?

The Lapps or Saami, a smaller Uralic people with a specific position, are also not without interest with regard to the problem of epics. While the folklore of the Lapps is no less rich than that of any of the other peoples mentioned, few traces of an epic tradition in verse have been found among them. They have, on the other hand, a rich tradition of semi-historical and mythological tradition in prose. The geographical and dialectical dispersion of the Lapps was, and still is, as much of a hindrance to the development of a unified culture and literature as it was in the case of the Ostyaks and the Nenets, populations of approximately the same size. Since their acculturation started much earlier than that of any other nation mentioned and has been going on for centuries, they have a considerable group of literati, and signs of a “national” and “linguistic” awakening already appeared before the First World War. It is no accident that among these signs are epics and epical attempts — together with several “external” questions concerning their authenticity.

O. Donner recorded four lengthy epic songs of 600 lines from an old head of the county constabulary in Lapland, A. Fjellner, which were published in 1876 and caused a sensation, but experts soon raised serious questions concerning their authenticity. Contemporary lappologues classify these songs as pseudo-folkloristic pieces of art born of the influence of the Kalevala which, therefore, and also because of their artificial language, do not deserve a place in anthologies of Lapp literature, not even a mention in essays on Lapp literature. In my opinion this approach is an exaggeration, since these songs, although not wholly folkloristic pieces, are still made of mosaics of Lappish folklore and mythology and, in addition, from several dialects, just like other naive epics of the world. In sum, they ought to have a place (and a prominent one) in the history of Lapp literature, where they should have played and even now could play the role of a unifying cultural event, as did Lönnrot's model-giving work.

The chances of small Baltic-Finnic groups

None of the minuscule Balto-Finnic peoples (Ingrians, Veps, Votes and Livonians) have reached the level of self-consciousness and literary activity that may be a precondition for the birth of an epic. Judging from the known and collected folklore material, it seems that — apart from the Ingrians — their tradition is neither rich enough, nor is it of a proper nature to offer itself for such an attempt. And no daring poet or writer has so far shown up who could make an epic even of a somewhat lower standard either. The Ingrians, who are an exception here, produced, like the Karelians, folkloristic “raw material” for Lönnrot's Kalevala. By the same virtue, the Kalevala could have been regarded as an Ingrian epic, had we taken an approach similar to that of Soviet-Karelian folklorists. Nowadays, when digging up sources and “prototexts” has become a fad, Ingrian epic songs are gaining new

importance, and with the help of a *poeta doctus* (like the Karelian Rugoyev) the possibility of compiling a modern Ingrian Kalevala-version cannot be excluded in the near future. With the knowledge and collection of an Ariste and with the help of a native poet, perhaps a Votian epic could also be called forth from the collections and, similarly, in the case of Livonian folklore. The preconditions for having a folklorist and a poet as possible compilers of an epic are present in the persons of O. Loorits and K. Stalte. A few decades ago a Veps epic would not have been merely a missed chance either (Voigt 1968).

Dreams and reality

By now, all this is but daydreaming. These minuscule peoples have already “run out of time”, and having lost the chance to develop literacy and literature in time, they are also losing momentum in creating an epic for good.

Among the Uralic peoples, only the Mordvinians, the Cheremis, the Zyrians and the Votyaks have — in my opinion — the vital force for creating modern epics of national spirit. It seems to me that there is a real demand for them from the public and there are groups of talented poets awaiting their chance, not to speak of critics eager to sharpen their tongues on these would-be works of art.

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Rudolf Schenda

Frédéric Mistral's Poem Mireille and Provençal Identity

150 years ago, Elias Lönnrot quite deliberately utilized the traditional epic songs of the Karelian people with the aim of demonstrating the autonomy of the Finnish language and the antiquity and respectability of Finnish history. He established the identity of Finnishness and of the Finns by means of linguistic monuments surviving in the oral tradition as “something constant through changing configurations” (Bausinger 1977: 210) and as evidence of a specific national cultural inheritance. Lönnrot's first version of the Kalevala came out three years after Erik Gustaf Geijer's History of the Swedish People, and should unquestionably be understood in the context of the many contemporary collections of folk poetry (on Lönnrot's reading during his studies, cf. M. Haavio in Strömbäck 1971: 1–10), whether as a Finnish contribution to the vogue debate on ‘folk poetry’ (Burke 1978: 3–23), or as a response to the Swedish and Danish collections (Dal 1956).

Moreover, as is well known, the same year saw the publication of both the Kalevala and Jacob Grimm's German Mythology, a work which in its unique (and not very poetic) way aimed at establishing a common heathen-Germanic identity for the entire German nation and also made reference to the “mythology of the adjacent nations, in particular of the Slavs, Lithuanians, and Finns” (Grimm 1835: 9). The second edition of Grimm's Mythology, in 1844, includes warm praise for Lönnrot's work, while in 1845 Grimm lectured to the Academy of Sciences in Berlin “On the Finnish Epic”, placing Lönnrot's achievement in its European context and stating that Lönnrot had “every right to remain unforgotten among the coming generations”, and that

German antiquity could be illuminated “in every respect” by the Finnish epic (Grimm 1865: 75–113).

It is not my intention here, however, to offer a description of the European folk-poetry movement in that era, characterized as it was by the various national post-Napoleonic Restorations, yet also by the liberal and proto-democratic stirrings leading up to the Prussian Revolution of March 1848 or the July Monarchy of Louis Philippe (cf. Schenda 1984). Let us pass over the Revolutions of 1848, the introduction of the first democratic Parliament in Germany in 1849, and turn instead to the period of the next Restoration in France, that of the Second Empire of Napoleon III (cf. Agulhon 1973; Plessis 1973). Let us leave behind us the misty world of the mythology of Lönnrot and Grimm, and travel to sunny Provence, the intellectual milieu of the Provençal Renaissance, and in particular to the milieu of the poet Frédéric Mistral (1830–1914), who received the Nobel Prize for literature in 1904 for his Provençal poetry (Björkman 1980), evidence of the admiration he had aroused in the North as well. (On Mistral, cf. Peyre 1959; on the biography, Clébert 1983; on life in Provence, Rollet 1972; and Frédéric Mistral — *au jour le jour* 1967.) I would like to pose the question whether Mistral can be seen as a Romance Lönnrot, helping his country to achieve its own language, culture, and national identity. As we shall see, the paradigm of the ‘National Epic of Provence’ displays many structural similarities with that of the Kalevala, while also being subject to its own, specific historical conditions.

The Provençal renaissance and the Félibrige

During 1854, a group of young Provençal intellectuals from in and around Avignon met, virtually every Sunday, to discuss the Provençal language and poetry, and to read out their own poems to their friends. In his memoirs, Frédéric Mistral writes:

We were a group of young people from the region, very close to each other, who understood each other perfectly, and devoted all our energies to this sacred cause of the Provençal Renaissance (*pèr aquelo santo obro de reneissènço prouvençalo*) (Mistral 1981: 426).

Eventually, these young writers adopted Font-Ségugne, a country house near the village of Gadagne, owned by the Giéra family, as their favourite meeting place. Mistral mentions (Mistral 1981: 440) the following names as his colleagues: (Joseph) Roumanille; (Paul) Giéra (with the anagram Glaup); (Anselme) Mathieu; (Jean) Brunet; (Alphonse) Tavan; (Antoine-Blaise) Crousillat; and (Théodore) Aubanel. The driving force in this group was clearly supplied by two figures: a *lycée* teacher named Joseph Roumanille (1818–1891), and Frédéric Mistral, a law graduate twelve years his junior, son of a family of landowning farmers from Maillane (Moreau 1931). (On the relations between Roumanille and Mistral, see Mistral 1981: 230–234, and more especially the *Correspondance Mistral–Roumanille* 1981.) It was at Font-Ségugne, on Sunday 21 May 1854, that the seven (or by some accounts five) young men founded a society, the members of which called themselves *félibre*, a word with many meanings: freethinker, book producer, scribe (in the New Testament sense). The movement was known as the *Félibrige*. The task they set themselves was to demonstrate that Provençal was a distinct language in its own right, capable not only of rhyme but of high poetry. As an expression of their shared ideals and undertaking, the *Félibres* launched an Almanack or yearbook, the *Armana Prouvençau*, which continues to be published annually in Avignon. The *Armana Prouvençau* for 1860, for instance, gives a full report on the recognition won by the *Félibres* in 1859 both in Nîmes and in Paris (Anselme Mathieu, *Crounico Felibrengo*, 19–31).

Three points need to be made here. Firstly, the *Félibrige* was not the only society of poets operating in Provence at that time. In his correspondence with Roumanille, Mistral himself refers to three schools, that of Avignon, that of Aix, and that of Marseille. Naturally, he placed his own group first; their poetry was radiant and rich, unforced,

unartificial, full of courage and honour like the ancient Muses, schooled on Virgil and Dante. In the first stanza of *Mireille*, The poets of Aix, Mistral describes himself as “Umble escoulan dóu grand Ouméro”, the humble pupil of the great Homer. Lamartine echoes this: “le jeune poète villageois, destiné à devenir, comme Burns, le laboureur écossais, l’Homère de Provence” (Mistral 1978: 473). The poets of Aix, adds Mistral, with Crousillat, Gaut, and d’Astros, were on the right path, the flourishing way; but those of Marseille he saw as trivial and utterly tasteless; ladies attending their meetings were forced to blush and take their leave; the most one could say of these was that they had energy and a free style of speech (Correspondance Mistral—Roumanille 1981: 103).

Secondly, the *Félibrige* was far from being free from conflict: there were numerous differences of opinion, both internally and with their colleagues in Aix and Marseille. One of the major difficulties was to achieve agreement on a standardized orthography. Mistral refers to a “pamphlet war” and “poisonous articles”, and had difficulties in reaching agreement on the orthography even with Roumanille. (Mistral 1981: 238–242; Correspondance Mistral—Roumanille 1981: 52–55, 85–86, 97, 112–114, 122–124, 126–127, 129–130, 141–143, 161–162, etc.) Moreover, Mistral and Roumanille wrote their poetry on very different topics, Mistral preferring rustic poetry with realistic details, and Roumanille committing himself to a catholic-conservative, often devotional style of writing (Correspondance Mistral—Roumanille 1981: 102).

The third point to be made is that Provençal poetry had by no means died out since the time of the troubadours (Berry 1958). Provençal studies had been greatly stimulated by the major troubadour anthology compiled by François-Juste-Marie Raynouard in 1816–1826, and in 1846 a history of Provençal poetry had been brought out by Claude Charles Fauriel. Of contemporary literature in the *Langue d’oc*, the most notable case was the considerable success in Paris of the coiffeur and poet Jacques Boë, known as *Jasmin*, to whom revived attention has recently been paid by the historian Emanuel Le Roy Ladurie. There were two Provençal dictionaries available, that compiled by Raynouard

as part of his anthology (Raynouard 1836–1844), and that by Simon-Jude Honnorat, a copy of which was bought by Mistral in Avignon in 1853 (Correspondance Mistral–Roumanille 1981: 110, 112–113; see also Honnorat 1846–1848).

These factors all point to the conclusion that a linguistic and poetic tradition had continued to exist in Provence since the Middle Ages, even if it was weak, disunited linguistically, and of insignificant quantity in comparison with literature in French. Mistral, although he was fully aware of all this tradition (Caluwé 1974; Dumas 1979), nevertheless saw the Provençal language as being crushed by the overwhelming weight of the dominant French literature; Provençal was the language of the defeated (“la langue des vaincus”). The language problem is stated by Mistral right at the beginning of *Mireille*, in stanza 2: “nostro lengo mespresado”, our despised language. The poetry of the South was creeping at the feet of the proud Northern French literature (Correspondance Mistral–Roumanille 1981: 79 cf. 44, 65–66). Mistral therefore devoted himself in Maillane to working on two major projects intended to contribute to the reassessment of Provençal poetry and the language, i. e. a national epic, and a complete Provençal glossary. The epic, *Mireille*, was published in Avignon by Roumanille in 1859, the dictionary, *Lou tresor dóu Felibrige*, did not come out until 1881 and 1886. A centenary re-edition of the *Trésor* came out in Paris in 1931, and this has been re-issued in a reprint, Geneva–Paris 1979.

Mistral's aim, as he describes it in his memoirs in 1906, was to throw light on the energy, the openness, and richness of expression of the people, and to represent the language in the pure form spoken in areas where it was still free from outside influence. Mistral alludes to similar undertakings by the Romanian poet Basile Alecsandri (1821–90), who spent long periods of his life in Paris, and in 1874, in Montpellier, published his poetic eulogy on the Latin race. Alecsandri hoped to replace the corrupt speech of the upper classes in Romania with that of the mountain people. Mistral would have found a better model to follow in Lönnrot.

The epic, Mireille

Mireille is an epic in twelve cantos, of 60 to 90 stanzas each, each stanza consisting of the (not unsymbolic) number of seven lines (not counting interspersed songs). The poem was written between 1852 and 1858, i. e. a span of seven years. Before entering into a discussion of the Provençal features of the work, a brief résumé of the poem will be given.

Canto 1. Mireille, the daughter of a wealthy farmer called Ramon, is fifteen years old, and works on the farm ("mas") of her parents. An old basketmaker, Ambroise, comes to the farm with his sixteen-year-old son Vincent, and stays overnight. Ambroise sings an old heroic song about a sea-battle, (Le Bailli de Suffren); Vincent tells the girl stories about animals, about the pilgrimage to Saintes Maries, and the races in Nîmes. Mireille falls in love with Vincent.

Canto 2. During the mulberry-leaf picking for the silkworms, the young people meet for the second time. Vincent climbs the tree to join Mireille, and finds a nest with young bluetits; while he is taking the birds for Mireille, they both fall from the tree. Subsequently Mireille declares her love, and he too confesses that he is in love with her.

Canto 3. During the gathering of the silk cocoons, the girls of the village chatter about their dreams; one of them wishes she were Queen of Provence, whereupon Taven, a kind of witch, warns them against envy and the evil eye. One of the girls sings the "Magali" song, about the magical transformations of two lovers.

Canto 4. During April, three suitors ask for the hand of Mireille: a wealthy shepherd, who is taking his flocks into the Alps, and offers Mireille a carved bowl; a horseherd from the Camargue; and a brutal bulltamer. Mireille rejects all of them.

Canto 5. On his way home, the bulltamer meets Vincent, who has by now met Mireille many times. The rivals fight a bitter duel, in which Vincent defeats Ourrias, who returns, however, and wounds Vincent in the chest with his trident. Ourrias is drowned on his way home, in the River Rhône.

Canto 6. Vincent, badly hurt, is found by Ramon's farmhands, and brought back to the farm, where he claims to have fallen onto his own axe. In order to save his life, Mireille takes him to the Fairy Cavern of the witch Taven, a journey to the underworld during which they meet ghosts, goblins, the Weathermaker witch, lost souls, witches, various monsters, the Wild Hunter, seven black cats, two dragons, a white cock, etc. In the Fairy Cavern, Vincent lies down on a table made of porphyry, and Taven casts a Christian spell and pours a healing mixture over his wounds. Vincent is healed, and returns from the Cavern with Mireille.

Canto 7. Vincent begs his father, the basketmaker Ambroise, to ask Mireille's father Ramon for her hand for him. At harvest time, Ambroise goes to the farm, and explains his errand. Mireille, too, declares her love, but Ramon, standing on his parental authority, totally rejects the request. Ambroise defends his humble status, and tells how he fought for France under Napoleon, but is contemptuously insulted by Ramon.

Canto 8. Mireille is in despair; at night, she rises and flees her father's house in order to pray for help at the shrine of Saintes Maries. She crosses the Crau wilderness, and spends the night in the tent of a fisherman's family.

Canto 9. Mireille's parents are in despair. Ramon summons all his labourers, who tell him of three evil omens, and that Mireille has fled to Saintes Maries. Her mother has the horses harnessed, and the parents set off in pursuit.

Canto 10. Mireille is ferried across the Rhône and wanders across the Camargue. She suffers sunstroke in the heat, and having reached

the shrine of Saintes Maries, collapses in the church. The saints step down and comfort her.

Canto 11. The Saint Marys recount how they travelled from Jerusalem to Provence, and how Provence was converted by the Saints Trophime (Arles), Marthe (Tarascon), Martial (Limoges), Saturnin (Toulouse), Eutrope (Orange), Lazare (Marseille), and Maximien (Aix). Mireille is referred to as virgin and martyr.

Canto 12. Her father and mother arrive at the shrine, where the local people are bringing the sick to the saints' relics. Vincent also reaches the chapel, and kisses Mireille, who is still able to speak a few words to him. She receives another vision of the saints, before the Last Sacraments are administered and she dies. Vincent throws himself on her body, while a hymn sounds round the church.

It was necessary to provide this brief, and incomplete, summary of the plot of the epic, in order for the frame of the poem to be revealed. Mireille takes place in an environment which is rural, Christian, and strongly bound to tradition. Every technical innovation of the industrial age is filtered out, and the image is created in both secular and religious terms of a static and closed society (on the religious dimension, see Jenatton 1959). The epic contains a love story and social conflict between the established landowning farmer and the landless vagrant artisan. The drama can also be described in terms of a clash between a patriarchal male world and oppressed womanhood: Mireille is the innocent victim of these relations of domination; and it is in fact unclear why she needs to be sacrificed, except by reference to the literary tradition of Romeo and Juliet or Paul et Virginie (Bernardin de Saint-Pierre, 1788; cf. Jan 1959: 43–55). None of these aspects, however, touches on the uniqueness of the epic; for all of these oppositions could be retained equally well even if the location were transferred to Brittany.

In truth, however, Mireille is far more than a dramatic love epic. It is in its detail, which takes on greater significance than the overall structure, that it becomes a Provençal encyclopedia, a Provençal Bible, the universal Provençal text.

The Provençal identity: Mistral's unified Provençal

First and foremost, there is the language of the epic. Mistral sets out, quite deliberately, to cram the maximum possible number of distinctive Provençal words into his literary bundle. He takes as his basis for this his home dialect from Maillane, the language of his parents and their farm. Against the relative impoverishment of this dialect, however, he sets the brilliance of his lexical studies, and expands it with the poetic vocabulary of the troubadours, whom he had thoroughly studied (Caluwé 1974), as well as that of his fellow poets, especially the *Félibres*. It is claimed that in the region of Arles, contemporary audiences were able to understand every word of *Mireille*, i. e. that they knew the poem's vocabulary, if not actively then at least passively (C. Rostaing in his introduction to his edition of *Mireille*, Mistral 1978: 23). It would seem to me that this claim can only apply to the Provençal intelligentsia. The language Mistral uses in *Mireille* is a poetic language which never existed as spoken Provençal, a conglomeration of all the periods in the language's history and all its levels. He substitutes for the dry linguistic bread of everyday an opulent linguistic feast. In doing so, he premisses a cultural unity, a Provençal identity reaching from Avignon to Montpellier, which in the 19th century did not exist. He postulates a hierarchical bilingualism, with Provençal in first and French in second position, which for the South as a whole was impossible to realize. It cannot be established historically that all the groups of population speaking one of the many varieties of the *Langue d'oc* shared a united political will. The French superstructure maintained its power.

Contemporary voices of criticism were also raised against this artificial language. In 1856, for instance, the Abbé Moyne (himself a dialect poet) made great fun of the *Félibres* and their *Almanack*: Soon, he commented, one would need a *Félibre* dictionary in order to be able to make sense of them. Similarly, 1864, the new troubadours were described in the satirical magazine *Le Grelot* (The Jester's Bell) as mystifiers attempting to persuade Parisians that everyone from Valence

to the sea spoke Provençal. The new poetry, writes Le Grelot (no 31, 3.7.1864) is ‘an affectation of the learned and the artist, an ingenious hoax by clever and talented people’ (“un raffinement de lettrés et d’artistes, l’ingénieuse supercherie de gens d’esprit et de talent”). There is cause for thought in the statement quoted by André (1928: 40 f.) from the *Armana Prouvençau* for 1856, where Mistral claims that Provençal had once been the language of the whole of Europe (sic!), spoken by Emperors and Kings as well as the peoples, although the only examples occurring to him are Richard Coeurdelion, Frederick II, Dante, and Petrarch. The “divine language”, claims Mistral, had led Europe out of barbarism. Mistral’s diction, therefore, is an artificial language, the bearer — over and above its unquestionable poetic force — of the ideological value of a postulated Provençal unity.

Provençal identity: Mistral’s folk museum

Even more than by means of language, in Mireille Mistral sets out to create a total picture of Provence through a wealth of factual information, relating not only to contemporary Provence, but also to Provençal history. Thus he describes the major landscapes of the South: the Camargue, the Crau, the Alpilles, the Lubéron, Mont Ventoux, the Alps up as far as Gap (Hautes-Alpes), and, naturally, the Rivers Rhône and Durance and the Mediterranean, as well as the cities and towns of Arles, Nîmes, Avignon, Aix, and Marseille. He describes Roman Provence and the conversion of the country to Christianity; and enthuses over the independent Kingdom of Provence (Mistral 1978: 128), how the Provençal navy had even defeated the English at sea (Colotte 1955: 57 f.) and, repeatedly, over the old and the new troubadours (see Canto III:130–132 and VI:224–226). Mistral describes the range of occupations: the shepherds and other herdsmen, the fishermen and boatmen, the ploughmen and harvest-workers, the sheavers and gather-

ers; the harvesting of silk cocoons, of hay and corn, the work of the basketmaker and the snailgatherer. In his memoirs, Mistral provides a description of his father's farm, which included a pair of draft animals, a "premier charretier" (first cart driver), several ploughmen, a herdsman, a housemaid, and several day-labourers at harvest time. Mistral describes his parents as "meinagié", "une classe à part: sorte d'aristocratie qui fait la transition entre paysans et bourgeois" (Mistral 1981: 6–9, 54). There is no space here to go into detail for all of these things, but I would like to discuss the folklore aspects more fully.

In his Memoirs, Mistral from time to time mentions the informants who had passed on to him the oral Provençal traditions. His father, who had only read three books — the New Testament, the Imitation of Christ of Thomas à Kempis, and Don Quixote (Mistral 1981: 58) — is mentioned only as reading the Gospels in the evening; but his mother, who could hardly read, was a good storyteller and singer of narrative songs as well of course as of nursery rhymes of every kind. In addition, Mistral writes of an old woman called Renaude, who used to come to spinners' gatherings in a sheepstall and tell old stories: that of the dragon slayer (*La Bête à sept têtes*), that of how Jean Cherche-la-Peur learnt to fear, that of the devil's horse with thirteen riders, of the magic cats (*Cat Sourcié*, *Matagot*), and the Fantastic Spirit (Mistral 1981: 88–102).

Later, Mistral had a ploughman at Maillane called Jean Roussière, who knew many cheerful songs, and also taught Mistral the tune of the Song of the Transformations (Mistral 1981: 576, 594–598). The text of the "metamorphoses de l'amour" was found by Mistral in a folksong which begins as follows: "Margarido ma mio / Margarido mis amour"; the name Magali (Margarete) he heard used by a shepherdess near Saint-Remi (Mistral 1981: 598–600; evidence that Magali was sung in the salons of Paris is provided by Paul Meyer for 1863, see Boutière 1978: 51, 274). In addition to these, and all his other immediate sources (Mistral 1981: 192), there came his reading of all the Provençal writers who had up to that time published "ethnic" Provençal material (Cerquand 1883). In *Mireille*, Mistral set out to incorporate all of this information in one way or another. Canto 6, for instance, with its

obligatory journey to the realm of the dead, is an overblown compendium of Provençal superstition, which sits uneasily in relation to the rest of the poem (Downer 1901: 115–116), and has still not been adequately assessed and explained (Maass 1896: 6–43).

A further example is provided by Canto 8, (La Crau), in which Mireille flees her parents' house and sets out for Saintes-Maries-de-la-Mer. Mistral includes a range of folklore facts in his description of the girl's night-time flight: household implements, etc., in the girl's wardrobe (her maiden's chaplet, sprigs of lavender, weather-candles); the folk costume of the Arlésiennes, which she puts on for her pilgrimage (she even puts on the diadem, but forgets the headdress); the chapbook of Magelone the Fair and her quest for her beloved, Peter of Provence; the shepherds who bring the lambs to the ewe in the morning, and milk the ewes; the saga of the giants of the Crau, who wanted to overthrow God but were crushed by Him with the *mistral*, lightning, and hurricane; the legend of St. Gent, who harnessed a wolf to his plough; a children's song about catching snails ("Cacalaus, cacalaus mourgueto..."); and the tale of the Trou de la Cape ("I'avié 'no fes uno grando iero", 'Once there was a great threshing-floor'), a crater which came about when a farmer mishandled his horses during the threshing, making them work on Sundays, until a whirlwind buried the entire threshing-floor in a great hole in the ground, which is nowadays full of water, from the bottom of which there can be heard bells, wailing and stamping. Finally, in the fisherman's tent, a *bouillabaisse* is cooked — a reference not only to a popular fish dish, but also to a magazine which Roumanille and Mistral had alerted to the new wave of Provençal poetry. (Lou Bouil-abaisso, *Journau populari en vers prouvençaous* was published from 1841–1846 in Marseille.) It is not possible to provide here a full ethnological commentary on every Canto of Mireille. The topic of Christian belief and superstition in Mireille, in particular, would require a full-length study (Cantos VI and IX–XII). It does seem pertinent, however, to make some comments on the political identity of Provence in the poem.

Provençal identity: Mistral's (un)political thinking

Notwithstanding the encyclopedic detail, Mistral excludes certain factors of the Provençal reality, in particular the political structure of the *départements* concerned — Vaucluse, Bouches-du-Rhône, and Gard — under the control of the central administration in Paris; the power of the Church, and especially the conservative, centralizing policies of the Avignon clergy; and the progress of communications, trade, and industry in the Rhône valley. Here and there in *Mireille* Mistral touches on social questions, which he solves by appealing to conservative morality: social injustice and inequality, Ambroise explains to his son Vincent, are the will of God, and are as natural as the unequal length of the fingers on one's hand (*Mireille* 1978: 268). Similarly, *Mireille*'s parents condemn the boy of lower status as 'the last of the scoundrels' ("lou darrié di piafo"), a gipsy ("un abóumiani"), and thief ("lou laire") (*Mireille* 1978: 332). In principle, however, Mistral displays no interest in political or social questions. His early republican leanings were abandoned after the Revolutions of 1848. It was never his intention to describe Provençal reality in the sense that this is found in the autobiography of Agricol Perdiguier (Perdiguier 1980) or in some, though not all, of the early photographs (Clébert 1980; Banaudo 1979). Consequently, Pierre Rollet finds Mistral useless as a historical source for the description of everyday life in Provence (Rollet 1972).

The only feature which Mistral refers to repeatedly is the relationship between Provence and the central French state. The girls in *Mireille* dream of the old Kingdom of Provence, with Les Baux as its capital ("Di Baus fariéu ma capitalo", *Mistral* 1978: 126); from the castle tower, one would be able to see the entire extent of the serene Provençal landscape (once again the unity motif) (*Mistral* 1978: 128) as far as Ventoux in the North, the Château d'If in the seas, and the River Rhône in the West. One of the other girls dreams for her part of the splendour of the old troubadours, with their Courts and Tribunals of Love (*Mistral* 1978: 130–132).

Nonetheless, Mistral was no separatist. He never supported the idea of a Provence independent of France along the lines of the demand for a distinct state independent of Madrid put forward by the Catalan movement. For Mistral, France is the Northern sister, a hard-working conqueror (Correspondance Mistral—Roumanille 1981: 79) but nevertheless a blood-relation. As the Rhône and Durance flow into the sea, he writes in *Mireille*, so does fair Provence, in the course of her history, fall asleep in the arms of her greater sister (Mistral 1978: 416). It would therefore appear that it is others who have cast Mistral in the role of a decentralizer: some of his more fanatical fellow-patriots, and even foreigners such as the German Romance scholar Eduard Koschwitz, who urged the award of the Nobel Prize to Mistral in 1904 with the argument, among others, that Mistral was an opponent of Parisianism (Björkman 1980: 430).

The Parisians, however, claimed Mistral as a French patriot. Pierre Lasserre wrote in 1918 of Mistral's rich and profound concept of *la patrie*, the fatherland, which could render the French soul spiritual aid in those difficult times (Lasserre 1918: 11–15). Similarly, in the same year, José Vincent quotes Mistral's poem *Aux poètes catalans* where France is seen as the greater sister, and where the two sisters, France the strong and Provence the fair, would combine to drive out the dark night (i.e. of war) (Vincent 1918: 246–258).

In his later years, it was the lost traditions, rather than the missed opportunity of a separate Provençal state, which Mistral mourned. In 1906 he complained that the Provençal children were being made to learn French; it had become fashionable, he asserts, to deny everything that was traditional. His mother, that holy woman ("la sainte femme") had fed him on the honey of tradition and the love of God ("le bon Dieu") (Mistral 1981: 23, 87), whereas the restricted and brutal system of Today left no room for childlike fantasy, attacked the need for wonder with its nude and crude Science ("la sciènci nuso e cruso"), and dessicated the heart and the soul (Mistral 1981: 84, 88). Here, as elsewhere, Mistral sets aside a clear vision of the present day, with its deterioration in Franco-German relations, (cf. Schenda 1978), to voice his *laus temporis acti* and pessimistic cultural idealism (see Lafont 1954).

Mireille in the consciousness of the people

Alphonse de Lamartine, who gave public support to Mistral's *Mireille* from the first, wrote in the 40th discourse of his *Cours familier de littérature* in 1859 that, had he the means, he would print Mistral's *Mireille* in a popular edition of six million copies and distribute them free of charge to every household in France; he saw *Mireille* as a veritable catechism of feeling, poetry, and virtue, a manna not from above but below, from Mistral, the peasant from Maillane. The salvation of the people must arise from the people itself ("c'est le peuple qui doit sauver le peuple") (Mistral 1978: 478).

As we have seen, however, the peasant from Maillane had long since become the intellectual from Avignon, a bourgeois with little in common any longer with the common people. And what about *Mireille* as a popular edition? Up to Mistral's death, there were the following editions: 1st, Avignon 1859; 2nd, Paris 1861; 3rd, Paris 1884; 4th, Paris 1884; 5th, Paris 1886; and 6th, Paris 1891. The seventh edition, by Koschwitz, came out in Marburg in 1900. No new editions appeared until the 1920s, when there were four. The second edition, that published by Charpentier in Paris, had by 1947 achieved a total sale of around 80.000 copies (Place 1969: 6–9), and altogether up to 1959 the total number of copies of *Mireille* in circulation may have been around 100.000. At a thousand copies a year, this is far from a bestseller.

Such awareness as there is among the ordinary people of *Mireille* derives in fact from the opera by Charles-François Gounod, the première of which took place in the Théâtre Lyrique in Paris on 19 March 1864 (Carré & Gounod 1907). This opera has not declined in popularity since then. It was performed, for instance, at the 1978 Music Festival in Carpentras (Kobbé 1982: 476), and has naturally been shown on French television. When the inhabitants of a small village on the North bank of the Vaucluse — genuine 'ordinary people' — were questioned about *Mireille*, what they recalled was this performance of the opera

in Avignon, or that one in Vaison-la Romaine, and what they associated with the name were certain melodies, and the French, not the Provençal, language. For these villagers, moreover, Provençal is seen as a high language used further to the South, and not identical with their local patois (Saint-Roman-de-Malegarde / Vaucluse, enquête by Susanne Schenda, spring 1984). In school, moreover, they had learnt nothing about Mistral.

These facts point to a serious difference from the popularity of the Kalevala epic. Both the Kalevala and Mireille came about as the result of many years of intellectual involvement, and each is the work of a single author supported by the knowledge of others of like mind. Mistral, however, once he had obtained his *Licenciat en droit*, abandoned the fieldwork research which Lönnrot repeatedly returned to even after qualifying as a doctor, or which Charles Joisten carried on in the mountain villages of Provence a hundred years after Mistral. The recognition Mistral sought was in the salons of Paris rather than among the people. His fellow-combatants, similarly, were unable to build the Félibrige up into a popular republican movement; and this was the result not merely of their limited political abilities or of the conservative power of the Church, but of the political evolution on a much larger scale, which created a totally different situation in France from that obtaining in Finland. Three murderous wars with Germany, in 1870–71, in 1914–18, and in 1939–45, have bound the people of Provence in an unconditional solidarity with the unloved “sister” in the North.

The Provençal identity has remained merely a provincial identity, a disunited complex of the ideas of a few intellectuals and separatists concerned with the preservation of one patois or another. These have then been complemented by backwards-looking idealists hoping to re-awaken old traditions, and the numerous young people in quest of an alternative, healthier environment. The historical process of the quest for a Provençal identity is thus far from complete, and for this, much of the credit is undoubtedly due to Frédéric Mistral.

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Africa

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Is Epic Oral or Written?

The term oral tradition is not always used correctly, because not all students of oral traditions are aware of all the sources of oral traditions. Many traditions have not come to us in their oral form, and in all such cases the oral form is lost beyond recovery. In some cultures the written and oral traditions of the same texts live side by side and scholars seem to ignore one of them, without realizing that this coexistence is itself part of such a culture. Moreover, the oral and written traditions are not always the same, and we are not justified in assuming that the written text we possess of some epic, say, is the faithful replica of the oral tradition we suspect behind it. How can we prove that every written text is only an oral tradition written down? And even where we do know that there was once an oral tradition, how can we be sure that it was not very different?

The factual and textual reliability of oral traditions

One of the first scholars to reflect on these problems was Theodor Nöldeke, who in his *Poesie der Alten Araber* (1864: 6) wrote:

We must have no illusion, but the fragments of ancient Arabic poetry, as we possess them, are very different from their original form. No folk literature can be kept for any length of time in its original form without the help of a script. Just as the mass of a

literature will gradually melt together, so the preserved pieces will change progressively, until at last writing will shackle the volatile sounds.

Especially since historians have deigned to take an interest in oral traditions (e. g. in tropical Africa, where there are no other sources), those traditions have become hallowed as if they had never changed, and never would. Yet Professor Innes told me that in several parts of West Africa a man of substance can pay a griot to create a genealogy for him, which will be sung in public and become accepted history. As I have described in my *Anthology of Swahili Love Poetry* (1972), the Swahili singers will freely use phrases, lines, metaphors or even entire stanzas from their predecessors' songs to adorn their own, and this procedure is considered quite normal. Indeed, I submit that this is the essence of oral poetry.

Similar traces of multiple composition in poetry that was originally transmitted orally have been detected in Andalusian Arabic Poetry by Francisco Marcos Marín (1971: 67, note 19). Later poets simply inserted lines which they liked as ornaments in their own songs, which they may have advertised as composed by their more illustrious predecessors, a practice which is still found in Africa today: in order to "sell" one's work, (this "selling" has to be taken literally in many cases), one pretends that it is the work of a well-known classical author. The point I am trying to make here is that all we have is the manuscripts and printed texts of the old poems in their present form. The rest is interpretation.

A thorny problem for the editors of the original texts whose task it is to date them, to recompose them from the remaining fragments, and to interpret them, is that even the sources are hard to date, and may themselves not be genuine. J. H. Kramers once told me that the Arab philologists of the ninth century, in order to prove certain points of Arab grammar, would travel to join the Bedouin tribes in the desert, hoping to discover some gems of ancient poetry of the sixth century. How sure can we be that the gems they brought back were not created for the purpose of proving that grammatical point?

H. Thorossian, in his *Histoire de la Littérature Arménienne*, opens with a chapter on the oral literature (1951: 49), in which he describes some fragments of “poésies épiques ou mythologiques appelées chants de Goghten”. These were recited or chanted by minstrels accompanying themselves on a kind of guitar called a *bambirn*. Thorossian is here writing about a period of Armenian history which ends with the fourth century A. D. The fragments of epic poetry he mentions were collected by a historian called Mouses Khorénatsi. But when we come to the chapter where this historian himself is discussed as author, it appears that his dates are by no means certain, and that he may have lived as late as the ninth century (Thorossian 1951: 86–87). How can we be sure then that he found the songs he quotes in their original form?

The tropical conditions in most parts of India are comparable to those in Subsaharan Africa and unlike North Africa and the Middle East. Under dry conditions papyrus, paper and parchment remain in fairly good condition for a long time, but in tropical areas literature does not live so long. No manuscript in tropical Africa is older than c. 1650, whereas in India, as F. C. Wright assured me, the limit is about 500 years. All the texts supposed to be written in an earlier period are copies.

Living and dead traditions

We must distinguish between dead and living languages, and between dead and living traditions. All four combinations exist. In the case of *Beowulf* both the language and the tradition are dead. Any assertion about its recital is pure speculation. The same is true of the *Song of Roland*; even though its language is called by the same name as a modern language, it is indeed very different. Old French is dead, and so is *Roland*.

In Hindu culture, the situation is different. Large portions of Sanskrit poetry, though a dead language, are still recited, and there are reasons to accept the assertion that the tradition is continuous and thus alive.

In the case of Chaucer's verse, we have to declare the language dead; whether there ever was a tradition of recital is doubtful. In the case of Tulsi Das' "Rama-carit-manas", both the language and the recital are kept alive by the tradition which is still elaborated at regular ceremonies.

In Holland there used to be, up till the beginning of this century, a tradition of reciters of folk ballads, some of which have survived in printed form. Even some of the chanting tunes are still known, but the tradition is quite dead. The language lives...

If we now turn to Africa, we find two types of traditions. In Swahili, Hausa and Fulani (Peul), the long poems are written in Arabic script and are available in manuscript form. At the same time there is a very lively tradition of recital and/or chanting and the bards can still memorise long poems (over 3.000 lines) from manuscript copies, or from listening to recitations. Finally, there is the purely oral tradition which Gordon Innes has described in the Gambia, where no written tradition exists (1976: 1 ff.).

It is only in this last case that we are on safe ground when seeking illustrations for our own cultures in pre-literate times. Here we meet exactly the same situation which I found in Swahili epic verse, and which Helmut von Glasenapp argues for Valmiki's Rāmāyaṇa: there is not one Sunjata, there are at least three complete versions, and several fragmented texts. The oral tradition, as long as it is alive, continues creating and is thus incomplete since it is in a continuous *statu nascendi*.

The author-scribe, making a second copy of his own composition, will change it, or else his son will, who inherits the art with the documents. The reciter can also change the text, but he can do this only in certain cultures and by no means in all. Albert B. Lord (1964: 129) has described this independent authorship for the Yugoslav guslars, but John Smith (1977: 150) stresses that the Rajasthani reciter reproduces his epic text verbatim. I have found the same in Swahili culture: the written text is followed line by line even though the bard may

never have seen it. Father Theuws found the same in Katanga: the oral text (prose myths) was always recited in the same words (Theuws 1983: 44–51). None of this tells us anything about the original version, the *Urtext*. In Swahili the author may change his text, even write a new text with the same title, but how can we be sure that the oldest surviving manuscript is also the oldest version of the text?

We should not forget that life is too short to examine more than one cultural tradition thoroughly. I shall never have time to learn enough Rajasthani or Mandinka. So we tend to generalise from our own local data. What Albert B. Lord wrote about the Yugoslav epics has been generalised for cultural traditions where it does not apply. Each tradition is unique and totally distinct. Finally we should not forget that most of our information comes from written, or even printed, sources, even in modern times. They have been collected by research workers in other parts of the oral world, who, in spite of their excellence, did not ask the questions that I would have asked, and I am sure this is mutual. I have been told that I should have paid more attention to the singers and their background. My answer to this is that I am a student of literature rather than an anthropologist. My first concern was to get a correct record of the text, secondly to get a complete translation of it, and a complete glossary. Thirdly, I thought the poets deserved priority over the singers, if known, and fourthly there was the metre and the melody to study.

Another reproach at my address was that I did not pay enough attention to the distinction between oral and written literature. The answer to this is that in Swahili culture, which has been a literate tradition for many centuries, the distinction between oral and written traditions has never been as sharp as it is in the English-speaking world, where there is a sophisticated high intellectual literature and a low-class popular folk tradition.

To describe in every detail the background of the singers is a separate task that will have to wait for another scholar. My work is to preserve texts that would otherwise have been lost. An example of this are the Wawe songs which were collected on Pate Island off the Kenya Coast

by Mw. Yahya Ali Omar from dictation by an old man who has since died. The songs have been just saved from the jaws of oblivion. In my own work, too, most of the texts I collected were dictated to me, partly because I did not possess, twenty-five years ago, the technical equipment nor the know-how that John Smith takes to India, bringing back a complete film of the performances. The other reason was that the experts who knew the texts were often not themselves singers but scholars and teachers, too old to sing. They knew much more than the singers, they knew the old texts in which the younger singers were not interested but which I was hoping to preserve, and they knew more about their interpretation.

This philological work must not be underestimated: very few Swahili poetic texts have been properly edited (only John Allen, Lambert and Dammann were good editors), as a result of which there was no appreciation of the precise metrical forms of the poems. The songs published by Hichens and Whiteley will have to be reedited.

Studies on African epics

In 1949 the Rev. E. Boelaert published a text from central Zaire called *Nsong'a Lianja*, which he translated as *L'Epopée Nationale des Nkundo*. Whether it can really be called an epic will be discussed later. Here I will quote some passages from E. Boelaert's Introduction, our only information about the performance of the reciters:

Lianja is the legendary hero of the Nkundo who straddle the Equator in the Congo Basin; they speak a Bantu language of an old type... they have connections with the Pygmies. The Nkundo love to quote the pair of Lianja and his twin sister Nsongó as their most distant ancestors, or even as the parents of the human species.

The epic of Lianja is not the work of one author but of the whole people, in time and space, where the imagination of all the storytellers

has embroidered, around a few central motifs, the poetry of prehistory. There is no fixed text with well defined lines. Nevertheless, there are some facts and songs that are typical but which each narrator relates in his own manner, after the inspiration of the moment. There are many renowned singers who teach the art of speaking and singing the narratives to a son or a disciple. Among them I used to know Boembe de Bosilela-Boleke, from whom I took down the first version (Flemish translation 1934), and many others.

Yet there is no caste of singers, no prohibition for women or children, no initiation before one can narrate the epic. Generally, the epic is sung at night around the fire, and one must have assisted those vespers to appreciate the significance of live poetry for these people, for whom it is not yet folklore.

The invited storyteller arrives in great style, his visage and body painted in asymmetrical figures, a plumed hat on his head and his lance in hand. He is accompanied by a chorus of men and women who will sit down around him and will take over the songs which illustrate every new passage of the recital with enthusiasm. The whole clan, the entire village comes, cramming the place as space permits to listen, to follow the legendary gestes, the miraculous exploits of the national hero.

This mythical narrative may preserve a historical basis, the recollection of the penetration of the ancestors into the forest of Equatorial Africa. The famous tree with the *sau* fruits is said to be still standing at Bompoma in the headship Injolo. Every bird sent by the owner to defend the tree is introduced with its own song...

The reader will easily understand how difficult it has been to collect these recitals. The narrators are unable to write them down or to dictate them without the narrative losing all its savour, all its colour. Most of the time one has to trust the memory of listeners, equally untrained to annotate suitably what he has heard. With the help of Mr. Van Goethem and Rev. Fr. Hulstaert, I have been able to collect some ten versions, one more complete than the other. Then it was necessary to unite these into a concordance ensemble, tailoring the discordant texts... (Boelaert 1949: 4–7.)

The last paragraph demonstrates that the published text is not the same, and cannot be, as any of the narrated versions. In 1957, E. Boelaert published a more complete version, more than three times the size of the 1948 edition, in which he had incorporated a long version which the above mentioned Boembe de Boleke had dictated to a student, with additions of others. In 1958 a second volume was added containing the recitals on Lianja's ancestors, also dictated, by the village elders, to a schoolteacher, and edited with great care by E. Boelaert (Boelaert 1957, 1958).

In those same years I was working on my edition of the Swahili epic of Herekali (Chuo cha Tambuka), in which likewise a number of versions of different lengths and contents had to be harmonised into one definitive edition, with a coherent story (Knappert 1958).

In Swahili epic literature there is only one text that was edited exclusively from a tape (by J. W. T. Allen); the result is not satisfactory, as there are too many questions left in the text. As John Smith has also shown in the Rajasthani epic, the recited text is not the same as the edited text, and cannot be.

Our conclusions are also in accordance with those expressed by Coupez and Kamanzi in their *Littérature de Cour au Rwanda* (1970: 119–124), that the performer during his presentation makes mistakes. In Swahili verse, such mistakes can easily be checked by reference to the manuscript; the oldest manuscript usually has the best reading for every *varia lectio*. In cultures with a totally oral tradition there may be recognized scholars in the community who will be referred to as final arbiters of the correct text, but they are not always available and they do not always agree. There is, however, recourse possible to internal evidence of correct ideals. In Swahili verse, I have worked through many hundreds of lines with the well-known scholar Mw. Yahya Ali Omar. Wherever there was a deficient line or rhyme, it is invariably obvious what it must have been: a scribe's error, a misheard word during dictation, a vague sound on the tape, can be rectified in nine out of ten cases.

Here again there is no great difference with the oral products of literature: the reciter, when his performance is played back to him,

will often point out his own mistakes and ask that they be corrected when the text is prepared for publication. In traditional poetry, mistakes in the metre often occur where the reciter endeavours to replace an archaic form, which he remembers only vaguely and does not understand grammatically, by a more familiar form which will not fit the prosody.

In written traditions recourse can be had to the old manuscripts. For the oral tradition, Coupez and Kamanzi have used statistics as a method to find some of the answers; others can sometimes be found by the comparative method in related languages. In one type of Rwanda verse, the pastoral poems, Coupez and Kamanzi have found that the metre is regular 13 morae per line. It is of great importance that this same metre has been used by the only modern poet who has so far *written* verse in Rwanda, Alexis Kagame, who composed a Dantesque epic describing the Creation. The frequent irregularities in some recitations could later be explained by Coupez and Kamanzi, because the performer had inserted a large number of his own lines which were not traditional but topical, and in which the rules were not obeyed.

Surveying all the alleged epic that has come to light in Africa so far (for a complete bibliography and discussion see Knappert 1983, Introduction), we may distinguish the following categories, admitting that the data are still incomplete:

1. Written epic verse composed under the influence of European literature, by such authors as Alexis Kagame (Rwanda), Mazisi Kunene (Natal) and some modern poets in Egypt.
2. A combined written and oral tradition in the cultures of the Islamic belt of Africa: Fulani, Hausa, Swahili, Amharic.
3. The purely oral tradition of epic in Mandinka, Nkundo, Nyanga.
4. The praise songs and commemorative court poetry as in Rwanda, Sotho, Tswana and Zulu. It contains heroic passages, as in Nyankole, but has not developed into epic.
5. The cycle of the animal fables, as in Zulu, Mongo, Tsonga and Luba, strongly reminiscent of Reynard the Fox, but not composed as epic. These are strings of tales with songs.

It is clear that in this paper we are only concerned with the long compositions of category 3. Curiously, the popular tradition of Arabic literature in Africa, the oral romances of the Sahara, show the same features: long prose narratives full of fantastic tales and wonderful literary devices, interspersed with short or long songs praising the heroes, their sweethearts, or for some magic purpose (see Knappert 1958: 16–21, with bibliography).

The Lianja epic of the Nkundo and the Mwindo epic of the Nyanga are also prose recitations, interspersed with songs. Here are some extracts from Daniel Biebuyck's Introduction to his edition of the Mwindo Epic. In his 1969 edition he has presented the longest and most elaborate version which he has recorded (Biebuyck 1969: 12); but this does not exhaust the many motifs and details of Mwindo's life that are still narrated by the Nyanga.

Episode by episode, the epic is first sung, then narrated. While singing and narrating, the bard dances, mimes and dramatically represents the main peripeties of the story. In this dramatic representation, the bard takes the role of the hero... Members of the audience also encourage the reciter with short exclamations (including onomatopoeia) and hand clapping or whooping. (Biebuyck 1969: 13.)

In a later book, *Hero and Chief*, Daniel Biebuyck (1978: 91–92) gives a few glimpses of the prosodic features of the Nyanga epic, implying that the lines have seven or nine syllables with a fixed tonal pattern. No examples are given, nor do we learn whether there is a reason for seven-or nine-syllable lines to be used. Neither does it become clear why the songs are printed as verse, while the body of the narrative is printed as prose. Is it? Much research is apparently still needed here. Can the entire text be sung? Do the drummers give a fixed rhythm (cf. Biebuyck 1969: 13)?

The same applies even to Innes' *Sunjata*. In spite of the fact that the bards can be accompanied by themselves or by assistants, on musical instruments, Innes writes (1974: 17):

As will be seen, the texts are set out in short lines in the manner of verse, but there does not seem to be any regular metrical pattern; at least if there is, it has not yet been determined. In the song mode, the division into lines is easy. The tune gives a quite unmistakable guide to the lines. In the recitation mode the division into lines is usually quite clear, though not as unambiguous as in the song mode. But in the speech mode it is sometimes difficult to decide where the end of a line should come, and the main criterion which has been used is the breath group. A line represents a breath group. The speed of utterance varies very considerably throughout all the performances. Sometimes it is so extremely rapid that it hardly seems humanly possible for speech to be articulated at such a rate, hence some lines are much longer than others.

The conclusion appears to be that the epic of Sunjata, just like the Mwindo epic, is mainly in prose, interspersed with songs. We may accept the "recitation mode" as a form of verse, but until we know more about the exact nature of poetry appreciation among the Mandinka, it seems that the "speech mode" *is* prose recitation. The Belgian scholars Boelaert and Biebuyck were both in the first place concerned with the contents of the long narratives they had recorded, and indeed the Lianja and the Mwindo are both qua content, undoubtedly epic. The question now to be decided is to what extent should we apply formal criteria, like those of syllable count or musical metre, and those of regularity of line length (the syntactic metre), as final yardsticks for the definition of epic.

Points of comparison outside Africa

One fascinating detail springs to mind immediately: the parallel with other oral traditions. The oral traditions of narrative verse in Finnish, Spanish, Malay, Russian and even Serbo-Croat (the *bugarštica*, see Robert

Auty in Hatto 1980: 196–199) all have lines of irregular length. In all those languages, lines of regular numbers of syllables were introduced only by the sophisticated individual poets of the nineteenth century except Spanish and Finnish, which developed much earlier in that direction. For Russian the beginning of regular lines seems to be in the eighteenth century. Is it a rule, then, that the oldest oral narrative poetry has irregular lines? Is it the writing poets who first count their syllables and make their lines regular? Do the bards of the oral tradition not care, or are they not aware of the irregularity of their songs? Can they easily stretch the pronunciation of a few syllables to make a short line longer? Or do they deviate from what was once a perfect composition but is being corrupted by forgetful bards? Or are the bards really the creators of the long poems they recite, and is the irregularity in the form the price paid for instant poetry? Is the beauty of perfect regularity the gain of the writer who can meditate about every line until it fits? Yet Theodore Nöldeke mentions an Arabian poet (A. D. 600) who complained that a reciter had corrupted a line about which he, the author, had thought for a whole night.

If the conclusion is correct that the irregular lines represent the oldest, the “aboriginal”, oral stage of epic poetry, this would tally beautifully with what John D. Smith has described for the Rāmāyaṇa (quoting Mary C. Smith in Hatto 1980: 52), where the lines in the irregular *tristubh* metre appear to form the c. 3.000 oldest lines, the nucleus of the Sanskrit Rāmāyaṇa.

Worth studying is also Nigel Phillips’ analysis of the 40.000 lines of the central Sumatran epic; most lines have 8–9 syllables (94.2 per cent; see Phillips 1981). Whether a more precise systematisation of the (often diphthongal) syllables would reveal greater uniformity remains to be seen, but it is doubtful. In spite of its length, this epic is a completely oral tradition.

The Sijobang cycle offers a problem in the context of our investigation, since it is the longest oral epic that has come to our knowledge. But is it a unity? And is it epic? Is it oral? Reading Phillips’ summary the tale seems to share features with the well-known Indonesian Panji-

cycle (see Knappert 1980: 103–144). Prince Panji, who changes names numerous times in one narrative, upon learning that a certain king has promised his daughter to whoever wins the tournament he is organizing, appears, often in disguise, solves the king's problem (by slaying a demon or by solving conundrums, like Oedipus) and marries the princess. Since he does this three times in the same story, one has the impression that three separate stories have been welded together. This is exactly the impression one gets from the long narrative of Sijobang. The hero, Nan Tungga, sails from island to island, winning a bride each time he has landed.

Phillips admits that only the reciters are aware of the Sijobang as a whole; the people never perceive it as a unity, since it is never recited in one night. The reciters who study to become professional bards learn the text piecemeal, the popular fragments first. They will be asked to perform a particular episode for a night and sometimes two episodes, not necessarily in their "correct" sequence. Only the few bards who know the entire text will appreciate the complete story. There is not a great deal of coherence in the narrative, so that it can easily be shortened to suit the needs of an evening's entertainment.

This leads us to the second question: is it epic? One of the requirements of epic is its fundamental unity of structure and composition. Secondly, the Sijobang does not seem to have the grandeur of vision, the greatness of highstrung language, the human strength of its heroes (see Ing 1973: 210). Thirdly, an important aspect of oral epic is missing: the binding to a nation (El Cid, Roland, Marko Kraljević), a participation in the texture of a newly coherent group of peoples.

The third question is also difficult to answer. Phillips (1981: 2–5) mentions a number of versions in manuscripts and in printed editions, in verse and in prose. Phillips does not go into the question of the comparison of the written and oral texts so that we do not know if there is a chronological sequence. It is possible to suppose that the ballads or oral poetic narratives were gradually sewn together and finally written down as one long epic. This is the hypothesis preferred by John Smith (see Hatto 1980: 55), where he regards the writing down

of a heroic text as a sign of acceptance, accompanied by expurgation of objectionable passages, among the literate classes. William Entwistle (1951: 31) describes a similar development for the Spanish ballads.

However, epic poetry is a tricky subject. Too many authors have built hypotheses that apply to one area but not to another. What is true for India and Spain may not be true in Indonesia. The art of writing has been known there for over a thousand years, and it is still quite possible that the Sijobang began its life as an epic written by one individual poet. Entwistle (1951: 26) describes this process too, and, of course, from his point of view, as a sort of decadence of the epic, broken up into ballads by minor bards catering for the lower classes rather than for kings, for whom epic poets write.

The dilemma of oral and written

We now come to a difficult part of our argument: whether it is possible, desirable or necessary to separate oral epic from written epic, epic in a tradition from an epic poem that was created without any previous tradition known to us? The first question must surely be answered in the negative on all three counts. As we have seen, many cultures go through the transition from oral to written literature, taking their epic poetry with them: the Castellians, the Swahili and the Indians are good examples. The oral tradition does not have to die out when the epics are recorded; on the contrary, the availability of written texts enabled the reciters to memorize even the epics which they had never heard. Nor is it even necessary to suppose that the oral tradition always preceded the written one.

We know for a fact, thanks to the research of Muhammad I. Abou Egl, that the Kenyan poet Muhammad Kijuma, who flourished about a century ago, wrote his songs down, then taught them to his friends and followers, and taught them the accompanying dances as well, which

he had himself invented. Numerous poems in his hand show his expertise in Arabic calligraphy, while Abou Egl collected songs on tape on Lamu Island which Kijuma had composed and taught and which the people still sing, in his tunes (Abou Egl 1984). One could perhaps compare the Dutch poet and composer Adriaen Valerius, who published a series of songs in 1626 which started a pious tradition which survives today even in the American celebration of Thanksgiving.

Like every other aspect of human culture, oral traditions have to be invented and organized, the songs have to be created by a poet, and the tradition has to be started off. A community does not make poetry, but it can sing it and preserve it. Whether the original poet wrote it down or not does not make the slightest difference.

In Zimbabwe I witnessed a storyteller teach the songs in his tale to his audience, before starting his tale, so that they could sing at least the refrains at the appropriate time. Whether he had invented the songs himself I do not know. It is quite possible, though in this case I do not think so. Although many folklorists have commented on the incredible age of some oral traditions and their faithful preservation, there is nothing to stop the storyteller or bard from creating a completely new story and/or song, and its hearers may repeat the new invention for ever after.

During the sixties and seventies, when the great school of oral literature reigned supreme, it became a fashion to play down individual authorship and credit it on some abstract community of people. Perhaps we have come full circle now, since it has transpired that many oral traditions were once created by individual poets and story-inventors. The traditions themselves are often quite explicit about this, by attributing the invention of song or poetry to a cultural hero, known by name. Though some may relegate such tales to the realm of myth, there is no reason why it could not be true. In many cases the inventor may have learned some aspect of culture while staying with another people, and decided to adapt it for use at home, thus introducing a new tradition, "translated" from abroad.

It may now have become clear that the two questions we asked at the beginning of this section are closely linked. The answers are as follows: The written epic may stand at the beginning of an oral tradition as well as at the end of its evolution. An epic may be one of a tradition of epic poems, i. e. a collection composed over a period of time by a series of poets; an epic may also have been composed *ex nihilo* by a poetic genius, and then become an oral tradition.

Criteria for the epic — are there any?

If there is, then, no argument to distinguish the true epic from minor narrative songs by means of its link to the oral tradition, is there another criterion? Most authors agree that length is a yardstick for distinguishing epic, but how long should the yardstick be? It is true that there must be an upper limit to what a bard can retain in his memory or sing in one night, yet there are shorter texts which are undoubtedly epic.

We come now to the question of the epic content. The answer to this question reveals a curious division between the great literary works of Africa. The martial poetry of the praise songs in Southern Africa (Cope 1968; Schapera 1965) and the Bahima of Uganda (Morris 1964) and also of the Swahili Islamic tradition, contrasts sharply with the magic tales of the Nkundo, the Soninke and the Mandinka, traditions that seem to show parallels with the Kalevala. The heroes' opponents are not warriors but evil spirits who can take human form or any other disguise; they cannot be killed on the battlefield in an honest combat, they have to be struck in the magically sensitive place, or they have a "deputy-soul", like the Indonesian characters of myth and epic, who could hide their souls in secret places. Liongo the hero can likewise only be killed through his navel by a brass needle. We are reminded of Siegfried and Achilles, and we may wonder if hidden below the heroic

epic there may not have been a magic epic, full of weird mythical characters, of which in Europe there are only vestiges left in the heroic age (cf. Knappert 1970: 76).

The Odyssey type epic, the voyage of the wandering hero, so brilliantly described by Camoens, is popular in Indonesia, where Hang Tuah and Sijobang are both 'naval' heroes. In Swahili there is one maritime epic, Utenzi wa Masaiba, though there are many fairy tales about travellers at sea (see "Tall Travellers' Tales" in Knappert 1970).

It seems that here again, there are too many possibilities to allow a simple categorization. Almost any good story of adventure and exceptional acts may supply the material for an epic. If it is well-told and well-structured, it will become great. In other words, a fine tale waiting for a fine pen.

In his Introduction to Traditions of Heroic and Epic Poetry, Professor Hatto discusses the concept of heroic *ethos* as a decisive element in the definition of true epic. In his own description of the contents of the Nibelungenlied (Hatto 1980: 171), however, one realizes that Siegfried was not as noble as he might have been; neither is Ulysses, nor is Krishna. Heroes can be tricky characters, like Reynard the Fox, whose character is amazingly identical with that of the animal heroes of other national cycles of fables: the hare Sungura in East Africa (see "Astute Animals" in Knappert 1970), Kalulu in Zambia, Kabundi in Kasai, a type of marten (Theuws 1983: 54), like Icakijana of the Zulu in Natal (Callaway 1868); the tortoise in central Zaire, the jackal in North Africa and in India (Knappert 1980: 183).

It is only in the Islamic heroic epic of the Swahili that all the heroes are noble. Some are more irascible, others are more patient, but all are God-fearing, honest men who will fight for Islam without fear or greed. Instead of conveying high ethical feelings, this flawless nobility gives an impression of unreality, of a nice fairy tale world, in which the heroes are no more than puppets in God's gigantic shadow-play "Round which we phantom figures come and go" (Omar Khayyam). Surely, men who confess to be no more than, as Ali recites: "He gave me strength, virtue and bravery / I am a sword, a dagger in His hand..."

(see Knappert 1967: 197), such men cannot be heroes in the sense of the European epic traditions. A hero braves his fate, conscious of potential (and often inescapable) doom, but in the popular epic of Islam there is no loser, except the heathen who refuses to accept Islam. Those of the faithful who die will travel up to heaven, as the holy prophet informs his companions at the very time it happens; he for whom Allah has reserved more years to live in, cannot die, so he has nothing to fear. And it is precisely the conquest of fear that makes the true hero.

The only Islamic epic tale in which there is a peak of tragedy is Husayn's death at Kerbela. That is no doubt one of the reasons why the theme has attracted so many poets in Arabic, Persian, Urdu and Swahili, apart from the purely religious reason (Knappert 1982, 1: 27–29; Knappert 1982, 2).

There does not seem to remain any clear criterion for epic except the subjective one of "greatness". A great work must be long in size, of perfect prosodic composition, having a complex contentual structure. It must be full of emotional drama, loaded with intense feelings and heroic struggle, yet be genuine and true to life, not exaggerated.

Only a few works in the history of literature meet all these criteria, and the judges must be impartial, so that they may not exclude written works in favour of oral epics, nor may they rule out the works written after A. D. 1600, the so-called secondary epics, for that would rule out even the Kalevala.

In order to answer the question: "Is epic poetry oral or written?" we have had to answer the question: "What is epic?" The main difficulty in arriving at a satisfactory classification of epic is that there are so few really great epics in world literature. Some nations have produced more than one epic in their long history but not all nations can boast an epic which truly deserves that name. Even in France there are less than a hundred great cathedrals and less than a hundred great epics. Research is not complete, our collecting and editing of epic poems has not ended yet. It is unlikely, however, that we shall discover another great epic as it is unlikely that we shall discover an old cathedral in the forests of Borneo. But again: what is great? The cathedral of Beauvais would

probably be disqualified on the grounds that it is incomplete. Yet it is the highest and one of the most elegant cathedrals in the world.

Many great poets took Homer and Virgil as their examples: Camoens, Dante, Milton, Tasso and Byron. They all set the standard by which they shall be judged. The Indian poets had the Mahābhārata as their example of epic poetry. But what was the example of the Shahnamé, the Sunjata, the Cid? By what criteria can we ever unite all those great works under one heading: epic?

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Christiane Seydou

Identity and Epics: African Examples

For a long time, Europeans have ignored, if not denied, the existence of African epics. This misperception has now been corrected by the publication of a large number of African epic narratives, and for a number of reasons, I believe they can be an excellent base for better understanding the meaning and function of this genre as a whole.

First, because the African epic has remained a “spoken genre” still fully integrated into societies of oral tradition, it can be grasped as it functions in its context of enunciation. Second, because the African epic displays a wide range of forms of expression and performance since it is produced by societies differing greatly in their history, sociopolitical structure and cultural values, a synchronic comparative analysis of these various epic narrations, by revealing their common traits and consequently the reasons for their differences, can be instrumental in defining the epic genre more precisely and in elucidating its specificity.

In my point to point comparison of the *Mvet* (Fang, Gabon) and the Fulani epic (Massina, Mali), presented in a previous study, only three points of convergence emerged from these two radically different epic traditions. The first is linked with the performance mode: An obligatory association of the epic narrative with its specific musical instrument. The second is linked with the narrative logic: The recurrence of the concept of transgression as the catalyst for all epic action (competitive challenge leading to transgression, leading to an agonistic situation). The third is linked to the very function of the genre: the reactualization of an “ideological” and cultural identity as the foundation of communal unity. It is only the quest for exaltation, obviously key to the epic’s ethics and aesthetics, that could account for these

three points of convergence, since all the textual, contextual, referential and paralinguistic (music and gestures) resources are used to favor and achieve the audience's exaltation. Clearly, the real goal of the epic is to mold the collective knowledge, bearer of the ideological values of the group, into a specific form that "activates" this knowledge by reanimating among the auditors, through communion in exaltation, a consciousness of their distinctive identity and a desire to realize this identity.

Given this pragmatic and semantic vocation of the epic, and given the fact that people shape their identity in relation to their ecological and historical situation, their social and political organization, their ethics and religion, it would seem worthwhile to also analyze the manner in which different types of epics relate to the different types of societies that produce them. In this article, my aim is precisely to focus on this interrelation by comparing four epic traditions issued from two main geographical areas — West Africa and a part of Central Africa — representative of two types of sociopolitical organization — polyarchical and hierarchical — and two types of epic traditions — mythological and historical. This paper will be organized around three specific and obviously interrelated points which seemed to be the most pertinent, given my comparative perspective. These three points are: the epic's sociopolitical context; its subject matter, and the role of the bard (or griot) as regards its elaboration and performance.

First example: the *mvét*

Among the Bulu, the Fang and the Beti of Cameroun, Gabon and Equatorial Guinea, the term *mvét* designates both a musical instrument (a four stringed long harp-lute) and the group of literary genres (lyrical, romanesque, epic) accompanied by this instrument. Among them, however, the epic is considered as the most representative and, therefore, most deserving of the name of *mvét*.

According to tradition, this mvet (both the instrument and the narrative) was revealed to the first initiate while he was plunged into a week-long lethargic sleep during the great migration that led these peoples from the banks of the Upper Nile to the regions in which they now live. And it is also said that it was the words and music of the mvet which inflamed the ardor of these runaway people and transformed them into invincible warriors, leading them all the way to the Atlantic coast. This mythical origin of the mvet explains the importance of this literary genre and clearly expresses its essential vocation. It is this inspired dream that the bards repeat when, during the endless mvet performances (some can last up to seven nights), they sketch out, first the cosmic creation (stemming from an original, copper egg), then the long genealogy ending up with the two brothers from whom both immortal and mortal peoples descend: the fantastic battles between these two groups — each represented by individual heroes — constitute the greater part of the Fang version.

During the performance of the mvet, the long narrative episodes relating the battles of the immortals to extend their hegemony and of the mortals to conquer immortality are intercut by lyrical interludes (with choral response on the part of the public) lamenting the bard's painful situation: "I sacrifice myself to the mvet... I die because of the harp-zither!" It must be understood that the bard is here a mere spokesman of the ancestral mvet dictated to him by his instrument: the ancient words only pass through him, and they do so at the cost of a dispossession of his self which is torn apart in the process.

The penultimate knowledge is only granted to him at the end of a costly individual and secret initiation which leads into the "realm of the spirits" in order "to eat" the mvet, and for which, according to popular belief, he had to pay dearly (death of a close relative, loss of eyesight).

In one of these songs included in the mvet, Zwe Nguema relates how the master who taught him his art had himself received the "charms of the mvet". As he was about to die, his own master transmitted the "charms" to all his disciples, sharing his heart and his liver with these

words: “Each mvet player must always be in possession of my heart and liver. Stay and give the mvet to the people; you will start playing the mvet... when you hear a song coming forth from my tomb, raise your arms upwards in order to receive the charms of the mvet”. And thus the bard inherits the “charms of the mvet”, inheritance which can be traced back up for twelve generations. One can therefore see the extent to which the ancestral message is inscribed, not only in the epic’s words but also in the very life of the bard who is entrusted with it.

This alternance between narrative recitation (prompted by myth) and personalized lyrical song, this back and forth between the epic hero and the bard himself, between literary “fiction” and biographical reality would repeatedly seem to draw the public’s attention away from the subject and the aim of the story; on the contrary, the initiated bard and his instrument, identified to the very voice of ancient times, reinforce group cohesion by tightening the network of relations between the living and the ancestors, between the audience and its system of representation — that is to say, its ideology.

Despite the rather esoteric aspect of the initiation to the mvet, and despite its mythological coloring, the recitation of this epic is done without any mystery. It can take place in the course of any festivity and is addressed at the entire community (without any distinction of age, sex or status), the audience demonstrating its profound implication through active participation: songs, hand-clapping, loud exclamations.

While listening to the heroic deeds of such unreal, fantastic and hyperbolic characters, the audience implicitly acknowledges the values that structure and underly its entire culture and stand as its foundation. Through this acknowledgement and through the solidarity created by the feast, it thus reaffirms in communion its profound identity and group solidarity.

It goes without saying that one must have a better knowledge of this society in order to understand its values. In this respect, D. Essone Atome Ongoane provides a well documented insight into Fang society in his thesis “Société et Métasociété (le système politique fang)” (1980). According to him, Fang society is polyarchical since it is founded on the

basis of clans, within which each lineage functions as an “autonomous decision-making center”. These lineages’ equality in law is counterbalanced by an individualistic desire for power, leading to internal competition and external conflict. The author clearly demonstrates how the entire society is in fact organized around a dialectic opposing interior and exterior which manifests itself in the interplay of cohesion and solidarity within the lineage, on the one hand, and latent hostility and occasional aggressivity towards “outsiders”, on the other.

The functioning of such a society explains the importance given to: 1) war, viewed as the only way to seal the group’s unity and to assert one’s virility; 2) both genealogy (the only means by which an individual can identify himself) and ancestor worship, basis of the main initiation — the byeri — (resting precisely on the knowledge and mastery of genealogies).

As a matter of fact, the epic reflects these two interrelated concerns. A long genealogy, starting as far back as the creation of the Cosmos, positions the two primordial adversary clans — the mortals and the immortals — on both sides of a dividing line that only a transgression will manage to break; this transgression is the very basis of a specific conception of heroism — the anchor of all epic action — which could be defined as an ideology of challenge, a glorification of the paradox demanding that the hero doom himself to the greatest risk of annihilation in order to assert his existence. One can, in fact, note that the heroes in the mvets are only designated by their names, mottoes and genealogies; they are not portrayed with individual or specific character traits; their stereotypical and redundant acts are always described in identical terms: imaginary frenzy and verbal profusion. Only the power of their magic science — gift of the ancestors — differentiates one from the other in the course of their extraordinary deeds. And the epic action, whose motor is the confrontation of supernatural powers, bouncing from challenge to superchallenge, projects them into the cosmic realm from whence original myth had taken them away. Hence, they move through the skies to the depths of the waters, under and above the

earth, incessantly going from the human to the spirit realm, in a surrealistic world in which the fantastic and the immoderate rule. But this does not mean that they forasmuch ever betray the familiar day-to-day world of the audience, as if this unreal and mythological formulation were in fact the expression of a deep-seated reality underlying the internal functioning of this society.

In such a culture, in which the power of the word together with the power of arms (be they real or magical) are the two founding principles on which authority and politics stand, one can well foresee the weight of a cultural institution such as the *mvet* in the reproduction of the group's patterns of thought and social dynamics. Is it not for this very reason that, whereas D. Essone Atome Ongoane recognizes the undeniable polysemy of such narrations, he can also identify them as "the principle vehicle of an ideology leading to a feeling of group identity". Moreover, embracing Marc Augé's reflection pointing out that "there can be no organization without representation" (Augé 1975: 19), he can also see that the *mvet* presents the image of a metasociety — that of the immortals — which instigates the human society to organize itself and act as its double.

Ongoane thus interprets the antithetical presentation of the antagonist parties engaged in perpetual wars from which the immortals always emerge victorious as the metaphor for a theory of power. For this author, the world of the immortals, "the crossroads of Palavers", founded on "polyarchy and competition", would seem to represent the humanization and socialization of original power through its division into three distinct spheres — religious, political, economic — and its distribution in various decision centers, operation indispensable to rendering power accessible to men, to controlling its effect, and to limiting its dangers. It would thus seem to be the ideological transposition of Fang society.

The circle is thus closed. The epic, reflection of the group's ideology, symbolizes its distinctive identity and summons this group to reproduce itself and to live out this identity within the community so defined.

Second example: Nyanga epic

As different as the Nyanga epic from Zaire might be from the mvvet, the two nevertheless border on myth and fall under the sign of communication with the spirit world.

This epic is considered as the fruit of the contact between a migrant population and the Pygmies it found *in situ* and who still play an important role in all social and cultural facets of this society (Biebuyck & Mateene 1969, 1978). All the different versions of the epic relate the numerous deeds and exploits of Mwindo, a hero who is extraordinary, not only by his very birth but also because of his excessive character and behaviour. He is cast by destiny into a succession of fantastic adventures in the course of an eventful voyage leading him back and forth between this world and the subterranean, aquatic, and celestial realms of diverse divinities; having at last vanquished all the monsters and escaped all the traps, and having been taught the difference between good and evil, he will finally return as a civilizing and civilized hero who will then be enthroned as a chief.

The transformation of this character, initially extraordinary and extravagant both in deeds and words, into a wise and measured chief bringing to humanity a decalogue, source of peace and prosperity, is the outcome of a long initiatory journey, involving a progressive humanization of the hero through tests and battles, crowned by his final stay in the celestial realm where, passive at last, he grasps the meaning of good and evil before he is permitted to return to earth.

Among the Nyanga, the chief (*mwami*) has sacred attributes of a divine nature and is only enthroned after a trial period and an initiation crowned by a secret ritual. For this reason, Biebuyck sees the image of this institution and of its underlying ideology in the very progression and final conclusion of the epic. In its mythical and symbolic representation, the epic seems to be vested with a vocation that could be qualified as "sacralizing" inasmuch as it gives divine guarantee to political power: the chief being the end-product of the metamorphosis of a superhuman

and even inhuman hero, metamorphosis accomplished by divinities that shape and model him through numerous trials and tribulations.

This sacralizing function of the epic is also reflected in the conditions under which it is taught to and performed by the bards. Even though anyone may, in theory, become a bard and even though narrating the epic does not require any specific ritual conditions, this genre, even more than the *mvet*, displays clear signs of a certain sacralization. Among the Nyanga, the term *Karisi* which designates the epic genre and the bard, is the name of a mythical chief, father of Mwindo — hero of the story — and, above all, that of a spirit. A man generally decides to become a bard when he has been summoned by the spirit in a dream. Besides following a long period of apprenticeship, the student must also worship this spirit in order to avoid any difficulty or delays in his study (Biebuyck & Mateene 1969). Furthermore, during his performance, each bard (*shekarisi*) must display the cultural emblems of this spirit (his lance is planted in the ground near the bard; bells are tied around his ankles...). With these accoutrements, he narrates, sings, dramatizes one or the other of the episodes of the long story of Mwindo, whose parts he plays. His assistants accompany him by beating the rhythm with percussion sticks, and by joining in the chorus, together with the audience. Because he was destined by *Karisi* to study epics, the bard sees himself as vested with a mission; he also believes he draws from his songs the very strength of the hero whom he incarnates in his narration. We can only be struck by the profound imbrication of the religious, political, sociological and literary spheres, even more evident here than in the *mvet*, imbrication that characterizes this epic in its content as well as in its modalities of transmission and performance.

In this epic, just as in the *mvet*, the fantastic and the marvelous are based on a system of symbols which underscore the mythical dimension of these texts. And, for these populations, it would seem that this is the only level at which they can satisfyingly and efficaciously formulate the literary expression of their identity and feeling of community.

The ancient migrations, the ecological situation, the socio-political organization (autonomous lineages, small chiefdoms, heterogeneous

and scattered occupation of their territory) the magico-religious representations of these two societies explain why, in order to feel a unified identity, they would need to have recourse to a mythological and ideological projection of their experienced history, projection that — like all other initiatory and political rituals — reaffirms the original and essential relation between humans and their cosmos. For the Fang, it reaffirms the relation that links the dead (founding ancestors of the clans and of the society) to the living who perpetuate the clans and the society by ensuring its reproduction and cohesion. For the Nyanga, it reaffirms the rapport that links the pantheon of divinities and cosmic space to society and the human space, rapport which is actualized through the hero-chief, the sacred mediator between the two worlds.

Despite their functional similarities, the great epics of West Africa would appear to be very different since they are traditional literary products stemming from a population whose history has been marked by a general orientation toward centralized power and the formation of great empires, and whose social organization is based on a hierarchical order affecting not only political power but the entire society, the function and status assigned to each one being inherited by birth.

The following two examples, issued from the Manding and the Fulani societies, will provide us with a new type of epic which could be grossly qualified as historical.

Third example: the Malinke epic of Sunjata

The Malinke epic, known as Sunjata, is the most famous and most widespread: it is found above all in Mali but is also performed throughout Senegal, the Gambia, Guinea, and even much further away. Its historical substratum is of great importance. This long “geste” centers on the figure of Sunjata, unifier of the Mande world, founder of the Mali empire whose glory replaced that of the Ghana empire from the

thirteenth century onwards. Before Sunjata's rise to power, the Mande world was a mere juxtaposition of small kingdoms (simple chiefdoms based on lineage and the regrouping of a few villages). Weakened by internal rivalries, these small kingdoms had become prey to their northern neighbors, who took spoils and slaves from them in order to supply their trade traffic — salt from the north in exchange for slaves and gold from the south. One of these minor kings, known as Sumanguru Kante (or Sumaworo), king of the Sosso (the country of gold and iron) managed to free himself from this yoke and then imposed his rule on the other kingdoms, thus transforming himself from liberator into oppressor. The central part of the Malinke epic relates the fight between Sunjata and this "blacksmith and magician" king.

Sunjata Keita, predestined child, had been forced into exile by his brothers' jealousy. But, when the whole of the Mande world was about to capitulate to Sumanguru, this prince, whose rights had been forfeited, was summoned back. Having returned, he defeated the tyrant at the famous battle of Krina. This victory inaugurated one of the most grandiose periods in the history of West Africa, and it is said that upon his death in 1255, Sunjata Keita, "the King of the kings", left a unified Mande world, freed from slave trade, policed and well administered. During his reign, he had developed trade, agriculture and, above all, a strong socio-political organization resting on alliance pacts between the different clans and on well-established social classes defined by their status and function within society.

But, historical as it might be, this geste is nevertheless introduced by an evocation of the mythical origin of the empire. Transforming history, it inscribes Sunjata's liberation deeds into the mythical destiny of the Mande world by lending its princes a genealogical depth going as far back as the three Simbon, these master hunters who had come from the heavens on a divine arch (or had been sent by Bilali — the Muezzin of the Prophet Mohammed), in order to establish the first village. This mythical episode (reappropriated by Islam, as well) is treated as a vast parable whose symbolic meaning is revealed by a mysterious character called Kabaku, at the end of an initiatory-like voyage.

Besides borrowing from history and myth, this long geste is also composed of an intermingled maze of elements, motifs, narrative structures, stylistic procedures which can all be found in other literary genres of this region. The episode which introduces Sunjata's mother, for example, borrows its structure and motifs from a widespread legend: the story of a liberating hero who, having managed, all by himself, to kill a monster persecuting the country, is given a princess as reward. Furthermore, all the strong moments of the epic are usually underscored by numerous songs — one of these has been chosen as the national anthem of contemporary Mali.

We can thus see that the various layers of relations to the world structuring this culture: mythical, religious, historical, sociological, political and ethical are all present in the epic genre. Such texts which represent a type of compendium of an entire society and culture, amalgamate the complete experience of a people which crystallizes the full power of its nationalism and ideology around a leading historical figure.

No one knows when this geste was composed; according to tradition, it was recited for the first time at Sunjata's funeral. For historians such as Yves Person, this text must have taken its present form toward the end of the sixteenth century, at a time when rallying the forces of unity among the Manding peoples may have been felt necessary.

Be that as it may, this geste, which undoubtedly has a long tradition and still rekindles, after seven centuries, the story of this historical hero, appears to be an enterprise of interlocked justifications: justification of history through myth, justification of contemporary Manding society and culture through ancient history.

Bearing the entire patrimony of the Manding people and symbolizing its grandiose destiny, this geste of Sunjata could only be treated as the foundation and pledge of all Mande existence. It is thus not surprising that its transmission should be strictly regulated and, if not sacralized, at least strongly institutionalized. Every ordinary griot can everywhere sing the famous hymns to "the bow", to "harmony", to "peace", and each can relate the most popular episodes of Sunjata's story, which they only know

in its public version. On the other hand, the parts considered as the “real” history of the Mande are kept and transmitted in a more confidential and formal manner only by the “King’s griots”: the keepers of tradition, genealogically linked to the lineage of the princes. They alone cultivate real knowledge, together with the art of speaking, and describe themselves as “word-bags enclosing highly secular secrets”. They also claim “they are unable to lie” but, at the same time, they state that “any true science must be a secret” (D. Tamsir Niane). They thus impart to the public only that portion of knowledge they deem suitable for it; as for the “true story”, they withhold its recitation for restricted and ritual sessions during which they verify their knowledge among themselves in order to perpetuate its authentic form because “the world is old, but the future comes out of the past” (D. Tamsir Niane). Respect for tradition is so strong that any significant mistake is said to incur the death (within the year) of any “master of words” who might fail.

Within Mande country, there are a certain number of recognized centers where the “real” epic tradition is taught and perpetuated in the midst of these families of the “king’s griots” who are its privileged bearers. In Mali, the most renowned are Kela and Krina, near Kangaba. Even though the Kela griots see themselves as its most authentic bearers, they must nevertheless complete their apprenticeship with a tour around the Mande world; traveling from master griot to master griot, they learn the various versions of the different family histories and end their tour at Krina, where they come to “receive the benedictions”.

In Kela as well as in Krina, the transmission of this tradition is associated with particular rituals and linked with cult practices. Near Krina, in Kangaba, a sanctuary shelters the ancestral relics and altars; every seven years, the reroofing of this sanctuary is the occasion of a specific ritual regrouping the most confirmed griots who participate in the private, secret séances mentioned above, but they also come here to call back to memory the origins of the Mande world and to recite the genealogies of its different clans to the public. For the young griots (who are present) this is an opportunity to pass a kind of exam that tests their knowledge.

In Krina, the cult of the mythical bird who announced Sumanguru's defeat is celebrated each year: and every sixty years, there is a public feast of the priests. For this very special occasion, the griots come to recite all the narratives they know. Besides these special ritual ceremonies, the funerals of eminent people in the Malinke community are yet another setting at which the griots narrate the public version of Mande history.

In all these public situations, the griot, leaning on his initiate's stick, always starts with his own genealogy, authenticating in this way his knowledge and his words. Then follows the narration of the mythical origins of the Mande and the genealogies of the royal clan — and for each name that is cited, women griots sing out its corresponding motto. The musical accompaniment (balafon, cora, lute and armpit drum) plays an important role since the musical themes, linked to each character or to each important event, function as the reference marks that rhyme and structure the story. But for each and every Manding, these musical themes also represent aural symbols endowed with great evocatory force, capable of focussing their feeling of identity and unity.

With this Malinke example, we have seen yet another type of epic. Contrary to the *mvét*, it does not start with an original cosmogony; anchored in history, it gives a mythical origin to the settlement of the Mande in a precise geographical location in order to justify, through a kind of a *posteriori* determinism (prediction, predestination) the foundation of an empire that had a decisive impact on the history of West Africa for nearly three centuries.

Also contrary to the *mvét*, this epic does not portray an image of a metasociety but acts as a guarantee for a real society, identical to the present one. Contrary to the *mvét* or to the Nyanga bards, the function of the Malinke tradition bearer is not sacralized by an initiation or by divine inspiration, but is socially institutionalized. By his very birth the griot inherits his function which the society controls and masters through the rituals described above and also through the dynamics at play in the interrelations between the different social categories.

We are thus faced with a type of epic that situates a people's identity not only in its historical depth but also in the stability and perennality of its institutions, among which the transmission of the epic is not at all the least. History thus reroots itself in myth in order to find its justification and myth transforms itself into parable — the symbolic or metaphorical projection of this history — in order to find its consecration — another way in which the circle can be closed.

This example can also enlighten us on the way in which griots manipulate historical facts in epic narration. Here, more than anywhere else, history is neither a neutral archiving of the past nor an objective analytical reflexion on this past; rather, it is the integration of the past into the present and it acquires meaning only if, at the hinge between reality and symbol, it is ideological history.

Fourth example: the Fulani epic

Even though Fulani epics are most likely a borrowed tradition, they can offer an interesting case since they articulate themselves around two poles illustrating the two fundamental cultural and ideological components of this population in a region in which two types of societies have lived in succession.

In Mali the Fulani peoples nomadicized with their herds in the bend of the Niger river in which the annual flooding provided large pastures. At the end of the eighteenth century, the country was still broken into huge principalities led by *Arêbe*, the traditional chiefs who were then vassals of the King of Ségou (Bambara). In the nineteenth century, this pastoral, semi-nomadic society dependent on Bambara power gave place to the Massina empire, whose maker was Sêkou Amadou: by rejecting the Bambara yoke, enlarging the borders of his empire, forcing the Fulani to sedentarization, and imposing Islamic law, he created the

strong state of “Dîna” within which he became recognized for his qualities as legislator, political figure, man of culture and religion.

The Fulani epic tradition in this region is marked by this historical evolution, split as it is between the exaltation of the ancestral culture of the Arê and the exaltation of this more recent past that saw the rise of the Fulani as a unified, liberated people, supported by a centralized and strongly structured power base.

We have many reasons to believe that the Fulani borrowed the epic genre from their Malinke or Bambara neighbors, since it exists among the sedentary Fulani who adopted the social structure of their neighbors, whereas neither the genre nor the cast of griots can be found among those Fulani who remained nomadic. Nevertheless the Fulani of the Massina have so well assimilated this literary genre that they consider it as the best vehicle for expressing their original identity and ideology. And indeed, the epics show a split that bears witness to the ambiguity of Fulani personality and culture in this region.

One type of epic is centered on the deeds and exploits of Sêkou Amadou and on the battles fought by his descendants to broaden or pacify their empire. These epics relating battles, meetings between adversary or allied chiefs, negotiations, and confrontations are, to be sure, narrated in the epic mode with its traditional musical accompaniment (lute), but they feel much more like historical chronicles in which realism predominates and in which the characters assume their human destiny all by themselves. This epic is the memory of a fairly recent period; it can be subjected to historical criticism and be used for establishing a history of this region, so much so that Hampate Bâ could make ample use of it as a kind of popular archives for his book, *L'empire peul du Macina*.

The other type of epic is much more similar to the Bambara epic in its artistic treatment and even in its themes — often based on common experiences. It is this epic, however, that is felt to be more authentically Fulani because of the ideology it expresses: the *Pulaaku* — the ideal and distinctive Fulani way of being. In this case, the most famous and representative figures are the Arê. These chiefs, who at the head of semi-

nomadic fractions used to share this territory among themselves before the founding of the Massina empire, were known as rebels to Bambara domination as well as to Koranic rule. Hydromel drinkers, with a fierce pride, always in search of one or another cattle raid, they cherished and cultivated to excess a spirit of independence and class pride.

Performed by griots accompanied by a lute, this epic is composed of gestes comprised of well circumscribed episodes and constructed so as to highlight a fully individualized hero whose actions are the very illustration of his particularized character. Each one of these heroes is intended to shed light onto one or the other of the cardinal values constituting the ideal of the Pulaaku: reserve, pride, bravura, absolute self-control, acute sense of liberty. Thus, contrary to other epic heroes, they each have a real human and psychological density that motivates and conditions their slightest act.

The emphasis placed on the hero's motto (be it verbal or musical) in contrast to the minimal place attributed to his genealogy demonstrates the importance given to the character as an individual. As in all the other epics we have seen, genealogy of course has its place, but whereas in the *mvvet* it is traced as far back as the creation of the world, and in the *Malinke* back to the three hunters (the mythical ancestors of the Mande), in this case it is only traced as far as two or three generations, evoking the hero's real ascendants and thus allowing him to define himself through his own actions and attitudes. These heroes are archetypes: excessive as all archetypes are, they never really are models to be followed, but live symbols whose only importance is their power of evocation.

This historical substratum is used here only as an ideological representation entirely centered on a type of ethical, social and especially psychological behavior believed to be the differentiating factor between a Fulani and a non-Fulani anywhere and at any time.

As one can see, we are here faced with a new type of epic characterized by a strong interiorization in which the sole aim of the action is to emphasize a character trait or a behavioral attitude seen as the very essence of Fulani identity. This "interiorization" can be explained by the Fulani's very situation. As any other nomadic people who experienced

isolation, dispersion, migration, contact with the most varied populations, their identity could only be maintained at its very deepest level, that is to say, at the level of an ideology centered on the person. This ideology is evident in their constant preoccupation with differentiating themselves from others by nursing a specificity that designates the individual as belonging to this culture and that identifies him, even in his isolation, as participating to a community in spirit.

This “interiorization” is also responsible for making the Fulani epic esoteric to a non-Fulani — one might call it a literary genre for “internal use”. In fact, the reactions of the heroes, completely significant for a Fulani, are often baffling for anyone who does not feel Fulani culture from within.

The epic (like all other Fulani literary works) displays a certain austerity of expression and a clear preference for the suggested, the understood, and the implicit; this reflects yet another trait found in the Fulani ethic and aesthetic: reserve, modesty. We are indeed quite far from the *mvét*, where verbal oneupmanship only had a fanciful imaginary as its equal, where baroque hyperbole and the unbridling of the fantastic were perfectly suitable for the grandiose battles between mortals and immortals. Here, on the contrary, one is not surprised to find an elliptical expression and a soberness of tone and style, perfectly suited to this intense “interiorization” of heroism, this “psychologization” of epic action often centered on an act, minute to be sure, but nevertheless bearing the weight of an entire culture and the significance of an entire ideology.

Among the Fulani, the epic — like the motto — is the apanage of a particular category of griots, the *Maabuube*, who are also weavers. The Fulani who did not have “casted artisans” in their traditional nomadic societies adopted the class distinctions of their neighbors once they became sedentary. And even though they still consider griots as non-Fulani by origin, they nevertheless perceive them as the appointed bearers of their epic patrimony which, as we have seen, represents the summum of their ideology in its literary expression.

Potentially destined to this function by his very birth, the griot has his verbal and musical apprenticeship first within his family; from

childhood on, he accompanies his father or uncle, progressively becoming imbued with their knowledge and learning all his art through imitation and experience. Later on, he completes his training and refines his knowledge in the company of renowned griots. He must not undergo any specific initiation, as was the case for the mvet player and Nyanga bard, nor is he subject to the institutionalized control of his fidelity to oral tradition, as was the case for the Manding griots; the only sanction of his knowledge and talent is his success with his audience. The latter will be all the more sensitive to his art inasmuch as it is familiar with the content of the narrated stories. Indeed, in this case, just as in the others, the audience does not expect from the epic tale information on his historical past but rather an ethical as well as aesthetic emotion which, awakened by the evocation of this past, arouses exaltation and a desire to be in conformity with the ideological representations of the Pulaaku expressed in this manner.

In order to do this, the griot must be master of the word and of the lute, which will “speak” only if he masters it. This very mastery over words and music gives him mastery over men, especially through their mottos: formerly, in fact, each chief had his own appointed griot who could force him to conform unfailingly to an ideal definition of himself by reciting his verbal motto to him or by playing its musical equivalent. And in fact, for the Fulani as a group the epic plays a role identical to that of the motto for the individual. The musical mottos of the heroes — which underscore the narration of their deeds all along — speak to the Fulani as so many echoing symbols of the Pulaaku, and the epic texts themselves are like a kind of collective motto of Fulani society.

While evoking his art, the griot Tinguidji (Seydou 1972) speaks of this particular power of words and music through which a griot can “seize” a person; he also recalls those musicians who, owing to their magical mastery of the lute, are so expert they can order their instrument to play by itself.

Moving from the Fang mvet player, who laments his complete submission to his instrument, to the griot of the Fulani who, on the

contrary, proclaims his mastery over it, one can measure how from one society to another the function of these epic bards can differ even though the epic's vocation remains identical. Medium-bard, historian-griot, or fully accomplished artist, each one nevertheless holds his proper place in the system of transmission of values specific to the society for which he remains one of the main warrants.

Conclusion

The analysis of these four examples has shown a first division between mythologically oriented epics and historically oriented ones. The first type would seem typical of societies having no centralized power base and whose means of identification lie in lineage organization consecrated by ancestor cults and initiation, and in original myth and imaginary stories: the projection of their ideological representation.

The second type would seem typical of societies having a centralized power base and whose means of identification lies in the constitution of empires or states and in a hierarchical organization of social relations, the basis of their functioning.

The Fulani epic offered a counter-example since it lies at the hinge of these two types of societies and orientations and since it constitutes a borderline case in both directions: set in the context of an emerging state, it tends to become historiography; emanating from a pastoral society, originally nomadic, it becomes a sort of collective motto completely inscribed in an ideology centered on the person.

Parallel with this first division, a second one became evident in the relation that links the epic text with its producer and whose orientation is inverted depending on the sociocultural context. The bards of central Africa — initiates invested by the “charms of the mvet” or “inspired by the spirit of Karisi” — act as quasi-passive mediums through which the ancestral words come from a far-away-beyond in order to reach

the living; on the contrary, the griots of West Africa, considered as congenital “masters of words”, are for this reason the appointed bearers of oral tradition, especially of the epic for whose shaping and transmission they are responsible.

While exploring the African context, we have seen how, by the very nature of its function, common to all societies, the epic was multiform because it was associated with the type of organization of social relations specific to each population, influenced by the historical situation of each group, and conditioned by the ideology specific to each culture.

The long voyage across societies and epic has once again highlighted the considerable cultural weight of the epic genre among civilizations of oral tradition where it is still alive and its function is still pertinent.

To be sure, it would be worthwhile to multiply the examples and present them in greater detail. On this same subject, there is yet another research direction one might follow. It would be interesting, for example, to conduct a comparative study of epic-producing societies in contrast with those in which no such tradition exists. We would thus be able to better grasp the causes and conditions linked with the emergence of this literary genre, where it exists and to identify the functional substitutes (literary or other) adopted by societies where it is non-existent.

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Micheline Galley

Arabic Folk Epics

As early as the 17th century Europeans showed a great curiosity and taste for anything coming from the Orient and, in particular, from the countries belonging to the Arab-Muslim area. An increasing number of people visited the Levant and the stories of their travels were in great demand. But it is from the beginning of the 18th century onwards that the vogue for the Orient really developed with the printing, in French, of a vast collection of heterogeneous tales, including one long epic — the Story of King ʿUmar al-Nuʿmān — and known, in their entirety, as *The One Thousand and One Nights* (1704–1708). Their extraordinary success gave birth to no fewer than seventy French editions during the 18th and 19th centuries, and during the 19th century the stories spread all over Europe. The prologue itself, which serves as a framework for the Nights, appealed to the reader's imagination; this is the story of the clever Sheherazade, who saved her life by the tales she told, interrupting her narrative every morning and resuming it every evening for one thousand and one nights. Nowadays, we somehow feel that some of the Nights — such as Aladdin and the Wonderful Lamp, Sindbad the Sailor, Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves — are part of our own cultural heritage.

On the reception of Antār's epic

The popularity enjoyed by the *One Thousand and One Nights* in Europe was shared, at least during the Romantic period, by one Arabian epic: *The Romance of Antār*. Starting with the adventures of a pre-Islamic

poet, the story develops into the epic of an African slave (his status is primarily that of his mother, although he is the son of an Arab prince). To the Europeans, Antar exemplified the Romantic hero by his love of freedom and his chivalric qualities. Lamartine viewed Antar as “the typical wandering Arab, a herdsman, a warrior and a poet at the same time”, and he compared him to Homer for epic-singing, to Job for his lamentation, to Theocritus for his love and to Solomon for his philosophy (in *Voyage en Orient*). Antar’s epic was introduced to European readers in 1802 by the Viennese orientalist von Hammer-Pugstall and parts of it were soon translated into various European languages, including Danish and Norwegian. Comparative studies of Antar and European legendary cycles were made by scholars (Norris 1980: 1 – 7). Several fields of artistic creation were inspired by the subject; Rimsky-Korsakov, for example, wrote a Symphonic Suite called *Antar in Oriental vein* in 1868.

Yet while Antar has held a real fascination for European men of letters, it has not (with a few exceptions) been regarded as worthy of interest by the Arab literate elite. The main reason for such discredit lies in the profound dichotomy, in Arabic-speaking countries, between classical Arabic — which is venerated as the language of the Koran, i. e. the word of God, and also as the language of accepted literature — and the vernacular tongues which are spoken in everyday life and do not merit consideration. Therefore Antar and similar vernacular epics were nothing in the eyes of theology and grammar. This was the position of — let us say — the official literary establishment (Connelly 1986). It required courage and prestige to express a different view: the well-known 14th century historian Ibn Khaldoun did denounce what he considered prejudice in his contemporaries’ minds and their incapacity for appreciating vernacular poetry:

Les savants des derniers siècles et la plupart de ceux qui, de nos jours, cultivent les sciences et surtout celles qui se rattachent à la langue, méprisent le genre de poésie que ces Arabes ont adopté, et quand on leur récite de ces pièces, ils les écoutent avec un dédain profond. Ils s’imaginent qu’elles offensent le bon goût, parce qu’elles

sont dans une langue abâtardie et que les désinences grammaticales ne s'y emploient pas. Mais ce sentiment n'est provenu chez eux que de l'impuissance où ils se trouvaient d'apprécier le mérite de cette langue: s'ils avaient possédé la même faculté de la comprendre qui existe chez les (Arabes bédouins), ils auraient trouvé dans leur propre goût et dans la disposition naturelle de leur esprit — si, toutefois, ils avaient eu le goût sain et le jugement droit — ils y auraient trouvé un fort témoignage en faveur de la capacité que cette langue possède pour exprimer des idées. (Ibn Khaldoun 1856: 405–406.)

Apart from the fact that vernacular epics were told in a supposedly “bastard” language, they were also despised and condemned for their subject matter, as well as for its treatment. They were regarded as “vulgar”, “frivolous”, “silly”, and — to put it shortly — as “a web of lies” and as such “dangerous”. At the time of Ibn Khaldoun measures were taken in Egypt to dissuade copyists from taking any interest in this folk production: they were warned that they “must refrain from transcribing narratives, such as *Antar*, which make you waste your time and for which religion has no need whatsoever” (Wiet 1966: 103).

But what is the situation nowadays? In the Arab countries there may still exist, here and there, suspicion of any initiatives taken in favour of vernacular literature; the argument is that dialects contribute to division within the Arab community (and it is true that colonial policy, in Algeria for instance, has at times included the encouragement of dialects), whereas the development of classical Arabic is a unifying factor. But generally speaking, during the last few decades a new attitude has been observed due to the pioneering scholarship by such Egyptians as Rushdi Saleh, Abdelhamid Younis and Farouk Khourshid (in Arabic). Efforts are now being made by scientific institutions and by individuals (in several cases in collaboration with foreign researchers) to collect and preserve this tradition. The intellectuals' quest for national authenticity also runs through the discovery of folk values reflected by this “other” culture. It is precisely in order to perpetuate, for the younger generation, the fundamental values embodied by the heroes that the late Mohammed

Marzouki wrote down an adaptation of one Arab epic (*Al-Ġāzya al-Hilāliyya*, 1978); but in this case, as is explained in the introduction (Marzouki 1978: 7–8), the author chose, for the sake of logic, to leave out such elements as were irrelevant to historical events and, for the sake of diffusion, to use a “medium” Arabic. His book won the Bourguiba Prize.

As far as Western orientalist are concerned, they also, until recently, looked down on this type of folk narrative. Their criticism mostly bore upon what they called “anachronisms”, “exaggerations” in relation to historical truth, as well as “monotonous repetitions” in style. Their approach seems to be biased by standards of literary composition: “A côté des Mille et Une Nuits, les autres romans de chevalerie font pâle figure...”, says Wiet (1970: 214). “Pour devenir de véritables épopées, il manque principalement à ces récits l’élaboration littéraire qui est la marque de chefs-d’oeuvre de la littérature épique...”, Pellat asserts (1971: 114). Such judgements are likely to have been influenced by the notion of authorship:

Unable to conceive of stories as existing without some pre-existing, definitive, written text, the critic is perplexed as to the relationship between the written texts, between the book and its oral manifestation, between the original “author”, the “original version” and the omnipresent storyteller and the great variety of extant versions or “variants” of a given story“ (Connelly 1974).

Sīra, a traditional genre

However, in spite of the negative judgements and virtual interdictions which surrounded Arabian epic traditions, they have continued to exist, being passed down from generation to generation. We shall now examine the genre. Let us begin with the Arabic term *sīra*, which is generally attributed to this type of folk narrative. I will then illustrate the genre through one example of a *sīra* (my choice being based upon

my personal research and focused on North African versions): “The Sira of the Sons of Hilal” (*Sīrat Banī Hilāl*), Hilāl being the ancestor of a pastoral nomadic people of Arabia.

The word ‘*sīra*’ given to the genre — one very popular and broadly represented within Arabian folk literature — belongs to a root meaning “to go along”, “to travel”; the noun ‘*sīra*’ conveys the idea of “behaviour”, “way of life”, and eventually, “biography”. One basic characteristic of the genre thus lies in the supposed truthfulness of its contents. A ‘*sīra*’ is a narrative which “portrays in detail the fate of successive generations within a family (or tribe) from birth to death” (Hasan El-Shamy 1976).

The *sīra* we are concerned with here deals with the fate of the Hilalian family. The historical background of this *sīra* is the following: in the 10th century, the Beduin tribe of the Sons of Hilāl moved from Arabia to Egypt. They stayed there until the 11th century, when they were sent to Ifriqiyya, i. e. Tunisia (and part of Algeria) nowadays. It is this long migration which is related in one part (or the last cycle), called “The March Westwards”; in most versions the march eventually ends in dissolution due to intertribal fights between brothers:

Where is the tribe of the Sons of Hilal,
Keepers of the milch camel,
Gone are their traces or still there?
(Baker 1978)

Où est-elle la tribu des Fils de Hilal
Qui honora la chamelle donneuse de lait
Peuple de la cavale et du méhari
Sa trace est-elle
à jamais effacée ou encore distincte...
(Galley & Ayoub 1983)

When and how did the Hilalian oral tradition start? We are aware that it is based on events that happened in the 11th century. It is very likely that the tradition dates back to that period, although we do not have

any evidence of its existence until the 14th century. The question of its genesis has given birth to various theories; some of them tended to prove that there was originally a datable epic (written by one known author) which has passed into the oral tradition and has in the process “deteriorated”; others, more recent, claim that successive anonymous poets have woven heroic deeds into the *sīra* by transmitting it orally. The latter hypothesis is strengthened today by scholarly works suggesting that the *sīra* is primarily and essentially oral (Connelly’s own analysis, and also her presentation of the research on the subject by Petraček, Pantuček and Onaeva, 1986).

From the 18th century onwards, more data have come to us concerning the fabulous geographical extension (and diversification) of the Hilalian *sīra*, that is from Syria to Morocco (from East to West); and from the Maghreb to Chad, from Egypt to Sudan (from North to South). Last century, Edward Lane reports that in the only city of Cairo there were more than fifty bards specializing in the Hilalian *sīra*, and they were called after the main hero in one cycle; for example, those who chose to specialize in the cycle about the hero Abu Zayd were known as “Abuzaydiyyah”, whereas others, who devoted their performances to the cycle of the Hilalians’ enemy, Khalifa Zanati, were called “Zanatiyyah”.

Performance

As far as the transmission by oral performance is concerned (studied in Egypt by A. Hawwas, in Syria and Egypt by G. Canova), it has been perpetuated by professionals who worked in cafés and could be hired by families on special occasions: nights in Ramadan, circumcision, weddings, pilgrims’ return etc. There are, roughly speaking, two types of professionals. One type is represented — as can still be observed in Upper Egypt — by epic singers who accompany themselves on a monochord

instrument (*rabāba*). Usually illiterate, they learn the epic (all in verse) through oral tradition from their family and/or from other poets. A “poet” — since the word is only used for the singers of the Hilalian *sīra* in Upper Egypt — must, according to a folk saying, be able to sing for 99 nights from sunset till dawn (Abnoudy 1978: 17). In any case, the profession requires an exceptional memory and artistic ability; the “poet” himself, as a perpetuator of tradition, is held in high esteem. However contradictory it may seem to us, these “poets” are not Arabs; they are of obscure origin and are called “gypsies” (Canova 1981).

The second type of professional is represented by story-tellers. They tell the Hilalian *sīra* in prose versions, interspersed with poems. In some cases they resort to a written manuscript. In Syria their recitation is based upon the reading of a manuscript; the audience then evaluates their competence from the quality of their declamation (Canova 1980).

Needless to say, oral performance has nowadays fallen into decline. However, the Hilalian tradition still has a remarkable vitality in some areas. For instance, during the last two decades, hundreds of hours of the Hilalian *sīra* have been recorded by one collector in Upper Egypt: Abderrahman Al-Abnoudy. Elsewhere, transmission for family entertainment is still alive here and there, thanks to amateurs, as I have been able to observe myself during fieldwork in Tunisia. Finally mention should be made of a new phenomenon with the appearance, at festivals and tourist places, of government-sponsored folk singers, at the risk, sometimes, of developing what folklorists would call “fakelore” rather than genuine folklore.

As I have said, recitation may, in certain cases, be supported by the written text. As a matter of fact, there has been a written tradition parallel to the oral one since at least the 18th century. The volume of manuscripts is considerable: one single European library, Berlin, has catalogued no fewer than 189 manuscripts of the Hilalian *sīra* (Ahlwardt 1896; Ayoub 1978). Cheap printed books are now replacing manuscripts; they are sold, even to-day, in book shops or in the market-places of the big cities. As for the text itself, it is written in a sort of “Middle Arabic” by semi-educated authors in an effort to approach Classical Arabic.

The characteristics of the epic hero

I will now give some characteristics of the hero pattern in which genealogy, circumstances of birth and origin of name play their part and usually determine an ambiguous status. For instance, Abu Zayd. The initial situation of his cycle is as follows: a prince's wife cannot give birth to a son. One day, her attention is caught by a spectacle which is taking place in the sky: birds fighting. She is struck by the noble appearance of a solitary bird fighting alone against several others. She cannot help saying: "May I give birth to a son, as noble as this bird, even though he were black as the bird is" (Baker 1978: 4). The prayer becomes reality: she conceives a male child, and he is black. But in fact he is described in most versions as being not absolutely black but rather as "piebald", or "half black half white", or "with one eye black and one white" or "with a white head and black body", or even "white within and black externally", etc. This factor probably has something to do with the possibility for different groups, either black- or white-skinned altogether, to make Abu Zayd their own, and for certain communities in Black Africa to adopt him as their "héros civilisateur" (MacMichael 1912: 231–234). It therefore seems that — besides the exceptional qualities which our hero develops in early youth — his ambiguous features legitimate his integration into various cultures.

As for Dyab, another male hero (actually the favourite one in North Africa, generally speaking), he also has a twofold nature because of his birth. Now this is important as a key to the better understanding of his personality and behaviour with others, within the tribe. Dyab's birth takes place in the desert among wild animals, because his mother has been left alone, simply "forgotten" — the jealous co-wife says —, when the caravan left in the morning. The new-born child is then identified with jackals and is called Dyab after the jackal (*dyāb*, plural of *ḍīb*). His life is apparently marked by the same characteristics as

the jackal's: solitude, marginality, an innate knowledge of the desert, cunning, divination.

As an illustration of the hero's strength in general let us mention his capacity for swallowing considerable quantities of food and water, his ability "to fly" (according to the phrase) over huge distances when riding his extraordinary steed, the possibility he has of piercing rocks when urinating, his endurance and skill when fighting, and also his vulnerability when the enemy happens to know the secret receptacle of his might: his knees.

Heroes, male and female, are given names which are usually associated with blessing (for instance, the first name given to Abu Zayd was "Barakat" from *baraka*, "benediction"); with plenty (the very name "Abu Zayd" means "increase", "surplus" and was given to the child when he showed qualities out of the ordinary); with vegetation (Abu Zayd's mother is called "Greenery"). Epithets are also relatively frequent; a horse is usually referred to by the colour of his coat: Dyab's mare is termed after a name designating a vague colour (varying from white to grey and blue) which means, more than a colour, "a sentimental nuance" (Boris 1958, s.v. *šabba*). As far as camels are concerned, they may be called by metonymic phrases, such as "the long strides", which are also associated with affectivity. A Beduin feels due respect towards his companions in life, horses and camels:

Où est-elle la tribu des Fils de Hilal
Qui honora la chamelle donneuse de lait
Peuple de la cavale et du méhari...

says the refrain of Tunisian versions from the South (quoted above).

Perhaps the most outstanding character of all in the Hilalian *sīra* (at least in Maghribian versions), is a woman whose personality is exceptionally versatile and powerful: Jāzya, a name which can be understood as "requital" (see Baker 1978; Galley & Ayoub 1983; Mukhlis 1964). It is true that her relationship with the Hilalian sultan — she is his sister — allows her to play an important role within the tribe. Yet if one third of the political power is conferred to her (Abnoudy

1978: 38), it is because she has exceptional qualities of intelligence and wisdom. At the time when the tribe has to take decisions of high moment (for instance, before migrating westwards), the Elders ask, and follow, her advice. In all cases she is pictured as the counsellor *par excellence*, in the sense that she knows how to disentangle intricate situations (*dabbar*) and find out the most appropriate concrete solution. For the sake of her people in periods of drought, she serves as the barter between the Hilalian tribe and a prince from the city: the latter gives grain, pasture and water, and marries Jāzya (a temporary marriage, in fact, until the Hilalians decide to take their sister back). In all circumstances she appears as the protector of the tribe and the guardian of its ancestral values. It may happen that she reminds her peers of the manly qualities required of a Hilalian; she does so when the Assembly of the tribe asks why she sometimes does not conduct the choir of mourners as she should. She then answers:

O Hilal Bou Ali! Trois genres d'hommes méritent d'être pleurés à chaudes larmes et à grand cris. Le premier est celui qui affronte les périls et éteint l'incendie de la guerre. Le deuxième est celui qui accueille les hôtes pendant les années de sécheresse et de famine où donner une gorgée d'eau à l'assoiffé demande un effort sur soi-même. Le troisième est l'homme spirituel et éloquent capable de faire valoir ses droits et de défendre ceux des autres. Le reste, ô Hilal Bou Ali, ne vaut pas plus que les lueurs indécises que perçoit un homme presque aveugle; leur vie se réduit à engrosser des femmes, à enfanter des marmots qui iront grossir la masse des imbéciles et à manger avidement l'assida des fêtes dans les grands plats de cérémonie. Ils ne méritent ni deuil, ni pleurs. (Guiga 1968: 28.)

The third virtue quoted by Jāzya concerns the art of speaking and, in particular, the subtle use of "allusion". The Hilalians themselves claim to be "people of allusion" (*ahl al-ma'na*, Galley & Ayoub 1983: 44). In the oral transmission of the Hilalian *sīra*, for reasons of either ethics or aesthetics (or both), the performer has recourse to implicit, allusive, suggestive phrases; mostly in completely versified versions. A "good" poet is felt to be capable of playing on word connotation and rhyme

pun to satisfy his public's tastes (see Connelly's analysis of "musical metaphors", 1986).

Prose versions contain descriptive sequences, and also incantation (in short rhymed stanzas or longer poems). What is special about the performance, as far as the prose versions are concerned, is the interplay between narrator and audience. A narrator usually addresses his public personally in order to maintain the latter's attention: "Listen, Sir! Listen", he constantly repeats. But he may also interrupt his story to bring in his own judgement or comment, or to simulate emotion at a very dramatic passage; for example, after describing the Hilalians' defeat, one Tunisian narrator stops, apparently breathless: "let me rest", he says to his listeners, "give me a cigarette..."

What I have said above constitutes only a short introduction to the world of Arabic epics. It has been my intention 1) to remind Western folklorists of the interest taken by the Romanticists in Arabian folk literature (Antar in particular) and of its role in the field of artistic creation in 19th century Europe, 2) to give materials for comparison and research results in studies on folk epics as they have been achieved both within Arab countries and, more recently, by Western literary critics, 3) to provide information on the wide diffusion and modes of transmission of the Hilalian *sīra* — a phenomenon to be viewed in relation to the sense of cultural identity shared by different peoples throughout Muslim Arabic and non-Arabic speaking areas, and finally 4) to illustrate the characteristics of the heroes of the Hilalian *sīra* and the language of the epic.

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Asia

Jaan Puhvel

The Iranian Book of Kings: A Comparativistic View

The Shāh Nāma is the national epic of Iran, a centerpiece and cornerstone of Persian literature, much the same way as the Kalevala is for the Finns. Firdausi composed his great work exactly a millennium ago (between 975 and 1010), while we are observing merely the sesquicentennial of the Kalevala. But this time-gap contracts and loses its glaringness when we reflect that both works dipped into traditions immemorial, and the points of their redaction were mere historical accidents at the hands of superior individuals, a country squire in Eastern Iran on the one hand, and a country doctor in Eastern Finland on the other. The Farsi language has not changed radically since Firdausi's time, nor has Finnish evolved much during most of the past millennium: had Lönnrot been incarnated in the eleventh century rather than the nineteenth, The Kalevala need not have been linguistically all that different. Both Lönnrot and Firdausi delved into the more remote, eastern traditions of their tribal homelands, and both welded a tragic-tinged heroic side-epic to the magic-suffused main body of their work: the Kullervo-saga on the one hand, and in Firdausi's case the even more easterly, Sistanian hero-cycle of Sām, Zāl, and Rustam, originating in the borderlands of Iran and Afghanistan.

Mythical introduction of history

While these analogues are obvious, they should not be pushed too far. For Firdausi was not really out to collect the lays of his land but to compose an epicized history of the kings of Iran from creation down

to the end of the Sasanian dynasty and the Islamic conquest. No matter what reality Kaarle Krohn and others of the historicist persuasion later tried to impute to the Kalevala, Lönnrot would not have dreamed of toying with history, even in a legendary vein, by incorporating into his work the likes of St. Erik or Gustav Vasa. In short, Lönnrot was a learned antiquarian of the 19th century, while Firdausi was an erudite poet of the tenth, whose verse-epic bears comparison above all with such an almost coeval prose-epic of another clime as Saxo Grammaticus' *Gesta Danorum*. But while in Saxo's case the division line of myth and history is quite distinct after his ninth book, in Firdausi's instance is much less clear and considerably more controversial how to separate mythical saga-material from mere chronicle-epic. In this respect the *Shāh Nāma* more nearly resembles another of the world's neglected and misunderstood prose-epics, namely the first part of Livy's *Ab Urbe Condita*, where even in Book 5 and around the year 400 b.c.e. it is far from clear where myth-tinged legendry leaves off and sober reality-based *fasti consulares* take over.

Just as Livy used earlier Roman chroniclers whom we know by reputation or inference alone, and Saxo freely cannibalized various Icelandic sources for his monkish Latin flights of narrative and poetry, even so Firdausi was by no means without antecedents. A great official Sasanian chronicle called *Xvatāy Nāmak* fueled not only the works of various Arabic writers such as the *Chronicle of Tabarī* or *Al Tha'ālibī's* *History of the Kings of the Persians*; a prose *Shāh Nāma* had also been compiled in eastern Iran itself by the middle of the 10th century. Neither the *Xvatāy Nāmak* nor the prose *Shāh Nāma* have survived, but their material fueled a flowering of versified epic between the years 1000 and 1300. After Firdausi a number of other epics were composed, some rivalling or exceeding in length the fifty-thousand plus rhymed couplets of the *Shāh Nāma*. This bulk is barely edited and hardly known in the west, and on the whole is rather epigonic and imitative of Firdausi.

There are many ways of viewing the *Shāh Nāma*: as a work of literature, as a source of history, as a repository of tradition ranging from folktale to myth, and, to employ a rank and regrettable cliché, as

“a mirror to the Iranian soul”. A literary analysis of the work, be it esthetic, thematic, structural, or typological in relation to other epics, is largely still an unmet desideratum; I am neither inclined nor fit to undertake it. Picking out the profusion of international folktale motifs would be a lengthy but simple undertaking, for the *Shāh Nāma* scores high on the Aarne–Thompson index. Purely at random, there is an echo of Archer Taylor’s “What bird would you choose to be?” (Taylor 1965) in Feridūn’s division of the world amongst his three sons, of Potiphar’s wife or Phaedra in the attempted seduction of Siyavuš by his stepmother Sudāba, of Siegfried’s weak spot or Achilles’ heel in Esfandiyar’s vulnerability in the eyes, despite having bathed in the blood of a wonder-bird *Sīmorg*. Both Feridūn in the national tradition and *Zāl* in the *Sistan Cycle* replicate the “average hero legend” postulated by Otto Rank and Lord Raglan, with ominous infancy, exposure, miraculous upbringing, and so forth. The unwitting slaying of Sohrab by his father Rustam matches the Germanic Hildebrand-Hadubrand motif and its Slavic or Celtic parallels. This is a mere drop in the motif-index bucket.

I shall concentrate here rather on the interplay of history, myth, and national psychology, for all three are intertwined in peculiar ways in the *Shāh Nāma*. The matter of historicity never bothered the practitioners of the art of epic poetry. For them the question of myth vs. history was still blissfully neutralized; they were neither conscious euhemerizers nor aware of the potential of myth-transposition to heroic saga (Puhvel 1981: 237). Modern scholarship, however, is squarely faced with this issue. Nobody disputes that the elaborate treatment of the Sasanian kings at the lower chronological end, and the briefly sketched Arsacid or Parthian period preceding them, are essentially historical in kind, although enmeshed in legend even here, as in the romance of Khosraw Parviz, the Sasanian ruler of around 600 of our era, and the Armenian princess Shirin. But essentially this latter part of the *Shāh Nāma* is a meticulous account of the Sasanian dynasty in its attested vicissitudes, its wars with Hephthalites and Byzantium, its persecutions of Manicheans and Christians, and the usurpation of Bahrām Chōbin interrupt-

ing the reign of Khosraw Parviz. Nor would anyone seriously query the mythical nature of the Pishdadian kings of the beginnings, ranging dynastically from Keyumars via Siyāmak (who is a bleak gap-filler) to Hūšang to Tahmuras to Jamšīd, then past the usurper Zohak to Feridūn and his sons, only to peter out in internecine killings. The evidence is overwhelming that this sequence is anchored not in Iranian history but in myth that partly antedates Iranian tradition proper and can even be traced to Indo-Iranian and even Indo-European levels. The figures involved straddle theogonic and anthropogonic strata in a manner which leaves no doubt about their mythic status. They have Avestan counterparts which help trace their origins. The first king, Keyumars, is the Avestan *Gaya marətan*, literally ‘Mortal Life’, and abstract anthropogonic ancestor, apparently created in the flush of the original Zoroastrian rush to abstraction (e. g. the *Aməša Spəntas*) and subsequently “re-mythologized”. Keyumars is thus a secondary replicate of the “first man”, caught in the web of mythical logic which equated the first man with the first king, and stuck at the top of the list. The next king, Hūšang, matches the Avestan *Haošyaŋha*, whose epithet *Paraŋfāta* means ‘first-created’ and underlies the term “Pishdadian” which characterizes these kings as a group.

Tahmuras is the Avestan *Taxma Urupi*, meaning ‘Valiant Urupi’, while Jamšīd, still the most renowned figure of Iranian legend and folklore, is the Avestan *Yama Xšaēta*, the glorious culture hero and all-round sovereign who ruled a golden age and also protected his people in an underground shelter when that age perished in a terrible cosmic winter. But Jamšīd is likewise the sovereign who was brought down by hybris and lost the *farr* or solar nimbus which marked the Elect of God, to be replaced by the intrusive dragon-king Zohak, the *Aži Dahāka* of the Avesta. Zohak, whose shoulder-snakes required a daily ration of children’s brains, was subsequently overthrown by Feridūn, the Avestan *Thraētaona*, in whom a portion of *Yama Xšaēta*’s lost *xʷarənah* (in Firdausi’s language Jamšīd’s vanished *farr*) had been re-invested. The figure of *Yama-Jamšīd*, rich and varied in Iranian myth and epic, corresponds to that of the Indic *Yama*, the primeval twin

who ruled the Vedic Otherworld. Yama's range has been severely curtailed on the Indic side, and much of his mythical dossier has been transmuted into saga and attached to such epic heroes as Yayāti and Vasu Uparicara, two ancestral figures of the Mahābhārata. Ultimately the reconstructed Indo-Iranian Yama bears comparison with the cosmogonic and anthropogonic 'Twin' figures of the Indo-European northwest, the Norse Ymir and the Tacitean Tuisto. What has happened in the Shāh Nāma is that, in the manner of chronicle epics, an overlapping anthropogonic set has been genealogized, Keyumars, Hūšang, Tahmuras, and Jamšīd being passed off as successive affiliated dynasts. The same diachronic projection is found in Tacitus' Germania, where the "first man" Tuisto (meaning 'Twin') is followed by his son Mannus, whereas in the Vedas Yama and Manu (the etymon of English 'man') are represented as brothers (or at least half-brothers of the same father, Vivasvat). The proof is in the Avesta, where Yama is the son of Vīvahvant, the counterpart of the Vedic Vivasvat, not at all of Taxma Urupi.

While the Keyumars-to-Jamšīd layer of the Book of Kings thus covers epicized anthropogony, with Feridūn's overthrow of Zohak there is instead a reflection of the demon- or dragon-killer myth exemplified by Thraētaona vs. Aži Dahāka in the Avesta, Trita Āptya vs. Triśiras or Indra vs. Vṛtra in the Vedas, Thor killing giants or fishing for the Midgard serpent in Norse tradition. In the Indo-Iranian and Indo-European orbit such a myth usually attaches to a warlike thunder-god who is also a rain-bringer and thus the furtherer of vegetal productivity: Indra releasing waters, Trita Āptya belonging to a watery clan (*āptyá-* 'watery'), Frētōn in Sasanian texts being the patron of agriculture, Thor as the friend of Scandinavian *karlar*, the peasant class. The champion wields a weapon which embodies thunder, be it Indra's *vajra* or Thraētaona's *vaṣra* (from which is borrowed Finnish *vasara*) or Feridūn's cow-headed mace *gurṣ* (going back to Avestan *vaṣra*), or Thor's hammer. The Feridūn-figure is thus firmly anchored in Old Iranian, Indo-Iranian, and Indo-European myth.

Yet a strange overlay has occurred which is a test case of myth-diffusion in the Ancient Near East. Grafted onto the otherwise disruptive sequence of rulers Jamšīd, Zohak, and Feridūn is an ancient Near Eastern theogonic myth of successive generations of divine rule, the so-called “Kingship in Heaven” theme, which is first encountered in the Hurrian-based translation literature of the Hittites (the Kumarbi-Ullikummi cycle), then in the Theogony of Hesiod (the Ouranos-Kronos-Zeus-Typhon sequence) and several later Greek sources (Apollodoros, Nonnos), and in the fragments of the Phoenician History of Philo of Byblos (C. S. Littleton, see Puhvel 1970: 83–121). In that myth a ‘Heaven’ figure is overthrown and castrated by his son who has cannibalistic tendencies vis-à-vis his own offspring, but is finally deposed in turn by his own son who becomes the ruling thunder-god. The fact that there are no filial ties between Jamšīd, Zohak, and Feridūn itself indicates that the thematic imposition is an intrusive one, even running counter to the normal genealogizing instincts of the chronicler. In the Avesta, when Yama sinned and lost his nimbus, he was subsequently cut in two by his brother Spityura and assorted henchmen, which is presumably a reminiscence of the dismemberment of the Indo-European cosmogonic twin (Puhvel 1981: 308). But in Firdausi Jamšīd is instead sawed apart by the usuper Zohak, who has snakes growing from his shoulders like Hesiod’s Typhon, and feeds these snakes on children’s brains in the manner of the child-eater Kronos, who castrated his predecessor Ouranos with a saw-toothed sickle. Firdausi’s thematics are especially close in curious detail to Philo of Byblos. In Philo the Phoenician Ouranos was castrated by his successor El in an ambush after a 32-year delay, and in the same unexplained manner Zohak waited a whole century before hunting down the dethroned Jamšīd and bisecting him. Among other unexplained but unmistakable random accordances Philo’s El married two daughters of Ouranos, and Zohak married two sisters of Jamšīd. Altogether it looks as if at this late date a potpourri of by now folkloric and hence footloose motifs has become encrusted onto a segment of a heroic sequence, thus accidentally cross-breeding Indo-Iranian and Near Eastern mythic motifs. Stig

Wikander, who first realized these connections at mid-century (Wikander 1951), drew the incorrect conclusion that the “Kingship in Heaven” theme is of Indo-European origin. Its absence from India and from the Avesta is enough to administer the corrective in this regard.

With the division of the world between Feridūn’s three sons Salm, Tur and Iraj, the Book of Kings becomes a bit more attuned to diffusionary folklore and geographical reality. Salm gets Rūm (i. e. Byzantium and the West), Tur gets the east, and Iraj inherits Iran itself by ultimogeniture. Salm and Tur gang up on Iraj and murder him, but are killed in turn in due time by Iraj’s daughter’s son Manuščihr. Amidst all this unpleasantness other dimensions are added to the work. Turan enters the scene as an ever-present invasive eastern arch-enemy of Iran, with its long-lived persistent chieftain Afrasyab. It would be wrong to look for historical background in all this, for the Iranian-Turanian tug-of-war bears the hallmarks of myth. Afrasyab is already present as Fraŋrasyan in the Avesta, where he performs in the company of gods, e. g. trying in vain to capture the royal nimbus of Iran which has been deposited by divinity in the mythical sea named Vourukaša. There he is clearly labeled foreign, emitting barbarous gibberish, but in the Book of Kings a degree of symbiosis seems to exist between Iran and Turan, as when Siyavuš defects and marries Afrasyab’s daughter, and their son Khosraw later ascends the throne of Iran. The situation is similar to the ambivalent state of hostility that obtains in the Irish Book of Conquests between the Túatha Dé Danann, the ruling mythical layer, and the Fomorians who are both an external arch-enemy and yet woven into the tribal fabric by various means including intermarriage.

The epic compromise

At this point the Sistanian “side-epic” intrudes as well. This is a provincial, heroic cycle of Sistan and Zabulistan north of Baluchistan. Firdausi’s home town of Tus was located further to the northwest in

the province of Khorasan. These eastern areas were the locale of both the Zoroastrian reform and of the consolidation of the mythical tradition. The two centuries of Achaemenian imperial power in the southwest were not quite enough to effect a transfer of the cultural heartland to the Persepolis-Susa regions across a thousand kilometers of the central desert, and only with the Sasanian empire of the 3rd to 7th centuries was this shift completed. Nor does Persia proper (the province of Fars) figure as the legendary scene of the early dynasts, unlike the north, where Zohak was chained by Feridūn on Mt. Demavend in the Elborz range north of what is now Teheran, and Rustam led fighting expeditions against the demons of Mazandaran, on the Caspian slopes of the Elborz mountains. After the Islamic conquest the east remained a kind of backwater where the national tradition was relatively sheltered under a thin veneer of Islamic rule. Much as in Yazd and Kermān in the central desert Zoroastrianism itself was able to linger indefinitely, the gentry of Khorasan not only kept alive the pre-Islamic heritage but made it thrive in a robust flowering of epic poetry, coterminous with the golden era of Persian literature.

Firdausi had to make a compromise. He had for his main topic the rectilinear national tradition, but he would not wholly neglect the rich store of the Sistanian cycle either. So he effected a forced solution. While the Kayanid kings rule Iran, their Sistanian parallels intervene in multiple, usually supportive ways in the *Book of Kings*, so that they frequently dominate the action and attention of the epic.

This Sistanian dynasty is also of patently mythical origin, descended from Garšāsp, i. e. The Avestan Kṛsāspa who figures besides Thraētaona and Mithra as the co-equal recipient of one third of Jamšīd's lost nimbus. Garšāsp's club is the dynasty's talismanic weapon, handed down from Sām to Zāl to Rustam, even as in the Rāmāyaṇa Rāma is invested with weapons originating with Kṛśāśva, who is thereby shown to be a common Indo-Iranian figure. The Sistan epic is replete with spectacular episodes, such as Zāl born with snow-white hair and reared as a discarded foundling in the eyrie of a Sīmorg, the great romance of Zāl and Rudāba, parents of Rustam, and the Rustam: Sohrab tragedy of filicide which Matthew Arnold learned about in Sainte-Beuve's

review of Jules Mohl's translation of the *Shāh Nāma* and which inspired one of the great English poems of the 19th century. Rustam has a preternatural life span that stretches through and beyond the entire Kayanid dynasty and obviously has nothing to do with any kind of actual historical synchronisms.

The Kayanids are a major problem of Iranian studies. The Avesta, in both the list of *fravašis* or immanent, pre-existent modules of human individuals in Yašt 13, and in the rundown of possessors of the nimbus or *x'arənah* in Yašt 19, provides a list of eight: Kavi Kavāta, Kavi Aipivohu, Kavi Usa(ḍa)n, Kavi Aršan, Kavi Pisinah, Kavi Byaršan, Kavi Syāvaršan, and Kavi Haosravah. Anecdotal legendry about the first two, as Kay Kobād and Kay Apivēh, is found in Sasanian and Arabic sources, and echoes down even from Omar Khayyam: "And this first summer month that brings the rose / shall take Jamšīd and Kaikobad away." But the *Shāh Nāma* only treats at length three successive father-son Kayanids, Kay Us, Siyavuš, and Kay Khosraw, that is, numbers 3, 7, and 8, while Kay Kobād is a founding ancestral gap-filler. The remaining 4, 5, and 6 are unexplained padding, certainly without any generational impact. Rustam is the real hero, and Kay Us frequently serves as a mere prop for his derring-do. Kay Us is an unstable character, alternately good king and reckless fool. He subdues the demons of Mazandaran and has them build him bejeweled palaces in the Elborz mountains, where gracious cultured living and rejuvenation reign, almost an echo of Yama Xšaēta's golden age in the Avesta when heat and cold, old age and death alike were suspended. But then again Kay Us gets in trouble with the same not-so-subservient demons, and indulges in hybristic stunts such as trying to conquer heaven in a contraption powered by eagles, and it takes Rustam to extricate or rescue him. Yet he somehow has a charmed life, and God always pardons him in the end. His son Siyavuš never rules, defects to Turan, and is killed there after begetting Khosraw. Khosraw grows up in Iran, succeeds his grandfather, has a reign still intertwined with assists from Rustam, and finally disappears into a snowstorm.

All this is clearly another massive helping of myth and folklore. And yet, amazingly enough, historicist bias has mounted a serious effort

to declare the Kayanids a real dynasty, most importantly in Arthur Christensen's book *Les Kayanides* (1931). The title *kavi* itself matches the Vedic *kavi* which designates a kind of priestly magician and has no truck with royalty, but this difficulty has been finessed by such renderings of the Iranian *kavi* as Jacques Duchesne-Guillemin's common denominator 'princes sorciers' or Kaj Barr's 'sakrale Stammefyrster'. It is now clear, as a result of the investigations of Georges Dumézil (Dumézil 1971: 133–238; 1986), that the Kayanids are a dynasty concocted around the figure and kind of Kay Us, who corresponds to the shadowy Avestan Kavi Usan and in Indo-Iranian terms matches the Indic Kāvya Uśanas, who in the first book of the *Mahābhārata*, among the ancestral tales, is the resident sorcerer of the demons, professional colleague of the god Brhaspati who in a similar manner sells his services to the gods. Kāvya Uśanas is thus in league with the demons and at one point becomes their master, even as Kay Us is the conqueror and sometimes the dupe of the *dēvs* of Mazandaran. Kay Us's bejeweled Elborz palaces are matched by the riches which Kāvya Uśanas has stashed on the mythical Mt. Meru. Kāvya's arsenal of sorcery includes the power to resurrect the dead and to manipulate age, even as Kay Us possesses an elixir for healing mortal wounds (which he callously withholds from the dying Sohrab) and institutes rejuvenation procedures in his Elborz palaces. And so forth. All told, it is clear that we have here a divine sorcerer-figure of Indo-Iranian date who has been sucked into saga and secondarily dynasticized already in the Avesta. Such transposition may have to do with the Zoroastrian upheaval which not only demonized patron deities of the regal (warrior) class but perhaps extended the halo of rulership to priestly manipulators (witness the recent Iranian parallel of 1979). Firdausi simply utilized and rearranged pre-existent material.

The artificiality of the Kayanids is mirrored indirectly in their successors. We can't readily see, nor did the national tradition itself understand where these came from. Suddenly there is Luhrāsp, (allegedly designated by Kay Khosraw much against the grain of his nobles), followed by his son Guštāsp. These are both "horsy" names, like Garšāsp, and the Avesta knows a similar pair Aurvataspa and Vištāspa.

The latter, the exact pre-form of Guštāsp, partakes of an aftermath of the “Kavi” tradition in the Avesta, where Kavi Vištāspa is the patron of Zarathuštra, even as in the *Shāh Nāma* Guštāsp accepts the teachings of Zardošt. It would seem that here at last the epic might approach reality, for Zarathuštra’s historicity is not in doubt. His father’s name is given in the Avesta as Pourušāspa, another “horsy” term, but Zarathuštra means either ‘old-camel’ or ‘camel-driver’, a down-to-earth tradename like the ‘Tentmaker’ that lurks in Khayyam. The “horsy” names themselves are of an ordinary compound type like Sanskrit *Bṛhad-aśva* or Greek *Agath-ippos*, or the Old Persian *Vištāspa* who was the father of Darius I and figures in Greek as *Hystaspes*.

Yet even here the mythical intrudes. *Luhrāsp* is such a pale nonentity out of nowhere that *Guštāsp* seems the dominant member of what is really a pair. His wife’s name *Nāhīd* reflects that of the great goddess *Anāhitā* of the Avesta, and Stig Wikander (Wikander 1950) was surely right in seeing here a saga-projection of the Iranian equivalent of the Indic *Aśvinic* pair *Nāsatya* and *Dasra* in association with a goddess figure. The Iranian opposite number of *Nāsatya*, *Nāṇhaithya*, was demonized by Zarathuštra, and the abstractions *Haurvatāt/Amṛtāt*, ‘Health/Long Life’ were substituted for the actual gods, but the old mythology lingered on under the new names and even diffused all the way to the *Koran*, where the two angels *Hārūt* and *Mārūt* act out dioscuric myth in association with *Zohra*, the planet Venus (*Anāhitā* had been associated with planets ever since her *Yāst* in the Avesta; see De Menasce 1947). Thus once more it is vain to look for history in this segment of the tradition.

The advent of history

At this point it is clear, however, that the mythical part of the epic is winding down. *Afrasyab* was killed already by *Kay Khosraw*, and the Turanian dimension peters out. *Guštāsp*’s son *Esfandiyār* fights with

and is slain by Rustam in a sequence studded with supernatural intervention by assorted Sīmorgs. Rustam himself is finally despatched by his own brother Šaghād. Esfandiyār's son Bahman has a daughter Humāy (already known to the Avesta as Humāyā associated with a Vištāspa), also known as Čehrzād (Sheherazade), and father and daughter combine incestuous efforts to produce Dārāb. Dārāb had two sons, Dārā and Sekandar.

This is how the Shāh Nāma crash-lands in history. Dārāb and Dārā reflect the name Darius, and Sekandar is none other than Alexander the Great. We find a compressed, syncopated, elliptic representation of what to the west at least was the great period of Persian history, that of the Achaemenians. Not a word about the founders of the dynasty, nor of Cyrus or Cambyses, Xerxes or the several Artaxerxeses. Dārāb and his son Dārā probably hark back not to the great Darius but to Darius II and Darius III Codomannus who was overthrown by Alexander, although three generations separate them historically. The influence of the Classical Alexander Romance is palpable in Firdausi's material, but the turning of the last Darius and his external nemesis Alexander into brothers, and of the showdown into a family feud, must be native to Iran. Iranian folk tradition does in fact exhibit a curious blind spot where the Achaemenians are concerned. However such a *damnatio memoriae* is to be explained, Persepolis is known to folk memory as *Taxt-e-Jamšīd* 'Throne of Jamšīd', and the royal necropolis near it, with the colossal rock-wall tombs of Darius the Great and his successors, is called *Naqš-e-Rustam* 'Pictures of Rustam'. Possibly the contrived fraternization of the last Darius and Alexander the Great in the Shāh Nāma owes something to the Hellenic-Persian syncretism of the Parthian period, with Hellenistic monarchs such as Antiochus or Commagene in the first century b.c.e., who in his hierothesion on top of Nemrud Dag in southern Anatolia not only syncretized Hellenistic Greek and Iranian deities but traced his paternal ancestry to a Darius and his maternal descent to Alexander. Against these trends, such latter-day western-inspired efforts as the late Shah's celebration of the 2500th anniversary of the Persian empire have been unavailing.

Thus the great epic of Iran is no clue at all to the actual early history of Iran, and scholarly efforts in this direction have been misguided. But it is a treasury of mythic and legendary tradition, an epic *tour de force* which displays Iranian national psychology in its wondrous as well as deleterious aspects. Heroism and sacrifice are there, as in an acute sense of the poetic and the miraculous, but so are fanaticism and xenophobia, with a disquieting stress on revenge and martyrdom. The *Shāh Nāma* is in fact a source book for comprehending the dynamics of distressing events, from High Priest Karter's martyring of the prophet Mani in the Sasanian Empire to the Ayatollah Khomeini's persecution of the Bahai in the Islamic Republic, from the mob lynching of Alexandr Griboyedov in the streets of Teheran in 1829 to the kamikaze madness of contemporary Iranian assassins. The influence of the *Shāh Nāma* on the Iranian nation has been quite as profound as that of the *Kalevala* on the Finns, and of much longer duration. The popular first names of present-day Iranians are not the Islamic staples of Mohammed, Ali, or Ahmed, they are rather Hūšang, Tahmuras, Jamšīd, Feridūn, Manuščihr, Khosraw, Dariuš, and Ardašīr. In the midst of Islamic overlay and the Arabic impact the epic has contributed vastly to the preservation of linguistic purity, national consciousness, and native culture.

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Motif Correspondences between Mongolian Epics and the Kalevala

Very soon after starting work on this paper, I found that the subtitle which I had originally intended — “Affinities of Genre or Ural-Altaic Links” — would need to be converted into a question. It also proved necessary to restrict the study to Mongolian parallels, of motif and plot. In view of the influence already established or posited of Finnish and Russian fairytales, bylinas, the Viking sagas, and oriental narratives on sections and anterior material of the Kalevala, these Mongolian links would nevertheless mean an extension in terms of the Eurasian dimension.

Common motifs in the Finnish and Mongolian suitor theme

It is no accident that Lönnrot's Kalevala contains the motif of the bridegroom's journey and the testing of the suitors; this is, after all, one of the major groupings into which the Central Asian epics, including the Mongolian ones, may be divided (Poppe 1937: 74–68; 1968: 189–197; Heissig 1978: 9). Within the total complex of the Kalevala, this motif is used three times, with increasing force: first, the fruitless journey of the old man Väinämöinen in quest of the hand of the Maiden of the North; the similar quest of the young Lemminkäinen; and finally, the quest of Ilmarinen the Smith, with his three tasks, who finally brings the Maiden of the North home as his bride. It is hardly surprising that

if all the song material collected by Lönnrot is included, the number of testings of suitors, and of the tasks imposed on them, is much greater (Fromm 1979: 442, 472), though there is less evidence of contamination.

The journey undertaken by Lemminkäinen in quest of his bride, described in Cantos 12 and 13 of the *Kalevala*, does, however, make use of a number of motifs which are also found linked in a narrative sequence in the Mongolian epics:

- Lemminkäinen's departure on his bridal quest occurs against his mother's advice and warnings;
- Lemminkäinen leaves his mother a brush, which will bleed if he dies;
- the first task he is set is to capture an elk made of animated pieces of wood by spirits;
- the second task is to fetch the gelding of the Hiisi;
- the third task involves the slaying of a swan on the river of death;
- in the course of this, the hero is hurt by a blind man by means of snakeweed; his body is dismembered and cast into the river of death;
- shocked by the bleeding of the brush left behind by Lemminkäinen as an omen of death, his mother seeks her son, in a series of zoomorphic transformations;
- she re-assembles the dismembered body and revives it with the aid of a honey ointment and the casting of spells;
- the dead man rises up and is under the illusion of merely having slept for a long time.

In this narrative combination, comprising Cantos 12–15 of the *Kalevala*, there can be found the following narrative motifs, given here in accordance with the typology proposed for the Mongolian epic (Heissig 1979: 14–22):

- warnings and forbiddance by the parents (6.1.–8.)
- three tests of the suitors (12.7–4)
- the hunt for a magic animal (12.7.4–3)

- the search for horses (12.7.4.—4)
- the slaying of a giant bird (127.4—1)
- oracle of life (8.3—4)
- the slaying of the enemy (10.6—8)
- the dismembering of a body (10.6—9)
- the quest for a dead person (6.1.3.—3)
- revival of the dead by means of medicine (11.3.—1)

Let us take a closer look at the correspondence between these motifs in Mongolian and Finnish epics.

The initial motifs

The motif of *warning and forbiddance* by the hero's mother or father when he proposes to set out in quest of a bride or of military repute occurs in Mongolian heroic poetry at the outset of the plot: as an initial motif, it cannot be disregarded. The parents point out the hero's extreme youth (mostly only three years old), and appeal to his lack of experience, his thin blood and soft bones (Heissig 1979a: 9); the mother, in particular, emphasizes the dangers to be expected and the threat of death (Taibai 1982). In the Mongolian Geser Cycle, it is one of the hero's consorts who attempts to prevent his departure into danger, with pleas and with wiles (Schmidt 1966: 125—126; Heissig 1983b: 265). In certain other Mongolian epics, the hero even has to steal away at night from the side of his sleeping spouse, who has warned him against setting out against the enemy; the youthful heroes, too, often have to set out against the will of those who warn them. The hero is frequently warned of the perils facing him and the country by his wife, who tells him of a dream repeatedly seen (Heissig 1979b: 22—23; 1984: 99).

Linked with the motif of the hero's departure we find in Mongolian epics the motif of the *omen or oracle of life*. The departing hero (irrespec-

tive of whether he goes with the approval or not of his partner: wife, sister, companion in arms, or blood brother) leaves behind him the present of an omen in the form of an earring, ring, file, or arrow, which by changing colour, rusting, breaking, or quivering will give warning of the hero meeting peril or death and summon the partner to his aid (Heissig 1981b: 112). This motif is directly linked with that of the revival of the dead, and indeed triggers the revival or actions leading to the revival on the part of the partner (Heissig 1981a: 88).

Death and resurrection

The bleeding brush left behind by Lemminkäinen clearly exemplifies the same motif. In the Mongolian epic, however, it is not the hero's mother, but his sister who is summoned to search for him and bring about his *revival*. This sister figure, like the mother in the Kalevala, has clear affinities with the healing female shaman, with her access to supernatural powers (Heissig 1981a). This figure of the aiding sister, like that of the heroic maiden Aju mergen (Heissig 1983: 21), displays affinities with the Altaic-Turkish and Yakut female figures with similar functions, as well as the healing powers of the Germanic Battle Maiden and Swan Maiden (Hatto 1980: 267–297; Poppe 1981). Just as the sister figures of Mongolian epics, like the Swan Maiden, set out clad as a hero to search for and aid their lost, dead brother (Lőrincz 1979: 62, 87; Poppe 1979: 28–36; Meletinskij 1963: 269, 312), so also there is an affinity between the mother of Lemminkäinen, setting out in a variety of zoomorphic forms in quest of her son, and the Central Asian shamans using various animal forms in order to enter and leave the realm of the dead.

The *dismemberment* of Lemminkäinen's body, which is cut up first into five and then into eight pieces which are then cast into the river of Tuonela, corresponds to the treatment of Mangyus, the monster

which he has killed, by the hero of the Mongolian epic. The dismemberment, dispersal and destruction of the limbs and skeleton of the monster (symbol of the threatening enemy) is one of the most widely occurring motifs in Mongolian heroic epics and tales throughout the entire Mongolian-speaking region. It occurs in the Mongolian Geser Cycle (Heissig 1983b: 244–245; 1979a: 13). Dismemberment in five pieces, i. e. the four limbs and the head, is frequently mentioned and also occurs in the Kalevala (14:449).

The total destruction of the bones and flesh of the corpse is supposed to prevent the magic revival of the enemy (Heissig 1979a: 13), since this was held to be possible only by a complete skeleton. This belief is also expressed in the widespread custom in Siberia of preserving all the bones of hunted animals, and in the similar practices in the Bear Cult of the northern Eurasian peoples (Paulson 1963: 483–490; Paproth 1976: 194, 289; Heissig 1981a: 95). In many Mongolian and Yakut epics, it is only when the final missing piece of the body has been found — an eye, or a rib — that revival is possible (Bükü hara khübün 1972; Priklonskij 1891; Poppe 1977: 178–183). This knowledge of the necessity of a complete corpse for revivification to succeed is similarly reflected in the search by Lemminkäinen's mother for every little piece of the body, however small (Kalevala 15:277–304).

The actual revivification, by means of the application of ointments prepared from honey and fats (Kalevala 15:397–470) and celestial balsam, is matched in the frequently recurring ointment in the Mongolian epic with sheep-white or ermine-white medicaments which heal before midday, or before a day or a night has gone by (Heissig 1980a; 1981a: 30–33). The corpse to be revived is also anointed in the Mongolian epics with *rasiyan*, heavenly ambrosia. The plot further suggests a link with the Indian *soma* drink and its preparation from distilled milk (Guseva 1982: 89–95). Again, there is a parallel between the female figures of the Mongols' epics and tales, with their ability to revive the dead and their magical arts of healing, Lemminkäinen's mother in the Kalevala, who speaks enchantments and has the power to transform herself into zoomorphic shapes, and the figure of the healing female shaman (Heissig 1981a: 98–99). Their quest for the

dead one corresponds to the task imposed on the male shaman during his journey to the dead, of finding and bringing back the sick or dead person (Stary 1979: 192–199; Nowak & Durrant 1977).

A further parallel to the motif of revivification in the Mongolian epic is provided by Lemminkäinen's words when he reawakens, that he has lain long in deep slumber (Kalevala 15:559–560); the heroes Altai sümben hüü, in the epic of the same name (Bawden 1982: 159), Uladaj mergen, in the epic Han harangui (Poppe 1982: 50), and the revived heroes in the Geser Khan Cycle and many other epics, similarly, enquire how long they have been asleep (Heissig 1983b: 113; 1962: 92–110).

The trials

The *three tasks* imposed on the bride's suitor Lemminkäinen also have parallels in the tasks imposed on the hero (who has already been victorious in three heroic encounters) by the bride's father, who hopes to sabotage the suitor's undertaking and to destroy him. When it is recalled that the Mongolian bridal-quest and retrieval epics originally mirror the shamanic journey (Heissig 1983b: 307), it becomes clear that the suitor's tasks imposed on Lemminkäinen are derived from similar bases. Rather than relying on early oriental influences on the Lemminkäinen songs mediated by the Byzantine trade routes (Fromm 1979: 437–438), we may see here evidence of Eurasian models.

In a wide range of Mongolian epics, the hero — like Lemminkäinen — has the suitor's task of taming a heavenly horse by speaking to it in a friendly manner. Often this is described in a formulaic manner. It is not difficult to see in the bull (an embodiment of the monster-figure) which the hero-suitor in the Mongolian epic must slay or defeat (Heissig 1983b: 503–504; 1987: 79–81), the counterpart of the elk made by spirits from pieces of wood made alive which is one of the obstacles Lemminkäinen has to overcome on his shaman's-journey-like

bridal quest. The hunt for a magic elk also occurs as such in Mongolian epic, in the Geser Khan Cycle (Hummel 1973: 37–38).

Finally, the third of the suitor's tasks imposed on Lemminkäinen, in Canto 15 of the *Kalevala*, i. e. the task of slaying the swan on the river of Tuonela, has a parallel in the slaying of the giant bird Garuda in order to obtain one tailfeather of the bird as proof of the suitor's worthiness and as a bridal gift. Correspondences may be found both in the Geser Khan Cycle, and in many other Mongolian epics (Heissig 1983b: 496–500).

The hero of the Mongolian epics, too, is required to make his way to his bride, who is an embodiment of the soul of the dead (as is the case in a majority of these epics) by way of crossing a raging river or unfordable stream or arm of the sea, which is usually only possible with the aid of a horse. The “whirling of the blessed waters” in the *Kalevala* corresponds in the Mongolian Geser Khan (Part IV) to a rapidly flowing magical river, in which “seemingly horses, men, and rocks surge past each other” (Schmidt 1966: 132), and which Geser must cross. This river at the boundary of the realm of the dead, paralleled also in Soyot, Manchurian, and Tunguz shaman journeys (Nowak & Durrant 1977; Stary 1979), recurs in Canto 16 of the *Kalevala*, where Väinämöinen succeeds in crossing the river with the aid of the daughter of the Lord of Tuonela.

Another striking resemblance occurs in conjunction with this same underworld journey during Väinämöinen's flight, when he escapes through all the iron nets magically set to catch him by slipping through them in the form of a poisonous snake. In Part XIV of the Mongolian Geser Khan Cycle we find the episode where the spirit of the monster, in the form of a vast golden Fish (Altaqai jiyasun), is being pursued by the hero Geser Khan and slips through the golden and silver nets the latter has set for it by transforming itself into a golden snake (Heissig 1983b: 132, 326). It is similarly related of Lappish shamans that they have escaped from nets in fish form (Fromm 1979: 457). The figure of the “old woman with the pointed chin” in Tuonela, who meshes the iron nets to prevent Väinämöinen's escape from the underworld, is also paralleled in both Mongolian and Altaic epics, where

similar figures pursue the hero or attempt to hinder him: e. g. the old woman with “a white snout like an icepick and a pointed chin” in the Buryatic epic *Bükü hara khübün* (Ulanov 1963: 69; Heissig 1983b: 320–321; Poppe 1977: 63; Oinas 1985: 150–151).

A further parallel is provided by the suitor’s task imposed on Ilmarinen the Smith, when he is charged with catching the fearsome pike from the river of Tuonela; this resembles the hunting of the golden fish *Altaqai* in the Mongolian *Geser* epic, mentioned above. This giant fish motif occurs not only among the Mongolians and Altaic peoples, but also in northern Eurasia (Aalto 1979: 33). One episode from Ilmarinen’s second suitor’s task in the *Kalevala* also has a corresponding grouping in the Buryat-Mongolian epic: in Canto 19 of the *Kalevala* Ilmarinen is charged with capturing the wild bear and a wolf. This he succeeds in carrying out, by first forging for himself a bridle of steel and a halter of iron, with which he captures and tames the wild beasts. In the Buryat-Mongolian epics *Irensei* and *Sonhodoj mergen bühün*, the bride’s father sets the hero-suitor the task of capturing and bringing with him a giant golden dog living on the shore of the eastern sea, or else he must surrender the bride’s hand. After first persuading a reluctant smith to forge him an iron chain, shackles and muzzle, the hero is able to overcome the wild dog and bring it to his future father-in-law (Homonov 1968: ll. 7705–8081; Poppe 1980: 363–372; *Bükü hara khübün* 1972: 130, ll. 317–416; Poppe 1977: 125–127). The episode also occurs in the Mongolian *Geser Khan* epic, but here it is *Geser Khan* himself who is the smith’s apprentice (Heissig 1980b: 42–43).

Other joint themes

There are three further parallels to be mentioned, not included in the suitors’ tasks complex: the swallower motif; the return of the hero to his deserted, ruined home hearth; and the rapid growth of a fatherless and vengeful boy.

The *return of the hero* to his deserted home often provides the transition in the Mongolian epic from the bridal quest to the retrieval epic. It motivates the new departure of the hero, returning from his bridal quest to find that during his absence an enemy has attacked his home and enslaved his father and mother, relations and people. The returning hero returns to an empty home; cattle, people, and *yurt* are gone; grass is growing on the formerly hard-trodden floor; only a rusty iron grate is left among the ashes in the hearth. The hero bursts out weeping, but then is informed about the attack of the monster (Mangyus) by a speaking animal, by servants who have survived in hiding, or (most commonly) from a message left under the grate by his mother or his kidnapped wife. The same narrative motif occurs in Canto 29 of the Kalevala, where Lemminkäinen returns home to find it sacked and deserted, and bursts out weeping for his mother. Eventually, however, he follows tracks in the trodden heather which lead him to a small hut hidden in the forest. Here his elderly mother has taken refuge, and she now tells him of the attack from the north which caused her to flee.

The *swallower* motif occurs in Canto 17 of the Kalevala, where Väinämöinen, in his search for knowledge, comes to the ancient giant Vipunen, who swallows him. Only after a long period in Vipunen's stomach (during which he plagues the giant with questions and smithy work), is Väinämöinen able to escape. The links between this swallower story and the spiritual journey of the shamans have been argued by other scholars, and the variants occurring in the fairystories of northern Europe have been examined (Fromm 1979: 462–463). The same motif occurs no less than twice in the Geser cycle alone; each time, the victim obtains his freedom by threatening to cut his way out of the swallower's stomach with a dagger or other sharp weapon (Heissig 1983b: 408). A similar motif is found in the western Tibetan version of the Geser Khan epic.

It should be noted that — in contrast to the relatively non-violent version in Lönnrot's Kalevala — an episode where Ilmarinen cuts his way out of the stomach of an old man who has swallowed him does

occur, in a song not incorporated into the Kalevala and reported by Fromm (1979: 463). The motif of cutting one's way out was, therefore, also known in northern Europe.

There is also a further point of resemblance between a guzzler episode in the Kalevala and a similar one in the Central Asian epic. In Canto 17, in order to awaken the giant, Vipunen, Väinämöinen forces an iron bar into its maw between its jaws (17:77–80), whereupon he is swallowed by Vipunen. In Part X of the Mongolian Geser Khan Cycle, which tells of Geser's struggle against the black-flecked man-eating tiger (Heissig 1977: 89–101), Geser, the hero, leaps into the tiger's mouth and jams the two lower fangs with two golden bars (Heissig 1981a: 267).

The motif of *exceptional speed of growing up* of the child destined for heroic deeds, often encountered in heroic poetry and tales (AT 585), also occurs in the Kalevala, in Canto 31, where the wife of Kalervoinen (slain by his won brother) gives birth, in imprisonment, to a son. When he is no more than three days old, the child breaks out of his swaddling bands and splits his cradle in two, and at the age of three months is already plotting his revenge for his father's death. This hero-to-be is Kullervo, whose exploits then form the subject matter of Cantos 32–36 (presumably an originally distinct lay incorporated into the Kalevala).

Examples of similar rapid growth of a child destined to become a hero are also to be found in the Mongolian epics, especially those of western Mongolian origin (Rinčendorji & Dongrubjamso 1981: 62; Taibai 1982). In one particular group of Mongolian epics, which tell of the destruction of the clan of the hostile giant Mangyus down to the last member thereof, the son of the dead monster, prematurely forced out of his mother's womb, speaks and bewails that he will not be able to remain alive to take revenge for his father (Bawden 1982: 75). A similar plaint is found in the epic *Agi ulayan gayan-u Altan yalab küü*, recorded in the Bargha region, where the son bewails (Heissig 1985: 108):

Alas that I never reached the tenth month,
 Alas that I never sucked my mother's milk,
 Alas that I took no revenge for my father ...

Similarly, in the Kalevala, Kalervoinen's son's words are cast in a similar frame (31:109–113):

Presently when I am bigger,
and my body shall be stronger,
I'll avenge my father's slaughter,
And my mother's tears atone for.
(Translation by W. F. Kirby)

There is one more motif, widely encountered in Mongolian epics, which also occurs in the Kalevala: that of the *address to a weapon*. In Canto 6 the young Lapp, Joukahainen, makes a crossbow in order to kill his hated enemy Väinämöinen. The bow of the weapon is described as being decorated with the figure of a horse on the back, the bend with that of a woman, and the nock or groove with that of a hare; and this description matches the formulaic descriptions of zoomorphic decorations on bows in Mongolian epic, and tales (Heissig 1983c: 239–244).

Before Joukahainen shoots at Väinämöinen, he address his crossbow in the following manner (6:156–158):

Do thou strike, O birchwood arrow,
Strike thou in the back, O pinewood.
Twang thy best, O hempen bowstring!
(Translation by W. F. Kirby)

This whispered address to the weapon, simultaneously a spell and the setting of a task (*sibsilekü*), is also found in the Mongolian epic, and examples may be cited from throughout the Mongolian-speaking area (Halén 1973: 88, 210; Poppe 1975a: 22, 87; Poppe 1975b: 48; Poppe 1955: 98, 188). In the epic Tsewün xara nüden xü, for example (recorded around 1900 in the Khalkha region by the Finnish Altaic scholar G. J. Ramstedt), the hero commands his arrow, before he shoots it, to (Halén 1973: 200):

... cut his backbone into pieces,
Tear his spine out in tiny fragments.

There is a similarity here with the task with which the giant monster charges his arrow before firing it at the hero in the Mongolian epic *Ayula Khan* (Halén 1973: 16):

Carve your path into his kidneys,
Gouge through his guts, whether thick or thin;
Once you have split in half his black liver,
Slice your way into his black arteries!

In another recently recorded epic, the western Mongolian *Naran gayan-u kü* (*Naran gan-u tuyuǰi*) (Rinčindorǰi 1981: 115), the hero is in combat with the giant *Tegsi sira bodong*, and after slowly stretching his bow, he commands his arrow:

Tear and penetrate the living veins
Of *Tegsi sira bodong*! His chest
Is the size of a wooden trunk: make in it
A gaping cavity wide enough
To house a laden camel,
And plug it with scarlet blood...

This motif of the addressed arrow, which then returns to the hero, also occurs in the Mongolian *Geser Cycle* (Heissig 1983b: 142), including an early Tibetan version from Ladakh.

Genre-specific similarities or diffusion of motifs?

In conclusion, it needs to be emphasized that no attempt was made here to show any direct influence of the Mongolian epic on the Finnish *Kalevala* poems. It did, however, seem necessary to draw attention to the parallels in the Mongolian epic between many of the motifs incorporated by Lönnrot into the *Kalevala* from a large number of old Finnish songs and lays. Nor has this been a comprehensive overview;

the examples given here will have to suffice. Many of the similarities may indeed simply be attributable to the norm-bound nature of heroic poetry; but there must also be much which is to be attributed to the great migrations of the peoples of Eurasia a millennium ago, which have been shown to have spread motifs from Tungus, Yakut, Evenk, Oroch, and Manchurian folk narrative throughout Eurasia (Kõhalmi 1980).

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'Jam-dpal rgyal-mtsho

The Singers of the King Gesar Epic

King Gesar is a great heroic epic collectively created by the Tibetans and the Mongolians, produced and developed on the rich basis of ancient Tibetan folk literature such as myths and legends. The protagonist, a hero bravely defying brute force, overcoming difficulties and obstacles, goes on expeditions north and south to subdue demons and monsters, fighting for the benefit of the people with amazing willpower and miraculous strength. Through the description of his heroic deeds, the epic celebrates the triumph of justice and light over evil and darkness. The epic reflects an important stage in the history of the nation and the basic structure of society against its broad historical and social background, with tremendous impetus and superb artistic technique. It expresses the hopes and high ideals of the people; it describes the complicated relations between different nationalities and the process of their unification; it shows the inevitable development of social history. Moreover, it also reflects the religious beliefs, customs and moral thinking of the ancient Tibetan people, with their distinctive national style and local characteristics.

The living epic of many nationalities

Once this epic had passed into the Mongolian region, it rapidly spread and began to be incorporated into traditional Mongolian culture. As it underwent re-creation by the Mongolians, it became a national epic, with its own special style, and was highly regarded by the Mongolians.

It holds an important place in the history of Mongolian literature, being regarded, along with *The Secret History of Mongolia* and *Jāngar*, as one of the three peaks in classical Mongolian literature.

King Gesar embodies the wisdom, talent and creative power of the Tibetans and the Mongolians. It is the fruit of their wisdom and the treasure trove of their knowledge. For a long time now it has been widely distributed over the Tibetan and Mongolian regions as well as among other minorities in our country, and it is deeply loved by the various peoples.

The structure of King Gesar is magnificent, the content rich and abundant. During the long process of handing-down and development, it has been continuously enriched and improved. According to the materials now available, it consists of dozens of volumes, several hundred thousand lines, more than ten million words, not to mention numerous versions in other languages. Not only is it a piece of outstanding literary work, it also has high academic merit and is an important source of information. It is an encyclopedia of the ancient social life of the Tibetan and Mongolian peoples, their national history, economy and culture, social class relationships, communication between nationalities, social ideology, moral concepts, customs and habits, religions, etc. Like the outstanding Greek epics, Indian epics and *Kalevala*, King Gesar is a brilliant pearl in the world's cultural treasure and is an important contribution made by our country to human civilization.

Compared with many of the world's famous epics, King Gesar has special characteristics and merits of its own, one of the most important being its continued popularity among the people. It is still a living work. In the process of diffusion one of the major contributory factors has been the role of the extraordinarily talented epic singers. They are the real creators, successors and spreaders of the epic. They are true artists of the people, great poets earning warm popular respect. In them we can see the wisdom, talent and creative spirit of the masses. If it were not for their extraordinary talent and untiring work, this great epic would have been submerged in the long deep river of history, and the Tibetan and Mongolian peoples, and the whole Chinese nation, would have lost an invaluable cultural treasure.

Who were the singers?

The Tibetans are a nationality renowned for their singing and dancing, and praised as “an ocean of songs and dances”. Almost every Tibetan can sing and dance and tell some folk stories. The Tibetans live on the Qing Zang Plateau known as “the Roof of the World”, where communication and education are at a very low level. Before the 1950s, most of the people there were illiterate. Under such special conditions the people (including a great number of monks) depended mainly on the various forms of folk art created by themselves to satisfy their cultural needs, and each district had its own rich and special variety of songs and dances.

This art of singing and dancing was created, performed and enjoyed by the people themselves. They were performers as well as audience; they were creators as well as admirers, critics and diffusers. This is how the rich and variegated Tibetan songs and dances, as well as other folk works, are created, preserved and handed down.

There are three other artistic forms beside the folk song and dance, namely the Tibetan play, *Reh-ba* song and dance, and King Gesar. They were performed by folk artists who became professionals as time went on and depended on this for their living. In the course of time three kinds of artists emerged.

Compared with other folk artists, the singers of King Gesar have certain characteristics.

Characteristic 1: Freedom of performance

The mode of performance was flexible and varied, seldom restricted by time, place or circumstances. In terms of the mode of performance, the epic singers are in some ways similar to the *Reh-ba* artists.

Unlike in the Tibetan play, their performance did not need a theatrical environment and had no restrictions. They could sing under the blue sky, in manor houses, in the fields or the vast pastures, in the castles of noblemen or in the poor huts of the serfs, and they could perform regardless of day or night, oblivious of seasons or weather conditions. Festivals, weddings, celebrations and gatherings in the villages or in the pastures would be occasions for them to show their talent. They contributed significantly to the spreading of knowledge, activated the cultural lives of the people and were deeply loved by them. This is also an important reason why King Gesar has remained popular.

Usually, there are no restrictions on what they sing or narrate. They can sing whatever they like or whatever they know best. Sometimes, however, they have to sing what the audience or the host asks them. After thorough field investigation, we found that they could be divided into three classes on the basis of the level of their artistic skills.

The first class consists of artists with a high level of skill who enjoy fame and great influence among the masses. They could sing and narrate according to their own preference and assessment of what was suitable for a particular situation, and did not have to obey others. They could refuse to sing if they did not receive proper respect. They were all highly talented, with a strong sense of devotion to and esteem for their nation. They cherished a deep love for the art of epic singing, taking the presentation of King Gesar as a sacred cause.

The second class would be on the middle level. They could generally narrate many parts, but did not know the text well enough to be able to narrate any part requested.

The third class would be those of low skill. They could only narrate extracts from the whole epic; some could only narrate particular sections. They were usually untalented and poor, and had to rely for their living on singing and narrating King Gesar.

Characteristic 2: Wandering bards

These were homeless, and had to roam about in the mountains and in the pastures. In this respect they were like the Reh-ba artists. Usually they had no fixed abode; their footprints could be seen everywhere, on the hills and in the valleys of the high plateau. Their beautiful songs could be heard floating over the wide pastures and in the villages. Often they would accompany the worshippers on a pilgrimage, or they would travel with Reh-ba artists, helping each other. These performers were carefree, open-minded and experienced. They knew many dialects, and were very knowledgeable in the habits, customs, legends and geography of the Tibetan region.

One of the famous singers of King Gesar, Za-ba, is a good example. Accompanying the pilgrims who travelled around the mountains to pay their religious homage to the Buddha, he visited almost all the well-known sacred mountains and lakes, and travelled to many places of historical significance and scenic beauty. He paid homage three times to the sacred mountain of Za-ri, which is located near the border of the country and is famous for its height and perilous peaks. He visited the old cities of Jiang-zhi, Qiong-jie, Nai-dong, and Sa-jia, and wherever he went, he performed. He can express his rich emotion and experience in his epic singing, for he cherishes a great love for the mountains, rivers and lakes of his homeland. His performance has thus been enriched, and is heroic and bold in style.

Characteristic 3: The weak social position of the singers

The epic singers mostly came from the families of serfs, herd-slaves or other poor families. They had to perform in order to support themselves. The upper class regarded them as beggars. In fact, they were as

poor as beggars, except for the one skill they possessed, with which they had to earn money and support their families. If they fell ill, and unless anyone gave them alms, they would have to take the whole family begging. Before 1949, though many of these artists were highly talented, they were at the bottom of society, and intolerably poor.

In former times, folk artists who sang in Tibetan opera and performed the Reh-ba dances had to pay poll tax (to show bondage to the serf-owners) and song and dance tax. Epic singers did not have to pay these taxes; instead they had to pay “begging tax”, as the beggars did, which gives an indication of their living conditions and social position.

Once the prevailing social conditions at that time are understood, it is easy to find a rational explanation for the fantastic stories full of superstition and the solemn religious ceremonies of various kinds which the folk artists performed: they wished the people to believe that their talent for singing and narrating the epic of King Gesar was given by God, rather than a demonstration of their own talent.

Modes of performance

As mentioned above, in singing and narrating King Gesar the singers did not need any stage properties, nor were they restricted by time or circumstances. They could perform at any time and place. However, certain formalities were in the past generally observed.

Form 1: Burning of incense and the possession of singers

When the singers started to sing and narrate, they would first set up an incense burner table; a big portrait of King Gesar would be hung in the middle, along with pictures of his thirty heroes and imperial concubines

on each side. On the incense burner table, weapons such as bows, arrows, swords and spears, which were believed to have been used by King Gesar, would be placed for worship. Some singers would place a statue of King Gesar; some would worship the God of the Lotus, Zhu-mu, Jia-cha, Dan-ma or the statues of other generals of the King. After lighting several butter lamps and placing a few bowls of “clean water” for the Gods being served, they would burn incense and pray in front of the pictures. Then they would hold beads in their hands and sit with legs crossed, eyes closed, palms together and begin reading the Buddhist scriptures. This is to ask King Gesar or a certain general (each artist would worship a different general) to make his presence and enter the singer’s body. After a little while, the singer would shake his head, shivering all over and dancing with joy. It was said that by this time the “sacred spirit” had already entered him, and he would take off his hat, place it in front of the portraits and start to sing and narrate.

Form 2: Singing while presenting pictures

Some singers would bring with them the scrolls of King Gesar’s story, which was called Zang-tang in Tibetan and was similar to the Buddhist scripture stories. When they sang and narrated, they would hang the scroll high in the middle and would point to it as they sang. These Zang-tang were usually drawn by the same artists as the portrait of Buddha. Some of them were very skillfully drawn and some were embroidered in various styles.

Form 3: The use of the ceremonial hat

In the past, all the epic singers, whether men or women, old or young, would wear a hat, which was called a Zhong-sha in Tibetan. ‘Sha’ means a hat which is worn when telling stories. These hats were made

of felt or silk, were rectangular in shape and decorated with agate, coral or pearl. When the singers started to sing, they would hold the hat in the left hand and describe its origin and value with lyrics in prose or in verse, and by gestures with the right hand.

Usually the hat would be described as the whole world, and the top of the hat was the center and the homeland of the Tibetans, as well as the territory of the ancient mountain kingdom, the King of which was Gesar. Sometimes, the four edges of the hat were said to be the four points of the compass and the ornaments were supposed to be rivers, lakes and seas. Then the singers would tell the audience that King Gesar was the greatest hero on earth, who controlled the fate of the whole world, and that they would only tell a small part of his numerous heroic deeds; only then would they go on to the main story.

Sometimes the singers would present the hat as a rich mountain with the top of the hat as the peak. The decorations would now be rich deposits of gold, silver, copper and iron. Then they would go on to say that it was only because King Gesar had vanquished all the demons and protected the precious mountain that we could have this abundant wealth and enjoy a peaceful life.

This description of the hat acquired a set form, accompanied with its special melody. It was called *Sha-xie* in Tibetan, meaning the worship of the Hat. This was equivalent to a prologue for the purpose of attracting the audience's attention. There was no definite content for the lyrics, which could be long or short, and varied according to time, place and singer. They could also be composed on the spot. Some of the lyrics were just like the epic itself, full of rich imagination, interesting and well-chosen metaphors and in simple and beautiful language.

These hats were not worn on ordinary days; they were only produced with considerable ceremony, as a stage property for performance. The singers would eulogize the hats in elaborate language, rendering them highly mysterious, so that the masses would think that the hats had really been blessed, or in Tibetan, *Jia-chi*, by King Gesar and they would respect them as sacred things and prostrate themselves in worship of them. Their awe of the hats far exceeded that of the artists.

Form 4: The use of the ceremonial mirror

Before starting to sing, some artists would place a bronze mirror on the incense-burner table. They would first recite from the scriptures and pray, and then began to sing while looking into the mirror. Those who sang the epic in this way would claim that they did not know the epic at all, but only acted as narrators, telling the people what they saw in the mirror. Without the mirror, they could tell nothing. Of course, ordinary people could see nothing in the mirror but their own reflections; this would be explained by the fact that they were not related to the Gods. Only those who were fortunate enough to have been related to the Gods in some way could see the image and acts of King Gesar in the mirror.

In Lei Wu Qi County in Tibet, there is a sixty-year-old man named Awang-jiazuo who sings and narrates in this way. He used to be secretary to a serf-owner, and is able to write in Tibetan and to make recordings himself. Whenever he performs or makes recordings, he always puts a mirror, a piece of smooth stone and a bowl of clean water on the table. According to him, without these things he can neither tell nor write. He has already recorded and compiled five volumes so far and still continues to work.

There were also performers who would hold a piece of blank paper in their hand and sing and narrate while reading this “heavenly book”. These were the customs followed by epic singers in the past, as they roamed about; nowadays epic singing is not usually accompanied by any ceremony.

The best singers still active

In recent years, several of the folk artists who sing and narrate King Gesar have been recorded. In August, 1984, performers from seven provinces of China, namely Tibet, Qinghai, Gansu, Sichuan, Yunnan,

Inner Mongolia, and Xinjiang, gathered in Lhasa, capital of Tibet, to perform. Thirty-six outstanding singers came to the meeting. We made interviews and investigations on eight of them with special talent. We discovered that all the outstanding epic singers have two obvious characteristics in common: they all have an amazingly good memory and they are full of enthusiasm when performing. The following are some examples.

Za-ba is now eighty years old and lives in Bian-ba County in Tibet. He came from a serf's family and is the youngest of three brothers; the other two died long ago. He told us that he could tell stories of King Gesar when he was only nine and could perform fairly well when he was about eleven or twelve years old. He said there were some epic singers in his home village who could tell the stories of King Gesar, and he often went to listen, but had never tried to learn. Later on, he married and soon had two children; life became even harder. In order to support his family and to entertain his friends, as well as to amuse himself, he began telling stories of King Gesar to his neighbours and friends after finishing his hard labour in the fields. In turn, they would give him some food or old clothing for his children. Soon he could tell and sing better and better; his interest in singing increased, and so did his reputation among the masses, who invited him to sing more and more often so that, finally, he gave up farm work and devoted himself to narrating King Gesar.

Za-ba claimed that he could narrate forty-two parts of King Gesar. In 1979, the regional Government of Tibet invited him to Lhasa to narrate, and a special group was organized to record and compile what he had sung and told. Twenty-one volumes have now been completed and the preliminary statistics show there are over four million words and four hundred thousand lines of poetry. Three of the volumes, "The Battle of Gate Peak", "The Battle of Pine Peak" and "Nine Scriptures of Divination in Fairyland", have been edited and published. To reward him for his great contribution to the work of saving King Gesar, in August last year the Tibetan Autonomous Region Government held a special party for him on his 79th birthday, and gave him a financial

award and a certificate of merit. The twenty-second volume is currently being recorded.

Yu-mei is a young woman singer in her twenties, from a herdsman's family in Suo County, Tibet. Her father was also an epic singer and used to sing King Gesar to her, but he never deliberately taught her. Only after her father's death, when she was seventeen, did she start her career of narrating King Gesar.

Yu-mei claimed that she could sing seventy parts, which is the largest number claimed. It should be noted that every singer has his own version of the parts ('volumes' and 'chapters') of the epic, which, therefore, cannot serve as a measure of length. Yu-mei's three volumes, "The Battle of Plum Peak", "The Battle of Pagoda Peak" and "The Battle of Pavilion Peak", have not been found in any manuscript or lithograph copies, nor have they been recorded from any other singers. Four volumes have now been completed, comprising a total of forty thousand lines and more than one million words. The fifth volume is being recorded.

How many parts does Yu-mei know, and how many lines do they contain? What is the merit of the versions performed by her? It is impossible to answer these questions before the work of collection and editing is complete. But we can see even from the four parts already recorded that Yu-mei really is a gifted artist with an individual style of her own. After hearing a performance by Yu-mei, the old singer Zaba was effusive in his praise of her "fine narration" and "exalted nature".

Ci-deng-duo-ji, a singer from Ma-xin County in Qing-hai Province, is now 55 years old. He claims to be the incarnation of General Xin-ba under the White Tent King and to be able to narrate "The Birth of Xin-ba", which is missing from the existing manuscripts and lithograph copies. He drinks some wine before embarking on his narrative so that he may attain a growing state of ecstasy as it proceeds. When he is very drunk, he rises to his feet, enters into a frenzied dance and bursts into laughter or tears. He may become so frenzied that he is in danger of losing his self-control. He seems to fall under the spell of ghosts

and spirits and to be in the state which Plato described as unconscious and bewitched, as in the realm of poetry. He dances and sings as the beautiful verses flow in a constant stream from his mouth; this only proves the astonishing power of his memory and performance. The local people hold him in great respect. Otherwise he is like any ordinary herdsman and of average intelligence.

As a performer Yu-mei stands in a class of her own. She is shy and quiet, and easily blushes even at the slightest jest. But when she sings King Gesar, she becomes a completely different person, like an actress on a stage. Being so sensitive, she is able to give a convincing performance, expressing surprise and danger, acclaim and scolding, pleasure and anger according to the events in the plot.

Such other artists as A-da, Yu-zu and Geh-sang-duo-ji from Tibet and Ang-ren from Qing-hai Province are also very talented and each has a performing style of his own. They all know many parts of the epic, and the local people treat them with great respect. I shall not, however, be examining them in detail in the present paper.

Actual tasks in collecting and editing King Gesar

Despite the great contributions to creating, inheriting and spreading the epic of King Gesar made in the past, these folk performers led very poor and miserable lives. Although the great epic they sang and narrated for generations was loved by the people, it was never systematically collected or published. Large quantities of first-hand materials still await discovery, not to mention the work of translation.

Since the establishment of the People's Republic, the Government has placed great importance on the saving of King Gesar. In the 1950s, a large-scale project was carried out for collecting and compiling the work. During the Ten-year Turmoil in our country, however, King

Gesar, like many other parts of our cultural heritage, suffered disastrously.

In recent years, the Government has again organized a group of people to continue the work of salvage. The social and economic position of the ballad singers, and their working conditions, have been significantly improved. For example, Za-ba, the old singer, has been elected a member of the Political Consultation Committee and the Literary and Art Federation of Tibet. Many other folk artists are also well cared for. These beggars of the past, homeless and discriminated against, are now regarded as "state treasure". They are loved by the people; their talent is protected and respected, and with the restoration of political stability and the progress of economic reconstruction, the folk artists will be able to make an even greater contribution to epic studies and the development of our national culture. Nowadays, the work of collecting and compiling King Gesar is one of the major items for scientific research and is scheduled for completion during the seventh Five-year National Plan of Reconstruction. On completion of this work, a comparatively standard copy will be compiled.

Apart from the continuous efforts to collect the manuscript and lithograph copies scattered among the people, one crucial part of our work of saving the epic includes the task of recording the folk artists themselves. This is actually the most urgent task at present, because many folk singers are very old and weak. As Elias Lönnrot, the compiler of the Kalevala, once said with deep emotion, "Really, if he (the eighty-year-old ballad singer Arhippa Perttunen) had died before I visited him, then a large part of our ancient songs would have died with him." His words apply with equal validity to our present work of collecting and rescuing King Gesar.

Scientific research into folk singers has both a theoretical significance and a practical value. The great philosopher and critic of Greek literature Plato discussed this in the first essay of his Dialogues. We may consider ourselves very fortunate that we still have among us many great singers skilled in the art of performing the mighty heroic epic of King Gesar and spreading it wherever they go "on the roof of the

world". In them we have a vast cultural richness and national treasure of which we are extremely proud.

The faithful recording and necessary editing of the folk singers' narratives, the scholarly analysis of their artistic practice, creative experience and performance, and the process of creation, diffusion and transmission of King Gesar in the cultural history of Tibet are among the challenging tasks facing researchers; at the same time it is our aim to arouse the interest of more people in their artistic heritage.

It is impossible in such a brief account as this to discuss the epic in any greater detail. What I have tried to do is simply to give our foreign friends some insight into our work. We sincerely hope to be able to continue exchanging experiences in the field of folklore research and thus to enhance our scientific research in the future too.

Silke Herrmann

The Life and History of the Epic King Gesar in Ladakh

The epic of King Gesar is widely spread within Tibetan civilization. One finds it in Mongolia, Tibet, Ladakh and Baltistan, in Sikkim, Bhutan and Nepal. It is assimilated into the oral traditions of two spheres of religious influence: the Buddhist and the Islamic. It is told in the Sino-Tibetan, Indo-Aryan and Mongolian language groups. These facts confront anyone interested in epic research with a series of questions worthy of investigation, e. g.: What kind of changes did the Buddhistic epic of King Gesar undergo when it was taken up by a tradition influenced by Islam? How do the different groups of languages effect the composition of songs and the use of formulas? Despite the potential importance which this unique tradition might have, international epic research has tended to overlook the Gesar epic up to now despite a rather voluminous secondary literature.

This is not the place to list all the publications concerning the Tibetan epic; I will only mention the milestones. The epic of King Gesar became known in the West in 1836 through a translation from the Mongolian by Schmidt. Starting in 1900 till 1941 the Moravian missionary Francke published one version of Upper Ladakh and one of Lower Ladakh in several fascicles. It is noteworthy of Francke's editions that they are based on oral performances. In 1931 David-Neel published *La vie surhumaine de Guésar de Ling*, which was followed in 1956 by Stein's *L'épopée tibétaine de Gesar*. In 1959 the same author published *Recherches sur l'épopée et le barde au Tibet*, which is still considered today as authoritative on all questions concerning the Tibetan epic. In this connection Herrmann's *Das Nationalepos der Tibeter*,

Gling König Gesar which appeared in 1965 should be mentioned. Next to these publications designed for Western research there are also numerous manuscripts and prints in Tibet. I just wish to mention the Gesar edition of Bhutan, which began to appear in 1979 and is planned to consist of 31 volumes. However, as pointed out above, we are not only dealing with manuscripts and editions, but also with notations of oral performances. And because oral tradition is still functioning in Tibet and neighbouring countries, one can still hear this epic sung today.

A living oral epic

In the summer of 1984 I flew to Ladakh to collect oral versions of the Gesar epic. Ladakh, although politically belonging to India, is imprinted by Tibetan culture (in fact, it is called Minor Tibet), and the Gesar epic is known everywhere. Managing to find several narrators in a short period of time, I taped altogether 70 hours of performance.

I will now present a short summary of the Gesar epic as it is told in Ladakh today. The core of the epic consists of four parts, which are in general called *Ling*: Lhajul, Lingkar/Skyesrabs, Dutjul, and Horjul.

1. (Lhajul): The land of Lingkar is without a lord and lawlessness rules the kingdom. Being obliged to the people in Lingkar, the king of Gods promises to send one of his sons. He asks his three sons, but only the youngest is willing to go. The father is unable to be parted from his youngest son, so he organizes a competition to let fate decide. The youngest loses, and has to go. But in order to be reborn in Lingkar, he must first die.
2. (Lingkar): The youngest son, Gesar, is reborn into a low-class family in Lingkar. No one knows he is to be the future ruler. Only the demons recognize the future king and try to kill him.

He destroys them although still a baby. Gesar passes his youth with various escapades. The climax and end of his adolescence is the winning of the girl Tukuma, who is destined to be the wife of King Gesar. The boy asserts himself as king by completing several deeds of heroism.

3. (Dutjul): Gesar is enthroned. His next task consists of visiting the land of demons to kill a particularly vicious specimen of huge dimensions. Having approached the palace of the absent demon, the wife lets Gesar in and the two pass the time together till the demon comes back. The she-demon helps Gesar to kill her husband. Now it would be time for Gesar to return to Lingkar, but the she-demon offers him the food of forgetfulness; so he forgets his home and his wife.
4. (Horjul): During Gesar's absence the king of Horjul carries off Tukuma to marry her. Finally regaining his memory, Gesar leaves the land of demons. Gradually he destroys the army of the Hor, though rarely in a duel, as would be expected in a heroic epic, but rather by means of magic, cunning and snares, or supernatural powers. Gesar kills the king of Horjul and the children who were born to Tukuma. He takes his wife back to Lingkar, where she has to do penance. Later she will again be established as queen.

Characteristic of performing the Gesar epic is the interspersing of songs into the narration. Prose and songs take up about the same space, the balance sometimes shifting in favour of the songs. The narrative elements deal with the action, while the so-called "epische Breite" is found in the songs. The narrative parts are free, while the verses of the songs are bound to a certain number of syllables. Only speech is sung, but not all the speech. The songs are sung to different tunes, which are connected rather to the mood which is to be conveyed and less to the personal dramatics. According to the quality of the singer, one can distinguish eight or more tunes. The songs are never accompanied by an instrument.

Based on observations which I carried out during my fieldwork in Ladakh, I would like to make some remarks on the state of Ladakhi oral tradition and the rhetorical scenery.

Every oral tradition exists by means of telling and the shaping of its narrative material by competent narrators. Even today you will find in every Ladakhi village at least one person who can tell the Gesar epic. But indispensable to an oral tradition is the interest of a broad population, and this is lesser than in earlier times. I am under the impression that the Ladakhi narrative tradition is in decline. This was confirmed by educated Ladakhis. The reason for this decay is to be found in the diminishing interest of the younger people in preserving their own culture. The values of the West, with its peculiarly trivial culture, hold a great attraction for the Ladakhi youth. Furthermore, the improved educational system, as desirable as it may be from another point of view, is also partly responsible. An oral tradition is kept alive by people who can neither read nor write. Connected to the knowledge of writing is the concept of reproducing a text in the same words over and over again, and this hinders spontaneity and creativity. (Nurup Namgyal, the only one among the tellers who could write and read, carried a note book to my taping session. He assured me that he had only written down the names of the actors.) A person familiar with writing will try to repeat a text rather than create it, and repetition means death to a living oral tradition.

The impact of radio programs

The Ladakhis themselves take pains to keep the tradition of Gesar alive, but the effects are still obscure. All India Radio Leh, the national radio in Ladakh, broadcasts every month for half an hour one part (called Ling) of Gesar in the winter time. For that event singers from all over Ladakh are invited. One cannot avoid second thoughts because of this procedure. This method assures that singers who can finish one Ling in half an hour will be favoured. Other singers, whose narration might be more desirable under different criteria, will be neglected. Nurup

Namgyal, aged 37, mentioned above, initiated this program. He is widely known as a narrator of the Gesar epic: first, because of his program, in which he has recited himself, secondly, because of his beautiful voice and his flow of narration, which displays neither jumps nor leaps. Nurup was also taped by me, and he was in fact able to finish the whole Gesar in three hours, the ideal candidate for his program! I, on the other hand, was surprised at the shortness of his recital, e. g. Rahim-ul-la took about 16 hours for the same part. Nurup also has clear ideas of how to tell the epic in the “right” way. When he introduced me to a storyteller from his village, he remarked that this man had not mastered the beginning of the epic. Nurup also regrets that there is no authoritative text for the Ladakhi version of the epic. In his opinion this is one reason why the Ladakhi tradition is condemned to death. I have mentioned Nurup, whose ideas about a living oral tradition deviate considerably from ours, at such length because he will take an active part in forming the Ladakhi oral tradition of the Gesar epic in future years.

Rules of performance

Traditionally the Gesar epic is only performed in winter, because people then have time and leisure for reciting and listening. It is not only a practical reason that keeps people from narrating in summer, when all are busy working in the fields. There are also traditional rules, and social pressure ensures adherence. But I was there in summer and could not wait till winter for my tapings. I had to persuade the narrators to perform, sometimes not an easy task. One of them only wanted to perform at night, another left his native village to recite unobserved by his neighbours. The best storyteller (perhaps because I taped him under normal conditions), the above mentioned Rahim-ul-la, ran away in the middle of the narrative (after 22 hours) because he was needed

in his village for harvesting; even promising him more money could not keep him from going.

The story is told in episodes or, as the Ladakhis call it, in *Ling*, whereby no chronological order is observed. Seldom is the epic told the way I taped it. I asked the singers to start “from the beginning”, and that was done. But under normal circumstances the narrator chooses an episode/*Ling*, or he will be asked for a particular *Ling* by the listeners (mostly for *Horjul*). The bard recites for two or three hours an evening and might continue the next day if people are still interested in his story. This mode of performing explains why Stein, who worked with written versions, never obtained two lists which named the same *Lings* in the same order. Every list and every text which he looked into had its own principles of succession. Assuming these texts to be products of an oral tradition, one is only mildly surprised, because a living oral tradition does not know of an authoritative version.

Observations on variation

By means of one episode I want to demonstrate the varied powers of creation of the storytellers. This episode seems of interest, because the parallel to Siegfried’s death in the *Nibelungenlied* suggests itself. The main character in this episode is Puma Lapstan, who is either a step-brother to Gesar or the son of Gesar. Chronologically this episode follows the abduction of Tukuma, the wife of Gesar, by the *Hors*. This episode is structured into three narrative elements in addition to the initial situation: 1) contact with the enemy, 2) betrayal, and 3) death. I will start with the version of Nurup Namgyal, because as director of the cultural program of All India Radio Leh he will influence the future of the Ladakhi epic by selecting the narrators to be broadcast.

Initial situation: Tukuma is kidnapped and the only hero who can bring her back is Puma Lapstan, but he is in retreat for meditation.

Apa Ldumbu informs Puma Lapstan of Tukuma's abduction. In a song Puma Lapstan refuses to interrupt his meditation, which will make him completely invulnerable in seven days. Apa Ldumbu tells him that Lingkar will decay if Tukuma is not brought back. So Puma Lapstan interrupts his meditation, which means that part of his shoulder remains vulnerable flesh in a body otherwise of steel.

Contact with the enemy: He follows the army of the Hor and takes Tukuma away from them. There is no fighting.

Betrayal: On the way home, during a pause, Tukuma gets a chance to talk to the king of Horjul, whom she meanwhile is in love with. She promises to offer Puma Lapstan salty food, so that he will be forced to quench his thirst at the nearby stream. They arrange that the king will shoot an arrow in Puma Lapstan's vulnerable shoulder and put their plan into effect.

Death: Puma Lapstan is hurt and Tukuma presses the arrow deeper into the injured man's flesh. Eloping with the king of Horjul, she leaves Puma Lapstan dying. That is how Apa Ldumbu finds him. In dry words Puma Lapstan explains what happened and subsequently Puma Ldumbu pulls out the arrow, whereby the hero dies.

Nurup took five minutes to narrate this episode. How does a talented Ladakhi narrator handle the same material? Rahim-ul-la, a Moslem from Chiktan, takes up six times as much space for the same episode.

Initial situation: Apa Thutung, a rather ambivalent figure among the heroes of Lingkar, breaks down the door of Puma Lapstan's retreat and tells him of the abduction of Tukuma. Puma Lapstan is indignant at this interruption because he will need another nine days to become invulnerable. Leaving his retreat, Puma Lapstan hurries to the heroes of Lingkar and scolds them for their stupidity, waiting at the wrong pass for the enemy. He is looking for equipment, but he only finds wretched weapons and a deplorable horse. While his horse is running in circles, as it does not listen, Apa Ldumbu approaches and asks him in a song: "Boy, are you leaving for playing or for fighting? If you want to play, ride a colt, if you want to fight,

take my experienced horse". Puma Lapstan informs him of his plans to get Tukuma back and asks the older man for advice. Apa Ldumbu announces in a song that the younger does not need his advice, but explains in detail the right way of acting in war and peace. Then he gives Puma Lapstan his horse and his weapons, but forgets to inform him about the interdiction not to take off his armor.

Contact with the enemy: Puma Lapstan rushes after the army of Hor and kills many. Seizing Tukuma, he rides with her to a mill. During their stay they procreate a child, named Kyalu Kyalsar. This is the only time a child of Tukuma and Puma Lapstan is mentioned.

Betrayal: Puma Lapstan wants to wash after a fight. Seeing one of the warriors of Horjul hiding beneath the mill, Tukuma still encourages Puma Lapstan to wash and to take off his armor. While he is washing, Tukuma talks to the enemy and betrays Puma Lapstan's secret. Now the warrior shoots an arrow into the vulnerable piece of flesh. Tukuma puts the child into the lap of her wounded rescuer and disappears with the Hor. Grabbing her dress, Puma Lapstan begs her to stay, but the woman cuts her dress apart and leaves him.

Death: Haunted by foreboding, Apa Ldumbu chases after Puma Lapstan. He finds him lying with an arrow in his body. Instead of caring for the wound, he orders Puma Lapstan not to touch the arrow till he comes back. This instruction is overheard by Apa Thutung, who has followed Apa Ldumbu without being noticed. While the latter absents himself (to avenge Puma Lapstan and kill the archer), Apa Thutung approaches. Allegedly concerned about Puma Lapstan's health, the scoundrel pulls out the arrow in such a way that all his inner organs are caught on the arrow-head and pulled out too. Then Apa Thutung runs away. When Apa Ldumbu returns, he finds Puma Lapstan dying. In a song he makes his last will known. He sings about how Tukuma left him when he asked her to stay. For that reason Gesar should punish "the red-mouth-one" when she comes back from the land of Hor: for three years she shall carry water for Lingkar, for three years she shall herd the goats. Finally he distributes his riches between Gesar and the people

of Lingkar. He dies. Apa Ldumbu carries him home to Lingkar, singing him a lullaby.

This gives an idea of the range of the episode of Puma Lapstan. The above named four elements are filled up with the following motifs, which are found in almost all the versions: The 'Initial Situation' is dominated by the abduction of Tukuma which leads to the interruption of Puma Lapstan's meditation. Thereby the disaster is launched, for the interruption means vulnerability of his body. 'Contact with the Enemy' consists of regaining Tukuma, either with or without fighting. In 'Betrayal' Tukuma discloses Puma Lapstan's deadly spot to the enemy. In contrast to the Nibelungenlied this disclosure is intended to lead to Puma Lapstan's bodily harm. 'Death' is initiated with his injury, which is by no means deadly. Fatal is the pulling out of the arrow, for the convalescence of Puma Lapstan is dependent on the arrow slowly "outgrowing" from his body. In the course of action the death of Puma Lapstan is postponed by the insertion of Apa Ldumbu's revenge or an initial healing of Puma Lapstan. These two motifs, retarding elements within the episode, seem to be used complementarily: One never finds these two motifs next to each other. Pulling out the arrow by force is made possible in almost all cases by the absence of Apa Ldumbu. (If the motif 'Healing' instead of 'Revenge' is used, Apa Ldumbu absents himself to fetch water.) The malefactor is usually the ambivalent Apa Thutung.

Deviations from the above mentioned 'Initial Situation' are to be found in the version told by Rinchen Namgyal from Sabu: When Tukuma has to leave Lingkar, she takes Puma Lapstan (who is born out of Gesar's shoulder) for rather sentimental reasons with her to the land of Hor. After the birth of her and the king of Hor's son she fears that Puma Lapstan will kill her child (because of succession?). She informs the warrior of Hor to ambush Puma Lapstan, but all the arrows bounce off his steel body. So she betrays the secret of his vulnerable spot and he is killed.

Rinchen Namgyal is a wilful storyteller. During his recital he was very lively and acted out his stories. But his version of the Gesar epic

differs considerably from that of other tellers. In fact he talked about getting interrupted by his listeners, who reproached him for not telling the story “right”. As a source of his material he named Beda Popo, a person quite famous in Ladakh, who died some time ago. Rinchen Namgyal claims to have learned the epic from him. He described in detail how Beda Popo came to his father’s house and recited Gesar for weeks. He told me that he tells the story just as Beda Popo did; he claims to be one of his three students, whose names he told me. Later I was told by a learned Ladakhi that his description could not possibly be true, because Beda Popo died long before Rinchen Namgyal was born.

The work on the Ladakhi epic carried out by me is by no means the first. As mentioned above, it was through just these orally performed Ladakhi versions that the Tibetan Gesar epic reached the West. Francke published two versions about 80 years ago: *Der Frühlings- und Wintermythus der Kesarsage* and *A Lower Ladakhi Version of the Kesar Saga*. Drawing on ten available versions of the Ladakhi epic (two versions of Francke and eight taped by me), I would like to raise two questions concerning the oral tradition: 1) How homogeneous (or divergent) is the Ladakhi oral tradition? 2) How conservative (or innovative) is it?

Comparing the episode of Puma Lapstan discussed above in its nine versions (in one of the Francke texts Puma Lapstan does not play any role), the following divergences are striking: 1) the differing descent of Puma Lapstan, 2) the differing treatment of the motif of armorment, 3) the complementary motifs of ‘Healing’ and ‘Revenge’. (1) While in the narrations of Lower Ladakh Puma Lapstan is the step-brother of Gesar, in Upper Ladakh he is the wonderfully emerged son of Gesar. Without the participation of Tukuma or any other woman he comes into existence out of Gesar’s shoulder or his vomit. (2) In the narrations of Lower Ladakh Puma Lapstan’s equipment for war and the advice of his fatherly friend take up a lot of space. Only in these versions does one find the motif of the interdiction of not taking off his armor which — in my opinion — is directly related to the motif of armorment. (3) As stated above, the motifs ‘Healing’ and ‘Revenge’ exclude one

another. The deadly pull on the arrow is rendered possible by the absence of Apa Ldumbu. While in the versions of Lower Ladakh Apa Ldumbu absences himself to rush after the archer, he stays with the injured warrior in the stories from Upper Ladakh. He treats Puma Lapstan with a special kind of soup and with medication, so that the arrow will slowly grow out of the flesh. This is supposed to happen the very next day. But while Apa Ldumbu is fetching water, the evil-doer approaches and pulls out the arrow, causing the death of Puma Lapstan.

Looking at the different treatment of the Gesar material, one cannot talk about two diverging oral traditions, but one can note a shift in emphasis. In Lower Ladakh the hero is more of a human being and the epic shows heroic traits. In the versions of Upper Ladakh the marvelous and the supernatural are more apparent. Why do the versions of Lower Ladakh correspond more to a heroic epic, as we conceive of it? An answer to this question would be pure speculation at this point, but certainly close contact with the Islamic tradition in Lower Ladakh has to be taken into consideration.

It is now appropriate to turn to the question of the stability of the oral tradition. This task requires comparison of the two versions of Francke published 80 years ago with those taped by me. First, it should be mentioned that the episode of Puma Lapstan is missing in *Der Frühlings- und Wintermythus der Kesarsage*. However, Francke's version from Lower Ladakh (*A Lower Ladakhi Version of the Kesar Saga*) corresponds fairly well with the story as told by the Lower Ladakhi Rahim-ul-la. In both versions Gesar and Puma Lapstan are step-brothers. In both forgetfulness of informing of the interdiction to take off the armor leads to Puma Lapstan's injury. It is interesting to see that Rahim-ul-la and Francke's bard sing similar songs in that episode: two songs concern the equipment and advice of his friend and another one deals with the death song of Puma Lapstan.

The versions of the Gesar epic which I taped in the summer of 1984 are part of the same oral tradition as the material published by Francke. As was shown in the episode of Puma Lapstan, the tradition proves to

be conservative. Of course differences are to be found, but they have to be explained by the creativity permitted to the individual. I would now like to discuss the scholarly debate which arose concerning Francke's versions and his opinion about the origin of the Gesar epic.

Debate on the origin of the epic

Francke's versions appeared in the first quarter of this century and were for a long time the only available editions of the Tibetan epic in the West. Thereby Francke came into the field of vision of all those Tibetologists who at that time or later on were concerned with the epic. They had to argue with Francke's rather wilful evaluation of the Gesar. Furthermore, Francke's versions were clearly of oral provenance, an origin which was considered inferior, because it dragged the noble epic into the lowlands of analphabets.

I will now describe how Francke evaluated his versions and how scholars in the field of Tibetan epic research assessed his approach. Thereby three complexes of problems will be discussed: 1) the time of origin of the epic, 2) the place of origin of the epic, and 3) the relation of written and oral versions.

Francke thought of his versions as prebuddhistic in origin and interspersed with mythological ideas. He did not commit himself to a date, but because Buddhism became the official religion in the 8th century A.D. and was generally accepted around the 11th century, the range of the time of origin is set. This assumption implies that the written versions, whose Buddhistic influence cannot be ignored (the only persons learned in writing were monks), are of later date than his own material.

Furthermore, he believed Ladakh to be the homeland of the Gesar epic. He advanced the following arguments: 1) oral versions of the Gesar epic can be collected in every Ladakhi village, 2) Gesar and his

warriors are connected with religious rites (e. g. the rite of marriage) and some of them are worshipped as gods, 3) in addition, Gesar is claimed by former rulers of Leh (capital of Ladakh) as their ancestor.

Francke believed the Ladakhi oral versions to be independent of written texts (this argument was later interpreted to indicate that written texts are secondary to Ladakhi versions). First, because they embody material prebuddhistic in origin, which he did not seem to find in texts (as it turns out later, Francke errs in that respect). Second, because the Ladakhi versions contain long passages in verse, while the texts known at that time were written in prose. Francke asked why, if the Ladakhis had taken the story from texts in prose, they would then have transformed it into verse (Francke 1905–41: xxiv).

These positions, and last but not least his proposed natural allegories, were highly provocative to the Tibetologists working on the epic because 1) their research was mostly conducted in Central and Eastern Tibet and so they felt more inclined to look for the place of origin in that direction and 2) they were working with written material and were biased against “vulgar”, oral sources.

In 1901 Laufer reviewed Francke’s *Der Frühlings- und Wintermythus der Kesarsage* and discussed the opinions expressed there. He compared a number of scenes of the Ladakhi version with the Mongolian one published in 1836 by Schmidt and concluded that there must be a link between the Ladakhi and the Mongolian version, on which both are based: an original version from Tibet. The Mongolian version is secondary, he argued, because it is fully Buddhistic, while the Ladakhi one shows prebuddhistic traits and should be dated for that very reason earlier. The Ladakhi one is derivative, because it is more condensed, shorter and fragmentary. Consequently both must be derived from a third version, which must be a Tibetan one. Second, Francke had talked about “auswendig gelernte Stoffe” (a rather hasty judgement which he corrected in 1925) and Laufer inferred that this material must exist somewhere, most probably in Tibet. He spoke of the “Originalquelle zu bezeichnende grosse tibetische Werk” (Laufer 1901: 80), “die authentische Quelle, das tibetische Gesarepos” (Laufer 1901: 87) and assumed

a Tibetan origin as the source of the “Heldensage” (Laufer 1901: 88). I have to stress that this was only an assumption, based on a comparison of the Ladakhi and the Mongolian versions. Laufer at that time only knew of one manuscript from Tibet, which he himself characterizes as a fragment and which is not connected by content to the version published by Francke.

In his article “The Epic of King Gesar of Ling” which appeared in 1942 Roehrich states with confidence that the place of origin of the Gesar epic is among the nomads of Northeast Tibet. Similar arguments to those which led Francke to locate this place in West-Tibet caused Roehrich to look for that place in the East: 1) the wide spread of the epic in the East, 2) the life-style described in the epic corresponds to that of the nomads, and 3) the rulers of Ling (province in Northeast Tibet) claim Gesar as one of their ancestors. He considers the 7th century to be the time of origin of the story, for certain parallels exist between the life of King Srong-btsan sgam-po of the 7th century and the life of Gesar. He also has clear conceptions about the relationship between the written and oral versions: the earliest material is to be found in manuscripts, because 1) there one finds the most archaisms, and 2) they show the closest similarity with the versions from the Northeast. These manuscripts are derived from a (non-existent) “Urgesar”, which was composed in verses. Prints and oral versions are based on these manuscripts.

Apart from this circular argument — Northeast Tibet is the place of origin, because a lot of different versions of the epic are to be found there; manuscripts (parts of the versions) are the oldest testimonies, because they resemble the versions from the Northeast — one can find more peculiarities in his argumentation. First, prints are based on manuscripts because they are shorter than the latter. Second, oral versions are derived from manuscripts because these are longer (“much enlarged and with a lot of details”, Roehrich 1942: 283) than the latter. And although oral versions contain more verses than the manuscripts — and according to Roehrich the “Urgesar” was composed in verses (which would indicate that the oral versions resemble the “Urgesar”)

—, he assumes the manuscripts to be the connecting link between the “Urgesar” and the oral narratives. Opposed to this is further his observation of young bards learning the epic not from texts but from older bards, just as one would expect in an oral tradition.

The leading authority on Tibetan epic research is Stein, who established our basic understanding of the Gesar epic in his *Recherches sur l'épopée et le barde au Tibet*, which appeared in 1959. His evaluation of Francke's versions resembles that of Laufer. He argues that Francke's material was derived from a literary source, for we are dealing with fairy tales, which are taken from Tibetan literature. Further, according to Stein, Laufer has clearly demonstrated that Francke's versions are secondary to a literary one (“Il [Laufer] avait surtout montré cette dépendance du document oral, folklorique, de la version littéraire par l'analyse d'un certain nombre de scènes”, Stein 1959: 163). It is true that Laufer expresses this hypothesis, but, as indicated above, he hardly provides adequate evidence for its validity.

Stein then starts to cement this presumption by means of a philological analysis. He shows that Francke's versions contain linguistic forms of classical Tibetan and, in particular, of Central and Eastern Tibet. Further, he points out that in Francke's versions one finds Buddhist influence, just as in the written texts. Stein concludes that Francke's versions are no more primary than the others, but, because the former are shorter than the latter, they must be derived from the written versions (“... il est impossible de concevoir que les versions écrites ou orales de grande étendue aient puisé leur inspiration lamaïque dans des récrits plus courts comme ceux de Francke. Le contraire semble vrai”, Stein 1959: 168). Dependency it must be! If the written versions are not derived from Francke's, then it must mean that Francke's versions are derivatives of the written ones. And dependency means dependency of the whole material!

The relationship of the oral versions to the written ones is commented upon by Stein as follows: “... die mündlichen Versionen, die wir heute kennen, sind nicht ursprünglicher, sondern hängen sicher von den geschriebenen Fassungen ab” (Stein 1978: 146). This contradicts the

observation, also made by Stein, that the written versions, no matter whether we are dealing with manuscripts or prints, are composed like oral performances. The part containing the action is written in prose, the part containing the dialogues in alternating songs in verse. The latter part takes up more space while the former is rather short. These two parts are often distinguished by different types of writing. Even in the written versions the songs start with “a-la a-la tha-la-la”, which clearly imitates the oral performance. Stein continues: “One may thus presume that the oral versions are primary in regard to the written ones” (Stein 1979: 3). But this is at once rejected by the remark that the epic, as we know it in its available versions, was most certainly composed by a clergyman of the type of an inspired holy poet. There could not be better proof of the resistance to incorporate the Gesar epic into an oral tradition! In spite of observances that written versions copy the songs of bards, this insight is dismissed and it is pointed towards an individual poet.

The interpretations of Laufer, Roehrich and Stein are all based upon the following assumptions:

- 1) A text is a literary product and the recital of a bard is an oral one. “Oral” is used here in the sense of “originated from a bard”. In this respect the possibility that a text written down might be part of an oral tradition is not taken into account. This leads to the above described surprise that texts are conceived like oral performances.
- 2) Because the question of whether a text is part of an oral tradition is not investigated, it is assumed, as soon as origin from an oral version is dismissed, that there must be an author somewhere. The question of the original (“original manuscript”, Stein 1979: 10; “source originales”, Stein 1959: 107) is raised. Connected with this is the equally misleading problem of the complete Gesar (“version intégrale de l’épopée”, Helffer 1977: 1). Because all versions of written and oral provenance name different numbers and successions of episodes, it is assumed that a complete version of Gesar once existed (Helffer 1977: 1; Stein 1959: 45), but, at some unknown time, was lost.

- 3) The course of a story, no matter what its origin, should not be erratic. This would point towards abridgement and discredit the version as secondary. To that Francke wrote in 1901: “Hierin Abschwächung einer ursprünglich kräftigeren Poesie erkennen zu wollen, ist unrecht. Höchstens kann von Abkürzungen die Rede sein” (Francke 1968: iv). However, jumps in narration might, in fact, point towards an oral tradition, because the teller can assume that his audience is familiar with his material.

Tibetan epic research has managed to ignore the scholarly debate about oral literature since Bowra, Parry and Lord, to name only the pioneers. The course to be pursued in future research concerning the oral epic could be the question of possibilities of composition other than those listed by Parry and Lord. For work regarding the written versions of the Gesar epic first priority should be given to the investigation of the extent to which written versions are based on the oral tradition. This presumption is forced upon us by 1) the remarks of Stein about the great similarity between written texts and oral performances, 2) the great wealth of seemingly independent texts with differing extent, and 3) the existence of a widely spread, living oral tradition. Therein lie — in my opinion — the most promising possibilities for future Tibetan epic research.

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Jia Zhi

Epics in China

As a consequence of the closed-doors policy practised towards the outside world during the long feudal period in Old China, of the language-barriers within a country with so many nationalities speaking different languages, and particularly of the constant reactionary discrimination against minority peoples and folk literature in general, we Chinese have for centuries had very inadequate information about our own folk literature. What is more, we have given it very little publicity, so foreign scholars have had almost no opportunity to get to know it. Since the Liberation, however, and especially in recent years, as a huge number of folk literature works of the country's 56 ethnic groups have been unearthed, collected and recorded, we have been in a position to recognize that our country is rich in folk literature, in epics and long narrative poems.

China abounds in poems and songs inseparably linked with the everyday life of many nationalities. For instance, the Kazak people have a proverb: "Poetry and steed are the Kazaks' two wings." Recent findings have shown that almost every ethnic group in our country has its own epics, narrating the birth and growth of its people. China is thus rich in epics and long narrative folk poems, although no definite statistics have so far been obtained.

Throughout China, from the river valleys of the Himalaya Mountains in the southwest to the Hulun Buir Grassland in the northeast, and from the Tianshan Mountains in the northwest, over the plateaux of Yunnan and Guizhou provinces, to the coastal regions in the southeast, many ethnic minorities have their own national epics. In recent years, many long narrative folk poems of the Han people have also been discovered, reflecting common customs and ways of life.

At present, there is no unanimity among Chinese scholars on the demarkations to be used in the classification of epics. It is, however, considered that epics on genesis and heroes came into being in the early stage of human society. The former category contains mythology about creation, while the latter emerged later, reflecting important historical events relating to the formation of an ethnic group or nation-state. In some cases, no hard and fast line can be drawn between these two different categories, since they overlap. Cosmogonic epics have mainly been found among ethnic minorities in the southern part of the country, while the impressive heroic epics tend to originate in the north.

The distribution of cosmogonic epics

Cosmogonic epics include those composed by the following ethnic groups: the Yi, Zhuang, Miao, Bai, Dai, Yao, Hani, Tujia, Buyi, Bulang, Gelao, Naxi, Zang, Menba, Lhoba, Lahu, Wa, Dong, Lisu, Jingpo, Benglong, Achang, Nu, Li, Pumi, She, Jinuo, and Drung living in the southern part of the country, and the Han and Tu peoples living in the north, comprising 30 ethnic groups in all. Sheng Min ("The Birth of Man"), the epic of the origin of the Han peoples, is included in their Book of Songs.

Within these ethnic groups, some epics exist in several versions, due to regional and tribal differences. For instance, there are several different texts of the epic Chamu (translated into the Han language as "The Origin of All Things on Earth"), composed by the Yi people in Chuxiong and Honghe prefectures in Yunnan Province. The Yi people's epic Meige is sung to its own Meige tune in Yao'an and Yandou counties in Chuxiong Prefecture, whereas the Axi's epic is sung to the Xianji tune in the form of antiphony between both sexes among the Axi, a different branch of the Yi ethnic group. As the Daliang Mountains region in Sichuan Province, where the Yi live, is fairly inaccessible,

there are four different versions of the Lewuteyi epic in comparatively complete hand-written copies. Other ethnic groups also have more than one epic.

Myths of the origin of the universe from a primeval body

In the ancient mythology of the Han people there was a god called Pan Gu. After his death, his body was transformed into heaven, earth and all things on earth. The account in the ancient books reads as follows:

Pan Gu was the first-born, transforming when dying. His breath turned into the wind and cloud, his voice into thunderbolts, his left eye into the sun, his right eye into the moon, his limbs and body into the four poles and the Five Mountains, his blood into the rivers, his sinews and blood vessels into the ground, his muscles into the earth in the fields, his hair and beard into the stars, his skin and the hair on it into grass and trees, his teeth and bones into gold and stone, his marrow into pearls and precious stone, and his sweat into rain and pools. The insects on his body were transformed into the common people by the wind.

The cosmogonic epics of many ethnic minorities have a moving plot such as this, describing how Pan Gu-like heroes transform their limbs and bodies into heaven, earth, sun, moon, mountains and rivers. Take the Buyi nationality's epic Kaitian Pidi ("Creation of the World"), for example. It says that Weng Ge cut out his two eyes and nailed them onto the sky, transforming them into the sun and the moon. He fixed his teeth onto the sky, transforming them into stars. The Lahu nationality's epic, Mupamipa, tells how Esha created heaven and earth, making the sun with her left eye and the moon with her right eye. She plucked the hair from her head to turn it into a silver needle for the moon and gave a puff to turn her breath into a gold needle for the

sun. She transformed the calluses on her hands into white clouds and her beads of sweat into stars.

In the Yi epic *Chamu*, it says that after the death of the god Heiailuobosai his eyes turned into the sun and the moon, his teeth into stars, his breast into hills and mountains and his exhalation into wind, rain, cloud and mist. In the Yao epic *The Song of King Pan*, it says:

The big mountains were originally Pan Gu's body. His two eyes became the sun and the moon, his teeth became gold and silver, and his hair became grass and trees so that birds and animals began to appear in the mountains and forests. His breath turned into the wind, his sweat into rain, and his blood into the rivers flowing forever.

There are also sayings about the incarnation of animals' dead bodies among the Yi, Hani, Bulang and Pumi peoples.

Mythology of the transformation of corpses also occurs among peoples in other parts of the world. For instance, it says in the mythology of northern Europe that the great god Odin used the ice giant Ymir's remains to create heaven and earth. Similar images about the formation of heaven and earth thus occur among many peoples. This indicates that their psychology was similar in the era of mythology. Despite the absurdity of such illusions about the creation of the universe, they do suggest a vision of man at the centre of all things. This idea of the unity of nature and mankind, exaggerating and stressing the role mankind plays in the universe, has abiding aesthetic value.

Deluge myths and gourd worship

Many epics on genesis also include stories about the deluge, as in other parts of the world, describing how mankind once experienced doom caused by the catastrophe of a worldwide deluge, before rebirth through

a few survivals. This category of stories about the deluge is also very widespread in the southern part of China, and a few similar accounts exist among the Han in the northern part of the country. Apart from the possible role of geological changes in the emergence of these myths, they are perhaps also due to psychological factors and the geographical environment, since the southern part of the country has much water and rain, while the northern part is cold and dry.

A large number of bronze drums have been unearthed in Guangdong, Guangxi and Yunnan provinces, from China's bronze drum culture. These bronze drums have nearly a thousand different patterns on them, such as geometric designs, animal and plant patterns, Buddhist motifs, and narrative patterns. Quite a few of these patterns are closely related to the ancient mythology and legends of the people concerned. According to textual research carried out by experts, it is very possible that these original and unique patterns of water and boats rich in national colour and features of the epoch are marks of stories about the ancient deluge.

Stories about the deluge are also linked with the country's gourd culture. The epics of many of the country's ethnic groups, such as the Han, Yi, Bai, Hani, Naxi, Lahu, Miao, Jinuo, Yao, She, Li, Shui, Dong, Zhuang, Buyi, Gaoshan, Gelao, Benglong and Wa, all contain myths about mankind emerging from a gourd after the deluge. For instance, it says in the Wa epic *Xigangli* that a boat drifted down from a place where heaven met the sea, carrying a gourd. A sparrow pecked at the gourd for nine years before it was opened. Then the Wa people walked out of the gourd. According to a myth of the Yi people it is said that, having survived the deluge, a man married his younger sister, who later gave birth to a gourd. When the god of heaven poked the gourd open, the forefathers of all the ethnic groups walked out. The Zhuang epic *Bobo* tells how, during the inundation, Fuyi and his younger sister hid themselves in a gourd. They were the only survivors of the deluge. They married and gave birth to mankind. Despite their differences of detail, however, all these myths assert that the gourd is the common parent of the peoples of all nationalities.

The myth that human beings originate from the melon to be found among the Han in Yunnan Province may also be included in the category of “gourd worship”. The Yi group known as “Luoluo” living in the Ailao Mountains in the southwestern part of Yunnan Province retained the custom of enshrining and worshipping the gourd as the incarnation of their ancestors until the eve of Liberation. The primitive gourd culture reflected in these genesis epics is also a current subject for study.

Creation from the primordial mist

Although the Kalevala is a heroic epic, it begins with a cosmogonic narrative, sketching a mythical, fairytale-like ancient world of mankind. The daughter of the air descends to the sea and conceives by the wind and waves, giving birth to the hero Väinämöinen. A little bird builds a nest on her knees and hatches an egg; when the egg breaks, the broken pieces of its shell turn into the earth, sky, sun, moon and clouds. Chinese cosmogonic epics also have many similar beautiful descriptions, rich in allusions. For instance, in the Dai epic *Inpia Creates Heaven and Earth*, water and vapour ascend and condense to become the great god *Inpia*, who creates heaven and earth; and *The Ancient Song of the Miao people* tells how, like the hatching of eggs, the cloud and mist hatched two giant birds, *Keti* and *Leti*, heaven and earth. It says in the Buyi epic *Brother Fu and Sister Xi Create Mankind* that, long ago, there were only clear and turbid gases. *Bujiegong* separated these two kinds of gases and transformed them into heaven and earth. It says in the Jingpo epic *Munaozhaiwa* that there was a little mass of cloud and mist, revolving in the centre of the universe and giving birth to the ghost of heaven, representing yin and yang and creating heaven and earth.

In the Yi epic *Lewuteyi*, three streams of light fog rise from the Chinese parasol tree, condensing to become three parts of red snow. Ice becomes bone, the snow becomes human skin, the wind becomes respiration, the rain becomes blood and the stars become eyeballs, finally changing into the 12 tribes of the Xue people. It is also said in the Yi epic *Chamu* that in ancient times there were only masses of fog and dew. The God *Heiluoobosai* gave birth to an egg, whose shell became the heaven, whose white became the sun, moon and stars, and whose yolk became the earth. The Naxi cosmogonic epic recounts how a beautiful sound grew on the mountain and good white gas gathered at the foot of a mountain; the sound and white gas condensed to become three drops of white dew, which turned into the big seas, while heaven gave birth to the egg of mankind. The sea gave birth to the god called *Henshihenren*, whose 9th-generation descendant was *Chongrenlisi*, the earliest ancestor of mankind.

The epics of the peoples mentioned above reflect their environment, since they mostly live in cloudy and misty mountain forests. It is commendable that they tried to explore the origin of all things on earth from matter itself, explaining the origin of the universe as the result of movements of such essential elements as gas, water or a unicellular egg. Although fantastic, this represents an attempt to break away from the idealism that god created all things on earth, revealing the dawn of science. Cosmogonic epics offer a naive and colourful imaginative vision of the objective world. We can see from them the epitome of our ancestors' struggle with nature.

The artistic description of the origin of heaven, earth and all earthly existence is in these cosmogonic epics clear, natural, direct, imaginative, uninhibited and at the same time magnificently simple. These unaffected and ingenuous lines have an appeal that never fades. Here we see a nation that has made a living environment for itself with endless labour, yet at the same time creating poetry. Herein lies the earliest cradle of ancient Chinese culture.

Epics on heroes: Geser, Manas and Jangar

As mentioned above, heroic epics are mainly found among the ethnic groups living in the northern part of China, although some are also found in the southern part of the country, e. g. among the Dai, Yi and Naxi. This category of epics mainly appeared during the period from the disintegration of clan society to the beginning of slave society, or even from the feudal period. They are the works of the “heroic age”.

The most famous Chinese heroic epics, such as *The Life of King Geser*, *Jangar* and *Manas*, are well-known. Since the Liberation, and particularly in recent years, further exploration and survey have provided us with lots of new materials for scholarly study. What is particularly encouraging is that our country has numerous folk artists who can perform epics such as *The Life of King Geser*, *Jangar* and *Manas*. They are the successors, preservers, and even co-authors participating in the collective creation of these epics, which are still alive in China today in their mouths. They continue to entertain the people with beauty and inspiration.

The Zang epic *The Life of King Geser* is widespread through the five provinces and autonomous regions of Tibet, Qinghai, Sichuan, Yunnan and Gansu. It is widely known among the Zang people, and looked upon as a classic. According to the information now available, the whole epic contains some 60 parts or more, totalling 1,5 million lines. New material is, however, continuously being found, so that a definitive figure cannot be obtained until the compilation is complete. There is also a Mongolian variant of this epic, *Geser Khan*, the Hero, in the eastern part of Inner Mongolia.

Slave society was established in Tibet by Songzanganbu in the 7th century A.D., and lasted until the 9th century. During the next three centuries, when tribal war expeditions were frequent, a feudal society of serfs began to emerge. It is generally maintained that *The Life of King Geser* emerged in the 11th century, later undergoing a long process of diffusion and evolution. In recent years, some legends and

relics concerning the expeditions have been discovered during surveys carried out in such areas as Sichuan, Tibet, Yunnan, Qinghai and Gansu. For instance, the He'er River, the site of the war of the He Mountain Ridge, has been found in Huzhu County of the Tu people in Qinghai Province. In addition, such cultural relics as the legendary bow, arrow, knife and armour used by Geser have also been found, providing new and rich data for the study of *The Life of King Geser* and opening up a new field for research.

The Kirgiz heroic epic *Manas* is found both in Xinjiang in China and also in the Soviet Union and Afghanistan. It is named after Manas, a hero of the first generation, and has been recorded and published in the Soviet Union. Quite a few books on it have also been written by Soviet and other scholars. However, only three parts have so far been published in China. In the last ten years or so, different versions of *Manas* performed by 70 singers have been recorded. Zhusufu Mamayi, a famous singer from Xinjiang, can sing eight different parts, all of which have already been recorded on tape, including *Manas*, *Saimaitaiyi*, *Saiyitaike*, *Kainainimy*, *Saiyite*, *Aselebaqia* and *Biekebaqia*, *Mubilaike*, and *Qigetaiyi*. The epic narrates the story of the hero *Manas* over eight generations in unifying all the tribes of the Kirgiz and leading them in battle against the Kalmuks and the Khitan.

A great deal of work has been done in Xinjiang in recent years to preserve the Mongolian heroic epic *Jangar*, and more than 60 chapters have been collected. The Mongolian Tu'erhute tribe in Weilate, Xinjiang, migrated to the lower reaches of the Volga River in the last year of the Ming dynasty (A.D. 1629); in 1771, they came back to their motherland, led by Wobaxi Khan. Some of them were, however, left behind because the river rose suddenly, and this epic is therefore also found in that locality. *Jangar* tells the story of 12 lion-like heroes and 6000 warriors, led by their tribal chief *Jangar*, waging a struggle against the invasion and pillage of their native region by enemies of all kinds. It eulogizes the ideal kingdom of the Mongolian people, *Baomuba*, where there is no difference between poor and rich, and everybody looks as young as if he or she were 25 years of age.

Other heroic epics

We have recorded a few scores of shorter Mongolian epics in eastern Inner Mongolia and other regions, for instance, *The Warrior Gunougan* and *The Brave and Resourceful Prince Xiretu*, reflecting the struggle waged by these heroes against Manggusi (the devil). These epics give accounts of tribal wars and battles with nature, reflecting the historical development of mankind from a hunting economy to one of animal husbandry.

In the Han and Tang dynasties, the famous Silk Road facilitated the flow of trade between China and the countries in Europe and Asia, and thus at the same time promoted cultural exchange between East and West. Its unique geographical position as the only thoroughfare to the West at that time made Xinjiang a place where various cultures gathered together. Xinjiang abounds in epics of various ethnic origins, many of them from the regions of Central Asia. Others have a rich flavour of Central or Western Asia. The Kazak have now collected more than 200 long narrative folk poems, including such universally known heroic epics as *Alepamisi* and *Ta'ergen*. The famous Uygur heroic epic *The Life of Wugusi* has aroused the interest of both Chinese and foreign scholars because of its simple and unsophisticated content, and the records of historical events it has preserved.

Among other peoples living in the northern part of the country, the population of the Hezhe, for example, had dropped to 300 by the founding of New China. With a present-day population of more than 1,000, the Hezhe also has many unique heroic epics, in a genre of folklore-singing called *Yimakan*. *Mandoumorigen* is a representative example. It describes consanguineous marriages and the making of alliances by means of war, the basic aim of which lies in the annexing of the conquered tribes and the enslavement of captives. The style of *Yimakan* is similar to that of the neighbouring

Mongolian epics. Some scholars also maintain that Yimakan is somewhat similar to the Ainu epic Yukar from Japan; this could be due to the fact that the Hezhen homeland was the ancient thoroughfare leading to Japan.

Although most of the epics found in the southern part of China are on genesis, there are also some heroic epics in a distinctive style. The tune of such Dai epics as Xiangmeng, Langaxihe, and Lifeng is quite different from that of the epics of the nomadic peoples living in the north. The Dai epics reflect a charming landscape, typical of the south, with subtropical forests, ancient tribal war, and national heroes in the period of the imperial dynasties.

On the northern grasslands, the heroes are described in epics as bold and powerful, fighting and subduing demons and devils. The heroes in the forests are also powerful, fighting with their treasured swords and crack shooting with arrows; but the stories are always set in a context incorporating such things as clear creeks, singing birds and fragrant flowers. In the Mongolian epic *Jangar* the fight between Honggu'er, the hero, and Houhechagan is described as follows:

Honggu'er, choosing the right moment,
Suddenly throws his arms around Houhechagan's waist,
Lifts him up and shakes him seven or eight times,
And then throws him on the ground with force,
Making rocks roll and high mountains tremble.

Houhechagan supports himself with his two arms,
Remaining calm and without a shiver in his body,
His head uncontaminated by a single grain of sand.
Thus for four days and four nights,
The two heroes are in stalemate.

By contrast, the Dai epic *Zhaoxiangmeng* begins with the line: "101 flowers blossom in the boundless forest which contains 101 countries."

The description of the fight between Xiangmeng and Shawali is as follows:

As the sun rises,
 It is covered up by clouds;
 As a hundred birds rise from their nests,
 They are scared to flight by the sound of fighting.
 Every tree has traces of sword and spear on it;
 Every leaf is stained with bright red blood.
 Fresh fallen corpses soak in the rivers,
 And broken swords and arrows are scattered all over the ground.

When they carry the fight up to heaven, the epic says:

As Zhaoxiangmeng brandishes his treasured sword,
 Trying to take Shawali's heart out,
 Shawali leaps up at once,
 Making the treasured sword scratch a cloud.
 As Shawali turns around,
 Trying to cut Xiangmeng's back with his sword,
 Xiangmeng pulls a star down,
 Breaking the treasured sword flying toward him.

Thus although the fighting described in the epic Xiangmeng is cruel, the description itself is poetic, and the tune of the epic is mild and periphrastic, never neglecting opportunities for beautiful description even during the fight under the glint and flash of cold steel.

Poetics and epic among the Dai

The book *On the Poetry of the Dai People*, written by a Dai Buddhist scholar Gubameng more than 300 years ago has also been discovered. This work is a book on poetics, especially literary theories, and is of

considerable academic value both for the study of the emergence and evolution of the poetry of the Dai and for the study of the emergence of literature and the origin of art in general. On the emergence and characteristics of Dai poetry he writes:

As our Dai ancestors were born in the forests and banana groves, it is the birds and water that have given us songs. Since the emergence of the Dai songs, flowers and plants have been their clothing, stars, clouds, sun and moon have been their ornaments, and muntjacs, red deer and native birds have been its partners. Therefore, the Dai people will never be parted from these. This is no mere artificial figure of speech; this is an actual record of the Dai people's history.

Langaxihe has been adapted from the classic Indian epic *Rāmāyaṇa*. It is not, however, a simple imitation or stereotype; it is an artistic fruit deeply rooted in the soil of the Dai people, fully coloured by their native characteristics, and actually recounts the tribal expeditions in the clan society of the Dai before the development of the feudal system. Here we also encounter another important subject for study, the problem of the influence of Buddhism on Chinese epics. Since its introduction into China in the Western Han Dynasty, Buddhism has greatly affected Chinese literature, poetry, painting, sculpture, dancing and architecture. The Dai are devout Buddhists.

Approaches to epic research

Some epics and long narrative poems have been rewritten or created on the basis of the Buddhist scriptures. The Buddhist influence is also reflected in the epics of all the ethnic groups living in the northwestern part of the country. For instance, both in the Mongolian and the Zang epics on The Life of King Geser, Geser is said to be the reincarnation

of the third son of the “white Buddhist king”, coming to the world to subdue demons and devils. This also involves historical cultural exchanges and mutual influences between China and India and countries in Southeastern Asia as well as other countries in Central and Western Asia. The effect of Buddhism on folk literature, the impact on the spread and evolution of folk literature through Buddhist and other missionaries, and the relevant cultural exchanges between ethnic groups from various countries, have also increasingly aroused interest among Chinese scholars.

The Yi cosmogonic epic *Lewuteyi*, which occurs throughout Sichuan, Guizhou and Yunnan Provinces, is also called *Zhige’along*, the Hero. It depicts *Zhige’along*’s shooting of the sun and the moon, his subduing of wild beasts, his tribal expeditions, and how he finally became a king and it is, therefore, classified by some scholars as a heroic epic. For the time being, the discussion of its classification may be ignored. This epic contains motifs such as the breaking of green from the rock with a bronze bow and arrow given him by a magic eagle, the making of bronze tools with ground fire, the subsequent setting up of the first stockaded village, and the planting of crops; it lays much emphasis on *Zhige’along*’s struggle with nature. In contrast to the heroes of the nomadic northern peoples, fighting for the unity of their tribes, this hero is somewhat like the Finnish hero *Väinämöinen*, who cultivated the forest, reclaimed the land, sowed seeds, and made boats and musical instruments for the Finnish people, singing for the peace and happiness of the nation.

The verse forms and rhetorical devices in these epics on genesis and heroes vary from one ethnic group to another. Some of them are strictly regular in versification, with a stress on the regular scheme of end-rhymes, others employ head-rhymes or inner rhymes. Some are rhymeless but rhythmical, stressing the undulating rhythm of the syllables. The different habitats and environments of different ethnic groups also contribute to the special rhetorical devices, such as contrast, exaggeration, figuration and so on, different in form and colour, and in each group’s own system of poetics and use of imagery. This field

of poetics constitutes an important part of Chinese scholarly research into the epic.

Epics and mythology emerged in remote antiquity, but they have continuously expanded in response to the social development of the later ages through which they have been handed down, and they thus reveal a broad historical picture. As many of the ethnic minorities of China remained at their different socio-historical stages up to the time of the country's Liberation, there existed remnants of clan society, matriarchy, slave society, feudal society and so on. Because of the slow social development of these ethnic groups, the original features of their epics and mythology have been preserved almost intact, surviving even up to the present day among the masses and linking closely with their life, customs and habits. The epics on genesis and heroes are these peoples' encyclopaedias, and they are still called by some of them their "genealogical tree". They are solemnly sung at major festivals and celebrations, as classics used to pass on the achievements and historical experiences of the forefathers to later generations.

Epics and mythology have in recent years become a popular subject in the study of Chinese folk literature. Research on the Life of King Geser epic has been listed as one of the State's major research projects, the first of its kind in our country. As the task of gathering epics is still in progress in our country, many aspects of them are still unclear. The emergence and development of some epics, for instance, is still unknown. Different categories of epics from many ethnic groups are now being surveyed, explored and recorded. They are being studied through textual research from various angles, including, for instance, artistic achievement, social-economic formation, the relationship between the country's ethnic groups reflected in them, the influence of primitive religion and Buddhism, contradictions between their growth and decline, and so on. Chinese scholars are exploring and studying the epics by means of dialectical materialism and historical materialism, in order to recognize and assess artistic forms and attainments which could only have emerged in undeveloped social stages.

Some of our country's ethnic groups live on both sides of a border, in two different countries. As cultural exchanges between China and her neighbouring countries are also of long standing, many epics are shared by China with her neighbouring countries. Therefore, in order to study epics, it is necessary for scholars of all countries to carry out a joint investigation so as to learn each other's strong points and offset each other's weaknesses. This enables us not only to improve the opportunities for successful academic research, but also to build a bridge for friendly contacts between peoples of all countries.

Taryo Obayashi

The Yukar of the Ainu and Its Historical Background

The Ainu of Hokkaido and Sakhalin have produced a rich oral literature, in which epics hold a venerable place. The classification and the terminology of the epics vary from district to district and from student to student; yet scholars are unanimous in including in epics the oracle songs of the female shaman (*tusu shinotcha*) and the narrative poems (*yukar* in the wider sense of the word), the latter falling into two categories: epics of deities (*kamui-yukar*, *oina*) and epics of humans (*yukar* in the narrower sense of the word; henceforth I shall use the term in this sense).

In spite of excellent studies by Kindaichi, Chiri, Kubodera and others, we are not yet in a position to understand clearly the genesis and development of the narrative poems of the Ainu. One reason for this is that hardly any serious study has been undertaken in the comparison of the Ainu epics with those of Siberian peoples. The present paper is but a modest endeavor to remedy this situation. Before beginning the comparison, I would like to outline the contours of the two closely related genres of Ainu epics: the *oina* or epics of the culture hero and the *yukar* or heroic epics.

The Oina and the Yukar

The *oina* denotes, in the terminology of Iburi and Hidaka Provinces, the story of the first ancestor of the Ainu, Aeoine kamui, which is supposed to be told by himself in the first-person singular. Aeoine

kamui is also known by other names, such as Ainu rakkur or Okikurmi, and he is the culture hero of the Ainu par excellence. An oina is usually recited with a refrain (*sakebe*) (Kubodera 1977b: 142).

Kindaichi divides oina into three sub-genres, probably based on the classification current in the Niikappu River area, Hidaka Province: 1) Kamui-oina (oina of deities), which includes the origin of the culture hero himself and the pantheon and genealogy of heavenly deities. It further tells that Aeoina kamui rescues a young goddess from the cave of an evil god to marry her, and he prepares the ground for human culture. Kamui-oina is the grandest in scale and longest in form of all the oinas. 2) Por-oina (great oina), in which the culture hero destroys a giant-monster to release the sun deity from her predicament and recovers the radiance to assure the peace and prosperity of the human race. 3) Pon-oina (little oina), in which the culture hero, disguised as Anururun kamui (the god of Western Bay), contends with the god of Mt. Kemushir for a beautiful girl, who is the fiancée of the latter and a sister of the owl god Kotan-kor kamui, that is, the guardian god of the village of the Ainu. In some versions the culture hero fights with Poro-shir-un kamui (the god of Mt. Poroshir) instead of the god of Mt. Kemushir (Kindaichi 1943; 1944: 209–226; 1950: 7; 1961: 315; cf. Kubodera 1977a: 22; 1977b: 143).

Aeoina kamui, the oina-god (Ainu rakkur or Okikurmi), is thought to be a boy hero, whom the heavenly deities sent to earth to be its ruler when the world of humanity was created. Another version lets not Aeoina kamui but his father descend, while the former is the ancestor of the human race, born on earth. Yet another version maintains that the oina-god is not just the first ancestor-god but also includes his descendants for several generations, all being known under the same appellation: Aeoina kamui.

Aeoina kamui left the country of the humans to go to heaven or to a neighboring country after he had made the human world comfortable for living, destroying devils and evil deities. Nevertheless, the Ainu believe that in cases of emergency in the Ainu country, Aeoina kamui will come back to help them (Kindaichi 1944: 211–229; 1961: 291–292).

While the hero of the oina is a god called Ainu rakkur, human-like god (Chiri 1955: 218; 1973: 204–205), the hero of the *yukar* is a mortal

called Poiyaunpe, “that young inlander” (Kindaichi 1944: 112–119), an orphan boy of a noble family.

The structure of yukar can be summarized as follows: The story begins with the life of the hero when he is an orphan boy. He is fed and brought up either by his foster sister and foster brother, or by a poor old man and a poor old woman. Sometimes he has an elder brother born of a woman other than his mother. The brothers are brought up together. The reason why the hero is an orphan is disclosed in the course of the story. According to the most common type, his parents embarked on barter trade by sea. On the way back they accepted an invitation by a chief. During the banquet in the village of the host, the parents were murdered by the host and his fellows.

Thus far the story is common to most of the yukars. The further unfolding of the story is divided by Kindaichi into four types: 1) The hero has an elder brother, who seeks the younger brother, the only survivor of his blood and flesh. He massacres the people of the villages where his inquiry after his brother receives a negative answer, “We do not know him”. Then the story branches into two subtypes: (a) When he meets his younger brother, they fight each other without knowing that the adversary is his own brother. (b) The elder brother becomes a prisoner of a female shaman. When he is on the verge of being killed, the younger brother comes to rescue him. Afterwards they succeed in massacring the murderers of their father in revenge. Type 1 is the most popular one. 2) The struggle for a coveted object, such as a golden sea otter or a golden fish, between rival heroes ends in the victory of Poiyaunpe. Yet this ushers in a series of wars. Envious villagers conspire together to plunder the object from Poiyaunpe, and war ensues between him and the invaders. The first war results in the second one, and thus a whole series of wars follows. 3) A struggle over hunting grounds introduces a series of wars. 4) The struggle for a girl is the cause of war. She is the fiancée of the hero. Few yukars belong to this type (Kindaichi 1931 I: 199–202; 1961: 276–280).

Kindaichi suggests that Type 1 is distinctive of the heroic yukar and it occurs neither in the oina nor in *uwepeker* (folktales); therefore it is

probably the original plot of heroic yûkar. On the other hand, Type 3 is a type which appears often in the uwepeker told by old men, while Type 2 is a borrowing from the oina, where Okikurmi is the hero (Kindaichi 1950: 8).

The major concern of heroic yûkar is certainly the battles and struggles of the hero; yet Types 2 and 3 often contain the character of a beautiful girl whom the hero has brought home triumphantly from the enemy camp. She is usually a girl who, though belonging to the group hostile to the hero, betrays her father and brothers to rescue the hero from danger. This romance is, however, only one episode in the epic (Kindaichi 1931 II: 202; 1961: 323).

The oina and the yûkar can be designated as twin genres in Ainu literature. The similarities between the two genres are indeed striking and far-reaching. To cite some examples: the oina-god Ainu rakkur, as well as Poiyaunpe, is an orphan boy who is reared by a foster sister. Ainu rakkur dwells in a citadel which looks quite similar to that of Poiyaunpe. The dress and armaments of Ainu rakkur, who launches a battle, remind us of those of Poiyaunpe, who set out to the battlefield. The combat of Ainu rakkur with monsters and evil deities is as heroic and dauntless as that of Poiyaunpe with his adversaries (Kubodera 1977a: 23; cf. Kindaichi 1944: 126).

Turning to the composition of the epic, the yûkar uses almost the same formulas as the oina. Many oinas even have the appearance of being a model or a miniature of a yûkar. An inattentive hearer might well mistake an oina for a yûkar if the name of the hero should escape him (Kindaichi 1944: 126).

Ainu epics and Siberian epics

As early as 1900 the great orientalist Berthold Laufer noted the similarities between the Nanai (Goldi) epics and those of the Mongol and Turkic peoples and suggested: "Central Asia is to be considered

as the country which originated and handed down the tales of the Gold, and consequently of all other tribes of Amoor river" (Laufer 1900: 330). Unfortunately, Laufer did not demonstrate his point in detail, yet I believe he was essentially right. I would go a step further and argue that the yukar of the Ainu is connected with the epics of the Nanai and some other Siberian peoples. This affinity is visible, among other things, in terms of the hero's character in these epics.

Poiaunpe, the hero of the yukar, conforms, for instance, to the general pattern of the "lonely hero" of Siberian epic literature, which, as Meletinsky remarked, is a character typically recurring in the epics of some Siberian peoples. Er-Sogotokh, literally, "lonely", is the most popular and ancient hero of the Yakut *olongo* (epic):

He is a hero who lives by himself, does not know other people and has no parents (hence his name) because he is the first ancestor of the human race. Er-Sogotokh seeks a wife in order to become an ancestor of other people... Other Yakut heroes (e. g. Yurung Uolan) also appear as "lonely heroes" having no parents. Similar to Er-Sogotokh is the first ancestor in Buryat epics; relics of this character are found in Altai epics telling from the very outset that the origin of the hero is unknown, he has no parents but afterwards it turns out that he is an heir to a rich cattle-breeding farm. Narrators sometimes attribute this "loneliness" of the hero to his being an orphan (Meletinsky 1969: 189).

The heroes of the epics of the Yakut and Altai peoples are thus "lonely heroes" without parents, like Poiaunpe of the yukar. Some of these Siberian heroes are, however, more akin to Ainu rakkur, the hero of the oina of the Ainu, than to Poiaunpe, being not only "lonely" but also "culture heroes" and the first ancestors of the people, points which will be discussed later.

Situated between the Turkic and Mongol tribes in the west and the Ainu in the east, the epic literature of the Nanai contains heroes whose life and adventures are remarkably similar to those of Poiaunpe.

Lopatin outlines the standard plot of heroic epics of the Nanai as follows:

Margo, the hero, is usually an orphan boy, who is fed and brought up by a superhuman woman or a supernatural female spirit. As a miraculous child, he grows up unusually quickly. When he comes of age, his wet nurse, who has been his educator, or his supernatural helper, reveals to him the secret that his father was murdered perfidiously by an evil magician or a giant and his mother was brought into slavery. After a mysterious initiation and instruction by his supernatural helper, Margo goes to seek the murderer of his father. He has to travel for a long time, visiting many distant countries, and experiencing extraordinary adventures. Some people whom he meets are friendly, but most are very hostile and malicious. He runs against the most difficult hindrances. Among the friends with whom he has become acquainted during his travels there is usually a girl, who renders good services to him and whom he marries, sometimes before, but in most cases after his act of revenge. Incidentally it is the only romantic episode; the episode has a subordinate position in the story and is always very short. At last Margo receives information of the dwelling of his enemy and hurries there. The enemy knows that Margo exists but is of an erroneous opinion that he is still a small harmless boy. When Margo gets near the dwelling of his enemy, he discovers that the enemy lives in an inaccessible place — on a high cliff, a rock island, and the like — and that the entrance to the dwelling is guarded by a huge dog or a wild animal (e. g. a wild boar), or by both. In the end Margo stands in front of his adversary, and a horrible, very long fight begins between them. Margo injures his enemy seriously, but he cannot kill him. Then comes one of the supporters of Margo, always a female disguised as a duck flying to the arena of combat. She may be a friendly shaman, or a girl whom he met on the way, or his sister. She explains that she cannot yet find the *ergenie* (soul) of the enemy. She encourages Margo to fight on for a while and flies away in a renewed trial to search for the soul. After a while, she comes back and urges Margo to catch dexterously the soul, which she has

finally discovered on the ground of the ocean or in another hidden place. Margo catches the soul skillfully and destroys it. The adversary dies. (Lopatin 1965: 438–439; cf. Lopatin 1933: 201–236.)

If we compare the plot of the Nanai epics with that of the yukar, we recognize as common features the character of the lonely orphan hero and his revenge on the murderer of his parents. Moreover, the character of a supernatural helper and that of the girl whom the hero marries are common to the epics of both the Ainu and the Nanai. The representation of a hidden soul of the adversary in the Nanai narratives is, however, alien to the Ainu but is a recurrent feature of the epics of the Turkic and Mongol peoples. The epic literature of Central Asia is likewise not lacking in the story of an orphan boy who takes revenge on the murderer of his parents. An example is provided by the *Manas* cycle of the Kirghis, wherein Seitäk, the grandson of *Manas*, is a character of this kind (Radloff 1885 V: 356–3721; cf. Chadwick & Zhirmunsky 1969: 307). However, in Central Asian epics, this type of story does not enjoy the same popularity as in the epics of the Nanai and the Ainu.

As I have remarked above, the characters of the lonely heroes of the Yakut, Buryat, and Altai tribes bears a certain affinity to Ainu *rakkur*, the hero of the *oina*, because they are not only lonely but also culture heroes and the ancestors of the human race. For instance, the first ancestor of the Yakuts, Er-sogotokh, came swimming along the Lena River from southern regions to the present habitat of the Yakuts, and he too was a culture hero. Meletinsky writes: “The invention of a means to drive away gnats by smoke, the breeding of cattle, the making of earthenware, the establishment of a spring ritual festival (*ysyab*), and the making of the first bloodless offering in kumiss in honour of luminous gods of cattle breeders *aiyy* is ascribed to him” (Meletinsky 1969: 189). Another feature of Ainu *rakkur*, his descent from heaven to earth, is a motif which is also common to some Yakut epics. Meletinsky observes: “Besides the character of a ‘lonely’ hero, there exists in Yakut epics another character, a hero sent by heavenly gods to earth with a special mission to clear it from the *abaasy* monsters. This also is a typical deed of a ‘culture hero’” (Meletinsky 1969: 189).

Who are the Repunkur?

The yukar is essentially an epic of the battles and wars of Poiyaunpe against foreigners. Poiyaunpe belongs to the people called Yaunkur, the inland people or the dwellers of Hokkaido, while his adversaries are classified as Repunkur, the people beyond the sea. Thirty years ago Mashino Chiri advanced a highly intriguing theory of the origin of the yukar. According to Chiri, the yukars are stories depicting inter-ethnic warfares between the inlanders of Hokkaido and the invaders from the Asiatic continent across the sea. Archaeologically speaking, the inlanders are the bearers of the Satsumon culture of Hokkaido, while the invaders are the people of Okhotsk culture coming from Amurland and Sakhalin to the Okhotsk coast of Hokkaido. The ethnic clashes took place during five centuries from ca. 650 to 1150 A. D. (Chiri 1955: 218–220).

Although Chiri's theory remains only a sketch without substantiation and has been criticized ruthlessly (e. g. Kubodera 1970: 759), he was essentially right, in my opinion, in that (1) the formation of the yukar owes a great deal to inter-ethnic conflicts of the Ainu with the invading Repunkur, and (2) the Repunkur are primarily the ethnic groups living in the part of the Asian continent adjacent to the north of Hokkaido. On the other hand, I cannot underwrite his chronology and hence his identification of the Yaunkur and the Repunkur with the two above mentioned archaeological cultures, as I shall discuss in the following.

The perusal of yukars indicates that they are literary products of the social and historical milieu in which animated relations, commercial as well as military, were maintained among the inhabitants of the area stretching from the west coast of Hokkaido to Sakhalin and eastern Amurland. This picture is supported by topographical names and cultural traits mentioned in yukars. While admitting that many of the topographical names in yukars are rather hazy (Haginaga 1984), I regard it as significant that the remaining verifiable names are mostly those

along or in the Japan Sea, northwest of Hokkaido, such as Yoichi, Ishikari, Rebun, and the country of the Santa (Kindaichi 1931 II: 310; 1944: 189, 98, 295; Chiri 1955: 219). The Santa is the Ainu appellation of a Tungusic people who, influenced by Manchu culture, lived in the area from the estuary of the Amur to Lake Kizi. They travelled from this homeland to Sakhalin for trade. The Japanese called them Santan (Takakura 1966: 253).

Another indicator is the fact that many of the culture traits as sung in the yukar are obviously of northern, that is, Santa origin. Kindaichi called attention to the curious fact that the attire of the hero of the yukar is of Manchu fashion, for example, a two-edged sword, a golden girdle, and a thin conical hat (Kindaichi 1944, 396; cf. 1931 II: 250–251). This connotes the social milieu which resulted from close contacts of the Ainu with their northern neighbors. Interestingly enough, Kindaichi believes that most of the cultural traits introduced by the culture hero Okikurmi into the Ainu land were derived from the north, that is, the land of the Santa. These are the bear festival, *inau*, spring bow (Selbstschuss), harpoon, fish spear, weaving instrument for fishing net, bow and arrow, quiver, carved wooden dish, embroidery, sheath for knife, vessel of birch bark for water drawing, spoon, *tama*-jewel, brocade, conical hat, etc. (Kindaichi 1944: 394–396). Though we need some reservations concerning certain items in this impressive list, nonetheless these make a strong case for Okikurmi's and hence the oina's connection with the northern culture. These traits, as well as the topographical names, reflect intensive trade between the Ainu of Hokkaido and the Santa and other northern neighbors.

Ainu society in the seventeenth century and the Yukar

The first Santan trade on record dates back to A. D. 1143, and during the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries Chinese ceremonial dress and other valuables trickled into Hokkaido via Manchuria and Sakhalin. Precisely

at this time, between the fifteenth and seventeenth centuries, Santan trade reached its apex. At that time the Ainu of the northwestern coast of Hokkaido were active as middlemen between the Japanese in the south and the Santa in the north. Chinese brocade, gold-glittering ornaments and other objects came from the north, while the Japanese supplied ironware, lacquered ware, and so on (Takakura 1966: 251–288; Sakurai 1967: 140–141; Kaiho 1979: 90–91). As a result of these trading activities, rich and noble families began to emerge in the society of the Ainu in Hokkaido. The yukar is a product of a class society and the hero an orphan boy of proud aristocratic descent, living in a citadel. Therefore the yukar, as we know it, only came into being after the maturation of the Ainu nobility, which seems to be of a much later age than that suggested by Chiri. The yukar came into being as a corollary of trading and military enterprises of the Ainu, enterprises which can be dated around the seventeenth century as discussed above (cf. Kaiho 1979: 96–98).

The culture characterized in the yukar fits in well with this dating: metal wares and implements of wooden vessels are mentioned in the poetry, while there is no sign of pottery. Villages (*kotan*), citadels (*chashi*), and huts (*chise*) full of imported treasure are described, while subterranean dwellings do not appear in the yukar (Kaiho 1979: 87). The seventeenth century is also a reasonable dating in view of other Siberian and Central Asian epics. The origin of the epic literature of these areas is certainly shrouded in the mists of antiquity; however, it is known that many peoples experienced the heyday of their epic composition several hundred years ago, and most of the extant epics took their present forms in relatively recent times. The *uliger* of the Buryat, for example, is thought by Vladimirtsov and other orientalists to date from about the fifteenth century (Shoolbraid 1975: 19). More instructive is the case of *Manas* of the Kirghis. This epic may contain certain reminiscences of inter-ethnic conflicts of the ninth and tenth centuries, but it deals mainly with the warfare with the Kalmuck from the fifteenth to the seventeenth century. Thus *Manas* as we know it first came into being in the eighteenth century (Shoolbraid 1975: 41,

46, 47; cf. Chadwick & Zhirmunsky 1969: 142–143, 306–307). In short, these epics have as their basis experiences of historical events, such as warfare with other ethnic groups, not a thousand years ago but only three to five hundred years ago.

First-person narration and possible Japanese influence

As we have discussed, the Ainu epics are certainly connected with those of Siberian peoples. Yet the northern affinity does not tell the whole story of the formation of the yukar. One important feature of the Ainu epics seems to be not their northern derivation but the possible influence of medieval Japanese epics and plays. The feature in question is the narration in the first-person singular. Kindaichi tried to explain this by the shamanistic origin of Ainu literature. The original version of an oina, for example, was nothing but a narrative sung by a shaman possessed by the god Okikurmi, and in the course of time it gradually developed into the present form of oina, which in turn gave impetus to the formation of the heroic yukar, both of them retaining the narration in the first-person singular (Kindaichi 1931 I: 399–434; 1944: 199–202; 1961: 243). This theory wielded an enduring influence on later scholars: Kubodera subscribed to it unreservedly (Kubodera 1977b: 103–116), while Chiri conceived another possibility, i. e. the derivation of the first-person narration in the kamui-yukar and the oina from a masked play, which was also partly acquiesced in the theory of Kindaichi (Chiri 1955: 112–115, 220–221).

Yet the shamanistic theory is one which may not be substantiated by ethnographic parallels. First of all, in Siberia and Central Asia, which are the homelands of shamanism, narration in the first person is by no means typical of epic literature. Certainly there are some cases in which a certain part of the epic is told in the first person

as a technique to make the hero's personality stand out more clearly. As Bowra puts it:

In the vast Kirghiz epic of *Manas*, in one version a substantial part of the story is put in the mouth of the hero Alaman Bet, and this adds much to the variety of the poem by telling it from a different point of view and allowing a hero to give his thoughts and emotions more personally than an impartial poet can for him (Bowra 1972: 76).

But the narration in the first person as a normal modus of epic singing is very rare. Philippi observes:

I know of no other examples in world epic literature where almost every song is told in the first-person singular. In one type of Nenets folk epic, the *yarabts*, first-person narration is used, but the third-person narration is used in another type, the *syudbabts* (Philippi 1979: 27).

Recently a Japanese anthropologist, Shinko Ogiwara called the shamanistic theory into serious question. Her survey of the shaman songs among the peoples of northeastern Asia, such as the Ainu, Koreans, Mancu, Evenk, and Nivkh, demonstrates clearly that the first-person narration is rather exceptional in shaman songs. She is inclined to Chiri's interpretation that first-person narration in Ainu epics is a relic of the masked play which he believed (on rather meager evidence) to have existed in former days among the Ainu. In this play each deity speaks about himself through the mouth of the *dramatis persona*, the actor impersonating him (Chiri 1973: 210–211). In this connection Ogiwara compares this hypothetical play with the masked hunting ritual of the Evenk (Ogiwara 1984). Ogiwara may be right in her supposition, but another possibility seems to be, to say the least, equally worthy of consideration, that is, the influence of the medieval Japanese masked play, the most famous of which is the *Noh*.

Another possible influence from the Japanese side is via a certain type of medieval epic, a cue which was already provided by Kindaichi. As Kindaichi maintains, the first-person narration in Ainu literature is nothing but a self-revelation of the major character of the epic. In this

sense it reminds him of a pattern observable in some of the Japanese epics of Buddhist coloring current from about the fourteenth to the seventeenth century. In these epics the real natures of major characters are revealed at the end of the story. The heroine of the *jōruri* epic of Onzōshi Shimawatari, for example, is revealed to be but an avatar of Benzaiten (Sarasvati of Indian Buddhism). Nevertheless, Kindaichi interprets the resemblance as the result of parallel development that occurred independently among the Japanese and the Ainu (Kindaichi 1961: 131). Yet it is not clear to me why he rejects Japanese influence here.

We have to reckon that contact between the medieval and early modern Japanese epics, on the one hand, and the Ainu ones, on the other, has been much closer than has hitherto been generally admitted. To cite but two examples, the *jōruri* epic Onzōshi Shimawatari inspired the plot of some yukars (Kindaichi 1961: 131), and the oina reminded Kindaichi of Japanese *saimon*, a genre of epic sung by itinerant singers, especially current from the seventeenth to the nineteenth century. Both the oina and the *saimon* describe the origin and the feats of deities for their glorification and to provide lessons for people lacking higher education. Among others the *saimon* of Oshira deity sung by the female shaman of northernmost Honshu has surprising similarities in content and expression with the oina sung by Ainu women (Kindaichi 1944: 200–201).

In any case the possible influence of medieval Japanese epics and plays on the formation of the first-person narration of the Ainu is a problem which invites serious investigation.

Conclusion

The yukar of the Ainu is connected with epics of some Siberian peoples, such as the Nanai, which share a “lonely hero” as the central character. The yukar as we know it came into existence rather late, in about the

seventeenth century, as a result of close contacts, commercial, military, and cultural, between the Ainu of Hokkaido with the Japanese to the south and west, and the peoples in Sakhalin and eastern Amurland in the north. The first-person narration of Ainu epics hardly seems to be derived from the north, while the possibility of influence from medieval Japanese epics and plays should be taken into account.

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Epilogue

Eino Karhu

The Role of Mythologism, Past and Present

I must at the very outset make it clear that I am at the moment interested in the Kalevala and its ancient folklore and mythological roots as a student of modern literature and not as a student of folklore and mythology proper specializing in ancient culture. While studying Finnish (and in this connection western) literature of the 20th century in recent years, I had to speculate again and again over the problem of how contemporary and very modern aesthetic forms are related to extremely archaic forms, how ancient thinking and cultural patterns “agree” with modern ones. Seeking to understand certain literary and cultural facts and their links with the traditions of the past, I have come to the conclusion that in the 20th century many things are from this point of view basically different from the literature and culture of the 19th century.

The ebb and tide of mythologism

Even in the first half of the 18th century J. Vico and about a century later Schelling were developing ideas on the universal importance of mythology to the origin, existence and understanding of art. Vico was convinced that any poetic metaphor is originally a “tiny myth”; this conception was subsequently supported and dealt with by many scholars. Schelling in turn regarded mythology as a necessary condition and a primary substance for all art, modern art included. Art was for him a kind of “eternal myth-making”.

Yet the 18th and 19th centuries belonged on the whole to the age of continued “demythologising” of world culture due to the tremendous growth in the natural and social sciences. Ancient cultures also appeared in a new light — to the Romanticists, for example. Much as they were interested in folklore and mythology, it was the Romanticism of the late 18th and early 19th centuries that contributed greatly to the development of historical knowledge and the historical approach to cultural phenomena.

By contrast, the 20th century is witnessing a growing “remythologising” of culture, and a “new myth-thinking” has evolved. According to Roland Barthes’ paradox it is our time that is most “mythological”. It must be emphasized that there are many varieties and types of “mythologism” in terms of modern world culture as regards its philosophical, ideological and aesthetic aspects. Until recently, whenever the “mythologism” of 20th century literature was referred to, it was primarily West European literature that was meant — mostly Joyce, Proust, Kafka, Eliot, Thomas Mann, whose works have been widely studied in this light. And now, in very recent decades, the modern Latin American novel (Márquez, Carpentier and others) has become popular the world over and its connections with mythology are eagerly discussed, emphasizing that this is a perfectly new type of “mythologism” in comparison with previous European literature, although possible succession and similarities can also be revealed (see materials of two discussions in: *Latinskaya Amerika*, 5–6/1982; 1–3/1983).

Soviet critical analyses frequently refer to certain developments in modern Soviet literature (novels by Ch. Aitmatov, for instance), which are in some way related to folklore and a mythological background. Soviet literature has social and ideological features of its own which are different from those of western literature. Alongside this, multinational Soviet literature combines scores of comparatively young literatures which are bound up with folklore in a very specific way, more or less directly, that differs from literatures with long lifespans covering many centuries.

In addition, there is a relatively independent and extensive area of theoretical research on general problems of the genesis of verbal art from the depths of ancient mythology. This area lies on the borders of ethnological and philosophical study concerning archaic forms of human consciousness. One of the most outstanding western scholars in this field is Ernst Cassirer (3-volume work *Philosophie der symbolischen Formen*, 1923–1929), and Soviet authors include A. F. Losev, O. Freidenberg and E. M. Meletinsky, whose book *Poetika Mifa* (*Poetics of Myth*, 1976) is a comprehensive study also involving the problems of “mythologism” in West European literature of the 20th century.

The contrast of history and myth

As to western literature of the 20th century, the category of historicism, the concept of man's history as a whole should be considered as rather a major point distinguishing it from literature of the 19th century. This can also be seen in the different approach to folklore and mythological traditions. And it is precisely the concept of historicism that I am going to consider in detail.

The beginning of “remythologising” in western literature is usually associated with the modernism of the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Its ideological precursor, or rather one of its precursors, was Nietzsche, with his “revaluation of all values”, his total criticism of the humanistic heritage, liberal bourgeois traditions, and emerging socialism. Nietzsche's basic creed was a nihilist negation, history as it is and its laws being one of the main objects. He denied philosophical rationalism, theories of social progress, ideals of democracy, traditions of humanistic ethics. Nihilism was for Nietzsche a permanent and universal state of mind in modern man (“*der Nihilismus als psychologischer Zustand*”), and he explained: “Was bedeutet Nihilismus? — Dass die obersten Werte sich entwerten. Es fehlt das Ziel. Es fehlt die Antwort auf das

‘Wozu?’” (Nietzsche 1966: 577). With some variation, this kind of thinking spread widely in 20th century western culture.

Speaking in terms of Marxist social philosophy, this is usually referred to as the crisis of late bourgeois thinking. The spiritual crisis was due to the developing general crisis of capitalism as a social and economic system. The existing order ceased to seem reasonable, rational and stable. Nietzsche himself felt the forthcoming world-wide cataclysms, and later Spengler, another representative of the irrationalistic “philosophy of life”, prophesied the decline of western culture. In this case there could be no talk of any historic optimism — Nietzsche hated the very word “history”, it aroused malicious irony and annoyance in him and nothing else. The notion “history” traditionally suggested many things which he and his followers could not recognize; the major point was that, being irrationalists and subjective voluntarists, they would not consider any objective laws of historical development, not the principles of determinism in the history of culture. It is worth mentioning that the *Geistgeschichte*-school in the study of German literature (W. Dilthey, G. Simmel, Fr. Gundolf; in Finland — V. A. Koskenniemi), which was also associated with “the philosophy of life”, appeared in many ways as an antipode to the positivistic sociology of art by Hippolyte Taine and his cultural determinism. The advocates of the *Geistgeschichte*-school criticized Taine’s method not only and not so much for its real faults and narrowness as for being an art sociology as such with the basic principle of determinism.

Instead of the discredited and denounced rational concept of history there was an irrational and ahistorical myth; instead of scientific sociology — extremely polysemantic mythological symbolism; instead of positivistic linear evolutionism and linear chronology — mythlike cyclic time: either the principle of “eternal return” (*die ewige Wiederkunft*) of Nietzsche or the biological birth-death cycle in Spengler’s morphology of culture. The denunciation of chronology meant giving up the concept of the progressive and successive character of historical movement.

Nietzsche's, Bergson's and Heidegger's disbelief in rationalistic knowledge, their nostalgia for the "presocratic", "prelogical" and "pre-existential" integrity of world perception, their singing praises to emotional, intuitive and personal inner life were in some way reminiscent of 18th and 19th century Romanticism, and it is quite common to qualify the philosophers named as being those of a romantic pattern.

The position of Romanticists

There is, however, a fundamental difference. For the Romanticists of the late 18th and early 19th centuries the mythological world was not opposed to the historical one, the former did not contradict the latter. On the contrary, mythology as a reflection of ancient prehistory was logically introduced into the entire concept of historical development. To be sure, European (and Finnish) Romanticism was not as simple as that. It had a lot of contradictions and extremes. But in any case the Romantics had taken a great step towards historicism in cultural problems; they contributed much to overcoming the ahistorical attitudes of the previous Age of Enlightenment. As is known, the enlighteners considered everything in the history of mankind in the light of some eternal, normative and ahistorical reason; the accent was on what seemed to be universal and common to all times and nations, but not on what was historically unique and peculiar only to certain periods, as became characteristic of the views of Vico, Herder and the Romanticists proper.

Hegel's aesthetics meant a further development of historicism, particularly as regards the interpretation of ancient forms of art, although Hegel did not pay so much attention to mythology itself as Schelling. In Finland Schelling's aesthetic views influenced Adolf Ivar Arwidsson and other early Finnish Romanticists. As to Hegel, his ideas of historicism were very fruitful with J. V. Snellman, Elias Lönnrot, Fredrik Cyg-

naeus, R. Tengström — up to Aleksis Kivi. The Finnish nation was at a period in history in which it had to do away with the old estate system and national oppression, to prove its national identity, to search for its own historical past in order to build its own future. This historical situation in itself helped the growth of historical thinking in its most democratic variant. For those early ideologists of the Finnish nation, history was a successive movement from the past towards the future, and historical time could not stop. The awakening nation was looking far ahead, dreaming about a romantically coloured future, seeing in dreams a far-fetched past as the starting point for national history and national existence. Historical time was not cyclic and the past could not be brought back, but as a starting point for further development it had to be discovered and proved. For the ideologists of that time the old folk songs and myths were not just an expression of some eternal and timeless, always similar and endlessly repeating situation of human existence, but a message from the very specific historical past which could not be repeated. And that was their native past, the heroes of the epic songs were legendary forerunners of the Finns, not the cosmopolitan “everymen” of 20th century literature with their fear of history.

In the 19th century it was considered quite natural to emphasize in the old runes the spirit of primitive collectivism, ideals of equality. Such ideas can be found in the prefaces and papers of Elias Lönnrot. Young Robert Tengström (1823–47), who was under the influence of the left Hegelians (Manninen 1983: 2–9), also expressed in the very first phrase of his paper “Portraying Finnish People in the Kalevala” (1845) the idea of a specific historical and social background to the epos. He wrote:

There was a time in the life of nations when the elements which later disintegrated from each other were still in their original entirety, when the individual did not yet stand apart from the nation and this was not yet differentiated according to education and living conditions into classes, the same spirit prevailing everywhere, and everything being held together by the natural unity of souls (Tengström 1966, 139).

This emphasis on the ideals of primitive unity and equality appeared later in the works of Aleksis Kivi, Armas Järnefelt and Eino Leino, the contrast to these ideals being modern individualism.

The Marxist view

It should particularly be stressed that this view of archaic folk poetry and its ideals was neither the mere invention of poets nor the utopian element of the Romantic worldview (and the Romantic folklorists customarily taken to include Lönnrot, too). There is no need to go into detail or to give examples. I should, however, like to note the following point. When reading some of the modern folkloristic and literary analyses, one comes across an ironic tendency and a not very serious attitude to the Romanticists and Hegel. It is thought that their understanding of folklore, their conception of “Volksgeist”, of “a heroic age” and “an epic state of the world” (“der epische Weltzustand” in accordance with Hegel) were just one element of romantic idealism and had little to do with the contemporary scientific approach to folklore. This kind of critical “surmounting” of the Romanticists and Hegel started as far back as the second half of the 19th century in positivistic philosophy and folkloristics and it has continued to the present day.

Marxism does not share this view. As is known, Hegel’s dialectics are one of the sources of Marxism. The founders of Marxism were able to expose truly historical and revolutionary contents of dialectics despite the idealistic shell. In aesthetics and the history of art, ancient cultures included, Marx and Engels were particularly careful about Hegel’s heritage. As far as mythology and folklore are concerned, the authoritative Soviet researcher is E. M. Meletinsky. This author pointed out that, unlike the positivists of the second half of the 20th century, Karl Marx did not only neglect the merits of German philosophy from Herder to Hegel in understanding ancient cultures, but directly leant

upon them (Meletinsky 1976: 22). What had been done by the German forerunners within the frame of idealistic philosophy was reconsidered and developed within the frame of materialism.

In a letter to Engels on March 25, 1868 Marx expressed profound ideas as to the understanding of ancient arts and their significance to contemporary people. The part of the letter which is valuable to us dwells on features of the Romanticist imagination, which was taking shape in Europe under the influence of the French Revolution in the late 18th century. The Revolution and the victory of bourgeois social relations were not acceptable to all and in everything; they made many intellectuals turn with special interest to prebourgeois forms of life. Marx wrote:

...die erste Reaktion gegen die Französische Revolution und das damit verbundene Aufklärertum war natürlich alles mittelaltig, romantisch zu sehn, und selbst Leute wie Grimm sind nicht frei davon. Die 2. Reaktion ist — und sie entspricht der sozialistischen Richtung, obgleich jene Gelehrten keine Ahnung haben, dass sie damit zusammenhängen — über das Mittelalter hinaus in die Urzeit jeden Volks zu sehen. Da sind sie dann überrascht, im Ältesten das Neueste zu finden, und sogar Egalitarians to a degree, wovor Proudhon schaudern würde. (Marx & Engels 1973: 51.)

In his letter Marx mentioned the books he had just read by a prominent German bourgeois historian G. L. Maurer, who studied the history of the mediaeval German community (Mark). Marx appreciated him particularly for his arguments in favour of the system of the commune's land cultivation, which according to Maurer's works existed in older times, and thus the alleged idea of "eternal" private landownership was disapproved. Marx wrote that Maurer's books "... sind ausserordentlich bedeutend. Nicht nur die Urzeit, sondern die ganze spätere Entwicklung erhält eine ganz neue Gestalt" (Marx & Engels 1973: 50).

Of primary importance are Marx's words about Hegel. They concern Hegel's categories of the general and the particular. These categories have correspondencies in Hegel's aesthetics, especially in his views on

the history of art. In fact, “der epische Weltzustand” suggests domination of the general over the particular and the individual. And the following “prosaic state”, without any premises for epos, suggests domination of the particular and the individual over the general. Whereas some critics and interpreters of Hegel find it pure speculation and fiction, with no historical and social ground, Marx found in Hegel’s abstractions something that had a real social content in history itself. In the letter from Marx to Engels quoted above:

Was würde aber old Hegel sagen, wenn er erführe jenseits, dass das Allgemeine in Deutschen und Nordischen nichts bedeutet als das Gemeinland, und das Sundre, Besondere nichts als das aus dem Gemeindeland ausgeschiedene Sondereigen? Da gehen denn doch verflucht die logischen Kategorien aus ‘unserem Verkehr’ hervor. (Marx & Engels 1973: 52.)

This explains why epic ideals proved so much closer to democratic-minded writers and why the Kalevala was consistently perceived not as a contemporary literary work but as a picture of primitive times, though to some extent reconstructed by Lönnrot. In Lönnrot’s prefaces, as well as in the article by R. Tengström referred to, certain things may seem naive and disagreeable in the light of present knowledge. However, the very accent on primitive collectivism and ideals of equality as the main features of epic poetry and the “epic age” does not seem outdated.

From chaos to cosmos

Perhaps one of the principal differences between the 19th century and the 20th century as regards the epic and mythological heritage may be expressed in the paradox: whereas Lönnrot, in the Kalevala, arranged the chaotic remnants of the mythological past into something “organized” on the basis of his general concept of history, a lot of 20th century

western writers have attempted to arrange the chaos of present-day reality and of man's entire history by means of the myth.

As far back as 1923, T. S. Eliot wrote about this on the occasion of the dispute over Joyce's *Ulysses*. Eliot's controversial article (mostly against Richard Aldington, who received Joyce's novel coldly) had a very notorious name: "Ulysses", Order and Myth. To Eliot the novel by Joyce was a true discovery in western prose because of the mythical method of arranging modern material; it was "the most important expression which the present age has found". Eliot proceeded from the premise that contemporary man's perception of the world was something fundamentally different from that in the 19th century. The traditional novel was no longer adequate, it ended with Flaubert and Henry James. According to Eliot the traditional novel was the reflection of a rational and relatively organized world. Now, however, chaos became predominant, and in art it could be organized only by means of a mythical "order". Joyce's method was "a way of controlling, of ordering, of giving shape and significance to the immense panorama of futility and anarchy which is contemporary history... It is a method for which the horoscope is auspicious". The new prose made use of modern psychology and ethnology (Eliot referred to *The Golden Bough* by J. Frazer). And "instead of the narrative method we may now use the mythical method. It is ... a step toward making the modern world possible for art" (Eliot 1979: 224–225). Eliot predicted a great future for the new method in modern literature and in many ways he proved right.

Eliot stressed clearly enough the structural and formbuilding function of the myth in the modern novel. The same "ordering" function was inherent in mythology itself. As Meletinsky points out, the transformation of chaos into an "organized" cosmos constitutes the content of any mythology, and in modern western literature "myth developed into an instrument of the structural analysis of the narrative, rid of social-historic and space-time aspects, focusing upon revealing the metaphorically eternal generalized contents" (Meletinsky 1976: 169).

Merging of time and space

Attention should be paid to the space-time categories as they appear in myths proper and in 20th century literature “mythologism”. The most important space-time aspects in myths as they are understood by scholars can be indicated briefly as follows: in mythologic thinking space, time and the world of things are not yet differentiated, they appear in a unity. There is no “empty”, void space, as there is no void abstract time. Space and time merge to make a unity, the so-called *chronotop*, everything occurs “here” and “now”. Then, myths know no movement and flow of time, no distinct division into the past, the present and the future. O. Freidenberg characterizes time in myths as “one-dimensional”, “static”, “timeless”; it is a kind of *praesens atempore*, “timeless present” (for E. Cassirer mythological imagination is “*ein zeitloses Bewusstsein*”). According to Freidenberg one of the basic laws of mythological thinking is “a symbiosis of the past and the present”, “insurmountability” of the past, which will always be present and recurrent in rites, and so will “actualize” in consciousness.

Something like this can be observed, though on a completely different psychological level, in the “mythologism” of 20th century literature. Very pronounced are the points of contact with e. g. Bergson’s interpretation of time. It is well known that Bergson had a considerable influence on 20th century literature and art (he was awarded the Nobel Prize in 1927 for literature). Bergson’s concept of duration (*durée*) is exceedingly psychologized and associated with the function of man’s memory, with the mechanism of thinking. Strictly philosophically, Bergson’s intuitivism is usually characterized as a kind of subjective idealism and “philosophy of life”, though from the point of view of modern psychologism the literature and art of the 20th century have gained from him not a little. “Internal duration”, Bergson wrote, “is a continuous life of memory to extend the past into the present” (Bergson 1914: 27). Reminiscences that have been accumulated by memory can be stored passively for a long time in some corners of the subconscious.

Under certain conditions they come to life (“are actualized”) and the awakened recollection of the past passes “into the state of the present”, turns into almost acute present experience. Reminiscences, therefore, are “materialised” in emotions, in images, and acquire spatial characteristics.

Finnish writers as examples

I am not going to touch on the influence these ideas have exerted on European literature — much has been written about this. Just a few examples from Finnish literature.

One of the first Finnish writers to begin experimenting with the category of time was F. E. Sillanpää (1888–1964). A biologist by education, a follower of evolutionism, he took an interest in Bergson’s ideas, Einstein’s theory of relativity, Freud’s psychoanalysis. All these latest theories in his creative mind were in contact with something like a very archaic mythological world-perception. Dominating Sillanpää’s prose is his primary concern for the natural cyclic and psychologically synchronic time, whereas linear chronology is in the background. In 1916 Sillanpää wrote his first novel *Life and Sun*, describing one summer in the life of a young man in such a way that there was no certain feeling of real time and its linear motion. The author stressed that in his novel time was “uncertain”, it was something like the “atemporal” present of myths.

The trend was towards a spatial and “landscapic” time depiction, its spatial metaphorisation. In the epilogue to the novel it was particularly emphasised:

All the autumns, summers, springs and winters which have ever been seen in this world make a chain of landscapes to be fancied as hovering in space in some distance. Seen like that, they no longer need any chronology. At first the notion of time disappears, then place, and now one is not sure at all that they do exist. (Sillanpää 1916: 335–336; see also Karhu 1984.)

In other words, not only time but also topos ceases to be concrete, loses its local certainty and becomes "topos in general".

In Finnish lyrics something like this is found in the books of Eeva-Liisa Manner (born 1921). In her poems and her own commentaries Manner has stressed more than once that time is in her mind associated with space, or rather time is transformed into space, it possesses the physical properties of space and appears in material and spatial images. In Manner's collection *This is the Way Seasons Take Turns* (1964) there is a lyric cycle called "On the relationship of time and space", and according to Manner "time is landscape" (Rainio 1969: 217; Karhu 1983). This "landscapic" view is also used to observe the history of humanity. Historic events and epochs from the earliest times up to the present day appear in the mind simultaneously, and in this simultaneous "landscapic" panorama of history only space coordinates, the space perspective and not the chronological one are of importance.

Apart from the purely subjective and psychological perception of time, with the past, the present and the future merging, this artistic vision also possesses a social and philosophical aspect. Being extremely pessimistic socially, Manner, like many other western modernists, is quite sceptical about such notions as progress, historic development. For one who recognizes social progress in history, time is full of historic movement. The historic past, present and future do not just succeed one another but differ from one another in quality. And on the contrary, for one who does not believe in the very possibility of historic progress, time is devoid of this qualitative movement and different historical epochs are not qualitatively different steps in social progress. So history as a whole is often perceived as an absolute evil, an endless row of recurrent tragedies and horrors. This leads to nostalgia for primitive "prehistorical" and "premetaphysical" times. Manner's world perception was noticeably affected by Heidegger, who, like Bergson, greatly valued myths. In Manner's lyrics the rationalistic is frequently opposed to "the magic", which is associated with the childhood of man and the childhood of mankind, with "the pre-existential" mythologic antiquity.

The role of mythologism today

Having made these observations about the unusual treatment of space-time relations in Finnish literature, I came across some most intriguing studies on a similar problem in western literature as a whole. This supports the assumption that the illustration from Finnish literature is not incidental; it is a particular case of a more widespread trend in western literature of the 20th century. Essential variations in interpreting space-time relations have been analysed in detail in the novels of Joyce, Proust and some other western prose writers by Joseph Frank in his work *The Widening Gyre* (1963). Referring to earlier researchers (A. Tate, M. Eliade) and giving parallels from the sphere of modern painting, Frank comes to this conclusion: by “juxtaposition” of past and present “history becomes ahistorical. Time is no longer felt as an objective, causal progression with clearly marked-out differences between periods; now it has become a continuum in which distinctions between past and present are wiped out... Just as the dimension of depth has vanished from the sphere of visual creation, so the dimension of historical depth has vanished from the content of the major works of modern literature... Ever since the Renaissance, modern man has cultivated both the objective visual imagination (the ability to portray space) and the objective historical imagination (the ability to apprehend chronological time); both have now been abandoned. What has occurred, at least so far as literature is concerned, may be described as the transformation of the historical imagination into myth — an imagination for which historical time does not exist, and which sees the actions and events of a particular time only as the bodying forth of eternal prototypes” (Frank 1963: 59.) Frank cites Eliade’s words confirming that in modern thought there is “a resistance to history, a revolt against historical time”. “The time world of history”, Frank concludes, is transmuted “into a timeless world of myth. And it is this timeless world of myth, forming the common content of modern literature, that

finds its appropriate aesthetic expression in spatial form.” (Frank 1963: 59—60.)

The analysis and conclusions made by Frank are of considerable interest, although certain accents appear to be extremely generalized. As I have said, there are completely different kinds of ”mythologism“ in modern world literature, also in Western European literature. Meletinsky points out that poetics of ”mythologising“ are employed quite differently by, say, Joyce and Thomas Mann, two western writers with a different world outlook and a different creative method. As a realist Mann cannot be squeezed into the framework of modernism, he never cuts his ties with realism; in him myth is combined with history, cyclic time with historical time (Meletinsky 1976: 298—340).

Occasionally a modern realistic novel may open in a way reminiscent of “epics of genesis” in myths and folk songs. The empirical events of history are preceded by legendary “prehistory” with an “absolute commencement”, as is usual in myths; in a novel an old man may tell a legend about the first people in his native locality, about how they built the first village and how life proceeded afterwards — the story may now go on in a more empirical way, not in a legendary one. Novels with such plots can be found in Finnish literature of the 19th and early 20th centuries. The modern Finnish novel writer Väinö Linna was about to follow this pattern (the story of three brothers in an early draft for his novel *Here Under the Northern Star*), but gave it up later (see Karhu 1980). Local legends as a prologue to historical events have been employed by modern Soviet Karelian writers, and in this case legends are combined with history. Something like this method, though in a very different stylistic shape, appears in Márquez’s *Hundred Years of Loneliness*. The story also begins “from the very beginning”, it is like a legend about the first people in the locality setting up a village, a kin, a community and so on.

In all these cases myth gets on rather well with history, it is not opposed to history. Moreover, it contributes to the aesthetically generalized perception of history. In relation to Márquez’s novels certain Soviet critics speak about his “new aesthetic historism” (Zemskov 1977:

83–85). Frequent violations of logic causality, very often typical of myths, neglect of the laws of empirical space and time — all these, alongside the mythological symbolism and rich fantasy, make Márquez's style very specific.

Some scholars are inclined to classify myths as “high” and “low”, “poetic” and “horrorful”. This strict division can hardly have any grounds within the frame of mythology itself. It is another thing that in the most recent culture, up to the present day, myths have been interpreted in very different ways. So far as “mythologism” in literature is concerned, the core of the problem seems to lie in the character of the writer's world outlook which determines his attitude to social history and cultural traditions.

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Lauri Honko

The Kalevala: Problems of Interpretation and Identity

The Kalevala is a good example of how an epic attains mythlike qualities upon its reception, how it becomes a uniting symbol and cultural force for some people and a repellent for others. It is enigmatic for its language, problematic for its contents (even to its compiler, Elias Lönnrot!) and ambiguous for its function. The latter half of the Kalevala process calls for an assessment of the impact that the epic made on the public that received it, especially the varying interpretations it was able to generate through time, and the role it played and still plays in the construction and maintenance of cultural identity or identities in Finland. The validity of interpretations must be checked both against the historical and political situation of the time in question and the rules of scholarly source criticism. Finally the epic must be placed in the arena of cultural communication: what mythologemes and messages does it carry for modern man? What are those processes like where the epic may be adhered to, and by whom and for what purpose?

The seesaw of interpretation

Is the Kalevala first and foremost a historical or a mythical epic? This has been a burning question among readers and scholars from the very beginning of the Kalevala process. For four decades the answer was sought in the Kalevala itself until, in the latter half of the 1870s, there

emerged a scientific school of folklore research that first of all ordered scholars to forget the Kalevala and to delve deep into the poems as they were originally written down. The question thus became formulated as: do the events and characters described in the folk poems on which the Kalevala is founded bear features that link them with historical facts verifiable by other means, or should the poems be viewed primarily as reflections of an ancient mythical worldview?

The problem was in a way taken outside the Kalevala, to apply to Finnish folk poetry in general, i. e. to a domain in which there had been debate even before the Kalevala, as during the days of Juslenius and Porthan in the 18th century. Even the exhortation by Gustav II Adolf (cf. p. 184) hints at the existence of both historical and mythological material, even though the former clearly dominated, and the model for the interpretation of Mikael Agricola's list of pagan deities (1551) is, understandably, purely mythological. In other words: interpretation is as old as the collection and study of folklore.

The shift in emphasis from the Kalevala to the original folk poems had both advantages and disadvantages. Naturally it was rational to analyse the exceptionally large source material for the epic and to use it as the basis for deductions on the nature of Finnish folk poetry. But at the same time the Kalevala became a mere facade for folklore research, more a matter of cultural policy than of scholarly interest, and study of the history of its sources became the concern of only a few scholars, tending at the same time to merge with literary research and aesthetic appraisals. Thus domestic research on the Kalevala had far less impact on international comparative epic research than it could have had. Similarly, research into the reception of the Kalevala did not receive the attention it deserved, for it was regarded as being of only secondary importance, though from the point of view of the reception of folklore and of national literature it was indeed primary. For a number of reasons debate on the Kalevala acquired an amateur stamp.

Elias Lönnrot's own view of the interpretation and source value of the Kalevala is only now receiving attention from scholars, thanks to Väinö Kaukonen's pioneering work. As referred to above (p. 219),

Lönnrot's view was historical and gained strength as the Kalevala process for his part drew to a close, but another possibility would be to view the Kalevala as a mythological dictionary along the lines of Hesiod or Edda. Lönnrot appears to have wavered between the historical and the mythical interpretation in selecting the sub-title for his Old Kalevala. "The Kalevala, or Old Karelian Poems about the Ancient Times of the Finnish People" does beyond any doubt suggest history, but one of the alternative names he had in mind was "Finnish Mythology as Manifest in Ancient Poetry" (Kaukonen 1979: 53). One reason for his indecision may have been that while he was editing the Kantele booklets he was also working on a manuscript entitled "Tillökningar till Gananders Finska Mythologie" (Additions to Ganander's Finnish Mythology), and he had plans for a new enlarged edition of Ganander's Mythology (Kaukonen 1979: 37). It should, however, also be noted that the categories of history and mythology did not mean quite the same thing to Lönnrot and his contemporaries as they do to the scholars of our time.

The developmental profile of the interpretation of the Kalevala and folk poems calls to mind a seesaw in which the components history and mythology are always present, but one weighs more than the other at a given moment (cf. Honko 1987). It seems to be the rule that the historical interpretation tends to be turned to at times when there is a pressing need to boost the national identity, or the nation is in a state of crisis, a crisis of identity. Nationalism both sharpens and narrows the angle of vision and does not do justice to the internationality of folklore. Of special interest in the historical paradigm founded on a linear concept of time is the evolutionist variant, according to which folk poems reflect particular stages in the development of society or the economic structure. The mythological interpretation is normally put forward at more peaceful times, which often may be dynamic from the point of view of research, and the international and universally human elements of tradition clearly get emphasised in the process.

Viewed from this perspective, the historical interpretation is uppermost in the case of Juslenius, Lönnrot, the old Kaarle Krohn and the

young Martti Haavio, the mythical interpretation in the case of Porthan and his students, Julius Krohn, the young Kaarle Krohn, the mature Martti Haavio and his students. This would mean that there were periods of crisis at the turn of the 17th and the 18th centuries, the early decades of the 19th century, in the 1910s and the 1930s. The mythological paradigm heralding the expansion and growing internationalism of scholarship would accordingly coincide with the latter half of the 18th century, the closing decades of the 19th century and the period since the 1950s. This hypothesis finds plenty of support in the history of the nation and of folklore research. Yet every era has its *rara avis*, its major nonconformist: E. N. Setälä in the 1930s and Matti Klinge in the 1980s. The idea cherished by William A. Wilson that the conclusions drawn by Finnish scholars have been guided more by nationalism and politics than by cool, scholarly logic would be far more convincing were it not applied with the same emphasis to eras in which the internal development of scholarship, not the external political situation, has been foremost in pointing the way. It is also necessary to bear in mind the dissimilarity between not only eras but also between scholars and schools: they may possibly explain why two professors, the visionary patriot Kaarle Krohn and the spirited nationalist politician E. N. Setälä, find themselves on opposite sides of the paradigm fence (cf. Honko 1979: 148–149).

Lönnrot's historical vision

The Turku Romantics and student politicians of the 1810s and 1820s, the pioneers in the building of a national identity for autonomous Finland, had circulated the idea that folklore was a real treasure trove for discovering the early history and indigenous literature of the nation. This could hardly fail to impress the young Elias Lönnrot, but he was also very much influenced by the views of his teacher, Reinhold von

Becker. A direct model was provided by von Becker's experiment in the interpretation of the poems about Väinämöinen; he came to the conclusion that Väinämöinen was a great historical figure, even going so far as to call him a king. It is not known whether or not von Becker possibly had in mind the ruler genealogies familiar from such ancient historical works as Saxo Grammaticus, in which the genealogies were always traced back to gods and mythical characters. In any case Lönnrot, continuing von Becker's experiment in his dissertation, gradually began to adopt as his guideline an ancient historical vision of an era when Väinämöinen lived and shaped the fate of his people. Later this vision was constantly added to and adjusted: Lönnrot studied Homer and the history of antiquity, collected scientific information on the ancient history of the Finns and sounded out the rune singers' feeling for history. This 'ethnohistory' was a genre fed entirely by folk poetry and a source not to be disdained, especially by the Romantics.

Lönnrot's vision of the primeval history of the Finnish people was one degree more Christian and euhemeristic than the oral poetry from which it was conceived: the compiler of the epic believed that the religion of the ancient Finns had monotheistic features, even though the meadows and forests were still peopled by local spirits. Very often posterity had attributed divine features to some historical figure, such as Väinämöinen or Ilmarinen. In seeking a time and a place for his vision, Lönnrot finally located the events recounted in the poems somewhere along the migration route of the Finnish peoples, to the south of the White Sea, more than a thousand years ago (Kaukonen 1979: 92–98). An echo of the ruler genealogies can be discerned in Lönnrot's speculations on Kaleva, a sort of initial ancestor from whom Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen and Lemminkäinen were descended (Kaukonen 1979: 82). Another very hypothetical figure was Louhi, the female leader of the people of Pohja of whose tribe Joukahainen was a member. The oral poems did not provide any proof whatsoever of these genealogies, but Lönnrot needed them to devise the plot structure of the Kalevala (Honko 1984: 34).

In formulating this fictive, quasi-historical ancient vision — part scientific, part poetic — Lönnrot entered the world of Kalevala more fully than we may imagine. Being a scholar, he wanted to incorporate any research results that might throw some light on the Finns' past, and as an epic poet he listened to the voice of the past as whispered to him by the rune singers, the first receivers of the poetic messages from the past. They too had a picture of history, albeit shifting and non-systematic, painted by their poems. In listening to the poems Lönnrot went so far that the ancient Kalevala era appeared to him as one stage in history of which the Kalevala was evidence. This perhaps explains the astonishing fact that Lönnrot from time to time speaks of the Kalevala as a source of academic scholarship providing an insight into the social life of the past. He clearly played down his own contribution and played up the historical or ethnographic source value of the Kalevala more than was justified. Outi Lehtipuro recently drew attention to this too:

One cannot help being astonished at the concrete vision of the world of the Kalevala Lönnrot had created in his mind by the 1840s. He could envisage the geographical relationships between the two focal points of his epic, Pohjola and Kalevala, the nature of his characters and the “belonging” of some of the poems to the Kalevala poems just as if he had forgotten his own role in creating that ancient world. (Lehtipuro 1985: 26.)

Some of the ethnographical and prehistorical conclusions reached by Lönnrot are to be found in, for example, the brief commentaries to his abridged edition of the Kalevala. He thus explains the place names Häme and Kemi (Lönnrot 1862, canto 20:15–16) and Neva (Lönnrot 1862, canto 47:83) as “itinerant names” that “accompanied the Finns on their migrations to their present abodes. They cannot therefore be ascribed to the present places of the same name” (Lönnrot 1862: 362, cf. 388). Of the name Lappi (Lapland) he says that it was in those days applied to “border peoples in general”, whereas the name Turja “probably referred to a Scandinavian people on the shores of the Arctic

Ocean” (Lönnrot 1862, canto 12:65–66). Lönnrot’s ancient historical vision forced him to detach familiar place names from their present referents and to ‘antiquify’ them by means of his itinerant name hypothesis. He further subjected the relations between Pohjola and Kalevala to meteorological scrutiny: “Since the cold northerly winds came from the direction of Pohjola [the North], Pohjola was called a cold village, even though the weather there was not much colder than at Kalevala” (Lönnrot 1862: 383–384). The concretisation of the “cold village” is astonishing, for Lönnrot must have known from many contexts that it was specifically an image associated with Tuonela, the Underworld.

Lönnrot’s ancient historical interpretation of the Kalevala certainly did not meet with universal approval. Snellman, among others, doubted it (Sarajas 1984: 38) and Jacob Grimm proposed a mythical interpretation instead (Grimm 1845). But neither such authorities nor his close friend Fabian Collan, who in 1838 suggested that Väinämöinen and Ilmarinen were originally divine beings (Kaukonen 1979: 95, 176–177), could make Lönnrot change his mind. He was prepared to compromise over details, but not over his basic view.

Lönnrot’s allegories

The opinions of most of Lönnrot’s contemporaries and interpreters of the Kalevala are indeed highly understandable when we recall the ease with which the most influential and even the most critical scholars, from M. A. Castrén to August Ahlqvist, fell back on the Romantic-inspired assumption that there might well be, somewhere in the background, an ancient original epic far exceeding the poetic sequences or “minor epics” (Ahlqvist) that had been preserved. But Elias Lönnrot, composer of the Kalevala, cannot be placed on a par with them. It is therefore astonishing to note his role as an outside interpreter of the

Kalevala, his conjectures, when in fact he should know. What in Lönnrot's case are the foundations for the autonomy of the Kalevala, what is the nature of a source constantly capable of revealing new depths of knowledge? Also surprising is the reinforcement of the role of interpreter towards the end of the Kalevala process, in other words simultaneous with his growing awareness of his personal responsibility as an epic poet. For Lönnrot the Kalevala was always to be an enigma.

We here see the fundamental difference between epics founded on folk poetry and epics that are purely literary. The creators of the former are not masters of their material to the same extent as the latter: they speak "through a greater mouth", in this case the mouth of a strong poetic tradition. This tradition contained elements that were not entirely unambiguous and that therefore directly provoked new interpretations. Elias Lönnrot had his hands tied: he had to make do with the line material available. In striving towards representativeness he could not discard at will anything that was difficult to understand. Thus the poems continued to contain riddles that could be solved by neither the singers nor the compiler of the epic.

What Lönnrot had to develop in this situation was a method of comparative reading. The numerous variations on the same theme did not merely confuse the message; they tended more to determine the boundaries of interpretation. A theme could be defined not by reading one variant word by word but by interpreting many variants simultaneously. Thus many of the conjectures Lönnrot put forward after the publication of the Kalevala may be viewed as a direct continuation of the arguments that passed through his mind as he collected his material and sketched his epic. Despite all the cutting up and rearranging, the ancient message portrayed in the poems nevertheless remained autonomous in Lönnrot's eyes. Fettered by his view of authenticity, he was at the mercy of his material, more so even than the composer/singer of some extensive oral epic in some living poetic culture. The jigsaw puzzle did not merely solve problems; it also created them. The reader unaware of this may in Lönnrot's company have the feeling he is facing pseudo-problems.

It would be doing Lönnrot an injustice to describe his interpretations as exclusively historical. They embrace far more than this, such as his argument of why the Kullervo episode is a vital condition for the successful abduction of the Sampo (Lönnrot 1862: 381) or why Väinämöinen could no more make a new kantele than Ilmarinen a new Sampo. ("Great deeds cannot be repeated", Lönnrot 1862: 384.) Lönnrot produces a model for Lemminkäinen's boasting on being shown a place by the door in the Pohjola household, "my father did not indeed stand in that place": "Homer's heroes boast of their fathers, too, and wished not to be inferior to them" (Lönnrot 1862: 371). He also had a clear partiality for allegorical explanations. The most impressive of these concerns the Sampo: the minimal, almost nonextant or abandoned elements of which the powerful Sampo machinery is made, i. e. "the tip of a swan's feather", "the milk of a farrow cow", "the fleece of a summer ewe", "a tiny ear of barley" turn out to be symbols of the development of society and its occupations (Lönnrot 1862: 349), and the interpretation continues as the Sampo is forged. The arrow poking up out of the fire is "the symbol of hunting", the red boat "the symbol of fishing", the heifer "the symbol of cattle-raising" and the plough "the symbol of farming" (Lönnrot 1862: 353). Reducing the cultural evolution of mankind to a series of images, the components of which combine in the Sampo and appear to presage the breakthrough of industrial society, is an allegory impressive even today. It is unlikely that Lönnrot would have read Morgan, and he would not therefore have been aware that his interpretation coincided with the cultural-anthropological theory of evolution.

The nationalist allegories are a category in themselves. The fact that Väinämöinen took hairs from a weeping maiden as the strings for his kantele is explained: "Thus Finnish poetry became a mixture of joy and of sorrow" (Lönnrot 1862: 386). The last poem in the *Kalevala*, widely known to be the work of Lönnrot, becomes a defence of the nation's poetry, and especially of that in the Finnish language: the singer's mother has died (= "the era that bore and nurtured Finnish poetry is no more"), the singer's listeners are the trees of the forest (= "the

gentry speaking a foreign language that favour my song just as much as the trees in the distant forest”), he was separated young from his mother (= “I took orders from another at a tender age”), found himself “cast to the winds” (= “to the cold, northerly borders of the land”), where “one cursed my tongue, one denounced my voice” (= “one became impatient at my Finnish words, another at my monotonous voice”) and where the singer “was forced to labour and toil” so that he could not, like the gentry, “seek learning abroad” (Lönnrot 1862: 392).

Väinämöinen’s parting promise to return once again appeared in the eyes of the Lönnrot working on the abridged edition of the Kalevala on the brink of the 1860s to be coming true: “The national and linguistic events of present-day Finland are carrying out Väinämöinen’s prophesy” (Lönnrot 1862: 391). The poetic message from the past was at one with the nation’s living history.

The difficulties confronting the historical and the ethnographic interpretation

Towards the end of the 19th century the tradition of interpretation fathered by Elias Lönnrot made its appearance in, for example, Finland’s schools, and it has coloured popularising debate on the Kalevala even up to the present day. It became the somewhat thankless task of the study of folklore founded by Julius Krohn to emphasise the importance of source criticism. Folkloristic debate on the Kalevala has in fact long been a question of tacking between Scylla and Charybdis: on the one side the patriots fearing the depreciation of Lönnrot’s work or the loss of their Kalevala inheritance, on the other side critics from K. B. Wiklund to William A. Wilson accusing the researchers of double-dealing or the failure to speak out.

Few scholars — and even fewer dilettantes — who have attempted a historical interpretation have the patience to attack the available folk poetry material so systematically that the scientific demands can be satisfied. As in the case of interpretations of the Sampo, there is a steady stream of new hypotheses, but no one can be bothered to relate them to all the evidence available. As far as the Middle Ages and earlier periods are concerned, there are so few documents that the researcher's imagination can roam almost unchecked.

There is, perhaps, no need for the folklorist to express an opinion on theories that are founded on and proved by criteria that exist for the most part or entirely outside folk poetry and tradition. But when this material is referred to, a word about source criticism is called for. Martti Haavio's work *Väinämöinen* (1952) is an example showing the potential of source criticism in a research situation in which the evidence is almost entirely folkloristic but the cultural-historical frame of reference is still adhered to. "God or man?" is the title of the first chapter, which opens up a perspective on a subject that has occupied many a generation of scholars. On reaching the end of the work the reader realises the impossibility of a plain either/or: there are at least two *Väinämöinen*s in the poems, the shaman and the cultural hero, whose characters display stratified motifs from primitive belief systems and international myths and legends. No historical core, such as the shaman-seer of centuries past, is to be found any longer in the poems, though the idea of the influence of one or more historical sage figures on the composition of the poems about *Väinämöinen* or the poetry ascribed to other shamanic heroes is not entirely impossible. The poems do, however, present a stratified mythical worldview that preserves remnants of different cultural eras and tradition contexts.

Source criticism is forced to invalidate the theory cherished by Lönnrot of the *Kalevala* as at least a guiding source of early Finnish history. But it must immediately be added that the socio-historical vision manifest in Lönnrot's *Kalevala* nevertheless preserves its cultural-historical interest, not least as a contemporary attempt to view history through poetry in a way that could not fail to influence the nation's

concept of itself. Maybe it was precisely through the Kalevala that the Finns' sense of history acquired a touch of 'ethnohistory', a folklore-oriented worldview manifest so widely in language and the arts. This is something different from and more important than the attempts, doomed it appears to failure, to connect Väinämöinen, Ilmarinen, Lemminkäinen and Joukahainen with some historical figure, or even to fit them into some exact time or place. The stratified nature and to some extent the regional divergences of these figures and their development make historical reconstruction in this respect impossible. The linear history of facts comes to grief in Finnish epic poetry, in which such unquestionably historical poems as *The Death of Elina*, *Duke Charles* and *The Death of Bishop Henry* play an exceedingly minor role. For some reason historical subjects have never enjoyed the popularity of mythical and ontological. Finland therefore lacks, for example, a genealogy of rulers listing the kings of the realm, beginning with mythical heroes and ending with historical rulers. Lönnrot and his contemporaries tried to amend this shortcoming by grafting Väinämöinen and Ilmarinen onto the family trees of hypothetical King Kaleva or the supreme god Ukko.

The question of the ethnographical reliability of the Kalevala and folk poetry is slightly more complicated. The question is, do the customs and behaviour, the tools and utensils, the vehicles and weapons, etc. described in the epic reflect the true culture of some region or era? Here again folkloristic source criticism is forced to curb optimism. In the Kalevala's case Lönnrot's working method imposes certain reservations: in combining the poems of different singers and regions he became estranged from the true cultures in which the poems lived and was forced to observe his instinct and his ancient historical vision. In a way he created a new authenticity that ultimately relied on his concept of Kalevala society as the preliminary stage in the nation's history. Ethnographically the result was, however, a patchwork quilt whose colourful squares might momentarily correspond to some feature of an existing folk culture, but only as pieces, never as weighty entities. Lönnrot's interpretations, too, often applied specifically to details. Thus

he commented on the lines describing how Väinämöinen and Ilmarinen made a fishing net (“weave a bast net, hammer one of juniper, they dyed it in a willow decoction, did this with water-willow bark”, Lönnrot 1862, 47:161–164): “For want of a better material, people in the olden days did perhaps weave nets of bast and juniper bark or roots. Nets were further dyed in bark water, to make them stronger and, so it is said, better for fishing” (Lönnrot 1862: 389). When, in forging the Sampo, Ilmarinen “set the winds to blowing, strong gusts to pumping the bellows” (Lönnrot 1862, 10:207–208), this was, according to Lönnrot, “proof that the force of the wind was even then used not only in shipping” (Lönnrot 1862: 353).

The second question is: do even the original folk poems reflect folk culture with photographic accuracy? The answer varies slightly from one genre of poetry to another — incantations, wedding lays, bear-ceremonial poems, lyrics, epics proper, etc. — but it is more qualified than might be assumed. The ritual poems, for example, were, after all, the products of everyday events and festivals, and the lyric reflected basic, more or less unceasing emotions. Even so the poems were not photograph-like representations of reality. There is always a distance between the reality portrayed in poetry and the true world of the singer, and spotting this distance calls for genre-analytic source criticism and a familiarity with the true culture. To give an example: bears were in reality slain with firearms, but in poetry always with bows and spears. Encouraged, presumably, by observations such as this, Lönnrot set out to construct a fictive ancient Finnish way of life. The customs and practices communicated by the poems are often poorly suited to the present day, but they may perhaps be better suited to some earlier period in history. This may have been the case, but not necessarily, and it was by no means easy to place the material on the same cultural plane or at the same stage of social development.

There is yet a third level at which we may speak of historicity, namely that of social structures and the worldview based upon them. It is then no longer a question of photographic accuracy but of the values and attitudes expressed in the poems. These may be assumed to

have filtered through the singers' consciousness in a way that could not but influence their concept of reality. They helped them to understand, to analyse and to express reality even when they lay remote from everyday experience. At this point we begin to shift from history and ethnography to the mythical worldview. In the Kalevala's case the question of the relationship between the realities manifest by poetry and by society acquires the form: what was Lönnrot's attitude to the social structures he encountered in folk poetry and how did he integrate them? In other words, the filter is again Lönnrot.

Mythologemes and communication

Folkloristic source criticism thus seems almost to eliminate the Kalevala in demanding external control independent of the Kalevala for almost all the material presented in it. Does this mean to say that the folk poems make the Kalevala unnecessary? Of course not. It would be equally groundless to say that an original folk poem can only be read and understood after reading a scientific monograph on it. The Kalevala has a direct part to play in cultural communication as such, it inundates us with mythologemes, for example, just as profusely and as effectively as the original myth poems. The listening method is exactly the same in both cases, which means that the poems must be accepted as such. Genuine, original folk poems, for example, do not need to be subjected to text-critical analysis, to be compared with their variants, to be held up against distant models. We have to assume that they made complete sense in their own performing context and that they were part of a living worldview. If we know enough about this context, the message of the poem may be captured even beyond the cultural and linguistic borders of the listener. It is, of course, also important to listen to other poems from the same region or community, especially if we wish to trace the systematic features of that worldview.

We approach the Kalevala by the same method. The Kalevala myths are of course Lönnrot's variants, but we may discern beneath them a mythologeme, the basic structure of a mythic motif. The archaic myths communicate to us through both the Kalevala and the folk poetry. A wealth of variants is part of the life of a myth (see further Honko 1987). On receiving the myth we create our own variant of it. A given structural basic message, which we may not always be able to express precisely in words, is preserved from one culture to another, and it is upon this that we found the actual meaning of a myth. Listening to myths demands a form of interaction involving us and the performer or sources of the myth, so there is neither any reason nor any need to reject Lönnrot as one transmitter of the myth. His variant is in this respect just as authentic as Ontrei Malinen's, the folk singer of the Sampo cycle. We are here dealing with one basic form of human communication, our media being mythologemes and a cyclical concept of time. As the receivers of myths we react in the manner of primitive man: we leave the present moment and the linear progression of historical time and place ourselves amid the events and sacred history of primeval time, drawing on its models and basic messages to analyse the meaning of events in the present moment. Viewed in this way, the question of the message communicated by the Kalevala and folk poems is tied to the present day, to our reception, our problems, our fears and our hopes. But it is important to note that the process of giving meaning is still structured by the old myths, many of which found their way into the Kalevala and there continued to revolve.

Like it or not, we are part of a folklore process, and of the Kalevala process. We find ourselves in the role of interpreter, and here we are not alone. We also operate with mythologemes in academic debate. Epic research has been guided by the age-old dream of a "golden age", the memory of which is thought to be preserved in epics. The Romantic scholars further developed a concept of a special heroic era characterised by battles and militant trading without which the epic could not exist. In the 19th century Friedrich von Schlegel and Hegel incorporated this in their aesthetics, and in Finland it was applied to the Kalevala by

such scholars as Snellman and Robert Tengström, the former doubting that the Finns ever had a heroic era and thus a true epic, the latter gathering together the militant features of the Kalevala to prove that a heroic era did indeed exist. In our century historians from Jalmari Jaakkola to Matti Klinge have again and again been fired by images of ancient empires and expeditions to distant lands, in connection with precisely this mythologeme and seeking support in folk poems. The opposing interpretation or Marxist variant sees the Kalevala and folk poetry as founded on a pre-feudal, classless society, the basic unit of which is the kin or tribal community operating on the principle of joint ownership. Among those who applied this to the Kalevala were Yrjö Sirola and O. V. Kuusinen (Sallamaa 1985: 108–118).

The competition between these two interpretations or myths of origin has had profound consequences in the study of folk poetry and the cultural history of the Kalevala. Basically the divergence between the interpretations applies to the nature of the society that gave birth to the poetry. According to both interpretations the trend was one of increasing impoverishment: the society of the golden age was lost, but the oral tradition preserved an unbroken tradition that passed on the message of the ancient existence of that society. And even today this message is taken up by more and more researchers, artists and politicians in their desire to reinforce or mould the Finnish or Karelian identity.

Right or wrong identity?

Any talk of history, mythology and the past is in the case of the Kalevala misleading, if it is thought to be founded purely on curiosity as to things past. Isolated historical facts and individual fragments of myths would indeed not be able to spark off the emotion and arguments that are constantly provoked by the Kalevala process. It has just as much to do with us, if not more, than with the past, and the real point

of the debate lies in the present and the future. When today the historians Heikki Kirkinen and Matti Klinge put pen to paper on the subject of the Kalevala, the item in the balance is no less than the Finnish identity, which Kirkinen domiciles in the Greater Karelia or Eastern Finland of ancient times, Klinge in the Baltic region and Southwest Finland (e. g. Kirkinen 1984a, b, c and Klinge 1985). The purpose of these orientations is fairly plain to behold — one looks towards Karelia, the other away from Karelia. One cannot help recalling the controversy that raged a century ago between August Ahlqvist, champion of the Kalevala's Karelianism, and A. A. Borenius-Lähteenkorva and Julius Krohn, proponents of the Western Finnish roots of the epic. It has if nothing else been proved that the Kalevala has maintained its instrumental value: it is still conceived of as the objectivisation of all that is inherently Finnish. On the other hand today's controversy derives its strength from a new source, regionalism: regional identities have come to take the place of or been instated alongside the national in many parts of Europe (cf. Siikala 1985: 84).

Identities pose problems. In fact they do not exist until they have become problems, says Hermann Bausinger:

It is a notable fact that the concept of homeland and the concept of identity become crystallised and the subject of lively debate only when they are no longer self-evident. Both concepts, homeland and identity, have acquired an emotionally-charged shade of meaning that to some extent corresponds to their challenging nature and their utopian content, but does not perhaps conform in the least with the historical reality with which the concepts are often associated. — The fact that it is by no means certain that historical development is the history of a strengthening identity and a growing 'homelandness' is already evident from the problematic nature of the concepts identity and homeland. The problem is aggravated even further by the fact that any sense of belonging does not, even in our society, merit the name of homeland or identity, in other words there is also a 'false identity'. (Bausinger 1977: 214—215.)

Identities are, therefore, something that possess the power to unite but that are discussed and on which opinions may differ. Emotional indicators, identity symbols, assume great significance because they are the outcome of selection and priority, i. e. they are something 'more' (cf. Honko 1988: 11, 17, 22). The meaning of a symbol may of course encompass differences of interpretation or emphasis, but the situation only becomes critical if the symbol is totally rejected. Alienation from national symbols is in most cases a sign of far-reaching changes in the social climate.

In underlining the 'we' spirit, identity symbols at the same time accentuate the differences between us and others. The functioning of the Kalevala as an indicator of all that is Finnish stems historically from the political situation in Finland at the beginning of the 19th century: it shifted the focal point of the nation eastwards, it brought to light the provinces of Savo and Karelia, linguistic relatives from beyond the border and even further afield, in a quite new way. At the same time it quickly created a rift with the Swedish-speaking culture that had dominated so far. The Kalevala epic was something the Swedes did not possess and which their cultural hegemony had done nothing to help create. According to the international element of Romantic theory this is just as it should be: every nation had, somewhere, a resource embedded in a pure language, a true poetry, its own tradition — the Swedes in ancient Norse poetry and mythology, the Finns in Eastern Finnish—Karelian folklore. This tradition could generally be explained as being of ancient stock, with roots stretching right back to antiquity.

Even so the Kalevala was from the very beginning a problematic symbol. Did the focal point shift too far to the east? Was the majority of the nation even capable of identifying with a culture that differed considerably in religion and spirit, and whose language was difficult to understand? For the academic elite constructing and propagating an identity this was a more serious issue than for the peasants of the developing regions of Finland. In those decisive decades the educated circles were, however, ready for a controlled revolution: they believed, for example, in the inevitability of the change of language from Swedish

to Finnish. The new language was, on the other hand, undergoing powerful development and needed support from the dialects in the east, too. Elias Lönnrot at an early stage, and with admirable perspicacity, grasped the balance that had to be aimed at. Being himself a western Finn, he was able to 'nationalise' the folk poetry of the east in a way that would not have been possible by, for example, C. A. Gottlund, who fought for Savo (and the east) only. Composing an epic that did not exist as such in the oral tradition, from heterogeneous linguistic material, was a venture that could have failed in a thousand ways.

Even after the Kalevala had become established and people began, with the aid of glossaries, translations and commentaries, to read and understand it, it still remained something of a problem. Research soon showed a tendency to claim that the easternness of the ancient epic poetry was merely a case of the familiar phenomenon of the old moving to the periphery to make way for the new. The western element had to be rescued, since Finland was after all a parapet of the west and not of the east. On the other hand Karelia became the goal of pilgrimages, where many a scholar and artist found a harmony of opposites, not so much in the verbal tradition or the cultivated environment as in the breathtakingly beautiful scenery.

The Kalevala is still a problem even today, also in the form of the classical east vs. west controversy. Hints of alienation are often to be discerned in the debate surrounding it; the workers' movement will not accept the interpretations of right-wing scholarship, the young people do not feel any affinity for the Kalevala, teaching in schools has made it a necessary evil, as a national symbol it is outmoded, a mere relic, etc. People really have become alienated from the Kalevala, yet it is always being rediscovered. Comparison of the atmosphere on the 150th anniversary of the Kalevala with that of the centenary soon shows that the corners truly have been rounded off: knowledge of the Kalevala is spreading further afield than ever before, Finland and Soviet-Karelia celebrated in perfect harmony, the workers' movement did not protest against the jubilee year, young people and the schools are rediscovering

the Kalevala through artistic possession, the Kalevala is still a source of inspiration to science and the arts. Too positive a picture? I hope so, for perfect agreement can only mean the death of an identity symbol.

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Index of Names

- Abou Egl, Muhammad I. 394–95
Agricola, Mikael 186, 266, 556
Aho, Juhani 241
Ahlqvist, August 212, 223, 236, 238, 278, 290, 561, 571
Aiskhylos 44
Aitmatov, Ch. 538
Akiander, Matthias 203
Alecsandri, Basile 363
Alhoniemi, Pirkko 23
Allen, J. W. T. 386, 388
Amadou, Sèkou 416, 417
Aminoff, F. 203
Anderson, Walter 145
Annist, August 265, 270, 272, 275–77, 281
Apollonius 51
Arant, Patricia 303
Arany, János 344
Ariste, Paul 355
Aristotle 17, 18
Arwidsson, A. I. 192, 234, 282, 541
Attila the Hun 98, 104
Augustus 50, 51, 53–55, 59–62
Awang-jiazuo 479
Avenarius, V. P. 300, 301

Barthes, Roland 538
Bausinger, Hermann 571
Bawden, C. B. 293
Becker, Reinhold von 158, 159, 193, 203, 231, 234, 248, 268, 558–59
Beck, Brenda 12, 13, 17
Bergson, Henri 541, 547–49
Biebuyck, Daniel 12, 390, 391, 409
Blackwell, Thomas 124
Blair, Hugh 115–17, 124–26, 248
Bodmer, Johann Jacob 98
Boelaert, E. 12, 386–88, 391
Bogdanoff, Jeremei 103
Borenius, A. A. 290, 571
Bosley, Keith 313
Bowra, C. M. 16, 105, 501, 533
Brakel, Gustaf Anton 237
Branch, Michael 313
Broch, Hermann 64, 65
Brockhaus, Hermann 235
Bubrih, D. V. 277
Bynum, David 24

Cainberg, Erik 237
Cajan, J. F. 102
Cajander, Henrik 94, 200, 247
Camoens, L. V. de 66, 397, 399
Cassirer, Ernst 539, 547
Castrén, M. A. 234, 236, 251, 561
Catullus 51
Čavayn, S. 346, 347
Chaucer, Geoffrey 384
Chiri, Mashino 519, 526, 528–30
Ci-deng-duo-ji 481
Coates, J. 349
Collan, Fabian 163, 561

- Comparetti, Domenico 153–54, 172, 258
 Cook, F. C. 258
 Coupez, A. 388, 389
 Cygnaeus, Fredrik 238–240, 541–42

 Dante 57, 66, 67, 362, 368, 399
 David-Neel, Alexandra 485
 Dean of Lismore 119–20, 126
 Domokos, Péter 24
 Donner, Kai 352
 Donner, Otto 278, 354
 Dryden, John 125
 Dumézil, Georges 450

 Eisen, M. J. 272, 274, 275, 279
 Eliade, Mircea 550
 Elmgren, S. G. 199
 Eliot, T. S. 51, 59, 65, 66, 538, 546
 Ennius 51
 Entwistle, William 394
 Erdélyi, Jonas 254
 Erkkö, J. H. 238
 Essone Atome Ongoane, D. 406–08
 Estlander, C. G. 292
 Europaeus, D. E. D. 238–39

 Faehlmann, F. R. 235, 267–70
 Ferguson, Adam 115, 119
 Firdausi 441, 442, 444, 446, 448, 450
 Francke, A. H. 485, 494–97, 499, 501
 Frank, Joseph 550–51
 Freidenberg, O. 539, 547
 Fromm, Hans 23, 67, 140, 144, 159, 241, 248
 Frosterus, B. 203

 Galley, Micheline 24
 Ganander, Christfrid 193, 231, 247, 248, 253, 266, 268, 299, 557
 Garcia Márquez, Gabriel 538, 551–52
 Geoffroy, M. A. 258
 Geijer, Erik Gustaf 359
 Gerd, Kuzebay 346, 347
 Gilferding, A. F. 292
 Glasenapp, Helmut von 384
 Goethe, J. W. von 68, 207–08
 Gorki, Maksim 265, 348, 351
 Gottlund, Carl Axel 97, 192, 193, 231, 233, 234, 249, 268–69, 573
 Grimm, Jacob 96, 167, 200, 214, 234–36, 251, 252, 359, 360, 561
 Grot, Jakov K. 214, 218, 255–56
 Gubameng 514

 Haavikko, Paavo 151, 241–42
 Haavio, Martti 232, 290, 311, 313, 326, 328, 330, 558, 565
 Hajdú, Péter 352
 Harkins, William E. 303
 Hatto, A. T. 10, 17, 397
 Hegel, Friedrich 3, 205, 207, 212, 541, 543, 569
 Heidegger, Martin 541, 549
 Heinze, Richard 56
 Heissig, Walther 24
 Hercules 55
 Herder, Johann Gottfrid von 8, 97, 187, 190–91, 206–07, 227, 248, 541, 543
 Herodotus 44
 Herrmann, Silke 13, 24
 Hertzberg, Rafael 274

- Hesiod 86, 87, 96, 200, 247, 446, 557
 Heusler, Andreas 97
 Hollman, R. 252
 Holmberg, H. J. 274
 Home, John 115, 116
 Homer 1, 2, 4, 11, 12, 17, 18, 22, 23,
 29, 32–34, 37, 41, 44, 47, 49, 50–
 58, 64, 67–69, 73, 86, 94–97, 108,
 125, 133, 134, 143, 159–61, 163,
 172, 182, 190–93, 199, 200, 207,
 214, 216, 218, 221, 225–27, 233,
 247–52, 257, 258, 326, 362, 399,
 426, 559, 563
 Honko, Lauri 24, 36, 49, 67
 Horace 59
 Hudyakov, M. 347, 351
 Huovinen, Jaakko 102
 Hurt, Jakob 272, 278–79, 282

 Ibn Khaldoun 426–27
 Iivana, Vatsuni 102
 Ingman, A. 203
 Innes, Gordon 12, 15–16, 382, 384,
 390
 Ipay, Olik 346, 347

 Jaakkola, Jalmari 570
 Jakobson, C. R. 272
 'Jam-dpal rgyal-mtsho 24
 Johnson, Samuel 118
 Joyce, James 538, 546, 550
 Juslenius, Daniel 231, 557
 Juteini, Jaakko 234, 237
 Järnefelt, Arvid 543

 Kagame, Alexis 389
 Kainulainen, Juhana 196

 Kallas, Oskar 272, 279
 Kamanzi, Th. 388, 389
 Kampmann, M. 274
 Karhu, Eino 24
 Karjalainen, K. F. 103
 Karjalainen, the singer family 138, 145
 Karjalainen, Martiska 139
 Karkama, Pertti 205, 208
 Kaukonen, Väinö 23, 68, 69, 103, 152,
 201, 204, 219, 556
 Keckman, C. N. 203
 Kellgren, Herman 235
 Kellgren, Johan Henrik 249
 Kellogg, Robert 84
 Kermode, Frank 63
 Kettunen, the singer family 138
 Kettunen, Jyrki 139
 Khayyam, Omar 397, 449, 451
 Khomeini 453
 Kieleväinen, Vaassila 160, 196, 200,
 201, 214, 247
 Kijuma, Muhammad 394–95
 Kindaichi, Kyōsuke 519–21, 527,
 529–31
 Kiparsky, Paul 303–05
 Kirkinen, Heikki 571
 Kivi, Aleksis 240–42, 542, 543
 Kličkov, S. 350, 351
 Klinge, Matti 558, 570, 571
 Knappert, Jan 13, 24
 Knauer, G. N. 56
 Koschwitz, Eduard 372, 373
 Koskimies, Rafael 172
 Kramers, J. H. 382
 Kreutzwald, Fr. R. 251, 252, 267–74,
 276, 280, 281

- Krohn, Julius 133–35, 137, 151–53, 258, 278, 279, 290, 558, 564, 571
 Krohn, Kaarle 143, 144, 164, 278, 279, 290, 442, 557, 558
 Kubodera, Itsuhiko 519, 529
 Gustav II Adolf 184–86, 556
 Kuusi, Matti 23, 288, 291, 302, 304, 313
 Kuusinen, Otto Ville 570
- Lachmann, Karl 11, 95, 133
 Lamartine, Alphonse de 276, 362, 373, 426
 Laufer, Berthold 497, 499, 500, 522–23
 Laugaste, Eduard 23, 252, 272
 Lehtipuro, Outi 560
 Leino, Eino 68, 110, 238, 241, 543
 Lenttisi, Varvana 298
 Léouzou Le Duc, L. 172, 224, 234
 Lesoni, Vihtora 102, 103
 Linna, Väinö 551
 Linsén, Johan Gabriel 86, 95, 96, 200, 202–03, 208, 233, 247
 Lipp, M. 282
 Livy 442
 Longfellow, H. W. 250, 276
 Loooris, Oskar 355
 Lord, Albert B. 2, 11, 30, 84, 153, 226, 303–05, 384, 385, 501
 Lucretius 51
 Lycophron 51
 Lytkin, V. 349
 Lönnbohm (-Mustonen), O. A. F. 274, 278
 Lönnrot, Elias 3, 9, 10, 13, 21–24, 36, 49–51, 67–69, 73, 75, 86–88, 93–97, 100–09, 127, 133, 135, 143, 151, 152, 157–70, 172–77, 181–83, 189, 193–204, 206, 208–27, 231–40, 247–51, 254–57, 269, 276, 280–82, 292, 293, 296, 300, 301, 311, 313, 326, 346, 350, 352, 354, 359, 360, 363, 374, 441, 455–56, 463, 466, 483, 541–43, 545, 555–69, 573
 Lönnroth, Lars 23
- Macpherson, James 23, 115–29, 189, 219–21, 224, 225, 248, 250, 252, 292, 293
 Magoun, Francis Peabody 84, 85
 Malinen, the singer family 138, 139, 141, 144, 145, 304
 Malinen, Jyrki 102
 Malinen, Ontrei 19, 143, 148, 151, 152, 160, 196, 201, 247, 569
 Mamayi, Zhusufu 511
 Manner, Eeva-Liisa 549
 Marín, Francisco Marcos 382
 Marx, Karl 543–44
 Marzouki, Mohammed 427–28
 McLagan, James 119, 122
 Melentšev, Palaga 103
 Meletinsky, E. M. 287, 523, 539, 543, 546, 551
 Mikušev, A. K. 348
 Miller, V. F. 288
 Milton, John 1, 66, 124, 125, 208, 399
 Mistral, Frédéric 360–63, 367–74
 Morgan, Lewis Henry 563
 Mühlberg, M. 253, 273, 274
 Müller, Max 257

- Naevius 51
 Namgyal, Nurup 488–91
 Namgyal, Rinchen 493–94
 Neus, H. 278, 282
 Niemi, A. R. 152, 161, 204
 Nietzsche, Friedrich 539–40
 Nöldeke, Theodor 381, 392

 Obayashi, Taryo 24
 Obereit, Jacob Hermann 98
 Ogiwara, Shinko 530
 Ohrt, F. 259
 Oinas, Felix J. 11, 23, 147
 Oksala, Teivas 23
 Omar, Mw. Yahya Ali 386, 388
 Otis, Brooks 55

 Pacius, Fredrik 237
 Paraske, Larin 104
 Parry, Milman 2, 11, 29, 30, 32, 33, 84, 153, 226, 303–05, 332, 501
 Peisistratus 45, 199, 208
 Percy, Thomas 248
 Perttunen, the singer family 138, 139, 141, 144, 145, 304
 Perttunen, Arhippa 143, 148, 152, 160, 196, 201, 282, 312, 483
 Perttunen, Miihkali 282
 Peterson, Kr. J. 266, 267
 Phillips, Nigel 12, 392, 393
 Pindar 44
 Plato 482, 483
 Plotnikov, M. A. 350, 351
 Pope, Alexander 119, 124, 126
 Poppius, Abraham 192
 Porthan, Henrik Gabriel 68, 146, 158, 183, 186–90, 192, 193, 198, 213, 219, 231, 238, 248, 556, 558

 Propp, Vladimir 20, 21, 287, 293, 297
 Proust, Marcel 538, 550
 Puhakka, Juhana 102
 Puhvel, Jaan 24
 Pumpurs, Andrejs 259, 282

 Radayev, V. K. 345, 346
 Rahim-ul-la 489, 491, 495
 Rank, Otto 443
 Rausmaa, Pirkko-Liisa 141, 149
 Raynouard, François-Juste-Marie 362
 Reguly, Antal 254
 Rein, Gabriel 158, 203
 Ridala, V. 272, 275
 Rjabinin, Trofim 299
 Roehrich, G. N. 498, 500
 Rosenkranz, Karl 257
 Roumanille, Joseph 361, 363, 370
 Rugojev, Jaakko 353, 355
 Runeberg, J. L. 158, 193, 205, 214, 218, 221, 232, 238, 240, 254, 256
 Rybnikov, P. L. 255, 292
 Rühs, Fr. 249

 Sæmund the Wise 87
 Salamnius, Matias 102
 Salminen, Väinö 49, 164, 290
 Sarajas, Annamari 158, 235
 Saxo Grammaticus 74, 75, 442, 559
 Schantz, Filip von 237
 Schauman, August 232
 Schelling, Friedrich von 537, 541
 Schenda, Rudolf 24
 Schiefner, Franz Anton von 234, 271
 Schildt, Wolmar S. 203
 Schlegel, A. W. 200
 Schlegel, Friedrich von 199, 205, 207, 569

- Schröter, H. R. von 231, 234
 Schultz-Bertram, G. J. 252, 253, 268, 269, 271
 Šestarov, Yuvan 350
 Setälä, Emil Nestor 150, 265, 558
 Sextus Propertius 53
 Seydou, Christiane 13, 24
 Shakespeare, William 190–91, 207, 240
 Shemeikka, the singer family 142, 145
 Sillanpää, F. E. 548
 Simrock, Karl 94, 300
 Sirola, Yrjö 570
 Sissonen, the singer family 145
 Sissonen, Simana 101, 102, 312
 Sjögren, A. J. 159, 192, 249
 Sjöstrand, C. E. 237
 Skaft Jensen, Minna 22
 Skaftymov, A. P. 294
 Smith, John 384, 386, 388, 392, 393
 Snellman, J. V. 163, 193, 204, 205, 213, 232, 233, 240, 541, 561
 Spengler, Oswald 540
 Ståhlberg, C. H. 203
 Stein, R. A. 485, 490, 499–501
 Steinthal, Heymann 97, 133–35, 257
 Suetonius 52, 54
 Suits, Gustav 272, 281
 Sydow, Carl W. von 145
 Tacitus 445
 Tasso, Torquato 66, 399
 Taylor, Archer 443
 Tegnér, Esaias 249, 254, 255–56
 Tengström, Robert 96, 162, 205–08, 212, 214, 233, 235, 249, 542, 545, 570
 Tenisova, Anni 103
 Tettau, W. J. A. von 258
 Thomson, Derick 23
 Thorossian, H. 383
 Topelius, Zachris 189, 193, 198, 209, 231, 237, 240
 Tuglas, Friedebert 281
 Wagner, Richard 58, 76, 81
 Waley, Arthur 11
 Varius 53–54
 Veselovski, A. N. 11
 Veske, Mihkel 279
 Vico, J. 537, 541
 Wiedemann, F. J. 271
 Wikander, Stig 446–47, 451
 Wiklund, K. B. 172, 564
 Wilson, William A. 205, 558, 564
 Virgil 1, 23, 49, 51, 53–58, 60–62, 64–67, 125, 182, 202, 208–09, 258, 362
 Virtanen, Leea 147
 Voigt, Vilmos 23
 Voldyin, V. 350
 Wolf, Friedrich August 11, 37, 50, 67, 68, 95, 133, 159, 172, 192, 193, 199, 207–08, 221, 257, 299
 Voltaire, François Marie 124
 Wright, F. C. 383
 Vörösmarty, Mihály 344
 Yu-mei 481, 482
 Za-ba 475, 480, 481, 483
 Zarathustra 451
 Zhakov, K. 348
 Zhi, Jia 24
 Zhirmunski, V. M. 287
 Zrinyi, Miklós 344

Index of Epics and Epic Heroes

(Names of epics in *italics*.)

- Abu Zayd 430, 432, 433
Achilles 32–33, 42, 52, 56–58, 68,
214, 253, 396, 443
Aeneas 51, 52, 54, 56–57, 59–66, 68
Aeneid 1, 18, 49, 50, 53–64, 66–67,
125, 208
Aeolus 39
Agamemnon 34
Ayula Khan 466
Ahti Saarelainen 151, 296
Ainu rakkur (Okikurmi, Acoina ka-
mui) 519–20, 522, 523, 525, 527,
529
Aithiopis 57
Aju mergen 458
Alepamisi 512
Alexandra 51
Altai sümben hüü 460
Amelungenlied 300
Annales 51
Antar 425–27, 435
Apollo 328
Argonautica 51
Arthur 106
Athena 45, 46, 319
Avesta 444–52
Agi ulayan qayan-u Altan yalab küü
464
Beowulf 1, 74, 77, 78, 81, 83, 85, 143,
383
Bible (The Old Testament) 125, 158,
239, 366
Byarmia 348
Boat trip epic 139
Bobo 507
Book of Conquests 447
Book of the Kievan Heroes 300, 301
Brave and Resourceful Prince Xiretu 512
*Brother Fu and Sister Xi Create Man-
kind* 508
Brynhild 76, 80–81
Brunhild 104
Bükü hara khübün 462
Calypso 56, 64
Chamu 504, 506, 509
Cid / El Cid 258, 393, 399
Circe 56, 64
Dido 56, 64–66
Dyab 432–33
Edda 1, 23, 73–76, 78–80, 82–88,
95–97, 105, 200, 247, 249, 251, 557
Snorri's Edda 82
Enkidu 108
Erensei 462
Er-Sogotokh 523, 525
Feridün 444, 445, 447, 448, 453
Fingal 117, 118, 121–26

- Fringe of the Earth* 350
Frithiofs saga 254, 255

Georgics 58, 60–61
Geser|Gesar 457, 459–64, 466, 510, 515, 517
Gilgamesh 108
Guðrún 79, 108
Gunougan, the Warrior 512
Gunther 108

Hagen 104, 108
Han harangui 460
Hector 41, 56
Hercules 253, 269
Herekali 388
Hermes 328, 329
Hilalian sira (Sīrat Banī Hilāl) 429–31, 433–35
Hildebrandslied 78
 Hildebrand 443
Hrnjica, Mujo 333–36

Iliad 22, 29, 32, 37, 40–43, 47, 50, 51, 53, 55, 57, 67, 68, 74, 81, 95, 124–25, 159, 161, 214, 226, 227, 233, 249, 257, 265
 see also *Homer*
Ilmarinen 58, 108, 137, 138, 140–43, 147–49, 151, 159, 160, 164–66, 168, 174, 175, 242, 247, 326, 455, 462, 463, 559, 561, 566, 567
Impia Creates Heaven and Earth 508
Ivanovič, Dunaj 295, 300–02

Jamšīd 444–46, 448, 449, 452, 453
Jangar 472, 510, 511, 513

Jāzya 433–34
Job 239, 426
Jonah 327
Joukahainen 88, 147, 165, 166, 171, 295, 301, 316, 317, 335, 465, 559, 566

Kaitian pidi 505
Kalev, Kaleva 159, 161, 169, 176, 265–66, 271–72, 277, 282, 294, 566
Kalevala 7–13, 18–25, 36, 49–51, 53, 58, 63, 64, 67–69, 73, 74, 78, 81, 85–88, 93, 96, 98–103, 105, 107, 108, 110, 111, 126–28, 133–35, 144, 147, 149, 151–53, 157–67, 171–77, 181–83, 185–88, 190, 193–205, 208–17, 219, 220, 222–27, 231–42, 247–60, 265, 267–69, 271, 273–82, 290, 293, 296, 300, 301, 344, 350, 352–55, 359, 360, 374, 396, 398, 441, 453, 455, 456, 459, 461–66, 472, 483, 508, 537, 542, 545, 555–57, 559–66, 568–74
Proto-Kalevala|The Collected Songs about Väinämöinen 88, 160–61, 197–99, 301, 313, 315, 317, 322, 327, 330
The Old Kalevala 73, 96, 157, 162, 163, 172, 196, 200, 203–05, 208, 212, 215, 221, 223, 232, 239, 247, 249–51, 254–57, 273, 282, 315, 317, 322, 327, 330, 557
The New Kalevala 88, 101, 127, 152, 157, 176, 198, 199, 205, 211, 212, 216, 223, 231, 236, 237, 255–57, 313, 315, 317, 322, 327, 330

- The Abridged Kalevala* 165, 198, 211, 560, 564
Kalevipoeg 11, 23, 50, 222, 235, 251–53, 259, 265–72, 276, 278, 280–82, 344, 351
 Kalevipoeg, Son of Kaleva 147, 159, 252, 265–72, 282, 294
Kamui-oina 520
Kantele 158, 197, 198, 557
Kanteletar 3, 97, 163, 213, 220, 238, 276, 282
 Kaukomieli/Kaukamoinen 146, 151, 198, 296
Kerbela 398
King Fjalar 205
King Gesar 6, 13, 18, 471–90, 492–501
 King of Aršam 338
 Knight Pera 349
 Kraljević, Marko 393
 Kriemhild 104
 Kudim-Ož 349
 Kullervo 108, 147, 161, 169, 174, 199, 238–42, 264, 275, 301, 441, 464, 563
Kullervo epic 301

Lāčplēsis (Bear Killer) 259, 282
Langaxibe 513, 515
 Lapstan, Puma 490–95
 Lemminkäinen 58, 108, 146, 151, 160, 161, 164, 167–69, 174, 175, 198, 199, 239–41, 247, 280, 296, 301, 455, 456, 458–61, 559, 563
Lemminkäinen epic 301
Lewuteyi (Zhige'along, the Hero) 505, 509, 516

Lianja 386, 388, 390, 391
Lifeng 513
Life of King Gesar 510, 511, 515, 517
Life of Wugusi 512

Mahābhārata 1, 17, 399, 445, 450
 Maid of the North / Maiden of Pohja / Daughter of Pohjola 141, 148, 149, 164, 166, 168, 169, 172, 175, 455
Manas 510, 511, 525, 528, 530
Mandoumorigen 512
 Margo 524, 525
Meige 504
 Menelaus 41
Mireille 24, 359, 362–74
 Mistress of Pohjola / Mistress of the North / Louhi 138, 140, 148, 149, 168–70, 175, 199, 299, 559
 Moses 30, 158
Munaozhaiwa 508
Mupamipa 505
 Muromec, Il'ja 293, 294, 300, 301
mvēt 403–06, 408–10, 415, 418–21
Mwindo 390, 391, 409, 410

 Nan Tungga, Anggun 16, 19, 393
Naran gayan-u kü 466
 Nausicaa 40, 64, 69
 Nestor 42
Nibelungenlied 1, 11, 12, 18, 23, 93–100, 104–07, 109–11, 134, 192, 209, 249–51, 258, 397, 490, 493
 Nikitič, Dobrynja 294, 298, 300, 301
 Norna-Gest 76–84, 87

 Odin 77, 80–82, 87, 88
 Odysseus 23, 38–41, 45, 46, 52, 56–58, 64, 214, 240, 253, 319, 320, 397

- Odyssey* 29, 37, 40–43, 45–47, 50, 55, 57, 68, 69, 95, 124, 209, 214, 226, 227, 233, 249, 319, 397
 see also Homer
Oedipus 393
olongo epic 523
Ossian, the Poems of 23, 96, 97, 116–18, 120–22, 126, 127, 189, 192, 220, 224, 248–51, 255, 257, 292
Ossian 118–23
Panji 392–93
Paradise Lost 1, 18, 125, 208
 Paris 41
 Poiyaunpe 521–23, 526
 Polyphemus 38, 41
 Popović, Aleša 294, 301
 Poseidon 45
 Priam 41, 42, 46, 57
 Princess of Aršam 339, 340
Rama-carit manas 384
Rāmāyana 6, 17, 384, 392, 448
Roland, the Song of 41, 134, 143, 258, 383, 396
 Romulus 51, 62
 Rustam 441, 443, 448, 449, 452
 Ruža 334, 335
Sampo, the epic of 135, 147–50, 164, 300, 301, 328
 Samson 315
 Senjanin, Ivan 333
Shāh Nāma/Shahnamé (Book of Kings) 24, 399, 441–43, 445, 447–49, 451–53
 Sheherazade 425, 452
 Siegfried 58, 81, 104, 108, 110, 253, 269, 396, 397, 443, 490
 Sigurd the Volsung 76, 78–81, 87, 105
Sijažar 346–47
Sijobang 12, 17–19, 392–94, 397
Sonhodoj mergen bühün 462
Song about Knight Čotkar 347
Song of Hiawatha 276
Song of Igor's Campaign 255
Song of King Pan 506
Sunjata 15, 384, 390, 391, 399, 411–13
Ta'ergen 512
Temora 118, 121, 123
The One Thousand and One Nights 425, 428
 Thormod 82
Tsewün xara nüden xü 465
Uliger epic 528
Utenzi wa Masaiba 397
Victorious Madur Vaxa 350
Widsith 76–78, 82, 85
 Vipunen, Antero 139, 140, 150, 165, 168, 173, 295, 296, 313, 314, 320, 322–25, 327, 334, 463, 464
 Višnjić, Ivan 337–40
 Vlahinjić, Alija 332, 335–40
 Väinämöinen 73, 86–88, 108, 136–38, 140–42, 147–51, 159–61, 164, 165, 168–71, 174, 175, 177, 193, 198–200, 202, 234, 237, 242, 247, 248, 267, 280, 295–97, 299, 301, 311–35, 339, 340, 455, 461, 463–65, 508, 516, 559, 561, 563–67

Xiangmeng 513, 514

Xigangli 507

Ymir 445, 506

yukar 519, 525–29, 531

Zakarić 334, 335

Zhaoxiangmeng 513

Zhige'along 516

Zlata 335

Zohak 444–46, 448

